

CHAPTER 1 Colonial America

American Puritanism

The settlement of the North American continent by the English began in the early part of the seventeenth century. The first settlers who became the founding fathers of the American nation were quite a few of them Puritans. They came to America out of various reasons, but it should be remembered that they were a group of serious, religious people, advocating highly religious and moral principles. They carried with them to America a code of values, a philosophy of life, and a point of view, which, in time, took root in the New World and became what is popularly known as American Puritanism. A dominant factor in American life, American Puritanism was one of the most enduring shaping influences in American thought and American literature. It has become, to some extent, so much a state of mind, rather than a set of tenets, so much a part of the national cultural atmosphere that the Americans breathe, that we may state with a degree of safety that, without some understanding of Puritanism, there can be no real understanding of American culture and literature.

Although the English government saw the colonization of the North American continent as a means of alleviating its own problems, a large number of the settlers themselves left home in the first years of the seventeenth century in earnest quest of an ideal of their own. It is true that they wished to escape religious persecution - and the English government regarded its American colony as an ideal dumping ground for the undesirables, but they were also determined to find a place where they could worship in the way they thought true Christians should. When they arrived and saw the virgin forests, the virgin land, and the vast expanse of wilderness that stretched miles around before them, they became aware that God must have sent them there for a definite purpose and that, as God's chosen people, they were meant to reestablish a commonwealth based on the teachings of the Bible, restore the lost paradise, and build the wilderness into a new Garden of Eden. Whatever they thought might jeopardize their endeavor to build their "City of God on earth" was, therefore, not to be tolerated. Hence, for instance, the ruthless persecution of dissenting individuals and denominations for their heresies.

The American Puritans, like their brothers back in England, were idealists, believing that the Church should be restored to the "purity" of the first-century Church as established by Jesus Christ Himself. To them, religion was a matter of primary importance. They made it their chief business to see that man lived and thought and acted in a way which tended to the glory of God. They accepted the doctrine of predestination, original sin and total depravity, and limited atonement (or the salvation of a selected few) through a special infusion of grace from God, all that John Calvin (1509-1564), the great French theologian who lived in Geneva, had preached. It was this kind of religious belief that they brought with them into the wilderness. There they meant to prove that they were God's chosen people enjoying His blessings on this earth as in heaven.

In the grim struggle for survival that followed immediately after their arrival in America, the character of the people underwent a significant change. Pushing the frontiers with them as they moved further and further westward, they became more and more preoccupied with business and profits. They became, in a word, more practical, as indeed they had to be. The very severity of the frontier conditions taught the American Puritans to be tougher, to be ever ready for any misfortune and tragic failures that might lie in wait for them. To say that the American Puritans were an admirable group of people is not really saying much. Commenting on the distinct personality of the American Puritan, Perry Miller writes:

He was a visionary who never forgets that two plus two equals four; he was a soldier of Jehovah who never came out on the losing side of a bargain.... He was a practical idealist.... He came to New England to found the perfect society and the Kingdom of the elect and never expected it to be perfect, but only the best that fallible men could make. His creed was the revealed word of God and his life was the rule of moderation; his beliefs were handed down on high and his conduct was regulated by expediency. He was a doctrinaire and an opportunist.

"A doctrinaire opportunist" came perhaps closest to the American Puritan ideal for man.

Although the Puritans did their best to help build a new nation and a new culture out of the wilderness, their descendants have not always been grateful. All through the nineteenth century and especially in the first few decades of the twentieth, American Puritans came under violent and often virulent attacks for their religious intolerance and bigotry, for their austerity of taste and killjoy way of life, for the very heritage they bequeathed to the new nation. The very term, Puritanism, evoked, for a time, antipathy and disgust in the minds of many people including pre-eminent critics like Van Wyck Brooks (1886-1963) and H. L. Mencken (1880-1956). Even today one cannot say very safely that a consensus has been reached, and the recognition, long overdue, has been given only grudgingly. In this connection we may venture to make a comparison between American Puritanism and Chinese Confucianism. There are indeed elements in Confucianism, which awaken abhorrence and even invoke a curse among the Chinese, and often in modern history a revolutionary was he who proved himself first an energetic iconoclast. Both the wrath and the action were justified, though the fact still remains that Confucianism alone has been the most powerful shaping factor in the cultural maturity of the Chinese nation. It has, through the centuries, for better or for worse, burned its way into the very fabric of Chinese social life, and way down into the Chinese consciousness, so that even the most incorruptible anti-Confucianist cannot escape its influence. Such is the force of a tradition that one tends to realize, however slowly, that one will do better to make a pact with it and "give the devil its due." Thus it is that when the mists of time have cleared away, traditions such as American Puritanism and Chinese Confucianism will receive, as they are already receiving, the kind of rehabilitation they so well deserve.

It is a critical commonplace now that American literature-or Anglo-American literature - is based on a myth, that is, the Biblical myth of the Garden of Eden. This literature is in good measure a literary expression of the pious idealism of the American Puritan bequest. The Puritans dreamed of living under a perfect order and worked with indomitable courage and confident hope toward building a new Garden of Eden in America, where man could at long last live the way he should. Fired with such a sense of mission, the Puritans looked even the worst of life in the face with a tremendous amount of optimism. All this went, in due time, into the making of American literature. If Emerson saw the American as Adam himself reborn, standing simple and sincere before the world, if Thoreau portrayed himself as an Adam in his Eden, and Whitman felt rapturous at the sight of the Americans bustling with activity as the children of Adam restored to their lost paradise, and Henry James talked, especially in his early career, about the innocence and simplicity of his Americans as so many Newmans, and if the spirit of optimism burst out of the pages of so many American authors, Chinese students of American literature should not be unduly surprised: the optimistic Puritan has exerted a great influence on American literature. Neither should they experience anything like amazement when they detect a mood of frustration or despair in the works of especially later periods. For, always at the latter end of weal stands woe. When the

dream did not materialize, and when only a "Gilded Age" came instead of the anxiously expected Golden, what else can one feel? Thus in either way American literature was from the outset conditioned by the Puritan heritage to which American authors have been the most communicative heirs.

Nor is this all. The American Puritan's metaphorical mode of perception was chiefly instrumental in calling into being a literary symbolism which is distinctly American. Puritan doctrine and literary practice contributed to no small extent to the development of an indigenous symbolism. To the pious Puritan the physical, phenomenal world is nothing but a symbol of God. To him the world was, in the words of Charles Feidelson the critic, "instinct with meaning by reason of God's concurrence and susceptible of interpretation by reason of God's salient acts." Physical life was simultaneously spiritual; every passage of life, en-meshed in the vast context of God's plan, possessed a delegated meaning. The world was, in a word, one of multiple significance. If one cares to read the writings of the early settlers such as William Bradford (1590-1657) and Cotton Mather (1663-1728), it is impossible to overlook the very symbolizing process that was constantly at work in Puritan minds. This process became, in time, part of the intellectual tradition in which American authors were brought up along with their people. If Jonathan Edwards (1703-1758) saw nature and even the Bible as "radically figurative," if Emerson's Nature is like a "continuous monologue," to quote Feidelson again, in which the genesis of symbolism is enacted over and over, and if, with Hawthorne, Melville, Howells and many others, symbolism as a technique has become a common practice, it is indeed as it should be. This peculiar mode of perception was an essential part of their upbringing.

With regard to technique one naturally thinks of the simplicity, which characterizes the Puritan style of writing. Here the Puritan seems to need some form of rehabilitation, too. The Puritans have been abhorred for their austerity and rigidity in matters of taste, "notorious," in a manner of speaking, for their distaste for the arts and for any manifestation of sensuous beauty. Although there is an amount of truth in all this, it is necessary to note that the popular image of the early seventeenth-century American Puritan, a teetotaler, gaunt, lank-haired, wearing a black steeple hat, is perhaps too much a distortion of the historical fact to remain creditable to thinking people. The fact of the matter was, probably, this, that the Puritans drank and dressed themselves in all the hues of the rainbow (as Perry Miller tells us), and that they built schools, encouraged learning, and loved reading, making New England and the east seaboard, which they came to settle first, centers of culture comparable in more ways than one to England and Europe. With regard to their writing, the style is fresh, simple and direct; the rhetoric is plain and honest, not without a touch of nobility often traceable to the direct influence of the Bible. All this has left an indelible imprint on American writing. Thus American Puritanism has been, by and large, a healthy legacy to the Americans.

The Literary Scene in Colonial America

American literature grew out of humble origins. Diaries, histories, journals, letters, commonplace books, travel books, sermons, in short, personal literature in its various forms, occupy a major position in the literature of the early colonial period. There was the famous John Smith's description of New England as a promising virgin land, which came to the attention of many people in England and Europe and drew many of them over to the New World. There were William Bradford's history of the colony (Of Plymouth Plantation) that he established after he led the Mayflower settlers across the Atlantic and John Winthrop's speech that he made on his way

leading his fleet of emigrants from the Old World over to America, "A Model of Christian Charity," - both of these illustrate the religious zeal of the first settlers of the North American Continent. Early poetry, such as *The Bay Psalm Book* (1640), *The Day of Doom* (1662), and *New England Primer* (1683) were all ponderously religious, and early poets like Anne Bradstreet (1612-1672) and Edward Taylor (1642-1729) were in fact servants of God. In content these early writings served either God or colonial expansion or both. In form, English literary traditions were faithfully imitated and transplanted.

We begin with a brief account of the writings of John Smith (1580-1631), William Bradford (1590-1657), and John Winthrop (1588-1649). Captain John Smith was one of the first early 17th-century British settlers in North America. He was one of the founders of the colony of Jamestown, Virginia. His writings about North America became the source of information about the New World for later settlers. One of the things he wrote about that has become an American legend was his capture by the Indians and his rescue by the famous Indian Princess, Pocahontas. Another thing he wrote about that became historically important is his description of the fertile and vast new continent in his *A Description of New England*. His narrative reveals the early settlers' vision of the new land as something capable of being built into a new Garden of Eden.

William Bradford led the Mayflower endeavor and became the first governor of the Plymouth Plantation that he established with his group of pilgrim fathers. His *Of Plymouth Plantation* records, along with other things of a historic nature, the deliberations that the first settlers of North America had regarding their colonizing undertaking. In chapter IV, "Showing the Reasons and Causes of their Removal," Bradford states the fourth reason for their departure for the new world when he says that his people had "a great hope and inward zeal" to do the spadework for disseminating "the gospel of the kingdom of Christ" in the new world and they were even willing to be stepping-stones for others in doing this great work. The religious and idealistic nature of their adventure into the unknown world is self-evident.

This is made clearer and more eloquent in John Winthrop's *A Model of Christian Charity*. The first governor of the Massachusetts Bay Colony states in this speech of his that there was the cause between God and his people who entered into a covenant with God for this work of building a new Garden of Eden in the new world: "...the Lord will be our God and delight to dwell among us, as His own people, and [He] will command a blessing upon us in all our ways, so that we shall see much more of his wisdom, power, goodness, and truth than formerly we have been acquainted with. We shall find that the God of Israel is among us, when ten of us shall be able to resist a thousand of our enemies... for we must consider that we shall be as a city upon a hill, the eyes of all people are upon us." Here is revealed the sense of mission and the religious fever with which these people and their descendants were to build their Puritan theocracy, tolerate no dissidents of any kind, and fight the American Indians whom they mistook as a threat to their holy cause.

Now Anne Bradstreet (1612-1672) was a Puritan poet who wrote "ponderous verses of interminable, inter-locking poems" on the four elements, the constitutions and ages of man, the seasons of the year, and the chief empires of the ancient world. Her poems made such a stir in England that she became known as the "Tenth Muse" who appeared in America. Most other verse has fallen into the obscurity of time, but her gentle "Contemplations" are still read today. For instance, the ninth offers the reader an insight into the mentality of the early Puritans pioneering in a new world:

Contemplations (9)

I heard the merry grasshopper then sing.
The black-clad cricket bear a second part;
They kept one tune and played on the same string,
Seeming to glory in their little art.
Shall creatures abject thus their voices raise
And in their kind resound their Maker's praise,
Whilst I, as mute, can warble forth no higher lays?

When the poet heard the grasshopper and the cricket sing, she thought of this as their praising their Creator and searched her own soul accordingly. It is evident that she saw something metaphysical inhering in the physical, a mode of perception that was singularly Puritan. Also interesting are her "personal" poems published after her death, chief among them those to her husband and on her children and the deaths in her family. One of these, "Upon the Burning of Our House....," subtly reveals the inner complexity of the Puritans. The 9-stanza work can be subdivided into three segments of three stanzas each. **The first describes the initial response of a Puritan to a disastrous occurrence:** she feels resigned because God takes away what He has given. But the 2nd segment shows that the pious rationalization fails to suppress the human reaction as a Puritan is first and foremost a human: she feels bad as she looks on the debris and reminisces about her good old times. Then the religious feeling gets the upper hand once and for all: she is happy at the thought that the world above is much better than this earthy earth.

Some of her poems such as "To My Dear and Loving Husband" and "In Reference to Her Children," however, denote the human side of her being clearly. Take "To My Dear and Loving Husband" for instance: "If ever two were one, then surely we, / If ever man were loved by wife, then thee; / If ever wife was happy in a man, / Compare with me, ye women, if you can. / I prize thy love more than whole mines of gold / Or all the riches that the East doth hold. / My love is such that rivers cannot quench, / Nor ought only love from thee, give recompense. / The Love is such I can no way repay, / The heavens reward thee manifold, I pray. / Then while we live, in love let's so persevere / That when we live no more, we may live ever." Coming from a devout Puritan, these lines are surprising because they reveal the inner "soul-scape" of the "Puritans" so graphically. Read Anne Bradstreet's poems on her children and grandchildren, and it will be clear that the love, the care, and the happiness that comes from family life are all the most important to her indeed.

But the struggle between the two impulses (spiritual and material) is perennial and constitutes the basic texture of the Puritan mind. Her poem, "The Flesh and the Spirit," depicting as it does two sisters arguing about their values, is a good illustration. The Flesh, one of the twin sisters, is forthright with her assertion of her views about the importance of this world while the Spirit, the other, tries to convince her of the greatness of the Kingdom of God. The Spirit seems to be winning as she has a much longer and more final argument to offer. The twin sisters are evidently the integral parts of one Puritan mind. The argument of most of Anne Bradstreet's poems is essentially about the justice of God's way with His Puritan flock. Her works search for a sense of man's nature and destiny and his mission in the new world. One more thing to note about Anne Bradstreet is her description of the early settlers' life in the new world. For example, "As Weary Pilgrim," one devoted to God as much as any of her other poems, offers some hints of the hardships that they suffered in their first days there.

Edward Taylor (1642-1729) was a meditative poet. In his elaborate metaphors he was

reminiscent of Richard Crashaw (1613?-1649), and George Herbert (1593-1633). In his splendid, exotic images, Taylor came nearest to the English baroque poets. For all his indulgence in his "un-Puritan" imagery, however, he was, first and last, a Puritan poet, concerned about how his images speak for God. A good example is his poem, "Huswifery," which indicates that he saw religious significance in a simple daily incident like a housewife spinning:

"Huswifery"

Make me, O Lord, thy spinning wheel complete.

Thy holy word my distaff make for me.

Make mine affections thy swift flyers neat,

And make my soul thy holy spool to be.

My conversation make to be thy reel,

And reel the yam thereon spun of thy wheel.

The spinning wheel, the distaff, the flyers, the spool, the reel and the yarn have all acquired a metaphysical significance in the symbolic, Puritan eyes of Edward Taylor. An interesting poem of Taylor's is "Upon a Spider Catching a Fly." His 18th-century mode of perception is radically different from a fellow poet - Robert Frost's 20th-century one. Taylor sees the spider as a symbol of Hell with its traps:

This fray seems thus to us:

Hell's spider gets

His entrails spun to whipcords thus,

And wove to nets

And sets

To tangle Adam's race

In's strategems

To their destructions, spoiled, made base

By venom things,

Damned sins.

It is obvious that Taylor has faith in God who can save the erring, or possibly sinful, humankind from the evil designs of Hell. However, Robert Frost is more skeptical. He sees a dark design at work, which he seems to think, has to do with God's overall scheme of things. This relates to the mooted point made by many later questioning minds as to why God allows evil to exist at all.

Colonial America did not always write the way Anne Bradstreet and Edward Taylor wrote. Some people wrote for civil and religious freedom, and some others wrote for America shaking off the fetters of the savage and rapacious British colonial rule. These authors sounded a clarion call for independence and rang the knell for the colonial era. Names that deserve special mention include Roger Williams (1603-1683), John Woolman (1720-1772), Thomas Paine (1737-1809), Philip Freneau (1752-1832), and Charles Brockden Brown (1771-1810).

Roger Williams was one of the greatest Puritan dissenters in the early days of Puritan theocracy in New England. He came to America in 1630 and began to preach for civil and religious liberty and against the Puritan oligarchy of Boston. His call for democratic government and his opposition to the eviction of the Indians from their ancestral properties incurred the wrath and hatred of such "orthodox" Puritans as John Cotton (1584-1652), who banished him from the

Massachusetts Bay Colony in 1635. He lived for a while with the Indians before immigrating to Rhode Island, where he established the "Rhode Island Way" to encourage religious toleration, and protect Indian rights. In refutation of the arguments by John Cotton who, a "pillar of iron" in the early religious establishment, opposed the cause of conscience and supported religious persecution, Williams published his "The Bloody Tenet of Persecution for the Cause of Conscience" (1644), furiously attacking the "soul-killing" requirement of religious conformity and vigorously upholding the spiritual freedom of the individual. What merits special notice is the fact that Williams anticipated John Locke (1632-1704) by over forty years in his call for "civil right," when he expressed the notion that sound government can only function with the approval of the people. Small wonder that, in the eyes of Cotton Mather (1663-1728), the orthodox Puritan, he was "the first rebel against the divine church order in the wilderness," and that his famous work "The Bloody Tenet" was ordered to be burned. Roger Williams will go down in American history as a staunch fighter for freedom and democracy.

Born into a pious Quaker family in New Jersey, John Woolman (1720-1772) was early convinced that true religion consisted in an inward life in which the heart loved and respected God and learned to exercise true justice and goodness toward men and brutes alike. Eventually he became a preacher, traveling far and wide in America, teaching goodness and piety, speaking against total depravity, original sin and limited atonement, and attacking all forms of iniquity, be it a social evil or the atrocious slavery system. Apart from the essays such as "Some Considerations on the Keeping of Negroes" and "A Plea for the Poor," in which he tried to plead for the rights of all men and for the abolition of the slavery system, he also kept a Journal for the most part of his life, recording his spiritual experiences of inward communication with God. The religious piety, the dedication to the ideal of humanitarianism, and the kind, gentle character of the man filled the pages in such simple yet immensely moving language that even the Chinese reader will be able to apprehend the best spirit of American Quakerism without difficulty. The Journal has been influential as a moral classic not only in nineteenth-century America but also in modern times. Thoreau and the New England Transcendentalists derived no small inspiration from Woolman.

The life of Thomas Paine (1737-1809) was one of continual, unswerving fight for the rights of man. He wrote a number of works of such a revolutionary and inflammatory character that it is no exaggeration to state that he helped to spur and inspire two greatest revolutions that his age witnessed. His *Common Sense*, declaring as it did that "Government, even in its best state, is but a necessary evil; in its worst state an intolerable one," attacked British monarchy and added fuel to the fire which was soon to bring the colossus of its colonial rule down in flames. Paine declared that the crisis with which the North American colonies were then faced could only be solved by an appeal to man's instincts and common sense and to "the clear, uniform and irresistibly obeyed" impulses of conscience. The booklet was warmly received in the colonies both as a justification for their cause of independence and as an encouragement to the painfully fighting people. Paine became a major influence in the American Revolution. Nor was this all. The first of his American Crisis series of pamphlets came out at one of the darkest moments of the revolution when Washington's troops had just suffered one of the worst defeats in the war and were in the process of retreating. When Washington had it read to the troops, it proved a heartening stimulus, a spurring excitement to further action with hope and confidence. "These are the times that try men's souls," it declared. "The harder the conflict, the more glorious the triumph." Paine was commended by the Congress of the United States for his distinguished service to the country.

Later he participated in the French Revolution, and wrote *The Rights of Man* and *The Age of Reason*, spreading the ideals of the French Revolution among the people. He was imprisoned during the "Reign of Terror" and escaped the guillotine only narrowly. He returned to America, only to die in poverty and in vilifications by the same people he had served three decades earlier.

Philip Freneau (1752-1832) was important in American literary history in a number of ways. Apart from the fact that he used his poetic talents in the service of a nation struggling for independence, writing verses for the righteous cause of his people and exposing British colonial savageries, he was a most notable representative of dawning nationalism in American literature. While still an undergraduate, he wrote in collaboration with one of his friends a poem entitled "The Rising Glory of America," the national spirit of which pointed forward to the intellectual and literary independence which achieved its maturity first in the writings of men like Emerson and Whitman and other pre-eminent writers of the nineteenth century. Almost alone of his generation, Freneau managed to peer through the pervasive atmosphere of imitativeness, see life around directly, and appreciate the natural scenes on the new continent and the native Indian civilization. Some of his most famous works, with their lyric quality, their sensuous imagery, and their fresh perception of nature and "noble savage," are distinctly American. Poems such as "The Wild Honey Suckle," "The Indian Burying Ground" and "The Dying Indian: Tomo Chequi" have been frequently anthologized. Here we may take a look at "The Wild Honey Suckle," just for a taste of his poetry.

The Wild Honey Suckle

Fair flower, that dost so comely grow,
Hid in this silent, dull retreat,
Untouched thy honied blossom blow,
Unseen thy little branches greet:
No roving foot shall crush thee here,
No busy hand provoke a tear.

By Nature's self in white arrayed,
She bade thee shun the vulgar eye,
And planted here the guardian shade,
And sent soft waters murmuring by;
Thus quietly thy summer goes,
Thy days declining to repose.

Smit with those charms, that must decay,
I grieve to see your future doom;
They died - or were those flowers more gay,
The flowers that did in Eden bloom;
Unpitying frosts, and Autumn's power
Shall leave no vestige of this flower.

From morning suns and evening dews
At first thy little being came:
If nothing once, you nothing lose,

For when you die you are the same:
The space between, is but an hour,
The frail duration of a flower.

The lyric beauty, the heartfelt pathos, and the multiple emotional responses and echoes that the sight described can awaken in the bosoms of the readers - all these are simply amazing. The poem is no doubt a graphic illustration of Freneau's poetic genius. Here we see Freneau moving his eyes from the relics of the Old World over to his own continent to enjoy the beauty that the American landscape is capable of offering to the observing and appreciative eyes. It is a kind of beauty that people in those days had to learn to become aware of. Freneau's observation is historically significant because, to many writers of his and later periods, the new nation was poor in material for people with some literary ambitions. It took a Cooper, a Hawthorne, and a Henry James to eventually find some "usable past" in American history to use in their literary endeavors. This Freneau poem also offers in a tangential way, along with other early writers like William Byrd II, Timothy Dwight, and Thomas Jefferson, a vision of an abundant America with the potential for providing a good life for all. The poem is an indication of the poet's dedication to American subject matter as he examined the peculiar characteristics of the American countryside. Freneau's "The Indian Burying Ground," in addition to giving recognition to the Native American culture as a potential indigenous subject for American writers, reveals not only his tolerance of a different way of life, but also his admiration for it. Freneau was the most important poet of eighteenth-century America. Some of his themes and images anticipated the works of such nineteenth-century American Romantic writers as Cooper, Emerson, Poe, and Melville.

Mention should be made of Charles Brockden Brown (1771-1810) and other eminent 18th-century novelists. These included Francis Hopkinson (1737-1791) with his *A Pretty Story* (1774), William Hill Brown with his *The Power of Sympathy; or The Triumph of Nature* (1789), Hugh Henry Brackenridge (1748-1816) with his *Modern Chivalry* (1792-1815), Gilbert Imlay (1754-1828) with his *The Emigrants* (1793), and Mrs. Susanna Haswell Rowson (1762-1824) and her *Charlotte Temple* (1791). These were in a way all writers of transition, who did the spadework for later comers. They wrote about American subjects such as the westering movement and the American Indians and laid the solid foundation for the American novel. But they were imitative, modeling their writings on British authors. This was to affect their permanence in history.

One most prominent among these writers was Charles Brockden Brown, whose first novel, *Wieland; or, The Transformation: An American Tale* (1798) has been regarded as the first American novel. Basically, Brown was an imitator. The Gothic features of his works are a good illustration. But he did a few things for which he has been remembered. One of these was his awareness that his inspiration was rooted in his own land, its new life and energy which, he felt, offer the writers with areas of exploration different from European subjects. Brown believed that his novels were all about his country and his people and that he employed new narrative techniques hitherto unheeded by his predecessors. He pointed out that the conflicts with the Indians and the dangers of the wilderness of the American west were far more appropriate subjects for novelists than naive superstitions, outdated customs and Gothic castles and ghosts. His four major novels - *Edgar Huntly* (1799), *Ormond* (1799), *Arthur Mervyn* (1800), as well as *Wieland* - are all solid evidence of his literary beliefs put into practice. In this respect he may well have been a source of inspiration to later writers such as James Fenimore Cooper (1789-1851) and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1807-1886) although he did not possess Cooper's kind of mythic vision

of his subjects like the westward movement. Another thing of historic significance that Brown did was his description of his characters' inner world. Some of his early writings such as the one carried in *Columbia Magazine* about a romantic, lonely introvert roaming the wilderness near a town indicates Brown's consciousness of the complexity of the human emotional spectrum. Contributing to Brown's awareness of this were John Locke (1632-1704) and his ideas on sensual experiences, and the discussions on philosophy and literature in which Brown participated in a New York club. Brown began to explore the emotional world of his characters and found that man is not always controlled by reason and that sensual experiences, passion and illusion could all impact human thinking and emotional responses. He became aware that the subconscious is mystic and unfathomable and that art is a necessary medium to externalize the deeper impulses of the human psyche. In a manner of speaking, Brown's works can be read as psychological novels. His protagonists - Wieland or Huntly or Ormond - all exhibit the essential characteristics of a neurotic. His minute description of the human soul reveals his acumen in observation and compassion as a fellow human. All these opened up areas of interest for later writers like Edgar Allan Poe and Nathaniel Hawthorne to further explore. Brown is found wanting in depth and scope when compared with these authors, but it was important that he took that road first.

The period of some two centuries from the arrival of the Mayflower through the end of the eighteenth century was, from a literary point of view, one in which the national experience of the American settlers building the wilderness into a habitable place groped and struggled for literary expression. It represents a process in which colonial literature strove for a higher degree of excellence and evolved slowly but steadily toward an indigenous American literature. If the eighteenth-century literary scene looked still barren and bleak, there appeared at least certain figures who exercised something like a seminal influence on the subsequent development of American literature.

CHAPTER 2 Edwards ranklin revecoeur

In his famous *America's Coming of Age* (1915), Van Wyck Brooks attempted a general survey of eighteenth-century America and the American character:

For three generations the prevailing American character was compact in one type, the man of action who was also the man of God. Not until the eighteenth century did the rift appear.... It appeared in the two philosophers, Jonathan Edwards and Benjamin Franklin, who share the eighteenth century between them. In their amazing purity of type and in the apparent incompatibility of their aims they determined the American character as a racial fact, and after them the Revolution became inevitable.... Strange that at the very outset two men should have arisen so aptly side by side and fixed the poles of our national life! For no one has ever more fully and typically than Jonathan Edwards displayed the infinite inflexibility of the upper levels of the American mind, nor any one more typically than Franklin the infinite flexibility of its lower levels.

This is a penetrating analysis, exhaustive in many ways, of American Puritanism as a cultural heritage as well. What Brooks is trying to say is, as indeed we tried to illustrate in our previous talk, that American Puritanism is a two-faceted tradition of religious idealism and levelheaded common sense. Jonathan Edwards represents the former aspect, and Franklin the latter. The one was as a good Puritan as the other.

Eighteenth-century American thinking was dominated, by and large, by two basic patterns

of thought. Toward the latter part of the seventeenth century, a completely new view of the universe came into being. With the publication of Newton's "Philosophiae Naturalis Principia Mathematica" in which his laws of motion and the idea of universal gravitation were embodied, the universe became, in the minds of thinking people, something mechanical, like a clock, subject, instead of to the close supervision of God, to certain physical and mechanical laws. This gave rise to a whole set of new ideas and philosophies, predominant among which was deism. The deists hold that God is indeed the creator of the universe, "the maker of the clock," but He has left it to operate according to natural law. Thus the best way to worship God is to study his handiwork, namely, the natural world and the human world, and to do good things to mankind. Voltaire (1694-1778) and Rousseau (1712-1778) in France and Alexander Pope (1688-1744), Daniel Defoe (1659-1731) and Samuel Johnson (1709-1784) in England were all great voices of the new concept of the universe that was radically different from the hitherto domineering Christian position of original sin and predestination. Rousseau, in his famous Social Contract for example, declared to a bewildered world that man is by nature good and free. Alexander Pope wrote in his Essay on Man the famous line, "The proper study of mankind is man." The encyclopedists like Diderot (1713-1784) brought out their 35-volume monumental encyclopedia to offer a rational explanation of the universe, to celebrate Newton's discoveries and all the advances of science, to show what man's reason can achieve. The idea of order became the watchword of the day. Everything fell into some order, like Newton's "clock," and all had a place in the divine plan. All these ideas were very much in the air in America then, and no one represented them better than Benjamin Franklin. **With Franklin as its spokesman, eighteenth-century America experienced an age of enlightenment, reason, and order like England and Europe.**

Constantly in collision with these ideas were the persistent Calvinist beliefs and tenets that man was, since the Fall, basically evil and enslaved by his sense of sin, and that God was all, and would in His mercy and love work for man's salvation, but as for man, all he could do (if ever there was anything he could do) was to worship the Almighty and hope. Though Newton's idea was very influential over the minds of the people in the eighteenth century, the Calvinist position did not seem to be dead. The best testimony that it was still, on the contrary, very much alive was the "Great Awakening" in North America, in fact a series of religious revivals which occurred in the 1730s and 1740s, Jonathan Edwards was probably the last great voice that was ever heard in America to reassert the Calvinist stance so as to bring the people back to its fold.

Edwards (1703-1758) was born into a very religious New England family. Well prepared by his father, he entered Yale at the age of 13. After graduation in 1720, he stayed on at Yale for a couple of years before he went to a New York Scotch Presbyterian church. In 1723 he returned to Yale, took his M. A., and became a tutor. Three years later (1726), he became, first, assistant to his famous grandfather, Solomon Stoddard, the well-known minister of the church of Northampton, Massachusetts and, then, its minister. He preached with horrific vividness in order to make religious ideas felt along the senses. His sermons taught the power of God and the depravity of man and man's need to communicate with the Holy Spirit to receive God's grace. What he was trying to do was to reinstate these Calvinist ideas in ways acceptable to an audience already becoming susceptible to the ideas of Enlightenment. Having realized that Calvinism had had its day, he spoke with great earnestness that humbled his people and made them tremble before an angry God. As a powerful preacher, at one time joining hands with George Whitefield, a fabulous English evangelist, in a preaching tour in America, he was in part instrumental in bringing about

the "Great Awakening." He became famous not only in his own country, but won a measure of international recognition as well. But the religious controversy, which came in the wake of the "Great Awakening," hurt Edwards so that he left in 1750 for Stockbridge, Massachusetts, dismissed from the office he had held for over twenty years. There as pastor to an Indian community, he meditated in solitude and seclusion upon subjects of great theological and philosophical interest and wrote, in the next eight most productive years of his life, his greatest works that have made people remember him even today. These include *The Freedom of the Will* (1754), *The Great Doctrine of Original Sin Defended* (1758), and *The Nature of True Virtue* (1765). The publication of his writings made him famous, and he was invited, in 1758, to be president of the college of New Jersey (Princeton), but before he could assume the office, he died of a smallpox inoculation.

Edwards was, probably, at once the first modern American and the country's last medieval man. Reading his books, one cannot fail to mistake the modern consciousness of the man. He was influenced to no small extent by Newton's mechanical view of the universe and, although it would be unjust to talk of him as being intentionally close to the position that the best way to worship God is to study his creation, there are obvious traces of the man trying to hold the mythical and pantheistic tendencies in check both in his sermons and writings. And his thinking was obviously colored by the Lockean thesis that knowledge is not given from on high, and that it is empirical, its sources being the senses. Read his writings like "Personal Narrative," and we shall find a Calvinist writing about his personal discovery, his personal revelation of God. We shall understand that his knowledge of God is not chiefly inherited from his forebears, but is personally experienced. Read, then, his sermons like "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God," and we shall find the man trying to convince his flock of the almightiness of God in a figurative language mainly intended to appeal to their senses. Edwards was obviously grappling in all his intellectual life with the knotty problem of reconciling Puritan ideas with the new rationalism of Locke and Newton.

The same works reveal the medieval mind of the man. Edwards represents the element of piety, the religious passion, the aspect of emotion and ecstasy, of the New England tradition, a tradition that he did his best but failed to revitalize. He discovered, beneath the dogmas of the old theology, a dynamic world filled with the presence of God. We know from Edwards' own account that from childhood he had experienced sweet delight in religion. He used to retire to secret places of his own in the woods to pray, sometimes five times a day. As he grew up he kept his religious exercises. Reading the Holy Scripture one day, he felt, all of a sudden, a sense of the glory of God, the Divine Being, diffused into his soul, and on another day, he saw, from the words he was reading, the loveliness and beauty of Jesus Christ. He liked to walk in the woods, to be solitary, far from all mankind, so as to sweetly converse with Christ, to be wrapped and swallowed up in God. Now this is what is meant by the inward communication of soul with God, by "conversion" through the heart rather than through reason. He dedicated himself to God, giving himself and all that he had to God on January 12, 1723, and went to converse with God in a solitary place more often than before. Once, going out into the woods in 1737 and walking for divine contemplation and prayer, he had a view which he called "extraordinary," a view of the glory of the Son of God in his "wonderful, great, full, pure and sweet grace and love, and meek and gentle condescension." He cried with joy and recorded the experience of ecstasy in his "Personal Narrative," a spiritual autobiography, in this way:

I felt an ardency of soul to be... emptied and annihilated; to lie in the dust, and to be full of Christ alone; to love him with a holy and pure love; to trust in him; to live upon him; to serve and follow him; and to be perfectly sanctified and made pure, with a divine and heavenly purity.

Edwards believes in the regeneration of man. He urges his people to enjoy the sweetness of "conversion," the change of heart with the help of the grace of God. He abhorred the spiritual apathy of his flock and lashed at them with the terrible whip of his tongue: "all that were never born again, and made new creatures, and raised from being dead in sin, to a state of new, and before altogether unexperienced light and life... you are thus in the hands of angry God; it is nothing but His mere pleasure that keeps you from being this moment swallowed up in everlasting destruction." The "enthusiasm" of Edwards' was such that no one, it seems, could be more religious and pious. There was a good deal of Anne Hutchinson in Jonathan Edwards.

The Puritans were opposed to mysticism and pantheism because these tended to destroy the transcendence of God. They conceded, however, that God is immanent, and that His presence is noticeable in the world that He created. In some of Edwards' writings the sense of God's overwhelming presence in nature and in the soul finds explicit, perfect expression. He holds that God who is Himself the source of all being, the substance of all life, created the world out of Himself by diffusing Himself into time and space. He made the world by an extension of Himself, by taking upon Himself the forms of stones and trees and men. The implication of all this is, of course, that God manifests Himself in nature and man, and that man, being a part of God, is divine. To Edwards the beauty of the skies, trees, fields, and flowers is a manifestation of spiritual excellence. Everything is an image or shadow of the divine. The clear blue sky denotes for him the glory of the departed saints. The growth of grass and other vegetables dependent on the rain and the heat of the sun represents for him "the dependence of our spiritual welfare on God's gracious influences and the effusions of His Holy Spirit." The extreme fierceness and extraordinary power of lightning is an intimation of the exceeding power and terribleness of the wrath of God. When Edwards saw the sun rise out of darkness and from under the earth, raising the whole world with it, raising mankind out of their beds and brightening up everything, he thought of Jesus Christ rising from His grave and from a state of death and bringing happiness, life and light to the world of man. His *Images or Shadows of Divine Things* contains a great many instances of this kind which were part of the Puritan typological tradition and, in the way that Edwards extends typology beyond the strict limits of the Bible, the work anticipated the nature symbolism of nineteenth-century Transcendentalism. In his doctrines of inward communication of God and man, and of the immanence of God in nature, and in his literary expression of all these ideas, Edwards was, in the words of F. I. Carpenter, a good deal of a transcendentalist. The mystical implications of his Puritan idealism was to be developed and given full, explicit realization by Ralph Waldo Emerson in the next century.

To see Edwards in proper historical perspective, it is good to quote Van Wyck Brooks once more: "the current of Transcendentalism, originating in the piety of the Puritans, becoming a philosophy in Jonathan Edwards, passing through Emerson, [produced] the... refinement and aloofness of the chief American writers..."

Standing at the other end of the spectrum was Benjamin Franklin (1706-1790), who represents everything that Edwards does not. Contemporaneous and contrasting, the two men may be the most closely linked antagonists in the intellectual history of America. As Perry Miller observes, both came from the same parent stock, the Puritanism of New England, and each may be

said to have realized a potentiality that was inherent in the original creed: they represent the paradox of Puritan materialism and immateriality. Between them they represent the whole of the colonial mind of America.

Franklin came from a very simple Calvinist background. Born in 1706 into a poor candle-maker's family "poor and obscure" as he says of himself in his Autobiography, he had very little formal education. As he was a voracious reader, however, he managed to make up for the deficiency by his own effort. When still very young he was apprenticed to his older half-brother, a printer, and began at 16, to publish essays under the pseudonym, Silence Dogood, essays commenting on social life in Boston. At 17 he ran away to Philadelphia to make his own fortune. His entrance into the city marked the beginning of a long success story of an archetypal kind. He set himself up as an independent printer and publisher, founded the Junto Club (a society meeting regularly for informal discussions of good books, business ethics etc.) and a subscription library, issued the immensely popular Poor Richard's Almanac and retired around forty-two years of age, soon after he became financially independent. He felt that he could now do what was to him a great happiness: read, make scientific experiments, and do good to his fellowmen. He helped found the Pennsylvania Hospital, an academy which led to the University of Pennsylvania, and the American Philosophical Society. Nor was this all. Among the things which he started and for which he is still remembered today were volunteer fire departments, effective street lighting, the Franklin Stove, bifocal glasses, and efficient heating devices. His research on electricity, his famous experiment with his kite line, the experiment that won Immanuel Kant's admiration when the German philosopher called him "the new Prometheus who had stolen fire [electricity in this case] from heaven," his lightning-rod, the recognition he won from the Royal Society of London all these made him one of the preeminent scientists of his day.

Franklin's public career began in the early 1750s. He became a member of the Pennsylvania Assembly, the Deputy Postmaster-General for the colonies, and for some eighteen years served as representative of the colonies in London, protecting their interests in the English court. In the meantime he wrote a good deal of propaganda, supporting the colonies in their disputes with Britain. During the War of Independence, he was made a delegate to the Continental Congress and a member of the committee to write the Declaration of Independence. He was instrumental in bringing France into an alliance with America against England, and played a decisive role at the Constitutional Convention. He was the only American to sign the four documents that created the United States: the Declaration of Independence, the treaty of alliance with France, the treaty of peace with England, and the constitution. He was one of the makers of the new nation.

Franklin was a rare genius in human history. Nature seemed particularly lavish and happy when he was shaped. Everything seems to meet in this one man, mind and will, talent and art, strength and ease, wit and grace, and he became almost everything: a printer, postmaster, almanac maker, essayist, scientist, orator, statesman, philosopher, political economist, ambassador, parlor man "Jack of all trades," Herman Melville thus described him, "master of each and mastered by none the type and genius of his land." He seemed to be born with King Midas' golden touch: in whatever field he happened to appear, he achieved a peerless degree of accomplishment. Thus it is no wonder that he won the admiration of some of his greatest contemporaries on both sides of the Atlantic. Thomas Carlyle styled him the father of all Yankees; and **for quite some time he was regarded as the father of his country, even more than Washington was.** The symbol of America in the Age of Enlightenment, he brought the colonial era to a close. It is true that, in the reaction of

the Romantic period that followed, Franklin's image as representing the Age of Reason was tarnished a little, and that Emerson in the nineteenth century and William Carlos Williams in the present (to name just two) both felt that America had had too much of Franklin. And both Sainte Beuve, the French critic and author, and D. H. Lawrence agree that Franklin was everything but a poet. However, all these and many other similar comments do not alter the fact that he was one of the greatest of men.

Franklin's claim to a place in literature rests chiefly on his *Poor Richard's Almanac* and *Autobiography*. For almost a quarter of a century he kept publishing *Poor Richard's Almanac*, expanding its literary part to the intense delight of its readers. Apart from poems and essays, he managed to put in a good many adages and commonsense witticisms which became, very quickly, household words and, for many, mottoes of the most practical kind. He did not always write the maxims himself. His sources are often easily identifiable. But though he borrowed from such writers as Rabelais, Defoe, Swift, and Pope, he made good use of his own wit and wisdom to simplify and enrich their axioms. Thus sayings like "Lost time is never found again," "A penny saved is a penny earned," "God help them that help themselves," "Fish and visitors stink in three days" and "Early to bed, and early to rise, makes a man healthy, wealthy, and wise" ?these and many other similar statements filled the almanac, and taught as much as amused. The practical wisdom of Franklin shone forth rays of grandeur from its pages.

The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin was probably the first of its kind in literature. It is the simple yet immensely fascinating record of a man rising to wealth and fame from a state of poverty and obscurity into which he was born, the faithful account of the colorful career of America's first self-made man. The book consists of four parts, written at different times. Franklin was sixty-five when he first wrote it. He was then staying with an English family of five daughters, to whom he must have told, in his charmingly humorous way, the tale of the adventures of a runaway boy, and was urged to write it down. He must have thought of his son, William, who was very close to him when the boy was growing up, and must have written his own life story first for his edification since he began it with "My dear son." The question he asked in the account is how a man should live his life, and the book furnishes the best answer he thought his life had been able to offer. The first part, about eighty pages, he wrote with extraordinary facility, bringing the story of his life down to 1730. He did not write anything more until 1784 when he added some more pages. The third part was written in 1788, and some months before his death he labored to write a brief, fragmentary fourth part, carrying the story up to his retirement.

The *Autobiography* is, first of all, a Puritan document. It is Puritan because it is a record of self-examination and self-improvement. The Puritans, as a type, were very much given to self-analysis. Because they believed in predestination, the Puritans and Calvinists constantly examined their conscience to ascertain for themselves how much more they should do to ensure salvation. Thus they were most of them great keepers of diaries and journals. Reading *The Autobiography*, one sees an old man, serene and cool, casting a backward glance, looking intensely into his past life and, pen in hand, carefully noting down his experience as if in this way, he could communicate with God. The meticulous chart of thirteen virtues he set for himself to cultivate to combat the tempting vices, the stupendous effort he made to improve his own person, the belief that God helps those who help themselves and that every calling is a service to God ?all these indicate that Franklin was intensely Puritan. Then, the book is also a convincing illustration of the Puritan ethic that, in order to get on in the world, one has to be industrious, frugal, and

prudent.

The Autobiography is also an eloquent elucidation of the fact that Franklin was spokesman for the new order of eighteenth-century enlightenment, and that he represented in America all its ideas, that man is basically good and free by nature, endowed by God with certain inalienable rights of liberty and the pursuit of happiness. Typical among the virtues he listed for himself to acquire is "order," a predominant notion of the Age of Enlightenment, the watchword of the eighteenth century, as best exemplified, in literature for instance, in the balanced, symmetrical and rigidly formal heroic couplets of Alexander Pope and his school. Then there is moderation: "Avoid extremes," Franklin told himself and, for that matter, his fellowmen, and we know that for that century moderation and temperance were among the best virtues of man. The whole book is an impressive record of a man trying to be of value to mankind: Franklin spent his whole life doing all kinds of things for the welfare of the world, as indeed we have noted a moment earlier. Creating as it does the image of a boy's rise from rags to riches, the book demonstrates Franklin's confident belief that the new world of America was a land of opportunities which might be met through hard work and wise management, and that "one man of tolerable abilities will work great changes and accomplish great affairs among mankind." Thus through telling a success story of self-reliance, the book celebrates, in fact, the fulfillment of the American dream. The spirit of self-reliance, originating from Puritan ethics, bloomed in the next century into Emerson's transcendentalist "infinite of the private individual," and the dream, adding more to itself in the age of Jackson, went through different phases of frustration, and evaporated, it seems, in the tragic failure of the great Gatsby, a veritable image of a latter-day Franklin. Franklin was supremely human. He knew humanity's foibles and deficiencies, but he was convinced, as his Autobiography shows, that man is good and capable of becoming better, and that, although men and institutions are often corrupt, they might be improved. Had this belief failed to triumph over the doctrine of people like Jonathan Edwards, the American Revolution would have been impossible.

Now a look at the style of The Autobiography will readily reveal that it is the pattern of Puritan simplicity, directness, and concision. The plainness of its style, the homeliness of imagery, the simplicity of diction, syntax, and expression are some of the salient features we cannot mistake. To illustrate, we may quote a passage:

And now I speak of thanking God, I desire with all humility to acknowledge that I owe the mentioned happiness of my past life to his kind providence, which led me to the means I used and gave them success. My belief of this induces me to hope, though I must not presume, that the same goodness will still be exercised toward me, in continuing that happiness, or enabling me to bear a fatal reverse, which I may experience as others have done, the complexion of my future fortune being known to Him only in whose power it is to bless to us even our afflictions.

The lucidity of the narrative, the absence of ornaments in wording and of complex, involved structures in syntax, and the Puritan abhorrence of paradox are all graphically demonstrated here and in the whole of the book. It is true that, in style, the first part written as a letter to his son is best; however, its easy, leisurely and reminiscent kind of style becomes overburdened with moral consideration in the rest of the book as Franklin was persuaded by his friends that he should write his memoirs for the benefit of posterity. But taken as a whole, it is safe to say that the book is an exemplary illustration of the American style of writing.

When we have talked about the embodiment in Franklin of the American dream and Franklin's sense of optimism, we must not lose sight of another aspect of life in the New World.

As we noted in an earlier chapter, the American dream began, as a matter of fact, with the settlement of the American continent. The wilderness filled the Puritans with the hope of restoring the Garden of Eden, and looked like the "Promised land" with which God rewarded His chosen people. Thus for a long time the hope kept floating before the people, keeping them happy and optimistic about the future. The note of pessimism may have made itself first heard and heeded in Mark Twain's *The Gilded Age*, but it began to vibrate in a much earlier book. We mean Hector St. John de Crevecoeur's *Letters from an American Farmer* (1775). Crevecoeur was a French settler. Obviously inflated with the hope that here at last in the New World man would be able to shake off the shackles of the old and live the way mankind should, he wrote letters back to Europe, explaining the meaning of America to the outside world. The first eight of Crevecoeur's twelve letters reveal the pride of a man being American, the "new man," planted in a new world, who left behind him the old world with its oppression and servility, working and getting "rewards of his industry" and acquiring the dignity and self-confidence of a true human being in what he called "the most perfect society now existing in the world." In his letters we hear the note of pride in democratic equality and abundance of opportunity, a note we are to hear over and again in the writings of later American authors. It is evident that, to Crevecoeur, the American is a new man acting on new principles: He is self-sufficient, self-reliant, and essentially self-made. Crevecoeur saw and spoke of the hope of a new Garden of Eden materializing in America.

What merits special notice is the fact, however, that, in his lifetime, Crevecoeur also saw and spoke of the illusory nature of that dream. In fact, starting from his ninth letter, he began to speak with a different voice, the voice of a definitely disillusioned man. There in the same New World, he became aware of the existence of slavery, avarice, violence, famine and disease, and all other forms of evil that he thought the American had left behind with his migration to this side of the Atlantic. His picture of an African American slave left to the tender mercies of nature itself, being pecked to death by birds of prey, is such a grisly sight that the reader can never forget it. As a matter of fact, a careful reader may have heard echoes of this tragic note in Crevecoeur's earlier letters which describe, often in minute detail, the life-and-death struggles between different species of the animal kingdom, and may have seen a ghastly picture of what Tennyson later portrayed as "nature red in tooth and claw," a picture that foreshadows "man's folly and inhumanity to man." Dismayed at the "civilized society" of the white European settlements, he looked toward the Indian tribes for comfort and refuge. "There must be in their [the Indians'] social bond something singularly captivating," he thus wrote in one of his letters, "and far superior to anything to be boasted of among us [Europeans]..." Maybe, and this was what he was trying to say, there in the community of the Indians under their primitive wigwams, existed a better, even an ideal social order, with social cohesion and freedom from avarice and rapine and murder. Thus almost from the very beginning, the New World had in its constitution the elements of the old, and the ideal had as its twin brother the anti-ideal. If, with time, the note of hope is becoming ever thinner in American literature and that of disillusionment and even despair dominates more and more subsequent major works of major authors, we should not be unduly surprised. For it is, indeed, as it should be.

CHAPTER 3 American Romanticism

American Romanticism

We are now dealing with one of the most important periods in the history of American

literature, the Romantic period, which stretches from the end of the eighteenth century through the outbreak of the Civil War. Here we see a rising America fast burgeoning into a political, economic, and cultural independence it had never known before. Democracy and political equality became the ideals of the new nation. Radical changes came about in the political life of the country. Parties began to squabble and scramble for power, and a new system was in the making. The spread of industrialism, the sudden influx of immigrants, and the "pioneers" pushing the frontier further west—all these produced something of an economic boom and, with it, a tremendous sense of optimism and hope among the people. A nation bursting into new life cried for literary expression. The buoyant mood of the nation and the spirit of the times seem in some measure responsible for the spectacular outburst of romantic feeling in the first half of the nineteenth century. The literary milieu proved fertile and conducive to the imagination as well. Among other things, magazines appeared in ever-increasing numbers, of which *The North American Review*, *The New York Mirror*, *The American Quarterly Review*, *The New England Magazine*, *The Southern Review*, *The Southern Literary Messenger*, *The Atlantic Monthly*, *Harper's Magazine*, and the *Knickerbocker Magazine* played an important role in facilitating literary expansion in the country.

Foreign influences added incentive to the growth of romanticism in America. The Romantic movement, which had flourished earlier in the century both in England and Europe, proved to be a decisive influence without which the upsurge of American romanticism would hardly have been possible. Sir Walter Scott, Samuel Taylor Coleridge, William Wordsworth, Byron, Robert Burns, and many other English and European masters of poetry and prose all made a stimulating impact on the different departments of the country's literature. The influence of Sir Walter Scott was particularly powerful and enduring. His border tales and Waverley romances inspired many American authors such as James Fenimore Cooper with irresistible creative impulses. Scott's Waverley novels were models for American historical romances, and his *The Lady of the Lake*, together with Byron's Oriental romances, helped toward the development of American Indian romance. Scott was, in a way, responsible for the romantic description of landscape in American literature. The Gothic tradition and the cult of solitude and of gloom came through interest in the works of writers like Mrs. Radcliffe, E. T. A. Hoffman, James Thomson, and the "graveyard" poets. Robert Burns and Byron both inspired and spurred the American imagination for lyrics of love and passion and despair. The impact of Lyrical Ballads of Wordsworth and Coleridge added, to some extent, to the nation's singing strength. Thus American Romanticism was in a way derivative: American romantic writing was some of them modeled on English and European works.

Although foreign influences were strong, American Romanticism exhibited from the very outset distinct features of its own. It was different from its English and European counterpart because it originated from an amalgam of factors that were altogether American rather than anything else. American romanticism was in essence the expression of "a real new experience" and contained "an alien quality" for the simple reason that "the spirit of the place" was radically new and alien. For instance, the American national experience of "pioneering" into the west proved to be a rich fund of material for American writers to draw upon. The wilderness with its virgin forests, the sound of the axe cutting its way westward, the exotic landscape with its different sights, smells, and sounds (the robin rather than the nightingale is Emily Dickinson's "criterion of tone," for example), and the quaint, picturesque civilization of a primitive race—all these constituted an incomparably superior source of inspiration for native authors. A rude Natty Bumppo in buckskin, dwelling in a frontier blockhouse, treading a solitary bridle path through

virgin forests was, perhaps, matter enough for any romantic genius. And indeed, American authors were quite responsive to the stimulus which American life offered. Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's tentative treatment of the frontier and the Indians in his works such as *Hiawatha*, Washington Irving's portrayal of the scenes from the Hudson valley, William Cullen Bryant's sketches of the wild west prairie where no human being had ever set foot and James Fenimore Cooper's five Leatherstocking tales with "their majestic descriptions of America's limitless forests and broad blue inland lakes" ?these are but a few instances whereby the new American sensibility began to make itself felt. And, of course, we should not forget to mention Emerson, Thoreau, Hawthorne, Melville and Whitman, all people who were instrumental, in one way or another, in creating an indigenous American literature.

Then there is American Puritanism as a cultural heritage to consider. American moral values were essentially Puritan. Public opinion was overwhelmingly Puritan; the Puritan atmosphere of the nation predominantly conditioned social life and cultural taste. Nothing has left a deeper imprint on the character of the people as a whole than did Puritanism; no one has been so successful in imposing his way of thinking on the continent as the American Puritan. Puritan influence over American Romanticism was conspicuously noticeable. One of its palpable manifestations is the fact that American Romantic authors tended more to moralize than their English and European brothers. It is true that Edgar Allan Poe fought vehemently against "the heresy of the didactic," and writers like John Greenleaf Whittier tried to advocate both beauty and goodness. But the fact remains, nonetheless, that many American romantic writings intended to edify more than they entertained. There seemed to be areas of life, which it was better for them to leave alone, taboos of a kind that most of the literary world agreed, however tacit it may have been, on not breaking. Sex and love were, for instance, subjects American authors were particularly careful in approaching. Hawthorne's *The Scarlet Letter* talks eloquently about the effect of the adultery on the people rather than about the sin itself, and Whitman was for a long time misunderstood by his own countrymen because his *Leaves of Grass* contains lines and passages not at all palatable to their "genteel" taste.

Another thing to mention in connection with American Romanticism was the "newness" of the Americans as a nation. We observed, in an earlier talk, Crèvecoeur's conception of the American as "this new man." Although it is difficult for an outsider to agree with some American writers and critics and historians who placed apparently too much emphasis on this "newness," there is an amount of truth in describing the Americans as somewhat different from the Europeans. Their ideals of individualism and political equality, and their dream that America was to be a new Garden of Eden for man were distinctly American. The ideals may have been mere talk, and the dream may have been in the process of evaporating or even may have been just the figment of imagination, but their very existence in any form in the minds of the people did probably produce a feeling of "newness," a feeling strong enough to inspire the romantic imagination and channel it into a different vein of writing. Hence the sense of mission with which some American romanticists undertook to represent their people in the New World. Anyone who tries to appreciate American literature in general and American romantic writing in particular in English and European terms will have to be content if they fail to find anything "great" there.

As a logical result of the foreign and native factors at work, American Romanticism was both imitative and independent. Writers like Irving and especially the group of New England poets such as William Bryant, Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, John Greenleaf Whittier, Oliver Wendell

Holmes, and James Russell Lowell tried to model their works upon English and European masters. These people cast a nostalgic glance across the Atlantic, and took their cue often from the English neoclassical authors like John Dryden, Alexander Pope, Joseph Addison, William Cowper, Oliver Goldsmith, Robert Burns, Edward Young, Thomas Gray, Byron and Wordsworth, to list just a few out of many. In their works they emphasized certain subjects and managed to avoid others. Thus their favorite themes included "home, family and children, nature, and idealized love" but they exhibited an apparent apathy to the major problems of American life like the westward expansion and democracy and equality. In technique they loved traditional meters and stanza forms; in language their English was usually British. Their metaphors were sometimes stereotyped and their symbolism tended to be explicit and superficial. Thus although they enjoyed popularity in their own day, they failed to speak to future generations. Even Longfellow is not much read today. This is not to suggest, however, that these people could be ignored. "The Flowering of New England" would have been impossible without their contribution.

Writers like Emerson and Whitman thought and wrote differently. Readers of American literature do hear voices peculiarly American even in colonial literary works such as Philip Freneau's "The Rising Glory of America," but talk of an independent national literature, commensurate with the nation's new political status, did not become generally significant until the third decade of the nineteenth century. Then we become aware of W. E. Channing's "Remarks on National Literature," Emerson's Nature, "The American Scholar" and "The Poet," and Whitman's announcement concerning an American national expression in his preface to the first edition of *Leaves of Grass*, and we agree with Robert Spiller who sees a vigorous literary independence in the process of emerging. Calling for the creation of a native American culture and literature, these people, as Spiller points out, represent "the deeper forces of a Romanticism at once indigenous and universal," and "the urge to create a literature distinct from and better than importations." They did what history meant them to do for American literature and deserve better and more detailed treatment in the few chapters on Romanticism that follow.

Washington Irving (1783-1859)

Irving was born into a wealthy New York merchant family. From a very early age he began to read widely and write juvenile poems, essays, and plays. Later, he studied law and led for a time the leisurely life of a gentleman lawyer, but he loved writing more. His first book *A History of New York from the Beginning of the World to the End of the Dutch Dynasty* (1809), written under the name of Diedrich Knickerbocker, was a great success and won him wide popularity. In 1815 he went to England to take care of his family business there, and when it failed, he had to write to support himself. With the publication of *The Sketch Book of Geoffrey Crayon, Gent.* (1819-1820), he won a measure of international recognition. In 1826 as an American diplomatic attaché he was sent to Spain where he gathered material for his *The History of the Life and Voyages of Christopher Columbus* (1828), *A Chronicle of the Conquest of Granada* (1829) and *The Alhambra* (1832). From 1829-1832 he was Secretary of the United States Legation in London. When he was about fifty, after an absence of seventeen years, he returned to America and bought Sunnyside, his famous home on the Hudson River at Tarrytown. There he spent the rest of his life, except for a period of four years (1842-1846) when he was away from home as Minister to Spain, living a life of leisure and comfort, and writing the *Life of Goldsmith* and a five-volume *Life of Washington* and a miscellany of other works. He died in 1859. He was not married.

Irving's contribution to American literature is unique in more ways than one. He did a

number of things that have been regarded as the first of their kind in America. He was the first American writer of imaginative literature to gain international fame: when he returned home in 1832, he was acclaimed as the one American author whom people in Europe knew about, and this Americans took as a sign that American literature was emerging as an independent entity. To say that he was father of American literature is not much exaggeration. The short story as a genre in American literature probably began with Irving's *The Sketch Book*, a collection of essays, sketches, and tales, of which the most famous and frequently anthologized are "Rip Van Winkle" and "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow." The book touched the American imagination and foreshadowed the coming of Hawthorne, Melville, and Poe, in whose hands the short story attained a degree of perfection as a literary tradition. It also marked the beginning of American Romanticism. The Gothic, the supernatural, and the longing for the good old days which some of its pieces clearly exhibit, are Romantic enough in subject if not exactly in style, as Irving wrote in the neoclassical tradition of Joseph Addison and Oliver Goldsmith. Looking at a picture of Irving surrounded by his other writers, one does sometimes think of the old man, benign and pleasant and refined, as the uncle of American authors.

Irving's career can be roughly divided into two important phases, the first of which span from his first book up to 1832, the other stretching over the remaining years of his life. The first period was predominantly "English," in which he was drawn, as if irresistibly, to the ruins and relics of Europe and writing, most of the time, about subjects either English or European. By temperament Irving seemed to be conservative and endowed with a love for the antique that amounted, sometimes, to an obsession. "The Authors Account of Himself," which opens *The Sketch Book*, is a confessional one and authentic as such:

... Europe held forth the charms of storied and poetical association. There were to be seen the masterpieces of art, the refinements of highly cultivated society, the quaint peculiarities of ancient and local custom. My native country was full of youthful promise: Europe was rich in the accumulated treasures of age. Her very ruins told the history of times gone by, and every moldering stone was a chronicle. I longed to wander over the scenes of renowned achievement to tread, as it were, in the footsteps of antiquity, to loiter about the ruined castle, to meditate on the falling tower, to escape, in short, from the commonplace realities of the present and lose myself among the shadowy grandeurs of the past.

He found value in the past and in the traditions of the Old World. America, being young (though promising), did not have what Europe had to offer for a man of imagination. His long sojourn in Europe proved both gratifying and rewarding. The Old World, enabling his fancy to work in white heat at times, found its way into his books with its picturesqueness, "ruins," and objects of antiquity. His books about Spain were good illustrations of this in addition to *The Sketch Book*.

Back in America, Irving found a whole new spirit of nationalism in American feeling and art and letters. American painters began to paint American landscape, and American poets stopped writing about nightingales. A few years before *Nature* and "The American Scholar" ?the "Declaration of Intellectual Independence" ?came out, the country was already agitating for an indigenous culture and literature. People, and Irving with them, awoke to the fact that there was beauty in America, too. In the last years of his life, Irving wrote a few books about the American West, such as *The Crayon Miscellany* which contains "A Tour on the Prairies," *Astoria*, and *Adventures of Captain Bonneville*. But these "American" books are of only secondary importance

in the Irving canon, and constitute the "minor phase" of his career.

Irving's style can only be described as beautiful. It is imitative, it is true, but he was a highly skillful writer. Never shocking and a bit sentimental at times, his manner seems more important than his matter. The gentility, urbanity, and pleasantness of the man all seem to have found adequate expression in his style. The adage, "The style is the man," applies to no one else so well. Responsive to sensuous experience, Irving was in fact recording his impressions in his writings. The reader sees, hears, smells, tastes and touches while reading him, and enjoys the lucid style probably as much as the stories. There are quite a few striking features which characterize Irving's writings. First, Irving avoids moralizing as much as possible; he wrote to amuse and entertain, which departs to no small extent from the basic principles of his Puritan forebears. Then he was good at enveloping his stories in an atmosphere, the richness of which is often more than compensation for the slimness of plot. His characters are vivid and true so that they tend to linger in the mind of the reader. The humor that has built itself into the very texture of his writings is such that reading him, it is difficult not to smile and occasionally even chuckle. And the finished and musical language (indeed, some people read Irving just for the music of his language) and the patent workmanship have been among the points of critical attention for a long time. There is a good deal of craft and skill in the man. If Franklin took pains to learn how to write well from Addison and Steele and Irving modeled himself on Goldsmith so that he is at times known as "the American Goldsmith," then a Chinese student of English may do well to read and even recite a little of Irving to improve his written English.

Irving has always been duly revered for his contribution to American literature, though it is necessary to know that, popular in his own time, he is now almost ignored except, perhaps, by the literary historian. He is best known as the author of "Rip Van Winkle" and "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow" on which his reputation seems to rest permanently. Both tales have been so famous and enduring in the history of American literature that they have become part of the American cultural tradition. For "Rip Van Winkle" Irving took suggestions from a German source. He changed the setting of the original and added conflicts of his own to make it American. It is a fantasy tale about a man who somehow stepped outside the main stream of life. Rip Van Winkle is, the story tells us, a simple, good-natured, and hen-pecked man. He does everything except take care of his own farm and family. He helps everyone except his wife and his own folks. He is welcome everywhere except at home. He is, Irving tells us, "one of those happy mortals, who take the world easy, eat white bread or brown, whichever can be got with least thought or trouble, and would rather starve on a penny than work for a pound. If left to himself, he would have whistled life away in perfect contentment." But his wife does not leave him in peace ("Rip" may be, incidentally, the telescopic form of "Rest in Peace"). She keeps "continually dinning in his ears about his idleness, his carelessness, and the ruin he is bringing on his family." Unable to stay happily at home, he finds refuge in the mountains, with his gun and dog as his companions. One afternoon he stays out late near the top of the mountain where he meets a group of odd-looking people playing at nine-pins. Out of curiosity, and being a thirsty soul, Rip drinks their wine and falls asleep. He wakes up to find his dog gone and his gun rusted. Back in his village, he is amazed at the tremendous changes that have taken place in what he thinks is just one night. Old houses have vanished, and so have some of his old friends. In place of the former little inn, there stands the large "Union Hotel," with a flag of stars and stripes fluttering in front of it. However, he is recognized by some of the old villagers and recognizes some of them. He discovers, to his great surprise, that he has slept for

twenty years. His wife has died; his son, every bit his counterpart in appearance and personality, is now a farm hand, and his daughter, now a happy mother, takes him home to live with her. Having nothing else to do, he begins to live the way he did before.

The story reveals, to some extent, the conservative attitude of its author. Rip went to sleep before the War of Independence and woke up after it. The change that had occurred in the twenty years he slept was to him not always for the better. Whereas, before the war, there had been peace and harmony, there came now the scramble for power between parties. What had been a disinterested, dispassionate idle talk about events and occurrences of the time, was now replaced by a passionate factional squabble. The tempo of life quickened. Pre-war leisurely existence acquired "a busy, bustling, disputatious tone." Instead of feeling happy about the country finally independent from the yoke of British colonial rule, Rip was pleased with his new life chiefly because "he had got his neck out of the yoke of matrimony." The story might be taken as an illustration of Irving's argument that change and revolution upset the natural order of things, and of the fact that Irving never seemed to accept a modern democratic America.

Then there is the equally famous "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow," in which there is the memorable event of an apparently headless horseman throwing his head at his rival in love, and the memorable character of Ichabod Crane with his mixture of shrewdness, credulity, self-assertiveness, and cowardice. No one, who has ever read the story of the clumsy, ungainly schoolmaster scared off by his rival in love who disguises himself as a ghost, is likely to forget it again. There are a few points of interest here that merit our notice. In place of a subtitle Irving writes "Found Among the Papers of the Late Diedrich Knickerbocker." Diedrich Knickerbocker is, as we noted a little earlier, the fictional author of *The History of New York* who, as literary historian A. H. Quinn points out, has baptized a whole section of America with his name. The fact that Irving does not claim to be original, that he seems to be reporting something for which he is not responsible this, together with the "Postscript: Found in the Handwriting of Mr. Knickerbocker," reminds us of Hawthorne who, among other things, professes to be retelling a story not always his own.

The creation of archetypes is a particularly subtle feat of Irving's consummate craftsmanship. We may see in Ichabod Crane a precocious, effete New Englander, shrewd, commercial, a city-slicker, who is rather an interloper, a somewhat destructive force, in village life, and who comes along to swindle the villagers. His book learning turns on him, and he is driven away from where he does not belong, so that the serene village remains permanently good and happy. Brom Bones, on the other hand, is of a Huck Finn-type of country bumpkin, rough, vigorous, boisterous but inwardly very good, a frontier type put out there to shift for himself. Thus the rivalry in love between Ichabod and Brom, viewed in this way, suddenly assumes the dimensions of two ethical groups locked in a kind of historic contest. As to the style of the piece, it represents Irving at his best. The association between a certain locale and the inward movement of a character, the emotional loading of almost every line of the story, their effect on the five senses of the reader whose attention is so fully engaged and who feels so much involved in what is happening all these have placed this and other Irving stories among the best of American short stories.

James Fenimore Cooper (1789-1851)

Born into a rich land-holding family of New Jersey, Cooper was one of the few American authors who did not have to worry about money. He was sent to Yale at 14 but was expelled in his junior year because of improper behavior. He went and spent five years at sea; then, while still in

his early twenties, he inherited his father's vast fortune and settled down to a life of comfort and even luxury. Cooper's career as an author began quite by accident. Tradition has it that, reading an English novel one day, he was so disgusted with it that he threw it down and said he could do better. His wife challenged him and he became serious about it. And succeed he did. After a mild success with his first book, the second one, *The Spy* (1821), a novel about the American Revolution, proved to be an immense success. In the three decades that followed, he wrote thirty-odd novels, including eleven of the sea, and a voluminous amount of other writings. However, he was best known in his own day and is still read and remembered today as the author of the "Leatherstocking Tales," a series of five novels about the frontier life of American settlers. James Russell Lowell, one of his younger contemporaries, was perceptive enough to say this of him: "He has drawn you one character, though, that is new of this fresh Western world..." Lowell meant, of course, Natty Bumppo.

Cooper's claim to greatness in American literature lies in the fact that he created a myth about the formative period of the American nation. If the history of the United States is, in a sense, the process of the American settlers exploring and pushing the American frontier forever westward, then Cooper's "Leatherstocking Tales," depicting as they do Natty Bumppo (in his various names such as Hawk-Eye, the Pathfinder, the Deerslayer or Leatherstocking so named because of his wearing leather leggings in the American Indian fashion) as a pioneer, effectively approximates the American national experience of adventure into the West. It is the history of modern civilization advancing on the receding wilderness, and of the juxtaposition of "the works of man and the reign of nature" on the American scene. Cooper wrote with increasing awareness of the importance to fiction of the Western frontier where, as Edwin S. Fussell observes, American society may be conceived as passing from one set of principles to another in two directions at once, and Cooper's power lay in his assurance that one direction was morally right and the other practically inevitable. Here lies Cooper's conflict of allegiances. He was at once devoted, to quote Henry Nash Smith, to the principles of social order and responsive to the idea of nature and freedom in the wilderness: Probably none of his contemporaries felt as deeply "the antithesis between nature and civilization, between freedom and law."

This ambivalence can be seen from the conflict between Leatherstocking and Judge Temple in *The Pioneers*. Published in 1823, *The Pioneers, or The Sources of the Susquehanna*, was the first of the Leatherstocking Tales. It is a romantic story of life in upstate New York ten years after the Revolution. **Its historical importance lies in the fact that it was probably the first true romance of the frontier in American literature.** The basic conflict of the story is, in essence, one between Leatherstocking who insists on man's old forest freedom and Judge Temple, standing at the head of the squire-archy on the frontier, to whom man remains savage without law and order. Judge Temple makes some deer laws forbidding shooting out of season, but Leatherstocking breaks them somehow. He is arrested, tried, and found guilty. His young friend, Oliver Effingham, helps him to escape and, when the right moment comes, tells the truth about his own identity as the grandson of Major Effingham, with whom Leatherstocking has served in the frontier wars, before Oliver and Elizabeth, Judge Temple's daughter, are duly married. Leatherstocking's faithful friend, old Indian John, dies of exhaustion in a forest fire. At the end of the novel Leatherstocking is seen, rifle over shoulder, trudging off toward the woods: His statement, "There's them living who say, that Nathaniel Bumppo's right to shoot on these hills is of older date than Marmaduke Temple's right to forbid him," rings clear and loud behind his disappearing figure.

It is evident that two forces were at work on the western frontier. On the one hand, Natty Bumppo represents the ideal American, living a virtuous and free life in God's world. To him, and to Cooper, the wilderness is good, pure, perfect, where there is freedom not tainted and fettered by any forms of human institutions. The grand knight of the prairie perhaps too good for his times, Natty Bumppo is a veritable embodiment of human virtues like innocence, simplicity, honesty, and generosity, a man born with an immaculate sense of good and evil and right and wrong. He finds "civilization" both corrupt and corrupting. "Might often makes right here as well as in the old country," he says to Judge Temple in the opening chapter of *The Pioneers*. What he rejects is in fact what Crèvecoeur says in his ninth letter, that the adventure into the new world has not produced an ideal social order, and that the "civilization" the white settlers imposed on the wilderness is poisoned at the root from the very beginning. Repudiating the various forms of civilization (in the five tales), Natty crusades against all its evils that he feels have disgraced his race.

On the other hand, there is Judge Temple the portrayal of whose character, it is interesting to note, is a good indication of Cooper's ambivalence as a writer of frontier life. It is not done without sympathy and feeling. Judge Temple's appearance is very impressive, with "a fine manly face, and particularly a pair of expressive, large blue eyes, that promised extraordinary intellect, covert humour, and great benevolence." And manly and benevolent he is in his dealings both with Leatherstocking and the Effinghams. If we follow him about, we will find that he is a man of honor and integrity, and we will probably come to the conclusion that he is as much a frontiersman as Natty Bumppo. He represents "the practically inevitable" aspect (to return to critic Fussell's thesis) of frontier life, whereas Natty Bumppo stands for its other, the morally right. Just as Bumppo embodies the idea of brotherhood of man and of nature and freedom, so Judge Temple symbolizes law and civilization. In his enactment of the law, he may have come into conflict with people like Leatherstocking, and in his effort to transplant "civilization" on a virgin land, he may have ruthlessly dispossessed the American Indians, but he does not appear mean and petty in the mind of the reader. Cooper probably means to say that the Judge's majestic residence with its spacious hall is just as much part of the general picture of frontier life as are the log cabins in one of which dwells Natty Bumppo, and that the aristocratic Judge is as good a pioneer as his "rebellious" fellow-villagers. It is, between them that they built the wilderness into anything like a civilized place. Hence the plural in the title of the book, *The Pioneers*.

Cooper is a mythic writer. His preface to the Leatherstocking series indicates that he wrote with increasing consciousness to create a mythic figure. He found myth an effective medium by which he could "reaffirm and transmit his values" (The words are Robert Spiller's). When Natty Bumppo first appears, we see a real frontiersman in his crude cabin, a man of flesh and blood in the virgin forests of North America. But as he moves out of *The Pioneers* into the world of *The Last of the Mohicans*, *The Prairie*, *The Pathfinder*, and *The Deerslayer*, he does so gathering more and more of a halo of a legendary and mythic nature around him. He becomes a type, a representation of a nation struggling to be born, progressing from old age to rebirth and youth. Reading the series in the order of their appearance in print, we find it hard to disagree with D. H. Lawrence when he says:

The Leatherstocking novels ... go backwards, from old age to golden youth. That is the true myth of America. She starts old, old, wrinkled and, writhing in an old skin. And there is a gradual sloughing of the old skin, towards a new youth: It is the myth of America.

First as transplanted Europeans, the Americans crept out of the trammels of the traditions of Europe and England and gradually came into their own. The five Cooper tales constitute a mythic reproduction of the whole process: The old and dying Leatherstocking in *The Pioneers* and *The Prairie* relives another phase of middle-age maturity in *The Last of the Mohicans* and *The Pathfinder* and enjoys another lease of youth in *The Deerslayer*. And if we stop to consider the fact that, of the five tales, three end in Natty's departure for the wilderness, and two (*The Last of the Mohicans* and *The Prairie*) with an Indian tribe, we cannot but agree with A. N. Kaul who sees the process as the American quest for an ideal community. And Cooper did not do this feat of authorship by any happy accident. He had ?or rather gradually acquired in the course of writing ?the intention to create a myth of his own. Fiction succeeds better, he says, "by delineation of principles and characters in their classes." Natty Bumppo as a fictional character is therefore the result of careful literary deliberations.

Cooper is good at inventing plots. He can complicate one quickly and well. His plots are sometimes quite incredible, it is true, but his stories are immensely intriguing. His landscape descriptions are majestic and suggestive of Sir Walter Scott, the legendary spirit of whose border tales might have been a source of inspiration for him: hence James Russell Lowell's line in *A Fable for Critics*: "... He [Cooper] need take no pains to convince us he's not... the American Scott." Cooper was, like Irving, quite conscious of the associations of different locales. He persuades himself, as he does in some of his prefaces, that the great lakes are, for instance, good places, linking them with art and character. The fact that he had never been to the frontier and among the Indians and yet could write five huge epic books about them is an eloquent proof of the richness of his imagination. His wilderness may not be real, but it is enormously appealing. His Indians may not be real; as a matter of fact they are all of Cooper's creation, always of a secondary importance in a white-centered situation, good or bad as Cooper's white pen adumbrates them, but **they are among the first Indians to appear in American fiction and probably the first group of noble savages**. Cooper has been known as a powerful yet clumsy writer. His style is dreadful, his characterization wooden and lacking in probability, and his language, his use of dialect, is not authentic. Mark Twain's comment on his literary technique is exceptionally harsh: in his opinion, one of the literary offences that Cooper committed was that he did not observe things accurately at all. But there is no doubt that his observations are also insightful and interesting.

Cooper hit upon the native subject of frontier and wilderness almost in spite of himself. He was troubled by the "poverty of materials" in America. From his first preface to *The Spy* in which he complained about the absence of lords or castles in America and about the scarcity of events, to his preface to *Lionel Lincoln* where he says "there is ... neither a dark, nor even an obscure, period in the American annals," and to the *Notions of the Americans* in which, in one of his letters on "Literature and the Arts," he says, "There is scarcely an ore which contributes to the wealth of the author.... There are no annals for the historian; no follies... for the satirist; no manners for the dramatist, no obscure fictions for the writer of romance, no gross and hardy offences against decorum for the moralist; nor any of the rich artificial auxiliaries of poetry" ?in all these writings the idea is both consistent and persistent. And Cooper concluded that it was the business of the American writer to discover new sources of fiction, cut off as he was from so many of those that had nourished European literature. He cast a glance backward in time. What he did in his novels like *Satanstoe* was to concentrate on one of the few places and times in American history that preserved, to some extent, the settled traditional life of rural England. Even the *Leatherstocking*

tales are set in the past. These relate the story of a man from 1740 through 1806. Thus he turned whatever American history can offer the West and the frontier as a usable past to good account and helped to introduce the "Western" tradition into American literature.

CHAPTER 4 New England Transcendentalism Emerson and Thoreau

New England Transcendentalism

In 1836 a little book came out which made a tremendous impact on the intellectual life of America. It was entitled *Nature* by Ralph Waldo Emerson. The New World was thrilled to hear the new voice it uttered. "The Universe is composed of Nature and the Soul," it says, "Spirit is present everywhere." It was apparent that the world had had enough of Benjamin Franklin, and a wind of change was beginning to blow. A whole new way of thinking began to exert its influence on the consciousness of man. Nature's voice pushed American Romanticism into a new phase, the phase of New England Transcendentalism, the summit of American Romanticism.

What is Transcendentalism? Emerson's answer in his essay, "The Transcendentalist," is probably the most definitive. "What is popularly called Transcendentalism among us," he declares, "is idealism; idealism as appears in 1842." What happened about this time was that some New Englanders, not quite happy about the materialistic-oriented life of their time, formed themselves into an informal club, the Transcendentalist Club, and met to discuss matters of interest to the life of the nation as a whole. They expressed their views, published their journal, the *Dial*, and made their voice heard. The club with a membership of some thirty men and a couple of women included Emerson, Thoreau, Bronson Alcott, and Margaret Fuller, most of them teachers or clergymen, radicals reacting against the faith of Boston businessmen and the cold, rigid rationalism of Unitarianism. The word, "Transcendental," was not native to America; it was a Kantian term denoting, as Emerson puts it, "Whatever belongs to the class of intuitive thought." The major features of New England Transcendentalism can be summarized as follows: First, the Transcendentalists placed emphasis on spirit, or the Oversoul, as the most important thing in the universe. The Oversoul was an all-pervading power for goodness, omnipresent and omnipotent, from which all things came and of which all were a part. It existed in nature and man alike and constituted the chief element of the universe. Now this, obviously, represented a new way of looking at the world. It was apparently a reaction to the eighteenth-century Newtonian concept of the universe: In the eighteenth century it was generally held that the world was made up of matter. It was also a reaction against the direction that a mechanized, capitalist America was taking, against the popular tendency to get ahead in world affairs to the neglect of spiritual welfare. Secondly, the Transcendentalists stressed the importance of the individual. To them the individual was the most important element of society. As the regeneration of society could only come about through the regeneration of the individual, his perfection, his self-culture and self-improvement, and not the frenzied effort to get rich, should become the first concern of his life. The ideal type of man was the self-reliant individual whom Emerson never stopped talking about all his life. The Transcendentalists like Emerson and Thoreau were telling people to depend upon themselves for spiritual perfection if they cared to make the effort because, in their opinion, the individual soul communed with the Oversoul and was therefore divine. Now this new notion of the individual and his importance represented, obviously, a new way of looking at man. It was a reaction against the Calvinist concept that man is totally depraved, he is sinful and perseveres in sinhood, and can not hope to be saved except through the grace of God. It was also a reaction against the process of

dehumanization that came in the wake of developing capitalism. The industrialization of New England was turning men into nonhumans. People were losing their individuality and were becoming uniform. The Transcendentalists saw the process in progress and, by trying to reassert the importance of the individual, emphasized the significance of men regaining their lost personality. Thirdly, the Transcendentalists offered a fresh perception of nature as symbolic of the Spirit or God. Nature was, to them, not purely matter. It was alive, filled with God's overwhelming presence. It was the garment of the Oversoul. Therefore it could exercise a healthy and restorative influence on the human mind. What the Transcendentalists seemed to be saying was, "Go back to nature, sink yourself back into its influence, and you'll become spiritually whole again." The natural implication of all this was, of course, that things in nature tended to become symbolic, and the physical world was a symbol of the spiritual. This in turn added to the tradition of literary symbolism in American literature.

Now, New England Transcendentalism was the product of a combination of foreign influences and the American Puritan tradition. Romantic idealism, as Transcendentalism has come to be called, can be said to have begun with the introduction of idealistic philosophy from Germany and France. The idealistic concepts of Schelling and Fichte as well as of Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* found their way to America. Thomas Carlyle's *Sartor Resartus* with its "idealism," "organic filaments," and "natural supernaturalism," and Coleridge's *Aids to Reflection* and *The Friend*, which Emerson read, all helped to spread idealism in the country. French eclecticism, especially that of Cousin, Collard, Gerando, and Jouffroy, also proved, to be an effective means for the transmission of Kantian and Platonic doctrine to America. It should also be noted that Transcendentalists like Emerson and Thoreau were indebted to Oriental mysticism as embodied in such Hindu works as Upanishads and Bhagavad-Gita and to the doctrine and philosophy of the Chinese Confucius and Mencius.

If we go back to our previous chapter on Jonathan Edwards and Benjamin Franklin, we will observe how much American Transcendentalism was indebted to the dual heritage of American Puritanism. The Edwardian notion of inward communication of the soul with God and divine symbolism of nature all find adequate expression in Emersonian Transcendentalism. As Charles Feidelson noted, Emerson recaptured the Edwardian vision and stated his ideas in terms of transcendental idealism, of Oversoul, and in the language of Nature, "Self-Reliance," and "The Divinity School Address." What Emerson and his fellow Transcendentalists (all men of religion by training and temperament) endeavored to do was in fact primarily to reassert the religious idealism of their Puritan past and rephrase their thoughts in forms and terms they borrowed from sources like German idealism. Then, we also notice that the Transcendentalists' emphasis on the individual was directly traceable to the Puritan principle of self-culture and self-improvement as best exemplified by the success story of America's first self-made man, Benjamin Franklin. Virtue alone, to Franklin, led to success: One had to be self-reliant and improve one's person. There exists a conspicuous resemblance, between Emerson's "the infinitude of the private individual" and Franklin's belief that "the least of men can rise" and "a man of tolerable abilities can work great changes and accomplish great affairs among mankind." Thus there is good reason to state that New England Transcendentalism was, in actuality, Romanticism on the Puritan soil.

New England Transcendentalism was important to American literature. It inspired a whole new generation of famous authors such as Emerson, Thoreau, Hawthorne, Melville, Whitman and Dickinson. Without its impetus America might have been deprived of one of its most prolific

literary periods in its history.

Ralph Waldo Emerson (1803-1882)

Emerson was the descendant of a long line of New England clergymen. When he was still a child, the family fortunes fell, and he experienced what some critics have termed "genteel poverty." He went to Harvard, where he underwent a spiritual "odyssey." The liberal atmosphere of the college made him reconsider his Calvinist belief with which he was brought up. Rejecting such Calvinist tenets as total depravity, unconditional election, limited atonement, God's irresistible grace, and the perseverance of the saints, he embraced the liberal Christianity of Unitarianism. Now Unitarianism was more rational and logical, occupying as it did a sort of middle ground between extremes. Its principles, on which most people agreed, include the fatherhood of God, the brotherhood of men, the leadership of Jesus (which ignores Jesus' divinity), salvation by character, and continual progress of mankind. It was an obvious improvement on Calvinism that never accepted the prospect of man's perfectibility. Emerson became a Unitarian minister to the Second Church of Boston. But not for long. Finding the rationality of Unitarianism intolerable, he decided to leave his job as minister. He went to Europe, and met and made friends with Coleridge, Carlyle, and Wordsworth, and brought back with him the influence of European Romanticism. With people of like minds such as Thoreau, Bronson Alcott, and Margaret Fuller, he formed an informal Transcendentalists' club, something like Dr. Johnson's circle. He **became the most eloquent spokesman of New England Transcendentalism**. He helped to found, and edit for a time, the Transcendentalist journal, the *Dial*, to explain their ideas. For a while ideas like Emerson's were up in the air and regarded by some people as "crazy." The epithet "Transcendentalist" was rather derogatory when it first came into circulation, meaning one whose feet did not touch ground. Although he left his ministry, Emerson never stopped "preaching," not at the pulpit, of course, but in the lecture-room. He traveled far and wide in the United States, and Canada and England, taught and spread his Transcendentalist doctrine. During his lifetime he was considered one of the two or three best writers in America, and certainly the most influential among his contemporaries. The prophet of his age, he was likened to a cow from which all had milk though not all liked the taste. Thoreau, Whitman, Emily Dickinson, and many others were indebted to him in varying degrees; Hawthorne and Melville, reacting to his doctrine of optimism, benefited in their ways from Emersonianism. His influence extended beyond his own century. Robert Frost and Wallace Stevens were among the authors of the present century responsive to his philosophy.

As the leading New England Transcendentalist, Emerson effected a most articulate synthesis of the Transcendentalist views. One major element of his philosophy is his firm belief in the transcendence of the "Oversoul." His emphasis on the spirit runs through virtually all his writings. "Philosophically considered," he states in his *Nature*, which is generally regarded as the Bible of New England Transcendentalism, "the universe is composed of Nature and the Soul." He sees the world as phenomenal, and emphasizes the need for idealism, for idealism sees the world in God. "It beholds the whole circle of persons and things, of actions and events, of country and religion, ... as one vast picture which God paints on the eternity for the contemplation of the soul." He regards nature as the purest, and the most sanctifying moral influence on man, and advocated a direct intuition of a spiritual and immanent God in nature. In this connection, Emerson's emotional experiences are exemplary in more ways than one. Alone in the woods one day, for instance, he experienced a moment of "ecstasy" which he records thus in his *Nature*:

Standing on the bare ground, my head bathed by the blithe air and uplifted into infinite space, all mean egotism vanishes. I become a transparent eyeball; I am nothing; I see all; the currents of the Universal Being circulate through me; I am part or particle of God.

Now this is a moment of "conversion" when one feels completely merged with the outside world, when one has completely sunk into nature and become one with it, and when the soul has gone beyond the physical limits of the body to share the omniscience of the Oversoul. In a word, the soul has completely transcended the limits of individuality and become part of the Oversoul. Emerson sees spirit pervading everywhere, not only in the soul of man, but behind nature, throughout nature. The world proceeds, as he observes, from the same source as the body of man. "The Universal Being" is in point of fact the Oversoul that he never stopped talking about for the rest of his life. Emerson's doctrine of the Oversoul is graphically illustrated in such famous statements: "Each mind lives in the Grand mind," "There is one mind common to all individual men," and "Man is conscious of a universal soul within or behind his individual life." In his opinion, man is made in the image of God and is just a little less than Him. This is as much as to say that the spiritual and immanent God is operative in the soul of man, and that man is divine. The divinity of man became, incidentally, a favorite subject in his lectures and essays.

This naturally led to another, equally significant, Transcendentalist thesis, that the individual, not the crowd, is the most important of all. If man depends upon himself, cultivates himself, and brings out the divine in himself, he can hope to become better and even perfect. This is what Emerson means by "the infinitude of man." In all his lectures, Emerson says, he had taught one doctrine, namely, "the infinitude of the private man." He tried to convince people that the possibilities for man to develop and improve himself are infinite. Men should and could be self-reliant. Each man should feel the world as his, and the world exists for him alone. He should determine his own existence. Everyone should understand that he makes himself by making his world, and that he makes the world by making himself. "Know then that the world exists for you..." he says. "Build therefore your own world." "Trust thy self!" and "Make thyself!" Trust your own discretion and the world is yours. Thus, as Henry Nash Smith ventures to suggest, "Emerson's message was eventually (to use a telegraphic abbreviation) self-reliance." Emerson's eye was on man as he could be or could become; he was in the main optimistic about human perfectibility. The regeneration of the individual leads to the regeneration of society. Hence his famous remark, "I ask for the individuals, not the nation." Emerson's self-reliance was an expression, on a very high level, of the buoyant spirit of his time, the hope that man can become the best person he could hope to be. Emerson's Transcendentalism, with its emphasis on democratic individualism, may have provided an ideal explanation for the conduct and activities of an expanding capitalist society. His essays such as "Power," "Wealth," and "Napoleon" (in his *The Representative Men*) reveal his ambivalence toward aggressiveness and self-seeking.

To Emerson's Transcendentalist eyes, the physical world was vitalistic and evolutionary. Nature was, to him as to his Puritan forebears, emblematic of God. It mediates between man and God, and its voice leads to higher truth. "Nature is the vehicle of thought," and "particular natural facts are symbols of particular spiritual facts." Thus Emerson's world was one of multiple significance; everything bears a second sense and an ulterior sense. In a word, "Nature is the symbol of spirit." That is probably why he called his first philosophical work *Nature* rather than anything else. The sensual man, Emerson feels, conforms thoughts to things, and man's power to connect his thought with its proper symbol depends upon the simplicity and purity of his character:

"The lover of nature is he ... who has retained the spirit of infancy even into the era of manhood." To him nature is a wholesome moral influence on man and his character. A natural implication of Emerson's view on nature is that the world around is symbolic. A flowing river indicates the ceaseless motion of the universe. The seasons correspond to the life span of man. The ant, the little drudge, with a small body and a mighty heart, is the sublime image of man himself.

This mode of perception had a significant effect on Emerson's aesthetics, the basis of which is contained in his *Nature*, "The Poet," "The American Scholar," and some other essays. Emerson's poet is no ordinary person. He is a complete man, an eternal man, one whose birth is the principal event in history. He should be able to see into the depths of infinite time, comprehend the path of things and the divine unity of the Universe by intuition, and communicate the feelings of contact with nature to his fellowmen. True poetry and true art should ennoble. It should serve as a moral purification and a passage toward organic unity and higher reality. It is evident that the Romantic organic principle was the governing factor in Emerson's aesthetics. Emerson places emphasis on ideas, symbols, and imaginative words. The argument of the poet (or his thought or experience) should decide the form of the poem instead of traditional techniques. The poet should express his thought in symbols for, to him, symbolism is a universal thing. He should use words for their pictorial and imaginative meaning. Form is important when fused well with content: "It is not metres, but a metre-making argument that makes a poem." As to theme, Emerson called upon American authors to celebrate America which was to him a long poem in itself, to celebrate the life of today, "the factory village and the railway." He lamented bitterly the fact that there had yet been no genius in America, ruthlessly ignoring the New England celebrities of his time. Emerson's aesthetics brought about a revolution in American literature in general and in American poetry in particular. It marked the birth of true American poetry and true American poets such as Walt Whitman and Emily Dickinson.

Emerson's influence on American literature and culture cannot be exaggerated. His call for an independent culture in both *Nature* and "The American Scholar" played a very important part in the intellectual history of the nation. In fact, "The American Scholar" has been regarded (first by Oliver Wendell Holmes) as "America's Declaration of Intellectual Independence." What Emerson was trying to say was actually this, that the Americans should write about here and now instead of imitating and importing from other lands. "The sun shines today also... There are new lands, new men, new thoughts. Let us demand our own works and laws and worship," he says. "Our long apprenticeship to the learning of other lands draws to a close. The millions that around us are rushing into life cannot always be fed on the sere remains of foreign harvests." He called on American writers to write about America in a way peculiarly American. Everything here, common and low as they may be, is worth writing about, for we are great in our own way ?that seems to be the sum total of what Emerson was trying to get across to his countrymen. Emerson's importance in the intellectual history of America lies in the fact that he embodied a new nation's desire and struggle to assert its own identity in its formative period.

Emerson's reputation has fallen somewhat in the twentieth century. It may have to do with his seemingly unqualified acceptance of life and his cheerful optimism that stemmed from that acceptance. He firmly believes that there is a force always at work to make the best better and the worst good, as if he knew from the first the victory of good over evil and that the angel must always be stronger than the demon. He does not seem to bother to distinguish good from evil. To him Good is a good doctor, but Bad is sometimes a better. He just cannot give much reality to evil

and pain. He feels that all misery and suffering is superficial. It is not that he did not see the disease and deformity of his age. In fact, he shared with many thinking minds of his day the sad conviction of universal decay and the decline of true Christianity. But it is his belief that moral deformity is good passion out of place. This everlasting "Yea" is possible only for a man who equates the wit, strength, and grace of man with the grace and presence of God. In modern times Emerson is sometimes dismissed as having no sense of evil, and his optimistic philosophy as so much Transcendentalist folly. Major American authors like Nathaniel Hawthorne, Herman Melville, and Henry James, and major modern and contemporary critics such as F. O. Matthiessen and Yvor Winters all agree that there is truth in the allegation.

Henry David Thoreau (1817-1862)

Another renowned New England Transcendentalist was Henry David Thoreau, a friend of Emerson's and his junior by some fourteen years. Thoreau's father was an unsuccessful storekeeper and a maker of lead pencils, but his mother was an aspiring woman, determined to send her son to college. So she did. Thoreau went to Harvard, but did not like the life and the curriculum of the college much. On graduation he stayed with his family, first helping his father to make pencils and then, for a time, running a private school. He made friends with Emerson, used his library, and embraced his ideas. In 1845 something happened that proved to be important both to him and to American literature in more than one way. With the permission of Emerson, Thoreau went to build a cabin on a piece of Emerson's property on Walden Pond, and moved in on July 4 to live there in a very simple manner for a little over two years. The idea was to move away from the rush and bustle of American social life which was, to him, getting more and more sadly materialistic-oriented. He was also planning to write an account of the trip he took with his brother in 1839 on the Concord and Merrimack rivers. There on the Pond, he tried to be self-sufficient in everything, spending, as he told us, about six weeks a year, planting beans etc. and working to eke out a scanty yet decent livelihood, but writing and enjoying nature most of the time for the rest of the year. A skilled woodsman with acute senses, Thoreau was in his element in the virgin forest, entirely, as it were, in communion with nature. During his stay in Walden he went back occasionally to his village, and on one of these visits he was detained for a night in jail for refusing to pay a poll-tax of \$ 2.00 to a government he thought unjust. The event was insignificant enough ?he was, in fact, soon set free after his aunt paid the sum for him, but it inspired him to write his famous essay, "Civil Disobedience" which, advocating passive resistance to unjust laws of society, influenced people such as Mahatma Gandhi. At the end of two years and two months, Thoreau moved back to Concord, feeling that he had lived one of the lives he was born to live in the world, and wrote about his experience in the famous book, *Walden*.

Thoreau was an active Transcendentalist. He helped Emerson to edit the Transcendentalist journal, the *Dial* and was susceptible to Oriental influences such as Hinduism and Confucianism. He was by no means an "escapist" or a recluse, but was intensely involved in the life of his day. He did not like the way a materialistic America was developing and was vehemently outspoken on the point. He hated the human injustice as represented by the slavery system and was known to have helped at least one African American slave to get free. His firm stance on the execution of John Brown was most explicit in his "A Plea for John Brown."

Thoreau's reputation as an author is archetypal of literary reputations in many ways. In his own time he was considered an eccentric and a loafer. He wrote two books, *A Week on the Concord and Merrimack Rivers* and *Walden*, and a lot of journals and essays, but he had few or no

readers. The failure of his two books did little to change the above-mentioned rather popular view of his personality. It should be noted that the miserable failure of his first book, *A Week*, intimidated the publishers so that his masterwork, *Walden*, when finished, was destined to wait for a few years before it appeared in print. If the final publication of the book brought its author anything it was infamy. It proved to be another failure and was regarded as "wicked and heathenish" and anti-social, thus earning him the name of "nullifier of civilization." Emerson's speech at Thoreau's funeral was ambivalent enough: he talked about Thoreau's virtues, but he also expressed the opinion that Thoreau did not do justice to his own talent, which is rather another way of saying that he wasted his life. Here Emerson was not being just. For half a century after his death, Thoreau remained in obscurity; but his reputation rose steadily, and the twentieth century found him charming and great. His works have been edited, published, and reverently and profusely commented upon. He became one of the three great American authors of the nineteenth century who had no contemporary readers and yet became great in the twentieth century, the other two being Herman Melville and Emily Dickinson. And he became a major voice for nineteenth-century America, now better heard perhaps than Emerson's. His influence goes beyond America. His statue was placed in the Hall of Fame in New York in 1969 alongside those of other great Americans.

Thoreau's masterpiece, *Walden*, is a great Transcendentalist work that came out of the period under discussion. As a young man Thoreau took a more than usual interest in the natural world. Like Emerson, but more than him, he saw nature as a genuine restorative, healthy influence on man's spiritual well-being, and regarded it as a symbol of the spirit. He tried to seek a way to unlock the secrets of the spirit. "Let us not underrate the value of a fact; it will one day flower into a truth," he thus wrote. To him, "we are able to apprehend at all what is sublime and noble only by the perpetual instilling and drenching of reality that surrounds us." As critic F.O. Matthiessen points out, Thoreau thought in images. It was his firm belief that "natural objects and phenomena are the original symbols or types which express our thoughts and feelings." Thoreau was never tired of staying alone in nature; he was ever seen lost in contemplation of the world around. Indeed, *Walden* is a faithful record of his reflections when he was in solitary communion with nature, an eloquent indication that he not only embraced Emerson's Transcendentalist philosophy but went even further to illustrate the pantheistic quality of nature. He can sit by a woodchuck for half an hour, talking to it. To him moose and pine trees are as immortal as he is, and "perchance will go to as high as heaven, there to tower above me still." What he is trying to say is in fact this, that it is possible (to quote literary historian Marcus Cunliffe's phrasing of it) to find godhead in the nearby woods. Thoreau's idea came very close to being heathenish and nature-worship, a pantheism which tended to destroy the "transcendence" of God.

Walden can be many things and can be read on more than one level. But it is, first and foremost, a book on self-culture and human perfectibility. It is a book, as J. L. Basile sums it up, about man, what he is, and what he should be and must be. Thoreau has faith in the inner virtue and inward, spiritual grace of man. He holds that the most important thing for men to do with their lives is to be self-sufficient and strive to achieve personal spiritual perfection. The fact that he moved into his little shabby cabin on July 4, Independence Day, illustrates his desire to be independent and find truth for himself. It is not surprising that Thoreau has been regarded as a prophet of individualism in American literature. Thoreau was very critical of modern civilization. It was, in his opinion, degrading and enslaving man. "Civilized man is the slave of matter," he said

on one occasion. He felt that man should seek truth directly by himself and not through imitation of others. And the best way to find truth is by leaving the life of hurry and bustle to get ahead in worldly affairs and sinking oneself in the wholesome atmosphere of nature. As he saw it, modern civilized life has dehumanized man and placed him in a spiritual quandary: by trying to amass material possessions, man is not really living; he is digging his own grave. Thoreau despised and pitied his fellow villagers and wished to be a chanticleer to wake them up from their spiritual slumbers and help make them into a new generation of men. Hence the book is full of people waking up: as a matter of fact, he woke up several times himself in the book. Furthermore, the book is full of ideas expressed to jostle his neighbors out of their smug complacency. He recorded how he tried to minimize his own needs on Walden Pond. "A man is rich in proportion to the number of things which he can afford to let alone," he says in one context. "An honest man has hardly need to count more than ten fingers, or in extreme cases he may add his ten toes and lump the rest." And he goes on to prescribe a panacea for the fatal modern craze for monetary success that came in the wake of mechanization and commercialization of life: "Simplicity, simplicity, simplicity! ... simplify, simplify!" Spiritual richness is real wealth. It is worth trying to live a life in which one needs to work only for six weeks to be free for the rest of the year. One's soul might not help one to get up in the world, but it will help make real "progress" in self-improvement.

Thoreau was sorely disgusted with "the inundations of the dirty institutions of men's odd-fellow society" with its "life without principle." Through his writings, and his behavior he declared war with the state in his quiet way. He was impatient with his fellowmen who took such an enormous amount of interest in the developments of the outside world like the railroad, the telegraph, and the French Revolution, and yet did not want to spend so little as a single moment on the improvement of his own person. He went to the woods not to gratify his whims as was alleged, but to experiment with a new way of life for himself and for his fellowmen. And he felt that he came out of it a better man, reborn and reinvigorated. Thus regeneration became a major thematic concern of Walden and decided, in a significant way, its structural framework, for the whole book is, as Perry Miller noted, within the frame of a single year, and progresses through summer and autumn to winter, and finally to a climax in the renaissance of spring. After the death of winter we see an ecstatic Thoreau absolutely fascinated at the world of creation coming back to life once more with the arrival of spring. Walden Pond booms, eager to reopen itself. Frogs jump and woodchucks fly. Squirrels chirp and sparrows twitter. The whole universe is a-thawing and reverberating with life and activity, and man with it. "What is man but a mass of thawing clay?" Thoreau asks meaningfully. To him man possesses "an inward heat" and "divine seed," and though he may die down to his root, he can still put forth "his green blade to eternity."

Walden exhibits Thoreau's calm trust in the future and his ardent belief in a new generation of men. After relating the impressive story of a strong and beautiful bug coming out to life from an egg deposited many years earlier and pointing to a similar possible prospect of a beautiful and winged life for man, the book concludes on a clear note of optimism and hope: "The light which puts out our eyes is darkness to us. Only that day dawns to which we are awake. There is more day to dawn. The sun is but a morning star." Here may be a place as good as any to note that, in his eagerness to prove his point, he found a fellow spirit in Confucius, the basic tenets of whose doctrine concern self-culture. Thoreau quoted ten times from the Four Books to support his thesis.

Thoreau's was not a solitary voice in his time. We mentioned earlier on that Emerson and his group of fellow Transcendentalists all fought against the frenzy of acquisition which seemed the

dominant spirit of the time. In England there were, among others, Thomas Carlyle (1795-1881) who saw the danger of men falling into a spiritual stupor and found distasteful everything branded Victorian, such as Victorian optimism, Victorian faith in progress and in popular science, and Victorian material expansion; John Ruskin (1819-1900) who lamented over the fact that ugliness had taken the place of beauty in the life of the people; and Matthew Arnold (1822-1888) who was disgusted with the cultural philistinism of the rising middle class. They all spoke out against the prevailing vice of materialism. In Denmark a great voice was heard crying out against the dehumanization of man, a process which became ever more alarming in the eyes of thinking people: We mean the voice of the Danish philosopher, Søren Aabye Kierkegaard (1813-1855). Seen in the historical context in which these and many other people lived and labored to achieve a higher level of human perfection, Thoreau's appearance on the mid-nineteenth-century American scene, while of decidedly historic significance, was but a matter of course, indeed. Thoreau spoke ahead of his time and, like some people of his kind, suffered, while alive, slight, misunderstanding, and even mockery. Only history and time eventually restored him to the place to which he had an inalienable claim.

CHAPTER 5 Hawthorneville

Nathaniel Hawthorne (1804-1864)

With the publication of *The Scarlet Letter* in 1850, Nathaniel Hawthorne became famous as the greatest writer living then in the United States (as indeed some critics put it) and his reputation as a major American author has been on the increase ever since. Over the years a good number of biographical and critical studies have been written, and almost all aspects of his life and work have been treated with meticulous care. He is also becoming more and more popular with Chinese readers. Since Shi Heng's Chinese translation of *The Scarlet Letter* appeared in the 1950's, scholars and readers in this country have shown an ever-increasing interest in his works, which offers another testimony of Hawthorne's power and permanence.

Hawthorne was born on the fourth of July, 1804 in Salem, Massachusetts. Some of his ancestors were men of prominence in the Puritan theocracy of seventeenth-century New England. One of them was a colonial magistrate, notorious for his part in the persecution of the Quakers, and another was a judge at the Salem Witchcraft Trial in 1692. Gradually the family fortune declined. His father, a sea captain, died in Dutch Guiana, leaving the widow and the child behind to shift for themselves. Young Hawthorne was intensely aware of the misdeeds of his Puritan ancestors, and this awareness led to his understanding of evil being at the core of human life, to "that blackness in Hawthorne," as Herman Melville put it. There is a certain amount of truth in the statement that Hawthorne wrote some of his books like *The Scarlet Letter* and *The House of the Seven Gables* as an attempt at expiating the sin of his ancestors.

In 1821 Hawthorne went to Bowdoin College, where he had Henry Wadsworth Longfellow as a classmate. He also developed a friendship with Franklin Pierce who was to become the fourteenth President of the United States. From 1825 to 1837 Hawthorne lived in solitude and seclusion. He read widely, became further acquainted with local history, and began to practice writing. His first attempt at novel writing, a book about his school life, proved to be a failure; his first tale appeared in print in 1830. The year of 1837 saw the publication of his *Twice-Told Tales*, a collection of short stories, which enjoyed critical attention. For a while he worked in the United

States Custom House in Boston and later in Salem. Another collection of short stories, *Mosses from an Old Manse* came out in 1846. All these works, however, brought him neither great fame nor any fortune large enough to relieve him of the harassment of poverty. It was *The Scarlet Letter* which did it for him: not only did the book make his name as a writer of no small talent, it also brought him the money which made him finally financially comfortable. *The House of the Seven Gables* came out in 1851, to be followed by *The Blithedale Romance* in 1852 and *The Marble Faun* in 1860. He was, during the four years (1853-1857) when President Pierce was in office, the United States consul in Liverpool, England, and later traveled in Italy. He died in 1864.

All his life, Hawthorne seems to be haunted by his sense of sin and evil in life. Reading his tales and romances, one cannot but be overwhelmed by the "black" vision which these works reveal. Evil exists in the human heart as is evident, for instance, in the short story, "Earthly Holocaust," which tells us that, though all symbols of tradition and the past have been burned in the bonfire of the life of the New World, the source of evil—the human heart—remains intact. Everyone possesses some evil secret as tales like "Young Goodman Brown" set out to prove. Everyone seems to cover up his innermost "evil" in the way the minister tries to convince his people with his black veil ("The Minister's Black Veil"). Evil seems to be man's birthmark ("The Birthmark"). Although Hawthorne is ambiguous and his tales are often capable of more than one interpretation, he is certainly at his best when writing about evil. Most of his works deal with evil one way or another. The blackness of vision which comes as a natural corollary has become his trade mark. It illustrates to some extent the influence that the Calvinist doctrine of "original sin" and total depravity had upon his mind. It also explains Hawthorne's aloofness from Emersonian Transcendentalist optimism and his skepticism about it.

To Hawthorne sin will get punished, one way or another. As a matter of fact he was said to be often troubled by the thought that the decline of his family's fortunes had to do with the sins of his ancestors. *The House of the Seven Gables* is an appalling fictional version of Hawthorne's belief that "the wrong-doing of one generation lives into the successive ones," and that evil will come out of evil though it may take many generations to happen. Colonel Pyncheon takes by force the land of Matthew Maule, and condemns him as a wizard. He builds a house on the land while Matthew Maule is sent to the scaffold. Before he dies, the "wizard" curses the colonel, saying "God will give him blood to drink." Retribution does come. The house seems to be haunted. The scion of the colonel wither and die out, and eventually it is the descendant of the persecuted wizard who gets the upper hand. The curse does, in time, materialize. It is true that the book concludes on a happy note, and that good triumphs over evil, and love and reconciliation end an enmity, but one feels somehow that the tragic part of the story impresses more. It is also interesting to note that Hawthorne seems to be of the opinion that evil educates. *The Marble Faun* is a good illustration. A young Italian nobleman, Donatello by name, falls in love with beautiful Miriam whose happiness is, however, threatened by a monk, an obvious token of evil. Innocent Donatello murders the monk and eventually gives himself up to a life-imprisonment while Miriam is resolved to lead a life of penance. Donatello lives through the tragic experience and attains maturity as a man. What Hawthorne seems to be saying is this, that the achievement is possible only "under the impact of and by engagement with evil—the tragic rise born of the fortunate fall," and that man is better for the crime which brings about the fall.

One source of evil in Hawthorne is overweening intellect. The tension between the head (intellect) and the heart (warmth and feeling) constitutes one of the elements which make his

writings enchanting. Hawthorne's intellectual characters are usually villains, dreadful because devoid of fellow feeling. Hollingsworth in *The Blithedale Romance*, Chillingworth in *The Scarlet Letter*, and Dr. Rappaccini in "Rappaccini's Daughter" are but a few specimens of Hawthorne's chilling, cold-blooded human animals. Take Dr. Rappaccini for example. The man is a pre-eminent scientist, "dedicated" to the advance of science at the expense of human lives. In order to prove a scientific hypothesis, he does not hesitate to sacrifice the happiness of his own daughter in an experiment. He succeeds but he has to pay dearly: his daughter dies. "Rappaccini's Daughter" is a sad story. It offers the reader a dreadful picture of a perverted Eden in which the drama of the new Adam and the new Eve destroyed by the Creator is enacted in alarming detail. If you try to be God and take away what is inextricably a person's nature, you kill her? that seems to be Hawthorne's view of what science can do to man. Hawthorne's negative attitude toward science, while it may represent his oblique reaction to the dehumanizing process to which, as we noted somewhere earlier, all thinking minds of his time were hypersensitive, is not always well justifiable. It may reveal a mind befuddled in face of a complex, developing life.

Hawthorne's aesthetics is clearly enunciated in the prefaces to his larger fictions, particularly those to *The Scarlet Letter*, *The House of the Seven Gables*, and *The Marble Faun*. Like Washington Irving, James Fenimore Cooper, and Henry James after him, Hawthorne repeatedly complained about "the poverty of materials" in a land where "there is no shadow, no antiquity, no mystery, no picturesque and gloomy wrong, nor anything but a commonplace prosperity, in broad and simple daylight" ("Preface to *The Marble Faun*") and where "there has never been" "the genial atmosphere which a literary man requires in order to ripen the best harvest of his mind" ("The Custom House: Introductory to *The Scarlet Letter*"). A man with any literary ambition would have to resort to the help of his imagination, "to recall what was valuable in the past," and "to raise up from dry bones" a treasure of even as small an interest as a rag of scarlet cloth ("The Custom House"). He would have to try "to connect a bygone time with the very Present," "to relate a legend, prolonging itself, from an epoch now gray in distance, down into our own broad daylight" ("Preface to *The House of the Seven Gables*"). In this way he may be able to create "a neutral territory, somewhere between the real world and fairy-land where the Actual and the Imaginary may meet, and each imbue itself with the nature of the other" ("The Custom House"). Thus Hawthorne took a great interest in history and antiquity. To him these furnish the soil on which his mind grows to fruition. "Romance and poetry, like ivy, lichen, and wall flowers, need Ruin to make them grow" ("Preface to *The Marble Faun*"). With their mist brooding over the real world and turning it into a "cloud-land," antiquity and history enable him to "dream strange things, and make them look like truth."

Hawthorne was convinced that romance was the predestined form of American narrative. It is not only "the poverty of materials" in America that led him, as he says in his prefaces, to write romances rather than novels; there is also his Puritan prudence to consider?romance allowing him to treat the physical passions obliquely and to avoid violating the human heart. Out of his Puritan scruples came his anxious desire not to offend the Puritan taste, his earnest wish "to present [the truth of the human heart] under circumstances ... of the writer's own choosing or creation," to avoid committing a literary crime of any sort. In short, to tell the truth and satirize and yet not to offend: That was what Hawthorne had in mind to achieve. Here lies Hawthorne's awareness, as Leslie Fiedler observes, "The modern writer's awareness that, if true to himself, he cannot produce a book which his fathers and his neighbors would approve." The anguish of this situation, Fiedler

goes on to tell us, Hawthorne sees with great clarity, knowing that in becoming a writer of the first rank he has also become "a citizen of somewhere else." This is indeed an insightful remark on Hawthorne.

Now let us take a look at *The Scarlet Letter* in which all elements of his thinking and aesthetics seem to find an adequate expression. The story is simple but very moving. An aging English scholar sends his beautiful young wife, Hester Prynne by name, to make their new home in New England. When he comes over two years later he is bewildered to see his wife in pillory, wearing a scarlet letter A on her breast, holding her illicit child in her arms. Determined to find out who her lover is, the old scholar disguises himself as a physician and changes his name to Roger Chillingworth. Gradually he discovers that the villain is no other than the much-admired brilliant young clergyman, Arthur Dimmesdale. Tormenting himself ruthlessly for his sin, Dimmesdale finds his conscience no less ruthlessly preyed upon by Chillingworth. He cuts himself off from community and withers spiritually as well as physically. Hester Prynne's response to the scarlet letter A is a positive one. Though living on the fringe of the community, she does her best to reestablish her fellowship with her neighbors on a new, honest basis. She helps her fellow creatures as a sister of mercy of sorts or as a skilled embroiderer in an unobtrusive and undemanding manner, and finally wins their love and admiration. At one time she plans to leave America with Dimmesdale, but he refuses her help. He dies in the end in her arms while confessing his sin at a public gathering. Chillingworth withers. Pearl, Hester's child, grows up to be married into a noble family of Europe.

Hawthorne's art is cumulative. Many of his earlier stories had treated themes that led to *The Scarlet Letter*. Puritan severity toward sex and matrimony and its tendency to suppress bright color and true feeling as revealed in "The Maypole of Merry Mount," and the stern Puritan punitive measure of making an adulteress wear a scarlet emblem of sin as a warning to the general run of mankind as in the story of "Endicott and the Red Cross" — these are but two notable examples. In all these and *The Scarlet Letter* Hawthorne drew heavily from the New England past. Literary historian A. H. Quinn perceptively states that Hawthorne is at his best when dealing with sin, the supernatural, and New England past. *The Scarlet Letter* is set in the seventeenth century. It is an elaboration of a fact which the author took out of the life of the Puritan past. In "The Custom House," Hawthorne tells us how he found the material for his masterpiece. As Surveyor in the Custom House in Salem, the author found, "one idle and rainy day," in the heaped-up rubbish in the corner of the room, a small package, in fact a private document of a former surveyor, which contained a piece of fine red cloth, "much worn and faded." This rag of scarlet cloth assumed the shape of a capital letter A. Placing it by accident on his own chest, Hawthorne experienced a sensation, not altogether physical, as of burning heat. A small roll of dingy paper, twisted around the scarlet letter, explained its history. One Hester Prynne, who lived before the close of the seventeenth century, committed some form of adultery and was punished by having to wear a scarlet letter A on her breast. We know that in the early days of New England the Puritans lived a life of strict and rigorous moral discipline, and that an adulteress had to wear a scarlet letter A on her breast. This fact proved fertilizing to Hawthorne's imagination and his way of introducing the fact in "The Custom House" is of great artistic interest. Although he declared that the original document was still in his possession and would be freely exhibited to those who would like to take a look at it, the whole story of its discovery is in fact a clever artistic fabrication of Hawthorne's in his attempt to give his tale a sense of historical reality and an air of authenticity. That "The

Custom House" is an integral part of the book is, therefore, quite evident. The "autobiographical impulse," on which Hawthorne talks so much about his ancestry, his views of life and art and the politics of his day, all serve well to prepare the reader for the story that follows.

The way in which Hawthorne wrote *The Scarlet Letter* suggests that American Romanticism adapted itself to American Puritan moralism. The load of didacticism is nowhere heavier and the desire to elevate nowhere stronger than it is, perhaps, in this nineteenth-century American classic. Reading it, one wonders whether it is a story of love. The answer is yes, but then no, because the love part of the story is long over before the book begins. One wonders whether it is a story of sin. The answer is yes, but then no, for the sinning part is long over before the book opens. Modern and contemporary authors would have written pages where Hawthorne uttered not a word. What he was predominantly concerned with was the moral, emotional, and psychological effect of the sin on the people in general and those complicated in it in particular. In the strong character of Hester Prynne we see the tension between society and solitude which, as Marius Bewley puts it, lies near the center of all Hawthorne's art. *The Scarlet Letter* is not a praise of a Hester Prynne sinning, but a hymn on the moral growth of the woman when sinned against. Hawthorne's female characters tend to fall into two broad categories, the blond and effete, and the dark-haired and sensual Oriental type. To the latter belongs Hester Prynne, as does Beatrice, Dr. Rappaccini's daughter. Attractive, appealing, and mildly aggressive, Beatrice gives the impression that she represents sexual guilt as love with her is fatal, but she is really pure and innocent, and dies to go to Heaven, too good for a world which cannot accommodate her. Young Hester borders on being licentious. Her drive is sexual. One need take just a casual look at her luxuriant head of black silky hair to understand this of her. But she lives a rigorous life; only once does she let loose her lovely dark hair. To the self-righteous community which outlaws her, she manages to move ever closer. She does her best to keep her hold on the magic chain of humanity ("The chain that bound her here was of iron links, and galling her inmost soul, but would never be broken"). Her life eventually acquires a real significance when she reestablishes a meaningful relationship with her fellowmen. Symbolic of her moral development is the gradual, imperceptible change which the scarlet letter undergoes in meaning. At first it is a token of shame, "Adultery," but then the genuine sympathy and help Hester offers to her fellow villagers changes it to "Able." Later in the story, the letter A appears in the sky, signifying "Angel." There is reason to agree with the critical observation that A may represent Adamic, or prehistoric, an archetypal vice suggestive of "original sin," as we have no means of getting to know when Hester sinned against the seventh commandment.

Dimmesdale, on the other hand, banishes himself from society. Deeply preoccupied with himself, he lives a stranger among his admirers. The result is that, whereas Hester is able to reconstruct her life and win a moral victory, Dimmesdale undergoes the tragic experience of physical and spiritual disintegration. He dies an honest man, it is true, but dies in part of his own hand. Between him and Hester they point to a moral as Hawthorne may intend them to do, that the best policy for man is to be true, honest, and ever ready to show one's worst to the outside world. Hester does it all her life; Dimmesdale does it finally. The real villain of the story is Roger Chillingworth, the scholar, the embodiment of pure intellect, who commits "the Unpardonable Sin" (as Hawthorne calls it) ?the violation of the human heart. He keeps preying on Dimmesdale's conscience until the poor wretch is tormented to death. The end of Chillingworth, when it comes, is also tragic enough. Dimmesdale declares God's judgment on him before he breathes his last:

"Thou, too, hast deeply sinned!" And Chillingworth simply shrivels. The last time we see him, he is kneeling down beside Dimmesdale "with a blank, dull countenance, out of which the life seemed to have departed."

The *Scarlet Letter* shows Hawthorne, the literary artist, at his best. In craftsmanship perhaps only *The Great Gatsby* can touch it in American Literature: Both works are a kind of cultural allegory, about different phases of American cultural history; both are structurally compact in a tiny frame arid impregnated with meaning. The twenty-four chapters of *The Scarlet Letter* are closely knitted together by means of the scaffold scenes which appear three times, almost symmetrically, in the beginning, the middle, and the end of the book, each time bringing the four major characters (Hester, Dimmesdale, Chillingworth, and Pearl) together. Chapters I and ?, ?, and ?? serve as the props holding up the frame of the novel. All the major figures have complex psychologies; there is a semblance of interior monologues which reveal their states of mind. One salient feature of Hawthorne's art is his ambiguity, of which the technique of multiple view employed in the last part of the book offers a good illustration. Here in the "Conclusion" people are heard to offer different views concerning the sign of the letter A on the dead minister's chest. The author's refusal to commit himself gives his work a richness which would otherwise have been impossible to achieve. There is a strong fairy-tale element in the story. It reads like a kind of romance, with two lovers coming together, finally united in death. Little Pearl acts like the forsaken child asking for recognition, and kissing her father (toward the end of the book) seems to break a spell. We note Hawthorne's use of the supernatural, too. The response of Pearl to the symbol of sin on her mother's breast is adumbrated so that a mystic influence is apparently felt. The appearance of the symbol A in the sky is another good example of Hawthorne's consummate skill to manipulate the reader's credulity: He pushes him into a twilight atmosphere in which all things, natural or otherwise, may become probable. The use of the supernatural can be seen as a hallmark of Hawthorne's art. The voice of the dead "wizard" heard on the death of Colonel Pyncheon in *The House of the Seven Gables*, the contact with the spiritual world in "Howe's Masquerade," the denial of a natural law in "Dr. Heidegger's Experiment," the supernatural allegory in "The Bosom Serpent" and "The Minister's Black Veil," and such vivid studies of the supernatural as "the Birthmark," "The Artist of the Beautiful," "Rappaccini's Daughter," and "The Snow Image" ?all these and more are enough to demonstrate Hawthorne's flair for the supernatural.

Hawthorne's symbolism merits particular mention. We noted the symbolic significance of the scarlet letter earlier on in our discussion of *The Scarlet Letter*. The names of its characters, Dimmesdale and Chillingworth, are symbolic, too, as are the flower at the prison door, little Pearl, the wilderness on the verge of which stands the Puritan community, and so forth. *The House of the Seven Gables* abounds in symbols of various kinds, the house and the rise and fall of its fortunes, the chickens and their dwindling in size, the love between the two young people, etc. Hawthorne's short stories are mostly symbolic. Let's take a look at his famous "Young Goodman Brown" just for an illustration. The young man leaving his wife despite her repeated earnest pleadings not to go off into the night can be seen in one sense as emblematic of the inner urge of the young to grow up and get initiated into the adult world. He must go; it is decided by his human nature: it is a phase to go through. He must lose his innocence to discover about the evil that exists in life as well as in himself in order to reach maturity. So the story itself is in this sense a symbol of the journey of life. Brown's tragedy lies in the fact that he fails to see evil in himself. The time of the

day at which the journey is undertaken assumes some symbolic magnitude as well. It is undertaken at night. The murkiness of night engenders a sense of uncertainty and fear, and signifies an unknown territory stretching in front and the possibility of losing one's direction ?all these indicative of the archetypal growing-up situation for inexperienced youth. Thus Young Goodman Brown is an Everyman. And sure enough, his name is suggestive of this notion ?he is a young farmer (Goodman could mean "farmer"), and Brown is a common name. Hawthorne's eyes were symbolic eyes; his mind worked with the help of signs and symbols. Reading Hawthorne without noticing this feature of his art would be an incomplete experience.

Hawthorne's influence has been great. He was accorded due recognition by his contemporary James Russell Lowell in the latter's *A Fable for Critics*. He changed Herman Melville's original scheme for his *Moby Dick*. The Jamesian psychological realism may have taken its cue from Hawthorne's soul-searching works. Other realists like William Dean Howells learned to use Hawthorne's fiction as the benchmark for their novel-writing practice. In this century William Faulkner and some Gothic novelists clearly show their indebtedness to him. If Hawthorne's reputation is still rising, it is indeed as it should be. As Henry James put it, "[Hawthorne's] work will remain... Among the men of imagination he will always have his niche."

Herman Melville (1819-1891)

The careers of some great nineteenth-century American authors were peculiarly interesting to talk about. Thoreau and Dickinson had few or no contemporary readers. Poe and Whitman were misunderstood. And Melville, apparently oblivious to the sensibility of his contemporaries because loyal to his own, suffered an agonizing neglect particularly painful to his soul, since he did care as Thoreau and Dickinson did not, and he suffered like Whitman without the kind of compensation that the latter lived to enjoy.

Melville's childhood was happy to the age of eleven when his father died in debt. He had little education and began to work early. He was a bank clerk, a salesman, a farm-hand on his uncle's farm and a school teacher, and when these all failed to offer him a decent livelihood, he went to sea at about twenty. There are three things which deserve mention about his life. Going out to sea is one of them, the other two being his marriage and his friendship with Hawthorne. Now a common sailor was about the lowest of workers at that time, but Melville was not even that. He was a Whaler, about the lowest of sailors. In that capacity he saw life from the bottom as did Mark Twain. He went to Liverpool, England and the South Pacific, spending most of his young manhood undergoing one of the most brutalizing experiences for a man. His experiences and adventures on the sea, however, stood him in rich stead. They furnished him with abundant material for fiction.

The married life of Melville was more like that of Scott Fitzgerald than Mark Twain's. These men all married above them. Mark Twain alone enjoyed the understanding of his wife. Both Melville and Fitzgerald had to do hackwork for the money they needed to keep their wives in their extravagant style. Melville married Elizabeth Shaw, the daughter of a wealthy judge. To support her and their growing family, he had to write for money, which was difficult for any American about that time, and especially so for a devoted literary artist like him. Thus Melville was for ever harassed by a pecuniary need and stopped worrying about it only when he was quite old.

During the summer of 1850 Melville and Hawthorne met. He was then living in Pittsfield, Massachusetts, and Hawthorne at Lenox. They became good friends. They exchanged visits, meeting at least nine times, and wrote to one another often, though one side of the

correspondence that of Hawthorne's is lost. Melville read Hawthorne's books and was deeply impressed. There was an obvious shock of recognition on the part of Melville. His essay, "Hawthorne and His Mosses," indicates what a change Hawthorne's Mosses from an Old Manse brought about in the younger writer's outlook on life and on the world. Against the background of New England Transcendentalist optimism concerning man and his world, Melville saw in Hawthorne the one American who was expressively aware of the evil at the core of American life. He found Hawthorne's understanding of evil, that blackness of vision, unusually fascinating. A significant change came about in the original design of *Moby Dick*, about one third of which he had completed when the two men met. The book, which would otherwise have been another of Melville's exotic whaling tales, was now rewritten into the world classic that we read today. It was dedicated to Hawthorne. One of his letters to Hawthorne reveals the secret of his "passion" for the companionship of the older writer: He needed badly somebody to understand and sympathize with, his literary work, as neither understanding nor sympathy was forthcoming from his own family. Although eventually the friendship cooled down, the fact remains that the two men were philosophically closely related. They represented a position of tragic humanism in their time. Hawthorne moved away in the autumn of 1851; they did not meet again except in 1856 when they saw each other for the last time. It is said that Melville stopped writing novels and stories after that and turned to poetry for the remaining twenty-odd years. *Clarel* is his most famous poetic work.

Melville was a voracious reader. Emerson, Hawthorne, Thomas Carlyle, Shelley, Thomas Browne, Lyell's *Geology*, and Shakespeare were on the top of his reading list. Melville was a serious reader. He wrote glosses and commentaries as he raced through the volumes that came his way. His discovery of Shakespeare stirred him to the depths of his being. Carlyle and Hawthorne's symbolism fascinated him. For Emerson Melville had mixed feelings of respect and repulsion.

For a period of some eight years after his return from the sea, Melville was at his most prolific. Books poured forth like a torrent. *Typee* came out first in 1846, to be followed in close succession by *Omoo* (1847), *Mardi* (1849), *Redburn* (1849), *White Jacket* (1850), *Moby Dick* (1851) and *Pierre* (1852). The first three drew from his adventures among the people of the South Pacific islands; *Redburn* is an account of his voyage to England; *White Jacket* relates his life on a United States man-of-war. He was thus known for some time as a popular writer of exotic tales. But these, with the exception of *Typee* and *Omoo* which sold well, did not bring him the recognition he craved or the money he needed. The cool response of the public to his *Moby Dick* disgusted him so that he almost left off novel writing in his late forties. Later in life he wrote some other books like *The Confidence Man* (1857), and *Billy Budd* which he left in manuscript at the time of his death, and some long stories such as "Bartleby" and "Benito Cereno." In most of these Melville seemed to continue to deal in black and white and not in the gray of a Hawthorne reconciled with the world of man. He refused to be pacified until *Billy Budd* when he seemed to win through years of pain and suffering to a final serenity of mind, an acceptance of the fact that one must live by the rules of this world. It is true that it is a trap of a world, one in which God offers impossible standards, a world which Melville defines as a paradox; but as it is a paradox of existence by no means for men to resolve, Melville decided to quit his quest and reconcile himself with fate. So in *Billy Budd* the young sailor accepts his verdict unquestionably and dies in peace and humility: "Billy stood facing aft. At the penultimate moment, his words, his only ones, words wholly unobstructed in the utterance, were these: 'God bless Captain Vere!' Syllables, so unanticipated coming from one with the ignominious hemp about his neck—a conventional felon's

benediction directed aft toward the quarters of honor; syllables, too, delivered in the clear melody of a singing bird on the point of launching from the twig, had a phenomenal effect, not unenhanced by the rare personal beauty of the young sailor spiritualized now through late experiences so poignantly profound." Billy in death shines with the glory of "the fleece of the Lamb of God seen in mystical mission," and his ascending body "took the full rose of the dawn." The description here is authentic both as a condensed account of Melville's life and as a prophecy about his future status in history and in the eyes of posterity. Thus Billy Budd has been widely regarded as its author's testament of acceptance, a sign that he had resolved his quarrel with God.

For the last twenty years of his life Melville worked in the Custom House in New York, going off in the morning and coming home later in the day. Even while he was still living he was forgotten as an author. He had tried to write for his audience, and they did not seem to appreciate what he had to offer. They ended up with disappointment on both sides. The problem with Melville lies in the fact that he was unwilling to sacrifice his insights and artistic standards to cater to popular feeling and demand. He often began a book with something like "a dish of roll and milk" which, with its flowering language and all that, promised well, but ended with a Shakespearean tragedy. So he sank further and further into oblivion, so much so that, when he died at 72, one reviewer was surprised that he had not died until then. No one saw his dilemma more accurately than Hawthorne who, after their last meeting, wrote, in his English Notebooks: "[He] will never rest until he gets hold of a definite belief. It is strange how he persists.... He can neither believe, nor be comfortable in his disbelief; and he is too honest and courageous not to try to do one or the other ... he has a very high and noble nature."

Melville is best known as the author of one book, *Moby Dick* which is, critics have agreed, one of the world's greatest masterpieces. To get to know the nineteenth-century American mind and America itself, one has to read this book. It is an encyclopedia of everything, history, philosophy, religion, etc. in addition to a detailed account of the operations of the whaling industry. But it is first a Shakespearean tragedy of man fighting against overwhelming odds in an indifferent and even hostile universe. As he had indicated in *Mardi*, we should get to know the extent of evil in life and the human soul to help make life and man better. As he puts it, "The way to heaven is through hell."

Moby Dick is a sprawling colossus into which the author kept dumping everything he saw as necessary to prove his point. The story goes roughly as follows. Ishmael, feeling depressed, seeks escape by going out to sea on the whaling ship, *Pequod*. The captain is Ahab, the man with one leg. *Moby Dick*, the white whale, had sheared off his leg on a previous voyage, and Ahab resolves to hunt him to the kill. He hangs a doubloon on the mast as a reward for anyone who sights the whale first. The *Pequod* makes a good catch of whales but Ahab refuses to turn back until he has killed his enemy. Eventually the white whale appears, and the *Pequod* begins its doomed fight with it. On the first day the whale overturns a boat; on the second it swamps another. When the third day comes, Ahab and his crew manage to plunge a harpoon into it, but the whale carries the *Pequod* along with it to its doom. All on board the whaler get drowned, except one, Ishmael, who survives to tell the tale.

Moby Dick represents the sum total of Melville's bleak view of the world in which he lived. It is at once Godless and purposeless. Man in this universe lives a meaningless and futile life, meaningless because futile. As some critics note, man can observe and even manipulate in a prudent way, but he cannot influence and overcome nature at its source. He must, ultimately, place

himself at the mercy of nature. Once he attempts to seek power over it he is doomed. The idea that man can make the world for himself is nothing but a Transcendentalist folly. It is like the world of The Confidence Man which reveals "the absurdity of man's attempts to attribute meaning and value to a world in which these can have no ground or status." Melville never seems able to say an affirmative yes to life: His is the attitude of "Everlasting Nay." Here lies the secret for Melville's resurrection in the twentieth century. The loss of faith and the sense of futility and meaninglessness which characterize modern life of the West were expressed in Melville's work so well that the twentieth century has found it both fascinating and great.

One of the major themes in Melville is alienation, which he sensed existing in the life of his time on different levels, between man and man, man and society, and man and nature. Captain Ahab seems to be the best illustration of it all. He is a typical Melvillean "isolato," and a typical Bartleby whose lips are set ever for an "I prefer not to." He cuts himself off from his wife and kid, and stays away most of the time from his crew. He hates Moby Dick which is an embodiment of nature. He is angry because his pride is wounded. After the loss of his leg in his encounter with the white whale, he seems to hold God responsible for the presence of evil in the universe. Thus his anger assumes the proportions of a cosmic nature. He is bent on avenging himself. He hears of no objection. In his egocentric obsession within "the masoned, walled town of a captain's exclusiveness," he loses his sanity and humanity and becomes a devilish creature rushing headlong toward his doom. And he knows it most clearly of all. When D. H. Lawrence remarks, "He [Melville] records also, almost beyond pain or pleasure, the extreme transitions of the isolated, far-driven soul, the soul which is how alone, without any real human contact," he had Ahab topmost in his mind. In a sense Ahab embodies all of the evil he once consigned to Moby Dick. In a sense, if we scrutinize each and every individual on the Pequod, we will find that most (if not all) of them suffer from alienation of varying levels.

Ahab may have been Melville's portrait of an Emersonian self-reliant individual. Melville lost no opportunity in his criticism of New England Transcendentalism. Constantly under his attack is its emphasis on individualism and Oversoul. To say that the whole of Moby Dick is a negative reflection upon Transcendentalism is not in fact an exaggeration. Take Emerson's self-reliance for instance. Ahab is too much of a self-reliant individual to be a good human being. He stands alone on his own one leg among the millions of the peopled earth. For him the only law is his own will. To him the world exists for his sake. His selfhood must be asserted at the expense of all else: lives may be sacrificed, and nature may have to be vanquished in order that he may do what he wills. He never stops to think and he never bothers about it that, in asserting his private personality, he denies ruthlessly the humanity and individuality of his fellowmen. Ahab is no Odysseus, and his crew seems to be a ship of fools too much under the captain's evil spell to exercise their discretion. Between them, they encompass their own undoing. Richard Chase is right when he says that the idea Melville conveys in Moby Dick is "death ?spiritual, emotional, physical," which is the price of self-reliance when it is pushed to the point of solipsism. Ahab is, to be more exact, a victim of solipsism, his tragedy stemming in the main from extreme individualism, selfish will, a spirit too much withdrawn to itself to warrant salvation. Moby Dick thus reveals the basic pattern of nineteenth-century American life: loneliness and suicidal individualism in a self-styled democracy.

A common theme with mid-nineteenth-century authors like Cooper, Hawthorne, and Melville is one of "rejection and quest," quest as a desire born out of the wish to reject. Cooper's

Natty Bumppo keeps running away from modern "civilized" settlement of the whites in search of an ideal social order. Hawthorne's Hester Prynne once attempts to relinquish her hold on the community which ostracizes her for no good reason. If we take a look at Melville's works, we will readily notice the motif of rejection and quest at work all the time. We find his heroes forever trying to escape from their corrupt world into a better place to live, or what he calls "another world." Typee is the idyllic story of two sailors stealing away from civilization to find paradise among noble savages. The Mardians are voyaging to look for their ideal "Yillah. In the brutal world of the Neversink (The White Jacket) the tiny maintop group with Jack Chase at its center appears to represent a higher order of human decency. Now we come back to Moby Dick. The very name of the narrator, Ishmael, is powerfully loaded. He resembles his namesake in the Bible in that he is a wanderer. He starts out feeling bad, hoping to find a place where he can live a happy and ideal life. Up to the time he goes on board the Pequod and midway through the book, he is an escapist. However, gradually he comes to see the folly of Ahab seeking to conquer nature, and begins to feel the significance of love and companionship. He learned to accept, an attitude which alone ensures his and humanity's survival. Voyaging for Ishmael has become a journey in quest of knowledge and values.

This, then, leads to the symbolism of the book. The voyage itself is a metaphor for "search and discovery, the search for the ultimate truth of experience." The Pequod is, to D. H. Lawrence, the ship of the American soul, and the endeavor of its crew represents "the maniacal fanaticism of our white mental consciousness." By far the most conspicuous symbol in the book is, of course, Moby Dick. The white whale is capable of many interpretations. It is a symbol of evil to some, one of goodness to others, and of both to still others. He is "paradoxically benign and malevolent, nourishing and destructive," "massive, brutal, monolithic, but at the same time protean, erotically beautiful, infinitely variable." Its whiteness is a paradoxical color, too, signifying as it does death and corruption as well as purity, innocence, and youth. It represents the final mystery of the universe which man will do well to desist from pursuing, as Howard P. Vincent observes. As Ahab and his crew do not leave it alone, it is only natural that they get drowned.

Like Hawthorne, Melville manages to achieve the effect of ambiguity through employing the technique of multiple view in his narratives. We may take one scene from Moby Dick for example. In chapter thirty-six there is an occasion when all the men gather to see Captain Ahab nailing the award of a doubloon to the mast for the man who sights Moby Dick first. There are quite a few people standing around, commenting on the features of the whale that the captain is dying to kill. Tashtego (the American Indian), Daggoo (the African American giant), Queequeg (the Polynesian) and Starbuck are all there talking. Moby Dick is thus portrayed for the reader from different angles. The method of using the multiple view, while indicating the author's unwillingness to commit himself, definitely helps to create a symbolic effect. And the reader is thrown upon himself for judgment. Melville tends to write periodic chapters (as Henry James prefers periodic sentences): the last paragraph of chapter one pulling all things into one sentence is a good illustration in point. Melville's rich rhythmical prose and his poetic power have been profusely commented upon and praised.

Melville spoke ahead of his time. He knew that he was doomed to write a book like Moby Dick in his day, but he just could not help himself because he was a dedicated literary artist. There was, to be sure, a good deal of Ahab in him. "I have written a wicked book," he said after finishing Moby Dick, and the public felt outraged. The result was his tragic fall into the oblivion from

which only the twentieth century found it necessary to resurrect him. In the 1920's a Columbia scholar, G. M. Weaver, did solid spadework in reviving him, and needless to add, Melville has been on the pedestal ever since. Thus born in the nineteenth century, Melville did not receive recognition until the twentieth.

CHAPTER 6 Whitman Dickinson

Both Walt Whitman (1819-1892) and Emily Dickinson (1830-1886) were American poets in theme and technique. Thematically, both extolled, in their different ways, an emergent America, its expansion, its individualism, and its Americanness, their poetry being part of what F. O. Matthiessen terms "American Renaissance." In technical terms, both added to the literary independence of the new nation by breaking free of the convention of the iambic pentameter and exhibiting a freedom in form unknown before: they were pioneers in American poetry pointing to Ezra Pound and the Imagists, and to William Carlos Williams and Wallace Stevens and other traditions in modern American poetry. In fact, a handy way of seeing modern American poetry is to find its sources in the two founts, Walt Whitman and Emily Dickinson.

Walt Whitman (1819-1892)

Whitman was brought up in a working-class background on Long Island, New York. He had five years of schooling and a good deal of "loafing" and reading. Thirsting for experience and gregarious in habit, Whitman tried at a variety of jobs and picked up a first-hand knowledge of life and people in the new world. He worked as an office boy, a printer's apprentice, schoolmaster, printer, editor (of eight successive newspapers), and journalist. He wrote some lurid tales, a tear-jerking novel, and some traditionally metrical rhymed verse. In 1848 he traveled to New Orleans and saw very much of the Mississippi heartlands. This experience with the people and the country furnished both the material and the guiding spirit for his epic, *Leaves of Grass*, the first edition of which came out in 1855. It contained twelve poems and did not sell well, but it made a stir on the American literary scene. It broke with the poetic convention, and its sexuality and exotic and vulgar language brought harsh criticisms on it. The *Leaves* were called "noxious weeds," its poetry "poetry of barbarism," and "a mass of stupid filth," and one of the New England poets, John Greenleaf Whittier, threw his gift copy into the fire. But it received a warm welcome from Emerson. The first edition is important for a number of reasons, one of which is the fact that it revealed, in the opinion of Malcolm Cowley, some strengths of Whitman's art. Cowley sees it as a "buried masterpiece of American writing" in which everything belongs together and everything helps to exhibit Whitman at his best, at his freshest and boldest in language.

During the Civil War, Whitman worked as a volunteer nurse, a "wound-dresser" in military hospitals, an experience which further enriched his knowledge of life and the world. In the meantime he continued to revise and expand his *Leaves of Grass*. It went through nine editions altogether: 1855, 1856, 1860, 1867, 1871, 1876 (two volumes, *Leaves of Grass* and *Two Rivulets*), 1881, 1889, 1891-92 (or the "Deathbed Edition"). When the fifth edition appeared, Whitman began to receive recognition in England and America. Tennyson and Swinburne spoke well of him in England, and in America, years after Emerson had called his book "extraordinary," something like a Whitman cult began to develop. 1881 saw the publication of *Leaves* for the first time by a reputable publisher, though ironically it was banned. The banning increased the sales, and Whitman began to realize money from his writings. His health had not been good after he suffered a paralytic stroke in 1873, but he continued to work at his *Leaves* until his death. In his last

months he prepared the "Deathbed Edition" which, containing all of his 400-odd poems, became the single "poem" of his lifetime endeavor.

Whitman was a catalog of American and European thought. As "the great acceptor," he was susceptible to many influences. The Enlightenment (as embodied in Jefferson and Paine) and its ideals of the rights and dignity of the individual, toleration, humanitarianism, and cosmopolitanism, idealism as was shown in Quakerism and its Inner Light, and in the Transcendentalism of Carlyle, Coleridge, Wordsworth and Emerson, German philosophy, especially Hegel's "doctrine of a cosmic consciousness that unfolds through conflict (and evil) to divine ends," with emphasis on cohesiveness and social solidarity, science, both Newtonian and evolutionary, pantheism, the idea of progress, and current American life with its western frontier spirit, Jacksonian laissez-faire individualism, and Civil War Unionism—all these found their way into his system and his poetry. Nor was this all. Whitman's relationship to Orientalism has been well established by modern and recent criticism.

Special mention should be made of Emerson's influence over Whitman. In his career as a poet Whitman drew most heavily from his older contemporary. He was groping both in theme and form when he chanced upon Emerson's works. The effect of these writings is well illustrated in a conversation which Whitman had in 1860 with J. T. Trowbridge, then editor of the journal, *Our Young Folks*. "I was simmering, simmering, simmering," he said, "Emerson brought me to a boil." Emerson's support came just at the moment when it was most needed. Against the angry responses at the first edition of *Leaves of Grass*, Whitman must have felt immensely relieved to receive Emerson's famous letter in which the leading New Englander calls *Leaves of Grass* "the most extraordinary piece of wit and wisdom that an American has yet contributed." And Whitman's reply to Emerson, hailing the older man as "dear Master" and pledging fervent devotion, well indicates the extent to which the struggling poet was influenced. There is no doubt, as John B. Moore observes, that Whitman was more indebted to Emerson than any other nineteenth-century American author.

It is generally accepted that the preface to the 1855 edition of *Leaves of Grass* is an elaboration of Emerson's essay "The Poet." Echoing Emerson's "America is a poem in our eyes," Whitman declares that "The Americans of all nations at any time upon the earth have probably the fullest poetic nature. The United States themselves are essentially the greatest poem." In response to the Emersonian concept of the American poet as the universal man, Whitman states that the greatest poet breathes into the world the grandeur and life of the universe. "He is a seer," he says, "he is individual... he is complete in himself." In an age in which faith began to become increasingly shaky, Whitman, along with Emerson, sees the poet as taking over what had used to be the job of a minister, a clergyman, the Church. In addition, both Whitman and Emerson wrote on the organic principle. To them, art should be based organically on nature; the poet's work grows out of nature and cosmic processes and derives its form from within. As Emerson holds that the "argument" (thought) from which a poem comes is so passionate and alive that like the spirit of a plant or an animal it has an architecture of its own, and "adorns nature with a new thing," so Whitman says, "The rhyme and uniformity of perfect poems show the free growth of metrical laws, and bud from them as unerringly and loosely as lilacs or roses on a bush, and take shapes as compact as the shapes of chestnuts and oranges, and melons and pears, and shed the perfume impalpable to form." No wonder that the appearance of the first edition of *Leaves of Grass* filled Emerson with such joy that he seemed to see the coming of the American poet on the horizon at

last.

Whitman was a child of his age. The fundamental ideas which were prevalent in America at the time pervade all Whitman's poems. General mysticism and anti-rationalism, pantheism, and the theory of "the Great Chain of Being" are among the most important, as G. W. Allen notes in his *Walt Whitman Handbook*. Whitman embraces idealism. He relies on insight and intuition. His poetry becomes a happy medium for communicating his views on the cosmos and on man. Unity, unreality of time and space, evil as only an appearance emerging into good, the equal potential divinity of everything from grass to mankind, the immanence of God in all creation, plenitude, continuity and gradation, the multiplicity of nature, and the need for a poetry commensurate with it—all these find adequate expression in his poems. His "Song of Myself" is a repertory of his thought. From a blade of "curling grass" the poet sees into the mystery of death and birth and concludes that "the smallest sprout shows there is really no death," and that "all goes onward and outward, nothing collapses." The "I," present everywhere in life, leaves one with the impression of a divine omniscience beholding nature and man alike. It is only natural that "I am deathless," "I exist as I am," and "One world is aware... and that is myself," and that the whole poem ends on an extremely transcendental note: "I am large, I contain multitudes."

Whitman extols the ideals of equality and democracy and celebrates the dignity, the self-reliant spirit, and the joy of the common man. "Song of Myself" reveals a world of equality, without rank and hierarchy. The prostitute dragging her shawl, the President holding a cabinet council, the stately and friendly matrons on the piazza walk, the Missourian crossing the plains and an infinite number of other things and people find their way into his poem and juxtapose with one another, illustrating the principle of democracy and equality. The poet, walking around, hears America singing. The mother is singing while setting food on the table. The carpenter is singing, planing his boards. And the day is singing "What belongs to the day," long catalogs of different people and different occupations indicate that here the new children of Adam are being restored to the Garden of Eden, developing their potentiality to the fullest extent possible. In a general sense *Leaves of Grass* is an Adamic song, and its author an Adamic singer.

Whitman responds enthusiastically to the expansion of America. The new bustling and progressive republic, with its dynamic creative fertility and its indomitable energy, finds a willing and refreshing voice in Whitman. Read again "Song of Myself" and poems like "There Was a Child Went Forth," and we see the spirit of an emerging America at its most aggressive and daring. The process of becoming is most clearly seen in the lines that suggest the daily growth of the child who is capable of absorbing everything and goes forth doing so every day "for many years or stretching cycles of years." In "Crossing Brooklyn Ferry" the poet sees everything in the universe as "glories strung like beads on my smallest sights and hearings." It is a universe in constant motion and flux, one in which it is a pride to thrive, expand and live for all time. Whitman's voice echoes the sound of America singing and foretells the future union of the nations and the world and the cosmos.

In later years Whitman came to see the failure of democracy and the social and moral corruption in America ("Democratic Vistas"), but he thought these curable by the self-reform of the individual. Material gains are fruitless without personal morality; individualism without brotherhood is suicide. Thus "Passage to India" extols "the marriage of continents" and different races, and "Proud Music of the Storm" envisages unity of "all the tongues of nations." The emphasis is clearly on brotherhood and social solidarity. This shows that Whitman was a

transitional figure from Romanticism and Transcendentalism to Realism.

Whitman was a daring experimentalist who, in the words of Ezra Pound, "broke the new wood." His early poems are in conventional rhyme and meter, but apparently he found the restrictions disappointing. He began to experiment about 1847 which led to a complete break with traditional poetics. One of the major principles of Whitman's technique is parallelism or a rhythm of thought in which, as Bliss Perry observes, the line is the rhythmical unit, as in the poetry of the English Bible. Another main principle of Whitman's versification is phonetic recurrence, i.e., the systematic repetition of words and phrases at the beginning of the line, in the middle or at the end. These two principles coordinate with and reinforce each other. They operate also in conventional poetry, but not as about the only rhythmical principles as they do in Whitman's poetry. Whitman broke free from the traditional iambic pentameter and wrote "free verse." His long "catalogs" of lines gave free rein to his imagination in his life-long attempt to celebrate life in the new world.

As we noted earlier, Whitman wrote over four hundred poems in his life which he put into his book of collected poetry, *Leaves of Grass*, "a book," as he says, "I have made, / The words of my book nothing, the drift of it everything, / A book separate, not link'd with the rest nor felt by the intellect, / But you yet untold latencies will thrill to every page." Whitman is not easy to read. What has made him puzzling is in fact the "untold latencies" that his poems contain. His poetry suggests, rather than tells; his whole *Leaves of Grass* is rather a dramatization of the idea that it is "a passageway [as he says of it himself] to something rather than a thing in itself concluded." It is good to take a close look at some of his poems just for an experience of his poetry. "Out of the Cradle Endlessly Rocking" and "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd" are good enough for our purpose here.

"Out of the Cradle Endlessly Rocking" is a reminiscence of a childhood experience. The incident described here is simple enough though its "drift" is profound as we shall illustrate. Once a long time ago a little boy was wandering on a bright "Fifth-month" day on the seashore when, all of a sudden, he heard two mocking-birds, a male and a female, happily singing together. "Shine! shine! shine! / Pour down your warmth, great sun! / While we bask, we two together / Singing all time, minding no time, / While we two together." But they did not stay long together: one day the she-bird disappeared, leaving her mate behind, disconsolate and "solitary." The he-bird, the lone singer, sat there calling out on land to return his mate and shaking out carols of "lonesome love": "O past! O happy life! O songs of joy! / In the air, in the woods, over fields, / Loved! loved! loved! loved! / But my mate no more, no more with me! / We two together no more." But there was no response: there was only the waning moon, the whispering sea, and the enveloping darkness that was night. The boy was moved. The out-setting bard was thrown into raptures and, in a moment of inspiration, became aware of the mission for which he was born: "Now in a moment I know what I am for, I awake / A thousand warbling echoes have started to life within me, never to die." He became restless, thirsting to know "the destiny of me," and seeking "the clew" from the waves. On the seashore where "liquid rims" and "wet sands" met, he heard the sea singing "Death, death, death, death." It was, he realized, the word of "the sweetest song and all songs." He became a mature poet.

As J. E. Miller points out, the poem can be split into three subsections. The first of these sings of ideal love and bliss, the second of bereavement and lonesome love, and the third of death as the spiritual fulfillment of lonesome love. A careful reading will reveal that there are two sets of symbols, the sun and the moon, day and night, land and sea, which between them indicate the

duality of nature and life. The sun, day, and land suggest life and the physical, while the moon, night, and sea represent death and the spiritual. On the seashore where the sea and land meet and merge, the cycle of nature in its rhythmical evolution ends only to renew itself, with death as the beginning of new life. When the boy became aware of these "meanings which I of all men know," he had progressed to maturity and become a "chanter of pains and joys, uniter of here and hereafter," and a singer of the endless cycle. It is no wonder that the poem begins with the cradle rocking and ends with "some old crone rocking the cradle," carefully encasing itself in an artistically hermetic whole.

"When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd" is, both in theme and form, a tour de force of Whitman's. Thematically, it deals with the typical Whitmanesque love-and-death motif. It was written in memory of President Lincoln, though the name of Lincoln never appears in it. Lincoln was assassinated and the whole nation was in mourning. Read the second section every line of which begins with an "O," a sign of the mouth of a person weeping, and we get to know the intensity of the grief with which the nation, the poet included, was stricken. For over half the length of the poem, the poet is seen writhing in the grip of physical loss. The coffin is seen passing, the great cloud darkening the land, the cities draped in black, the sea of faces silent and solemn, and the mournful voices of dirges strongly rising. Joining, the poet chants a song for the "sane and sacred death." He looks up and sees the western fallen star. "O the black murk that hides the star!" he thus laments. When he looks around he spots the lilac bush blossoming in the dooryard and feels its physical appeal strongly. Then he becomes conscious of a shy and hidden thrush warbling forth "Death's outlet song of life." The lilac bush, with its rich colors and scent, represents physical life, while the hermit thrush bodies forth spiritual life. And the poet finds himself attracted to both. It is apparent that he has got to progress from the one to the other, namely, to reconcile a love of life, to quote James E. Miller again, with a love of death, death as representing rebirth onto spiritual life. Thus gradually we see the poet recovering from his deep grief over mortality and becoming aware of the spiritual existence of Lincoln and his immortality. The song of the bird, which he is beginning to appreciate, induces in him "a mystical state" from which come mystical visions: To the tally of my soul, / Loud and strong kept up the gray-brown bird /... While my sight that was bound in my eyes unclosed, / As to long panoramas of visions." In this way, "Lilac and star and bird twined with the chant of my soul." Reading the poem we perceive the stages through which the mind of the poet goes through. The poetic process is highly symbolic: The star is associated with the thought of death, the lilac with a token of life for the dead, and the bird with insight and knowledge of death not as the end but as the beginning of new life. Whitman was a mystic. He detests talking of the beginning and the end as, for him, "All goes onward and outward, nothing collapses" ("Song of myself). **"When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd" is one of the best poems which embody his visions.**

Whitman's influence over modern poetry is great in the world as well as in America. His best work has become part of the common property of Western culture. Many poets in England, France, Italy and Latin America are in his debt. In America, it is true that his optimism seems to have become a liability to his reputation in the twentieth century, but modern American poets like T. S. Eliot and Ezra Pound would not have been what they were without Whitman. **Pound, who called him a "pigheaded father," recognized him nonetheless as a father figure who led the break from the past.** He took over, as M. L. Rosenthal noted, Whitman's vision of the poet-prophet and poet-teacher and recast it in a more sophisticated and Europeanized mood. Hart Crane's Bridge

derives its incentive and inspiration in part from Whitman. Carl Sandburg was probably the only great poet who carried, in his Chicago poems, the Whitmanesque tradition into the twentieth century in a whole-hearted way. Whitman has been compared to a mountain in American literary history. You may go around him if you like, but you cannot pretend that he is not there. His excessive optimism led to a decline of his reputation, but the last few decades have seen an immense change in critical attitude toward him and his poetry. Contemporary American poetry, whatever school or form, bears witness to his great influence. For his innovations in diction and versification, his frankness about sex, his inclusion of the commonplace and the ugly and his censure of the weaknesses of the American democratic practice these have paved his way to a share of immortality in American literature.

Emily Dickinson (1830-1886)

Dickinson differs from Whitman in a variety of ways. For one thing, Whitman seems to keep his eye on society at large; Dickinson explores the inner life of the individual. Whereas Whitman is "national" in his outlook, Dickinson is "regional" ("because I see New-Englandly"). In formal terms the two poets are vastly different: Whitman's endless, all-inclusive catalogs contrast with the concise, direct, and simple diction and syntax which characterize Dickinson's poetry. Dickinson denied having read Whitman.

Dickinson was born in 1830 into a Calvinist family of Amherst, Massachusetts. Her father was a Whig lawyer, and later in life, treasurer of Amherst College and Congressman. He did not join the Congregational Church until his middle age. This old Puritan, with a heart "pure and terrible," influenced his daughter in no small way. Emily enjoyed a normal and vivacious girlhood. From her family she had love, though not always understanding. She was shy, sensitive, sometimes rebellious. For two years she studied at Amherst Academy and spent one more at the Mount Holyoke Female Seminary. The school was strongly Congregational, but Emily refused to observe its religious customs. Although she could be disconcertingly individualistic, there were no signs then that she would become a recluse. She settled down to a normal New England village life, reading and writing and baking bread for the family. She read the Bible, Shakespeare, and Keats, among others, and was greatly influenced. She stayed almost all her life in the same house and the same yard except for a visit of a few weeks to Washington, D. C. From her biographers we learn of her intense love for home, her devotion to relatives, and her passionate joy in merely being alive ("I find ecstasy in living," she told a friend on one occasion, "the mere sense of living is joy enough"). Dressed in white and avoiding visitors as much as possible, she wanted to live simply and as a complete independent person (as is indeed indicated in "The Soul selects her own Society," a poem about the inviolability of the self, a tremendous celebration of the self). Her two passions were her garden and her poetry.

It was conjectured that during her twenties she began writing seriously. Around 1858 she was copying her poems and "gathering them together in little packets, loosely bound by thread." She wrote altogether 1775 poems, of which only seven appeared in print in her lifetime. The "surgery" that editors like Thomas Wentworth Higginson and Samuel Bowles did to her published work appalled her so that she decided to withdraw from a world which was not ready for her. She trusted, not exactly unwittingly perhaps, to the future ("If fame belonged to me," she wrote, "I could, not escape her"). After her death her poems were "discovered" accidentally by her sister, who then requested Mrs. M. L. Todd and Thomas Wentworth Higginson to edit them. The result of the endeavor was a volume of 115 poems which appeared in 1890. Later two more volumes of

poetry and two volumes of letters came out. 1914 saw more Dickinson poems coming to light, a fact which established Dickinson's place in literature. In 1950 Harvard University bought all her copyright, and five years later the complete works of the poet, including three volumes of poems and three volumes of letters, was published. Dickinson was "rediscovered" in the twentieth century.

Dickinson's poetry is a clear illustration of her religious-ethical and political-social ideas. Calvinism with its doctrine of predestination and its pessimism pressured her during her childhood and adolescence and colored her work so that her basic tone was tragic. She expressed a passionate yearning for religious certitude, God's help, and the good life. "At last to pray is left," making as it does an earnest plea to Jesus, reveals a perplexed poet in search of love and help: "Say. Jesus Christ of Nazareth, / Hast thou no arm for me?" The loss of faith, the religious uncertainty, which harassed intelligent, thinking minds like Thomas Carlyle, John Stuart Mill, Tennyson, Arnold, and Arthur Hugh Clough, was apparently assailing the American poet as well. For the God of the Bible is not always real to her; she does not always believe in God's plan for an after-life; she cannot bring herself to reconcile a belief in "our" Father's benevolence with an almightiness which permitted evil to exist. As she failed to confess herself Christian, she embraced poetic life. In an act of self-recognition, realizing that poetic interpretation of life conflicted with religious dogma, Dickinson affirmed her individuality and emerged a mature poet.

By far the largest portion of Dickinson's poetry concerns death and immortality, themes which lie at the center of Dickinson's world. Her preoccupation with these subjects amounted to an obsession so that about one third of her poems dwell on them. Dickinson's many friends died before her, and the fact that death seemed to occur often in the Amherst of the time added to her gloomy meditation. "My life closed twice before its close" portrays the poet as ever-ready for the assault of death:

My life closed twice before its close;
If yet remains to see
If immortality unveil
A third event to me,

So huge, so hopeless to conceive
As these that twice fell.
Parting is all we know of heaven,
And all we need of hell.

Dickinson was "bereaved" twice when she lost her "tutors," Benjamin Newton in 1853 and Charles Wadsworth in 1862. Newton, a law student in her father's office, may have been the individual responsible for introducing her to Emerson and other literary influences which began to direct her to intellectual independence and ultimately to poetry. Wadsworth, the married Presbyterian minister, Emily Dickinson may have loved in her imagination: it was an emotional turmoil which may have sparked her frenzied poetic creativity in 1862. For Dickinson death leads to immortality, as is illustrated in poems like "Because I could not stop for Death." Death comes as imperceptibly as grief and marks the beginning of a higher life ("As imperceptibly as Grief). So deeply engrossed was the poet in her macabre deliberations that she began to conceive of the process of dying in poems such as "I heard a fly buzz when I died": "and then it was / There interposed a fly ?/ With Blue ?uncertain stumbling Buzz ?/ Between the light ?and me ?/ And then

the Windows failed ?and then / I could not see to see ?[.]” She was skeptical and ambivalent about the possibility of achieving immortality.

Dickinson was original. She sounds idiosyncratic, sometimes. Like Gerard Manley Hopkins, she never imitated others. The way she wrote about love is a good case in point. "Mine ?by the Right of the White Election" expresses a passionate and eternal love in an elegiac tone. "Wild Nights ?Wild Nights" is in more than one respect a peculiar work on love:

Wild Nights ?Wild Nights!
Were I with thee
Wild Nights should be
Our Luxury!

Futile ?the Winds ?
To a Heart in port
Done with the Compass ?
Done with the chart!

Rowing in Eden ?
Ah, the Sea!
Might I but moor
Tonight ?In thee!

The erotic image is self-evident. Love is expressed in an unabashed manner. The boat and the sea as symbols of male and female lovers coalesce into wild consummated love.

Dickinson sees nature as both gaily benevolent and cruel. Her nature poems are great in number and rich in matter. Natural phenomena, changes of seasons, heavenly bodies, animals, birds and insects, flowers of various kinds ?all these and many other subjects related to nature find their way into her poetry. The grandeur of a sunrise ("I'll tell you how the sun rose,"), the mixed feelings of joy and grief at the coming of spring and autumn ("New feet within my garden go" and "These are the days when birds come back"), the sense of momentary transitoriness ("A Route of Evanescence"), and the power and majesty of a summer storm are among the themes Dickinson handled in her own original way. In the meantime the cold indifference of nature is also revealed in her poems which indicate that she shares in part Tennyson's sense of an evolutionary nature "red in tooth and claw with raven." "Apparently with no surprise" tells of an accidental murder to which the sun is apathetic and of which God approves. Frost ?the blond assassin ?kills a happy flower at its play and goes unmolested while both the sun and God look on. A bird that comes down the walk may have served as a symbol of nature itself with which the poet (man) tries to establish a form of connection and understanding, but all in vain: alienation exists in between. Here may be a good place to say a word or two about Dickinson's view of science. Science, she says in one of her letters, will not trust us with another world. "Guess I and my Bible will move to some old-fashioned spot where we'll feel at home." "Arcturus" suggests that she thought science could not destroy the mystery of nature by using technical terms for stars, etc.

On the ethical level Dickinson emphasizes free will and human responsibility. Her poems, "To fight aloud" and "A triumph may be," for instance, view the cause and cure of evil as mainly within the individual, whose highest duty is "Renunciation" of anything low or hostile to man's spiritual heritage and self-respect. Lines like "To fight aloud is very brave, / But gallanter, know, /

Who charge within the bosom, / The cavalry of woe" are a clear indication of the poet's preoccupation with self-improvement. Dickinson believes that man is aided in his struggle by a resolute faith in immortality, as her "Death is a Dialogue between" demonstrates:

Death is a Dialogue between
The Spirit and the Dust.
"Dissolve" says Death ?The Spirit "Sir
I have another Trust" ? Death doubts it ?Argue from the Ground ?
The Spirit turns away
Just laying off for evidence
An Overcoat of Clay.

The fact that man's immortal spirit satisfies the claims of Death by "Just laying off for evidence / An Overcoat of Clay," reminds us of the poet's relationship to New England Transcendentalism, for Transcendentalist philosophy regards body and outward nature as merely "clothes." Dickinson read Emerson appreciatively, who became a pervasive and, in a sense, formative influence over her. As George F. Whicher notes, "Her sole function was to test the Transcendentalist ethic in its application to the inner life." In fact, the power of her best poetry comes from the psychological tension it describes. With regard to the soul, her conviction of its sovereignty is absolute. "The Brain is wider than the Sky" and "I know that He exists" are but two of many good illustrations. Like the Transcendentalists, Dickinson attacks over-emphasis on materialism and commercialism ("I took my power in my hand / And went against the world"). Though her enemy is a monster like Goliath and she not a David, she feels twice bold and fears no fall. Her response to the expansion of America was a warm one. The simple and direct way in which she tells about the railway is as impressive as her striking image of a galloping horse intended as a symbol both of the railroad and developing America: the poem, "I like to see it lap the Miles," sparkles, as one critic observes, with her pleasure in telling it. Dickinson admired the crusading liberal Republicanism (associated with abolition and Lincoln as the Great Emancipator) found in the Springfield Republican of her close friend, Samuel Bowles. She thinks "Revolution is the pod" from which outworn political systems fall in the wind. Her sympathy for the poor and the weak appears in poems such as "The beggar lad dies early," and "If I can stop one heart from breaking." There is evidence from her correspondence that, if she saw few people in her later days, she always befriended her neighbors and all in distress. She also wrote a few poignant war elegies such as "When I was small a woman died."

Like Emerson, Dickinson holds that beauty, truth and goodness are ultimately one. In "I died for Beauty ?but was scarce," discussing beauty and truth, she concludes that the two are one. In "I reckon when I count at all," she considers "First Poets ?then the sun ?then summer ?then the Heaven of God" (goodness), but concludes that the true poet can "comprehend the whole." Dickinson delights in telling all the truth but telling it slant:

Tell all the Truth but tell it slant ?
Success in Circuit lies
Too bright for our infirm Delight
The Truth's superb surprise
As lightning to the Children eased
With explanation kind

The Truth must dazzle gradually
Or every man be Blind ?

She is good at catching the charm of something but dropping the thing itself. "A narrow Fellow in the Grass" talks about the snake all the while, but the word "snake" never occurs. This may have, in a way, made Dickinson obscure and inscrutable sometimes. Like Whitman she was a courageous experimentalist. "I have no monarch in my life," she confessed. Indeed, little that she wrote seemed conventional: her choice of words, her verbal constructions, even her spelling. And, then, there are her images. To her poetry is "a bodying forth by means of concrete images" of an inspired thought. Her poetry abounds in telling images. In the best of her poems every word is a picture seen. A salient feature of her technique was her severe economy of expression. Her poetic idiom is noted for its laconic brevity, directness, and plainest words. All these characteristics of her poetry were to become popular through Stephen Crane with the Imagists such as Ezra Pound and Amy Lowell in the twentieth century. She became, with Stephen Crane, the precursor of the Imagist movement.

Dickinson lived to write a "letter to the world" that would express, to quote R. N. Linscott, in poems of absolute truth and of the utmost economy, her ideas of the world and paint what Henry James called "the landscape of the soul." If the cultivated taste of her own day failed to appreciate her genius, as both Samuel Bowles and Thomas Wentworth Higginson failed, the long day has passed and she has won the fame that "belonged" to her.

CHAPTER 7 Edgar Allan Poe

We are not placing Edgar Allan Poe (1809-1849) at the bottom of the list of nineteenth-century American romantics because he was the last in the chronological order or the least in importance. It is because he stands alone, representing a category very difficult to pigeonhole. We also want to emphasize Poe's unique position in the history of American literature.

Poe's childhood was a miserable one. He lost both of his parents when still very small, and was taken care of by John Allan, a wealthy merchant of Virginia. The Allans failed to offer the orphan a normal home as father and son enjoyed nothing but an unhappy relationship together. At 17 Poe entered the University of Virginia but did not finish. He went to West Point as a cadet but was dismissed because of misbehavior. A man of literary genius, Poe wrote and worked as editor most of his short life. His first book of poetry appeared in 1827, his second in 1829, to be followed by his third in 1831. Five of his tales came out in 1832. One of his best tales, "MS. Found in a Bottle," won first prize in a short story contest run by a Baltimore newspaper in 1833. In 1838 he published his one full-length novel, *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym*, and the next year saw in print his *Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque*. The tale, "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841), an ingenious detective story, became the ancestor of the genre, influencing, among others, Conan Doyle. His poem, "The Raven" (1844), was an immediate success and has remained one of his most enduring works. Poe's literary output (some seventy short stories and a dozen poems) is small, but it is immensely interesting and influential as a literary inheritance. We need to mention here that Poe's only longer narrative, *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym*, is a critical failure despite the fact that it has been the subject of one interesting chapter in Fiedler's *Love and Death in the American Novel*. It may be proof that Poe was not good at a sustained effort. Poe worked as editor of a number of magazines such as *The Southern Literary Messenger*, *Burton's Gentleman's Magazine*, *Graham's Magazine* and *The Broadway Journal*, and wrote a good number of reviews

which reveal his insight and originality as a critic. He was poor all his life. At 27 he married his thirteen-year-old cousin, whose death in 1847 left him inconsolable and bitterer with life than ever. He died, in mysterious circumstances, in October, 1849.

For a long time after his death Poe remained probably the most controversial and most misunderstood literary figure in the history of American literature. And that for good reasons. As a critic Poe was perceptive, but the fact that he wrote some scathing criticisms on the works of such distinguished New England literary celebrities as Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1807-1882) incurred the wrath of quite a few of his contemporaries. And his literary executor, Rufus Griswold, spared no pains, after his death, to sully his reputation. He painted him as a Bohemian, depraved, and demonic, a villain with no virtue at all. Poe's own work did at times seem to corroborate the view of Griswold's and many others that his was an evil genius. Thus the legend steadily building up about Poe placed the man in a very unfavorable light. Emerson dismissed him in three words, "the jingle man." Mark Twain declared his prose to be unreadable. Henry James made the ruthless statement that "an enthusiasm for Poe is the mark of a decidedly primitive state of development." And Whitman, who was the only famous literary figure present at the Poe Memorial Ceremony in Baltimore in 1875, had mixed feelings about him: he did admit Poe's genius, but it was "its narrow range and unhealthy, lurid quality" that most impressed him. In the present century, T. S. Eliot proclaimed him a critic of the first rank, but charged him with "slipshod writing." And Yvor Winters regarded Poe's literary merit as "a very frail delusion." For a long time American literary criticism was reluctant to come to terms with Poe and failed to do full justice to his genius. Writing in 1954, critic P. F. Quinn lamented that, "in American criticism, ancient and modern, the treatment Poe has received has as a rule been either lean with censure or fat with platitude and thus has generally failed to give a satisfactory account of his undeniable permanence and power."

Ironically, it was in Europe that Poe enjoyed respect and welcome. Swinburne, Bernard Shaw, D. H. Lawrence, and W. H. Auden all admired and spoke highly of him. Shaw's evaluation of Poe's achievement in the three areas of work as a critic, poet and short story writer proved to be one of the most comprehensive and insightful: Poe was, Shaw said on the centenary of his birth, "the greatest journalistic critic of his time"; his poetry is "exquisitely refined"; and his tales are "complete works of art." Poe's influence was considerable in Spain and Spanish America, in Italy, in Germany where writers such as R. M. Rilke were indebted to him, and in Russia where the works of Dostoevsky, among others, bear a visible imprint of Poe's influence. Poe's reputation was first made in France. Charles Baudelaire, determined that "Edgar Poe, who isn't much in America, must become a great man in France," spent the best part of his mature life translating Poe. It was he who elevated Poe to the status of a literary deity. Other famous French writers such as Stephane Mallarme and Paul A. Valery all paid their homage to the American. Naturally enough, the first most exhaustive critical studies of Poe's work were written in France. Marie Bonaparte's two-volume work, *The Life and Works of Edgar Poe: A Psycho-Analytic Interpretation*, with its theory of psychoanalysis and Gaston Bachelard's study of Poe have both remained classic works in Poe criticism. They reveal the particular power in Poe which has ensured his position among the greatest writers of the world. Needless to say, the majority of critics today, in America as well as in the world, have recognized the real, unique importance of Poe as a great writer of fiction, a poet of the first rank, and a critic of acumen and insight. His works are read the world over with appreciation and understanding.

Poe was good at generalizing. He tried to cash in on his own literary practice to rationalize

about literary creations. His poetic theories are remarkable in their clarity even if they lack what Joseph Wood Krutch terms "intellectual detachment" and "catholicity of taste." These are best elucidated in his "The Philosophy of Composition" and "The Poetic Principle." The poem, he says, should be short, readable at one sitting (or as long as "The Raven"). Its chief aim is beauty, namely, to produce a feeling of beauty in the reader. Beauty aims at "an elevating excitement of the soul," and "beauty of whatever kind, in its supreme development, invariably excites the sensitive soul to tears. Thus melancholy is the most legitimate of all the poetic tones." And he concludes that "the death of a beautiful woman is, unquestionably, the most poetical topic in the world." Poe is opposed to "the heresy of the didactic" and calls for "pure" poetry. What he seems to be saying is this, that art does not lie in its message; poetry does not have to inculcate a moral; it has only to be; the artistry of the poem lies not so much in what is being said as in the way it says it. He stresses rhythm, defines true poetry as "the rhythmical creation of beauty," and declares that "music is the perfection of the soul, or idea, of poetry." Poe was unabashed to offer his own poem "The Raven" as an illustration of his point. It is about 100 lines (108 in fact), perfectly readable at one sitting. A sense of melancholy over the death of a beloved beautiful young woman pervades the whole poem: the portrayal of a young man grieving for his lost Lenore, his grief being turned to madness under the steady one-word repetition of the talking bird introduced right at the beginning of the poem:

Once upon a midnight dreary, while I pondered, weak and weary,
Over many a quaint and curious volume of forgotten ore ?
While I nodded, nearly napping, suddenly there came a tapping,
As of some one gently rapping, rapping at my chamber door ?
"Tis some visitor," I muttered, "tapping at my chamber door ?
Only this and nothing more."

After he sees the bird, its response ?or its imagined one ?"nevermore" ?keeps breaking upon the young man's psychic wound ruthlessly and ceaselessly as do the waves on the sea shore until his depression reaches its breaking point:

And the Raven, never flitting, still is sitting, still is sitting,
On the pallid bust of Pallas just above my chamber door;
And his eyes have all the seeming of a demon's that is dreaming,
And the lamp-light o'er him streaming throws his shadow on the floor;
And my soul from out that shadow that lies floating on the floor
Shall be lifted ?nevermore!

The young man, a neurotic on the brink of a mental collapse, outpours his sorrow in his semi-sleep on the appearance of the bird. Poetic imagination externalizes itself in the phantom of a bird and intermingles with it to enhance the effect of the tragedy of the bereavement. Here it is good to note that Poe's poems are heavily tinted in a dreamy, hallucinatory color. "The Raven" is a good example as the narrator is in a state of semi-stupor. So are poems like "Annabel Lee" which contains lines, "... the moon never beams without bringing me dreams / Of the beautiful Annabel Lee"; or "The Sleeper" in which the poet, standing beneath the mystic moon at midnight in the month of June, smells an opiate vapor, finds the universe wrapped up in a fog, and half dreams of the dead beauty sleeping peacefully in her grave; or "A Dream Within a Dream," wherein the poet realizes that all his days have been a dream and that, with hope gone, all is dream within a dream. This was probably the reason why James Russell Lowell (1819-1891) says of Poe in his *A Fable for Critics*: "Three fifths of him genius and two fifths sheer fudge[.]"

In addition, Poe insists on an even metrical flow in versification. "The Raven" is a marvel of regularity: W. L. Werner records that, of its 719 complete feet, 705 are perfect trochees, ten doubtful trochees, and only four clearly dactyls. Poe rarely allows himself twenty-five percent of irregular feet as is found in "Israfel." For the sake of regularity in rhythm, Poe disapproves of the use of archaisms, contractions, inversions, and similar devices. "The Raven" is thus a perfect illustration of his theory on poetry. A good specimen of a poem which does not say very much is his "The Bells", which is an elaborate display of pure technique with little or no substance. Its poetry exists in its ingenious creation of sounds. All sounds, vowels and diphthongs for example, and all poetic devices such as alliteration, assonance, and consonance are brought into full play for the "rhythmical creation of beauty." This was one of the reasons why Poe was and has been regarded as **one of the first aesthetes** in literary history. It is also good to note here that, though well-formulated, Poe's poetics is not always sound. His stress on brevity and on "an elevating excitement of the soul" can, for instance, exclude even Paradise Lost from what we call "great poetry." And his own best poems are always meaningful.

"Sonnet ?To Science" is, perhaps, as good as any of Poe's works to begin our more detailed discussion of the poet with. Here the poet is talking to an abstraction, science, which is personified: "Science! true daughter of Old Time thou art! / Who alterest all things with thy peering eyes. / Why preyest thou thus upon the poet's heart, / Vulture, whose wings are dull realities?" Here science as against art and imagination is treated as a villain. It is animalized as a vulture with wings of "dull realities," dull in the sense of being un-poetic. Analytical, empirical, and logical, science, through scientific investigation and knowledge, has relieved the world of a lot of its myth and, with it, room for poetic imagination: The romance of Diana, Hamadryad, Naiad, and the Elfin is broken, and so is the poet's "summer dream beneath the tamarind tree [.]". The poet is hindered in his aspirations of wandering and soaring with an undaunted wing to "the jeweled skies" for poetic treasures. The tension between science on the one hand and art and imagination on the other endows the poem with a unique power and significance. "Sonnet ?To Science" is a good indication that Poe was in essence a Renaissance man. He derived in part from Plato the notion that the universe was endowed with myth, and tried to restore it to the primordial unity which the cosmos once possessed. The same idea finds adequate expression in another of his best poems, "Israfel." Israfel is a perfect poet, with his lute of heart-strings, singing "wildly well" in Heaven. Here is an ideal world in the upper air of which this world is but an inadequate approximation (this is Plato again). This world longs to sing the same songs as does Israfel, and the poet longs for the same kind of poetic ability of Israfel's:

Yes, Heaven is thine; but this
Is a world of sweets and sour;
Our flowers are merely ?flowers,
And the shadow of thy perfect bliss
Is the sunshine of ours.
If I could dwell
Where Israfel
Hath dwelt, and he where I,
He might not sing so wildly well
A mortal melody,
While a bolder note than this might swell

From my lyre within the sky.

"To Helen," one of the most famous of Poe's lyrics, was written, as Poe recalls, "in my passionate boyhood, to the first, purely ideal love of my soul." It was inspired by the beauty of the mother of a schoolmate of Poe's in Richmond, Virginia. The poem is famous for a number of things, for example, its rhyme scheme, its varied line lengths, its metaphor of a travel on the sea, and its oft-quoted lines, "To the Glory that was Greece / And the grandeur that was Rome." "The City in the Sea," earlier entitled "The Doomed City," is an unusually disturbing poem. It is decadent, with Death on its throne overlooking the whole place, for the poem derives its force from numerous legends of drowned and buried cities. The tone is ghastly, indeed: "Lo! Death has reared himself a throne / In a stranger city lying alone / Far down within the dim West, / Where the good and the bad and the worst and the best / Have gone to their eternal rest. / There shrines and palaces and towers / (Time-eaten towers that tremble not!) / Resemble nothing that is ours. / Around, by lifting winds forgot, / Resignedly beneath the sky / The melancholy waters lie." The poem is significant as its theme ties in with Poe's overall thematic concerns.

Poe's theories for the short story are equally remarkable in their clarity. His principles for the short story are best illustrated in his review of Hawthorne's *Twice-Told Tales*. The short story, he says, must be of such length as to be read at one sitting (brevity), so as to ensure the totality of impression. The very first sentence ought to help to bring out the "single effect" of the story. No word should be used which does not contribute to the "pre-established" design of the work (compression). A tale should reveal some logical truth with "the fullest satisfaction," and should end with the last sentence, leaving a sense of finality with the reader. Poe's own creations of imagination satisfy his critical theories more or less perfectly. Take his "The Fall of the House of Usher" for example. The initial sentence, a long periodic, leads the reader right into the story of "the melancholy House of Usher." It is obvious that "melancholy" is to be the tone of the story (to say the least), and that tone is set from the very outset by the few words which Poe chose carefully to place on the first page. Words like "insufferable gloom," "desolate or terrible," "bleak walls," "vacant eye-like windows," "decayed trees," "depression of soul," "iciness," and "dreariness" serve to establish the gloomy and dreadful atmosphere of the story admirably well. The whole story is narrated in agonizing suspense: Roderick and his sister (in effect his double), the corruption of his mind and the disintegration of his house, and the narrator apparently losing his own reason in his friend's presence—all these contribute to the single effect the author intends the tale to produce on the reader: the disintegration and annihilation of a human mind. There is not much to cut in the narration. And the end of the story, a wonderfully loaded long sentence, fits the standard of "finality" as much as one can possibly imagine. We may also take a look at "The Cask of Amontillado." Here, again, the first sentence introduces the reader right into the story, and the last one ("For the half of a century no mortal has disturbed them. In peace requiescat!"), gives the reader a wonderful sense of absolute finality. We do not find much that is irrelevant to the organic whole of the story. In both this and "The Fall of the House of Usher," brevity is emphasized. Other stories like "Ligeia," the first sentence of which contains a mystery enough to get the story started, "The Purloined Letter," in which no one knows where the letter is placed before the end of the second page, and then "The Murders in the Rue Morgue," to quote just a few titles among so many, all seem to substantiate his critical assumptions with regard to the short story.

As a short-story writer, Poe was a fascinating man of imagination (like Israfel). In theme (though not in form) Poe anticipates twentieth-century literature in his treatment of the

disintegration of the self in a world of T. S. Eliot's "nothingness" and Hemingway's "nada." Poe was sensitive enough to feel the pressure of a world where science and reason reign supreme, one in which, as Matthew Arnold best expresses in his "Dover Beach," there is "neither joy, nor love, nor light, / Nor certitude, nor peace, nor help from pain." Baudelaire first took note of the psychological content of Poe's tales and regarded Poe as "a writer of nerves," who in exploring mental and moral disease had opened up for literature a new order of experience that seemed to have been hitherto effectively sealed off. Erich Heller saw Poe's psychological fiction as a vast and original contribution to "the discovery and colonization" of the mind. D. H. Lawrence saw Poe's stories as the disintegrating process of the soul. Indeed, Poe places the subconscious condition of the mind under investigation and probes beneath the surface of normal existence. What interests him most is the deep abyss of the unconscious and subconscious mental activity of the people, the subterranean recesses of the mind at work. This area of human experience Poe reveals sometimes with alarming accuracy. His assumption seems to be that every mind is half mad or capable of slipping into insanity. As a result of all these, his fictional characters are mostly neurotics. **He was the first author in American literature to make the neurotic the heroic figure, the protagonist, in his stories.** His heroes are mostly like Melville's "isolatoes," with no sense of their identity, no name even, no place nor parentage, dislocated, alienated from society, wandering from place to place like William Wilson, or a man desultorily following the crowd ("The Man of the Crowd") because he does not know where to belong, or a criminal who attempts to establish his sense of identity by the crime that he commits, or a bereaved lover which is essentially the situation we find in "Ligeia," "The Tell-Tale Heart," and "The Fall of the House of Usher." Poe's most enduring tales are those of horror, the horror coming, as it is most probably Poe's intention to reveal, from the workings of an irrational or criminal mind, driven to evil or insanity by a perverse, irrational force which, to Poe, is an elementary impulse in man. A number of Poe's tales treat a number of different people who, going mad, are all along aware that they are going mad, thus exhibiting the believable stages of mental disintegration.

Let's take a look at some of his tales. Another look at "The Fall of the House of Usher" will reveal that it is interesting in more ways than one. Here in this decaying, disintegrating house live a brother and sister. The sister is so ill that the brother buries her alive and puts the coffin away in one secluded part of the house. Then on a stormy night, the sister breaks out of her coffin and dies in the embrace of her brother, who then also dies. The house collapses into the lake on the shore of which it has stood. Roderick Usher, the brother, is very much a Poe character. He knows every turn of his own disintegrating mind. Poe places Usher's school friend beside him, watching and then coming back to retell the appalling process of the dissolution. What drives Roderick crazy is not immediately clear. He tries to destroy his twin sister with whom he may have committed incest. Her removal might free him from his emotional and physical stress as well as his life, for he knows that, as soon as she dies, he dies, too. The destructive, incestuous joining may be responsible for the tragedy of the mind. The collapse of the house is symbolic of the ultimate annihilation of the being that was Usher. Approaching this theme from a slightly different point of view is the story "William Wilson," another strange case of "Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde." The namesake schoolmate of William Wilson is in point of fact his double, and Wilson's mind refuses to acknowledge what he really is until it is totally disintegrated. "Ligeia" is a good case in point, too. The narrator is so obsessed with the death of his first wife that he cannot see his second wife except in the guise of his first. More than that, even his vision is reflected in the eyes of his first

wife: there is no sense of reality except as he knows it from her. What also merits attention are the eyes of Poe's ladies which Poe insists on presenting as in "Ligeia." "The Tell-Tale Heart," a tale of murder, tends to present the internal disintegration in an exterior way. The narrator-murderer is obviously a schizophrenic, to whom the eyes of the victim prove to be intolerable. The murderer commits the crime and cannot resist the temptation, the neurotic joy, of revealing his criminal secret. (One interesting interpretation of the tale is to see it as representing the love-and-hate relationship between the anxiously overseeing parents and the rebellious urge of the youth to remove the parental supervision.) "Black Cat" is an incisive inquiry into the capacity of the human mind to originate its own destruction; "The Imp of the Perverse," more allegory than a tale, illustrates Poe's rationale that "to indulge alone in any attempted thought is inevitably lost." These tales turn on the central theme that the human mind would be healthy and alive if it were incapable of thought, but since it is a mind and does possess the power of introspection and self-knowledge, then that very power and knowledge spell its death. In other words, thought is the constituent of the mind, but the act of thinking can be its undoing. That is one of the reasons why Poe is a lot more interesting as a writer now than he was in his own century. In the twentieth century Freud, Jung, and their associates and disciples have pushed research into the deepest recesses of the human mind, and have thus influenced modern life and literature in a profound way. Poe's greatness lies in the fact that he anticipated these developments as no one else did.

There is another thing about Poe that merits attention. On the one hand he was much given to the world of imagination and fancy (where Israfel stands), and on the other, he was also a full rational human being, logical to a fault, with an intuitive faculty and a sixth sense impossible to define. In other words, he was immensely interested in deduction and induction. Poe wrote half a dozen stories which A. H. Quinn has termed "Ratiocinative." "The Murders in the Rue Morgue," "The Purloined Letter," "The Gold Bug," and "The Mystery of Marie Roget" are the best of this category. Poe seemed to be fascinated with the intuitive faculty, the power to enter intuitively into the mind of another person as a source of technique in solving a crime. Take "The Purloined Letter" for example. Dupin is endowed with the miraculous faculty to place himself in the mind of the criminal. With this power of inductive reasoning, he manages to solve a problem without even having to leave his room. Before he takes the final action to retrieve the critical letter about the Queen, he envisions, and accurately, the place where Minister D would hide it: the criminal would be clever enough to leave the letter where most people of mediocre intelligence would fail to notice ?the most visible yet the least attention-grabbing card-rack. He exhibits a rare combination of imagination with "a keen analytical mind and mathematical powers of a high order" in proving that the assassin in "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" is not human. Here the pattern which the story follows is immensely fascinating. It is a locked-room puzzle. One opens the door, finds not only no murderer and no weapon, but no trace of any human being having ever moved about in the room. Poe obviously delights in such analytical feats of the mind.

Poe's style is traditional. It is much too rational, too ordinary to reflect the peculiarity of his theme. Somehow he failed to carry the newness of his idea into his style, which incidentally failed to echo his central theme. He is not easy to read. Dickens is much easier. So is Henry David Thoreau whose prose may be involved but, as it is fluent and coherent, is comfortable to read. Poe's choice of words and his syntax may have been responsible for his difficult prose. Occasionally one feels his mannerism hindering a smooth and pleasurable reading.

Poe's position in world literature is secure. His influence is world-wide in modern literature.

His aesthetics and conscious craftsmanship, his attack on "the heresy of the didactic," and his call for "the rhythmical creation of beauty" have influenced French symbolists and the devotees of "art for art's sake." Poe was **father** of many things, one of which is psychoanalytic criticism, the other being the detective story. Some of his tales left a visible imprint on such major English authors as H. G. Wells. American authors like T. S. Eliot and William Faulkner all owe a good deal to him. His popularity has been on the increase in the last half-century. Poe's relationship to Chinese literature is not insignificant. A recent study has revealed an interesting fact, that modern Chinese masters like Lu Xun and Guo Mo-ruo all felt his presence on the Chinese literary scene of the early decades of this century: They read and commented upon his works. It is obvious that further research need be done in this field.

CHAPTER 8 The Age of Realism Howells James

Political and social events influence writers in both theme and technique. We are dealing with the period following the most important single influence on American Literature ?the Civil War. The industrialized Hamiltonian North fought the agrarian Jeffersonian South like two separate countries for supremacy. The factory defeated the farm, and the United States headed toward capitalism. In a way the surrender at Appomattox marked the beginnings of a course which America has followed to this day. The war led many to question the assumptions shared by the Transcendentalists ?natural goodness, the optimistic view of nature and man, benevolent God. It taught men that life was not so good, man was not, and God was not. The war marked a change, in the words of Lionel Trilling, in the quality of American life, a deterioration, in fact, of American moral values.

In post-bellum America, commerce took the lead in the national economy. Railroads tripled in 15 years and was multiplied five times in 25, and petroleum was discovered in sizeable quantities. By 1880 half the population in the east lived in towns, and movement away from the farm became obvious. Increasing industrialization and mechanization of the country, now in full swing after the war, soon produced extremes of wealth and poverty. Wealth and power were more and more concentrated in the hands of the few "captains of industry" or "robber barons" such as John D. Rockefeller, Andrew Carnegie, and J. P. Morgan. These people had most of them as young men avoided service during the war and made fantastic profits in the booming war-time economy. Now they became dominant in the social and economic life of the nation. The spirit of self-reliance that Emerson had preached became perverted into admiration for driving ambition, a lust for money and power. Preachers shouted it from the pulpits; children were brought up on the Horatio Alger success stories which said that a person with ambition could make his own world. When John D. Rockefeller claimed in all seriousness that his money had been given him by God, nobody laughed. Too few people recognized the chicanery and graft going on around them. In the meantime, life for the millions was fast becoming a veritable struggle for survival.

Added to this was the fact that the frontier was closing. The frontier had been a factor of great importance in American life. As long as the frontier was there, people could always hope to escape troubles over the next hill and have a better life ahead. Now that the frontier was about to close and the safety valve was ceasing to operate, a reexamination of life began. The worth of the American dream, the idealized, romantic view of man and his life in the New World, began to lose its hold on the imagination of the people. Beneath the glittering surface of prosperity there lay suffering and unhappiness. Disillusionment and frustration were widely felt. What had been

expected to be a "Golden Age" turned out to be a "Gilded" one.

By the 1870s New England Renaissance had waned. Hawthorne and Thoreau were dead. Emerson, Longfellow, and other New England celebrities, though still writing, were old and feeble. Melville had ceased to publish. Dickinson had not been brought to light. Of the older generation Whitman alone remained active, a solitary singer in the field with his *Leaves of Grass*. The age of Romanticism and Transcendentalism was by and large over. Boston and New England ceased to be the cultural center of the country. Meanwhile, younger writers appeared on the scene. William Dean Howells, Henry James, and Mark Twain were becoming established as novelists of no small talent. "Local colorists" like Bret Harte and Edward Eggleston were making their voices heard. And a good number of other writers like Louisa May Alcott (with her *Little Women* [1868-1869]) were beginning to publish. The age of realism had arrived.

As a literary movement realism came in the latter half of the nineteenth century as a reaction against "the lie" of romanticism and sentimentalism. It expressed the concern for the world of experience, of the commonplace, and for the familiar and the low. William Dean Howells, the champion of the new school, felt that he must write what he observed and knew ("He ... can only write of what his fleshly eyes have seen," as Henry James says of him). The main theme of Henry James' "The Art of Fiction" reveals his literary credo that representation of life should be the main object of the novel. And Mark Twain had, as his aim of writing, the soul, the life, and the speech of the people in mind. In matters of style, there was contrast between the genteel and graceful prose on the one hand, and vernacular diction, rough and ready frontier humor on the other. Twain serves as an example of a man who made the bridge, beginning as a frontier humorist and working his way into polite society, while not forgetting where he came from. The American authors lumped together as "realists" seem to have some features in common: "verisimilitude of detail derived from observation," the effort to approach the norm of experience, a reliance on the representative in plot, setting, and character, and to offer an objective rather than an idealized view of human nature and experience. With Howells, James, and Mark Twain active on the scene, realism became a major trend in the seventies and eighties of the nineteenth century.

William Dean Howells (1837-1920)

Howells was born in a small town in Ohio and brought up in the humble surroundings of the rough-and-ready American Midwest. He had little formal education but was widely read. His successive "literary passions" included Goldsmith, Irving, Cervantes, Heine, and Tennyson; later major influences were Jane Austen, George Eliot, Turgenev, Hardy, and others. He became a reporter, and by 1860, had had three of his poems printed in *The Atlantic Monthly*. As he wrote a successful campaign biography of Lincoln to help him to win the Presidency, Howells was appointed American consul in Venice (1861-1865), where he learned to know Europe and contrast it with America. On returning home at the end of the war, Howells moved to Boston and became, first, assistant editor and then editor-in-chief of the country's most influential journal, *The Atlantic Monthly* (1871-1881). He made friends with Lowell, Longfellow, and Holmes, and married into an eminent New England family.

As a critic of eminent standing and as a prolific writer, Howells helped to mould public taste and became the champion of literary realism in America. It is estimated that he wrote, in addition to the good number of social novels, eight critical books and about 1 700 book reviews to spread the credo of realism. As editor and critic Howells was generous in constructive and sympathetic reviews, helping younger and more radical writers to get a hearing. Writers such as Hamlin

Garland, Stephen Crane, Frank Norris, Henry James, and Mark Twain all enjoyed his friendly advice and assistance in times of need. Thus he was, for several decades, the dean of his country's literature (the words are H. L. Mencken's) and became, naturally, the first president of the American Academy of Arts and Letters. Yale, Princeton, Columbia, and Oxford all conferred honorary degrees upon him. However, his reputation fell drastically in the first decades of the twentieth century and began to rise only in recent years. Howells deserves better treatment. His works have been reprinted, and he is now considered as a major figure in American literary history.

Most of Howells' literary-aesthetic ideas are best elucidated in his *Criticism and Fiction*, a selection of essays he had written for his column, "The Editor's Study," in *Harper's Magazine*. Howells defines realism as "fidelity to experience and probability of motive," as a quest of the average and the habitual rather than the exceptional or the uniquely high or low. His expressed aim in *Their Wedding Journey* was, for instance, to do nothing more than "talk of some ordinary traits of American life." He preferred not to look upon man in his "heroic or occasional phases," but "to seek him in his habitual moods of vacancy and tiresomeness." Thus man in his natural and unaffected dullness was the object of Howells' fictional representation. To him realism is by no means mere photographic pictures of externals but includes a central concern with "motives" and psychological conflicts. Silas Lapham's meditation on personal integrity as against possible bankruptcy is a telling example. In a eulogistic essay on his friend Henry James, Howells argues that the main line of development in the novel is not from Dickens and Thackeray but from the psychological analysis of Hawthorne and George Eliot to James. He condemns novels of sentimentality and morbid self-sacrifice, and avoids such themes as illicit love not because of squeamishness but because they were not representative in his day. As a non-academic realist, Howells attacks Platonic "archetypes" as artificial (akin to "paste-board grasshoppers"), but he tactfully observes that Lowell's *Biglow Papers* in dialect and Emerson's devotion to the American scene and the familiar had paved the way for realism. Authors should minimize plot and the artificial ordering of the sense of something "desultory, unfinished, imperfect" in life. He argues for the idea that "a free and simple design where event follows event without the fettering control of intrigue, but where all grows naturally out of character and conditions, is the supreme form of fiction." Characters should have solidity of specification and be real.

As Howells saw it, realism, interpreting sympathetically the "common feelings of commonplace people," was best suited as a technique to express the spirit of America. This was so because it regarded the average as revealing a civilization's progress more than any eccentric or capriciously unique single individual's. The test of a civilization is the principle of the greatest happiness of the greatest number, the good of all. Democracy in literature aimed to "make them [men] know one another better, that they may be humbled and strengthened with a sense of their fraternity." American conditions tended "to invite the artist to the portrayal in every art of those finer and higher aspects which unite rather than sever humanity." He urged writers to winnow tradition and write in keeping with current humanitarian ideals. On truth Howells held that truth is the highest beauty, but truth includes the view that morality penetrates all things: "the beast-man will be ... subdued." With regard to literary criticism, Howells felt that the literary critic should not try to impose arbitrary or subjective evaluations on books but should follow the detached scientist in accurate description, interpretation, and classification. The critic's job was "to identify the literary species and explain the weaknesses of a work in the light of the author's intentions."

Howells was a prolific writer. He wrote volumes of drama, poetry, and novels in addition to criticism, travelogues, and autobiography. The greatest of all his works is *The Rise of Silas Lapham* in which Howells' qualities as a novelist are shown at their best. The book relates the story of a new upstart in mid-nineteenth-century Boston. Silas Lapham is a self-made man. He starts his paint business from scratch and becomes a millionaire. That is his material rise in the world. Aspiring to conquer Boston polite society, he spends a lot of money on building a gorgeous house in a "respectable" area of the town. One of his daughters falls in love with a young man of an upper class family, the Coreys. Then competition becomes keener. Silas is in danger. Some English syndicate comes along to offer a handsome sum of money for some property of his which he knows the railroad needs and would force any owner out at a ruinous price. Silas is in a dilemma. Cheating, he would survive; being honest would be his undoing. He decides to be honest. As he does not sell and fails to find the money he badly needs to save his business, his company goes bankrupt. He falls and suffers, but manages to keep more people from suffering. Falling, he achieves his moral and ethical "rise."

The Rise of Silas Lapham is a fine specimen of American realistic writing. The world of Silas Lapham is that of the commonplace Bostonian of the late nineteenth century. Here is an average American happy with his family, and proud with his success in the world. He is seen on his trotter going down the streets of Boston where there is a ceaseless stream of cutters coming and going, a burly policeman silently directing traffic amid the rush and bustle of men. We hear Silas talk with his wife and kids, his wife addressing him "Si" when things go well and "Silas Lapham" when she is about to read him a lecture. The Coreys and others are all in their "habitual moods." There is nothing heroic, dramatic or extraordinary. Howells is here so devoted to the small, the trivial, and the commonplace that he was even mocked on occasion for building "in the stones of the street when he might have built in more durable and beautiful material."

Howells' emphasis has always been on ethics. He stresses the need for sympathy and moral integrity, and the need for different social classes to harmoniously adapt to their environment and to one another. There is indeed some bitterness toward the Boston upper class in *A Chance Acquaintance*, but after that Howells was studiously fair to both classes and urged both the simple kindness of heart and the recognition of the deeper significance of manners and courtesy. Thus we see the Laphams and the Coreys trying to overcome their prejudices and come together. In Tom Corey, and to some extent Atherton in *A Modern Instance*, Howells attempted to spread a new concept of the gentleman as self-independent, considerate of others, and scornful of class distinctions. Howells did not approve of competitive economic individualism. He was convinced that laissez-faire competition had proved the rapacity of man. Silas Lapham has handled his partner Rogers roughly and is in turn treated in more or less the same way by his own rivals. What Howells tried to recommend as a pattern of virtue was a Lapham acting on the utilitarian principle of the greatest happiness for the greatest number.

An important thing to note about *The Rise of Silas Lapham* is the house which Lapham spends a fortune to build, only to be burned down in the end. To Lapham it is a symbol of his success and his aspiration for the polite society which, he dreams of conquering. But Mrs. Lapham sees it as an emblem of her husband's selfish individualism, declaring that there is blood on its timbers; she has in mind Rogers whom her husband has squeezed out of business. Lapham's moral rise begins with his financial fall; both are dramatized by the irretrievable destruction of the house. The burning down of the house represents the victory of Howells' idealized view of man and

society, for Howells was critical of the rise of materialism in American life. America at the time was building a house of the Vanderbilts, the Carnegies, and the Rockefellers at the expense of the miserable millions. Lapham's house is, to quote Everett Carter, a representation of the society Howells feared America was becoming, of the evils which he felt were overtaking the culture he knew and loved. He would like to see his country become a more humane, a morally higher place, an Altruria from which Silas Lapham was to be a traveler.

The love subplot of the story is interesting in more than one way. On its most superficial level, the love subplot adds an element of mystery and suspense to the story, thus exciting and holding the interest of the reader in general. Thematically, there are two ways in which the subplot serves as a foil to the main one. First, the "economy of pain" formula evolved in the subplot, where "one suffers instead of three," seems to help toward preparing Silas Lapham for the self-sacrifice he is to make later in the book. Tom Corey falls in love with Penelope, Silas' elder daughter. He is not aware that Irene, the younger daughter, has a crush on him. In her selfless love for her kid sister, Penelope withdraws from the triangle, hoping to make Irene happy. But Irene is hurt when Tom is not responsive to her advances, and Tom is hurt when Penelope stops being responsive to his. All the time the kind Penelope suffers for having to act the way she does. In the end the advice of a clergyman addresses the problem well. Instead of all three suffering, as Mr. Sewell suggests, let Irene drop out of the game and suffer so that the other two would achieve happiness. This is the "economy of pain" formula to ensure "the greatest happiness for the greatest number." Donald Pizer sees the moral rise of Lapham as the result of his ready absorption of the "economy of pain" formula. Lapham decides not to sell his property to the English people who come to ask for it. As a result, he fails to save his own neck in the world of competition, but he helps avoid the possible suffering of many other people. Another way in which the subplot serves a useful purpose is that it presents a roughly analogous pattern of experience and behavior between Penelope and Silas Lapham. Both did something which, not quite right in strictly moral terms, helped move them to an act of self-denial: Lapham in his dealings with Rogers, and Penelope in giving Tom Corey, whether unwittingly or not, the hope that she was not indifferent to him. Both underwent trials and resisted temptations and decided on a course of action which they considered to be morally right.

Though Howells wrote about "this happy continent," it is good to remember that his oft-quoted phrase "smiling aspects" was first used in a rather ironic sense. America became somber in *The Rise of Silas Lapham* and *The Minister's Charge*. *A Modern Instance* is mildly naturalistic, and *A World of Chance* presents a universe in which men are at the tender mercies of chance and blind and meaningless futility. This, and *Annie Kilburn* and *A Hazard of New Fortunes* reveal a Howells definitely not "smiling." Howells was disillusioned with his America: "I suppose I love America less because it won't let me love it more," he thus wrote to Mark Twain later in life: "After fifty years of optimistic content with civilization and its ability to come out all right in the end, I now abhor it, and feel that it is coming out all wrong in the end..." Howells was saved from pessimistic defeatism only by his constructive use of the novel to promote brotherly love in daily living.

Placed in historical perspective, Howells is found lacking in qualities which would have made him great and eternal. He is wanting in depth. Much of his realism was external characters and events viewed from without. His works rarely achieved, or sought to achieve "psychological depth." If there is evil, it is slight; if there is passion, it is restrained; and triumphs, if there are, are

but few. In refinement he is not up to James; in rough and ready humor he falls short of Mark Twain. In addition, by the turn of the century, naturalism had replaced his "smiling" brand of realism. His vogue had passed, and he became a "dead cult." But time and history are just. The part which Howells played in the history of American literature will not be forgotten. If he is not great in the sense that Mark Twain and William Faulkner are great, he is at least a major figure in that literature. This much is certain.

Henry James (1843-1916)

Henry James was born into a wealthy cultured family of New England. His father, Henry James, Sr., was an eminent philosopher and reformer, and his brother, William James, was to be the famous philosopher and psychologist. Henry James was one of the few authors in American literary history who did not have to worry about money. His early upbringing was unusual: he was exposed to the cultural influence of Europe at a very early age. Later he met and developed a life-long friendship with William Dean Howells, who became his "moral police." For a while he attended the Harvard Law School, where he read, instead of law, French novelists and critics such as Balzac and George Sand. He also read intensively George Eliot and Hawthorne. He toured England, France and Italy, and met, among others, Flaubert and Turgenev who was then staying in Paris. At first James tried to live and work as an art and drama critic in New York, but found the materialistic bent of American life and its lack of culture and sophistication intolerable. He settled down in London in 1876 and, except for some visits to America, spent the rest of his life there. In 1915 he became a naturalized British citizen and the following year received on his deathbed the Order of Merit from King George V. James was not married. He once loved his attractive cousin Minny Temple who died young.

Henry James was a voluminous writer. His whole life was a long career of continual fertile productivity. The quantity of work he produced filled up a good many volumes ?novels, travel papers, critical essays, literary portraits, plays, autobiographies, and a series of critical prefaces on the art of fiction. In addition, he was a copious letter writer and left a good number of notebooks.

James was influenced by some English, European and American writers. He found in George Eliot his ideal of the philosophical novelist, impressed by her looking into the minds and souls of her characters. To him she observed, thought, and felt, but was wrong to place emphasis on conscience rather than on passion which he saw as the ruling force in life. Turgenev was an "adorable" novelist who served as a guide for him. "He [Turgenev] had an eye for all our passions, and a deeply sympathetic sense of the wonderful complexity of our souls," he once thus commented upon the Russian novelist. Turgenev's portraits of women proved to be an inspiration to him. James expressed his admiration for the masterpiece of Flaubert, *Madame Bovary*, in an essay of 1876. The resemblance between James' *Madame de Mauves* and Flaubert's work is remarkable. The one American author who exerted a measure of influence on James is Hawthorne whose insight into the human psyche impressed the younger writer deeply.

The creative life of Henry James can be divided into three distinctive periods. In the first period (1865-1882) he produced a number of novels, among which the most important include *The American*, *Daisy Miller* which won him international fame and which reveals James' fascination with his "international theme" (or American innocence in face of European sophistication), and *The Portrait of a Lady*, one of the greatest books that James ever wrote. The second period of his career extended from 1882 to 1895, in which he dropped the "international theme" and wrote his tales of subtle studies of inter-personal relationships. As these novels were

poorly received, James turned to play-writing in 1890. His plays being also failures, he returned to the novel in 1895 with renewed vigor and a better knowledge of literary techniques which he was able to obtain from the five years of play-writing. Now began the third and final phase of his creativity. Between 1895 and 1900 he wrote a few novellas and tales dealing with childhood and adolescence, which was a revival of his earlier theme of innocence in a corrupted world. The most famous of these are the enigmatic *The Turn of the Screw* and *What Maisie Knew*. In the first four years of this century, James wrote in quick succession, the three great novels, *The Ambassadors*, *The Wings of the Dove*, and *The Golden Bowl*, which represent the summit of his art and thus constitute "the major phase" of his career. Here James returned to his old ground, "the international theme." In the last years of his life he wrote some American impressions and some autobiographical matter, and left two novels, *The Ivory Tower* and *The Sense of the Past* unfinished.

During his lifetime his fame rested largely upon his handling of his major fictional theme, "the international theme": the meeting of America and Europe, American innocence in contact and contrast with European decadence, and its moral and psychological complications. For the American it was a process of progression from inexperience to experience, from innocence to knowledge and maturity. James presented, through his fiction, the superiority of at least some of the values of the New World to those of the Old. He enjoyed juxtaposing American moral innocence with the somber decadence of Europe, or in the words of William Troy, American innocence caught in the toils of European duplicity. James' fictional world is peopled almost always by American heroes and heroines who, confronting European sophistication, either triumphed over it or were overwhelmed. As S. G. Putt writes, James' work is his tableau showing the plight of the Americans who, once they had passed through the "passionate pilgrim" phase, were striving to come to grips with the phenomena of Europe. Christopher Newman in *The American*, frustrated by the evil of French aristocratic selfishness, finds to his infinite dismay that the dead hand of its traditions has reached out to snatch his happiness away from him. Daisy Miller relates the tale of a young girl from Schenectady, New York, who goes to Rome and never realizes for one moment that European values can be any different from those of her hometown. Fresh Daisy withers and dies in Rome. *The Portrait of a Lady* tells about the fate of one of those splendid Jamesian American girls, Isabel Archer, arriving in Europe, full of hope, and with a will to live a free and noble life, only to fall prey to the sinister designs of two vulgar and unscrupulous expatriates, Madam Merle and Gilbert Osmond. "Ground in the mill of the very conventional," Isabel's dreams and expectations evaporated: her unawareness of evil around her and her money combined to work her undoing. *The Ambassadors*, which James considered his "most perfect" work of art, is a comedy of American and European manners. Strether, the middle-aged American, is sent to Paris to bring back a young man too fascinated with Europe to return home, but is eventually convinced that Paris is the place both for the young man and for himself. James stresses mutual understanding and sympathy. "All life [in his opinion] comes back to the question of our relations with each other." If Europe symbolizes traditionalism and America individualism (self-dependence), James' ideal may have been to combine the best of both harmoniously.

James' contribution to literary criticism is immense. Himself a dedicated artist, he wrote for half a century to help perfect the art of writing. A voluminous and discriminating critic, he developed gradually, as Morris Roberts shows, from early evaluation in terms of stiff moral standards to inductive inquiry, flexibility, and a subtle perception of aesthetic nuances. His

criticism is both concerned with form and devoted to human values. James defines the novel as primarily having a "large, free character of an immense and exquisite correspondence with life." To him "art without life is a poor affair," "the province of art is all life, all feeling, all observation, all vision." Art must be related to life; it must be life transformed and changed so that the art form would give the truthful impression of actuality. In fact the main theme of his famous essay, "The Art of Fiction," is that the aim of the novel is to represent life. "The only reason for the existence of a novel is that it does attempt to represent life," he says in one context. "The air of reality (solidity of specification) seems to me to be the supreme virtue of a novel," he states in another. The production of the illusion of life, he feels, forms "the beginning and the end of the art of the novelist and is his inspiration, his despair, his reward, his torment, his delight." He advocates an immense increase of freedom in novel-writing and argues for inclusion of the disagreeable, the ugly, and the commonplace. Thus he was one of the three staunch advocates of nineteenth-century American realism, the other two being Howells and Mark Twain.

Though closely related to life, art is important in its own way. "It is art that makes life, makes interest, makes importance." While actual life is "all inclusion and confusion," with the important mixed up with and obscured by the ephemeral, James would use art to bring pattern and meaning out of life, for art is "all discrimination and selection" of what is centrally revelatory and "typical." To be completely great, James declares, a work of art must lift up the heart; there is no substitute for the force and beauty of its process. James prefers to work in the light of the chemist's parallel attempts to recombine elements purposefully to create a better product, to render the artist, in Joseph Conrad's words on James, the dramatic "historian of fine consciences" such as those of Theale Milly and Isabel Archer.

In his whole writing career James was concerned with "point of view" which is at the center of his aesthetic of the novel. To correspond to life the author should avoid artificial omniscience as much as possible. Very early in his career, as Leon Edel notes, James discovered the trick of making his characters reveal themselves with minimal intervention of the author. He used a particular method of telling the story, that is, illumination of the situation and characters through one or several minds. This method he termed "point of view." Here we observe events and people filter through the consciousness of his characters. In Roderick Hudson the center of interest is in the consciousness of the character Rowland Mallet. In *The Portrait of a Lady* James placed the center of the subject in the consciousness of the heroine, Isabel Archer; Isabel's vigil and meditation is presented as a very elaborate internal monologue, so that the reader is within her mind and has her inner vision. The interesting novella, *The Turn of the Screw*, is interesting precisely because of the confusion caused by the point of view of the governess from which the story is told: the common reader is liable to be misled by the governess, a very unreliable narrator. What Maisie Knew presents experience merely through the intelligence of a child as she is shuttled back and forth in an evil world. And *The Ambassadors* is unified by having the action presented entirely through the consciousness of Strether as he becomes increasingly aware of the differences between American and Parisian concepts of gracious living. Thus James, by emphasizing the inner awareness and inward movements of his characters in face of outside occurrences rather than merely delineating their environment in any detail, became probably the first of the modern psychological analysts in the novel and anticipated in his works the modern stream-of-consciousness technique so widely employed in the first decades of this century. His consistent conscious attention to the art of the novel earned him the deep respect of the world, so

that toward the latter part of his life there grew "the legend of the Master" around him.

In political-social ideas and attitudes James, writing about the wealthy, deep-rooted leisure class, became in a way its spokesman, stressing travel, cosmopolitanism, manners, and taste as indices to social superiority. He was conservative toward overzealous reformers the way Hawthorne was toward his fictional heroes Holgrave (in *The House of the Seven Gables*) and Hollingsworth (in *The Blithedale Romance*). But it is worth noting that James was critical of U.S. imperialist behavior as in the Spanish-American War, and that he exposed predatory business competition of the New World and its dehumanizing result, and the decadence and corruption of the Old, seeing, among other things, the condition of the English upper class as "rotten and collapsible." He was very critical of American life, its obsession with "business," its extremes of wealth and poverty, its lack of culture and sophistication. *The American Scene* (1907) is his "restless analyst's" report of observations from Boston to California and the south. Like Hawthorne, James regarded evil as essentially of inward cause and cure, advocated free-willed renunciation of the low or mean, and repeatedly emphasized magnanimity and the beauty of goodness.

With regard to the reputation of Henry James, there has also been a process of "discovery." He was not widely read at his death. The over-elaborate style was often irritatingly intimidating and discouraging, and the psychological complexities of his novels, while interesting from the literary point of view, are not always to the liking of the common readers. With the development of the modern novel and the Freudian approach that became a vogue in the first years of the twentieth century, the importance of James' literary theories and practice has been duly recognized. If early literary historians such as V. L. Parrington and A. H. Quinn failed to emphasize that importance, modern critics like F. O. Matthiessen, P. W. Dupee, Leon Edel, Robert Spiller, and Oscar Cargill have successfully moved Henry James out of his "incorruptible silence of Fame." He is, today, a world literary figure, one of the "largest" to come out of America during the nineteenth century and the early twentieth, a remarkable New World bridge, in the words of Leon Edel, from the Enlightenment to all that is "modern" in the literary art of the twentieth century. His has become a name no one can afford to ignore in the history of Western literature.

CHAPTER 9 Local Colorism Mark Twain

Local Colorism

The vogue of local color fiction was, as Claude M. Simpson puts it, the logical culmination of a long, progressive development. It was the outgrowth of historical and aesthetic forces that had been gathering energy since early nineteenth century.

In his *Crumbling Idols* Hamlin Garland defined local colorism as having "such quality of texture and background that it could not have been written in any other place or by anyone else than a native." Garland's "texture" refers to the elements which characterize a local culture, elements such as speech, customs, and mores peculiar to one particular place. And his "background" covers physical, setting and those distinctive qualities of landscape which condition human thought and behavior. The ultimate aim of the local colorists is, as Garland indicates, to create the illusion of an indigenous little world with qualities that tell it apart from the world outside.

The social and intellectual climate of the country provided a stimulating milieu for the growth of local color fiction. The United States, still expanding westward, had not had time to solidify itself into a cohesive cultural whole. Marked differences existed between different parts of

the country, with the East assuming the superior "aristocratic" posture. The rest of the country keenly felt the psychological need to assert their cultural identity, seeking understanding and recognition by showing their local character. Intellectually, the frontier humorists, who had flourished several decades before the Civil War, had prepared the literary ground for local colorism. In the humorous "tall tales" of these writers, there was an obvious emphasis on local peculiarities of speech, dress and habits of thought and the presentation of native character types, which continued, to some extent, into local color fiction. The earlier humorists influenced local color writers so much that one of the latter group, Bret Harte, even declared that local color derived directly from them. After the Civil War a good number of periodicals appeared unusually willing to accept and pay well for local color short stories: Harper's Monthly, Harper's Weekly, The Galaxy, and Scribner's Magazine ?to name just a few ?all were ready to spread local color.

Local colorism as a trend first made its presence felt in the late 1860s and early seventies. The appearance of Bret Harte's "The Luck of Roaring Camp" in 1868 marked a significant development in the brief history of local color fiction. Bret Harte's stories managed to draw the attention of the nation to the new genre of writing and make editors and readers more responsive to the speedy growths of similar, regional literature in different sections of the country. The voice of Bret Harte was echoed and made more resonant by those of such local colorists as Harriet Beecher Stowe with her *Oldtown Folks* and Edward Eggleston with his *The Hoosier Schoolmaster*. By the early seventies William Dean Howells noticed that the whole varied field of American life was coming into view in American fiction. Magazines were filled with local sketches and stories. The next decade saw a spectacular growth of regional literature when the literary geniuses of different localities rose to join the race to paint their own section of the country in the best colors available. The movement was so widespread that it became as contagious as whooping-cough. Not until the turn of the 20th century did local colorism cease to be a dominant fashion.

Local colorists concerned themselves with presenting and interpreting the local character of their regions. They tended to idealize and glorify, but they never forgot to keep an eye on the truthful color of local life. Bret Harte's *The Luck of Roaring Camp and Other Stories* contains, in his own words, "bits of local color that are truthful" and characters that had "a real human being as a suggesting and starting point." Mrs. Stowe's object was "to interpret to the world the New England life and character in that particular time of its history which may be called the seminal period," and her studies for this object "have been taken from real characters, real scenes, and real incidents." And Hamlin Garland, in writing about the region which he knew best, and dealing explicitly with the local environment, coined the word "veritism" for his particular brand of realism. His *Main-Traveled Roads*, a truthful record of the commonplace farm life of the West, Howells saw as a creation out of the burning dust of the truth about human experience on the American soil.

The list of names of the local colorists is a long one. In addition to those mentioned above, there are, among others, Constance Fenimore Woolson's *Castle Nowhere: Lake-Country Sketches*, Sarah Orne Jewett's *Deephaven*, a collection about coastal Maine, Kate Chopin writing of Louisiana Cajun-life in her *Bayou Folk*, *A Night in Acadie* and *The Awakening* (1899), Gertrude Atherton of Spanish California, Owen Wister of Wyoming cowboy life, and C. B. Fernald of San Francisco's Chinatown. There were also Mary H. Catherwood, in the middle West, Mary Hallock Foote in the far West, and Mary N. Murfree, G. W. Cable, J. Chandler Harris and Thomas Nelson Page in the South. For over three decades, there raged such a sweeping vogue of local color that

virtually no corner of the country was left untouched. The local colorists formed an important part of the realistic movement. Their truthful depiction of the common people in their commonplace lives added strength to the fight for realism which Howells championed with James and Mark Twain. There was, in addition, the tall-tale kind of humor built into the very texture of most of local color literature. In a sense local color literature stemmed directly from the frontier tall-tale tradition. Although it lost its momentum toward the end of the nineteenth century, the local spirit continued to inspire and fertilize the imagination of authors such as Willa Cather, John Steinbeck and William Faulkner, who ultimately managed, by rooting their work in their place, to reach the plane of universal meaning.

Mark Twain (1835-1910)

Mark Twain, pseudonym of Samuel Langhorne Clemens, was brought up in the small town of Hannibal, Missouri, on the Mississippi River. He was twelve when his father died and he had to leave school. He was successively a printer's apprentice, a tramp printer, a silver miner, a steamboat pilot on the Mississippi, and a frontier journalist in Nevada and California. This knocking about gave him a wide knowledge of humanity. With the publication of his frontier tale, "The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County," Twain became nationally famous. In 1866 he went east, where he met Howells and married Olivia Langdon of Elmira, New York, both symbols of gentility who combined to tame this "wild humorist of the Pacific Slope." His first novel, *The Gilded Age* (1873), written in collaboration with Charles Dudley Warner, was an artistic failure, but it gave its name to the America of the post-bellum period which it attempts to satirize. His boyhood experience, so happily remembered later in his *Autobiography*, furnished him with ample material for "fiction." *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer* (1876) was an immediate success as "a boy's book"; its sequel, *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (1884) which Mark Twain wrote some years later, became his masterwork, the one book from which, as Ernest Hemingway noted, "all modern American literature comes." Mark Twain's three years' life on the Mississippi left such a fond memory with him that he returned to the theme more than once in his writing career. *Life on the Mississippi* (1883), another masterpiece of his, relates it in a vivid, moving way. Mark Twain was essentially an affirmative writer. But toward the latter part of his life, he became increasingly violent in his censure of man and his society. In his later works the change from an optimist and humorist to an almost despairing determinist is unmistakable. *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* (1889), *The Man That Corrupted Hadleyburg* (1900), *The Mysterious Stranger* (1916), and his *Autobiography* (1924) all contain bitter attacks on the human race. Some critics link this change with the tragic events of his later life, the failure of his investments, his fatiguing travels and lectures in order to pay off his debts, and added to this, the death of his wife and two daughters which left him absolutely inconsolable. There is certainly a good deal of truth in this, though the basic reason is to be sought in the darkening social life, as in the case of William Dean Howells.

Although Howells, James, and Twain all worked for realism, there were obvious differences between them. In thematic terms, for instance, James wrote mostly of the upper reaches of American society, and Howells concerned himself chiefly with middle class life, whereas Mark Twain dealt largely with the lower strata of society. "I have never tried in even one single little instance," he wrote in one of his letters, "to help cultivate the cultivated classes. I was not equipped for it, either by native gifts or training, and I never had any ambition in that direction, but always hunted for bigger game ?the masses." He proposed to entertain them with his

prodigious humor. Technically, Howells wrote in the vein of genteel realism, James pursued an "imaginative" treatment of reality or psychological realism, but Mark Twain's contribution to the development of realism and to American literature as a whole was partly through his theories of localism in American fiction, and partly through his colloquial style which we shall discuss in detail in connection with *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*.

Mark Twain preferred to represent social life through portraits of local places which he knew best. Indeed, he started off as a teller of tall tales and local colorist. He felt that a novelist must not try to generalize about a nation. "No," he says, "[The novelist] lays before you the ways and speech and life of a few people grouped in a certain place ?his own place ?and that is one book. In time, he and his brethren will report to you the life and the people of the whole nation." He goes on to state that "When a thousand able novels have been written, there you have the soul of the people, the life of the people, the speech of the people, and not anywhere else can these be had." Here he clearly defined the place and function of local colorism, and foresaw the coming in sections of the "great American novel" to which he did his best to contribute his share.

Mark Twain drew heavily from his own rich fund of knowledge of people and places. He confined himself to the life with which he was familiar, convinced, as he states in a letter of 1890, that "the most valuable capital, or culture or education usable in the building of novels is personal experience." And certainly he was at his best when, in the words of Everett Carter, transmuting the ore of his personal experience into "the gold of reminiscence, autobiography and autobiographical fiction." In a way Mark Twain was his own biographer, and the central drama of his mature literary life was his discovery of his "usable past" which took him the rest of his life to transform imaginatively into literature. His usable past was mostly related to the Mississippi and the West which incidentally became his major theme. Life on the Mississippi was such a truthful description that Howells felt that he could taste "the mud" in it; Tom Sawyer walked out of Twain's pages directly from his fresh memory of his boyhood in the West. By quoting from his own experience, Mark Twain managed to transform into art the freedom and humor, in short, the finest elements of western culture.

The best work that Mark Twain ever produced is, as we noted earlier on, *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*. The writing of the book was evidently not easy for him, for he wrote some of it, then put it away and worked on other things, then later wrote some more of it ?he kept this up for a number of years. Commenting on the writing of the book, Sherwood Anderson observes that here for once, the real Mark Twain became again "the half savage, tender, god-worshipping, believing boy" that he had once been. "I believe he wrote that book in a little hut on a hill on his farm," Anderson said, imaginatively. "It poured out of him. I fancy that at night he came down from his hill stepping like a king ?a splendid playboy, playing with rivers and men, ending on the Mississippi, on the broad river that is the great artery flowing out of the heart of the land." The book was a success from its first publication in 1884 and has always been regarded as one of the great books of Western literature and Western civilization.

The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn tells a story about the United States before the Civil War, around 1850, when the great Mississippi Valley was still being settled. Here lies an America, with its great national faults, full of violence and even cruelty, yet still retaining the virtues of "some simplicity, some innocence, some peace." Here is a "hymn" to that ante bellum America, the moral values of which vanished with the war. The machine and the worship of money were on their way in, but the river-god, with its "sunlight, space, uncrowded time, stillness, and danger,"

had not been forgotten.

The story takes place along the Mississippi River, on both sides of which there was unpopulated wilderness and a dense forest. Along this river floats a small raft, with two people on it: One is an ignorant, uneducated Black slave named Jim and the other is a little uneducated outcast white boy of about the age of thirteen, called Huckleberry Finn, or Huck Finn. The book relates the story of the escape of Jim from slavery and, more important, how Huck Finn, floating along with him and helping him as best he could, changes his mind, his prejudice about Black people, and comes to accept Jim as a man and as a close friend as well. Now Huck Finn comes from the very lowest level of society. His father is the poor town drunkard who would willingly commit any crime just for the pure pleasure of it. Huck Finn is an outcast, with no mother, no home, sleeping in barrels, eating scraps and leavings, and dressed in rags. All of his virtues come from his good heart and his sense of humanity, for most of the things he was taught turned out to be wrong; for example, he was taught that slavery was good and right, and that runaway slaves should be reported, so what Huck has got to do is to cut through social prejudices and social discriminations to find truth for himself. Huck starts by believing that Blacks are by nature lower than whites ?inferior animals of sorts in fact. A good illustration is the conversation between him and Aunt Sally after the explosion on the river. Aunt Sally is asking whether anybody has been hurt. "No'm. Killed a nigger" is Huck's reply. And much of the book is concerned with Huck's inner struggle between this attitude (hence his sense of guilt in helping Jim to escape) and his profound conviction that Jim is a human being ?one of the best, in point of fact, that he has ever known. At first he cannot see Jim as a proper human being, and less as his equal. Through their escape down the river, he gets to know Jim better and becomes more and more convinced that he is not only a man, but also a good man. Thus he ends up by accepting him not merely as a human being but also as a loyal friend.

Huck Finn is a veritable recreation of living models. Huck, his father, Jim, the swindlers (the Duke and the Dauphin), Colonel Sherburn and the drunkard Boggs ?all these characters had prototypes in real life. The portrayal of individual incidents and characters achieved intense verisimilitude of detail. Serious problems are being discussed through the narration of a little illiterate boy. The fact of the wilderness juxtaposed with civilization, the people half wild and half civilized, many of whom are coarse, vulgar, and brutal, such as the loafers of the town of Brickville, amusing themselves by torturing animals ?pouring kerosene on dogs and setting them on fire, democratic citizens quickly changed into violent mobs, ready to take the law into their own hands and lynch people, or to seize people and pour hot tar over them and ride them out of town on a rail, and the fact of brutal slavery and of human beings ?the Blacks ?being sold in the market places like animals, the Shepherdson-Grangerford feud shown in all its senseless, sickening perversion of a code of "honor," the poignant portrayal of swindlers which was a common sight in the South then ?all these and many other incidents are depicted in true-to-life detail as the background against which Huck Finn's awareness of good and evil develops. Though a local and particular book, it touches upon the human situation in a general indeed "universal" way: Humanism ultimately triumphs.

Another feature of the book which helps to make it famous is its language. The book is written in the colloquial style, in the general standard speech of uneducated Americans. Mark Twain's introductory note on accents is an indication of his conscious attempt to achieve accurate detail. "In this book," he says, "a number of dialects are used, to wit: the Missouri negro dialect;

the extremest forms of the backwoods Southwestern dialect; the ordinary 'Pike County' dialect; and four modified varieties of this last. The shadings have not been done in a haphazard fashion, or by guesswork; but painstakingly, and with the trustworthy guidance and support of personal familiarity with these several forms of speech." "Painstaking" and "not haphazard," though they possess a humorous ring, denote the conscientious effort on the part of the author, and "trustworthiness" and "familiarity" and the author's awareness of dialects in use reveal his attempt to reproduce actual daily speech with a degree of accuracy. We may quote a passage from this masterpiece of nineteenth-century realism to serve as an illustration:

"I took the sack of corn meal and took it to where the canoe was hid, and shoved the vines and branches apart and put it in; then I done the same with the side of bacon; then the whisky-jug. I took all the coffee and sugar there was, and all the ammuniton; I took the wadding; I took the bucket and gourd; took a dipper and a tin cup, and my old saw and two blankets, and the skillet and the coffee-pot. I took fish lines and matches and other things ?everything that was worth a cent. I cleaned out the place. I wanted an ax, but there wasn't any, only the one out at the woodpile, and I knowed why I was going to leave that. I fetched out the gun, and now I was done."

The words used here are, except perhaps "ammuniton" which is etymologically French, mostly Anglo-Saxon in origin, and are short, concrete and direct in effect. Sentence structures are most of them simple or compound, with a series of "thens" and "ands" and semi-colons serving as connectives. The repetition of the word "took" and the stringing together of things leave the impression that Mark Twain depended solely on the concrete object and action for the body and movement of his prose. What is more, there is an ungrammatical element which gives the final finish to his style. The whole book approximates the actual speech habit of an uneducated boy from the American South of the mid-nineteenth century.

One of Mark Twain's significant contributions to American literature lies in the fact that he made colloquial speech an accepted, respectable literary medium in the literary history of the country. The style has impacted American literature and made books before Huck Finn and after it quite different. Its influence is clearly visible in twentieth-century American literature. It is continued in both prose and poetry. **Sherwood Anderson took his cue from Mark Twain and became, as Richard Bridgman puts it, about the first writer after Twain to take the vernacular as a serious way of presenting reality.** Anderson was for a while Hemingway's mentor in the colloquial style. Ernest Hemingway was the direct descendant of Mark Twain. His masculine prose, with its infinite power of suggestion and connotation, is the continuation of and improvement upon Twain's style. Among the number of American authors who acknowledged their indebtedness to Mark Twain are T. S. Eliot who noted that Twain established a new way of writing valid not only for himself but for others as well, and **William Faulkner when he declared, "In my opinion, Mark Twain was the first truly American writer, and all of us since are his heirs, who descended from him."** And if we survey the contemporary literary scene we will easily find authors like J. D. Salinger (in his *The Catcher in the Rye*) obviously following Mark Twain's tradition. In modern and recent poetry there is a conversational element clearly observable as is revealed in the works of E. A. Robinson, Robert Frost, Carl Sandburg, William Carlos Williams, E. E. Cummings, and even in T. S. Eliot and Ezra Pound. The importance of the style in American literature cannot be overrated.

And now we come to Mark Twain the social critic. For some reason or other, Mark Twain the great humorist seems to have overshadowed Mark Twain the social critic, so that the

importance of his social criticism has tended to be overlooked. All his life Mark Twain loved life and people, and freedom and justice, felt a pride in human dignity and advocated brotherhood of man. He hated tyranny and iniquity, despised meanness and cruelty, and took his role as a social critic in a serious and responsible manner. "From the beginning, [Mark Twain] took the side of the defenseless or oppressed, and fought corruption, privilege and abuse wherever he found them with a fierce humor." His writings, novels, letters, notebooks and pamphlets, and all included, touch upon almost every issue of his time such as politics, religion, capital and labor, slavery, U.S. imperialism abroad, and the persecution of the Chinese and the Jews. His earlier works reveal his frontier sense of self-reliance, fair play, equality, and early hopefulness, though an element of rascality and violence is already disturbingly noticeable in the background. When *Innocents Abroad* came out in 1869 it was apparent that the satirizing edge of his humor began to exhibit its vehemence. It lashed at the pretensions of the American elite (chiefly the New England Brahmins) who saw more in European ruins and tradition than common sense and humanitarian stance could justify. *Roughing It* that appeared in 1872 offered a carefree picture of the silver fever and the rush to Nevada to stake claims. The Gilded Age made legislative corruption, industrial free-enterprise, and speculation the butt of his biting satire, and one of its characters, Colonel Sellers, has become memorable as the gullible man of hope. In some of his works such as *Pudd'nhead Wilson* and *Huck Finn*, Mark Twain made his stance on anti-slavery and anti-lynching unequivocally clear; and in others like *The Prince and the Pauper* (1882) and *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court*, he cuttingly satirized monarchy, feudal caste, and inhumanity, as sanctioned by the politically-established church, and he angered the British by saying that monarchy could only be reformed by bloodshed. In these books democracy is, by contrast, exalted along with humanitarianism and progress which was assured by science. *American Claimant* (1892) deals with an English earl (in disguise) disillusioned by finding that, in the United States, the social Darwinian "struggle for existence" undermined the American professed equality and humanitarianism. After a brief acceptance of imperialism (in India, in *Following the Equator*), Mark Twain became an ardent critic of U. S. imperialism in the Spanish-American War, in the Philippines, South Africa, and China. His writings and statements on the subject were both fierce and bitter.

Mark Twain was a friend of the Chinese. He was not indifferent either to the Chinese immigrants persecuted in America or to a China suffering intense agonies of humiliation and dismemberment by imperialist powers. It is true that Mark Twain's attitude toward the Chinese developed gradually, but both the treatment of the Chinese immigrants and the imperialistic activities of the United States in China clashed with his ideals of democracy and equality and outraged his sense of justice. His "Disgraceful Persecution of a Boy" is a scathing piece of criticism directed against the persecution of the Chinese immigrants in California. "Goldsmith's Friend Abroad Again," in the form of the letters from Ah Song Hi, a Chinese emigrant to the United States, to his friend in China, Ching Foo, describes vividly the disillusionment and despair of the emigrant in a land of hostility and discrimination. Mark Twain stated in his introductory note that, though the letters were imaginary, their contents were based on reality. Mark Twain stood on the side of China in its struggle against foreign invasions. His "The Treaty with China" and "To the Person Sitting in Darkness" are two notable examples of his vigorous attacks on the imperialist behavior of the United States and other foreign countries in China. On August 12, 1900, a day before the international troops entered Peking, Mark Twain wrote, "It is all China now, and

my sympathies are with the Chinese. They have been villainously dealt with by the sceptered thieves of Europe, and I hope they will drive all foreigners out and keep them out for good."

Commenting on Mark Twain as a social critic, Philip Foner observes that Twain's social criticism ranks with that of Milton, Swift, Defoe, and Bernard Shaw both in literary quality and influence on public opinion, and that it is an important part of Twain's bequest. It is only right that Mark Twain should be remembered both as a great literary artist and a great social critic in the history of the United States.

CHAPTER 10 American Naturalism Crane Norris Dreiser Robinson

American Romanticism

The post-bellum decades witnessed the emergence of "Modern America." Industrialism and science and the new philosophy of life based upon science were among the important factors which helped to create the economic, social, and cultural transformations of the country. Industrialism produced financial giants, but at the same time created an industrial proletariat entirely at the mercy of external forces beyond their control. Slums appeared in great numbers where conditions became steadily worse, and the city poor lived a life of insecurity, suffering, and violence. One of the worst slum areas was the New York Bowery which Stephen Crane wrote about in some of his stories. The westward expansion continued to push the frontier nearer the Pacific coast, and the settlers found themselves subject to the ruthless manipulation of forces including the railroad, which charged heavy freight rates and drove farmers to bankruptcy, as can be seen in Frank Norris' wheat novels. Howells' "happy continent" became now "odious" to this once smiling American.

New ideas about man and man's place in the universe began to take root in America. Living in a cold, indifferent, and essentially Godless world, man was no longer free in any sense of the word. He was completely thrown upon himself for survival. The world in which God was still good and warm and caring enough to redress the wrong of Hawthorne's condemned wizard was gone not to return, and the comfortable belief that man could hope to fall back on divine help and guidance was exploded and irretrievably lost. Life became a struggle for survival. The Darwinian concepts like "the survival of the fittest" and "the human beast" became popular catchwords and standards of moral reference in an amoral world. Darwin's ideas of evolution and especially those of Herbert Spencer and his vogue in America helped to change the outlook of many rising authors and intellectuals, and produced an attitude of gloom and despair which characterize American literature of this period.

The literary climate of the country was also changing. To some young writers just emerging, Howellsian realism was now too restrained and genteel in tone to tell the truth of the harsher realities of American life. Both Howells and Mark Twain had written their best work and, especially in the case of the former, had said what he had to say. Apparently they were too old and too set in their ways to re-orient themselves in the new period. In the nineties, French naturalism, with its new techniques and new ways of writing, appealed to the imagination of the younger generation like Crane, Norris, and Theodore Dreiser. They tore the mask of gentility to pieces and wrote about the helplessness of man, his insignificance in a cold world, and his lack of dignity in face of the crushing forces of environment and heredity. They reported truthfully and objectively, with a passion for scientific accuracy and an overwhelming accumulation of factual detail. They painted life as it was lived in the slums, and were accused of telling just the hideous side of it and making a god of the dull commonplace. Also, American naturalism received an impetus from

other foreign influences like Tolstoi and Turgenev.

A casual look at the major works of Crane, Norris, and Dreiser reveals a bitter and wretched world where human beings such as Maggie, McTeague, and Sister Carrie battle hopelessly against overwhelming odds in a cold, harsh, and at best apathetic environment, driven as "a wisp of wind," with their lives very much determined by forces they have no means whatever of manipulating. The whole picture is somber and dark; and the general tone one of hopelessness and even despair. However, the reader also finds humanistic values in these naturalistic works, as is noted by critics such as Donald Pizer, Everett Carter, and R. W. Horton. Here is a desire to assert one's human identity, to define oneself against the social and natural forces one confronts. "Though gloomy, pessimistic, and often bitter," Horton states while commenting on American literary naturalism, "American naturalists could not accept the deterministic attitude of the complete helplessness of man and the view of an amoral and predatory universe and adopt a thoroughgoing scientific attitude in the portrayal of the American scene." Here lies, Horton feels, the strength and influence of writers like Crane and Dreiser in modern twentieth-century literature. It is good to take note of this feature of American literary naturalism in the study of its writings.

Stephen Crane (1871-1900)

Stephen Crane was born into a New Jersey Methodist clergyman's family. He attended a military prep school, Lafayette College, and Syracuse University where he stayed for less than a year. Then he moved into New York to earn his living as a free-lance journalist. First-hand knowledge of New York slum areas furnished him with material for his *Maggie: A Girl of the Streets* (1893). *The first uncompromising naturalistic novel in America*, *Maggie* painted an unabashed picture of the bitter life of the slum-dwellers, and was therefore rejected by all editors and publishers. In 1895 Crane published his first book of poems, *The Black Riders*, and his novel, *The Red Badge of Courage*, which won the admiration of such writers as William Dean Howells, Joseph Conrad and Henry James, and brought him into prominence. His experience as a correspondent in Cuba and his shipwreck on the way there provided the background for his most famous short story, "The Open Boat." As his marriage to a lady who had run a sporting house in Florida outraged many of his countrymen, he went to settle down in England, where he enjoyed the company of Conrad and James. He died of tuberculosis in Germany at the age of 28.

Crane was a pioneer writing in the naturalistic tradition. As critics have noted, his writings gave the whole esthetic movement of the nineties "a sudden direction and a fresh impulse." *Maggie* is a naked representation of slum life in Howell's once "happy" land, and *The Red Badge of Courage* one of the greatest war novels. Crane was also a pioneer in the field of modern poetry. His early poems, brief, quotable, with their unrhymed, unorthodox conciseness, and impressionistic imagery, were to exert a significant influence on modern poetry: As a matter of fact, he is now recognized as one of the two precursors of Imagist poetry, the other being Emily Dickinson.

Writing to Hamlin Garland to whom he sent a gift copy of *Maggie*, Crane observed that "it [Maggie] tries to show that environment is a tremendous thing in the world and frequently shapes lives regardless." Crane's fictional world is a naturalistic one in which man is deprived of free will and expects no help from any quarter whatever. It is a world in which "God is cold" as is adumbrated vividly in some of his poems. "A Man Said to the Universe" is revealing enough: "A Man said to the universe: / 'Sir, I exist!' / 'However,' replied the universe, / 'The fact has not created in me / A sense of obligation.'" So is "A Man Adrift on a Slim Spar," where there are lines

like the following:

The puff of a coat imprisoning:
A face kissing the water-death
A weary slow sway of a lost hand
And the sea, the moving sea, the sea.
God is cold.

The universe does not care about man, who is submerged by forces like environment and heredity. Such is the world in which Maggie finds herself.

Maggie: A Girl of the Streets relates the story of a good woman's downfall and destruction in a slum environment. Maggie grows up in a typical naturalistic home background where mere existence became a battle and where men behave like animals. Maggie is not resigned to her fate. She has her own aspirations and craves for self-fulfillment. When old enough, she goes to work in a factory where the conditions of life turn human beings into machines. Her home proves also suffocating so that Maggie tries to leave her beastly mother and brother. She places hope and trust in Pete who, himself a product of the hopeless slum, fails to come to her rescue after he has seduced her. In despair she is forced to walk the streets and eventually to plunge herself into the river. Maggie has been a rose in a mud-puddle. All her short life she has been struggling to escape her mud-puddle prison but all in vain. As Crane says, environment is a "tremendous" thing for an insignificant human being to battle against.

The Red Badge of Courage is a story set in the period of the Civil War. The basic theme of the animal man in a cold, manipulating world runs through the whole book. Here Crane is looking into man's primitive emotions and trying to tell the elemental truth about human life. A boy-soldier is enlisted and dispatched with his untried regiment to the front. In face of danger he is imperceptibly seized with panic. He finds himself asking the question, "Will I run from a battle?" And he does run away. War is seen as a force moving men ruthlessly and blindly as if they were pawns on a chess-board. The young soldier is moved about as if in a box with no free will, serving as an instrument of blind fate. (And men fighting are so many helpless animals.) Crane's debunking of war has a singularly modern touch about it. Against the romantic view of war as a symbol of courage and heroism, Crane talks about war in alarming honesty. War in The Red Badge is a plain slaughter-house. There is nothing like valor or heroism on the battlefield, and if there is anything, it is fear of death, cowardice, the natural instinct of man to run from danger. The corpses of the dead are seen without its traditional sheen of glory but quite literally rotting where they are left. By thus de-romanticizing war and heroism, Crane initiated the modern tradition of telling the truth at all costs about the elemental human situation, and writing about war as a real human experience. Now this was an event of a revolutionary nature both in theme and technique, one which was bound to produce a far-reaching influence on later writers: Hemingway, Dos Passes, and, in recent history, Norman Mailer, Kurt Vonnegut, Joseph Heller, and Thomas Pynchon are but a few names which come to our mind. It is no exaggeration to state that Crane anticipated the chief phenomena of American literature in the first few decades of the present century. Crane's best short stories include "Open Boat," "The Blue Hotel," and "An Experiment in Misery," all reinforcing the basic Crane motif of environment and heredity overwhelming man.

Frank Norris (1870-1902)

Frank Norris was born in Chicago and lived there until 1884 when the family moved to San Francisco. He studied art briefly in Paris, and entered the University of California at Berkeley in

1890. During a year at Harvard (1894-1895) he began to write novels, one of which was *McTeague*, an interesting novel very much like a textbook for naturalistic fiction. Before his death (from peritonitis) he was writing a trilogy on the production, distribution, and consumption of wheat, the first of which, *The Octopus* (1901) is Norris' best work. It is a long and complex book based upon an actual clash in 1880 between farmers in the San Joaquin valley and the South Pacific Railroad, the octopus of the title. The second of the trilogy, *The Pit*, which appeared posthumously in 1903, concentrates on the distribution of wheat; the third book was never written. Norris' essays of literary criticism have been collected in *The Responsibilities of the Novelist* (1903). Representing a sharp break with the genteel tradition in American literature, Norris exercised a general influence on the writers of the 1920s and 1930s such as William Faulkner and John Steinbeck.

McTeague has been called "the first full-bodied naturalistic American novel" and "a consciously naturalistic manifesto." It is a classic case study of the inevitable effect of environment and heredity on human lives. *McTeague* is a fine specimen of the "human beast," with his primitive, atavistic behavior, and wild desires. Under the pressure of an adverse environment, the elemental forces of his wild birthplace and the hereditary elements of his alcoholic father work havoc with his civilized life and combine to dehumanize his person. The "beast" in him gets the upper hand and drove him to evil and violence. *McTeague's* tragedy lies in the fact that he cannot shake himself free of the brutalizing influences destined to destroy him as a man. He must, under their impact, become an alcoholic like his father before him and must return to the state of primitivism and elementalism to which he was conditioned at birth. The story of this violent, murderous human brute outraged the genteel taste of many people including Howells who felt that "it is a little inhuman," so that it did not get published until four years after it was first written. It added strength to the naturalistic endeavor beginning to make its impact felt in the country. Dreiser saw it as a somber and yet true presentation of reality as had been "conceived by any writer in any land."

In *The Octopus* Norris is, as Lars Ahnebrink sees it, predominantly a social determinist, illustrating how social and economic conditions ruined the lives of innocent, powerless people. The railroad reaches out its millions of tentacles, coiling round the throats of the farmers who have no alternative but to choose between leaving their crops to rot and carting them out through the railroad at a capriciously exorbitant freight rate, in either case ending up in bankruptcy and destruction; and what is worse, the railroad raises the price of the land, which it has rented for the people so that all the farmers and the poor in general face stark destitution and ruin. A typical case is Dyke. He has been a good engine driver but is forced to raise hop in hard times. To finance the project he mortgages his crop and homestead. He envisions a bumper harvest and has sanguine hopes for the future. He works hard and is rewarded with a good crop. Now the railway, with which he has agreed upon the freight, raises it to a rate which would ruin him altogether. And it does ruin him. His life is thus thoroughly wrecked. Dyke has had energy, industry and foresight, but he is no match for the insatiable social monster. Thereafter he follows the archetypal naturalistic process of degradation which leads from drunkenness to highway robbery to life imprisonment. The disintegration of the man is then complete. Nor is he the only victim. A whole group of the farmers of the San Joaquin valley collapse with him. Some meet an untimely death like Annixter, Harran Derrick, Hooven, Osterman and Broderson. Others are demented like Magnus Derrick. All are crushed under the wheels of the railroad. However, Norris did not seem

to blame the railroad officials for the tragedies; conditions, natural forces, not men, were responsible for what happened. The head of the railroad, Shelgrim, puts it most clearly when he says to Presley, "You are dealing with forces, young man, when you speak of wheat and the railroads, not with men. There is the wheat, the supply. It must be carried to feed the people. There is the demand. The wheat is one force, the railroad, another, and there is the law that governs them ?supply and demand. Men have only little to do in the whole business." The laws of nature could ruin an insignificant farmer as well as a financial superman. Jadwin's defeat (in *The Pit*) is a fitting illustration. Having challenged the laws of nature, he meets a ruin no less cruel than that of others. Norris' determinist view is nowhere more apparent.

Frank Norris is not much read now, but his influence is visible. It is true that there are lapses and occasional failure to control his materials, but their richness and exuberance do make Norris appealing. His vibrant and fresh imagery, his ability to etch situations indelibly on the readers' mind, his poetic mode of fiction, as in the choice of words for their precise and exact effect and even his mysticism, were all part of the literary legacy of the period under discussion.

Theodore Dreiser (1871-1945)

Dreiser was born in Indiana, the ninth child of German-speaking parents. His childhood was spent in extreme poverty. After some months at Indiana University, he became a reporter on the *Chicago Globe* and worked in St. Louis and Pittsburg before arriving in New York in 1894. His first novel, *Sister Carrie*, was rejected because of its relentless honesty in presenting the true nature of American life. The young author felt so depressed by "a decade's delay" ?in the words of Larzer Ziff ?in social recognition that he was said to have walked by the East River at the turn of the century, seriously contemplating suicide. He faced every form of attack that a serious artist could encounter, misunderstanding, misrepresentation, artistic isolation, and commercial seduction. But he endured all and held out long, and survived to lead the rebellion of the 1920s. *Sister Carrie* came out in 1900, followed by *Jennie Gerhardt* (1911) and two volumes of his Cowperwood trilogy, *The Financier* (1912) and *The Titan* (1914), the third, *The Stoic*, being published posthumously. His other works include *The Genius* (1915), an autobiographical work, *An American Tragedy* (1925), and *The Bulwark* (1946).

Dreiser was left-oriented in his views. He visited Russia and wrote *Dreiser Looks at Russia* (1928) and *Tragic America* (1931) to express his new faith. He retained a strong sympathy for communism and, shortly before his death, joined the Communist Party. Dreiser has been a controversial figure in American literary history. His works are powerful in their portrayal of the changing American life, but his style is considered crude. He showed a new way of presenting reality and inspired the writers of the 1920s with courage and insight. The revival of naturalism in the 1930s enthroned Dreiser as the guide and pioneer for the latter-day naturalists such as James T. Farrell, John O'Hara, and John Dos Passes, for it is in Dreiser's works that American naturalism is said to have come of age.

Dreiser was widely read in literature. Balzac, Zola, Mark Twain and his contemporaries, Jack London, and Frank Norris, were all on his reading list. By far the greatest influence which had a determining effect on his outlook came from Herbert Spencer whose works he read with avidity after 1897. He embraced social Darwinism. He learned to regard man as merely an animal driven by greed and lust in a struggle for existence in which only the "fittest," the most ruthless, survive. Man is, to him, only a "mechanism" reacting to "chemic compulsions," and human tragedy comes as a result of the collision between man's biological needs and society's ruthless

manipulation. Life is predatory, a "game" of the lecherous and heartless, a jungle struggle in which man, being "a waif and an interloper in Nature," "a wisp in the wind of social forces," is a mere pawn in the general scheme of things, with no power whatever to assert his will. No one is ethically free; everything is determined by a complex of internal chemisms and by the forces of social pressure. Dreiser was scathingly critical of his own country: "The moral and social codes of his America misrepresent the truth of human nature, and so does conventional fiction." It is Dreiser's announced intention to report "the coarse and the vulgar and the cruel and the terrible" in life in defiance of the genteel and evasive current literature with which he had absolutely no patience and sympathy. Nevertheless, Dreiser had a warm heart. His sympathies were always with the oppressed and the weak. Even his famous determinism is essentially sentimental at root. As Charles Walcott observes, Dreiser's writings reveal a tremendous vital lust for life with a conviction that man is the end and measure of all things in a world which is devoid of purpose and standards.

The amorality of Dreiser's world is best illustrated at the beginning of *The Financier*. Here is young Frank Cowperwood standing before the fish market's tank and watching the life and death struggle between a squid and a lobster ending on the side of the stronger. For Cowperwood this represents the sum total of the world's amorality. "Might is right," and the powerful and the ruthless alone survive. This is a Godless world in which man is thrown upon himself to keep alive as best he can against the overwhelming odds of the cold, indifferent environment. It is in such an amoral world that Carrie Meeber finds herself.

On *Sister Carrie* Dreiser wrote, "It is not intended as a piece of literary craftsmanship, but as a picture of conditions done as simply and effectively as the English language will permit." A country girl, Sister Carrie, comes to Chicago to look for a better life. She first stays with her sister whose working-class home is, however, too poor to keep her. Winter is coming and she is seriously ill. A traveling salesman, Druet by name, comes to her rescue and takes her home as his mistress. Sister Carrie's beauty appeals to Druet's friend, Hurstwood, so that the respectable manager deserts his comfortable home and family and forces her to elope with him. They run first to Canada and then settle down in New York. For some time they experience dire poverty. Sister Carrie goes out to find work on the stage, but Hurstwood proves himself to be utterly unfit to survive. He can not find work, and begs for and receives some occasional support from Sister Carrie. His downfall is complete when he commits suicide one cold winter night. Sister Carrie manages to move up in her career, and Druet comes back to renew some connection with her, only to be rebuffed and leave rejected. At the end of the book Sister Carrie is seen sitting in her rocking-chair, still rocking.

With a painstaking documentation of detail, Dreiser portrays three different worlds in which Sister Carrie moves and which between them offer a panoramic view of the crude and the savage aspects of social life at the turn of the twentieth century: these include her sister's working-class existence, her life with Druet in Chicago, and with Hurstwood in New York. Every detail is related with an amazing dispassionate exactitude and so assumes a sense of importance. Clothes, furniture, how much one owes the grocer, and exactly how much one earns and spends, the contents of a meal—all these indicate the plight of the heroine and her desire for a better life. The world is cold and harsh to her. Alone and helpless, she moves along like a mechanism driven by desire and catches blindly at any opportunities for a better existence, opportunities as offered first by Druet and then by Hurstwood. A feather in the wind, she is totally at the mercy of forces she cannot

comprehend, still less to say control. She does not seem to possess what may be called a moral fiber in her.

Then there is the tragedy of Hurstwood. Here Spencer's influence is seen at its most powerful. Hurstwood cannot help himself in his relationship with Sister Carrie. No respectable job, no handsome income, no "genteel" family, nothing could overcome his biological need and stop him from returning to savage, atavistic unreason. Dreiser's portrait is an authentic one of the impotent modern man unfit to survive. "His innate instincts dulled by too near an approach to free will, his free will not sufficiently developed to replace his instincts and afford him perfect guidance," he thus hovers between being a man and a beast in his behavior. He must die. And die he does.

Dreiser's style has been a point of heated discussion. The consensus that has been reached so far seems to be that, although Dreiser's novels are formless at times and awkwardly written, and his characterization is found deficient and his prose pedestrian and dull, yet his very energy proves to be more than a compensation. Dreiser's stories are always solid and intensely interesting with their simple but highly moving characters. Dreiser is good at employing the journalistic method of reiteration to burn a central impression into the readers' mind. His interest in painting is reflected in his taste for word-pictures, sharp contrast, truth in color, and movement in outline. Here lies the power and permanence that have made Dreiser one of America's foremost novelists.

Other Authors of the Period

Before we move into the 1920s, the decade in which modern American literature is said to begin, there are a few other writers whom we mention briefly only because of space constraint. They were once giants of some national stature in their own day and have since taken their places as minor gods in the American literary pantheon.

We begin with Edwin Arlington Robinson (1860-1935) who started writing poetry in the closing years of the nineteenth century. He achieved recognition in the first decade of the twentieth century and was generally regarded as America's greatest living poet in the 1920s. Robinson's world is naturalistic in nature. Here God is no longer caring, men suffer from frustrations and want of mutual understanding, and life is in general futile and meaningless. These reveal Robinson as a modern poet, capable of a tragic vision in step with the modern spirit, trying to suggest a despairing courage to seek out the meaning of life. Robinson's poems, "Man Against the Sky," "Richard Cory," "Miniver Cheevy" and "Flammonde" are all memorable pieces. Take "Richard Cory" for example. Richard Cory is a gentleman, rich and human and clean and graceful, the way he is dressed, walks downtown, speaks to people, "In fine, we thought that he was everything / To make us wish that we were in his place." But, all of a sudden, we here of his suicide: "And Richard Cory, one calm summer night, / Went home and put a bullet through his head." The poem does not tell the readers why Richard Cory dies the way he does: it is anybody's guess. The poem is thus also an illustration of Robinson's fascination with "psychological enigmas," enigmas that were the product of modern life.

Jack London (1876-1916) was a very popular author in the first years of the twentieth century. His rise to fame was in a way meteoric. He came from the bottom of society and, through hard work and study and sheer will power, made his way up to the summit of the social hierarchy. He read Marx, Charles Darwin, and Nietzsche, among others, and was well self-educated in natural law and determinism. He wrote in quick succession and sold well. But when he became a millionaire, he found fashionable society life empty and distasteful. He died, exhausted and in

despair. Among his best works are *The Call of the Wild*, at all-time bestseller, *White Fang*, *The Sea Wolf*, and his masterwork *Martin Eden*, which is somewhat autobiographical. *Martin Eden* is a sailor who works and reads hard so as to become rich and famous and break into polite society. He writes and is repeatedly rejected by publishers, but perseverance leads to final success. He reaches the top, only to find that his dream has not been worth realizing at all. In listlessness and despair, a death wish, the desire for total annihilation, gets hold of him. He drowns himself when out at sea. Taken as a whole, Jack London's works are a penetrating criticism of America of the time in which they were written.

O. Henry (pseudonym of William Sidney Porter, 1862-1910) was one of the most prolific writers in the history of American literature. A clever short-story writer, he actually began his career when serving a three-year prison term. There he learned about "gentle grafters" and noble-minded burglars. Later, in New York as he got to know life better and became sympathetic to the socially low, he wrote fascinating stories about them. O. Henry tended to repeat the motifs of his stories and fall into melodrama and sentimentality, but his best stories are free from all these and remain intensely readable today. "The Gift of the Magi" is one of these. This is an extremely moving story of a young couple who sell their best possessions — Delia her hair and Jim his grandfather's watch — in order to get money for a Christmas present for each other. The hair is cut and sold to buy a glorious watch fob, and the watch is sold to buy a beautiful comb, neither knowing that the present can no longer be of any use when offered to the loved one. The ending is heart-warming as the couple end up in a loving embrace. O. Henry's irony here is of a cosmic kind very much in the same vein as Maupassant's famous story "The Necklace." Here in their fictional world, some forces seem to be at work manipulating human desire and behavior. At his death O. Henry was regarded as a great master of the art of fiction.

It is not fair to say so little about a man who wrote so much. Upton Sinclair (1878-1968) wrote with incredible facility all his long life: his manuscripts came to weigh eight tons. At the turn of the twentieth century Sinclair, with his relentless criticism of American life, became an important part of the famous "Muckraking Movement," the aim of which was to expose corruption, chicanery, and evil existing in American social, economic, and political life. *The Jungle*, revealing as it does the inhumanity and total absence of hygiene in Chicago's Packingtown, made quite a stir both in America and outside. Sinclair's power as a literary artist is severely vitiated by the fact that he seldom rose above his customary polemical level.

Placed in proper historical perspective, the naturalistic enterprise of the 1890s was not, as some critics thought it was, "an aborted movement." It is true that writers like Crane, Norris and Dreiser had to take risks and were all of them rejected for some time by the genteel magazines and publishers. But they held out and, in so doing, cleared the way for the next generation, the "lost generation" of the 1920s. In theme they represented the life of the lower classes truthfully and broke into such forbidden regions as violence, death, and sex; in technique their works exhibit honest skills and artistry. Thus they prepared the way, as has been noted in modern and contemporary literary criticism, for the smooth acceptance of the younger writers like Hemingway and Faulkner.

CHAPTER 11 The 1920s Imagism Pound

If F. O. Matthiessen regards the "flowering of New England" in the first half of the nineteenth century as an "American Renaissance," then the decade of the 1920s, with a greater number of

great writers producing a voluminous amount of distinguished literary works, can be termed the second renaissance in the history of American literature. Just as Emerson and his contemporaries embodied in their writings the temper of their age, so the works of T. S. Eliot and Ernest Hemingway and their generation constituted an adequate expression of the spirit of their times.

The decade of the 1920s has been one of special interest in more ways than one. Sandwiched as it was between two events of great historic significance, the First World War and the Great Depression, it assumed a unique importance of its own. There were at least two important factors that made the decade different from the periods both preceding and following it: the First World War, and the sense of life being dislocated and fragmented which was more keenly felt in the first years of the twentieth century. First, the war was the biggest event that had a profound impact on the period. The people went into the war with an unusual amount of enthusiasm, inspired by the ideal of making the world safe for democracy. It proved, also, tremendously profitable; the United States made a great deal of money in the war and became, as a whole, a lot richer, so that there appeared an economic boom, a deceptive affluence, when the war was over. There was a feeling that there was money everywhere, and no one could or bothered to foresee the crash to befall the country in 1929. People became aware of a sudden jump in technology. All of a sudden automobiles and radios appeared, which helped to widen the horizon of the people and increase their knowledge. The movie revolution and the music, notably Jazz, now becoming available to everybody, enriched and impacted the way of popular thinking. The country became urban in these years; a new type of industrial economy developed. Mass production, mass consumption, and mass leisure became essential to economic and cultural life and were soon to dominate the nation's culture and institutions. The wind of vital change began to blow. A social revolution was going on. Old moral codes were breaking down. Old modes of perception were questioned. One important development related to what had hitherto been regarded as "the second sex." Now new women appeared on the scene, demanding the same social freedom as men enjoyed and affecting life significantly. Traditions regarding courtship and marriage, rearing of children, dress length, etc., everything that involved women, underwent a rapid, palpable change. New industries emerged to cater to their needs, such as cosmetics, and new institutions were established to appeal to their taste such as beauty contests. Whereas women were covered down to the ankles only a few years earlier, for example, girls now appeared on the scene in short skirts, wearing bobbed hair, smoking and drinking, and dancing wildly; they were "flappers" (as Fitzgerald calls them in one of his books) of the "Jazz Age." Conservative people blamed all this on the war, but the change had probably more to do with the urbanism that emerged in the wake of industrialism.

After the war there was a tremendous letdown because nothing had changed. The idealism that had spurred droves of young men into the war evaporated in face of its disastrous effects. The heroism, patriotism, and the zeal for democracy that the romantic notion of war had inspired now proved to be false and tasteless to a generation who had once had faith in them. Excitement and enthusiasm subsided to make way for disillusionment. The debunking of war that first began with Stephen Crane in his *The Red Badge of Courage* became the paradigm for the war novel in the decade of the 1920s. It was as if the party was over and an anti-climax of discontentment and restlessness and disgust followed, as well expressed in, say, Hemingway's *A Farewell to Arms* or Dos Passos' *U. S. A.*

On the social scene, there was a high degree of intolerance in American society as a whole.

All forms of radicalism and all assertion of social and religious rights other than those known as WASP (White Anglo-Saxon Protestant) values were treated with least tolerance. Pre-war socialist reform movements were ruthlessly suppressed during the war and in the "Red Hunt" after it, very much in the manner that McCarthy was to do following World War I. Minorities, African Americans and newer immigrant people were discriminated against. The Chicago Race Riot of the summer of 1919 resulted in destruction, death, hatred, and bigotry. The Ku Klux Klan redoubled its effort at racial persecution. In the meantime there was in the south an attempt to conserve the southern lifestyle and southern values which were in the main agrarian as against the industrial north. For some intellectually thinking people like William Faulkner, the American south, with its rise and fall, became the subject for scrutiny and evaluation. One more thing to note about the 1920s was that it was an era, also, of great popular contempt for the law. The Prohibition of alcohol outraged popular taste; bootleggers moved in to reap huge profits from illegal sales. At the same time there was a general feeling among many who were living through it, like Fitzgerald, that this was a sad period; the dream had failed, and the country was building up economic troubles all along and heading direct toward disaster.

Meanwhile, the loss of faith, which began noticeably with Darwin's theories of evolution and was intensified by the development of modern science, continued with greater intensity into the twentieth century. The German philosopher Nietzsche (1844-1900) had declared the death of God. By the end of the first decade of the twentieth century, all forces seemed to be pulling apart. There appeared a reality with no mythical center, with God expelled from the universe, a world of Crane, Norris, and Dreiser, of random forces, with nothing to mediate between man and his cosmos. Modern science destroyed man's ability to believe unquestioningly. Without faith man could no longer keep his feeling and thought whole; hence the sense of life being fragmented, chaotic, and disjunctive. And without faith man no longer felt secure and happy and hopeful in his world. Hence the feeling of gloom and despair. In short, people found themselves living in a spiritual wasteland, as T. S. Eliot's epochal poem suggests, where life was a meaningless and futile affair and man felt homeless, estranged, and haunted by a sense of doom.

One of the influential philosophers at the beginning of the 20th century, Bertrand Russell (1872-1970), was most eloquent commenting on the spirit of the period. In his "A Free Man's Worship," he observes to the effect that the universe had become purposeless and indifferent to human wishes. Man must not expect any help from a beneficent God. The idea of a world order that smiles on man's desires is an illusion. Man must recognize that he is of no importance in such a world, and he would do well to adapt himself to it on the basis of that recognition, however disturbing it may be. Nothing can preserve an individual life beyond the grave. Death will doom all human endeavors and achievements to ultimate extinction. All human effort is thus futile and leads only to despair. Man's life is brief and powerless, and the slow, sure doom will pitilessly fall on all his race. Russell advises man to believe in himself, to face life with "a despairing courage." This is the kind of courage with which Hemingway endowed his heroes.

The new, varied experience of the period demanded a new varied expression. Thinking minds in the field of art and literature began to feel that the old forms of representation were no longer adequate enough to represent reality and that newer ways must be found. Hence the ebullience widely felt among the younger generation for experimentation of various kinds. Europe was simmering with the innovative zeal. Paris emerged as the center of experimental art and literature to which ambitious, struggling artists and writers flocked. Impressionism appeared along

with Dadaism and Expressionism. Symbolism and surrealism became stylish and popular. While older writers such as William Butler Yeats, Edwin Arlington Robinson and Theodore Dreiser were still writing to keep step with the changing times, High Modernism began to dominate the world of literature and art. Modernist masters were busy at work, and works of permanent power and appeal came out in print in quick succession. James Joyce's *Ulysses*, Virginia Woolf's *Mrs. Dalloway* and *To the Lighthouse*, Thomas Mann's *The Magic Mountain*, and Marcel Proust's *Remembrance of Things Past* were out there to shine forth the splendor of the new era. In American literature a whole new generation of younger writers, "the Lost Generation," surfaced with their new voices. The most active, presiding spirit was probably Ezra Pound whose sense of urgency about revolutionizing literature led him from one movement to another, lending support to people who struggled to add to the newness of the era. By far the most seminal influence of the time was T. S. Eliot and his *The Waste Land*, the man soon becoming a leader figure of the generation and his epochal poem a watershed, "spawning" a whole group of "waste-land painters." These include, to offer just a short list, Hemingway, Fitzgerald and Faulkner in fiction, Cummings, Frost, Sandburg, and Hart Crane in poetry, and Eugene O'Neill, Elmer Rice and Susan Glaspell in drama. Although William Carlos Williams and Wallace Stevens differed from Eliot and Pound in some aspects, they were definitely part and parcel of the group working to represent the *Zeitgeist*, or spirit, of the time. There were also lesser lights to consider. Sherwood Anderson and Gertrude Stein both tried to come up with something unique and help others in need at the same time. Cather Willa, one old-timer at the threshold of a changing world, was creating major minor classics. Sinclair Lewis, though "Edwardian" in form, wrote to pave his way for the first Nobel Prize in literature that an American ever won. In the meantime the distant rumblings of a different thunderous voice were first heard in Harlem, New York City. Long pent-up emotional lava, stirred up by a new intellectual energy, now found an outlet and erupted into what has come to be known as the Harlem Renaissance. This outburst of African American creative energy was historically important not just because it marked the further awakening, literary as well as racial, of the African American people, but also because it heralded an era of multiethnic and multiracial literary expression in America that would eventually result in possible redefining of American literary history and re-canonizing of American literature.

Thus the 1920s was a peculiar period in which the postwar economic boom and the sense of spiritual disorientation combined to produce a peculiar mood of the age. The greatness of the literature of the decade lies in the fact that it managed to capture that mood and keep it on record for posterity. The few chapters that follow are designed to offer a sketchy account of the bustling American literary activity during this famous stretch of ten years.

The Coming of the Image

The new age demanded proper literary expression. Between 1912 and 1922 there came a great poetry boom in which about 1 000 poets published over 1 000 volumes of poetry. Indeed, to express the modern spirit, the sense of fragmentization and dislocation, was in large measure the aim of quite a few modern literary movements, of which Imagism was one. It came, it is true, as a reaction to the traditional English poetics with its iambic pentameter, its verbosity, and extra-poetic padding; but it served, first and foremost, to meet the need of expressing the temper of the age. Nobody propounded the point more convincingly than the first Imagist theorist, the English writer T. E. Hulme. Hulme suggests that modern art deals with expression and communication of momentary phases in the poet's mind. Poetic techniques, he goes on to state,

should become subtle enough to record exactly the momentary impressions. The key word here is "momentary." The most effective means to express these momentary impressions is through the use of one dominant image. "Each word must be an image seen." The image is a representation of a physical object, and the reader is made to react to it as such. "Each sentence should be a lump; a piece of clay, a vision seen." Hulme advises the poet to seek the hard, personal word for expression. These became the basic principles on which the movement was launched.

The Imagist poem was the invention of a small group of English and American poets who came together in the first years of this century to work out some new way of writing poetry. The movement underwent three phases in its brief yet immensely important history. It first began in London in the years 1908-1909. A young Englishman, T. E. Hulme, founded in 1908 a Poets' Club which met in Soho every Wednesday to dine and discuss poetry. The presiding spirit of the period was Hulme who theorized a lot on poetic technique, insisting on "absolutely accurate presentation and no verbiage." Ezra Pound was present at some of the meetings, though, according to the first historian of the movement, F. S. Flint, he did not contribute much except by talking about some Provencal poets. It seems that there was a lot of talking but not as much writing. Hulme died in the First World War.

The second phase of the movement was the period of some three years (1912-1914) when Ezra Pound took over and championed the new poetry. Something like an Imagist manifesto came out in 1912 in which Pound and Flint laid down three Imagist poetic principles: (1) Direct treatment of the "thing," whether subjective or objective; (2) To use absolutely no word that does not contribute to the presentation; and (3) As regarding rhythm, to compose in the sequence of the musical phrase, not in the sequence of a metronome. The first principle, with its emphasis on direct treatment, indicates a desire to make the expression resemble the "object" as closely as art can make it. By "direct," Pound means no fuss, frill, or ornament. The second stresses economy of expression, a reaction to the nineteenth-century tendency of philosophical "padding" of extra-poetic matter, or "emotional slither." To Ezra Pound any unnecessary word represents a loss of precision and a moral and artistic defection. The third concerns a breaking away from conventional prosody and the use of free verse, and the interrelationship between music and verse. Pound did not mean to sponsor "free verse" as the only verse form to use; he advocated freedom in verse. "Free Verse" means form, not formlessness. It is not "free"; as T. S. Eliot once said, "No vers is libre for the man who wants to do a good job." Neither was it new with the Imagists. Free verse went as far back as Milton. But it was with the Imagists that it became a legitimate poetic form. Free verse is a poetic mode closely allied to music; hence the third principle relates to verse form and music at the same time. In 1914, Pound edited the first anthology of Imagist poems, entitled *Des Imagistes*, which included poets such as Hilda Doolittle, Richard Aldington, F. S. Flint, Amy Lowell, William Carlos Williams, and Ezra Pound.

We shall be brief with the third phase of Imagism (1914-1917) when Amy Lowell took over from Pound and pushed the movement into the period of "Amygism," as Pound called it. Pound did not like the way this headstrong American woman manipulated the activity of the movement; nor was Amy Lowell pleased with Pound's authoritarianism within it. Pound left to devote his attention to new movements like "Vorticism," and the Imagist movement gradually lost its momentum. The most concise of the Imagists, H. D. (Hilda Doolittle), became wordier, and the six principles that Amy Lowell and other Imagists worked out were in essence an expansion and an adulteration of the first Imagist manifesto of 1912. In this period three anthologies came out

respectively in 1915, 1916, and 1917, edited by Amy Lowell, all entitled *Some Imagist Poets*. After 1917 Imagism ceased to be a movement.

What is the image as the Imagists saw it? Images exist in all poetry, but the image of the imagists has something new to offer. T. E. Hulme said that the image must enable one "to dwell and linger upon a point of excitement, to achieve the impossible and convert a point into a line." Pound defined an image as that which presents an intellectual and emotional complex in an instant of time, and later he extended this definition when he stated that an image was "a vortex or cluster of fused ideas" "endowed with energy." An Imagistic presentation is hard, clear, un-blurred, done by means of the chosen "exact word." And the exact word, according to Richard Aldington, another of the first Imagists, must bring the effect of the object before the reader as it had presented itself to the poet's mind at the time of writing. An Imagist poem enables the reader to see the physical thing rather than put him through an abstract process. Lucid logical exposition is no good poetry. The best poetic effect is visual and concrete. Thus an Imagist's image represents a moment of revealed truth, truth revealed by a physical object presented and seen as such. An Imagist poem, therefore, often contains a single dominant image, or a quick succession of related images. Its effect is meant to be instantaneous.

Let us look at some Imagist poems. "In a Station of the Metro," by Ezra Pound, has been regarded as a classic specimen of Imagist poetry:

The apparition of these faces in the crowd;
Petals on a wet, black bough.

Pound was once in a Paris subway station and was struck by the sight of the faces of a few pretty women and children in a crowd hurrying out of the dim, damp, and somber station. So impressed was he by the spectacle that he resolved to bring it out in poetic language. The result was, of course, the poem. "The object" to be treated is the faces in that dim and damp context. The impression is brought out most vividly by the single, dominant image of flower petals on a wet, black bough, which serves as the most concise, direct, and definite metaphor for the "faces in the crowd." Here is perhaps the place to put in a word about the influence of Chinese poetry on the Imagist movement and on Pound. The Imagist movement drew from a variety of poetic traditions. Greek, Provencal and Japanese poetry are among the many acknowledged sources of Imagism and Pound's poetry. The influence of ancient Chinese poetry is not the least of these. Eminent Imagist poets like Pound and Amy Lowell were well acquainted with Chinese poetry, and even Hulme was not indifferent to Chinese poetics. The reason that the Imagists found value in Chinese poetry was because Chinese poetry is, by virtue of the ideographic and pictographic nature of the Chinese language, essentially imagistic poetry. The Chinese language is concrete and direct and metaphorical, and Chinese poetry is noted for its virile laconism and austere pregnancy (which also characterize Imagist poetry). The history of Chinese writing conditioned Chinese literature to its conciseness and precision. To make fewer words do more work was the cherished aim of literary training in ancient China. Since images need fewer connectives and convey more, it is only natural that they are built into the very texture of classic Chinese poetry. They either juxtapose with, or superimpose or melt into each other, and often form clusters of fused ideas impregnated with power and energy. It is no wonder that both champions of Imagism, Ezra Pound and Amy Lowell, were infatuated with Chinese poems, notably poems by Li Po.

But to return to Imagist poetry. H. D.'s "Oread" is another classic example:

Whirl up, sea ?

Whirl your pointed pines,
splash your great pines
on our rocks
hurl your green over us,
cover us with your pools of fir.

This is Pound's favorite poem. Oread is a goddess in Greek mythology. The poem represents what the goddess of long ago felt about the turbulent sea, but this feeling evidently awakens the same response in the bosom of the poet. Thus the poem manages to generate a vague but vast sense of mystery and history. The "pools of fir" is the impressive dominant image of the whole poem, conjuring up as it does in the reader's mind a vivid picture of the billowing sea. It is good to note that H. D. wrote her poetry in such a conscientious manner that she first provided Ezra Pound with the inspiration for the new school of "Imagists." Some time in the latter part of 1912, H. D. brought five of her poems to Ezra Pound, who was so impressed by her clarity, her intensity, her "hardness" ?directness, and absolute economy of expression ?that he later even declared that Imagism had been founded in order to get her poems publicized.

William Carlos Williams' "The Red Wheelbarrow" is an oft-quoted and almost always anthologized piece, not only of Imagist poetry, but of modern American poetry in general:

So much depends
upon

a red wheel
barrow

glazed with rain
water

beside the white
chickens.

As Frederick J. Hoffman observes, "Here the material facts are reduced almost to the level of plain factual statement." Short as it is, the poem is rich in meaning and is capable of more than one interpretation. The consensus seems to be that the poem demonstrates that life is poetic, and that poetry inheres in the life around us. There is not much need to delve into books or seek the help of other cultures in order to write poetry. The life as it is lived offers material enough for any poetic endeavor. This falls incidentally well in line with Williams' poetic credo; we will come back to the point later on when discussing the poet.

In the history of American poetry, Imagism was only a transient phase of no longer than a decade. In 1908 it began. During 1912-1914 it gathered momentum and put out a manifesto with immense activity around Ezra Pound, and it continued, under Amy Lowell, to grow for a while until it tapered off after 1917. Its limitations are apparent. A single dominant image can supply energy for a two-line poem of Pound's or a 16-word one of Williams', but it is hardly capable of sustaining a longer poetic effort. Thus no great poetry came out of the movement. Its own aesthetics stunted its growth into something more ambitious and eternal. But the movement was important in a number of ways in the development of modern poetry. It was a rebellion against the traditional poetics which failed to reflect the new life of the new century. It offered a new way of

writing which was valid not only for the Imagist poets but for modern poetry as a whole. In fact, it is no exaggeration to state that the movement was a training school in which many great poets learned their first lessons in the poetic art. Almost all major modern poets were in one way or another associated with it and benefited from it in a significant way. Apart from Ezra Pound and William Carlos Williams, there are Wallace Stevens, T. S. Eliot, Carl Sandburg, and Marianne Moore, to mention just a few American names. Its literary theories and poetic forms have continued to exercise their influence on modern and contemporary poetry. **It is this movement that helped to open the first pages of modern English and American poetry.**

Ezra Pound (1885-1972)

The first two decades of the present century saw the birth of a sensitive, rebellious poetic spirit who was satisfied with little of the Victorian poetic bequest, with its extra-poetic values, "its frills and festoons of language." Ezra Pound was convinced that poetry was in a bad way. He felt keenly the need to revise the status of the arts and to redefine the artists' responsibilities. Confident in his belief that the artist was morally and culturally the arbiter and the "savior" of the race, he took it upon himself to purify the arts and became the prime mover of a few experimental movements, the aim of which was to dump the old into the dustbin and bring forth something new. Restless, dynamic, and with a brain whirling with ideas, Pound moved about in literary circles and discovered and spurred talents to action. He helped to revolutionize poetry.

Ezra Pound was born in 1885 in Hailey, Idaho, and brought up in Pennsylvania. He studied Romance languages at Hamilton College and the University of Pennsylvania where he met William Carlos Williams and H. D. In 1908 he sailed to Europe and published his first book of poetry, *A Lume Spento*, in Venice. Then arriving in London, he came into contact with T. E. Hulme and his Poets' Club, and later founded Imagism together with H. D. and Richard Aldington. In 1912 he appointed himself foreign editor of *Poetry* (Chicago) and in this capacity was able to discover struggling talents like Robert Frost, and T. S. Eliot whose masterpiece, *The Waste Land*, he blue-penciled ruthlessly and who dedicated it to him as a better craftsman. Among those who also acknowledged their debt to him were William Carlos Williams and Marianne Moore. Meanwhile, his ebullient innovative spirit impressed William Butler Yeats, his senior by twenty years, so that the older man moved into one new period of his multi-phase career. In 1913 Pound became the literary executor of Ernest Fenollosa (1853-1908), the noted American Orientalist, and began his fruitful study of the Chinese language and ancient Chinese culture. The next year he broke with Amy Lowell and left Imagism in favor of Vorticism: the aesthetics of both movements were to leave a permanent imprint on his works. Around 1915 he finished his volume of Chinese translations, *Cathay*, and began to work on his *Cantos*, which in time grew into a sprawling colossus of a modern epic. Ezra Pound was a seminal figure in modern poetry. Cranky, irascible, and full of argumentation, he was a busybody, a meddler, a thruster, a self-styled leader, or at least he posed like one wherever he went. His contribution to the development of modern poetry was altogether unique.

The First World War woke Pound up from his intense poetic occupations, and pushed him into exploring an area to which he had hitherto been a total stranger. His subsequent interest in economics proved to be unfortunate for him in more ways than one. After the publication of *Homage to Sextus Propertius* (1917) and *Hugh Selwyn Mauberley* (1920), he moved first to Paris where he assisted young American writers like Hemingway, and then settled in Rapallo, Italy, to work on his *Cantos*. He leaned in the direction of Mussolini's fascist totalitarianism and broadcast

over Radio Rome, during the Second World War, against the Allies. At the end of the war he was arrested by the U. S. military authorities at Pisa. There he wrote the first draft of his *Pisan Cantos* in prison. He was brought back to the States to stand trial for treason, but was sent, instead, to St. Elizabeth's Hospital in Washington, D. C., after being declared insane. There he stayed and completed the *Pisan* sequence, the *Rock Drill Cantos* and his translation of a Chinese classic, *The Classic Anthology Defined by Confucius*. In 1958, the concerted effort of such eminent personalities as T. S. Eliot, Robert Frost, and Hemingway secured his release. He returned to Italy, where he worked until his death in 1972.

When Ezra Pound appeared on the scene in the first years of the twentieth century, the West presented a panorama of a wasteland. It was a world in which Pound saw pervasive and impenetrable gloom, and chaos and disorder and barbarism were rampant everywhere. To him life was sordid personal crushing oppression, and culture produced nothing but "intangible bondage." He considered it his mission to save a tottering civilization. Trying to derive standards from the cultures of the past and resurrect lost principles of order, he became, as M. L. Rosenthal calls him, "the prophet of the open spirit." He surveyed earlier literatures and cultures, made a synthesis out of bits of history, and adapted their conventions to his own purposes. From Greek, Provençal, Latin, Chinese, Anglo-Saxon, French, and Spanish traditions he drew in his highly eclectic manner and assimilated the borrowing into his system to "make it new." Pound owes heavily to Homer. His hero has always been an Odysseus figure. The narrator of *Hugh Selwyn Mauberley* is Odysseus-Pound, and the substructure of the *Cantos* is Homeric. And his major poems often take the form of a voyage. Provence was the country of Pound's dreams. The Provençal troubadours possessed an unusual appeal to his imagination. His most favorite one was Arnaut Daniel, the King who, along with quite a few others such as Vidal and Cavalcanti, found their way from his lyrics into his *Cantos*. Pound's enthusiasm for Dante was unbounded. The influence of the Italian poet is most evident in the *Cantos*, bearing as it does a direct relationship to *Divine Comedy* from which Pound derived the title of the poem. The tripartite structure and its number of about one hundred poems both correspond to the scheme of Dante's masterpiece.

The greatest cultural influence over Pound came perhaps from ancient China. In a way, it was Pound's intention to celebrate Chinese civilization, for Pound began his career with a "grand abnegation." He saw no effective cure in Christianity for the disease of his times. To him official Christianity was a sink, and the Bible was poison which had been "instilled for centuries into helpless babes and dumped on men like god-blithering tosh." And as time went on he even lost faith in the efficacy of Greek culture. Greek thought was, he felt, utterly irresponsible; it was at no point impregnated with a feeling for the whole people. Thus when he looked about and turned east, he found a Messiah in Confucius and the medicine for the disease of the West in his teachings. As the "one lantern" "under the cabin roof" (*Canto* 49), Confucius, Pound believed, can enlighten and "civilize" the barbarous Occident. The wisdom of the Confucian classic, *Ta Hio* (*Da Xue* or *The Great Learning*) is, as Pound saw it, not yet exhausted and inexhaustible. As contained in the forty-six characters of the "Text of Confucius," that wisdom boils down in the final analysis to one notion: order and tranquility, from which light shines forth. Order and tranquility come from enlightened rule, and a salient feature of Confucian enlightened rule is even distribution of wealth and light taxation. These constitute the thematic concerns of the Chinese *Cantos* (*Cantos* 13, 49, 52-61), and in a sense underlie the *Cantos* as a whole. The ideogramic and pictographic nature of the Chinese characters appealed to him so that he discovered, with great delight, an ideal medium

for poetry.

The best poem that Pound ever wrote is probably his two-part *Hugh Selwyn Mauberley*. It is a poem about the commercialization and debasement of art, about the feeling of frustration and failure on the part of the artist, and about the poet himself (for many elements of the poem are apparently autobiographical) who, "out of key with his time, / strove to resuscitate the dead art / Of poetry..." It is a painful record of the growth of Pound as a poet from his refusal to write "socially useful," "engaged" poetry in his *Homage to Sextus Propertius* to his final realization that aestheticism will not work in the modern world. The opening lyric of the first part of the thirteen poems, "E. P. Ode pour L'Election de Son Sepulchre" (Ezra Pound: "Ode on the Choice of his Tomb"), reveals a poet reflecting on his self exile and symbolic death. Here Pound or Mauberley-Pound seems to be a Homer seeking a great world, but there is defeat, a fading away, a sense of pathos and fatality, a kind of muted anger. The second and third lyrics accuse "a tawdry cheapness" of degrading art and civilization, and banishing any cultural heritage of any refinement and grace out of life. The next two lyrics lament the decay of value which sacrifices youth in the mass slaughter of the First World War: "There died a myriad / And of the best, among them, / For an old bitch gone in the teeth, / For a botched civilization." The seven poems that follow present a historical review of the literary scene since the 1880s. A philistine Robert Buchanan attacking Rossetti and Swinburne, painters becoming synonymous with adulterers, a Mr. Dixon, probably modeled on Arnold Bennett, advising the budding poet "to give up verse, my boy, / There is nothing in it" ?all indicate the alienation of the artist and the degradation of his status in modern history. The concluding poem, "Envoi," contrasts in tone with the preceding lyrics. Here there is beauty visualized: "I would bid them live / As roses might, in magic amber laid, / Red overwrought with orange and all made / One substance and one colour / Braving time." Here is the reassertion of the poet's belief and dedication to art: change may break down all but definitely not beauty.

If the first part of *Mauberley* suggests the quest of an artist in an unresponsive world, the second part, which contains five lyrics, represents a similar quest but has, however, taken on a new dimension of meaning. *Mauberley* is searching, hoping to find his true home, his Ithaca and Penelope, but when he does, he finds that his "true Penelope" is the truthful art of Flaubert, the true classicism of the modern world. Now new beauty seems to be in sight, but then there is a sense of bewilderment, a sense of estrangement in the elegiac tone and the hesitating movement of the lines. "His new found orchid" is fragile, rare and delicate and will be lost if not caught quickly. In the way "mouths [bite] empty air," he does not seem to be equipped with the fine sensitivity necessary to appreciate it. Hence a sense of failure. His vision leads inwards and isolation comes over him. He raises the question of the relevancy of art in general and feels the imperfection of his own. He cannot bring himself to believe in his exclusion from the world of letters and rules out all possibility of serving a world which fails to appreciate him. Thus, *Mauberley* is in a sense a Pound already aware of his plight as an artist in the modern world, who has caught sight of his "tree Penelope" and is groping toward her. This quest continues with renewed vigor in his lifelong endeavor, the *Cantos*.

The *Cantos* has been called Pound's "intellectual diary since 1915." Containing a total of 117 poems, it is social history, an amalgam of heterogeneous cultures and languages, a poet's attempt to impose, through art, order and meaning upon a chaotic and meaningless world. The world of the *Cantos* is indeed cheerless and somber. There is in Canto 1 the joyless Hades of the

dead, and in Canto 3 the tragic sight of the Spanish hero Ruy Diaz being ostracized and breaking his way to Valencia, and also the murder in a decayed Renaissance mansion. Cantos 4 and 5 offer not a ray of sunlight but an expanse of unfruitful world, while Canto 7 portrays a contemporary society of phantoms and ghosts. We witness the rise and fall of the fortunes of the eventually despoiled Malatesta in Canto 11 and arrive at a scene (Cantos 14-15) where there is nothing but perversion and "darkness unconscious" on all conceivable levels of life. Even in Canto 16, which offers a glimpse of an earthly paradise, we see a Europe very much ruined and destroyed.

A major thematic concern of the Cantos is the treatment of usury which, in Pound's eyes, like a beast with a hundred legs, blasts light, life, and love out of existence. Canto 12 talks of banks not likely to ease distribution. Canto 30 mentions money debasing the arts and customs of Venice. Canto 34 records the fact of banks breaking all over America and prostrating every principle of economy. Canto 37 registers the pernicious effect of the Bank of the United States deranging the country's credits and controlling the public mind. Before the denunciation of the malpractice of the Bank of England in Canto 46, Pound lashes himself into a fury at usury in Canto 45, and repeats his charge against both usury and the Jewish people in Canto 51. In short the first fifty cantos paint, as Hugh Kenner observes, a picture of "the complete and utter inferno of the past century.

Pound sees in Chinese history and the doctrine of Confucius a source of strength and wisdom with which to counterpoint Western gloom and confusion. Canto 13 shines with the light of the Confucian ideal of harmony and order. Canto 49 illumines the dim, repulsive world of Cantos 45 and 51, and helps to establish a larger framework to contain and unify the bits and fragments the poet keeps dumping into his "rag-bag" of a poem. Based on the Confucian classic, *Li Ji*, Canto 52 throws the idea of order into relief, and constitutes a proper introduction to the whole of the China cantos sequence. Here the Confucian notion that a good prince, keeping down taxes, ensures order and happiness, becomes the yardstick for Pound to evaluate history. His survey of Chinese history from the ancient mythical period to the middle of the eighteenth century (Cantos 53-61) is highly idiosyncratic, simplistic, and idealistic. He sees the rise and fall of dynasties purely as the result of their following or violating the Confucian principle. The Adams Cantos (62-71) are related to the Chinese sequence because there is, to Pound, Western thought that conforms to Confucius', and the career of John Adams and other early American leaders embodied for Pound the finest virtues of the national period.

In a sense the Rock Drill (Cantos 85-95) and the Thrones (Cantos 96-109) sequences are a continuation of the theme treated in the China cantos. The first of these may dwell more on usury, and the second may devote more to the eulogy of virtuous rulers, but neither deviates much from the general thematic pattern as set in the China cantos. "Canto 85 is," Pound says in a footnote attached to the canto, "a somewhat detailed confirmation of Kung's [Confucius'] view that the basic principles of government are found in the *Shu*, the History Classic." So it is, on the whole, a liberal rendering of the Confucian classic, *The Book of History*. Canto 86 interpolates Chinese characters in between statements of or about Bismarck and Talleyrand, a quick look at Babylon, and a poignant thrust at F. D. Roosevelt, but the character for the cardinal Confucian virtue, "compassion," opens and informs the whole canto. The theme of usury is again prominent in Canto 87, and in the next two cantos, the American banking system is under fire as a form of usury against the people. As Pound himself points out, the Thrones concerns the states of mind of the people responsible for something more than their personal conduct. These sage kings are

selected and put in the Thrones in keeping with the obvious Confucian principle regarding virtuous rulers. The Chinese diptych in this sequence, Cantos 98 and 99, recounts the royal edicts of the enlightened Manchu emperors Kang Xi and his successor Yong Zheng, the first of the two cantos being an overview and the second an elaboration. The basic virtues stressed here are essentially Confucian.

Despite the fact that his anti-Semitism led him to stray in the 1940s, Pound was a visionary artist, believing that humanity deserved better than it got. He saw a chaotic world that wanted setting to rights, and a humanity, suffering from spiritual death and cosmic injustice, that needed saving. Anxious to stem the tottering Western civilization from going under, and to find a rudder for the rudderless American people, he ransacked history for the ideals and principles long buried and lost in the golden past. Whether for good or for evil, rightly or wrongly, Pound was for the most part of his life trying to offer Confucian philosophy as the one faith that he felt could help to save the West. We are aware that the Cantos is, thematically as well as formally, a diversity, and it would be hard to fit this colossus neatly into any one framework, however inclusive it may be. But if we choose to see Confucius' philosophy as the thread stringing the disparate beads of the hundred-odd cantos together, then it is not too much of an exaggeration to state that the ethos of the Cantos is essentially Confucian. Pound endeavored to "be useful," as he said in Canto 70. If, toward the end of his Cantos, his earthly paradise is still in the making, he has at least tried for "the little light and harmony" (Canto 113, Drafts and Fragments). It is somewhat pathetic to hear him uttering in plain desperation these lines: "I lost my center / fighting the world. / The dreams clash / and are shattered" (Canto 117).

Pound's early poems are fresh and lyrical. His Chinese translations are uneven. The Cantos can be notoriously difficult in some sections, but delightfully beautiful in others; it is, on the whole, not easily approachable. Few have made a serious study of the long poem; fewer, if anyone at all, have had the courage to declare that they have conquered Pound; and many seem to agree that the Cantos is a monumental failure. Nevertheless, Pound's influence has been on the increase. In the postwar period when tastes and values began to change and the influence of T. S. Eliot and the New Criticism started to wane, Pound, along with William Carlos Williams, offered a sense of direction to the writing of new poetry. His Cantos, especially his Pisan Cantos, became the new model for contemporary poets with its features such as its autobiographical and personal tone, and its open, spontaneous, and sometimes agrammatical style. And he became a **father figure**. His letters, literary essays and selected prose, for a long time out of print, have been reissued along with most of his pre-war writings including *The Spirit of Romance* (1909), *ABC of Reading* (1934), *Guide to Kulchur* (1938), and his Chinese and Japanese translations. With the passage of time people seem to be forgetting his wartime misbehavior and beginning to evaluate his achievement as a poet, and have come to the realization that he has helped, through theory and practice, to chart out the course of modern poetry. And as such he will be remembered.

CHAPTER 12 T S Eliot Stevens Williams

T. S. Eliot (1888-1965)

The poetic scene of the first years of this century was dismal and uninspired. With Whitman and Dickinson dead, the field was strewn with pieces of poetry extremely moralistic, sentimental, and imitative of what had gone before. This was the situation that prevailed in 1900-1910. There was obvious disaffection widely felt, especially among the younger generation. Some events took

place that helped toward the evolution of modern poetry. We have dwelled briefly on the Imagist movement in the previous chapter. Then there was a book by Arthur Symons, an English critic, *The Symbolist Movement in Literature* (1899), which was exerting a profound influence on T. S. Eliot, Ezra Pound, and practically everybody else who was interested in new voices in poetry. In 1912 Harriet Monroe started publishing a very small volume of verse, called *Poetry*, a magazine of verse, with the declared intention to print new poetic voices in it. A few years later Margaret Anderson published her *Little Review*, another magazine devoted to new verse by people like Pound, Eliot, Sandburg, and Williams. Meanwhile, some events of comparable significance took place in music, ballet, drama, and the fine arts, which shocked the audience into a pained recognition of the fact that old artistic standards were beside the point in face of modern experience. The years 1912-1914 witnessed the appearance of all kinds of innovations. Here were indications that a new poetic revolution was taking place, comparable in scope and significance to (if not greater than) the one Whitman represented in 1855. The new poets wrote a poetry that defied most of the accepted rules, and dealt with subjects which had not been dealt with except, perhaps, by Whitman, thus pushing the boundaries of poetry further back. And they wrote in new ways and techniques. These people were in effect creating a poetic revolution in America, and also a very large American poetry reading audience. This audience was in large part a very fragmented one, because modern life was fragmented and dislocated; the West was, philosophically and religiously, a fragmented civilization with no longer a unified set of beliefs which characterized the world of Dante's *Divine Comedy*, Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales*, Spenser's *Faerie Queene* or the world of Shakespeare, Milton, and Alexander Pope. The new verse was responsive to the fragmentized nature of modern life. Within a little over two decades, it scored a complete triumph over old poetry. Pound, Eliot, Williams, Stevens, Sandburg, E. E. Cummings, and Hart Crane, to name just a few, all made their presence felt, and Eliot became, by 1925, the acknowledged leader of the new verse and criticism both in America and Great Britain.

T. S. Eliot was born in St. Louis, Missouri where his grandfather had helped to found the University of Washington. Both of his parents were cultured people so that young Eliot received a good education, especially in classic literature. He went to Harvard in 1906 to study under such eminent scholars as George Santayana (1863-1952), Barrett Wendell, and Irving Babbitt (1865-1933) whose neo-humanism had a great influence on his intellectual growth. Eliot read Dante, who was to become his most admired poet. He read Jules Laforgue, the French poet brilliant in portraying modern cityscape with his unusual wit and visual imagery, who endowed Eliot with a unique, fresh, and original tone. Eliot explored the poetry of the seventeenth century Metaphysical poets like John Donne and later acknowledged his indebtedness to them. In 1911 he finished *The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock*, a poem with a notable modern emotional coloring. After he received his M. A. degree in Harvard and had studied in Paris and Oxford, he settled down in 1915 in England, teaching, working as a bank clerk, writing book reviews for publishers, suffering intensely from an unhappy marriage, and all the while composing poetry. Around this period, English authors like Virginia Woolf (1882-1941) had tried to found a fund in order that Eliot might be able to concentrate on poetic creation, but Eliot declined their kind offer.

Eliot's poetry was becoming noted for its fresh visual imagery, its flexible tone, and highly expressive rhythm. "Gerontion" came out in 1920, to be followed two years later by the epochal epic, *The Waste Land* which, revealing as it does the spiritual crisis of postwar Europe, read like the manifesto of the "Lost Generation" and established Eliot's position as the leader not only of

new American poetry, but of a whole generation of writers later to be identified as "Waste Land Painters" like Hemingway and Faulkner. "Hollow Man" appeared in print in 1925, exhibiting a pessimism no less depressing than *The Waste Land*. For two years (1917-1919) Eliot was editor of *The Egoist*, founded *The Criterion* in 1922, and was its editor until 1939. The publication of *Ash Wednesday* (1930) and *Four Quartets* (1943) indicated that the poet had turned conservative. Eliot was also a playwright. His interest in verse drama was traceable to his Harvard days. He excelled in the dramatic monologue and studied the Senecan tradition seriously. His dramatic works include *Sweeney Agonistes*, *Murder in the Cathedral*, *The Cocktail Party*, and *The Confidential Clerk*.

Eliot was also a distinguished literary critic. Although his criticism was in large measure an elaboration of and a guide to his own literary practice, he became "a giver of laws and the arbiter of taste" in the new poetry and criticism. With a sound training in philosophy and classic literature, his criticism possessed an air of authority and offered a measure of reassurance. The basic themes of his criticism concerned the relationship between tradition and individual talent, and between the past, the present, and the future. His famous doctrine on poets and poetry is known as the "impersonal theory," or the theory of impersonality and objectivity. Eliot claims that "[t]he progress of an artist is a continual self-sacrifice, a continual extinction of personality." He employs the term "depersonalization" for this critical notion. One of the things that this theory emphasizes is the relation of a poem to the poems by other authors and suggests "the conception of poetry as a living whole of all the poetry that has ever been written." It explains the importance of tradition, the past, which we will discuss further later on. Another thing that this theory tries to focus on is the relation of the poem to its author. To T. S. Eliot, what the poet has to express, is not a "personality," but a particular medium in which impressions and experiences combine in peculiar and unexpected ways. Impressions and experiences that are important for the man (the poet) may take no place in poetry, and those which become important in the poetry may be not so to the man, the personality. Thus poetry is not a turning loose of emotion, but an escape from it; it is not the expression of personality, but an escape from it. In this way universal applicability can be achieved. Incidentally, it is the poetry, not the poet, that should be the focus of critical attention, and a work of art is an independent entity. All these ideas of Eliot's would necessarily lead to the emergence of the New Criticism in later years and influence a whole generation of poets. Eliot himself practiced the theory in his own writing. The "impersonal" feature of his poetry continued in his creative endeavor until his composition of *Four Quartets* in the mid 1930s when he felt the temptation of the self-reflective mood and tone and began to sound in certain sections of the long poem like a Postmodernist. Eliot's theory became something like a law for American poets for over two decades from the mid 1920s through the 1950s.

As a theorist Eliot was not original in ideas and assured in tone as Coleridge or Matthew Arnold, but it is no exaggeration to state that he was the most successful literary dictator in American literary history, one who wielded the most decisive influence over literary development for a long time. It was he who started the reevaluation of poets like Milton and the Romantics. It was he who probably did more than any other person in the twentieth century to popularize the seventeenth-century "Metaphysical poets" such as John Donne, and the late-nineteenth-century French symbolists. And it was he who emphasized the need to see the vitality of the literature of the past and to draw from literary traditions other than English literature. Collections of his critical essays include *The Sacred Wood*, *Essays on Style and Order*, *Elizabethan Essays*, *Essays Ancient*

and Modern, The Use of Poetry and the Use of Criticism and After Strange Gods.

Eliot's was a highly refined sensibility. He was one of the first if not the first to sense the futility and fragmentization of modern life and see modern society at its most disgusting. As Archibald MacLeish, one of his followers, noted eloquently, Eliot's poetry said more about the modern chaos in fifty or sixty lines than all the social critics and their volumes put together. But his search for order, form, and discipline led him toward conservatism and to religion for salvation. In 1927 he announced that he was a royalist in politics, a classicist in literature, and an Anglo-Catholic in religion, a declaration which, though it shocked few, angered and hurt a good many followers. To people like Hemingway, he was very much what Wordsworth had been to Robert Browning: a lost leader. Ultimately as a poet, Eliot was to transcend his politics and religion and even his literary principles and remain a monument in modern poetry. He won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1948.

Eliot's poetry is difficult to read, and more so for us Chinese. For one thing the images and symbols seem very much disconnected, as we shall see in more detail in our analysis of *The Waste Land*. An obvious source of difficulty lies in his learned quotations and allusions. Thus source-hunting has taken up very much of Eliot criticism. To appreciate Eliot it is good to understand that the essence of his thought lies in the interaction between the past, the present, and the future. "In some minds," Eliot stated in a lecture on *Ulysses*, "certain memories, both from reading and from life, become charged with emotional significance. All these are used, so that intensity is gained at the expense of clarity." Later Eliot developed this notion into his famous principle of "objective correlative":

The only way of expressing emotion in the form of art is by finding an "objective correlative"; in other words, a set of objects, a situation, a chain of events which shall be the formula of that particular emotion; such that when the external facts, which must terminate in sensory experience, are given, the emotion is immediately evoked.

Poetry that expresses emotion in this method tends naturally to be impersonal, in keeping with the "impersonal theory." In poems where this principle is applied, authorial presence tends to be effaced as much as possible. It is difficult for such poetry to be meditative in tone and autobiographical in subject. The poet frequently has to have a surrogate, a persona, to speak for him. A distance exists between the text of the work and the response of its readers. The sense of immediacy in appreciation would be somewhat diminished. These are some of the points regarding the theory to which the Postmodernist poets of the 1950s and 1960s would object, but not before Eliot had enjoyed ascendancy for over a quarter of a century. For an illustration of the "objective correlative" theory here, we may read, among others, one of Eliot's "Preludes" ? "The Winter Evening Settles Down." Here a voice, not that of the author's, is speaking. His manner of communication is indirection: he piles up a heap of images, visual, auditory, olfactory, and more for the readers to figure out what is being said: the evening settling down, the smell of steaks in the passageways, the "burnt-out ends of smoky days," the gusty showers, the grimy scraps of withered leaves and newspapers, the showers beating on broken blinds and chimney-pots, the steaming and stamping cab horse ? all these external facts sink into the minds of the readers and make an impact so that they feel they see someone exhausted at the end of a heavy, dull, long day, not feeling good, but not losing hope yet since the last line of the poem connotes that he sees light in the ambient gloom ("And the lighting of the lamps"). This kind of poetry apparently calls for the cooperation of the readers in its full appreciation. Its claim on the readers' attention and

response can be too demanding for them to like it. If *The Waste Land* had been understood when it first came out, it is now over eighty years removed from the circumstances which prompted its composition, and is therefore hard to understand without proper annotations.

Now let us take a look at *The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock* and *The Waste Land*, for a further experience of Eliot's poetry. *The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock* depicts a timid middle-aged man going (or thinking of going) to propose marriage to a lady but hesitating all the way there. It takes the form of soliloquy, an interior monologue like that of Browning's. Whether the man actually leaves his spot at all remains a question. Most probably he stays where he is all the while, allowing his imagination to run wild. Prufrock is the image of an ineffectual, sorrowful, tragic twentieth-century Western man, possibly the modern intellectual who is divided between passion and timidity, between desire and impotence. His tragic flaw is timidity; his "curse" is his idealism. Knowing everything, but able to do nothing, he lives in an area of life and death; and caught between the two worlds, he belongs to neither. He craves love but has no courage to declare himself. He despairs of life. He discovers its emptiness and yet has found nothing to replace it. Thus the poem develops a theme of frustration and emotional conflict.

The title of the poem is ironic in that the "Love Song" is in fact about the absence of love. The name of Prufrock is that of a furniture dealer in St. Louis. His initial "J" sounds tony and classy, giving one a sense of the upper class to which he belongs. The epigraph, taken from Dante's *Inferno*, is in fact a confessional, a kind of "I'll tell you all." The speaker in it is the flame of Guido suffering in the eighth circle of Hell for consular fraud. Through the tongue of the flame Guido says to the effect that, since nobody ever goes out of Hell, I can answer you without fear, which is another way of saying that we can talk candidly about our sins. The implication of all this is that Prufrock is, like Guido, also in Hell or a hellish situation. Since Prufrock is not guilty of anything and Guido is, the resemblance is highly ironic. The epigraph also implies that modern man inhabits a nightmarish inferno. The first line, "Let us go then, you and I," suggests that what follows is a dramatic monologue with an audience. It reminds us of Browning's "My Last Duchess" where there is the impregnated line, "Nay, we'll go / Together down, sir." The identity of "you" has invited a variety of comments. Eliot himself says that it is "an unidentified male companion." Some critics see it as "the generalized reader." But most seem to agree that it is Prufrock's alter ego, symbolizing the split nature of this divided person; "I" represents his inner self. Thus probably he has been talking to himself, and the whole poem is an interior monologue of a kind.

Prufrock is a middle-aged dandy, well dressed, and self-conscious to a fault. He lives in an urban world, seedy, raw, more or less Zolaesque as the first few lines suggest and the third section of the poem (LL. 15-22) confirms. It is a world where there is no social unity, and where there is elegance and beauty of a kind such as divorced from force and vitality. It is a trivial world of total emptiness ("I have measured out my life with coffee spoons"). Here walks (or he imagines himself walking) this man with an obsession he cannot handle in the natural way, afraid of rejection, of being misinterpreted, of speaking out his mind and proposing to a lady ("[forcing] the moment to its crisis"). Here is an extreme example of the Hamlet problem: a man harassed with self-doubt, never reaching that "Readiness is all" state with his inability to act and be alive at the moment. Neurotically desperate, Prufrock can conceive a heroic action which he is incapable of fulfilling; he can see his actions on the grandest level but do not a thing. He sees himself as Lazarus coming back from the dead, but can not break through his deadness. He sees himself as John the Baptist,

that vigorous, dynamic, committed human being that he is by all standards not, with his aimless, silly, repetitive way of wasting his life in a purposeless social environment. He is most probably sexually inadequate. At the end of the poem he fancies himself "in the chambers of the sea / By seagirls wreathed with seaweed red and brown," but the "human voices" wake him up from his reverie. Unable to bring himself and his world together and build a base for meaningful action, Prufrock, with his physical impotence, represents the spiritual impotence of archetypal modern man. What is redeeming is probably his self-perception: he sees his own absurdity.

The poem is interesting also for its method of presentation. We do not move in a sequential fashion. Apart from the surreal vividness which characterizes certain parts of the poem, there are elliptical structures, strange juxtapositions, an absence of bridges, so that the whole seems broken; nothing is explained in a logical manner. We have to make leaps in our reading and appreciation, as the poet seems to jump from one scene to another and from one idea to another. It is important to note here, however, that the association of images establishes the general feeling. Nothing is discordant, irrelevant, or abrupt any more, and everything is falling in place when the overall mood of the poem is perceived. We shall see more of this method in *The Waste Land*.

Commenting on James Joyce, T. S. Eliot remarked once that the only way the modern writer has of "giving shape and significance to the immense panorama of futility and anarchy which is contemporaneous history" is by indicating or "manipulating a continuous parallel between contemporaneity and antiquity." Now out of this famous statement three things come immediately that merit careful analysis. The first is the feeling that the modern world presents an "immense panorama of futility and anarchy." Indeed, no one, in the first decades of this century, sensed the confusion and fragmentization of modern life more keenly than did T. S. Eliot. No one was more aware of the horrid and sordid aspect of the modern experience. "The contemplation of the horrid or sordid or disgusting, by an artist, is the necessary and negative aspect of the impulse toward the pursuit of beauty," he states in *The Sacred Wood*. "The negative is the more importunate." Secondly, there is the keenly felt need to "[give] shape and significance" to the meaningless, futile, and chaotic experience of modern man. To T. S. Eliot modern human experience is chaotic, irregular, and fragmentary, and it is the poet's job to form new wholes out of disparate experiences. This fusion of disparate elements into an artistic form and order is the very poetic process for the modern poet. The fragmentary nature of life is projected rather than analyzed. The best way to do this is through finding an "objective correlative." Then comes the third point, the poet's use of "antiquity," the past, the tradition, from which a poet can perfectly legitimately draw. A poet should have his unified sensibility, and "one of the surest tests for this sensibility is," as T. S. Eliot states in *The Sacred Wood*, "the way in which a poet borrows.... A good poet will usually borrow from authors remote in time, or alien in language, or diverse in interest." The "welding process" that follows, transmuting borrowed materials into something better or different, characterizes Eliot's own literary creative endeavors. His method is, in part, to rely on past literatures and cultures which fuse in his mind with his own personal and private agonies into something rich and strange, something universal and impersonal. Eliot holds that the negative qualities of the modern world can be sensed only through contrast with the positive qualities of an older world. To appreciate all this, it is good to take a look at *The Waste Land*.

T. S. Eliot composed *The Waste Land* in the autumn of 1921, while taking a vacation at Lausanne, western Switzerland. Before returning to London, he visited Pound at Paris and left the draft with him. Pound blue-penciled it and reduced its length which was nearly twice as long as its

present form. Impressed by this editorial feat, T. S. Eliot dedicated the poem to him: "For Ezra Pound il miglior fabbro [the better craftsman]," which is a quotation from Dante's *Purgatorio* xxvi, line 117. In October 1922, *The Waste Land* was first published in the *English Criterion* and in November in the *American Dial*; and in the same year by the New York publishers, Boni and Liveright.

The epigraph of the poem is taken from the *Satyricon* (xlvi) of Petronius, the Roman satirist of the first century, A. D. Its prose translation in English reads: "For I myself saw with my own eyes the Sibyl of Cumae (in Italy) hanging in a cage, and when the boys cried to her, Sibyl, what do you want? She used to reply, 'I want to die.'" The Sibyl of Cumae is a prophetess who has been given long life by Apollo but has failed to ask for eternal youth and health. She is both the guardian of a sacred cave from which she derives her oracles and a gatekeeper of the underworld. Her misfortune to be shut in a cage and to wither away indefinitely represents the motif, the somber mood, of *The Waste Land*, emblematic as she is of life in death, of a desperate struggle to attain salvation.

The title of the poem draws its significance from the Fisher King legend, to which the plan of the poem relates. In her book, *From Ritual to Romance* (1922), Jessie L. Western tells the various versions of the Grail legend of which the story of the Fisher King is a part. The Fisher King sins against God, who then punishes him by making him sexually impotent. The disability of the King is reflected on his land, so that his kingdom becomes a waste land. Hence the title. To restore the King to virility and his land to fertility, a quest is undertaken to search for the Holy Grail, the cup which is said to have been used by Jesus Christ at the Last Supper and later brought to Britain by Joseph of Arimathea. The quester does not have to get the Grail, but he must come to the right place and ask the right question about the nature of the Holy Cup. His question would be enough to make the King well and young and his land fertile again. But if he fails to ask the necessary mysterious question, the quest would fail, the King would remain sexually wounded, and his kingdom a desolation. Western also states that the Holy Grail legend is connected with the Arthurian legend. For 1 000 years the land lies in waste until, in the days of King Arthur, his knights set out in quest of the Grail. Only the noblest and purest of them can hope to accomplish the task. Thus the story of the Fisher King and the quest of the Holy Grail serves as the governing myth of *The Waste Land*. One of the major features of the poem is incidentally that sexual failure connotes spiritual debilitation. T. S. Eliot acknowledges in his "Notes on *The Waste Land*" his debt to Western's book and recommends it, in fact, to the reader in case any difficulty in understanding the poem should occur.

In his *Sense and Sensibility in Modern Poetry*, William Van O'Connor points out that modern civilization, with its characteristic disorder and fragmentization of experience, makes it difficult, if not utterly impossible, for modern poets to "see life steadily and see it whole." As modern poets experience chaos and dislocation, a driving intellectual ambition is seen present in all their poems to shore fragments together for order and meaning. Their poems are a m 聞 ange of fragmentary experiences, incidents and episodes, shifting without much notice from one to the other, rather than in a traditional narrative manner. These poems can be subdivided into different sections, not formally connected, but all subsumed into a thematic whole. *The Waste Land* is a good illustration. Here we see an ideal parataxis which is the stylistic norm of the poem, as paratactic structures usually indicate a sense of discontinuity and unrelatedness. The five parts of the poem, "The Burial of the Dead," "A Game of Chess," "The Fire Sermon," "Death by Water,"

and "What the Thunder Said" do not have sufficient formal connection between them. Things stop and begin without explicable shift: the transition from the unreal city of London to a Cleopatra sitting in splendor, from the scene in a pub to "Sweet Thames [running] softly," from Saint Augustus coming to Carthage to "Phlebas the Phoenician, a fortnight dead," to the nightmarish imagery, the reminders, of the waste land ?the change is abrupt and jerky, with no hint of logical order and causal relationship. This radical disconnectedness is true even of the transitions between the different sections within any one part of the poem, and between the different ideas within any one section. Through gaps, absence of connective tissues, and discordant juxtapositions, the poet intends the reader to see and feel the fragmentary nature of life.

The Waste Land reveals its author's strong historical sense. To T. S. Eliot the past is of great significance to writers. In his famous "Tradition and the Individual Talent," he states that a writer should have the historical sense which is a perception of both the pastness of the past and its presence, and should write with the feeling that the whole literature of the past has a simultaneous existence and composes a simultaneous order. The past should be altered by the present as much as the present is directed by the past. "What is to be insisted upon is that the poet must develop or procure the consciousness of the past and that he should continue to develop this consciousness throughout his career." T. S. Eliot himself was well acquainted with the whole of the literature of Europe from Homer and the whole of the literature of his own country. He wrote with an acute consciousness of the past. In his The Waste Land he uses the past as a yardstick to measure the present and underscore what is missing from the present. For example, he juxtaposes the passionate love of Tristram and Iseult with the passionless hyacinth girl who faces a bare and cold sea, the perfunctoriness of the typist with the sensitivity of Oliver Goldsmith's lovely woman, Cleopatra with the wealthy lady who cries out, "What shall I do now? What shall I do?" and waits "for a knock upon the door," Elizabeth and Leicester with the girl who murmurs helplessly "what should I resent?" ?in a word, Eliot is trying to throw into relief the negative qualities of the present by contrasting them with the positive ones of the past, and shock the reader into a recognition of the dismal truth about modern life. The long poem is certainly an eloquent social criticism. It is true that, when the poem first came out, its effect was overwhelming to an audience used to reading comfortable nineteenth-century authors like Dickens. It was the poem of despair for the 1920s and 1930s. However, as we read along, we will find that the poem moves, through recurrent reminders of the modern waste land, toward a hope of regeneration and builds toward the possibility of restoring order and life. There is an underlying desire on the part of the poet to help create order and sense out of a disorderly and senseless existence. T. S. Eliot is able, through his discovery of the myth of desolation and rebirth, to find sanction for his doctrine which the thunder states as "Give, Sympathize, Control," or self-surrender, immersion in the problems of others, and submission to God's control. He would like to help to rehabilitate those beliefs which people know but shrink from and discredit.

Eliot's search for salvation for the West continued in his Ash Wednesday and Four Quartets; he hoped to find it in religious belief and self repentance. **The Four Quartets is the best work of the later phase of his career, and some critics claim that it is one of best long poems (if not the best) to come out of the twentieth century.** The four quartets are "Burnt Norton," "East Coker," "The Dry Salvages," and "Little Gidding." The first of these was written as a separate work in the mid 1930s, and the rest were composed between 1940 and 1942. Later Eliot put these together as Four Quartets. If The Waste Land is a representative work of the High Modernism of the 1920s,

impersonal, discontinuous with its fragments, full of literary allusions and ancient myths, measuring modern life against the historical past and finding it wanting in many ways, then the Four Quartets is quite different in many aspects such as speech, mood, and tone, so much so that it sounds like a Postmodernist poem in some of its passages. In certain parts of the long poem, the speech is personal, the mood is reflective, the presentation is continuous and discursive and less allusive, and the emphasis on the significance of the past is toned down so much that there is little social critique in evidence in the poem. Just as Virginia Woolf sensed the need for a change in style in her later works such as *Between the Acts* and *The Waves* (which indicates her inclination toward Postmodernism), so Eliot felt the inevitable Postmodernist impulse, which was forthcoming in a decade to dominate the contemporary literary scene in America. The Four Quartets is easier to read, and the personal and autobiographical nature of some of its passages and their meditative style have endeared the author to his readers. Personal memories appear, such as those of the rose garden in "Burnt Norton," of his visit to East Coker, of his childhood in St. Louis and boyhood experience in Massachusetts. We need to note here, however, that the impact of Eliot's change was not comparable to that of Pound's *Cantos*, especially the Pisan *Cantos*, and Williams' *Paterson*, both making their impressive presence felt in the late 1940s and becoming the harbingers of the new phase of American poetry—that of Postmodernism. It was these two who would become the prophet figures of the new period, and not Eliot whose decline in influence, along with that of the New Criticism, was to become a matter of course despite the enormous growth of his reputation in the postwar period. All this is seen in retrospect. And all is now history. The mist of time has cleared up, and Eliot has remained probably the best poet of his generation and his century.

Wallace Stevens (1879-1955)

In more ways than one Wallace Stevens was an unusual poet in modern American literary history. He was late in starting; his first major volume of poetry was not published until he was 44 years old, and he was successful in two fields of activity which did not seem compatible with one another: he was a very successful business man, rising to the position of vice-president in a Connecticut insurance company, while at the same time **writing poetry of a kind which was to make him a father-figure among contemporary poets**. He was in his early career influenced by the Imagist movement and the verse revolution of the time. His *Harmonium* bears a visible imprint of the Pound's 1912 statement of the Imagist "manifesto." But the style in the final phase of his career (from the 1940s through his death in 1955) underwent a significant change. He became diffuse and reflective. His poems were composed in the meditative mood and were filled with paradoxical generalizations and quasi-philosophical deliberations (to quote David Perkins' comments on him). So he became, along with Pound and Williams, a major influence on contemporary American poetry.

Wallace Stevens was absolutely committed to the notion that a poet lives in two worlds—the world of reality and the world of imagination—and builds bridges between them. So obsessed was he with the interrelationship between reality and art that a key to understanding his poetry and criticism lies in realizing that this is a very basic theme for him. Stevens' poetry is all of one piece, an elaboration or amplification, as some critics say, of Coleridge's famous poem entitled "Dejection: An Ode." What Coleridge talks about is the making of poetry, how to invent joy in poetry in the absence of anything in this world that gives certainty. Speaking in an age of shaky faith, Coleridge saw very few certainties in this world and felt that the job of the poet was at least

in part to create through art things that give life meaning and pleasure in the absence of consoling belief. Like Coleridge, Stevens deals repeatedly in his poetry with the role of the power of imagination. He sees the role of the poet as "Picnicking in the ruins that we live," which is another way of saying that a poet should find beauty and pleasure and excitement and meaning in the sordidness of reality. So we find, in Stevens, the poet as the imaginative man, a heroic type, heroic because capable of imagination, and we find poetry as a major modern form of revelation, revealing, among other things, the heroism of modern man who, even though recognizing the nothingness of modern existence, yet brings order and meaning to its chaos and meaninglessness. The poet operates in the two spheres of the real world and the imagined world and anchors his poetry solidly in the world of the here and now, or in the words of Keats, one of Stevens' favorite poets, reaches "upward from the world." It is good to note here that, for Stevens, the structured reality as present in a poem, or the "supreme fiction" (in his words), might not be the ultimate truth. Hence his ceaseless search and pondering over the true nature of reality which is to him, as to John Ashbery, not quite knowable.

Let us take a look at some of his poems. "Anecdote of the Jar," we must admit, is a strange poem in some ways and not very easy to interpret. Wallace Stevens was rather opposed to telling people what his poems meant. He said at one time that things that have their origin in imagination or emotion very often take on a form that is ambiguous and uncertain, and that it is not possible to attach a single rational meaning to such things without destroying the imaginative, emotional ambiguity and uncertainty inherent in them. It seems that here he agrees with T. S. Eliot's notion of poetry as an autonomous construction capable of more than one interpretation. So we can only decipher the meaning of "Anecdote of the Jar" by placing it in the larger context of his aesthetic credo and thematic concerns. Here lies the wild and chaotic and formless rural Tennessee, which let us assume is a symbol of the world of nature. Then the "I" of the poem places in it a tall, round jar, a man-made object, which is suggestive of the world of art, and by extension, the world of imagination. What happens when the jar is standing there is almost a miracle: it controls the whole disorderly landscape, so that "The wilderness rose up to it, / And sprawled around, no longer wild." The poem seems to be talking about the relationship between art and nature. The world of nature, shapeless and slovenly, takes shape and order from the presence of the jar. The world of art and imagination gives form and meaning to that of nature and reality, thus suggesting, as Stevens may be doing, that any society without art is one without order and that man makes the order he perceives, and the world he inhabits is one he half creates. Stevens firmly believes that the poet is the archetype of creative power on which all human understanding depends. His poet is "the necessary angel of the earth," in whose sight man sees the earth again. The poet is, in other words, an instrument by means of which man is made to see life whole again.

To Stevens poetry creates an aesthetic order and converts "the pressure of ominous and destructive circumstances ... as far as possible, into a different, an explicable, an amenable circumstance." As much as the jar relates to the wilderness, Crispin (in "The Comedian with the Letter C") tries to reduce the disorderly profusion of reality to the order of his imagination; and Paltry Nude undertakes her voyage through the world of Harmonium to become fully attuned to nature and fashions, and creates, through the power of her imagination, an acceptable order for herself. In the same way the singer of "The Idea of Order at Key West," facing a chaotic world of nature with its "meaningless plungings of water and wind," walks, singing all the while, and makes a world through her artistic endeavor. She is "the single artificer," the maker of the world

that was never there until she made it. And the effect of her art, signifying "the [b]lessed rage for order", is evidently universally felt: "Ramon Fernandez, tell me, if you know, / Why, when the singing ended and we turned / Toward town, tell why the glassy lights, / The lights in the fishing boats at anchor there, / As the night descended, tilting in the air, / Mastered the night and portioned out the sea, / Fixing emblazoned zones and fiery poles, / Arranging, deepening, enchanting night." It is because the singing has created and given order to the world in which we live. Here the role of the artist is elevated almost to that of a creator. And we also notice Penelope in "The World as Meditation" living in a world of meaning and belief which her mind builds absorbing the whole realm of sensory experience. The exaltation of the role of imagination and art reaches the highest point in Stevens in modern American literary history.

On the other hand the world of reality exists to determine the limits of art, and imagination can construct only on the basis of the world of nature. Stevens manages to keep a balance between art and life in his creative work. Take "Anecdote of the Jar" again. It is true that the jar imposes order and form on the sprawling wilderness around, but the two concluding lines, "It did not give of bird or bush, / Like nothing else in Tennessee," render the jar something dependent on the physical world as its "central reference." The interrelatedness between the two is well illustrated also in "The Emperor of Ice-Cream," the crux of which is in the line, "Let be be finale of seem." What Stevens is trying to say is, perhaps, "to let that which is put an end to what seems to be," or let reality show up and accept the real world for what it is ?the woman has died and is lying cold and dumb there, and there is nothing art or imagination or piety could do about it except accept it as a fact of life: "Take from the dresser of deal, / Lacking the three glass knobs, that sheet / On which she embroidered fantail once / And spread it so as to cover her face. / If her horny feet protrude, they come / To show how cold she is, and dumb. / Let the lamp affix its beam. / The only emperor is he emperor of ice-cream."

One very important idea that gets well expressed in his "Sunday Morning" is in fact the poet's meditation on earth and his insistence on accepting earth as against paradise. This eight-section poem, one of Stevens' major works, portrays a woman lost in thought on a Sunday morning. At the same time it records what she sees, hears, smells, feels, and thinks, the poem registers the poet-speaker's comments about these sensual experiences of hers, the two often merging with and into each other to produce a subtle artistic effect. Here exists a vivid contrast between Christian beliefs on the one hand and, on the other, pagan views and attitudes which are based on a deep experience of life and also exhibit a kind of worship for nature and the sun. The poem, exhorting man to realize one's self-worth joyfully within the possible limits of life, sounds composed but somewhat sad in tone, and thus acquires a dimension of complexity unique to itself. What the poem tries to convey is man's desire for harmony with his environment, his here and now, and his self, and also his need to experience the harmony between man and nature, the interdependence between man and his environment, and the faith in eternity achievable only through the understanding of absolute values.

The first section of the poem begins with the woman breakfasting on this bright Sunday morning in the sunny courtyard. In the quiet abundance of nature, she thinks of death ("that old catastrophe"), of the crucified Jesus Christ of Palestine, "Dominion of blood and sepulcher." The second section depicts the woman, wishing for timeless beauty in paradise, feels troubled by the encroachment of the notion of mortality. In face of variegated nature and her own life and sentiments, she begins to doubt if divinity and immortality do not exist only in darkness and

dreams, and realizes that divinity exists right in the beauty of nature and in herself, thus accepting this world as the frame of reference for her life and soul. Divinity has to live within her in her responses to nature: "Passions of rain, or moods in falling snow; / Grievings in loneliness, or unsubdued / Elations when the forest blooms; gusty / Emotions on wet roads on autumn nights; / All pleasures and all pains, remembering / The bough of summer and winter branch. / These are the measures destined for her soul." The sections that follow elaborate on the theme further. Section three portrays her stream of thought moving to Zeus, the God of gods in ancient mythology, who, though a god, never severs his connection with the human world, and further on to a possible world where man and god would mingle as one. The question comes to her mind, "... And shall the earth / Seem all of paradise that we shall know?" The next section follows up on the idea and edges, in small, gingerly steps, toward the notion that paradise is here and now. The fifth section dwells on her desire for immortality: "She says, 'But in contentment I still feel / The need of some imperishable bliss.'" The poet-speaker comments on this, saying that death is the source of beauty because death opens onward to rebirth. The sixth section, which reads like both her flow of consciousness and the poet-speaker's comments, exclaims at the amazing resemblance between heaven and earth. The idea is picked up in the seventh section which suggests a secular "religion": since, in paradise, there is also change of death, ripe fruit also falls, the tree branches do not hang always heavy in a perfect sky, rivers seek for seas like our own, the people there wear our colors, pick the strings of our lutes, etc., then heaven is every bit "like our perishing earth," and earth is in fact paradise. The section ends by reiterating, in a declarative tone, the idea expounded in the previous section, that death is the beginning of renewal. In the last section of the poem the woman hears a voice, becomes aware that Jesus himself was mortal as anyone else on earth and that, despite her thirst for eternal joy, she must accept the fact of mortality, without which there would be no renewal. There is almost sadness in the notion of the coming of evening, but then pigeons do come down with a touch of nobility:

And, in the isolation of the sky,
At evening, casual flocks of pigeons make
Ambiguous undulations as they sink,
Downward to darkness, on extended wings.

"Ambiguous" is loaded enough to inspire thought. It could mean, among other things, that the descent is not absolute but relative in the cycle of life. The image of "extended wings" connote a composure, a peace of mind, in face of the inevitable descent, but not without a resignation that builds itself into the texture of life in its various forms. And it just occurs to mind, talking about the relative nature of things, that Stevens' "Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Blackbird," while emphasizing the fact that there are no absolutes except what you see and that reality is not always estimable in the normal way, is Stevens' poetic statement that we have to accommodate our mind to the image of the bird, which is part of the natural process.

Stevens' was a long career of ceaseless and conscientious creation. The first book of poetry appeared in 1923, and was reprinted in 1931. Four years later *Idea of Order* came out, to be followed by *The Man with the Blue Guitar* (1937), *Parts of a World* (1942), *Transport to Summer* (1947), *The Auroras of Autumn* (1950), *Collected Poems* (1954), and *Opus Posthumous* (1957) which includes his uncollected works. His prose writings appeared in the collection, *The Necessary Angel*, in 1951. Stevens is, like Keats, a very sensual poet. He delights in depicting the world as revealed to the senses, hoping to relieve the monotony and grimness of everyday

existence by finding pleasures in the senses. Colors, sounds, and exotic images appeal to Stevens as they do to no other poets except, perhaps, Keats. There are, for example, many references to colors. Blue, the color of heaven, tends to be symbolic of the imagination, the world of aspiration and non-being as opposed to that of being. Green, which figures prominently in Stevens' poetry, is emblematic of nature's vitality, and so is red which also indicates virility. Of all the senses, Stevens values that of sight most. His visual imagery very often builds around the sense of the eyes. In his later poetry Stevens became increasingly more meditative and even obscure in style, and more difficult to appreciate. But there is no question that he always kept pace with the modern spirit of his times.

William Carlos Williams (1883-1963)

There were, in modern American literary history, two major literary figures for whom poetry was only an avocation. One of them was William Carlos Williams, and the other was Wallace Stevens. Two factors in the life of William Carlos Williams seem to have had a determining effect on his literary aesthetics and practice: he worked all his life as a physician in America except for two brief visits to Europe. He sees America as the place where he should root his poetry, and loves and remains faithful to the world of reality and things, of which his poetry is an adequate expression.

Williams was independent in his literary judgments. He had his own distinct views concerning the nature of poetry, the function of the poet, and the poetic process, very much unlike T. S. Eliot's. He wrote poetry not because he had to but because he wanted to, and what is more he did not feel the need to be accepted by the gods of poetry like the Eliots, the Pounds, and the Yeatses. One of the notable features of modern poetry is the absence of any unified concept of poetry. If T. S. Eliot represents a particular attitude toward poetry, then Williams definitely stands at the other end of the line, representing quite a different one. As a matter of fact, Williams was anti-Eliot all his life, spending a lot of time railing at people like Eliot. He was bitterly opposed to those "who know all the Latin and some of the Sanskrit names." A friend of Pound's but resenting his broken multi-cultural style, he saw Pound as living among the splendor of ancient human artifacts and thus as "the best enemy the United States verse has." His antagonism to T. S. Eliot dated from the publication of *The Waste Land* which, he says in his Autobiography, still feeling hurt and enraged beyond consolation, "[giving] the poem back to the academics," and "[returning] us to the schoolroom," was "a great catastrophe to our letters."

Williams strongly disapproves of the Pound-Eliot bookish, "internationalist," and intellectual brand of poetry, for he believes that "localism alone can lead to culture." One cannot have an imagination which is not rooted in the real world. And American poetry must be rooted in America as its fount of inspiration and its source of information and subject matter. It is the place for American poets. "We live only in one place at a time," he states, "but far from being bounded by it, only through it do we realize our freedom." What he wanted to achieve is to reach the universal plane of meaning through the representation of the local, in very much the same way Robert Frost was silently doing all his long life. Williams was obsessed with discovering "a primary impetus, the elementary principle of all art in our local conditions." His major prose work, *In the American Grain*, though dealing with people and events, is in point of fact a search for "the impact of the bare soul upon the very twist of the fact which is our world around us." It is "a descent to the ground" of his desires, a "going back to the beginning." Like Daniel Boone who "lived to enjoy the ecstasy through his single devotion to the wilderness with which he was

surrounded," and like Edgar Allan Poe whose greatness was "in that he turned his back and faced inland" and in whose works America as a place and a new locality first burst into expression, Williams was committed to reproducing the life, the soul, and the music of America in poetry. His long poem Paterson is, along with his short works, a poetic embodiment of his devotion.

William Carlos Williams' poetic power stems from his clear vision of the real world. Clarity of imagery constitutes the essential element of his work. He is very devoted to the phrasing of speech and is anxious to use its numerous rhythms. He is also faithful to his own unformulated thoughts. Williams has been recognized as a **forefather** of open verse.

A careful reading of Williams' poetry reveals some basic principles of his composition. For instance, he values the peculiarity of an object, and tries to allow it to reveal its true character. He hates to see an object stereotyped by association or sentimentality and lose its true value. Through the use of fancy, Williams gives everyday objects the charm of uniqueness and guides the mind's eye to the loveliness and wonders of the world before us. Williams also takes meticulous care to bring a new sense or meaning to an object and make it vivid and beautiful by creating a clear image of it or attaching a sensory experience to it. Reading Williams, we can sense him always carefully watching human experiences and trying to recapture evocative moments from them. To him there is poetry in every day life that careless eyes and ears may miss: there is poetry in the words spoken by the people, in the life being enacted, in eyes widened or shut, in smiles or grimaces, in the postures of the bodies or in the sights around. Thus his poetry represents the exceptional truth of ordinary life and the beauty of the commonplace. In addition, Williams feels that a poem represents a moment of the mind and that it delineates the shape of life not always planned ahead but often discovered later. The poet should keep taking the world to a new dimension and give it new imaginative validity.

So Williams feels strongly that poetry must be grounded in everyday experience and in the speech of the common man. It must use the common meters of living speech. It must rid itself of all encrustation and ornamentation. Williams is not interested in philosophical and metaphysical speculation which, in his opinion, has absolutely no place in poetry. The most important line he ever wrote is perhaps this line of Book I, Paterson, "Say it! No ideas but in things." What he is trying to say is in fact this: Don't philosophize; simply say it in terms of some kind of concretization; visualize in terms of that which is physical and particular. He holds that the poet's business is not to talk in vague categories, but to write particularly, specifically, as a physician works upon a patient, to discover in the particular the universal, the relationship between the actual world and the mental, between the here and now and the then and there, to see something for the first time and say it in ways of one's own. For Williams life as it is lived is the beginning and the end of the poet's endeavor. Life with its sundry concrete details and its rhythms, when closely observed and well appreciated, is in itself poetry simple and pure. Poetry will be defeating its own purpose if it goes, not to life and the actual world, but to books and the past for inspiration. "The world spreads / for me like a flower opening ?and / will close for me as might a rose ?/ wither and fall to the ground / and rot and be drawn up / into a flower again. But you never wither ?but blossom all about me..." he thus says in the second volume of his Paterson. And he is convinced that, if he ever deviates from his faith in life, he is sure to find his "despair."

And so Williams is noted for his fidelity to the facts of life. Art inheres in carefully observed life. Earlier on, we cited his famous "The Red Wheelbarrow" as an illustration of the Imagist credo which Williams shared as part of his literary theory. The poem appeals to the imagination

because it forces it to visualize and derive an aesthetic pleasure from the contemplation which is the reading of the poem. Placed in strategic positions separately in their lines, words as simple as "upon," "barrow," "water," and "chickens" assume immediately significance of a kind which they would otherwise not have possessed by any other means. With the animate juxtaposed with the inanimate, and the white color in contrast with the red, here we have in our minds' eye meaningful textures and clear, delightful colors. We become aware that it is important to perceive them to make life fuller, and that so much depends on how we perceive them both in our life and in our writing of poetry. Read his "Queen Ann's Lace," which is all concrete details well observed and specified: "Each part / is a blossom under his touch / to which the fibres of her being / stem one by one, each to its end, / until the whole field is a / white desire, empty, a single stem, / a cluster, flower by flower, / a pious wish to whiteness gone over ?/ or nothing," and we understand the relationship of poetry to life and our physical world so graphically explained in a language so much of our own. Indeed, to Williams, everything in actual life, including even the eating of "the plums / that were in the icebox," "so sweet / and so cold" ("This Is Just to Say"), is emblematic of some deeper level of human significance, and is therefore poetic in the very sense of the term.

Then there is the well known "Spring and All" which is almost all perception and observation. Williams wrote this poem to catch that moment in time when winter is on its way out but still lingering, and spring is coming in, though not yet quite sure of its entrance. Here there are no clichés which poets of a mediocre caliber frequently resort to. What is offered is all line after line of visual images giving one that wonderful sense of "spring is here," that captivating effect of the moment in time between winter and spring. The setting is by the road to the contagious hospital (that smacks of sickness and death). The first two stanzas delineate a very much dead landscape, with the cold wind, dried weeds, and the scattering of the trees. From the third and fourth stanzas, which are transitional in nature, we are enabled to perceive life germinating out of death, life juxtaposing itself with death:

All along the road the reddish
purplish, forked, upstanding, twiggy
stuff of bushes and small trees
with dead, brown leaves under them
leafless vines? Lifeless in appearance, sluggish
Dazed spring approaches?

Though still dead and lifeless in appearance, there appear colors of purple and red in an otherwise universal gray, and bushes which begin to put forth twigs. Spring is just awakening ("dazed"), from sleep and hibernation. It is not really that growth has started and a new cycle of nature has begun. But life has made its hesitating appearance on the scene (stanzas 5-6): Spring quickens and gives evidence of life. The last stanza indicates that the whole cycle of nature, of which spring is only a part, has begun. The concluding lines, "... rooted, they / grip down and begin to awaken," illustrate the poet's keen perception of nature around him. The poem excels in the visual impression it creates on the reader, and has been seen as an eloquent proof of Williams' supreme competence in handling the objective in poetry.

In 1946, the first book of the five-volume Paterson came out. Williams first planned to write four books of Paterson, with the first part introducing "the elemental character of the place," the second comprising the modern replicas, the third seeking a language to make them vocal, and the fourth, "the river below the falls," reminiscent of episodes "all that any one man may achieve in a

lifetime." Following Book I, Books ?, ? and ? appeared in 1948, 1949, and 1951 respectively. Then recognizing that it was a long, endless story that he was telling, he wanted, nonetheless, to keep the world of Paterson whole to himself and wrote a concluding Book ?, which was published in 1958. But this was not to be the end. Toward the end of 1960 and early in 1961, Williams began to plan a sixth volume, of which he managed to write only a few pages of notes and drafts before his death in 1963.

Paterson is a lucid statement of Williams' aesthetics. "For the poet," he writes of Paterson in his Autobiography, "there are no ideas, but in things.... The poet does not ... permit himself to go beyond the thought to be discovered in the context of that with which he is dealing: no ideas but in things." In writing Paterson Williams tries to find an image large enough to embody the whole knowable world about him. "The longer I lived in my place, among the details of my life, I realized that these isolated observations and experiences needed pulling together to gain 'profundity.'" A famous line occurs in Book ? of Paterson: "Why should I move from this place / Where I was born?" ?a line which reveals the committed attitude of the man toward his native place. Another equally famous line, which concludes Book ?, visualizes a man "[heading] inland," which is a distant poetic echo of his chapter on Edgar Allan Poe in his *In the American Grain*, and also a confirmation of the poet's resolve to turn his back on the sea (symbolic of a pull outward from the source) and keep his eyes and ears open only on his America. No one has uttered a more apt and pertinent remark about Williams than Robert Lowell when he said in 1962 that nobody, except Williams, has seen America or heard its music. Williams' "description of the pastoral Paterson of early days is a lyrical display of his intense love for his homeland with its vivid concrete particulars:

In a deep-set valley between hills, almost hid by dense foliage lay the little village. Dominated by the Falls the surrounding country was a beautiful wilderness where mountain pink and wood violet thrive: a place inhabited only by straggling trappers and wandering Indians.

Here he sees the river ?farms and the simple but pastoral life of the people, wearing homespun clothes, raising their own stock, with rude furniture on sanded floors, primitive in a sense but quiet and hearty. Here he discovers the source for art, for poetry. Paterson is innovative in technique. It faithfully reproduces the quiet, serene rhythm of life itself in its natural flow, now in prose, now in verse, with interpolations of monologues, conversations, and letters in between the unhurried narrative. The form of the poem is highly flexible to accommodate the variety of themes which keep coming into it. Williams' unceasing experimentation in free verse and accentual verse is here brought to fruition. He succeeds in lifting, by use of his imagination and the language he hears, the material conditions and appearances of his environment to the sphere of the intelligence where they will have new currency.

Williams' recognition came later in his career. He lived long in the shadow of T. S. Eliot. After *The Waste Land* appeared in print, Williams feared that American poetry would be steered away from a primary focus on the temporal world to constructing beliefs based on a metaphysical foundation, and from its experimental forms to the traditional. And he was right. Not until the 1950s and 1960s did Eliot's influence begin to wane and Williams' poetry begin to have a chance to assert itself. By then Williams had labored in the poetic field for almost four decades. Now that his position as a major voice in modern American poetry was established, his poems began to exercise their influence on the general course of development of contemporary poetry. Paterson came out at a time when the domination of the New Criticism was questioned and began to

diminish. A whole new way of writing, a whole new kind of poetics, was becoming increasingly visible. The postwar generation needed new models and new paradigms for their creative endeavors. Paterson, bodying forth its author's emphasis on American locality and speech, his fresh moral vision, and his "always beginning anew" mode of writing, became attractive to the younger poets of the postwar period (along with Pound's *Cantos*). Williams became a prophet figure of the new age. In contemporary poetry Williams is a stronger influence, perhaps, than anybody else's. All major schools of poetry, be it the Confessional, or the Black Mountain, or the New York school, acknowledge their indebtedness to the literary theories and practice of this New Jersey physician-poet. One contemporary poet, Charles Olson, went as far as calling his generation "sons of Pound and Williams." Although, in a literary history of movements and counter-movements, no voice is the voice of poetry, Williams' has been a major one and as such has been heard attentively.

CHAPTER 13 Frost Sandburg Cummings Hart Crane Moore

Robert Frost (1874-1963)

A very common thing to occur to authors is to be misunderstood. Most suffer from misunderstanding and misrepresentation, but a few occasionally benefit. Of these rare few Robert Frost was one. If he became the most popular poet in postwar America ?indeed as popular as Longfellow once was if not more, that popularity stemmed in large measure from a prevailing misconception of Robert Frost as a lyrical poet, as an authentic painter of local landscape, and as a poet whose poetry it is always a delightful experience to read. Few are willing to admit that Robert Frost's universe can be terrifying, as Lionel Trilling once pointed out.

Robert Frost's way to recognition was a long one. It was not until he was forty that his first important volume, *North of Boston*, came out in England. He had gone there in 1912 and met, among others, Ezra Pound, who then tried to get him published because he heard a fresh voice in Frost. In 1915 Frost came back to the United States which recognized him as its bard. Thereafter his road to fame and popularity was smooth. He won the Pulitzer Prize four times and received commendations by the American Academy of Arts and Letters and the Poetry Society of America respectively in 1938 and 1941. He received honors from forty-four institutions, and became the nation's unofficial Poet Laureate when invited to read his poem at President Kennedy's inauguration in 1961.

The image of Robert Frost is one of a white-haired old sage who speaks and sings in a manner as pleasant as it is edifying. Reading his poetry ?or some of his poetry ?can be a highly ennobling and relaxing experience. Here the reader tends to find wit and wisdom, peace and harmony, serenity and joy, which serve for him as "a momentary stay against confusion." Take the famous "The Road Not Taken" for instance. "Two roads diverged in a yellow wood, / And sorry I could not travel both / And be one traveler, long I stood / And looked down one as far as I could / To where it bent in the undergrowth[.]" These lines present an archetypal human situation where man is faced with the difficulty of making choices. In one sense Frost ?or the speaker of his poem ?seems to suggest that the choice one makes would "[make] all the difference"; but the poet is too deep and too wise to be so absolute about life and people. There is a visible amount of skepticism, a disclaimer of a kind, about the difference the choice could make: "Then [I] took the other, just as fair, / And having perhaps the better claim, / Because it was grassy and wanted wears; / Though as for that the passing there / had worn them really about the same" (*italics mine*). What the speaker is saying is probably this, that ultimately life would come full circle and the roads

make no difference after all. And if we read further, we may find embedded in the texture of the poem a kind of complaint that life is too confining to offer us much leeway for options. The same can be said about "Mending Wall." One possible reading of the poem could be that it is about the sense of alienation inherent in life and human nature. There is truth in that, but the poem is about a lot more. It could be, for one thing, about understanding life and human nature. The "I" in the poem feels that he is wiser as he no longer lives in the darkness in which his neighbor, probably much older and much more experienced with life and people, is still moving. Actually the poem hints that the neighbor is the wiser because his experience has taught him the paradox of life and human nature: distance makes for closer relationships. Here we recall Benjamin Franklin's almanac adage: "Fish and visitors stink in three days." To be friends for good, people need to be close for no longer than three days and then stay apart for a while.

And Frost has been linked with the tradition of nature poetry. Frost did write very much in the Wordsworthian tradition, and there is a good deal of Emerson in him. Nature appears as an explicator and a mediator for man and serves as the center of reference for his behavior. It stands as a kind of perfection against confusion. In "Mowing" there is a momentary awareness of one's relationship to nature, an epiphany of some kind. In "Birches" there is an image, in the boy swinging, of relationship with nature, a moment of fullness and harmony and a sense of fulfillment achievable only in the healthy influence of nature. And a literal interpretation of the famous "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" can be that it represents a moment of relaxation from the onerous journey of life, an almost aesthetic enjoyment and appreciation of natural beauty which is wholesome and restorative against the chaotic existence of modern man.

In one sense at least, Robert Frost stood consciously aside from the Modernist endeavor of his time: he did not seem particularly enthusiastic about experimentation in form. Whereas the question for William Carlos Williams and Ezra Pound was how to get out of the "trap" of the traditional rhythm and the iambic pattern which they regarded as not true to contemporary experience, Frost was perfectly willing to follow that pattern, though only as a structure against which he broke the dramatic tones of meaning. In a sense he retained a faith in the traditional forms of poetry. For him form is as important as sense; the ordering of sound and theme is one major concern of his career. For him a poem is the product of the intersection, a crossing over, a joining of meaning, feeling and metrics, all elements which can be potentially contradictory and disjunctive. He tends to use the formal stanza pattern and may have taken an enormous delight in the fact that his meaning manages to strike across the rigidity of his meters. Thus he did not attempt, as Williams and Pound did, to break the back of traditional modes of poetry.

A natural question to ask about Frost is then how his poetry manages to stand up in the midst of all the breaks from tradition in the history of modern poetry? The answer is to be sought only in the basic thematic concern of the poet. At the bottom of his heart Frost was a modern man, keeping in step with the spirit of his times. The difficulty that Frost recognized is, as Allen Tate notes, that of maintaining the will to order in a world of confusion and chaos. All his life Frost was concerned with constructing, through poetry, "a momentary stay against confusion and chaos." "All I would keep for my self," he wrote at one time, "is the freedom of my material ?the condition of body and mind now and then to summons aptly from the vast chaos of all I have lived through." He sounds as if speaking in the Eliotic tone of "shoring these fragments against my ruins." Viewed in this spirit, the poems of Frost assume a sudden, somewhat different dimension. Indeed, Frost conquers with his unexpected illumination. A fresh look at "Birches" and "The Wood

Pile" reveals Frost's concern for order. In the former poem the poet admits that when he feels that life is becoming too tough for him, he would like to get away from the earth for a while, going back to be a swinger, and wishes that fate would willfully misunderstand him and snatch him away not to return ("And so I dream of going back to be. / It's I'm weary of considerations, / and life is too much like a pathless wood ... / I'd like to get away from earth awhile / And then come back to it and begin over"). But Frost is committed to life on earth, "Earth's right place for love: / I don't know where it's likely to go better." What he craves for is a momentary relief from the disorder of earthly life in the way the boy, swinging, leaves the ground but returns when "the tree could bear no more." "The Wood Pile" is likewise a metaphor for order. It begins with the narrator far from home and deep in snow in an alien world, full of fear like the bird in the woods (which for Frost can have ominous meaning) and uncertain where to turn in this cold universe. Then he sees a woodpile: "It was a cord of maple, cut and split / And piled ?and measured four by four by eight." Against a background of unpredictability and confusion, here is something that generates a sense of order. It is the only order created by men. The woodpile is there, like Stevens' jar in Tennessee, controlling and consoling, filling a vacuum with some human significance, giving form and meaning to the shapeless and meaningless world around it. The poet is struck by the fact that the man has left his woodpile for some fresh tasks, a fact that suggests the transience of a man-created order.

Although Frost depicts mostly New England landscape, those scenes of rural life often reflect the fragmentization of modern experience. Frost is keenly aware of this and portrays and interprets it in his poetry. At moments Frost is very close to the "slough of despond" but he nearly always manages to draw back. The world of Frost can appall and terrify. The short poem, "Design," can overwhelm one with a great sense of uncertainty and fear. The spectacle of the white spider holding a white moth on a white flower enables one to glimpse at the "design of darkness" that governs the world and reflect on the impotence of its inhabitants, including, by extension, man. If we compare Frost's poem with Edward Taylor's work on the spider catching a fly, we will readily see Frost's modern outlook on life: whereas Taylor sees the spider as a symbol of Hell opposed to God's will, Frost associates it with a grand scheme which he speculates might be part of God's own design. Even the lovely "Stopping by Woods" is not completely free of tragic connotation in lines such as "Between the woods and the frozen lake / The darkest evening of the year," implying, among other things, a death-wish of some kind. To the person passing through the woods on his way from one village to another (both symbolic of the human world of obligations), the "dark and deep" natural world of the woods proves lovely and fascinating: "He [my little horse] gives his harness bells a shake / To ask if there is some mistake. / The only other sound's the sweep / Of easy wind and downy flake." Evidently the passenger would like to stay forever in comforting nature from the exacting life of commitments, but he changes his mind on second thought. Somewhat recharged by his brief stay in nature, he feels better, remembers that he has "promises to keep," and is now ready to face the "miles" stretching before him. After all, no place is better than this world; here goes the main idea of "Birches" again. And the first three stanzas of "Desert Places" adumbrate such an alarming landscape of desolation and loneliness that, if there had not been the last redeeming stanza, we might have called Frost the modern poet of solitude: "And lonely as it is, that loneliness / Will be more lonely ere it will be less ?/ A blanker whiteness of benighted snow / With no expression, nothing to express."

Another frightening aspect of Frost's poems is seen in the great number of abnormal people

they talk about. These people suffer no less than the grotesques of Sherwood Anderson's Winesburg, Ohio. Let us take a look at some of Frost's works in his North of Boston. The mother in "Home Burial" about to crack up with grief over her child's death, the common-law wife in "The Fear" with her desires disguised as obsessions, the lunatic in "A Servant to Servants" who makes life bitter and hideous for all as well as himself—all these indicate Frost's awareness that something has gone wrong with the land and its way of life. Poems like "The Black Cottage" and "The Generations of Men" all describe the feeling of alienation among modern men.

Robert Frost is often deceptively simple. His poems can be read very often on many levels. He did write, for instance, about his remote and primitive New England, but, as John F. Lynen observes, he made it "a medium for examining the urban world of his day, a standard by which to evaluate it, and a context within which to discover the order underlying the experience that modern life has obscured and confused." What Frost did was in fact to juxtapose the regional and the cosmopolitan, and the human and the natural, in a word, to root his poetry in New England to reach the plane of universal meaning. He was good at exploring the complexity of human existence through treating seemingly trivial subjects, and had always in view the ultimate aim in writing of making life "whole again beyond confusion": "Back out of all this now too much for us," he writes in "Directive," "Your destination and your destiny's / A brook that was the water of the house..." and "Here are your waters and your watering place / Drink and be whole again beyond confusion."

Carl Sandburg (1878-1967)

Carl Sandburg was one of the Mid-west prairie poets that became known in the Chicago Renaissance (1912-1925). At about the same time Robinson and Robert Frost were writing and publishing in the east, the Chicago poets Vachel Lindsay (1879-1931), Edgar Lee Masters (1869-1950) and Carl Sandburg were making their voice heard in the Mid-west. These poets, along with other writers and artists in Chicago, made Chicago a center of literature and arts, and in the field of poetry, added to the momentum of the new verse then locked in battle with the dominant genteel tradition of the time. Vachel Lindsay had close contact with the lower strata of social life. He was a poet devoted to social reform. He was in a sense an idealist, dreamed of building the US into the best place in the world, and hoping to see a society emerge in which religion, equality, and beauty prevail. His work, "General William Booth Enters into Heaven" (1913), reveals the poet as a dreamer, believing that God would help realize the ideal impossible in real life. The success of his two other poems, "The Congo" and "Santa Fe Trail," established him as a modern minstrel. Lindsay read his poetry and sang his songs in public, and spoke for the people. The few years before 1920 was the most creative period of his career, and after that his works showed a visible decline in power. Coupled with the fact that his writing was not well received in a world in which Eliot and Pound dominated, Lindsay committed suicide in 1931. There is no doubt, however, that he made his contribution to the fight against the genteel tradition.

Edgar Lee Masters made himself famous with the publication of his first volume of verse, *Spoon River Anthology*. It is a collection of 200-odd elegiac poems, portraying 200-odd different characters from all walks of life: workers, farmers, clergymen, clerks, prostitutes, judges, poets, philosophers, scientists, soldiers, atheists, Christians etc. —almost everyone, now dead, but once associated with Spoon River town by birth or in some other way. Nineteen plot lines intertwine and correlate to present the workings of the society of the town. The ghosts come alive telling their diverse life stories of noble ideals, or mediocre thoughts, or dreams not come true, or petty

jealousy, or sexual love, murders, suicides etc. very much in the fashion of 18th-century poet Thomas Gray's *An Elegy Written in a Country Churchyard*. But the collection is not spooky. It is human and humorous. As it delves into the depths of the human soul, reveals the seamy side of social life, and reflects local customs and historical changes, it became popular instantly. It is also significant as a censure of the corruption and depravity of which a small town is capable and of the genteel tradition in general. Masters was a productive writer. In addition to the 20-odd volumes of verse, he wrote 13 plays, seven novels, and nine biographies. As he failed to offer anything better, his first work became his best.

Now we come to Carl Sandburg, the greatest of the prairie poets. In popularity Carl Sandburg came next after Robert Frost. This was indeed as it should be. For Sandburg's most cherished ideal in life was to be "the word of the people," to articulate in song the thoughts, feelings, and aspirations of ordinary men and women. Sandburg's poetic career can be divided into three not exactly distinct phases. He had begun writing poetry when he was in college and had published a collection of poems, *In Reckless Ecstasy* (1904), but he did not become known as a poet until his first volume, *Chicago Poems*, was put out by a nationally known publisher in 1916. This was followed by *Cornhuskers* (1918), *Smoke and Steel* (1920) and *Slabs of the Sunburnt West* (1922). He continued to write and publish such collections as *Good Morning, America* (1928), *The People, Yes* (1936), and *Collected Poems* (1951). As a poet he was associated with the Imagists and wrote well-known Imagist poems such as "Fog", "Lost ?", "Monotone," "The Harbor," and "Nocturne in a Deserted Brickyard." His longer poems also show Imagist influence. Sandburg had also taken interest in folk songs which he tried to collect and sing during his travels. These included songs of cowboys, hobos, and Black spirituals which eventually appeared in print in his well-known *The American Songbag* (1927). This love of folklore developed in time into a rather modern tendency to represent it in literature such as in his *The People, Yes*. Then, Sandburg turned to the writing of a multi-volume biography of Abraham Lincoln, *The Prairie Years* (1926) and *The War Years* (1940), a work on which his reputation mainly rested at one time. He also wrote an autobiography and a historical novel of some kind.

Carl Sandburg was probably the only great poet who wrote in the Whitmanesque tradition in the present century. Like Whitman, he contains "multitudes." It is not fair to say that he does not see the evils of modern life. In his "The Harbor," the city of Chicago presents a sight of evil and frustration, with its huddled and ugly walls, its women with their hunger-deep eyes, "haunted with shadows of hunger-hands." Here is a city, wicked and crooked, where prostitutes sell their bodies and gunmen kill and go free to kill again ("Chicago"). His sympathy for the people living in the shanties, the \$6 a week department store girls and the mass of the jobless poor was warm and strong as is seen from poems such as "To a Contemporary Bunkshooter." And he could be very despondent and desolate as he is in "Cool Tomb." But Sandburg wrote chiefly "to help the sick and give the people hope." He knew the importance of the people, "the mob," better than any of his contemporaries. It is the people who have done the great work of the world, who have invented and produced food and clothes, witnessed history and sent forth Napoleons and Lincolns. He was confident in the belief that the people will one day rise and come into their own. A careful reading of his works like "I am the People, the Mob" in which the poet identifies himself with the people he speaks for will readily reveal Sandburg at one with the masses.

Sandburg was, therefore, optimistic. He saw an America of "tomorrows" and wrote about it in his poems such as "The Prairie":

Sandburg's attitude toward the industrial and mechanical civilization that America was developing was essentially affirmative. It was costing human blood and exacting a heavy toll of human suffering, but then since man made the steel and the machine, it would eventually work toward the amelioration of his lot. Man would come out of the ordeal triumphant and better off, and laugh the best. With all its wickedness and brutalities and hunger and suffering, Chicago is, in his eyes, a city vital, vibrant, proud, and laughing as a mainstay to the nation ("Chicago").

Sandburg was a socialist. His was a hearty voice from the masses of the people he had close contact with all his life. Possibly partly because of this and partly because of the fact that his vision is, to a good many critics like M. L. Rosenthal (who has few if any words of praise for him), found wanting in depth, he did not receive the kind of critical attention he deserved. Sandburg kept in step with the evolution of modern poetry. He joined the poetic revolution which Pound, Eliot and Williams were making then, and wrote in free verse and rich and spontaneous slang. His contribution to the colloquial style in America should be given due recognition. Although he was not happy with the critical world which he accused of being snobbish, he did win a good measure of popular acclaim. Moreover, he was awarded the American Poetry Society prize in 1919 and 1920, and the Pulitzer Prize in 1950 when his *Complete Poems* was brought out. Today Carl Sandburg stands, and rightfully, alongside the other great masters of modern poetry in American literary history.

E. E. Cummings (1894-1963)

To the common readers of poetry the usual response that the name of E. E. Cummings evokes is probably a broad smile, not of mockery, but of amused appreciation. E. E. Cummings was probably the most interesting experimentalist in modern American poetry. "A juggler with syntax, grammar, and diction," he wrote entirely regardless of any established conventions of poetry, thus becoming a symbol of the modern pioneering spirit in modern American literary history.

There were forces, both cultural and social, at work shaping E. E. Cummings into a poet. While at Harvard, the future poet became aware of poetic influences such as Tennyson, Keats, Rossetti, Swinburne, and the Decadents of the 1890s. Then the discovery of free verse led him toward the modern verse revolution as he found it in Amy Lowell's Imagist anthologies and the little magazines of the time. A very important fact to note in the appreciation of E. E. Cummings is that he was also a modern painter, fascinated with Post-Impressionist and Cubist paintings and sculptures and with C 闕 anne, Duchamp, Picasso and other modern masters. It was largely the prevailing rebellious spirit in the art and literature of the time that moved the dynamic personality of e. e. cummings to challenge tradition and assert its individuality in his daring experiments.

His propensity for anti-orthodox innovation picked up a good deal of robust energy from his antagonism to what Dos Passos terms "the machine," both social and mechanical. During the First World War, he was wrongly accused of espionage and detained in a French concentration camp for three months. His anger with this outrage of individual liberty finds adequate expression in his somewhat autobiographical narrative, *The Enormous Room* (1922). And e. e. cummings' hatred for science and technology was as strong as Thoreau's if not stronger. He went as far as shunning the radio and the television in his house. What enraged him was the inhumanity of science and materialism which made it impossible for mankind to be human. As a matter of fact, E. E. Cummings was formally employed only once, and that for just three months, in the whole of his adult life: life was too valuable for him to squander in getting ahead in the world of material

successes.

Most of the youthful poems he wrote while at Harvard are traditional in form. However, a creative jump into the unconventional forms and themes occurred in the latter part of 1916 after he left Harvard. He began his long journey of poetic innovation, writing poems that revealed a radical break from tradition. He played with language on his typewriter, dabbled in cubist painting and read the latest criticism on modern art and literature. His experiments included new spatial arrangements, both horizontal and vertical, new poems based on patterns of vowel or consonant groups, linguistic constructions dealing with "unpoetic" subjects ?casual conversations, banal statements, urban impressions ?all presented by means of a variety of voices and a range of tones. He was moving toward a mature, personal style. After his return from the World War I, he composed some of his best work, some of the most sexually intense poems and some cubist poems. For the next couple of years (1918-1920) E. E. Cummings wrote mostly love poems and poems which handle such motifs as the coming of dawn, an urban scene in snowfall, and a satiric rendering of religious preaching. In the 1920s e. e. cummings tried to write in the spirit of cubism or dadaism, using unusual diction and phrasing. Gradually a distinct Cummings style came to maturity. In the last thirty years of his life, his linguistic play was more fully developed and controlled, with "his scrambled word order in syntactic anagram, his extension of the semantic possibilities of words he chooses to stretch, squeeze, or intensify by typographical acrobatics or grammatical innovations."

His basic outlook on life and society became more evident. He values vitality ("aliveness"), celebrates individualism and rejects groupiness. His abhorrence of collectivism and conformity is forcefully expressed in some of his poems. The usual themes on love and lust recur; an increasing number of nature poems reveal the poet's fascination with a world, often a child's world, born anew with its simplicity, innocence and spontaneous joy. In form he was writing, as M. L. Rosenthal noted, as if "juggling" with syntax, grammar, and diction, and with verbal effects. His poems, more ideogrammatical and pictorial than aural, with its low-case, peculiar punctuation, and jamming of words, produce often a shocking effect and reveal the author's attitude of nonconformity. In fact Cummings' assault is spearheaded against almost everything doggedly held as accepted and established.

Let's quote a couple of Cummings poems to conclude our discussion here. First, there is the frequently anthologized "Chanson Innocenter":

in Just ?
spring when the world is mud-
luscious the little
lame balloonman

whistles far and wee

and eddieandbill come
running from marbles and
piracies and it's
spring.

when the world is puddle-wonderful

the queer
old balloonman whistles
far and wee
and bettyandisbel come dancing
from hop-scotch and jump-rope and

it's
spring
and
the

goat-footed

balloonman whistles
far
and
wee

Here spring comes, the earth becomes mud-luscious, boys and girls, Eddie, Bill, Betty and Isabel, dance in groups of twos in joy on the playground, and the goat-footed balloonman ("goat-footed" alluding to the riotous followers of Dionysus, the wine-god in Greek mythology) appears on the scene to add to the children's "and the world's "delight at the revival of life and rebirth of the universe which they celebrate. As Barry A. Marks observes in his E. E. Cummings, "The spacing of his words suggests the children's shared pleasure, the instinctive hurry and jostle of their play, and their delight in the balloonman's appearance."

"O sweet spontaneous" is a paean of the eternal life force of the earth and a censure of the destruction that man has done to it in various forms. Here are listed the doting philosophers, the "naughty" science, and the oppressive religions, all of which have tried to encroach on earth, but earth has always responded with its life-generating spring:

O sweet spontaneous
earth how often have
the
doting

fingers of
prurient philosophers pinched
and
poked

thee
, has the naughty thumb
of science prodded
thy

beauty. how

often have religions taken
thee upon their scraggy knees
squeezing and

buffeting thee that thou mightest conceive
gods
(but
true

to the incomparable
couch of death thy
rhythmic
lover

thou answerest

them only with
spring)

Hart Crane (1899-1932)

Hart Crane was one of the best American poets of the twentieth century. He began writing poetry in his early teens, and published his first poem at 17. His early work, carried in *Little Review*, revealed the imprint of Elizabethan literature and French symbolism and recorded his high-strung state of mind and homosexual orientation. Believing that he had found his life's work, he tried to perfect his poetic art in poverty and fatigue, and became more and more addicted to alcohol. Never on good terms with his divorced parents (he grew up with his grandparents and tended to take his mother's side in his parents' quarrels), he left home and went to New York, where he got to know some well-known literary figures such as Waldo Frank, Malcolm Cowley, and Allen Tate. There, with the help of a financier, he was able to focus on writing. His first volume of verse, *White Buildings*, came out in 1926, and was received with mixed feelings. His major work, *The Bridge*, was published in 1930, and its critical reception was far from unanimous. As he had worked hard at it for seven long years (1924-1930) and had had greater expectations, the lukewarm response left him inconsolably dejected. For a long time now, Crane had been feeling emotionally stressed out: his unstable life, the death of his father, the alienation that he experienced from his mother and later from many friends, and on top of it all the Depression of the 1930s which destroyed his faith in the future—all these conspired to bring incredible pressure on his increasingly fragile nerve system. In 1930 he traveled to Mexico, hoping to write a long poem on Mexican history and loosen up a little at the same time. But he jumped into the sea on his way back to New York in April, 1932. He was 32 then.

Crane was a voracious reader. He had his own views on poets and poetry. In one of his letters he said that he did not quite like Elizabeth Browning, Tennyson, Thomson, Chatterton, Byron, Moore, Milton, and some others, and that he admired Poe, Whitman, Shakespeare, Keats, Shelley, Coleridge, Donne, Webster, Marlow, Baudelaire, Laforgue, and Dante. In addition, the works of T. S. Eliot and Ezra Pound had an immense impact on his poetry. Crane's *White Buildings* includes 23 poems of his early career, one of which, "For the Marriage of Faustus and

Helen," a long poem, expresses his views on beauty, love, and rebirth, and was meant to be a response to T. S. Eliot's kind of "cultural pessimism." The marriage of Faustus with Helen, a scene which appears in Christopher Marlowe's poetic drama, *The Tragical History of Doctor Faustus*, became for Crane a recurrent symbol of modern life, a structural splice, in his poetry, especially in his *The Bridge*. Other poems such as "Voyages" and "At Melville's Tomb" exhibit the poet's insistence on the use of the sea as a complex image. Some critics see "The Voyages" as the poet's best work. Crane's masterwork, *The Bridge*, taking the bridge –the Brooklyn Bridge –as an emblem of life and of the ideal future of America, was meant to be another vehement response to T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*. Crane's *Collected Poems* was published in 1933 and reprinted in 1958. *The Complete Poems and Selected Letters and Prose*, which came out in 1966, includes all the poems of the early and late periods of his life that had been either never included anywhere or published in various magazines.

The critical appraisal of Crane's poetry has gone through different phases. In the early 1930s *The Bridge* was controversial. Some major critics seemed to be inclined to think of Crane as possessing some genius which he did not use wisely. The labor-intensive work, *The Bridge*, was seen basically as a failure. However, a new perception regarding his poetry began to develop since 1937, the year in which his biography appeared. A critical biography was out in 1948, to be followed by a commentary reevaluating the long poem. 1952 saw the publication of Crane's collected letters. Ever since then, a favorable reassessment by famous critics has successfully established Crane's place in American literature. His reputation has been on the increase. Over the years in both spirit and language Crane has exerted a measure of influence on the works of his contemporaries such as Horace Gregory and on the writings of younger poets like Robert Lowell, Dylan Thomas, Karl Shapiro, and John Berryman.

The Bridge is one of the long poems to come out of the twentieth-century American modern epic tradition, ranking alongside *The Waste Land*, the *Cantos*, and *Paterson*. Crane moved to New York in 1924 and happened to stay in the apartment in which Washington Roebling, the architect who designed the Brooklyn Bridge, once lived. There looking at the bridge out of his window, the young poet felt moved and inspired to write an epic in praise of the colossus. He spent seven years on the conception and composition of the work, and brought it to finish in 1930. Now in retrospect, the poem is in fact the most majestic of its kind since *The Waste Land*. What Crane tried to accomplish was to offer a modern, mythic synthesis of the American experience, with which to help make sense of it, reveal the close relationship between the present and the past and show the hope for the future. He regards the Brooklyn Bridge as a symbol of America's future and its unique identity, and sees hope in the mechanical civilization that his contemporaries had ruthlessly censured. It is evident that Crane was writing about the myth of America in "an epic of modern consciousness" (to quote Crane's own description of the poem).

The Bridge consists of the poem and eight sections, totaling 15 poems. The poem, "To Brooklyn Bridge," imaging a well poised and free seagull, contrasting it with the confining existence of a clerk, and linking it with the Bridge, puts forward the theme of the long poem –the hope for and the problems of America. The first section, "Ave Maria," a monologue of Columbus', delineates the man's thoughts on his way home after his discovery of the New World. Here Columbus acts as a mask for the poet-speaker, connecting the two sensibilities of the European past and the American present. The second section, "Powhatan's Daughter," consists of five poems in praise of Pocahontas (the famous American Indian princess of myth and legends) as the frame

of reference for measuring modern life. These include "The Harbor Dawn," "Van Winkle," "The River," "The Dance," and "Indiana." The daughter of Powhatan, Pocahontas by name, is seen as the Goddess of North America, the Ideal, who inspired the generations of Americans to move forward. "The Harbor Dawn" introduces the goddess, presenting the poet-speaker's vision of the princess in the modern city. In "Van Winkle," telling as it does about an American legend, the poet-speaker merges with the legendary character in his poetic quest. "The River," referring to the Mississippi, talks about its connection with the American Indian culture and the "white" civilization. In "The Dance," which focuses on the American Indians, the poet-speaker as an Indian is united with Pocahontas, dies sacrificially in a ritual dance, is resurrected and symbolically united with the princess, now a symbol of America. "Indiana" touches on the transition from American Indian culture to that of the whites in a sentimental portrayal of the mythical lady, and wraps up the section as a whole. The third section of the long poem, "Cutty Shark," reproduces the conversation the poet-speaker has with a phantom sailor, mentioning in the end the wreck and the loss of the ship. In the next, the fourth section, "Cape Hatteras," the poet-speaker seems to celebrate technological advances, renews his Whitmanesque faith, rejects pessimism, and becomes spokesman for the New World. "Three Songs," the fifth section, include three subdivisions, "Southern Cross," "National Winter Garden," and "Virginia," presenting various perversions of Pocahontas in modern life. The next section, the sixth, "Quaker Hill," mentions the spread of philistinism in the wake of commercialization in a tone that suddenly drops to gloom and dejection. "The Tunnel," the seventh section, occupies a pivotal position in the whole epic. Describing the monotonous motion on the subway, portraying its overall filthy environment, and recording fragments of conversations overheard, the mood of the speaker sinks to the lowest of the low, as if he was right down in Hell. He identifies with Poe, somehow, and then exits to stand by the East River and see the harbor, indicating a kind of resurrection in process. The poem ends with its eighth section, "Atlantis," which is full of passionate praise, extolling the mythical city as symbolic of a hopeful future. Contrasting in tone with "The Tunnel," they manage, between them, to keep the double keynotes of the whole poem running parallel to the end. The double keynotes are necessary in view of the fact that the whole poem represents a quest for the Ideal, a progressive overcoming of its antitheses ?the horror, for instance, as embodied in the image of the sea in "Ave Maria," the inhuman historic evolution at the end of "The River," the savagery as shown in "The Tunnel," and added to all these the poet-speaker's own unpleasant experiences in his youth. The Bridge is a national historic epic which Crane tried to compose. Intended to be an answer to the pessimism of T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*, The Bridge represents the poet's desire to search for faith and harmony in an age in which both seemed conspicuously lacking to him. It also suggests the poet's effort to link past and present, old and new, East and West, and man and God. The whole of it sounds like a huge symphony, the movements of which are gleaned from the major myths of America ?Pocahontas, Rip Van Winkle, Melville, Poe, Whitman, Columbus, the subway, Atlantis ?and carefully interwoven together with an immense imaginative power. Nowhere else is Crane's quest motif for harmony, love, and beauty brought to such prominence. As to its weakness, the work may appear to be incoherent in certain parts of it, its images and symbolism may hamper reading and comprehension, and it is structurally capable of leaving loose ends untended. But critical consensus has been reached that it is a great work here to stay.

Let's take a look at the critical section, "The Tunnel," one of the best poems in the long work,

before we move on. The tunnel here, as noted earlier on, refers to the subway. The section is well known for its description of one major experience of city life – riding on the subway. There are in the tunnel the dinning noise, the bits and fragments of on-and-off conversations, the staring eyes, the dim light, the sudden stop and start jerks at each and every one of the stations, the train making abrupt turns etc. All these dreadful and hateful scenes get their full share of apt depiction in the poem. Crane calls the tunnel a kind of purgatory; he spearheads his thematic thrust against the encroachments that the machine makes upon the humankind. However, although the subway presents such a disconcerting sight, the poet-speaker refuses to succumb to pessimism:

O caught like pennies beneath soot and steam,
Kiss of our agony thou gatherest;
Condensed, thou takest all the shrill ganglia
Impassioned with some song we fail to keep.
And yet, like Lazarus, to feel the slope,
The sod and billow breaking, the lifting ground,

A sound of waters bending astride the sky
Unceasing with some Word that will not die.

The possibility of resurrection, embedded in the parable of Lazarus in the Gospel of John (11: 43-44), and the Word, which for Crane equates with the Ideal or God, manage to offer a consoling relief. This note of affirmation is reinforced in no small way by the sacred "Hand of Fire" that appears at the end of the section, thus allowing a ray of light and hope to shine through the ambient gloom:

Kiss of our agony Thou gatherest,
O Hand of Fire
gatherest?

Marianne Moore (1887-1972)

Marianne Moore was born in Missouri and graduated from Bryn Mawr where she had H. D. as her classmate. Her poems began to appear in the Poetry magazine around 1915 and impressed the readers with its newness and vivacity. For some time (1925-1929) she was editor of the literary magazine, the Dial, and was instrumental in publishing many of the best poets of the time. Over the years Marianne Moore's poetry has won admiration from diverse quarters such as William Carlos Williams and T. S. Eliot. In 1951 her Collected Poems appeared and won a Pulitzer Prize, the Bollingen Prize, and a National Book Award. Her Complete Poems came out in print in 1967. Her poems on exotic animals and plants and things such as steamrollers won many awards for her. Late in life Marianne Moore became nationally famous also as a baseball fan.

Marianne Moore has a unique place in the history of American poetry. Native grown and original, she did a couple of things for which she is and will be remembered. One of these was the fact that she was one of the first "new" poets in the first years of the twentieth century along with William Carlos Williams and Wallace Stevens. These people met and talked about serious subjects such as the function of poetry and the role and value of the artists. All of them were part of the Imagist movement from which Marianne Moore learned a lot of poetic craft. Imbibing the contagious influence from Europe and Paris, and in the exciting innovative milieu of the American 1920s, Marianne Moore underwent her self-discovery as a poet of the new order. She took an enormous interest both in herself as a poet and in poetry as a new, experimental form of

expression. For Marianne Moore, poetry is the most important concern. Poetry is important because it encases the essence of life and reality. Her poem, "Poetry," is a graphic statement of her views in this regard. The job of a poet, as she suggests here, is try not to be a half poet, but a "literalist of the imagination" and endeavor to exalt, by inspiration, the insolent and trivial to the level of imaginative reality. Writing is a continuous process of discovering "the genuine," or "the usefulness" of the raw materials of poetry. To write good poetry, it is essential to understand all the phenomena of life and discriminate against nothing that may be seen as lacking in the poetic. Her views on poetry in relation to life are very much akin to those of William Carlos Williams.

Another thing for which Moore is remembered as an influence over younger poets of later times such as Elizabeth Bishop is her observation of minute details in things great or small. This is, naturally, linked with her poetic credo. Never biased against anything including the trivial, the banal, and the sordid and ugly, and sensitive and observant by nature, Marianne Moore was good at catching hold of the poetic in the varied manifestations of mundane reality around her. "The Fish" is a good case in point. The description here, vivid, and imagistic, reveals an acute pair of eyes that sees pictures even in the poses and creatures where the poetic or "the genuine" often (if not always) suffers neglect and oversight.

One other notable feature of Marianne Moore's poetry is worth mentioning because it is conspicuous with her: it is often full of well chosen quotations which, however, present little or no difficulty as the poet always furnishes notes for her sources. Her poems such as "Silence" and "The Student" come immediately to mind in this connection.

CHAPTER 14 Fitzgerald Hemingway

F. Scott Fitzgerald (1896-1940)

Just as Mark Twain and William Dean Howells grew up thinking that America would become the hope of the world and became very bitter old men in the end, so F. Scott Fitzgerald and Ernest Hemingway as young people were very enthusiastic and excited about this new world they were living in but lived to realize eventually that, instead of success, it was all disaster. For Fitzgerald, who lived in the midst of the "roaring twenties" and was part of it all ?driving fast cars, drinking hard whisky, and taking an immense delight in it, America was, he was perceptive enough to understand, "a moon that never rose." As much as he enjoyed the "roaring" of the postwar boom years, he foresaw its doom and failure.

Fitzgerald was born in 1896 into a St. Paul middle-class family. His father was gentlemanly but unsuccessful in business. Scott had an expensive education first in private schools, and then at Princeton, where he became part of the intellectual set, the Triangle Club, which included, among others, Edmund Wilson. He began to write for the shows of the club, became editor of a university magazine, and was developing a reputation. He felt that he was heading for the upper class life in which he would play a leading part as a writer. Then he had to leave Princeton, probably partly because of his academic record that had suffered from his illness and from too heavy an extra-curriculum schedule and also because the First World War that was going on offered him a good excuse to stay away for a while. A year's absence from the university wounded his pride and ambition so that it ironed itself into his consciousness as one of the major disappointments he suffered in his short, unhappy life. He returned to Princeton only to stay for another year in which he managed to finish the draft of his first novel, *This Side of Paradise*. Then he left for the army.

Fitzgerald was never sent abroad. One of the major events during the period of 15 months of

service was his meeting Zelda Sayre in the same way as Gatsby meets Daisy. Zelda was the daughter of a judge in Montgomery, Alabama, a beautiful society girl, who told Fitzgerald that she liked him well enough but was too expensive for him. After his discharge from the army early in 1919, it became apparent that he had no means of supporting this woman with such great financial and social expectations; he had no way of making a fortune by writing advertisements in New York. Zelda soon broke their engagement, in June, and Fitzgerald went back to his father's home to rewrite his novel. Six months later he surfaced again in Montgomery, this time triumphant with the news that his novel had been accepted and promised to sell well. Zelda agreed to marry him when the novel was published. *This Side of Paradise* is not really very good because juvenile, but is historically interesting. It became immensely popular for the simple reason that it caught the tone of the age. Essentially autobiographical, the book describes Fitzgerald's sense of failure with his academic performance and the frustration of his dreams at Princeton. It portrays at the same time a generation, his generation, feeling frustrated with life in which all gods are dead, all wars are fought, all faith in man is shaken. On the strength of this one successful book, Fitzgerald won the expensive prize of Zelda, and began, in a sense, his onerous life of making money to support her. This affected his writing tremendously. The Fitzgeralds stormed into New York as the pattern of youth, wealth, and beauty and became the admiration of all who met them.

This was also a period in which short stories were very profitable; *The Saturday Evening Post* was paying \$4 000 a story to its best writers. Both Fitzgerald and Hemingway were thought of in their day as short-story writers: it was the short story that made them popular. The Fitzgeralds lived in expensive style, and their need for money was tremendous. Scott Fitzgerald wrote at a rapid speed and made a fabulous amount of money, which went as soon as it came. Out of his voluminous writings in the early twenties came two collections, *Flappers and Philosophers* (1920) which glittered with the image of the Fitzgeralds as the symbol of an American ideal (the word "flapper," used to describe the new woman of the postwar period, became widespread henceforward), and *Tales of the Jazz Age* (1922) which, like Mark Twain's *The Gilded Age*, gave its name to an important historical period in the history of the country. The 1920s, or "the Jazz age," was, in the words of Malcolm Cowley, "not so much a historical period as a legend of glitter, of recklessness, and of talent in such profusion that it was sown broadcast like wild oats." It was a legend of "Americans adolescence before pain set in." Fitzgerald became "the angel of the twenties" and his writings those of a man inside that legendary period.

In 1922 Fitzgerald finished his second novel, *The Beautiful and the Damned*. He wrote, as usual, a good deal of himself into it. Here is a world of parties, similar in grandeur and extravagance to those of Gatsby's, and amid boisterous, reckless merry-making there is unmistakable anxiety over money, gloomy spiritual barrenness, and a hint of decadence and decay. The silhouette of Fitzgerald as the tragic hero of the period, first seen in *This Side of Paradise*, became more definable here. *The Beautiful and the Damned* is interesting especially as a sort of first attempt at writing *The Great Gatsby*: its theme is the same as that of the later book though the writing is not as great. Meanwhile, the Fitzgeralds were living, on the proceeds of Scott's books and stories, the life of the people who go to Gatsby's crazy parties. Fitzgerald began to feel the decline of his powers as a writer. Thus it was amazing that he was still artistically whole enough to produce in Paris his masterpiece, *The Great Gatsby* (1925). The Fitzgeralds had gone there from New York and met Hemingway and Gertrude Stein, among others. After this Fitzgerald wrote one more important book, *Tender is the Night*, and some collections of short stories such as *All the Sad*

Young Men and Taps at Reveille. *Tender is the Night* seeks to trace the moral doom of its protagonist to the sapping influence of wealth and portrays an America dying, in bar-room brawls and decadence, of spiritual sterility and meaninglessness which characterized the times. All the Sad Young Men, including one of its author's best stories, "The Rich Boy," and the satirical Taps at Reveille both reveal the anguish of a man who had been all along a member of the party and yet seen all the while the moment when the party would be disastrously over.

Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald were not always happy in their married life. They were loving each other without question at all. The charm, glow, and the pathos of their flamboyant life together had been an inspiration for Fitzgerald. But they were also fighting each other all the time, partly over Zelda's ambition to be a writer herself. Fitzgerald might have used her ideas without giving her any credit. He declared that there was to be one writer in the family, so he kept her down all the while. Now Zelda, not an emotionally and mentally strong woman, began to have breakdowns and, before long, had to be put in a mental institution. This occurred in the early thirties ?it was a tragic time. Fitzgerald was cracking up. Meanwhile, he had to write harder to earn more money to send Zelda to the best mental hospital in the country and their daughter, Scottie, to the best and most fashionable school.

Three things eventually combined to break him down: loneliness, alcohol, and the awareness that he was dissipating his talent. Even in the best of their days together, Scott Fitzgerald, as an artist, was sober enough to feel alien to the "vanity fair" of which both he and Zelda were an integral part, and as a man at once infatuated with an ideal and emaciated by an unduly early awareness of its deceptive character, he had always stood mentally aloof from the spectacle which kept passing before him. Fitzgerald was always a heavy drinker. As his life became a tragic mess, he tried to find solace in his cups. It was alcohol as much as anything that killed him in the end. To a man who valued artistic integrity over and above anything else, nothing hurt more than the acute consciousness that, by writing trash for popular magazines in order to make money, he was frittering away his talent. Fitzgerald was tormented virtually all his life by the fact that he could not concentrate on the novel and the improvement of his art in general.

Between 1934 and 1937 Fitzgerald was on the brink of despair and disintegration. He was ill with tuberculosis, drank more heavily, and made two unsuccessful attempts at suicide. By 1937 he recovered well enough to accept a writing contract for Hollywood. There for a year and a half he had to work on some very embarrassing movies, but under the healthy restorative influence of Sheila Graham, a movie columnist, he began to live a quiet productive life. Late in 1938 he was dismissed from his work, and thereafter the decline was steady. He wrote some more short stories, stayed in a New York hospital for several months, and began in the last year of his life, one very interesting novel, entitled *The Last Tycoon*, which he never finished. It is the tragic story of a man who begins to realize all the show of life. As Fitzgerald explained, it is not meant to be sad despite the fact that it may end on a tragic note. Here amid gloom and doom, Fitzgerald the artist made his final attempt to muster all his powers in the creation of a work of art, and succeeded in doing so in the fragment that he wrote. Here the author is in sure control of his powers, so that John Dos Passes sees "the beginning of a real grand style." Had he finished it, the book would have been a great success to set alongside *The Great Gatsby*. In 1940, at the age of 44, he died, of frustration. He had been dead and forgotten as a writer long before. After his death, his friend, Edmund Wilson, put together some of his very interesting writings ?letters, and a series of confessional articles about his feelings of frustration and failure ?into a book called *The Crack-Up*. The

collection reveals the intense agony of a dedicated artist living through all the ordeals of a kaleidoscopic mundane existence.

Fitzgerald's greatness lies in the fact that he found intuitively, in his personal experience, the embodiment of that of the nation and created a myth out of American life. The story of *The Great Gatsby* is a good illustration. Gatsby is a poor youth from the Midwest. He falls in love with Daisy, a wealthy girl, but is too poor to marry her. The girl is then married to a rich young man, Tom Buchanan. Determined to win his lost love back, Gatsby engages himself in bootlegging and other "shady" activities, thus earning enough money to buy a magnificent imitation French villa. There he spreads dazzling parties every weekend in the hope of alluring the Buchanans to come. They finally come and Gatsby meets Daisy again, only to find that the woman before him is not quite the ideal love of his dreams. A sense of loss and disillusionment comes over him. Then Daisy kills a woman in an accident, and plots with Tom to shift the blame on Gatsby. So Gatsby is shot and the Buchanans escape.

Now Gatsby's life follows a clear pattern: there is, at first, a dream, then a disenchantment, and finally a sense of failure and despair. In this, Gatsby's personal experience approximates the whole of the American experience up to the first few decades of the twentieth century. America had been "a fresh, green breast of the new world," had "pandered to the last and greatest of all human dreams" and promised something like "the orgiastic future" for humanity. Now the virgin forests have vanished and made way for a modern civilization, the only fitting symbol of which is the "valley of ashes," the living hell. Here modern men live in sterility and meaninglessness and futility as best illustrated by Gatsby's essentially pointless parties. The crowds hardly know their host; many come and go without invitation. The music, the laughter, and the faces, all blurred as one confused mass, signify the purposelessness and loneliness of the party-goers beneath their masks of relaxation and joviality. The shallowness of Daisy whose voice is "full of money," the restless wickedness of Tom, the representative of the egocentric, careless rich, and Gatsby who is, on the one hand, charmingly innocent enough to believe that the past can be recovered and resurrected, but is on the other hand, both corrupt and corrupting, tragically convinced of the power of money, however it is made, and in addition, the behavior of these and other people like the Wilsons ?all clearly denote the vanishing of the great expectations which the first settlement of the American continent had inspired. The hope is gone; despair and doom have set in. Thus Gatsby's personal life has assumed a magnitude as a "cultural-historical allegory" for the nation. Here, then, lies the greatest intellectual achievement that Fitzgerald ever achieved.

One important point on which Fitzgerald has often been misunderstood concerns his attitude toward the rich. Hemingway once ridiculed Fitzgerald's fascination with the rich in one of his short stories. This is not quite fair. Fitzgerald has always been critical of the rich and tried to show the disintegrating effects of wealth on the emotional make-up of his characters. Here in *The Great Gatsby* we have met Tom and Daisy, completely dehumanized and dehumanizing, people for whom nothing is held sacred except, possibly, themselves. The aimlessness and weary restlessness of these people remind one of the dwellers of Eliot's unreal city, where "death has undone so many." Fitzgerald's narrator, Nick Carraway, finds it hard to conceal his contempt for them: "It was all very careless and confused," he thus says of their behavior. "They were careless people, Tom and Daisy ?they smashed up things and creatures and then retreated back into their money or their vast carelessness, or whatever it was that kept them together, and let other people clean up the mess they had made..." The very rich attracted and repelled Fitzgerald at the same time.

At his best Fitzgerald's craftsmanship is impeccable. The choice of a dramatic narrator, through whose consciousness everything filters, ensures the compact organic wholeness of the work. Nick Carraway is on the whole a reliable narrator. Because he follows his father's advice on toleration, he does not make quick judgments, and thus is able to gain access to "many curious natures" and become "privy" to unsought confidences. The world of *Gatsby* is inhabited in the main by three groups of people socially distinct from one another in behavior, language, and everything else. The magic power of Carraway lies in the fact that he has contact with them all, intimate enough to weave them skillfully into the unified fabric of the dramatic tapestry that is *The Great Gatsby*. The first group includes Tom, Daisy and their friends, rich, arrogant, contemptuous, pretentious, talking about science and art and reading the socially polite *Saturday Evening Post*, but definitely lacking in intellectuality. The second group is made up of people like the Wilsons, vulgar, speaking in bad grammar, and reading gossipy *Tatler*. Then there is Gatsby, one of the "wild, unknown men" who is worthy of the whole bunch of the others and whose secret griefs make Carraway see the world anew.

Carraway's limited omniscience determines the fact that he deals out information in such a manner that he seems to withhold it first, thus creating a superb effect of mystery and suspense. For example, the revelation of Gatsby's story is gradual. We first hear his name mentioned by Miss Jordan Baker, and it takes some four pages before Carraway discloses in a hesitant way that he is Gatsby's neighbor. Gatsby remains a hidden phantom until Mrs. Wilson's sister brings him and his fantastic parties up another sixteen pages later. All the while "Gatsby" is in the air but nothing definable comes up about him. Carraway himself is in for a story. He is invited to the party at Gatsby's mansion but unable to find the host. From the gossip that goes around he learns that Gatsby once killed a man and that he was a German spy during the war. He hears some other kinds of stuff of the romantic speculation Gatsby has inspired. And he finds that Jordan has never met Gatsby. It is not until about one fourth of the book is over that we are led into the presence of the man, and that is done in a fashion as sudden and abrupt as it is quiet and unobtrusive:

I was still with Jordan Baker. We were sitting at a table with a man of about my age...

At a lull in the entertainment the man looked at me and smiled.

....

"Much better," I turned again to my new acquaintance.

"This is an unusual party for me. I haven't even seen the host ... and this man Gatsby sent over his chauffeur with an invitation."

For a moment he looked at me as if he failed to understand.

"I'm Gatsby," he said suddenly. (47-48)

However, this is not the end of the mystery. Far from it. The identity of the man becomes the center of interest. A lot is to come in a well-arranged sequence. The fact that Chicago is calling adds a new dimension to the personality of Gatsby. He is said to be an Oxford man but may be not. A lunch in New York reveals a darker side of the man in touch with underground figures. Then there is Jordan Baker's story about her meeting with Gatsby and about Daisy's marriage, Carraway's own summary of the life of Gatsby, his parties, and so on and so forth until the whole secret is unraveled and past and present mingle to bring the tragic drama to a pathetic, significant finish.

Fitzgerald was one of the great stylists in American literature. T. S. Eliot read *The Great Gatsby* three times and concluded that it was "the first step that American fiction has taken since

Henry James." Fitzgerald's prose is smooth, sensitive, and completely original in its diction and metaphors. Its simplicity and gracefulness, its skill in manipulating the relation between the general and the specific, its bold impressionistic and colorful quality, in short, its competence to convey the vision of the author all reveal Fitzgerald's consummate artistry.

Fitzgerald was essentially a 1920s person. He was part of it and eventually died with it. Inside he knew it well. Outside he saw it ironically. And he continued to write about it right until his death. Even *The Last Tycoon* is not a book about anything else. He thus became the spokesman of a crucial and revealing period in the cultural history of his country. And as such he will go down in the history of American literature.

Ernest Hemingway (1899-1961)

Hemingway was born in Oak Park, Illinois. His father was a physician, fond of hunting and fishing, who took young Ernest with him on his trips. Hemingway's style of living as an adult and the fact that his books abound in sports terms are partly traceable to his early life. As a boy, Hemingway liked boxing and football and wrote light verse and humorous stories. He had on the whole a happy boyhood though he did run away from home twice and observed once that the best training for a writer is an unhappy boyhood. After leaving school at 17, infested with the then prevailing fever among the young "to get into the thick of it," and the sense of the need to experience or observe war at close quarters, he tried to enlist in the army, but was rejected because of his bad eye which he had injured while learning boxing. He went to the *Kansas City Star* and served as its eager and energetic reporter. Then he was recruited as an ambulance driver working with the Red Cross and went to Europe. This led to the crucial happening of his life. On July 8, 1918 he was severely wounded in the knee in Italy. He recovered in time and remained with the Italian army until the end of the war. His war experience proved so shattering and nightmarish that his life and writings were permanently affected. In a sense, all his life he lived with it emotionally and continued to write about it in order to relive it and forget about it.

Back to the United States, he stayed for a time in North Michigan, reading, writing, and fishing the way his fictional character, Nick Adams, does in "Big Two-Hearted River." Then he worked with a Chicago commercial journal, met Sherwood Anderson, his stylistic mentor in a sense, and acting on his advice went to Paris as a foreign reporter for the Canadian *Toronto Star*, carrying with him Anderson's letters of introduction to Gertrude Stein and Ezra Pound. Although Hemingway was not pleased with Gertrude Stein's later presumptuous chatter about his debt to her and ruthlessly parodied Anderson's style in his first novel, *The Torrents of Spring* (1926), it remains a fact that he did benefit not a little from their schooling. For him Anderson was a guide in style. Critic Richard Bridgman saw him as a counselor and a model of seriousness for Hemingway, and Alfred Kazin noted in his *On Native Grounds* that the younger writer learned honest simplicity from the older. His first published book, *Three Stories and Ten Poems* (1923), owes clearly both in theme and style to Anderson. As for Gertrude Stein, Hemingway acknowledged that he learned everything from her "about the abstract relationships of words," the many truths about rhythms and the uses of words in repetition. As a journalist, Hemingway trained himself in the economy of expression. His use of short sentences and paragraphs and vigorous and positive language, and the deliberate avoidance of gorgeous adjectives are some of the traces of his early journalistic practices.

He settled down in Paris and worked on some short impressionist stories. Gradually a distinct style of his own began to evolve, and together with it a Hemingway theme with a

Hemingway hero. In one sense Hemingway wrote all his life about one theme, which is neatly summed up in the famous phrase, "grace under pressure," and created one hero who acts that theme out. The book that appeared in 1925, *In Our Time*, is interesting precisely because, for the first time, a Hemingway hero appears on the scene to learn to live in grace under pressure. Nick Adams is, when he first shows up, the embryonic Hemingway protagonist, introduced to a world of violence, disorder, and death and learning the hard way about what the world is like. The very title is typical of Hemingway's style of irony, being a mocking reference, as Philip Young observes, to a well-known phrase from a Christian prayer, "Give us peace in our time, O Lord," for, as all the stories reveal, there is no peace at all in Nick's life. Growing up in violent and dismal surrounding, Nick's psychological and emotional wound is followed by a physical wound in the war, which alienates him from his society. He makes "a separate peace" with the enemy, leaves for the country swamp to fish, and learns to endure as a man. It is safe to state that most of the later works of Hemingway are a repetition of these Nick Adams stories. The image of Nick finds newer and fuller dimensions in more stories in such collections as *Men Without Women* (1927) and *Winner Take Nothing* (1933). None of the Nick Adams's stories is pleasant and comfortable reading matter. We feel perpetually assailed by a poignant sense of anxiety and fear as we subconsciously identify ourselves with Nick in our reading. One example suffices for our discussion here. The opening story, "Indian Camp," relates the story of young Nick observing his father help an Indian woman to give birth. Hemingway holds it in abeyance until at last we suddenly realize that it is a Caesarian without any drugs to relieve the pain. The cries of the mother and the cruel death of the husband cause such a repulsion in us that the story continues to sicken and disturb long after we finish reading it.

In the same year *The Torrents of Spring* came out, Hemingway published his first important novel *The Sun Also Rises*. Though not a bestseller, it attracted a good deal of attention from the critical world. In the same way that Fitzgerald's *Tales of the Jazz Age* becomes a symbol for an age, Hemingway's book paints the image of a whole generation, the Lost Generation. This included the young English and American expatriates as well as men and women caught in the war and cut off from the old values and yet unable to come to terms with the new era when civilization had gone mad. Jake Barnes, Robert Cohn, and Brett Ashley are seen wandering pointlessly and, restless and impotent, enjoying things like fishing, swimming, a bullfight, and beauties of nature but aware all the while that the world is crazy and meaningless and futile. Their whole life is undercut and defeated. Jake Barnes, the protagonist, wounded and made sexually impotent in the war, finds life a nightmare after it. The only strength to live on with any dignity comes from nowhere but himself. He comes to see that, in a world in which "all is vanity and vexation of spirit," there is nothing one can do but to take care of one's own life and be tough against fate and tough with grace under pressure. Jake Barnes is really a Fisher King in an Eliotic Waste Land. His physical impotence is a token of modern man's spiritual impotence.

A Farewell to Arms (1928), his next important novel, can be read as a footnote to *The Sun Also Rises* in that it explains how people like Jake Barnes come to behave the way they do. Frederic Henry goes to the war and discovers the insanity of the universe in which he lives. Guns that spit out death, the Carabinieri killing the innocent in the rain at night, his own wound and the death of Catherine—all this happens in a world of complete unreason. Lieutenant Henry becomes a very embittered man, fighting single handed against overwhelming odds. Here stands the Hemingway hero, an average man of decidedly masculine tastes, sensitive and intelligent, a man

of action, and one of few words. Here is an individualist, alone even when with other people, somewhat an outsider, keeping emotions under control, stoic and self-disciplined in a dreadful place where one cannot have happiness. Frederic Henry is completely disillusioned. He has been to the war, has seen nothing sacred and glorious but has found it like a veritable Chicago slaughterhouse. Like Jake Barnes who hates to "talk about it," Lieutenant Henry is shocked into the realization that "Abstract words such as glory, honor, courage, or hallow were obscene," and feels "always embarrassed by the words sacred, glorious, and sacrifice and the expression in vain." *A Farewell to Arms* caught the mood of the post-war generation, and brought international fame to young Hemingway.

The break of the Hemingway hero with society becomes extreme in his next two books, *Death in the Afternoon* (1932) and *Green Hills of Africa* (1935). Both are non-fiction; neither is very important. One is about bullfighting; the other concerns big game hunting. Again in the words of Philip Young, they are really about death—the death of bulls, bullfighters, horses, and big game. Here is a man having broken with his kind, escaping into the bullfighting arena or the green hills of Africa to find peace and solace. For almost ten years after *A Farewell to Arms*, Hemingway did not produce another book which could touch it in either emotional intensity or artistic workmanship. Possibly because the social and intellectual milieu of the 1930s was not provocative enough to his genius, his works done in mid-career were not up to general expectations. *To Have and Have Not* (1937), while reflecting the spirit of the age, was not a successful book. The Spanish war was conducive to his writing *The Fifth Column* (1938), a play which was universally deplored. Set in Madrid in the middle of the Spanish war, the play proved to be more a piece of propaganda than a work of art. However, the social concern that occupied Hemingway's mind in this period led to a significant change in his tragic vision of man and his world.

Now Hemingway's world is a world essentially chaotic and meaningless, in which man fights a solitary struggle against a force he does not even understand. The awareness that it must end in defeat, no matter how hard he strives against it, engenders a sense of despair, but the Hemingway hero possesses what Bertrand Russell terms "despairing courage." It is this courage that enables a man to behave like a man, to assert his dignity in face of adversity. This is the essence of a code of honor in which all of Hemingway's heroes believe, whether he is Nick Adams, Jake Barnes, Frederic Henry, Robert Jordan, Santiago or the undefeated bullfighter. But they differ, some from others, in their view of the world. The difference which comes gradually in view is an index to the subtle change which Hemingway's outlook had undergone. A sure sign of this is seen in the last words of Harry Morgan, the hero of *To Have and Have Not*: "A man alone ain't got no bloody chance." Here for the first time Hemingway's old individualistic postulate gave way to a fresh faith in the social destinies of men. *The Fifth Column* shows the growth of a man who, though perhaps as tough and sensitive and sleepless as Lieutenant Henry, no longer believes with him that faiths are indecent.

Then, in 1940, the book of any importance in ten years, *For Whom the Bell Tolls*, came out in print. Traces of Lieutenant Henry are still clearly visible in Robert Jordan. Here is a man living all the time in the shadow of fate and doom. He is keenly aware all along that he is fighting a losing battle, but he keeps on striving. He may have planned well and tried to get things done his way, but that his doom is sealed is a foregone conclusion. The story opens and ends with the man in a lying position, one that suggests death. The whole action takes place within some seventy

hours, which corresponds to the three score and ten years of man, and there are Robert's references to the fact that he has lived his whole life in the seventy hours. He does love a woman and try to give up himself and join with her, but the universe tends to frustrate any human effort. The war dominates so that the love story represents a mere dream which the brutal and atrocious realities of life do not allow to materialize. However, Robert Jordan is no longer a Lieutenant Henry, the solitary individual at odds with the forces dealing out nothing but defeat, doom and death to man. Nor is he a Jake Barnes, trying to accommodate himself to a purposeless and futile existence. He is no longer alone, having a cause to work for and a group to fight with and, more important, someone to love and die for. The war he is fighting is, for him, a metaphor for a struggle for freedom. It is for democracy that he sacrifices himself. Nowhere else in Hemingway is the theme of human brotherhood so emphasized. Hence the significant title of the book. It is an allusion to John Donne's Meditation (??): "All mankind is of one author and is one volume," and "Any man's death diminishes me because I am involved in mankind, and therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee."

Between 1940 and 1950 when his next novel, *Across the River and into the Trees* appeared, Hemingway was silent from a literary point of view. *Across the River and into the Trees* was such a poor performance that critics all agreed that Hemingway's talent was dead. But not for long. *The Old Man and the Sea* (1952) helped toward restoring his literary image, so that he won the Nobel Prize in 1954. It is a short novel, a fable of a kind, about an old Cuban fisherman Santiago and his battle with a great marlin. For 84 days Santiago does not catch a single fish but he does not feel discouraged. He goes far out into the sea and hooks a giant marlin. A desperate struggle ensues in which Santiago manages to kill the fish and tie it to his boat, only to find that on the way home he has to fight a more desperate struggle with some dangerous giant sharks, which eat up the marlin, leaving only a skeleton. The old man brings it home and goes to bed to dream, almost dead with exhaustion. Here in Santiago we see again the spirit of the noble ?if tragic ?Hemingway type of individualism, contending with a force he knows it is futile to battle with. He keeps on fighting because he believes that "a man is not made for defeat.... A man can be destroyed but not defeated." However, the old man eventually comes to the realization that in going far out alone, "beyond all the people in the world," he has met his doom, and he feels good to be one of the human and the natural world. That he begins to experience a feeling of brotherhood and love not only for his fellowmen but for his fellow creatures in nature is a convincing proof that Hemingway's vision of the world has undergone a profound change.

Hemingway was a myth in his own time, and a myth in American literature. He was a glamorous public hero of sorts whose style of writing and living was probably more imitated than any other writers in human memory. He was so precisely because he acted out the theme of his own books. That was why he liked sports of all kinds and was thought of as one going deep-sea fishing, big game hunting, going into the bullring or becoming a prize ring boxer. His public image was one of a tough guy whom even an air-crash could not kill. During the 1930s and the 1940s his non-literary activities were widely publicized and did more to advance his reputation. In 1942 he began to work for the United States Navy and for two years scoured the Cuban coast to seek to help destroy enemy ships. In 1944 he went on several flights with the British Air Force as a reporter. He took part in the landing of the Allied Forces on the French coast and fought with a small force of his own in Paris before the French entered their capital themselves. He was injured many times, suffered at least a dozen injuries to the brain, and survived three bad automobile

accidents and two air crashes. From the wounds, 237 steel fragments were taken out of his body. In his later years he often behaved in an odd manner and looked much older than his years. Possibly because he could not write any more, or possibly because he could not act out his code, or because of both and his ill health, he shot himself on July 2, 1961. The world was shocked into the disconcerting awareness that, with his death, an era had come to an end.

Hemingway is essentially a negative writer. It is very difficult for him to say "yes." He holds a black, naturalistic view of the world and sees it as "all a nothing" and "all nada" ("A Clean Well-Lighted Place"). A man is to him nothing, too, because he is insignificant and powerless in face of the odds he is up against. The title of his first important book, *The Sun Also Rises*, referring to the biblical "Ecclesiastes," emphasizes the nothingness of life itself. For the preacher of the "Ecclesiastes" is downright nihilistic in tone when he says, "The sun also ariseth, and the sun goes down, and hasteth to his place where he arose," and "The thing that hath been, it is that which shall be; and that which is done is that which shall be done; and there is no new thing under the sun." His is evidently a very negative attitude toward life. Hemingway sees life in terms of battles and tension. All of his works dramatize this concept of life, that it is dangerous and always ready to defeat and destroy you, but that, if you keep calm and stand on your set of principles (which Edmund Wilson calls "this principle of sportsmanship" in his *The Wound and the Bow* and Philip Young sums up as a "code of honor"), you may win on your own terms, though as the winner you get nothing except, perhaps, the knowledge that you have played well. Thus the typical Hemingway situations are usually characterized by chaos and brutality and violence (as in *A Farewell to Arms*, *For Whom the Bell Tolls* and many sketches in *In Our Time*), by crime and death (as in *To Have and Have Not* and "The Killers"), and sport, hard drinking and sexual promiscuity (as in *The Sun Also Rises* and some of his short stories). And the typical Hemingway hero is one who, wounded but strong, more sensitive and wounded because stronger, enjoys the pleasures of life (sex, alcohol, sport) in face of ruin and death and maintains, through some notion of a code, an ideal of himself.

In the latter part of his life, Hemingway came to be known as "Papa Hemingway." This compliment refers in the main to his contribution to the development of a new style of writing in America, that is, the colloquial style. As we noted earlier, this style may be traced first to Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, the book from which Hemingway once said that "all modern American literature comes." Hemingway's apprenticeship in writing was a painful one. Apart from his conscientious effort in groping for a style which he could call his own, he had the schooling of Sherwood Anderson, Gertrude Stein, and Ezra Pound, to name just a few. Pound's advice to Hemingway was particularity and concision. The whole art of writing was, in the words of Pound, concision, or saying what you mean in the fewest and clearest words. This was in fact what Hemingway tried to achieve in writing. Comments on his style have been legion; all seem to agree on the simplicity and apparent naturalness of his prose, and its effect of directness, clarity and freshness. This is true in view of the fact that he always manages to choose words concrete, specific, more commonly found, more Anglo-Saxon, casual and conversational, and employ them often in a syntax of short, simple sentences, which are orderly and patterned, conversational, and sometimes ungrammatical. But it is good to note that Hemingway's style is deliberate and polished and is never natural as it seems to be, and its simplicity can be disastrously deceptive, as it is highly suggestive and connotative and capable of offering layers of undercurrents of meaning. Hemingway's strength lies in his short sentences and very specific details. His short sentences are

powerfully loaded with the tension which he sees in life. His abhorrence for the vague and the general is extreme. He labors to get "the real thing, the sequence of motion and fact which made the emotion," as he declares in *Death in the Afternoon*. In his opinion, a writer has got to catch "the whiteness of the bone," to catch the one specific thing and bring it to life and make it vivid for the readers and leave everything else out. Thus Hemingway's world is one of particulars. Reading him, we experience the immediacy and directness of a person wounded by a bullet and trying to talk before he dies. Terse, effective, and no nonsense – these are the obvious effects of his prose. Hemingway's influence as a stylist was neatly expressed in the praise of the Nobel Prize Committee about "his powerful style-forming mastery of the art" of writing modern fiction.

We have placed Fitzgerald and Hemingway in one chapter partly because they grew up out of the same period and out of the same social situation. The world after the First World War was quite different. All the old certainties were gone, and everything was new. The disillusionment with the war, the new inventions, especially the automobile which changed the lives of the people drastically, and the mobility that this brought about and with it the lack of supervision, and all this happening at the same time as the rise of the gangsters, the enforcement of the Prohibition and the loss of respect for the law – under these circumstances, social life was going through very odd changes. There was affluence and excitement on the one hand, and on the other, disturbing indications that the old world was simply dying. Against this background Fitzgerald and Hemingway wrote. Fitzgerald was an analyst. He stayed in the United States and wrote about the Jazz Age. We go to him to know what this world was like. Hemingway, on the other hand, reacted to it; he did not describe it. He went away to Europe and wrote about the expatriates. His world was basically rootless. It is Fitzgerald who was so broken emotionally by the failure of the American dream. So they reacted differently to their times. Both were talented writers; both lost the ability to write rather early in their career. Ultimately when the dust of time settles down and a clearer outline appears visible, it may be that both will remain great, the one as the other, but for different reasons: Hemingway predominantly for his style, and Fitzgerald for the fact that he tried to understand American culture at its roots and thus had more to say to posterity.

CHAPTER 15 The Southern Renaissance William Faulkner

The Southern Renaissance

Before we begin our discussion on William Faulkner it is good to take a brief look at the American southern literary tradition. The American south has been a unique region all along. There was the historically significant conflict between the Hamiltonian north and the Jeffersonian south. For a long time after the Civil War the agricultural south remained subordinate to industrial north, and there existed a glaring gap in culture and way of thinking between the two parts of the country. Measures were taken to develop the south; economic improvements slowly came about. Although the south remained conservative, there appeared a visible sign of change in literature, and there were efforts to reassess the past and the present and do self-searching. Since the beginning of the 20th century, there have emerged a few generations of southern writers who have all tried to root their works in the south with a view to achieving universal applicability. There was Ellen Glasgow (1874-1945) who, with her series of novels set in Virginia, focused more on the future rather than keeping casting a backward glance. She was no reporter of the racist terror of the south, neither did she complain about past glory gone with the wind. She wrote in her works about the builders of the future of Virginia. This is basically the situation that her novels such as

Virginia (1913) and Barren Ground (1925) represent. Ellen Glasgow made her unique contribution to the emergence of William Faulkner (1896-1962). The most important figure in this constellation of writers is William Faulkner, whose 19 novels and numerous short stories, all relating to the south, form a profound scrutiny of the problems with which the south has been beleaguered. Faulkner struggled to add to the American renaissance of the 1920s and helped usher in a whole new group of southern authors of the 1930s such as Katherine Anne Porter, Eudora Welty, and Carson McCullers. The 1930s also witnessed the emergence of the Fugitives and their famous statement *I'll Take My Stand* (1930), affirming their position on the superiority of the southern, agrarian lifestyle over that of the industrialized north. Then the postwar period has seen a number of younger writers keeping up the southern tradition: Flannery O'Connor, William Styron, and Percy Walker, to name just a few. These writers have kept the continuity of the southern theme and kept it afloat before the readers' eyes. This glittering group of writers have managed to keep reminding the world of the existence of the resilient south. They have made the southern literary renaissance a fact of history. In the following chapters we'll be discussing some of these writers in the periods in which they fit as we move along.

William Faulkner (1897-1962)

Now let's take a look at William Faulkner. The fact that Faulkner was born into a Southern family with a fairly long tradition is perhaps the most important of all the influences that made him what he became: a major writer in American literature. The town of Oxford where he was brought up and studied briefly at the university, became the model for his fictional Jefferson, the seat of his fictional Yoknapatawpha county. His own family history found its way into his novels; the members of his family, including his great grandfather, grandfather, and his parents and brother, proved to be valuable prototypes for his fictional characters. And his knowledge of the life of the American Deep South, with its tragic history of rise and fall in its fortunes, its ways and mores, and its language, all fused in his imagination and recreated, became the substance of a Faulknerian world strangely inspiring both nostalgia and a sense of impending doom in modern readers.

Like most writers of his generation, Faulkner was eager to go to the First World War, and like Fitzgerald he was never sent to Europe. He joined the Royal Flying Corps in Canada and was still under training when the war was over. He returned to the United States, attended the University of Mississippi for a year, and supported himself with a variety of odd jobs in New York and Oxford. In his lifetime Faulkner cultivated a literary friendship with two men which was of great value to his career. The first of these was Phil Stone, a lawyer widely read in classic literature and modern French and English authors, who introduced him to the world of rising American writers such as Frost, Pound, and Sherwood Anderson, and who paid, in 1924, for the publication of a book of his poems, *The Marble Faun*. Through the recommendation of Phil Stone, Faulkner became acquainted with Sherwood Anderson in New Orleans, who helped him to write and publish his first novel, *Soldier's Pay* (1926). New Orleans was then a literary center of a kind, where the little magazine, *Double Dealer*, published avant-garde poetry. There Faulkner learned about James Joyce, Joseph Conrad, and Sigmund Freud. In 1925 he went on a trip to Europe, saw Joyce, his idol from afar, and was impressed by modern painting.

His first two novels, *Soldier's Pay* and *Mosquitoes* (1927), were not very promising, but *Sartoris* (1929) revealed Faulkner's fuller development as a writer. For the first time, he entered his fictional county and began to create a world of his own. With *Sartoris* his training as a writer came to a close. His next book, *The Sound and the Fury* (1929), was definitely the mature work of a

major author. In 1930 *As I Lay Dying* came out, and what had apparently begun to worry him was the lack of obvious critical acclaim for his work. He then contrived the sexually aggressive and sensational plot of *Sanctuary* (1931) to shock the public into a kind of recognition. Shock it did, but as it jarred on the nerves of the people, it earned him a rather bad reputation. During the next ten years, he continued to work on his Yoknapatawpha county. His major works such as *Light in August* (1932), *Absalom, Absalom!* (1936), and *Go Down, Moses* (1942) appeared one after another. Recognition came but slowly in his own country, though the French were quicker to spot his rise as one major author in America. Both Andre Malraux and Jean-Paul Sartre wrote serious, highly complimentary criticism on his work. In the early 1940s Faulkner began to get a measure of the belated recognition, but it was also a fact to note that some of his works were beginning to be out of print.

The moment came for him in 1946 when Malcolm Cowley edited *The Viking Portable Faulkner* with a generous introduction of his works. Faulkner became the center of critical attention. Valuable studies were devoted to his high achievement in fiction. His mythic picture of the South, his fictional world as epitomized in his Yoknapatawpha county, his distinctive narrative method, and his skillful use of language were all profusely commented upon. The critical reaction that Cowley touched off led, a few years later, to the Nobel Prize for literature, which Faulkner won in 1950. By now Faulkner's place in literature was secure.

Faulkner wrote altogether 19 novels and three volumes of short stories. Of these three novels, *The Sound and the Fury*, *Absalom, Absalom!* and *Go Down, Moses* are masterpieces by any literary standards, and seven or eight others are very impressive. Here the Deep South is delineated in as minute detail as possible. Its people, Black and white, its small farms, and magnificent mansions some of which are decaying, its small towns with their court-houses, jails, stores and statues, its soil, rivers, and change of seasons are all parts of the general picture. Indeed, Faulkner's works have been termed the Yoknapatawpha saga, "one connected story," "one mythical kingdom" (the words are Malcolm Cowley's). Faulkner writes about the histories of a number of southern aristocratic families such as the Compsons, the Sartorises, the Sutpens and the McCaslins, and traces them back to the very beginning when the Chickasaw Indians were still lawful owners of the land. In the very rise of these family fortunes, Faulkner sees their inevitable fall. These white settlers may have dreamed, built great houses with confidence and courage, and achieved a degree of success in their golden past, but they can not escape the defeat to which they are doomed from the very outset, for they have displaced the Indians and enslaved the black race, thus putting a curse upon the land. When the same story of the tragic rise and fall recurs in one novel after another, it assumes symbolic proportions. It becomes clear that what Faulkner is talking about concerns not merely the American South but the human situation in general. The spiritual deterioration which characterizes modern life stems directly from the loss of love and want of emotional response that seems to be one important message of Faulkner's stories.

Let us take a look at *The Sound and the Fury*. Here is "a tale / Told by an idiot, full of sound and fury, / Signifying nothing." There is enough despair and nihilism but not much love and emotion in this sad story of the Compsons. Mr. Compson is disenchanted with life and the society he lives in. Unable to find meaning in the moral verities he was brought up with, he escapes into alcoholism and cynicism. Mrs. Compson is spiritually effete and has little love to spare for her children. Of the four children, Caddy is the only one capable of loving, but she loses her virginity. Her youngest brother, Benjy, is an idiot, a curse on the family. Another brother, Quentin, lives in

the ideal world of his youth with his dreams of love, honor, and integrity, and, when he fails to keep off the intrusion of the "loud, harsh world," he destroys himself. The life of her eldest brother, Jason, is empty and meaningless. Love is alien to him, and so are other traditional humanistic values.

The Sound and the Fury tells a story of deterioration from the past to the present. The past is idealized to form a striking contrast with the loveless present. There is in the book an acute feeling of nostalgia toward the happy past. Quentin's section offers a good illustration. A miserable creature in the modern world, Quentin frequently casts a backward glance at the time of his childhood when life was innocent, romantic, and secure. He just cannot bring himself to come to terms with the present which is, to him, purposeless, futile, and devoid of the values which make life worth living. His suicide offers an example of a complete negation of the present. In a sense, Quentin's value system may represent Faulkner's own idea of an ideal way of life, that of an antebellum society. The fact that Benjy's section begins the book is not a haphazard arrangement on the part of the author, for it is Benjy who feels most keenly the loss of love. Benjy lives on the emotional support of love. Although an idiot with no sense of time, he knows who loves him best. When Caddy is gone, his world of love vanishes with her; and nobody can take her place, not even Dilsey. Thus this section helps to dramatize the theme of loss from the very beginning of the story. With the story of Jason whose life embodies all the vices of the modern world, the contrast between the ante-bellum society and the present one is brought out in the most poignant manner possible. The triumph of rationalism over feeling and compassion is best illustrated in this sterile and loveless individual.

The life of Joe Christmas, Gail Hightower, and Joanna Burden in *Light in August* is singularly wanting in compassion and understanding. Joe Christmas is an illegitimate son. His mother dies at childbirth. His father is not known but may be a Negro. Grandfather Eupheus Hines is so bitter about the whole affair that he leaves the baby with a home for orphans. There Joe never knows what love is, and when adopted by the McEacherns who have little warmth for him, Joe becomes a total stranger in the human world. His world is a void, a nothing, a nada, and his attitude toward humanity is indifference and denial. He refuses to love and to be loved. He may have, in the last few days of his life, felt the desire and need for reconciliation with humanity at large, but hostility and retaliation have contaminated his life too long and too deeply for a chance of regeneration. He can only die in the world with which he has been long at odds. Joe Christmas is never sure of his own racial identity and is thus typical of the spiritual predicament of modern Everyman. Gail Hightower is also negative toward life. Completely withdrawn into himself, he lives in a world of fantasy. His actions invite persecution and destruction, which he enjoys. He enjoys a "Satanic glee" at the meaninglessness of his existence. He enjoys denying and being denied by his fellowmen, and so encompassing his own undoing. To relive each day in that moment between light and dark his grandfather's Civil War death charge on a chicken coop releases him from the terrors of the harsh reality of life around him. Thus keeping himself safely away from the actual world, he becomes one of the living dead. Although Joanna Burden has contact with the Black section of the community, she lives on the fringes of the town, cut off from the white part of the society. Repressing her femininity, she leads a sterile life. Her sexual relationship with Joe Christmas, while symbolic in a way of a positive life force within her system, disconcerts with its suggestion that she is fast moving toward damnation.

One important theme of *Absalom, Absalom!* is doom brought about by the denial of

humanity. Thomas Sutpen is the son of a poor white family. After suffering humiliation and rejection at the gate of one of the great houses, he comes to see the importance of birth and blood and family, and is determined that he will never be poor and humble again. He will build a great house such as the one from which he has been turned away. So he goes to the West Indies, where he marries a woman who has Negro blood in her veins and has a son born by her. Disgusted with their origin, he deserts them, thus beginning to repeat the same tragic process of denial. Back in Jefferson he builds a great mansion out of the blood and labor of the Negroes, remarries, and has a son, Henry, and a daughter, Judith. Years later his West Indian son, Charles Bon, shows up on the scene, falls in love with Judith and is killed by Henry, his half brother, who shares his father's denial of the Black race. Henry vanishes from the scene. Then the Civil War comes and the defeat of the morally unjust south is complete. Sutpen comes back from the war to renew his effort of establishing a dynasty, but his continual denial of the humanity in others brings about his final downfall. He is shot dead, his mansion burnt down, and what is left is an idiot Negro grandson. Thus, to counter rejection, man tries to assert his own individuality and the significance (or maybe insignificance) of his existence, but all comes to nothing in the end. The speech of Judith Sutpen sums up man's knowledge of the futility of his effort and the more desperate need to make it. "Because you make so little impression, you see," she says to Mrs. Compson, "you get born and you try this and you don't know why only you keep on trying it ... and yet it must matter because you keep on trying or having to keep on trying and then all of a sudden it's all over and all you have left is a block of stone with scratches on it..."

Go Down, Moses tells roughly the same story of moral injustice which, in Faulkner's opinion, poisoned southern civilization at the root. The tragic drama of the McCaslins begins to enact itself when the first of the McCaslins is born in Carolina in 1770s and arrives in the second decade of the nineteenth century in Yoknapatawpha county. Old Carothers McCaslin brings with him a wife, two boys and a daughter. On a trip to New Orleans Carothers buys a female Black slave, Eunice by name, who bears him a daughter called Tomey. Twenty years later, this daughter is seduced by her father and becomes the mother of a boy, Tomey's Terrel. At this Eunice takes her own life. The house of the McCaslins is thus placed from the beginning on the basis of a moral wrong ?an incestuous relationship and of injustice to a different race. Though the second generation of the McCaslins are enlightened enough to free some of their slaves and devise the share-cropping system on their plantation to help the poor, it is Ike McCaslin, the grandson of Carothers McCaslin, who decides to end the terrible racial legacy and repent in the hope of replacing it with a better order. He repudiates his family's heritage of guilt, refuses to assume the responsibility of the plantation, and goes back to his sources ?the forest, the earth, for virtues of love, honor, and reason with which to expiate the sins of his ancestors.

Against the whole nihilistic spirit of modern man and his absurd and impotent world, there appears the healthy life of primitive man and his natural world, through which a different attitude toward life is revealed with a different set of values. In a household like the Compsons where life deteriorates and decays, there is one woman whose heart brims over with love and compassion and who, though only a servant, stands as the center of the family. We mean the Black woman, Dilsey, in *The Sound and the Fury*. She cares for the needs of the family. She takes care of the children in place of Mrs. Compson. She loves Benjy as a human being. The Compsons would not have endured another day of its listless existence had Dilsey not been there to keep it going. Dilsey is all emotion and feeling. Her response to life and to people is natural and intuitive. She

understands the plight of the Compsons well enough to pronounce their tragic end: she has seen both their beginning and their end. She seems to demonstrate that love and compassion are what man has lost and must recover to achieve revitalization.

The Lena Grove story line (in *Light in August*), though it runs parallel to that of Joe Christmas, Gail Hightower, and Joanna Burden, dramatizes a different value system based on a different outlook on life. Lena is a simple girl with a simple faith. Pregnant with child, she starts her hitchhiking from Alabama to Jefferson, assured in the belief that she will find the father of her child, and that the Lord will care for her. And it looks as though, if she is improvident, her Lord sees to it that she be provided for. All the people she meets on the way are kind to her and ready to help. And wherever she goes she seems to bring the best out of the people. Saintly in her innocence and simplicity, and fertile as against the meaningless existence of people like Joanna Burden, she represents, together with Byron, a reinvigorating life force which stems from an unquestioning affirmation. Her story and Joe's balance each other well.

Another of Faulkner's primitives is Sam Fathers in *Go Down, Moses*. He is a natural man close to his sources in the natural world. Natural in feelings and responses, Sam Fathers keeps what has been long "tamed out of blood" by modern existence. Deep in the forest, he initiates Ike McCaslin to virtues such as honor, pride, pity, justice, courage, love and compassion, virtues already missing from the life of the Compsons and the Sutpens, and he manages to bring him back from the brink of the abyss that is modern civilization. Faulkner writes for affirmation. As he notes in his Nobel Prize speech, he wants to reassert "the old verities and truths of the heart," the truths like love, honor, pity, pride, compassion, and sacrifice. That would endow a story with power and permanence. He would like to help to revive the natural man in human beings which modern life constantly endeavors to smother. It is his belief that man may discover his true identity and retrieve his innate capacity to accept and endure if he keeps off modern intrusion upon the natural man within himself.

Faulkner's attitude toward the southern "aristocratic" families that he wrote about is ambiguous. Alongside his censure of their injustice to the African Americans, there is some indication of pity or sympathy. One of his famous short stories, "A Rose for Emily," is a good index to the mixed feelings that his works reveal. Emily is the last of a long line of the southern "aristocrats." Obstinate, asocial, out of step with the tenor of modern life, she lingers, when alive, as a "monument" to a glory gone with the wind, never to return. Yet she possesses a measure of dignity, a stature of tragic dimensions, which inspires wonder and admiration. Her past represents to some townspeople "not a diminishing road but, instead, a huge meadow which no winter ever quite touch." That golden era is now encased in the minds of people as an ideal of some kind to look back to, somehow. When she dies, she lies in state under a mass of bought flowers for people to view. The "rose" in the title indicates, as the tone of the story insinuates, a feeling not altogether unfriendly, one probably of compassion.

Faulkner was a daring formal experimentalist. He evolved his literary strategies so as to be better able to communicate his ideas. Not only was he a dedicated student of human nature, but he was also a conscious artist the way Henry James was. One of his most important statements on the writer's job was the observation he made on one occasion, that "The writer is interested in all man's behavior with no judgment whatever." Immediately two things come out of the remark that deserve careful analysis. For one thing Faulkner felt that the province of a writer's art included all human conduct, human verities, and that it was the primary duty of the writer to explore and

represent the infinite possibilities inherent in human life. Then, in doing this, authorial intrusion should be reduced to the lowest minimum.

Characterization was, to Faulkner, the essential medium to reveal the multifaceted nature of man. He possessed an amazing gift for creating "flesh-and-blood people that will stand up and cast a shadow." To him his characters were real and constant and moved in his mind all the time. He allowed them to enjoy a maximum degree of autonomy and independence and felt quite content with the role of a spectator-recorder, ever ready to observe at close quarters and reproduce their complexity. These characters may have their own idiosyncrasies and even self-contradict, but then life itself is not at all always consistent. And Faulkner was happy to create a fictional world which resembled the actual one. "To me they [the characters] are people, and they have grown older as I have grown older, and probably they have changed a little ?my concept of them has changed a little.... They have grown. I know more about people than I knew when I first thought of them, and they have become more definite to me as people."

There are quite a few devices by means of which the autonomy of the characters is ensured. One of the most important of these is authorial transcendence, the obvious effort on the part of the literary artist to resist the temptation to step between the characters and the reader and explain. He would rather let the characters explain themselves and hinder as little as possible the reader's direct experience of the work of art. The reader does hear, sometimes, an anonymous voice, but it is "the author, seeing himself distanced or as one more perspective on the scene, one more legitimate but not conclusive point of view." Faulkner was good at employing a fallible narrator who is willing to remedy a deficiency in perception, or multiple narrators who "contradict, correct, supplement" one another. There are in his fictions "juxtaposed scenes involving either a lapse of time or a change of place, leading the reader to recognize both simultaneity and progression." All these techniques relate to the authorial transcendence and ensure the maximum revelation of human possibilities.

Faulkner carried on ceaseless technical experimentation all his literary career. As Olga W. Vickery observes, Faulkner's novels can be grouped into several different categories. One of these is the story-novel with its emphasis on a revelatory moment in the narrative of a single incident or character, and its use of "skeletons" like love, money, and death, which are necessary to the narrative development, though they may have little to do with "the aspirations and the conflicts of the human hearts involved" (to quote Faulkner). *The Unvanquished*, *Go Down, Moses*, and *Knight's Gambit* are among Faulkner's story-novels. Then there is the novel of formal juxtaposition which places emphasis on the presentation of a state of mind or attitude through interior monologues as in *The Sound and the Fury* and *As I Lay Dying*. With the counterpoint novels like *The Wild Palms*, *Requiem for a Nun*, and *Light in August*, the separateness of the stories receives deliberate stress. And the "fused" novels such as *The Hamlet* and *Absalom, Absalom!* combine "the virtues of the short story . . . with the illusion of the density and of the complexity of life typical of the novel proper."

Faulkner is a difficult writer. Like all modern authors his demand on the cooperative response of the readers is exacting. He always structures his stories in his own original fashion and is proficient in employing a distinctive narrative method of gradually fitting in and of withholding or even giving confusing information. Gradually confusions vanish as context and periphery are defined and the center is revealed. There are a lot of interior monologues; the modern stream of consciousness technique is frequently and skillfully used. Words are often run together, with no

capitalization and no proper punctuation. Sentences are not always clearly indicated; many long ones are pushed together in peculiar ways. One fragment runs into another without proper notice, and added to all this, is the use of pronouns which often causes irritating perplexity. There is also Faulkner's handling of language to consider. His prose ranges from colloquial, regional dialects to highly charged courtroom rhetoric, covering a variety of "registers" of the English language. Faulkner was a master of his own particular style of writing.

Faulkner's powers of imagination are very great. Rooting his works in the Deep South, he manages to create a literary milieu of his own through which he tries to transcend the limits of particularity to reach universality. He keeps moving his fictions toward the condition of myth and succeeds eventually in elevating a simple, true story of human life on to the plane of an elaborate mythology. Talking about his South, Faulkner says: "I am inclined to think that my material, the South, is not very important to me. I just happen to know it, and don't have time in one life to learn about another one and write at the same time. Though the one I know is probably as good as another, life is a phenomenon but not a novelty, the same frantic steeple chase toward nothing everywhere and man stinks the same stink no matter where in time." His major concern was, thus, always with the general human situation. He was no more a Southern novelist than Robert Frost was a New England poet.

Faulkner has been considered America's greatest novelist to come out of the twentieth century. The best of his fictions, which deal with basic human nature and the basic patterns of human behavior, rank among the most enduring works of world literature. In writing about his land and about "man in the ageless, eternal struggles," Faulkner speaks for both his people and humanity, and becomes as timeless and spaceless as his stories.

CHAPTER 16 Anderson Stein Lewis Cather Wolfe Sherwood Anderson (1876-1941)

Sherwood Anderson's life was in a way archetypal of literary lives in modern America. His personality was peculiar in a very interesting fashion. At a certain point in his life, when he was about thirty-six, already a successful businessman with a happy family, he suffered a nervous breakdown. The fact of the matter was that he had been tormented by what may be rightly called "a divided self." Feeling that he could be servant to words only, he found it impossible to carry on the paint business which, as "a smooth son of a bitch" (he thus called himself), he had been working smoothly well with his colleagues to make very prosperous. He felt called upon to undertake a nobler vocation, to be loyal to his soul and become a writer. Unlike Wallace Stevens the two levels of whose personality formed the necessary elements of his unified sensibility, Anderson found the pull toward the practical and the emotional too much to tolerate. After he had worked for a few years, acting the manager by day and writing novels at night, the clash came to a head. One day, in the middle of a dictation, he stopped and left his office, never to return. He was found wandering about in a confused condition and was sent to a hospital. Thus he said farewell to the business world. In time he found himself in Chicago again where he had worked as a laborer in his early twenties.

By the turn of the century, Chicago had become a cultural center in the Midwest. It was there that Poetry and The Little Review were founded and became well known in Europe as well as in America. And there also it was that new authors and new works were introduced with great enthusiasm. For some time Anderson lived by writing advertisements for an agency while working

on his novels. He got to know Carl Sandburg and Theodore Dreiser who encouraged him to publish. He experienced the thrilling moment of awareness that he had become a writer. His first book, *Windy McPherson's Son*, came out in 1916. *Marching Men* followed the next year. The year of 1919 was unusual for Anderson; it was the year in which he published his masterpiece *Winesburg, Ohio*. He was to write more volumes, collections of short stories such as *The Triumph of the Egg* (1921), *Horses and Men* (1923) and *Death in the Woods* (1933), and novels like *Poor White* (1920), *Many Marriages* (1923), *Dark Laughter* (1925) and *Kit Brandon* (1936), but none of these could ever touch *Winesburg, Ohio* either in depth of vision or in literary craft. Anderson also left three personal narratives: *A Story-Teller's Story* (1924), *Tar: A Midwest Childhood* (1926) and *Sherwood Anderson's Memoirs* (1942), all interesting because indispensable to understanding him both as a man and a writer.

Anderson did a few things for which he is remembered today. Thematically he had the courage to explore new material for fiction: the psychological and emotional aspect of American small-town life, with emphasis chiefly on lower-class figures, the unsuccessful, the depraved, and the inarticulate. In more ways than one, Anderson was a writer of an important period in American history, one in which America passed from a rural to a predominantly industrial society. The transition, which was drawing to a close in the first years of this century, had been a painful experience in small towns. Alienation, loneliness, and want of love and understanding made life intolerable, and turned people into "grotesques." Thwarted emotions, repressed drives, frustrated lives, and distorted natures became the distinct features of America's small-town life. The historic importance of Anderson lies in the fact that he offered in his best works a rather timeless record of these for posterity. *Winesburg, Ohio*, which has become an American classic, is a good illustration. It is a book of the grotesques, of people each with a ruling kind of passion which distorts their personalities. "Hands," one of the twenty-five stories in the book, relates the bitter story of Adolph Myers and his pair of sensitive hands which have lost their right to express the love of man. Myers has never been able to recover from his traumatic experience of being beaten out of his job as a schoolteacher because of his hands. He lived alone in the town for twenty years and looked sixty-five though he was only forty. "Paper Pills" tells of an old man, Doctor Reefy, whom "Winesburg had forgotten." The Doctor, who loves his fellow men, is portrayed as a gnarled apple which the pickers have rejected but which possesses a sweetness only a few people know. He finds it so hard to communicate himself that he scribbles his thoughts on some bits of paper and stuffs them away in his pockets to become round hard balls. "Mother" probes into a mother-son relationship which becomes very awkward and abnormal as a result of the fact that neither mother nor son is communicative enough to break through to understanding. Then there are other "grotesques" such as Doctor Parcival, Louise Trunnion, Jesse Bentley, David Hardy, Joe Welling, Alice Hindman, Wash Williams, Seth Richmond, Tandy Hard, Reverend Curtis Hartman, Kate Swift, Enoch Robinson, Belle Carpenter, Elmer Cowley, Ray Pearson, Tom Foster, and Helen White. All these people are seen suffocating in an environment the dominant feature of which is want of understanding. Their stories reveal a nostalgic glance backward at "a kind of pastoral golden age" that has passed.

Technically, Anderson was a highly original writer. He depended on inspiration in his creative endeavor. Like the old writer in "The Book of the Grotesque," Anderson seemed to have a "young thing" active within him, directing his pen. He must have often had the same experience, again like the old writer, of falling into a half-dream in which he meets a procession of figures,

some amusing, some almost beautiful, but all grotesques of one kind or another: He felt there was something, "the young indescribable thing within him" as he calls it, that was driving this long procession before him. Listening to the call from inside, Anderson wrote his stories that appeal not through careful fabrications of incidents or episodes, but by the sheer emotional force of the moments of revelation, or the Joycean epiphany, that these stories describe. Here lies Anderson's contribution to the art of fiction. He observed human grotesqueness and eccentricity from a Freudian psychological point of view and tried to reveal the abnormal states of mind in a more or less accurate way. As Malcolm Cowley puts it, Anderson was endowed with "a gift for pouring a lifetime into a moment." Then there is his style to consider. **Anderson was probably the first writer since Mark Twain to write in the colloquial style.** He regarded the vernacular as an honest medium and developed a style the major features of which included clarity, directness, and a deceptive simplicity. This style, though its power was very much vitiated by its weaknesses like monotony, crudity and sentimental expansiveness, was to influence such writers as Hemingway and Faulkner. For Hemingway Anderson served as his stylistic guide for some time; and **for Faulkner the younger writer expressed his respect for the older more than adequately when he stated that Anderson was "the father of my generation of American writers and the tradition of American writing which our successors will carry on."** Anderson has been called **"a writer's writer."** In addition to Hemingway and Faulkner, there were also Hart Crane, Thomas Wolfe, and John Steinbeck, to name just a few, who owed a debt to him. Modern American literature would not have been the same had there not been such a seminal figure as Sherwood Anderson.

The works of Anderson have obvious weaknesses as well. For one thing they are very uneven. The best are among the eternal of American literature, while the worst tend to be slipshod and defective in plot or dialogue or both. Even his style is deficient so that it is ruthlessly parodied in Hemingway's *The Torrents of Spring*. Anderson is not much read today. In fact his hold on the readers began to relax as early as the 1930s. It is true that he is now chiefly remembered as the author of *Winesburg, Ohio* and a handful of stories like "I want to Know Why," "Death in the Woods," and "The Egg," but even this much is already enough to entitle him to a measure of immortality.

Gertrude Stein (1874-1946)

Gertrude Stein's claim to fame in literature is attributed to her writings as well as to her personality as a patron of art and literature. She came from a well-to-do family and was able to live comfortably on her inheritance in Paris most of her adult life. She graduated from Radcliffe College, Massachusetts where she managed to impress her writing instructor with her unusual power of abstract thought, and took courses in psychology which were offered by William James, brother of Henry James, the novelist. All her life she kept writing, and was a well-known writer of over fifty books. These include *Three Lives* (1909), *Tender Buttons* (1914), *The Making of Americans* (1925), *How to Write* (1931), and *Four Saints in Three Acts*. She lectured on her theories at Cambridge and Oxford Universities, and did a lecture tour in her own country in 1934.

Gertrude Stein did quite a few things that have ensured her niche in the American literary pantheon. For one thing she was very sensitive to the temper of her time and its subtleties of change. She believed that life after the war (WW I) was no longer the same as in the pre-war period, and the modes of representing it in the arts and in literature should change accordingly. She felt that life is a jumbled and disorganized experience, and literature should develop ways to reflect its true nature rather than dishing out anything traditional which falsifies life with its clear

character portraits and sequential plots. Thus she helped, in her way, usher in the new, modern, period. As she was a very self-confident individual and believed she was right in her vision, in her theory of art, and her judgment of things and people, she became with time "The Matron Saint of Paris Art." Hers was a gregarious glamorous lifestyle. When she settled down in France, she began collecting modern experimental works of art like the paintings of C 閼 anne and Picasso. She was actually Picasso's patron, and one of the Spanish painter's famous works is his painting of Gertrude Stein. Her apartment in Paris became a meeting place, a salon of a kind, for artists and writers, especially those of the experimental and the avant garde inclinations such as Anderson and Fitzgerald. Her memoirs, *The Autobiography of Alice B. Toklas* (1933), recording as it does her encounters with those famous people, made her very well known in Europe and America. The book, although it bears the name of Alice B. Toklas, her long time companion, relates in fact her reminiscences of her own experiences. It was a very popular book for a while. One of the celebrities that appeared in her salon some time around the 1920s was Ernest Hemingway, who came to her for advice at the beginning of his career with a letter of introduction from Sherwood Anderson. Hemingway acknowledged that he learned everything from her "about the abstract relationships of words," the many truths about rhythms and the uses of words in repetition. Hemingway was learning to write in a modern way and developing a style that would present "the thing seen" effectively. Gertrude Stein helped him see things in a contemporary way. The two were close once but later alienated from one another as the younger writer disagreed with her and deviated from her ideas about writing. Stein did not tolerate the behavior, called Hemingway names, and Hemingway responded later in his *A Moveable Feast* (1964) when he said to the effect that, although he learned from her, she was not his mentor as she had been saying that she was. Gertrude Stein might be a little presumptuous, once comparing herself to Shakespeare, and some people, including her brother, did not think much of her genius and her contribution. But she was an impressive presence in the world of art and literature of her time and exerted considerable influence around her. She was a kind of cultural monument in Paris

Another thing for which she has been noted is her literary theory and practice. Her literary theories are best expounded in her *How to Write*. She stressed "the value of the individual word" in her writings so as for her readers to see the objects rather than the mere printed text that describes them. One of the hallmarks of her writing is her repetitions of words which she felt could erase their superficial meaning and reveal their true sense. Her writing is filled with cryptic language and obscure abstractions which she believed would help to delineate essential reality. In most of her writings she deviates from conventional word order and coherence so that she is not always easy to understand. Sherwood Anderson took an immense interest in her laying word against word, relating sound to sound, feeling for the taste, the smell, the rhythm of the individual word. Her writing exhibits its unmistakable experimental daring and modernity.

It is good to read some of her writings. For her poetry, Stein's most famous and most frequently quoted line has been "Rose is a rose is a rose is a rose" from her domestic idyll, "Sacred Emily." Her poem, "Susie Asado" (1922), one of her rhythmic Spanish poems, is equally interesting, containing lines like "Sweet sweet sweet sweet sweet tea. / Susie Asado. / Sweet sweet sweet sweet sweet tea. / Susie Asado." The difficulty of the poem lies in this, that its meanings are abstracted or absent or so multiplied that any choice among them is next to impossible. A close friend of Stein's, setting the poem to music, said that he wanted "to break, crack open, and solve for all time anything still wanting to be solved" and that if a text were set sensibly, according to

sound, its meaning would "take care of itself." This apparently did not happen as people still have a hard time making sense of it. However, the experimental nature of the writing is clear enough to impress people. It demonstrates the limitless potential of available language resources.

The same feature of writing appears in Stein's prose works. One of these, "Picasso," begins thus: "One whom some were certainly following was one who was completely charming. One whom some were certainly following was one who was charming. One whom some were following was one who was completely charming. One whom some were following was one who was certainly completely charming." And it goes on: "Some were certainly following and were certain that the one they were then following was one working and was one bringing out of himself then something. Some were certainly following and were certain that the one they were then following was one bringing out of himself then something that was coming to be a heavy thing, a solid thing, a complete thing." The words and phrases such as "the one who was," "following," "certainly," "bringing out of himself," "working," "something," and other significant ones keep popping up in repetition. Then read this:

This one always had something being coming out of this one. This one was working. This one always had been working. This one was always having something that was coming out of this one that was a solid thing, a charming thing, a lovely thing, a perplexing thing, a disconcerting thing, a simple thing, a clear thing, a complicated thing, an interesting thing, a disturbing thing, a repellant thing, a very pretty thing. This one was one certainly being one having something coming out of him. This one was one whom some were following. This one was one who was working.

This, whether good or not from the point of view of conventional "good English," achieves amazing effectiveness, nevertheless. As Picasso was an innovator and his paintings were novel and unique, it was only befitting to talk about him in a way equally innovative, novel, and unique as does Stein's essay "Picasso." The style of the writing, solid, charming, lovely, perplexing, disconcerting, simple, clear, complicated, interesting, disturbing, repellant, and very pretty, as indeed its subject is, tends to impress its readers so much so that they may remember its subject for a long time indeed. Over the years so many people have written about Picasso, but not many of the writers have managed to engrave an imprint as deep and probably indelible upon the readers' minds as Stein has. Gertrude Stein may have carried her point on writing a little too far; this hallmark of repetition may not always be congenial to different tastes. But used wisely as Hemingway learned to do with it, it can generate a superb artistic effect.

Stein's first published book, a novel, *Three Lives* (1909), is still read today as one of her best, most readable works. It is about three women, all servants. The good Anna in "The Good Anna" is a housekeeper. The gentle Lena in "The Gentle Lena" marries the son of German parents. Melanctha in "Melanctha" is a colored girl, a mulatto, her lover being a young physician. The book may be artistically crude and off focus at times, and does not quite tell a story per se, but it offers a serious picture of life. It is about the simple, vague, humble lives of the three women, with their passion, feelings, and inner thoughts. They are all groping in bewilderment for a way out of a life with which they are at odds. Reading the book, we are face to face with three naked souls, the whole spectrum of their emotional responses to their obscure lives, and the terrain of their innermost world, and realize that we are in fact scrutinizing ourselves. Take the good Anna for example. She is good, always serving the people around her but also struggling with them. Hers is the most simple, commonplace life, humdrum to a fault, yet not without the ripples of rich human

feeling. She dies in hospital, and we may shed tears of grief as her life is moving and we empathize with her because we are all as human. We know her weakness and love her despite that.

Three Lives is seen as one of the earliest modern works of American fiction. It possesses some salient features that made it stand out as new fiction immediately. One of these is its "peculiar exposition of the art of character delineation," as shown in constant repetition of ideas in the minds of the three women. Take "Melanctha" for example. Three motifs about Melanctha Herbert recur: her seeking rest and quiet, her getting into trouble, and her learning to become wise. These converge in her relationship with Jeff Campbell. The two meet often, try to talk about things, change attitudes toward one another until Melanctha loses her patience and seeks gratification in another man, Jem Richards. But Jem deserts her so she dies in a poor house for consumptives. The story is slim enough, and the narrative focus is often on the description of the inner thoughts of the people trying to comprehend and relate to each other in a meaningful way, but often failing in their efforts either because of their temperamental flaws or the callous or unresponsive surroundings, or both. Reading the book we do see a shadow of Henry James or Gustav Flaubert around. Another notable feature that critics immediately noticed as soon as the book was out is its style of repetition of words and phrases in its narrative. The repetition appears eccentric and slipshod at first glance, but on close perusal, people find more of its subtlety, spinning and involving and turning back and reiterating a motif so as to keep it afloat before the readers' inquiring eyes.

Sinclair Lewis (1885-1951)

The first American author to win the Nobel Prize for literature, Sinclair Lewis has been called the worst important writer in American Literature. Born into a middle-class family in Sauk Center, Minnesota, Lewis was to place that class under ruthless satire, and at the same time to affirm its best virtues. He began writing when still in college and developed the habit of taking meticulous notes to be used in his novels. After graduation from Yale, he knocked about for a number of years, trying to be a journalist, selling story plots to Jack London in California and working for publishing companies in New York and for several magazines. All the time he tried to write novels and get them published. From 1912 to 1919 he was able to publish five novels, but it was not until the summer of 1920 when his sixth book, *Main Street*, came out that he became a famous man. For the next ten years the rise of Lewis was meteoric. With the appearance of *Babbitt* (1922), *Arrowsmith* (1925), and *Dodsworth* (1929), Lewis forced his literary presence on the consciousness of the readers not merely in America but in Europe. He managed to acquire an international reputation which led straight to the Nobel Prize. Thus within some twenty years Lewis climbed to the summit of his career. Thereafter, however, it was a steady slide downhill. Another ten novels were to appear yet, but none would ever reach the height of either *Main Street* or *Babbitt*. Writing after 1930 became a mechanical routine for him.

Lewis was a sociological writer. His novels form a segment of American social history. Lewis never wrote before he acquainted himself thoroughly with his material. He would study the section of social life closely, record his observations in detail, overhear conversations and note them down carefully, and draw maps of the locality and even the house with its furniture before he began to work out an outline, a detailed draft, and prepare the final manuscripts for publication. This method of work shows Lewis to be a genius of a lower intellectual order, very much inferior to that of, say, Dickens, but it had its own merit. For several decades Lewis nibbled like a silkworm at the mulberry leaf of American middle-class life so that he got to know it inside out. *Main Street* deals with parochial small-town life; *Babbitt* paints a truthful picture of the

middle-class business world of post-war America; Arrowsmith brings the operations of the medical profession to light; Elmer Gantry reveals the appalling religious decay in the country; and Dodsworth attacks the social standards of the middle class in general. And so as we read on, we get to know more about almost every aspect of American life. If, after James Fenimore Cooper and Hector St. John de Crevecoeur, no one had explicitly written to introduce America to the outside world, Lewis took over from them and wrote in such a way that at least one class of the American society is explained and even given a name, Babbitt, a word which has found its way into the English dictionary as a synonym for the vulgar and philistine businessman.

Although a man of a generous nature, always ready to help people such as Anderson, Hemingway, and Dreiser, Lewis was, somehow, neglected and despised in the literary world. He was rarely, if ever, taken seriously as an author deserves to be. Some writers regarded him as a commercial writer; others simply refused to treat him as a literary artist; and many, especially academic critics, frankly regretted the decision of the Nobel Prize Committee to give him the award. Lewis may have deserved better. He helped to discover "real America" and clear any vestiges of the genteel tradition out of the way so that a greater freedom both in theme and technique was ensured for the younger, rising generation. However, there are also definite suggestions that he was out of step with the more dynamic, more "revolutionary" generation of writers already active on the literary scene. In theme his affirmation of what he regarded as the best middle-class virtues made him appear rather old-fashioned. In style, apart from the fact that his novels sprawl and want order and art, he was what Virginia Woolf would have labeled "Edwardian," accurate in external description but lacking in psychological exploration. Thus amid the experimental atmosphere of the postwar years, he looked strangely conservative and outmoded. That image has remained in the memory of critics and readers alike even today.

Willa Cather (1873-1947)

Willa Cather was one of the few "uneasy survivors of the nineteenth century." Hanging onto the traditional values, she was never able to come to terms with modernity. In very much the same way Virginia Woolf said "On or about December 1910 human nature changed," Willa Cather made the grave statement that "in 1922 or thereabouts," the world "broke into two." And she lived in between the worlds, rejecting the modern and trying to escape into the refuge of the past. Her works are a fictional projection of her own crisis in life.

Although she was born in Virginia, Willa Cather moved at the age of nine with her family to a prairie state of the West-Nebraska. Old West thus becomes in most of her novels the center of moral reference against which modern existence is measured. The frontier rural community is always morally higher whereas the town is effete and corrupting. The immigrant folks are both simple and noble, and their life, though primitive to an extent, orderly and meaningful. Thus Antonia, the frontier village woman in *My Antonio* (1918), is seen lending herself to immemorial attitudes universal and true, a "rich mine of life, like the founders of early races," whereas the successful man of the city, Jim Burden, feeling dull and uneasy, returns west to seek her out as if in quest of a lost paradise. There is a moving touch of nostalgia in Jim's remembrance of things past and a touching pathos of sadness that the simple old ways have gone never to return. "In the lives of mortals," Jim recalls a quotation from a book he read at the university, "The best days are the first to flee."

The same vein of thought runs through all Willa Cather's work. *The Song of the Lark* (1915) is an implicit criticism of the culturally sophisticated East where, though the talent of Thea

Kronberg has an opportunity to develop, the girl feels uncomfortable and longs for the company of those prairie people like "Professor" Wunsch, Dr. Archie, and Ray Kennedy, a railroad worker. Here the East is evaluated, if only in an oblique way, against the spiritually idealistic standards of the West and found wanting. This proves to be the burden of *A Lost Lady*, which appeared in 1923. Old Captain Forrester, who fought in the Civil War and built railroads across the prairie, is a symbol of Old West, one of the pioneers, "great-hearted adventurers," a pattern of courage, chivalry, and courteous brotherhood. What is lamentable is the fact that modernity is daily encroaching upon tradition, and life is fast declining into cheap materialism. New men like Ivy Peters, men who "would drink up the mirage, dispel the morning freshness, root out the great brooding spirit of freedom, the generous, easy life of the great land-holders," are taking over and establishing a different value system which would appall the pioneers, a system infested with small-town spirit and commercial standards.

Willa Cather has a deep-seated abhorrence for the modern present with all its amenities and contrivances. The garage becomes a token of the "mechanized, packaged, and tinned" modern existence and stands alongside and in opposition to the drawing-room, the place of learning and taste and tradition. *The Professor's House* (1925) bodies forth its author's keenly felt desire to reject and withdraw from the modern world. Professor St. Peter builds a new house and furnishes it so that all the modern utilities and gadgets are available to make life easy and comfortable, but he refuses to move from the old house where he wrote his book and won with it the prize money with which to build the new house. Like his creator, Professor St. Peter has got to choose between the new and the old, and he prefers the latter. There he stays, retreating into the past. As Willa Cather sees it, modern life is simply suffocating.

Like the Professor, Willa Cather withdraws in her later fiction into the historical past. *Death Comes for the Archbishop* (1927) and *Shadows on the Rock* (1931) both endeavor to recapture an ideal past. Bishop Jean Latour is a pioneer of spirit, laboring amid doubt and opposition to establish the diocese of New Mexico in mid-nineteenth century, and so are the people of Colonial Quebec, building in the 1700's a new nation with their, indomitable Gallic spirit. Willa Cather writes in the belief that, when a pioneer goes forth with his tradition into a new land, he will found a home with the graces and riches of the mind and spirit, and she may have found solace and satisfaction in her writings. Thus a traditionalist to the end, she managed to cling to her ideal and left an inspiring literary record of a thinking mind's response to modern life.

Thomas Wolfe (1900-1938)

In the history of English and American literature, there have been authors who impress chiefly through the sheer power and vitality with which their works over-brim. We think of Thomas Hardy and Theodore Dreiser. Now we have come to face another creative prodigy whose exuberance of spirit and verbal energy have continued to awaken response in contemporary readers. We mean Thomas Wolfe of Asheville, North Carolina.

There have been amusing stories about Wolfe's creative energy which can only be properly termed "torrential." The man was so overflowing with ideas and words that these simply poured out of him. If Dickens was spontaneous, Wolfe was perhaps more. He was said to be writing non-stop in his New York flat and sending his manuscripts in a truck to his editors, who would then set to work cutting and pasting and putting the sprawling matter into some kind of order and return it in a taxi, for Wolfe believed in the power of words and the art of "inclusion." Art and control were to worry him, but only when he became more mature. The romantic abandon and

spontaneity began to give way to some form of artistic calculation, and Wolfe began to move from a "putter-inner" to somewhere close to being a "leaver-outer," though he never quite became one. "I want to be a better artist," he declared in his letter to Scott Fitzgerald. "I want to be a more selective artist." But he never quite became one.

Wolfe was a personal writer. All his writings are self-revelations so that his art borders on being confessional. All his protagonists, be they Eugene Gant or George Webber, are in essence reproductions of his own personality. All the experiences related in his fiction are autobiographical down to the minutest detail. Nor did Wolfe deny the fact that he had written himself wholesale into his novels. He was convinced that serious creative work must be all autobiographical in the final analysis, and that people must quote from their own life experiences to create anything of substantial value. Thus his first book, *Look Homeward, Angel* (1929), is in fact a narrative of his boyhood experiences, his life with his parents and brothers, and his final departure from his native place. *Of Time and the River* (1935), his second novel, picks up the story where the first leaves off, and tells about his stay at Harvard, his brief career as an instructor of English in a New York University, and his trip to Europe and return to America. Although the hero of the two books is the same person by the name of Eugene Gant and his native town is Altamont, Catawba, we know very well that Eugene Gant is Thomas Wolfe fictionalized and Altamont, Catawba is but another name for Asheville, North Carolina. And it is hardly necessary to add that Wolfe went to Harvard, taught English in a New York university, and traveled to Europe after that. *The Web and The Rock* (1939) continues the narrative of the previous book, while the last book, *You Can't Go Home Again* (1940) recapitulates the major events that occurred in the last few years of Wolfe's life. In these last two novels, published after he died of tuberculosis of the brain, Wolfe managed to achieve a degree of objectivity in his narrative art: his personality as an artist changed and transfigured everything of real life in his works. Even his first book is not a literal transcription of his own experience.

Wolfe was an ambitious man. He saw the whole life of America as the province of his fictional representation. What he set out to achieve was nothing short of defining the American experience. He may be seen as a latter-day Whitman, both infatuated and frustrated with the American dream. In talking about himself he found the rhythm of American life. As the depression of the 1930s deepened, Wolfe awoke to the painful fact that America was not that great, after all.

Wolfe was an original artist. All the strengths and weaknesses evident in his art are his own. There is an abundance of inflated rhetoric, it is true, and he can be badly rhythmic, but he can be exquisitely lyrical. He is conscious of his unique power to recreate everything physical and sensual such as odors, sounds, colors, shapes, and feel of things vividly, and make these real to the senses of his readers. The dramatic power with which he endows his sensuous factual details is an eloquent testimony to his prodigious talent. And the power and the vitality that his body of prose generates are more than compensation for his rhetorical excesses and novelistic formlessness for which he is unjustly remembered. When all is said, Wolfe must be ranked with the important authors of this century.

CHAPTER 17 The 1930s Dos Passos Steinbeck

The 1930s

The 1930s is often regarded as a dim decade as compared with the glittering twenties. There is a visible continuity between the two decades. While authors who made their names in the

twenties, authors such as Eliot, Hemingway, Fitzgerald, and Faulkner, continued to produce great works of literature, new forces appeared on the scene, writing with no less vitality and energy. It is safe to state that it is the literature published during these twenty-odd years that has been most widely read and greatly admired.

But the 1930s was radically different from the 1920s in mood as well as in expression. To begin with, its mood was colored differently from the very beginning. The Wall Street crash of 1929 set the tone for the writing of the decade. On October 24, 1929 "the bottom dropped of the stock market" (to quote from Warren French), and the great Depression began. For ten years the Americans plodded through a lightless tunnel and substantial change came only when WW ? broke out. The 1930s was truly a dark time, one of dreadful travail. Banks failed, factories closed, and agriculture withered. Jobless millions roamed the streets, breadlines stretched long, and absolute poverty became a fact of life. As the Depression spread, life became a nightmarish experience of a struggle for survival for millions of people. There was overall chaos with little or no cheer. If T. S. Eliot had tried to represent a spiritual waste land in his famous poem, the writers of the 1930s were faced with the challenge of painting a physical waste land that America had become. Economic disaster and the wretched workless existence for the masses of the people brought home to all the unnerving realization that the system might have collapsed. It had failed to work because it had allowed possibilities like the depression to be built into its fabric; it had failed because it had not been able to resolve the paradox of life that it might itself have created: food rotted while people starved; textile mills shut down while people needed clothing; and farmers lost their farms because they produced too much. The "milk and honey" of the land went down the drain instead of nourishing its people. Everything seemed to be disintegrating all of a sudden and all at once, and an ordered, rational existence proved to be impossible. There was widespread panic. If there had been any hope in the frustrating "roaring" twenties, there was, for many, sheer despair in the bleak years of the thirties. It is true that, when F. D. Roosevelt came into the White House, he brought with him a refreshing breeze of hope and optimism into it and into the country. Roosevelt was clever enough to borrow freely from the socialist programs of the previous decades and offered his synthesis of them with his own ideas as the New Deal which helped toward dispelling the crisis-laden atmosphere hanging over the country. He found ways to obtain money from financiers and industrialists to support projects like those of the C. C. C. (Civilian Conservation Corps) and the Federal Theater, all of which restored a measure of confidence to the defeatist nation. But nothing like a significant improvement occurred. It was not until the outbreak of the war that the country felt safe again. The war saved the United States, in a sense.

Faced with the reality of want and despair, American writers, like their brothers in England and Europe, found themselves asking the question, "What can writers do for the country?" This seemed to be the burden of a number of speeches at the 1935 American Writers' Conference, at which John Dos Passos, Langston Hughes, and Thornton Wilder were present and to which Hemingway sent a message of support. It was apparent that social concern was topmost in the minds of many authors, and that social involvement was to be the major feature of the literature of the thirties. Just as the crisis of 1893 was in some measure instrumental in introducing the violence of the naturalistic rhetoric in the last years of the nineteenth century, so the impact of the crisis of the thirties brought about a revival of that tradition, with the shadow of Dreiser and Norris moving behind the new literary sensibility that was appearing. In addition, the writers of the 1930s responded to the turbulence of their times very well. Literary expression in the period was

abundant and forceful. All the three major departments of literature ?fiction, poetry, and drama ?exerted their best efforts to rise to the challenge of history. The number of people writing was amazingly huge; the number of works written was no less surprising. Although many of these are period pieces, too much time-bound and space-bound to make for permanence, they deserve adequate recognition and admiration.

Let's take a look at the field of fiction. The 1930s was a great age of fiction. Dreiser's naturalistic style became a model of sorts for the depression novelists. Gertrude Stein and Sherwood Anderson tried to add to the strength of the novel of the new period. Hemingway and Fitzgerald lost their momentum for a while, but both made up somehow with their works later in the decade and at the beginning of the next (we have *For Whom the Bells Tolls* and *The Last Tycoon* in mind here). William Faulkner and Thomas Wolfe both published their major novels in 1930. Faulkner managed to stay aloof from the impact of the period and try to keep the timelessness of his message in tact. Along with him there were other southern writers such as Ellen Glasgow (already well established by then), Katherine Anne Porter, Eudora Welty, and Carson McCullers (included here as she was a bit hard to place) working to add to the luster of the period. The two major authors who became dominant figures in fiction were John Dos Passos and John Steinbeck. Dos Passos' *U. S. A.* and Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath*, along with their works and those of other writers, offer an authentic account of the American experience in the debilitating years of the Depression. Then there was the "hard knocks" generation, tough, ironic and hard-boiled "children of the depression." These include James T. Farrell, Erskine Caldwell, James M. Cain, John O'Hara, Nelsen Algren, and Homer McCoy, all beginning to publish in the decade. Along with these people, a group of proletarian writers worked hard to record faithfully the details of common life and the desires of the low strata of society. Michael Gold, Jack Conroy, and John Reed were but a few names to pick out of what was once an eloquent literary movement. Mention should be made of three novelists who were neglected in their time but have been "resurrected" somehow in postwar years ?Henry Miller, Henry Roth, and Nathanael West. Henry Miller wrote some scandalous works on sexual perversity ?*Tropic of Cancer* (1934) and *Tropic of Capricorn* (1939), was suppressed for quite some years but emerged in the 1960s as precursor to the Beat Generation. Henry Roth's *Call It Sleep* (1934) has been found fascinating in its use of Joycean interior monologue and its subtle handling of various dialects. And Nathanael West's four novels, now well evaluated, are said to relate to the black humor of the 1960s. Another interesting figure of the period was the African American novelist, Richard Wright, who increased the weight of the novel of the 1930s with his short stories in *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1938) and other writings although his major work, *Native Son*, came out at the beginning of the next decade. We should mention in passing two popular novels, Margaret Mitchell's *Gone with the Wind* (1936) and Hervey Allen's *Anthony Adverse* (1933). These books, although not much noticed by critics, served one purpose well if nothing else: they offered an avenue of escape from the wretched reality of the time.

The drama of the 1930s is rich and varied. It is true that no figure comparable to O'Neill appeared, but many people of talent tried to enrich the stage with their plays. Among these were Clifford Odets, Maxwell Anderson, Lillian Hellman, and Thornton Wilder, to list just a few. O'Neill published two of his most important plays in the decade, *Mourning Becomes Electra* (1931) and *Ah, Wilderness* (1933), but neither related to the Depression as they were probably carry-overs from the playwright's most creative 1920s. Clifford Odets was a major playwright of

the period; his works such as *Waiting for Lefty*, *Awake and Sing*, and *Golden Boy* prove to possess some measure of enduring claim to attention. Maxwell Anderson produced a good number of plays in the 1930s, such as *Elizabeth the Great*, *Mary of Scotland*, *Valley Forge*, and *Winterset* although he did not keep up his early promise of becoming another O'Neill in the American theater. Lillian Hellman wrote some plays which both related to and transcended their time period. Her *The Children's Hour* and *The Little Foxes* can still awaken echoes today. Thornton Wilder's *Our Town*, evoking as it does American small town heritage, was a remarkable addition to the richness of the American stage of the 1930s. Also deserving mention was John Steinbeck's effort to dramatize his novel, *Of Mice and Men*, which was a successful experiment. In addition to these major figures, there were so many other lesser talents working to make the Depression years theatrical. William Saroyan with his *My Heart's in the Highlands*, Robert E. Sherwood with his *Reunion in Vienna* and *Idiot's Delight*, George S. Kaufman in collaboration with Moss Hart and their *The Fabulous Invalid* and *You Can't Take It with You*, Richard Rogers with his *Pal Joey*, and a good number of musical comedies — these all contributed to the rich variety of the theater of the period.

The 1930s was not very good for poetry. Probably because of the overwhelming influence of T. S. Eliot, poetry did not flourish in the new decade as did the novel and the drama. No new major poet appeared on the scene. The older generation was still busy working. Frost won two Pulitzer Prizes though he did not find the period congenial to develop his art much. Eliot published another of his major works, *Ash Wednesday*, "*Burnt Norton*" (the first of the *Four Quartets*), and a couple of his poetic dramas. Ezra Pound's *Cantos* continued to grow, giving his poet-propagandist's warnings to his native country. Wallace Stevens, refusing to turn poetry to propaganda, created his permanent works such as *Idea of Order* and *The Man with the Blue Guitar*. Marianne Moore and William Carlos Williams were in between their periods of creative highlights. E. E. Cummings and Robinson Jeffers continued to write without adding significantly to their reputation. Carl Sandburg's *The People, Yes* offered a vehement optimism in face of the defeatist spirit of the times. As to Hart Crane, although his major works, *The Bridge* and *Collected Poems*, were out in print in the decade, they were clearly of the 1920s in spirit. Younger poets included Kenneth Fearing whose poetry was probably the best remembered of the radical works of the time, and Archibald MacLeish, who suffered somehow from his identification with the propagandists. One thing that deserves special mention is the rise of the New Criticism as a school of poetry writing and criticism. John Crowe Ransom, Allen Tate, Robert Penn Warren, and Cleanth Brooks, along with others, did their utmost to institute its values and bring its influence into college classrooms. For some three decades it assumed the status of some orthodoxy in the writing and criticism of poetry until the 1950s and 1960s when a change in taste and values became inevitable. But its influence has extended beyond the period of its supremacy and has left its imprint on history.

Let's begin with a brief look at the fiction of the period. In addition to John Dos Passos and John Steinbeck both of whom we will discuss in some detail later on, there were young novelists such as James T. Farrell, John O'Hara, and Erskine Caldwell who poured out their torrents of anger and protest in their left-oriented works. James T. Farrell (1904-1979) was a voluminous writer. His reputation rests chiefly on his *Studs Lonigan* trilogy. Here is a meticulous record of the brutalizing experience in Chicago during the Depression period. *Studs Lonigan*, the hero of the trilogy, living in a meaningless and violent slum environment, encounters forever alienation,

violence, and eventual destruction. He deteriorates with the deteriorating city of Chicago. Over and above the economic crisis there exists an acutely felt spiritual poverty. Conventional values are uprooted. Moral sanctions fail in the wake of economic disintegration. As the social ground on which he stands falls away beneath him, he meets his doom however hard he tries to avert it. The determinism of the old naturalists reasserts itself in Farrell's work. The fact that Danny O'Neill ultimately survives the harsh destructive environment, while it reveals Farrell's improvement on the previous naturalistic tradition, does not do much to alleviate the intensity of the dreadful reality, which the trilogy presents. Farrell is noted for the absolute literalness and solidity of detail in his representation. To read him is to relive the violent rawness and distemper of the thirties. In addition to the Studs trilogy which include *Young Lonigan* (1932), *The Young Manhood of Studs Lonigan* (1934) and *Judgment Day* (1935), Farrell is also author of the Danny O'Neill pentalogy, the Bernard Carr trilogy, some seven other novels, about 200 short stories, and miscellaneous writings including literary criticism.

The thirties also witnessed the vogue of the hard-boiled novels, of which the best was perhaps John O'Hara's (1905-1970) *Appointment in Samara* (1934). As is usual with O'Hara, this is a study of the life of a member of an upper class family. Julian English seems to be seized with a death wish and behaves in an abnormal way. Through the case history of Julian English, O'Hara is presenting a segment of the life of the thirties. Here, as indeed in most of his works, O'Hara follows faithfully his own principle of recording life "with complete honesty and variety." It is obvious that O'Hara has a "shrewd" eye and a "sharp" ear, and he can reproduce the speech, feeling, and thought of the people with alarming accuracy. He is observant and perceptive, and the detail and precision with which he handles a situation, a character, or the manners of a particular social group are well based on his rich fund of knowledge of and experience with the people and their lives. But O'Hara's weakness is also apparent. He is not a profound writer. Very often we have the feeling that he records very well, but he may not understand what he perceives and notes down in his fiction. Thus his art appears superficial, often degenerating into a form of pure mimicry. O'Hara was remarkably prolific. He wrote a good number of novels and a huge number of short stories. The portrayal of the thirties would not have been as authentic and trustworthy as it is in American fiction had there not been O'Hara's contribution.

Mention should also be made of Erskine Caldwell (1903-1987), a left-wing naturalist who worked hard to document "capitalist decay." Caldwell is adept at adumbrating a shocking scene of violence or an act of cruelty and atrocity which reveals man's disconcerting capacity to do evil. Though occasionally comic, Caldwell seems to enjoy causing extreme mental misery in his readers. A sharecropper being devoured by hogs, little girls sold into prostitution for a quarter, and events of a nature which tend to push man centuries back in his evolution—all these are portrayed in vulgar and nasty detail. Reading him, one derives little or no aesthetic-vicarious-pleasure, but often feels very uncomfortable, to say the least. It can be a nauseating experience which rankles in one's mind. Perhaps this is just the kind of effect Caldwell intends to produce on his readers. After all, truth is not always a twin brother of beauty, and it may have been especially so in the cruel thirties when man was forced to drop off all pretensions.

However, man is man. He possesses dignity and the capacity to wonder and hope. The sum total of his experience enables man to reach, ultimately, beyond the dismal and grim realities of the time, to see hope in face of adversity and try to improve his life. A great literary artist is he who possesses a greater capacity to transcend the temporal and inspire confidence and courage

with which to face life squarely. If some of the prolific writers of the Depression fail to attain immortality, it is probably because they have been found wanting on this score.

John Dos Passos (1896-1970)

In a sense the thirties can be called the decade of John Dos Passos. He was the leading naturalist of the Depression, and his masterwork, *U. S. A.*, was probably the best work that came out of the period. John Dos Passos was a spectacular phenomenon in the twentieth-century literary history of the United States. Of all the major literary figures involved in the turbulence of modern American life, he experienced most the agony of having to do an about-face in his political outlook. He started off writing for the oppressed, calling himself in 1917 a "red radical revolutionary." His writings were Communist-oriented for a long period, almost from the beginning of his career through a part of the thirties when the Communists of the U. S. A. could look upon him as their fellow traveler. Then disillusionment came in 1936 when he switched over to being a New Dealer and dismissed communism as one of so many ideas and powers that would promise to improve the lot of the people at the expense of their freedom. In the meantime, his attack on capitalism remained vehement until the fifties when his change to conservatism seemed complete. During the latter part of his career, Dos Passes showed admiration for business, and supported the U. S. involvement in the Vietnam War.

Dos Passos' literary output was immense. In addition to the two trilogies, *U. S. A.* and *District of Columbia*, he wrote novels, plays, volumes of reportage, and a series of socio-historical works. But he is remembered today chiefly for *U. S. A.*, the most ambitious of fictions produced in the thirties. An imaginative compendium of the nation in its various facets during the first three decades of this century, the trilogy comprises *The 42nd Parallel* (1930), *1919* (1932), and *The Big Money* (1936). The first of these covers the period in which America emerged as an industrial giant, the "machine" which was to dominate and impede the free growth of individual lives. *1919* is a record of the First World War, a continuation of the "depersonalizing" process that had been going on as narrated in the first book, and a preparation for documenting the booming twenties in the last, *The Big Money*. Beginning with the birth of the 20th century and leading up to the Sacco-Vanzetti incident in 1927, the trilogy presents a near-authentic fictional history of the evolution of America which began from the Gilded Age. These were the years in which the socialist movement suffered defeat, and industrialists and financiers and big businessmen emerged winners. Individuals of all classes lost out to the "machine" which tyrannically subjected them to its will and power. From the point of view of personal development these were most frustrating years. Dos Passos saw this and sensed the mood of despair more keenly than most of his contemporaries. The world of *U. S. A.* is therefore one where, as Edmund Wilson observes, no birds sing, no flowers bloom, and the air is virtually unbreathable.

U. S. A. belongs to that category of fiction which Northrop Frye would call "anatomy." It is a kind of narrative in which ideas dominate. Dos Passos uses his characters to stand for ideas, indeed, so much so that they often appear to be stereotyped. *U. S. A.* has been known as a "collectivist" novel, dealing with the lives of eleven leading characters and over 30 minor ones to body forth one pervasive idea that the "machine" is hostile to the physical and spiritual welfare of the individual. Dos Passos is good at depicting the classified existence that was modern life. His characters as individuals are all of them every moment of their lives subjected to the pressure of the "machine" and succeed or fail depending on their response to its workings. There is, for instance, J. Ward Moorehouse, who represents in his life and career, that section of the

society ?big business ?which manipulates and dominates through the "machine." This section grows aware of the operations of the "machine," complies with its demands, submits willingly to its will and power, and becomes its spokesman. J. Ward Moorehouse's is a success story, one of material rise but decidedly spiritual fall. To this segment belongs Richard Ellsworth Savage who starts out being an idealist, gets to know the nature of the system, and learns to conform to and take advantage of it. He manages to attain a degree of satisfaction in his material success though at the expense of his moral integrity. Eleanor Stoddard is a different case from both Moorehouse and Savage. Hers is an almost instinctive quest for a parasitic kind of happiness. Inadvertently she accepts the tyranny of the "machine," and tries to make the best of what it can offer her. Jumping from one man's bed to another, she succeeds in obtaining a material security after she has gone through the stages of degradation. In their frenzied attempt to get ahead in worldly affairs, these people lose all spiritual orientation.

Dos Passos' picture of the lower classes is done with a pathos at times bordering on sentimentality. Janey Williams, Mac McCreary, and Charley Anderson represent between them the varied experience of the working class. Coming from the working class, Janey tries to get out of it. She seems to accept her world as the best possible and makes ready to cash in on any luck that comes her way. The idea of caste becomes increasingly clear and important to her so that she becomes obsessed with it. Thus she turns her back not only on the people who try to do things for her, but also on her brother. She seems to be intended as a foil to the one-time revolutionary, Mac McCreary. A former "Wobbly" turned Mexican revolutionary, Mac is the foremost representation of working-class men, fired at first with a fervent sense of mission to better the lot of the whole of his class. He goes to join the revolutionaries in Mexico, but becomes entangled with a woman there, ultimately overwhelmed with too much capital to continue his revolutionary work. Mac's life suggests that as soon as one gets property, his social ideas get watered down, and for him the revolution is over. Such is the sweeping force of Dos Passos' satirical pen that its thrust is pointed toward almost everybody, sparing not even people like Mac. And such is the nature of his attack on the system as a whole that to say that he was left-oriented may have been absurd because beside the point. Charley Anderson becomes a victim of the "machine" because he fails to manipulate it for his own good. As some critic has noted, he accepts the domination of the "machine" but cannot live under its pressure "without steeping himself in seas of whisky." Then there is Mary French who, closely tied to the Communists, opposes the "machine" bitterly, but unaware, as Dos Passos hints, that communism may be another form of "machine" working against the freedom of the individual: an idea Dos Passos found time to develop in his *Adventures of a Young Man* (1939). And there is Ben Compton, a socialist, agitator, determined to invite the "machine" to destroy him. Thus a wide spectrum of life is seen in U. S. A.

John Dos Passos was a courageous experimentalist in the art of novel-writing. He employed, in his fiction, devices which had not been known before. In between the narratives about the lives of ordinary people, devices like the "Newsreels," the "Biographies," and the "Camera Eye" are introduced. "Newsreels" consist of newspaper headlines, extracts from newspaper reports, and bits of popular songs. These give an idea of the social unrest and the mood of the times against which the fictional characters define themselves, and establish a time scheme for the reader as well. The "Biographies" are about the famous Americans who emerged as "benefactors" of mankind, and indicate what the prodigious energy of America could produce ?labor leaders, electricians, scientists, heroes and villains such as Eugene Debs, Big Bill Haywood, Luther Burbank, Bryan,

Carnegie, Edison, La Follette, John Reed, Theodore Roosevelt, Wilson, Veblen, the Wright brothers, the Morgans, Henry Ford, and Frank Lloyd Wright. The lives of these people contrast with the meaner existence of the ordinary people and furnish a frame of reference with which to comprehend and evaluate it. The "Camera Eye" registers the responses and reflections of some presiding consciousness, moving around alone, standing aside from or over and above the kaleidoscopic experience of the human world, meditating on it, and maturing emotionally. Here are thoughts, sometimes fragmentary, always done in an impressionistic or stream-of-consciousness manner, with motifs repeated, and themes played back and forth, all intended to increase the awareness of the reader. In addition to the devices for which Dos Passos will be remembered in the literary history of his country, he is proficient in the use of simple diction, impressive images, rhythmical sentences and parallels. He is good at creating a proper distance between his narrator and the events narrated, and connecting thought units by "and" ?a typical feature of twentieth-century colloquial style in America. John Dos Passos is a stylist in his own way.

Dos Passos intends to be an "architect of history." He wants to place the whole of the American experience in the first thirty years of this century under close scrutiny and bring into relief the mind of a generation ?his generation. As he feels the mind of a generation is its speech, he wrote U. S. A. in the speech of the people. Reading the trilogy, one tends to be overwhelmed by the documents, facts, and the exquisite chaos of modern experience that it contains. One tends to lose sight of order in disorder, connection in dislocation, and unity in disparateness and diversity. But one manages to secure a totality of impression, the idea that the capitalist "machine" thwarts individual growth and destroys individuality in its ruthless leveling operations. Thus U. S. A. is an organic whole, every bit as well organized as *The Waste Land* and *The Cantos*. Dos Passos wants to tell the truth about American life. He hopes to paint a panorama of American society. It is just to note that he did both to the best of his ability in U. S. A. If he had not written anything else, he would still have been a major American author of this century.

John Steinbeck (1902-1968)

Another significant Depression writer was John Steinbeck. He was born in Salinas, California. His father was a government official, and his mother a school teacher. He grew up at home reading British and French classics. He went to Stanford University (1919-1925), but never graduated. A rather odd period of his youth followed in which he did not know what to do with himself. He worked as a farm laborer, a seaman on a cattle-boat, a newspaper reporter, a bricklayer, a chemist's assistant, a surveyor, and a migratory fruit-picker. This was a very educational period for him because it set the basis of his works, especially *The Grapes of Wrath*. Later, with his father's support, he decided to be a professional writer. He wrote some romantic books such as *Cup of Gold* (1929), *The Pastures of Heaven* (1932) and *To a God Unknown* (1933), but none of these made any stir on the literary scene.

Then in 1935, at the age of 33, Steinbeck discovered himself. He discovered both his subject and his method. The book that appeared that year, *Tortilla Flat* (1935), made him popular. It tells, in an affectionate manner, about the life of a few Spanish bums. Though not a fighting book, it is very well done, and remains one of his better works. The next year he wrote a book about a strike which began his period of concern with a very big subject of the time, namely, the class struggle in the United States. The book was entitled *In Dubious Battle*, a very articulate "proletarian" story. Now Steinbeck found himself in a creative rush. He managed to bring out a book a year. When Of

Mice and Men appeared in 1937, it became a bestseller. It is a story of two migrant workers, one of whom is very strong and powerful physically but mentally weak and deficient, and the other, the younger and smaller, who takes care of the big one. What they wish for is a permanent home, a very small white house with trees around it. But this is pure daydream for the helpless. Finally disaster overtakes them. The big one is accused of having killed somebody and the local people are after him to lynch him, while the small one tries to keep him from being lynched. The story was rewritten into a play and a movie and made Steinbeck's reputation.

His greatest book is, of course, *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939). A story of the migration of agricultural workers from the dust bowl of Oklahoma to California, the novel is full of bitterness and pain but not exactly despair. Through inconceivable suffering and privation shines still a refreshing ray of hope conspicuously absent in the other crisis novels of the thirties. It is essentially its humanity that triumphs. *The Grapes of Wrath* helped in great measure toward increasing the nation's awareness of the seriousness of its problems, and won in time the Pulitzer Prize for fiction. However, the book caused a good deal of controversy. It was attacked and banned for a length of time on both ideological and artistic grounds: it was accused of being communist (which it is of course not) and a structurally formless book. World War II furnished Steinbeck with material for some of his books like *The Moon is Down* (1942). His later books include, among others, *East of Eden* (1952) and *The Winter of Our Discontent* (1961). Of these *East of Eden* is perhaps the most ambitious though it never can touch *The Grapes of Wrath* by any standard. He wrote a bestseller, *Travels with Charley* (1962), one of the most embarrassing of his books. Like the later Dos Passos, Steinbeck in his later years turned very conservative. He won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1962.

The Grapes of Wrath is one of the major American books. The title of the book comes from "The Battle Hymn of the Republic," a war song of the Civil War, in which there are the lines, "Mine eyes have seen the glory of the coming of the Lord, / He is tramping out the vintage where the grapes of wrath are stored." The implication of this is that as injustice is building up and up, something is going to explode into violence. *The Grapes of Wrath* is a crisis novel. It is Steinbeck's clear expression of sympathy with the dispossessed and the wretched. The Great Depression throws the country into abject chaos and makes life intolerable for the luckless millions. One of the worst stricken areas is the central prairie lands. There the farmers become bankrupt and begin to move in a body toward California, where they hope to have a better life. The westering is a most tragic and brutalizing human experience for families like the Joads. There is unspeakable pain and suffering on the road, and death occurs frequently. Everywhere they travel, they see a universal landscape of decay and desolation. When they reach California and try to settle down, they meet with bitter resistance from the local landowners. Iniquity is widespread and wrath is about to overwhelm patience. The prophecy of an imminent explosion is sent forth from the anger-saturated pages. What Steinbeck is saying is that when most people are hungry and cold, they will resort to force and take what they need. It is a heinous crime to burn coffee for fuel in the ships, burn corn to keep warm, slaughter the pigs and bury them, and let the people suffer. The day of wrath is coming. In the souls of the people the grapes of wrath are filling and growing heavy. Something in the nature of a social revolution would be imminent, the book is in effect saying, if nothing is done to stop the detonation. This is perhaps one of the reasons why the book was for many years banned.

Structurally, *The Grapes of Wrath* consists of two blocks of material: the westward trek of

the Joads and the dispossessed Oklahomans, and the general picture of the Great Depression. The fact that the intercalary chapters are dispersed in between others tends to give one the impression of a formal looseness not to be tolerated in a good work of art. However, critical research has revealed a close relationship between the two parts of the book. The interchapters function as informational and informative, offering, for instance, the social and historical background against which the characters move. We read the appalling description of drought at the beginning of the book to get ready for the unnerving population movement that constitutes its action. The dismal look of Highway 66 enables us to visualize the tragic nature of the trek of the Oklahomans. The chapters dealing with migrant life appear in between the narrative chapters of the actual westering journey, while the last interchapter describes the rain in which the action of the novel ends. These are some illustrations of the inherent unity of the novel.

The novel is structurally interesting for another, perhaps more important, reason, that its structure is dictated by the Bible. There are suggestions that the author was thinking about the Bible when writing the novel. The 30 chapters fall neatly into three sections, with the description of the drought in the first ten, the journeying in chapters 13 through 18, and the remaining 12 devoted to a narrative of the life of the migrants in California. These three sections correspond to "The Exodus" story in the Old Testament. The Exodus tells about the bondage of the ancient Jews in Egypt, their escape out of it and journeying toward Canaan, the Promised Land. In distant times, so the story goes, the Jews went to Egypt in search of food and, having stayed there for some 400 years, became the slaves of the Egyptian Pharaoh. Their suffering was such that God sent Moses as His prophet to lead them out. This Moses did, and the great host traveled through the desert toward Canaan, only to meet with bitter resistance there. *The Grapes of Wrath*, in emphasizing the fact of the Oklahomans coming from the Oklahoma desert, crossing the big Death Valley desert and into California, the land of hope for them, works out the parallel to "the Exodus" admirably well. Steinbeck is not stating this very explicitly, but the suggestion is very strong, and is supported by symbols such as that of the grapes. For instance, there is mention of grapes in such Bible books as "Deuteronomy" (??? 32), "Jeremiad" (??? 29), and "the Revelation." And the fact that Rose of Sharon gives milk to the dying old man, that Ma Joad always says, "We are the people" (meaning "God's chosen people"), and uncle John, placing Rose of Sharon's stillborn child in an old box and setting it in a stream among the willow stems, murmurs, "Go down an' tell'em" (a very strong reminder of the birth and the mission of Moses) ?all these are but come of the many details illustrating biblical influence in the novel.

The reading of *The Grapes of Wrath* can be a very odd experience. One sees the Depression spreading devastation and desolation, the dispossessed and the wretched walking the earth like so many condemned souls in Hell, and the worst of human nature in its uncontrolled and uncontrollable manifestations. One senses despair as one reads along, and sees no prospect of compensation for all this earthly suffering until one reaches the last chapter of the book. There, in the meaningful act of Rose of Sharon offering her milk to a dying man, one sees a gleam of hope, and one's confidence in man and human nature, the belief that a better life will be possible, returns, almost to overbalance the scale of one's judgment. Here lies, probably, the distinction which tells Steinbeck apart from other crisis writers of the 1930s. Amid the gloom and the defeatism which pervade the writing of the decade, Steinbeck manages to keep a refreshing faith in humanity, in the future when man will come to grips with his problems and come out all right. This ability to see beyond the immediate present into a better future has proved to be one of the things that have

given Steinbeck his claim to fame and permanence.

CHAPTER 18 Porter elty McCullers West The New Criticism

Porter, Welty, and McCullers

Katherine Anne Porter (1890-1980) was born in Indian Creek, Texas. She began her life as a news reporter and sometimes as an actress and ballad singer traveling through the south. Later she stayed in Europe and Mexico which proved very valuable for her writing. She was basically a short-story writer. Her famous short fiction includes "The Flowering Judas" and "The Jilting of Granny Weatherall," both collected in *Flowering Judas* (1930), and makes her one of the finest short story writers of her century. Her *Pale Horse, Pale Rider* (1939) and *Learning Tower and Other Stories* (1944) reinforced her reputation so that she became a writer of a high order that had to be reckoned with. She was not as good at sustained creative effort. She began work on her one novel in the 1930s, but the book, *Ship of Fools*, which she kept talking about writing and completing for twenty years, and kept working at on an on-and-off basis, came out at long last in 1962. There was an expensive advertising campaign, with a great number of favorable reviews and good sales, and it was made into a popular movie. It made her financially comfortable. Robert Penn Warren called it "one of the publishing events of all time." It was an immediate success. But it has not stood the test of time well. She is today mainly remembered for her famous short stories. Her *Collected Stories* (1965) won her both a Pulitzer Prize and a National Book Award. Katherine Anne Porter lectured at various universities, such as Stanford, the University of Michigan, and the University of Virginia, and received honorary doctorates from various institutions. She was vice president of the National Institute of Arts and Letters from 1950 to 1952. She knew that she would have a place in the literary history of the country. In 1956 she wrote to the effect that it would be inconceivable for people to write the story of American literature and leave her out. And she was right. Her writings, especially her short fiction, have been well anthologized and offered as "standard fare" for the college classroom. She has been well remembered.

Her *Ship of Fools* was based on her first voyage from Mexico to Europe in 1931. She took notes of her experience on the trip and began the long process of conceiving and writing the novel. She declared that her novel was concerned with the downhill drag of western civilization. The title is a translation of the German of Sebastian Brant's *Das Narrenschiff* which Katherine Anne Porter read in 1932 immediately after her voyage. Sebastian Brant, a 15th-century savant with deep religious convictions and highest motives, was a satirist of human follies. So was Katherine Anne Porter in her *Ship of Fools*, with this difference that she made it clear in her prefatory note to the novel that she was a passenger on that ship herself. The novel consists of three parts, "Embarkation," "High Sea," and "The Harbours." The first of these introduces the passengers. Here on board the German *Vera* is a rich assortment of people, the Germans, some Spaniards, Swiss, Mexicans, Americans, Cubans, and one Swede. In age there are little kids of six to eight years old or younger, single boys and girls, the newly wed on honeymoon, the middle-aged, and the dying old. In terms of human emotions and experiences there are exhibited the whole spectrum of emotions such as love and hate, snobbery and apathy, envy and jealousy, and the whole gamut of possible occurrences like violence and murder, incest and prostitution, theft and deception, personal incompatibility, and religious bigotry. Katherine Anne Porter sees in the *Vera* the "universal image of the ship of this world on its voyage to eternity." It is meant as a metaphor for the macrocosmic human world. The novel is supposed to tell the truth about man and his life. And

the truth as is revealed here is disconcertingly depressing. Man is portrayed with his foibles and failings that make him out as an arrant fool. Their behavior is generally so disgusting, there is so much evil in their nature, life is so sad and lonely and sickening that it is not quite worth living. They voyage toward a place waiting dark and cold for them. One reads the book and comes away with the impression that misanthropy is justifiable.

Let's take a look at Katherine Anne Porter's oft-anthologized "The Jilting of Granny Weatherall." This was written in the stream of consciousness manner. Ellen (or Granny) Weatherall, the protagonist of the story, now eighty years old, is dying. On this last day of her life, her mind is busy shuttling back and forth between now and the past, trying to look for an answer to the puzzle that has bothered her all her life. When she was young and ready to get married, her fiancé? George, did not appear at the altar. However, she moved on and got married to John. They had five fine children together, but John died young, leaving Ellen to shift for herself all alone. The strong and able Ellen did all the hard work, brought up the children well, and had a meaningful life. She has managed to weather through it all. She has proved herself a truly wonderful and admirable woman. Now that her end has come, she is not ready to die. Something that has gnawed at her soul all along at the bottom of her being now surfaces in her last-moment reminiscences. She would find George and tell him that she has had a good life despite his jilting of her. It is evident that she has all through the decades not forgotten George; nor has she forgiven him for the havoc he had wreaked with her life. She would like to have her vengeance on him by telling him about the wonderful life she has had. As she does not forgive, she has a quarrel with her God. So, as goes with Christian teachings, she is not forgiven. The end of the story shows that she is doomed to go down to Hell. Granny Weatherall is a tragic heroine. Her flaw may be twofold: her un-forgiveness, and the fact that she is a one-man's woman. She loves George and has never stopped doing so. On her last day, she sees John's enlarged picture on the dresser and complains about the photo-shop doing a sloppy job: John's eyes in the picture are very black but Granny thinks they should have been blue. Evidently her befuddled mind mistakes John for George whose eyes were obviously blue. Although married to John, she has not related to him as her husband, and has seen George as her love. All her life she feels that what George's jilting has destroyed has been given back to her, but now she makes to the painful realization that not all has been and something is missing. It is her true love. Whereas her love is heroic (in the sense that it stays for one man), it is not fair to John. This could have been a reason for her gloomy end as well. "The Jilting of Granny Weatherall" is a rich and complex story, and as such it is capable of more than one interpretation. It reveals the exquisiteness of Katherine Anne Porter's artistic imagination.

Eudora Welty (1909-2001) was born and raised in Jackson, Mississippi. She was well educated and had wide contact with life and people. Since the publication of her first story, "Death of a Traveling Salesman" in 1936 (which made her immediately famous), she had been very productive up to her death, writing short stories, novellas, and novels and winning awards including the Pulitzer Prize. She has been most well known for her achievement in writing short stories.

Eudora Welty emphasizes the importance of place for literary creations. In her essay "Place in Fiction" (1956), she observes clearly that "place" serves as a repository for the feelings of authors, makes them pay attention to detail and portray things with clarity, and prepares them to see through things. She feels that art that speaks most clearly, explicitly, directly, and passionately from its place of origin will remain the longest understood. She is noted for her fidelity to her

place, the American south, but manages to reach out to her readers on a more universal plane.

Welty's major themes relate to traditional southern family relationships. Her focus is not so much on describing the vicissitudes of family fortunes (as in a way Faulkner does) as on the exploration of the inner world of her characters, their interactions, and the power of love. Her characters range from aristocrats to farmers, who come forth with their interior monologues and reveal the emotional tenor of their lives. These people engage in self-searching, and look for meaning in their existence. Her most famous story, "Death of a Traveling Salesman" is a good example.

"Death of a Traveling Salesman" dramatizes the importance of family. R. J. Bowman is a shoe salesman who travels all year round in order to make a living. He does not know what it feels like to have a family. Now sick and weak, he drags himself out along and seeks help from a farmer when bogged down in an accident. Here he is very moved to see a happy family scene where the farmer and his wife live happily, expecting the birth of their baby, and he feels sad and sorry for himself, sick, lonely, craving love and warmth but having none. He dies on a long night road stretching before him. Here Welty offers a picture of alienation through her portrait of Bowman. Cut off from the rest of the world, Bowman lives a loveless, meaningless life with no sense of belonging whatever. In contrast, the farmer and his wife enjoy mutual love and trust and make the best of what they have got. They are poor, but they think positive, and act positive, and always have something good to look forward to. They illustrate the kind of harmony absent from the bleak existence of the salesman, the harmony of the inner with the external world, and of reason with emotion.

Welty's preoccupation with family life is well exhibited in her novel, *Delta Wedding* (1946). The main narrator is a nine-year-old girl whose interior monologue details the elaborate, emotionally charged preparations for the wedding of a plantation owner's daughter, the events surrounding it, and the picnic in honor of the couple returning from their honeymoon. The narrative brims with love that holds a large family together. The novel is a song of compassion and selflessness in human relationship.

Welty's other works emphasize the theme of isolation and alienation and other aspects of family life. "A Worn Path," for instance, depicting a grandmother going downtown to get medication for her grandson, touches both on isolation that the heroic old woman experiences on her journey and on the sacrifice that one must make for love of family. "Why I Live at the P.O." tells the story of a young woman leaving home and settling down at a post office because of disrupted family life. Read "Lily Draw and the Three Ladies," "The Key," "The Whistle," or "Flowers for Marjorie," and so many other similar stories, and we will get to know about the author's obsession with family, love, and human fellowship.

Carson McCullers (1917-1967) was said to touch William Faulkner in writing. This is not very valid because she does not equal Faulkner in vision and power. Faulkner has that epic stature that few, including McCullers, possess, and his view of life and people is incomparably larger. But the very critical notion of putting her aside the older novelist indicates the great achievement that McCullers scored in her career.

Carson McCullers was born in Columbus, Georgia. When she was little, she was precocious and determined but had few friends. The acute sense of isolation might be in part accountable for her obsession with themes such as alienation, violence, and horror. She had a rich imagination and wanted to become a writer. She was well read and attended fiction-writing classes at Columbia

University. When her first novel, *The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter*, came out in 1940, her successful career began. She wrote some bestsellers, became rich and famous, suffered emotional upheavals, and died at 50. Her important works include *Reflections in a Golden Eye* (1940), *The Ballad of the Sad Café* (1943/1951), *The Member of the Wedding* (1946), and *Clock Without Hands* (1961). In addition, she wrote numerous short stories, a play, and a book of children's verses.

Carson McCullers has a Gothic vision of human life which her friend Tennessee Williams called the "sense of the awful." Some people, she seemed to think, are meant to live lives of horror and alienation. These mostly physical and spiritual freaks exist to represent forces that can wreck havoc with human life. It was the grotesque, the freakish, and the incongruous of the human condition that caught her attention. It was the lonely and the outcast, the sense of not belonging, that became the focus of her fiction. Love is important, but it brings with it insoluble problems that cause pain or even death. McCullers' fictional world is inhabited by hunchbacks, deaf mutes, or adolescents who find it hard to love and live normal lives. Many of them are bisexual or asexual.

The Ballad of the Sad Café is one of her well-known works. It reflects the basic tenor of life and behavior in her fiction. The love and pain theme runs through the whole story. The owner of the small town café, Amelia Evans, a girl of nineteen, is married with a man, Marvin Macy by name, who is said to have killed a man and still carry the victim's dry salted ear around. Having found this ghastly possession on him on the wedding night, Amelia drives Marvin out, who then runs away, robs some stores and serves time in prison, and returns in the end to avenge himself. While he is away, a hunchback of a cousin, Lyman Willis by name, shows up and somehow arouses the love latent in the bosom of the hitherto still virgin Amelia. The café changes, so does her life. Then Marvin resurfaces and somehow arouses the love latent in Lyman who then follows him around like a dog and even invites him to stay with him on Amelia's premises. The stage is thus set for the showdown between Marvin and Amelia, and Marvin wins only with the help of the hunchback. The café and Amelia are both devastated, and so is the town. Marvin and Lyman vanish. The agony and the violence would not make sense if McCullers' characters were not understood in her way. McCullers makes it clear in the middle of section two of the three-part story that love is doomed to bring pain to the two parties involved because the conflict between them is insoluble. The lover and the beloved experience the relationship differently so that hate inevitably occurs. It is this feeling that would lead to violence, death, and suffering. The love-hate complex exists here in all the three love relationships, with Lyman epitomizing the author's notion of love.

Carson McCullers was versatile and productive. Although sick most of her adult life, she wrote novels, novellas, short stories, and a play. She was an admirable writer indeed.

Nathanael West (1903-1940)

An important figure to appear in the 1930s was Nathanael West, who tried to adapt European avantgardism to American writing. Born into a wealthy New York family, Nathanael West was well read in world classics. In the mid-1920s he went to Paris where he made the acquaintance with modernist writers such as Gertrude Stein, Pound, T. S. Eliot, and James Joyce and became one of the young expatriate writers there. There he was exposed to the influence of French symbolism, aestheticism, and surrealism. In the Depression of the 1930s West had contact with the writers on the left and expressed support for the Spanish people in their fight against Fascism. West died in an automobile accident in 1940.

In the particular milieu of the Depression years, West was keenly aware of his dilemma: he thought he was on the side of the left, but the radicals did not seem to like him, and those that he detested detested him. His belated recognition came in the postwar years when there appeared an enormous interest in his works. The Complete Works of Nathanael West came out in 1951, and he was profusely commented upon. In recent decades West's writing has been reread as a kind of negative critique of commercialism and the culture industry, and its avant-gardist techniques intrigued the curious younger generation. His influence on later writers has been given sufficient credit. Carson McCullers, Flannery O'Connor, Joseph Heller, Saul Bellow, Thomas Pynchon, Ralph Ellison, and Ishmael Reed are all found to be in one way or another indebted to him. **Whereas he was little known when alive, he has received good posthumous critical attention and has been regarded as one of best writers to come out of the 1930s and the first important postwar novelist. He is seen as a predecessor to the American novelists of the absurd in the 1960s.**

West wrote quite a few unique novels. These include *The Dream Life of Balso Snell* (1931), *Miss Lonelyhearts* (1933), *A Cool Million: The Dismantling of Lemuel Pitkin* (1934), and *The Day of the Locust* (1939). He thought he wrote "moral satires," but there are signs of visible immorality and spiritual decay there (as W. H. Auden sees it). Reading West, one gets the impression that he delights enormously in scandalizing his readers. His subjects often involve violence of a brutalizing kind, his narratives are presented in a surrealist manner, and his characters are grotesque and dehumanized. His bleak and absurd vision comes through well in his works. For instance, the first novel is scatological and collagistic. There are the anal penetration of the Trojan horse, the intestine tour and meeting with authors in search of an audience there, and the onanistic orgasm. His *A Cool Million: The Dismantling of Lemuel Pitkin* portrays the literal dismantling of the protagonist in his attempt to become president. Lemuel Pitkin virtually dies toothless, eyeless, thumbless, bald, and with one leg. The scalping of the man and the looting of the bloody head with his teeth and glass eye can be a nightmarish reading experience. It reminds the readers of Thomas Pynchon's novel *V.* in which the physical disintegration of "V." is delineated. It is probable that to Nathanael West, the life of the 1930s, especially that of the struggling millions, was downright violent and filled with black comedy. West's most famous work is probably his *The Day of the Locust*. It is a satire on the Hollywood dream factory, in which the losers feature most prominently rather than the winners, and there is bloody violence, prostitution, and chicanery all around. His *Miss Lonelyhearts*, a satire on the Hearst newspapers, is noted for its avantgardist features, and its 1946 French edition has been considered a landmark in European postwar fiction.

The New Criticism

The New Criticism as a school of poetry and criticism established itself in the 1940s as an academic orthodoxy in the United States. It is still very much in evidence today as an influence in the literary world and in college classroom instruction. The school had its beginnings in the 1920s, took over 20 years to win acceptance and some dominance in poetry writing and criticism in the 1930s and 1940s, and aroused rebellion in the 1950s and 1960s when it gradually ceased to be a school.

The New Criticism first emerged in fact as a reaction against the prevailing time-honored critical tendency to focus attention on the theme often in disregard of the form of a work. The "old" critics often demanded a literary work, such as a poem, to be something other than it is and to do a job it may not be meant to do. For instance, with the "old" critics, a discussion of a poem

often, if not always, turned out to be one of the life and times of the poet and seldom if ever got to the poem itself. The overemphasis that these critics placed on critiquing a poem from an ethical, sociological, psychological or political point of view and thus finding it wanting or inferior proved too much for some other critics so that they began voicing their ideas about what literary criticism should do. These people felt that a poem is first and foremost a poem, and that the job of the critic is to evaluate it on its own merits, and not in terms of external factors such as its social or cultural or political background and possible information from the life of its author. The critic should first find out the formal aspects of the verbal structure that is the poem, and the text should be the focus of critical reading and analysis. So the new critical concept was to be known as a kind of formalism. The new idea caught on and something like a movement was afoot. It was not a movement as organized as movements are supposed to be, but the convergence of similar voices and the echoes that it awoke in the young generation of the 1930s and 1940s made it look like one. And John Crowe Ransom's book, *The New Criticism* (1941), did not a little to foster the notion that there was such a movement in history. It was, more accurately, a school of thought that dominated American literary criticism for over two decades.

The "new" approach to criticism made these critics "the New Critics," and their critical theories "the New Criticism." These critics included T. S. Eliot, I. A. Richards, John Crowe Ransom, Allen Tate, Robert Penn Warren, William Empson, R. P. Blackmur, and Yvor Winters. It is good to note here that, from the very outset, the New Criticism has tended to divorce criticism from social and moral concerns, which was to become one salient feature of the movement.

The New Criticism dates back to the 1920s. In the High Modernism of the 1920s, new developments on the literary scene proved conducive to the emergence of the New Criticism. T. S. Eliot's attack on Romantic emotionalism, his appreciation of the 17th-century Metaphysical poets like John Donne, and his own theories of "impersonality" and "objective correlative" helped a good deal toward starting the school and establishing its basic features. So did I. A. Richards with his ideas about poetry, that a poem should be an organization of meanings capable of rational analysis, its textual structure is more important than its subject, and attention should be paid more to the works than to the "periods" and the authors in literary criticism. In addition, I. A. Richards "rediscovered" the famous Romantic poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge's critical theories as expounded in his *Biographia Literaria*. Coleridge emphasized the multiplicity and diversity of a work and the close reading of the text. Coleridge's book became popular and influential in the period from the 1920s through the 1940s. As a result of all these efforts, the critical notion became popular that the poem should be an independent entity once it is published and that the text of the poem could express meanings of which the writer may not be aware. The text should be read closely and evaluated on its own merits, not on elements external to it, be they biographical, sociological or cultural.

The new theory received further impetus in the 1930s when famous critics such as F. R. Leavis, R. P. Blackmur, Yvor Winters, and John Crowe Ransom chimed in with all their might. William Empson, one of I. A. Richards' students, developed I. A. Richards' critical thought in his *Seven Types of Ambiguity*, and Robert Penn Warren and Cleanth Brooks edited and published a textbook, *Understanding Poetry* (1938), which explained the features of the New Critical poem and pushed the new formalism into the college classroom. In addition, some literary magazines played a significant role in spreading the tenets of the New Criticism. These include T. S. Eliot's *The Criterion* (1922-1939), Leavis' *Scrutiny* (1932-1953), Cleanth Brooks and Robert Penn

Warren's *Southern Review* (1935-1942), John Crowe Ransom's *Kenyon Review* (1938-1959), and Allen Tate's *Sewanee Review*. Prominent in the New Critical school were the Fugitives (so named after the little magazine, *The Fugitive* which Ransom and Tate founded in 1922) such as Ransom, Tate, Brooks and Warren, or otherwise known as "the Southern Critics." These people made their voice heard first with the publication of their famous *I'll Take My Stand* in 1930, stating their anti-industrialization position that the agrarian south should keep its own lifestyle. They continued all through the 1930s and the 1940s to write and publish to support the new school of poetry and criticism. Their writings helped in no small way to build the New Critical theories into a coherent system and establish its importance in literary history. What was more, the creative efforts of the first generation of New Critical poets ?John Crowe Ransom, Allen Tate, William Empson etc. ?made the school of poetry a fact of history. John Crowe Ransom's collection of critical essays, *The New Criticism* (1941), gave it its final historic name.

The New Criticism dominated literary criticism and poetry writing for over three decades (right through the 1950s). As it became matter for college classroom instruction, it managed to iron its imprints into the intellectual texture of many creative minds. A good number of writers, poets in particular, were brought up with the New Critical values, and their works formed an important part of the literary canon of contemporary American poetry. The New Criticism helped younger poets learn discreetly from the Modernist tradition, and integrate it with other traditions. The 1940s generation, or the 2nd-generation New Critical poets, for instance, was notable for their achievements in the New Critical style. The names that come to mind instantly include Robert Lowell, Elizabeth Bishop, Richard Wilbur, John Berryman, Randall Jarrell, John Ashbery, and James Merrill. And there is a list of other well-established poets, probably too long to mention. The influence of the New Criticism was so profound on these poets that, when the wind of change and rebellion began to blow in the 1950s and 1960s, they found it hard to shake it off and adjust to the new milieu. It took almost a decade for Robert Lowell to switch to the new style of his *Life Studies*. Richard Wilbur, John Berryman, and James Merrill continued writing in traditional meters and stanzas. Elizabeth Bishop wrote both in traditional forms and free verse.

To sum up, as a school of formalist criticism, the New Criticism has been noted for its salient features. One of these is its focus on the analysis of the text rather paying attention to external elements such as its social background, its author's intention and political attitude, and its impact on society. Then it explores the artistic structure of the work rather than its author's frame of mind or its readers' responses. It also sees a literary work as an organic entity, the unity of content and form, and places emphasis on the close reading of the text.

Now what are the major features of the New Critical poem? The New Critical poem kept the basic Modernist values ?economy, wit, irony, impersonality, careful with form etc., but abandoned or toned down other High Modernist features such as extreme fragmentation, paratactic syntax, ellipsis, symbolism and myth, cross-culturalism, and allusions. As a result it became cautious and traditional, and less revolutionary and disorienting, and was more amenable to all tastes and more popular with the rising younger generation of the 1940s. In literary creation, attention was paid to the poem as a well-wrought urn, with its coherent form, coherent images and figures, rhymes and stanzas, impersonality, and integrated attitude and vision. The new mode of writing soon caught on. It proved to be easier to compose. It was rational, witty, rigorous in meters and stanzas.

The New Criticism may have been one of the many phases in the history of American literary criticism; its influence on the careers of many poets may have been just one of the many

phases of those creative lives. Ultimately, however, its orthodoxy was challenged and displaced; many poets grew out of its long shadow in their literary endeavors and stepped into the postmodernist era of postwar America. In retrospect, it is necessary to mention that, though the New Critical poetry may have shone forth its grandeur, few masterpieces came out of it. When all is said, one point still remains to be made, that the New Criticism is still very much in evidence today as one critical concept and one mode of writing. This is testimony to its permanence in literary history.

Now let's take a look at some of the people who helped make the New Criticism what it has been. One major figure associated with the New Criticism was John Crowe Ransom (1888-1974), a poet and a critic from Tennessee. He was more a critic than a poet. His poetry, while remarkable in some aspects, is less important than his critical works. His volumes of verse, *Poems about God* (1919), *Chills and Fever* (1924), and *Two Gentlemen in Bonds* (1927) contain some of his best creative efforts. After these books came out, he turned his attention to literary criticism and became one of the seminal influences in the New Criticism.

Ransom was basically conservative in his mindset. His collection of essays, *God without Thunder* (1930), is a vehement attack on science which he felt destroyed the myth of God. In 1930 he published *I'll Take My Stand* along with Tate and others and took his firm stand for the agrarian southern lifestyle and against that of the north and industrialization. His contribution to the New Criticism was great. Ransom was teaching at Vanderbilt University at one time, and had a group of teachers and students meeting at regular intervals to read and comment on each other's poems. In 1937 he left Vanderbilt for Kenyon College in Ohio, where he founded the *Kenyon Review*, and made it one of the most famous journals in the U. S. It carried writings on literature and criticism by Allen Tate, Robert Penn Warren, R. P. Blackmur, William Empson as well as Ransom himself and became an organ of the New Critics. His book, *The New Criticism* (1941), summarized his own critical theories as well as those of the New Critics, commenting as it does on I. A. Richards and William Empson, T. S. Eliot as a critic, and Yvor Winters. As he did not seem to think that these critics had gone far enough in their "newness," he concluded the book with its last chapter, "Wanted: An Ontological Critic." What he meant was probably that he was that kind of critic himself. Ransom's notion on the ontology of poetry is probably his major addition to the New Criticism. The "ontology of poetry" is his grand way of saying "the structure or the text of the poem itself." He holds that literary criticism should focus on the ontological value of the work and its artistic structure. The study of the life and experiences of its author, or the synopsis of its content, or analysis of its historical background, or its moral inclinations ?all these are irrelevant to the job of the critic. Ransom solidified the New Critical view that the major concern of the critic was with reading and analysis of the text of a poem as a verbal structure rather with anything else, thus helping bring a new respect for poetry and new attention to textual details. He also revealed the formalist tendency of the New Criticism to separate criticism from social considerations. The New Criticism became a significant publication, not just because it gave the final designation to a historically important movement, but because it became the battle cry for the postwar generation to declare their critical stance against the academic authorities of the time.

Allen Tate (1899-1979) was another important figure in the development of the New Criticism as a school. He began his literary career as editor of the magazine *The Fugitive*, and became one of the twelve southerners to sign the *I'll Take My Stand* in 1930. With time his poetry came to the notice of the readers and critics alike. His famous volumes include *Mr. Pope* and

Others (1928), Three Poems (1930), Collected Poems: 1922-1947 (1948), and Collected Poems (1977). Tate's best-known poems are his "Mr. Pope" and "Ode to the Confederate Dead." Like Ransom, his college professor, Tate tended to be conservative in his views. He published many essays on the importance of restoring the southern traditional values, attacked the tendency of linking politics with poetry, and embraced Catholicism in 1950. One important critical stance that Tate took on poetry and criticism was his insistent argument against interpreting literary works from a socio-economic point of view. He holds that a poem is a meaningful organic whole, self-sufficient and self-inclusive. It is different from and higher than science. As such, it can be criticized only on its inherent merits, and any other standards relating to sociology, political science, ethics, psychology and natural sciences are simply irrelevant. He claims, among other things, that a poem is an independent entity, with two levels of meaning, its intension (inherent in it) and extension (extended interpretation of it), the unity of the two is "tension," which also represents the unity of content and form. Thus he helped reinforce the New Critical position on focusing critical attention on the inner structure of the text of the poem itself.

Mention should be made of Cleanth Brooks (1906-1994) who, as a professional critic, borrowed from the theories of T. S. Eliot, I. A. Richards, William Empson, John Crowe Ransom and Allen Tate and integrated the best of these into one system. His major contribution to the New Criticism lay in his application of the New Critical theories to the analysis of specific literary works. He edited, in collaboration with Robert Penn Warren, college textbooks such as *Understanding Poetry*, which annotated poems and provided exercises, and in so doing helped the New Criticism to worm its way into the classroom. There the textbooks have stayed and are read and taught even today. The effort has had a far-reaching impact on contemporary literature. Brooks' unique role in popularizing the New Criticism cannot be overrated.

CHAPTER 19 American Drama

To say that American drama began in 1916 when the Provincetown Players produced Eugene O'Neill's first play, *Bound East for Cardiff*, is to write off the efforts of the nineteenth-century playwrights too ruthlessly to be just. It is true that there were no great masters in the theater comparable in stature to such major figures in fiction as Melville or James, but there had been people who did spadework for the rise of American drama in the 1920s. Late nineteenth-century realists such as William Vaughn Moody (1869-1910) made his tentative attempt to place realistic drama on the American stage, and Eugene Walter and Percy Mackaye carried out some dramatic experimentation around the turn of the century. With the stimulus that came from the naturalistic, symbolic, and critical drama of Europe, and possibly moved by the vigorous stirrings in American poetry and fiction, American drama began the process of developing itself into a department of American literature equal in significance to both poetry and the novel. Experimental theaters sprang up, and the works of European dramatists like Ibsen, Strindberg, and Bernard Shaw appeared on the stage. In the meantime, modern American dramatists began to attract attention. The Theater Guild produced Elmer Rice's *The Adding Machine*, and O'Neill's *Beyond the Horizon* was performed on Broadway. These, together with Maxwell Anderson's *What Price Glory?*, George Kelley's *The Show-Off* and Sidney Howard's *They Knew What They Wanted*, made a renaissance of drama in the 1920s.

The theater of the Depression was not depressing. Like other branches of literature the drama was preoccupied with social concerns. In addition to O'Neill and Maxwell Anderson,

Clifford Odets with his *Waiting for Lefty* and the dramatization of Steinbeck's *Of Mice and Men* captivated large audiences. All through the 1940s and the post-war period, new playwrights and new plays kept appearing. If Eugene O'Neill dominated the theater in the 1920s, then it is safe to say that Tennessee Williams did so in the post-war years. The staging of his *The Glass Menagerie* on Broadway in 1945 was an event of unusual significance, as it marked American drama's coming of age. Also active in the theater were Williams' contemporaries, Arthur Miller and William Inge. Miller's *Death of a Salesman* and Inge's plays of the early fifties touched American audiences to the quick. The late fifties saw a temporary decline in dramatic productions, but in the next decade, with Edward Albee, Arthur Kopit, David Mamet and Sam Shepard active on the scene, American drama picked up a good deal of fresh energy. With the passage of time there has appeared the increasingly more obvious tendency to "decentralize" from Broadway with more and more plays staged Off-Broadway and Off-Off-Broadway. And from the end of the sixties American theater entered a new phase in its development when diversity became one of its salient features. New voices are heard. The theatrical canon needs redefining. There are the multiracial and multiethnic playwrights such as August Wilson, Hanay Geiogamah, David Henry Hwang, and Luis Valdez, and there are the feminist playwrights like Beth Hanley, Marsha Norman, and Tina Howe. The period is still in progress, and reputations are still being made. This, then, is a sketchy overview of American drama.

We begin with Eugene O'Neill (1888-1953), America's greatest playwright. With his father, James O'Neill, being a famous actor, love of drama ran in the blood of the man. It was some years yet before he became a mature playwright, but those years of knocking about in the world can be legitimately seen as a preparation for the vocation which he eventually took. O'Neill traveled around with his father's group and took a year in Princeton, from which he was expelled because of misbehavior. He went to sea and voyaged to South America and South Africa. Back in America, he was out of work. He made friends with the lowest of society and got to know life better. The experience of wandering and loafing about stood O'Neill in good stead. As we shall see presently he drew so much from it in his creative work. The most decisive period in the career of Eugene O'Neill came in the winter of 1912-13 when he developed tuberculosis and was sent to a sanitarium. For the first time in his life he had the leisure to read and meditate. He read widely in the world's dramatic literature, and became infatuated with the works of Ibsen and Strindberg. The imitativeness of the theater of the time, with its performances at once melodramatic and divorced from reality, disgusted young O'Neill, so that he began to think seriously of breaking new ground. After he recovered from tuberculosis, he joined, some time in 1914, the famous Professor Pierce Baker's 47 Workshop at Harvard to learn to write better. After that, he lived in Greenwich Village, New York, where he began to write. The summer of 1916 proved to be significant both for O'Neill and for American drama: the Provincetown Players produced O'Neill's first performed play, the one-act *Bound East for Cardiff*. The event marked the beginning of O'Neill's long and successful dramatic career and ushered in the modern era of the American theater. Thereafter the road to Broadway was smooth for the rising star.

There he "arrived" in 1920 with his *Beyond the Horizon*. The response was universal acclaim, and for the next fourteen years he stayed on Broadway. After *Beyond the Horizon*, a series of theatrical triumphs followed in fairly quick succession: *The Emperor Jones* (1920), *Anna Christie* (1921), *The Hairy Ape* (1922), *Desire under the Elms* (1924), *All God's Chillun Got Wings* (1924), *The Great God Brown* (1926), *Lazarus Laughed* (1926), *Strange Interlude* (1928),

Marco Millions (1928), Dynamo (1929), Mourning Becomes Electra (1931), Ah, Wilderness (1933) and Days without End (1934). Then between 1934 and 1946 a period of silence intervened in which O'Neill suffered from ill health but planned new plays. When he came back to Broadway he brought with him The Iceman Cometh (1946), with which he began the last and best phase of his great career. Plays staged in this period included the superb Long Day's Journey into Night (1956), A Moon for the Misbegotten (1957), and A Touch of the Poet (1958), all of which were performed after his death in 1953. O'Neill was a prize-winning playwright. He received the Pulitzer Prize for his Beyond the Horizon and Anna Christie between 1920 and 1922, and the Nobel Prize in 1936.

O'Neill was always active and dynamic. If the reputation of other playwrights have followed the pattern of a rise and fall, that of O'Neill has remained enduring. The magic of his power lies in his never ceasing attempt to improve his art in step with the spirit of the times. We notice that O'Neill began writing in a naturalistic vein, as is evident in his plays like The Hairy Ape, Beyond the Horizon, and Anna Christie. Then, inspired by the prevailing zest for experimentation, he moved on into a phase of his career in which he became somewhat obsessed with devices such as symbolism and expressionism. The Emperor Jones is a good example. During the 1940s O'Neill turned back to the naturalistic spirit in which he wrote some of his best works like Long Day's Journey into Night. Thus in a sense, his career came full circle.

O'Neill was a sensitive artist. He felt "the discordant, broken, faithless rhythm" of his time and tried to "get at the root" of human desires and frustrations. The tragic sense of modern man being helpless and impotent remained with O'Neill all through his career. The Hairy Ape is a good illustration. It concerns the problem of modern man's sense of "belonging." A stoker on a luxury liner, "Yank" by name, is happy with life until the day when he is forced to realize that he does not "belong" anywhere. He is disconcerted, becomes violent, and is even rejected by the radical workers. In his quest for self-identity, he wanders to the zoo where he finds affinity with the great ape there. He goes over to it and finds its outstretched arms lovely and fascinating: "Come on, Brother," he calls out to the gorilla, holds out his hand and invites the gorilla to shake it. Then something happens and the gorilla looks enraged. It wraps its arms around Yank. A cracking snap of crushed ribs is heard with a gasping cry. Then Yank makes to the pathetic realization that he even does not quite belong among the hairy apes. Thus crushed in the embrace of the gorilla, he dies, without ever finding his place of "belonging." The general feeling is one of total despair: Man is rootless in an indifferent and impersonal universe.

By far the best works which O'Neill ever wrote are The Iceman Cometh and Long Day's Journey into Night. They represent the fact that O'Neill's lifelong quest for values ended in failure. If his earlier frustrated characters manage to retain some faith in life, then the group of misfits in The Iceman Cometh and the Tyrone family in Long Day's Journey have nothing but the night stretching before them. The mood of sheer despair that pervades these plays indicates that any illusion O'Neill had cherished about life had evaporated completely. The Iceman Cometh offers an appalling description of the inner world of a group of people who fail to come to terms with life. Despite the fact that they come from different walks of life there is one common denominator in their lives, that by the time they meet in a riverside bar, they have all begun to live on nothing but illusion. Afraid to face the life of the moment, they cast a backward glance at the past and brag about turning over a new leaf in life tomorrow. Though tomorrow never comes, they manage to derive from the idea a kind of courage with which to keep on living, for they all know that as soon

as that illusion vanishes, they would vanish, too, into night. They have escaped into the sanctuary of illusion, and the only way out of it is death. Nowhere else is the depth of despair in O'Neill revealed so unequivocally.

Long Day's Journey into Night is somewhat autobiographical. The Tyrone family of the play are in fact modeled on the O'Neill family. The four major characters include James Tyrone, the father, a famous actor, anxious to become rich at the expense of his own talent; Mary Tyrone, the mother, a drug addict; Jamie Tyrone, their elder son, and Edmund Tyrone, their younger son. The Mother becomes mentally ill because she is extremely unhappy with her married life. Young Jamie loses faith in life, while Edmund the wanderer comes back with tuberculosis. All the four suffer frustrations and wish to escape from the harsh reality, James and Jamie looking for solace in their cups, while Mary and Edmund seek the protection of the fog which they hope would screen them from the intrusion of the world outside. They meet in the living room of the family's summer home at 8:30 A. M. of a day in August, 1912 and torment one another and themselves until midnight. The father is angry with the mother for her drug addiction, the mother with his sons for being good for nothing, and the sons with their parents for not being good parents. All are torn in a war between love and hate, and no one is sure which is the stronger emotion. Life is too painful for them even to try and make sense of it. Edmund's desperate advice in face of the horrible burden of Time weighing on people's shoulders and crushing them to the earth is to lose feeling in their cups and stay always drunk. Thus the long day journeys into night when the tragedy of the family is finally enacted. No relief is felt, no light is seen, and all ends in the engulfing darkness. In a figurative sense, *Long Day's Journey into Night* is a metaphor for O'Neill's lifelong endeavor to find truth and the way to acceptance. The former he found, namely, the faithless, fragmentary nature of modern life, whereas the latter he did not: for him all passed into night. In despair O'Neill thought of the old God of the Catholic church on which, it is ironical to note, he had turned his back long before.

O'Neill was a tireless experimentalist in dramatic art. He took drama away from the old traditions of the last century and rooted it deeply in life. He seemed to agree with the early T. S. Eliot who felt that "the contemplation of the horrid or sordid or disgusting, by an artist, is the necessary and negative aspect of the impulse toward the pursuit of beauty," and saw beauty inhering in the ugly. The hollow romantic stories of heroes moving against a gorgeous background disgusted O'Neill, so that he introduced the realistic or even the naturalistic aspect of life into the American theater. The stylistic aspect of O'Neill's art merits notice for its variety and its display of consummate craftsmanship. He borrowed freely from the best traditions of European drama, be it Greek tragedies, or the realism of Ibsen, or the expressionism of Strindberg, and fused them into the organic art of his own. He borrowed freely from modern literary techniques such as the stream-of-consciousness device with the help of which he managed to reveal the emotional and psychological complexities of modern man. And he made use of setting and stage property to help in his dramatic representation. O'Neill's ceaseless experimentation enriched American drama and influenced later playwrights such as Tennessee Williams, William Inge, and Edward Albee. It is possible that he will go down in the history of American drama as the American Shakespeare.

One of the most distinguished playwrights who remained in evidence for over four decades on the American stage was Elmer Rice (1892-1967), author of the well-known play, *The Adding Machine*. Elmer Rice was born in New York. Although he studied law at night school, he was resolved to be a dramatist. His career began in 1914 when his play, *On Trial*, was produced and

became an immediate success. *On Trial* is a mystery play of victimization told through expressionist flashbacks. Rice's most influential years came in the 1920s. *The Adding Machine* was performed in 1923. It was Rice's masterpiece in more ways than one. Thematically it is a vehement protest against the dehumanizing effect of what T. S. Eliot termed a barbaric civilization, and thus placed its author immediately among the group of modern masters of the 1920s which included T. S. Eliot, Pound, Williams, Stevens, Hemingway, Fitzgerald, Faulkner, and O'Neill. In technical terms it employs the expressionistic devices which also characterize the best work of Eugene O'Neill and Tennessee Williams. Rice's next success came in 1929, the year in which his *Street Scene* came out. A story of slum life, murder, and frustrated love, the play was made into a musical in 1947 by Langston Hughes and Kurt Weill. During the years that intervened between the two dates, Elmer Rice produced a series of plays which demonstrate both his range of subjects and competent artistry. These include *Left Bank* (1931), *Judgment Day* (1934), and *Dream Girl* (1945), the last being the most popular work since *Street Scene*. Rice's creativity slackened in the fifties. Only *The Grand Tour* (1951) and *The Winner* (1954) were produced but were not well received. In 1962 he published his Autobiography which made a stir on the literary scene. **Elmer Rice was also a novelist. *A Voyage Purilia* (1931), a Utopian satire, is the best of his fictions.**

Now let us take a look at *The Adding Machine*. Mr. Zero has worked in a store for twenty-five years, doing the same job "adding figures" and is expecting a raise when his boss comes one day to tell him that he has to leave because the store has bought adding machines. In a sudden fit of anger he kills his boss with a bill file. He is tried and condemned to death. A failure and a "waste product" of mechanization, he remains a "zero" in modern life.

The scathing irony of the play is obviously spearheaded toward the modern mechanical civilization. Machines turn people out of jobs and drive them to their doom. Modern life turns people into mechanical imbeciles. Mr. Zero, never having "missed a day, an hour, a minute" in his twenty-five years work adding figures, can no longer think except in terms of figures. Even when defending himself in the courtroom, he cannot help dragging in figures. In the midst of confessing to the first degree murder that he has committed, he starts counting numbers from one to twelve, telling a puzzled audience that six and six makes twelve, and five is seventeen, and eight is twenty-five, and three is twenty-eight, etc. Then his mind switches back to the court proceedings, curses the figures, and says pathetically that he has worked for twenty-five years all for nothing. The human mind has been mechanized so thoroughly.

And the power of the machine is magnified: a mechanical device adds automatically, and does the work of man in half the time. Even a high school girl can operate them to improve efficiency, economy, and business. Man will change from "antiquated adding machines" to "a superb, super-hyper-adding machine." The old Zero dies out to become a new superb, super-hyper Zero, a slave of a higher mechanical order, who can operate with greater mechanical precision. Modern civilization enslaves human souls over and over again. Men become numbered, Mr. One, Mr. Two...as if they were machines or machine parts. There is a touch of pathos all through the play. Zero is portrayed as dehumanized so that he is almost devoid of emotional response. That is probably the saddest part of his modern man's life.

The play can be called a tour-de-force of Elmer Rice's. In addition to the flashback technique which helps to hold the interest of the audience by first withholding and then releasing information in an unexpected fashion, Elmer Rice made the best of every offstage effect of the theater such as sound and light. The murder scene is, for instance, rendered in such a way that a

good deal is left to the imagination of the audience. Here a pantomime is going on. Zero and the boss are seen facing each other, motionless, except for the silent, incessant movement of the boss' jaws, indicating that they are talking with one another. The music keeps increasing in volume; the off-stage effects of the wind, the waves, the galloping horses, the locomotive whistling, the sleigh bells ringing, the automobile siren etc. ?all these add to the tension that is building up. Then a peal of thunder is heard, and a flash of red is seen. Then all is blackness. The power of the symphony of life, with its intricate complexities of joy and sorrow, is brought into full play to reveal the extent of the turbulence and disorder which characterize the inner state of a desperate Zero becoming a murderer. The force of this expressionistic scene of manslaughter does not show its dazzling effect on the perplexed audience until exactly a scene later when, into the mellowness of the quiet commonplace gossip of an evening party at the Zero's, policemen intrude and take the expectant Zero away to the amazement of the gaping guests. The artistry of Elmer Rice is unique in its own way. Elmer Rice's permanence is illustrated by the fact that some of his works such as this play and Street Scene still possess a great appeal and awaken emotional response in the audience today.

The early 1920s saw the upsurge of the women's liberation movement. The idea of asserting women's rights continued from the previous century with greater intensity. Feminist writings appeared also on the American stage. Susan Glaspell (1882-1948) was a well-known feminist author of the time. She was inspired and influenced by such authors as Kate Chopin who challenged society and tradition, and became a strong and opinionated feminist. Glaspell was a founding member of Heterodoxy, a radical group of women activists prominent in the feminist movement of New York in the years 1910-1920.

Glaspell grew up in Iowa, and attended Drake University. In 1915 **she founded with her husband the first influential noncommercial theater troupe in America** ?the Provincetown Players in Massachusetts and staged the earlier works of experimentalist drama by such authors like Eugene O'Neill. Probably mainly because of this, **Glaspell has been regarded by some people as "mother of American drama."** Later they moved the troupe to New York and renamed it The Playwrights' Theater. Glaspell was both a playwright and a novelist. Her plays included a pioneering feminist drama, *The Verge* (1921), and the Pulitzer Prize-winning *Alison's House* (1930). She wrote ten novels such as *Fidelity* (1915) and *The Morning Is Near Us* (1930).

Let's take a look at her one-act play, *Trifles*, which is interesting not as a kind of detective story it resembles on surface, but as an important feminist work. Here a murder is committed. John Wright is strangled in his bed, and his wife Minnie Wright is detained as a suspect. George Henderson, the county attorney, comes along to investigate the case. Accompanying him on the scene are Henry Peters, the sheriff, Mrs. Peters, and the Hales, Lewis and his wife. What is ironic is that, while the men, especially the self-important county attorney, strut upstairs and down, and cudgel their brains looking for the required evidence for prosecution, the women, who are supposed to take care of only trifles, move quietly around, find it, and decide to be silent about it so that their imprisoned sister could regain the freedom that in their opinion is hers. The play derives its artistic energy from the three levels of tension subtly embedded in it. These include the tension between women vs. men, woman vs. woman, and woman vs. self. The first of these, the opposition between the two genders, is obvious to notice. The second is less evident as Mrs. Hale tactfully wins the sheriff's wife over to her side of the confrontation. The third level of tension is the least tangible: the two women both do some soul-searching and come to empathize with

Minnie Wright and see her act of manslaughter as self-defense (the bird is her alter ego; killing the bird is tantamount to killing her). Glaspell has been remembered as one who made a great contribution to the development of American drama as well as the growth of feminist awareness in America.

The Depression was a decade fascinating not only from a sociological and economic point of view, but as literary history as well. It was a period completely different from the 1920s. Such new ideas and new techniques appeared that they shook things up as nothing else had done before. The literary movements in the decade were all bound up in the social movement. For the only time in American history writers met at a writers' congress to discuss what the function of writers should be when the country was in a crisis. American drama, along with other literary genres and very much like them, became highly social-oriented and was produced to fulfill a clear social purpose. In 1931 actors, dramatists and producers formed their own organization, The Group Theater, to produce plays of social significance. After their first success on Broadway, *The House of Connelly* by Paul Green, the association offered 23 productions in those "fervent years," which included works by pre-eminent playwrights like Maxwell Anderson, John Howard Lawson, Sidney Kingsley, and Clifford Odets. The list of dramatists of importance in the decade is simply amazing: in addition to those mentioned above, there were Lilian Hellman (with her *The Children Hour* and *The Little Foxes*), Thornton Wilder (notably with his *Our Town*), William Saroyan, Robert Sherwood, George S. Kaufman (and his *The Fabulous Invalid*), and Richard Rogers, to name just a few out of a good many names and titles. These authors may have begun their careers earlier and continued their creativity well into the postwar period, and most of them may have written pieces which were, temporally and spatially too much products of their decade to stay vital and vibrant beyond it, but they surely all did their best to help address the problems with which their crisis-ridden country was then beset.

Clifford Odets (1906-1963) may not be the best craftsman of the group (as probably Maxwell Anderson was), but his ability to impress was remarkable. He joined the Group Theater in 1930 and won recognition as one of the country's leading dramatists in 1935. This was the year in which he placed four plays on Broadway: *Waiting for Lefty*, *Till the Day I Die*, *Paradise Lost*, and *Awake and Sing!* A period of over a decade followed in which plays such as *I Can't Sleep* (1936), *Golden Boy* (1937), *Rocket to the Moon* (1938), *Night Music* (1940), and *Clash by Night* (1941) appeared on stage and, with the exception of *Golden Boy*, all were on the whole less impressive performances. *The Big Knife* (1948) is a first-rate play and *The Country Girl* (1950) and *The Flowering Peach* (1954) complete the Odets canon.

A great play by Odets is *Waiting for Lefty*. It is about a taxi driver's strike. A union meeting is going on. While the drivers are trying to decide whether to go on a strike, the union boss, who has already sold out to the companies, is trying to keep them from striking. All the time people come up on the stage and tell their stories, the union boss is smoking a cigar. The smoke keeps drifting in, a telling symbol of the fact that he is the one who has got all the decisions to make. Now Lefty is a character fighting against the corrupted union boss and trying to get the people to strike for higher wages. Throughout the play people are waiting for him before they make the final decision, but he never appears. In the meantime people keep talking about their bitter lives. Finally, there comes a shout from the back of the hall which interrupts everything. Somebody runs in and says, "Wait a minute! We've found Lefty! We found him in an alley with a bullet in his head!" The suggestion is clear, that the union boss has had him killed. The people run up on the stage and

shout, "What are we going to do?" Somebody at the back of the audience shouts, "Strike! Strike!" and they pick this up on stage and join the chorus.

The interesting thing to note about the play is its acting. The actors are scattered through the audience and some of these people jump up now and then to echo in shouts what is being said on stage. It is very exciting to see one person next to you, who looks just like you, working himself up in agitation and presently standing up, shouting, "Listen! Listen!" and charging onto the stage: He is, you realize, one of the actors! The point of this arrangement was to include the audience in the acting, and its effect was powerful in the social theater of the 1930s. The audience joined the "chorus" and the whole theater was boiling. Propaganda it certainly is, but as certainly it is also exquisite art: The whole performance is a most ingenious combination of the two. And from the stories of the drivers we get very authentic details of life during the Depression. *Waiting for Lefty* is altogether a very powerful play to come out of the theater of the thirties.

Awake and Sing is another fine work of Odets' in which the story of a poor Jewish family assumes the significance of a universal nature. *Paradise Lost* relates the process of a middle-class family going from Depression degradation to social rebellion. And quite a few Odets plays concern the loneliness of modern life and the money-success theme in American society. It is generally safe to state that social purpose impregnates all the Odets plays.

Postwar American drama has been said to begin with the staging of *The Glass Menagerie* in 1945. Its author, Tennessee Williams (1911-1983), has certainly become one of the greatest American dramatists to go down in the country's literary history. Williams was born Thomas Lanier Williams but he changed the "rather dull" "Thomas" to "Tennessee" in 1939, the year in which he won a national drama award for a group of plays called *American Blues*. His first play, *Battle of Angels* (1940), proved to be such a fiasco that he did not surface again, until 1945 when *The Glass Menagerie* won him international recognition. After that, Williams kept writing at the rate of a play every two years, and enjoyed popularity all along except, perhaps, during the 1960s when there seemed to be a decline in his powers. But he managed to recover from it in the 1970s and has retained his hold on popular imagination ever since. Now universally accepted as one of America's classic playwrights, he is in evidence practically everywhere in the theaters of the nation. Williams was also a novelist and a poet. He wrote a novel, two volumes of poetry, and six volumes of prose, including three collections of short stories.

Williams was a typical product of the post-O'Neill era. It is true that O'Neill led the American theater even in the postwar period, but the courageous endeavors of his generation made it possible for the public to accept new people like Williams, daring enough to deal with themes such as violence, sex, and homosexuality on the stage. Williams was thematically rather sensational. *A Streetcar Named Desire* (1947), a Pulitzer Prize-winning play, introduces both violence and sexual abnormality. The sexual emphasis of *Summer and Smoke* (1948) is self-evident. *The Rose Tattoo* (1951) presents a picture of depravity. *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof* (1955), another Pulitzer Prize-winning play, is in a way an amalgam of the Williamsian themes, and *Suddenly Last Summer* (1958) deals rather plainly with homosexuality. William's other plays include *Sweet Bird of Youth* (1959), *Period of Adjustment* (1960), *Night of the Iguana* (1961), one of his best works, *The Milk Train Does Not Stop Here Anymore* (1963), *Red Battery Sign* (1975), and *vieux Carre* (1977).

When it was first produced in New York City in 1945, *The Glass Menagerie* won immediate critical acclaim and received the New York Drama Critics Circle Prize as the best play of the year.

It is a pathetic story of a family, the Wingfields, whose major problem is existential both physically and spiritually. The world in which the family tries to survive is an impossible one. The main conflict centers on the mother's anxiety to marry off her physically handicapped daughter, but other problems of an equally harassing nature exist to intensify it. Mother Amanda is worried about the future of her two children, Tom and Laura. She is worried that Tom, a worker in a warehouse but dabbling in poetry, might become a drunkard, might smoke too much and become a good-for-nothing, so that she might lose her bread-earner. Amanda can not rest in peace whenever she thinks of her daughter, Laura, a young lady of 24, sensitive and lovely though slightly crippled; she often envisions her as an old maid left uncared for after she is gone. Although she says that she is old and that she does not bother about her own life any more, it is evident that she is not happy and tries to cling to the good old days when she was always in exuberant spirits, expecting "gentlemen callers." Amanda is portrayed as a loving and caring Holy Mother figure. Tom's acute mental suffering is best illustrated by his restlessness and his obsession with the idea of moving on from the humdrum life of a dull warehouse. As to Laura, she is the archetypal Williamsian heroine, lonely and vulnerable, completely withdrawn into herself and trying to live in the world which she constructs to ward off the intrusions of a painful existence. Living in a "mysterious universe" where there is only "everlasting darkness," all three are escapists from reality (think of "the fire-escape" from the apartment!). Tom runs away into the exciting world of the movies where he enjoys a vicarious experience of adventure, and eventually runs away from home as a merchant seaman into the wide world. He escapes into space. Laura runs away from reality into the world of her collection of glass animals, all as fragile and vulnerable as herself, in which she perceives an ideal order of everyone seeming "to get along nicely together." There is peace and harmony, but no discrimination against anything different (such as the one-horned unicorn with which she identifies herself), no competition, and no painful change. She escapes into her imagination. Both Tom and Laura know that theirs is an illusory world. Tom feels disgusted with the frustrating fact that "[p]eople go to the movies instead of moving! Hollywood characters are supposed to have all the adventures for everybody in America, while everybody in America sits in a dark room and watches them have them." And he seems to understand the gist of his mother's sarcastic remark that he lives in a dream and manufactures illusions. Laura slowly comes to the realization that her glass menagerie is too fragile to escape damage and destruction, and that damage or even destruction may be "a blessing in disguise." For her part, the mother derives her courage to live on only from her dreams of past happiness and from her uncertain expectation of a happy future for both her children. Her groans can be very pathetic and touching: "Gone, gone, gone. All vestiges of gracious living! Gone completely!" And she finds immense consolation in reading *Gone with the Wind*. Obviously she escapes into time. The escapist spirit of the Wingfields finds adequate expression in the picture of the "gallantly smiling" father who has said "Hello-Goodbye" to his family and disappeared, thus cutting himself free from all the worries and cares of life. Of all the characters in the play only Jim is a man of common sense. It is he who brings the illusory worlds of the Wingfields to an end. In a symbolic sense, he is a savior figure, a Jesus Christ, to the Wingfields (just think of his coming on a Friday and eating fish for dinner!), coming as it were to save the people from their despair and help them regain hope.

All the three run away from life because it is a prison for them, so confining and constraining that they find it hard to breathe. The play successfully portrays life as prison in two ways: the world as prison and the self as prison. The world of the major characters is delineated

clearly as a prison at the beginning of the play: "The Wingfield apartment is in the rear of the building, one of those vast hive-like conglomerations of cellular living units that flower as warty growths in the overcrowded urban centers of lower-middle class population and are symptomatic of the impulse of this largest and fundamentally enslaved section of American society to avoid fluidity and differentiation and to exist and function as one interfused mass of automation." The image of the prison is apparent here. In addition, there is another kind of prison, that is, the self as prison, or memory as prison, and the narrator says that this is "a memory play." Tom's closing speech at the end of the play is a good explanation of what it is like. Tom travels around the world on a merchant ship, and would have stopped but feels pursued by something, which "always came upon me unawares, taking me altogether by surprise." It may be a familiar bit of music, which is of course Laura's music. It may be only a piece of transparent glass or some perfume or some pieces of colored glass, which are all obviously reminders of Laura's presence. So it is his memory of his sister that keeps harassing him: "Then all at once my sister touches my shoulder. I turn around and look into her eyes... Oh, Laura, Laura, I tried to leave you behind me, but I am more faithful than I intended to be." Tom cannot flee from the prison of his own mind. So there are two kinds of prisons for the people, one external from which one may be able to escape successfully for a time, and the other internal from which one can never quite stay away. The circular structure of the play begins with the image of the world as prison, and it ends with the self as prison, and the people in the play live and suffer and try to do better within the large framework of the prison of existence. Complete freedom is impossible. What the play is trying to say is that, although people may escape and they may have different kinds of symbolic glass menageries for them to take temporary refuge in, escapism is not the answer to their problem. Along with escape, they have to "participate," which is the major mode of human existence. Escape can offer temporary relief and make life less demanding and more tolerable, but people will have to come back and face life and work it out. That is when and where Jim O'Connor kicks in. He comes on the scene as a reality check for everybody, Tom and Amanda as well as Laura. After the storm he causes in the life of the Wingfields and "the sky falls," the family makes to the realization that it is high time to address their problems instead of living in illusions. The end of the play is not unredeemed despair. Although all illusions are shattered and reality proves to be ruthlessly frustrating, and although there is despair and desolation, we do see the touching scene of the courageous mother, recovering from her sense of loss, comforting a badly hurt Laura with "dignity and tragic beauty." Toward the end of the play, Amanda says goodbye to her husband's picture, which is another way of saying goodbye to her escapism, and Laura manages to "[lift her hidden face] to smile at her mother." She has "blown out" her candles of false hope and expectation and begun to brave the harsh world in which she lives. Illusion goes. Courage and confidence come with which mother and daughter straighten up to face life, no matter how hard it may be. Tom is roaming, still groping, but he has seen the need "to blow out the candles," and has helped Laura to do it if he has not done it himself. All become wiser and more down-to-earth for the disappointing experience of life. The Glass Menagerie is a typical Williams play in that here is a lonely vulnerable woman living in her illusion, which is smashed to pieces by a male intruder, who is the embodiment of reality. The whole performance is pointed against modern civilization which blasts happiness out of human existence. The Glass Menagerie is autobiographical. For one thing, Williams did have a sister, Rose by name, who was "handicapped" all her life by an operation of lobotomy. Williams felt guilty as he was not there for her when she needed him most at the time of the operation, and

he had been always kind to her, visiting her in her hospital at regular intervals and catering to her childish fancies with all his love and care. There is reason to assume that the "memory play" was written as an apology to his family just so that he could come to terms with his tormenting sense of guilt somehow.

Another great dramatist to come out of the 1940s is Arthur Miller (1915-) who has, along with Tennessee Williams, led the postwar new drama. Miller grew up in the Depression. He witnessed his father's business failure and worked at a variety of proletarian jobs. In the mid-1930s he studied journalism at Michigan University and began to write plays and radio scripts. For a while he worked with the Federal Theater project, and during the Second World War he was a fitter in a navy yard and on an army training film. His first play, *The Man Who Had All the Luck*, was produced in 1944, and his first important work, *All My Sons* (1947), did a good deal in fostering his reputation as an Ibsenian playwright. The staging of *Death of a Salesman* (1947), his masterpiece, won him the Tony Award and the Pulitzer Prize, and established him once and for all as a writer of no small talent. With another two plays, *The Crucible* (1953) and *A View from the Bridge* (1955) placed on Broadway, Miller became a name forever linked with Tennessee Williams and, further back, with Eugene O'Neill. In 1957 he published his *Collected Plays* and left the stage until 1964 when he came back with *After the Fall* and *Incident at Vichy*. His other plays include *The Price* (1968), *The Creation of the World and Other Business* (1972), *The Archbishop's Ceiling* (1977), *The Last Yankee* (1993), and *Broken Glass* (1994). Arthur Miller is a man of moral integrity. He refused to cooperate with the House Un-American Activities Committee in 1956 which was then investigating "left-wingers." In 1965 he was elected the first American president of the international P. E. N. (International Association of Poets, Playwrights, Editors, Essayists, and Novelists). Arthur Miller has some connection with China. He visited China in 1978 and again in 1983 to help stage his masterpiece in the country. The play enjoyed a good deal of popularity as a lot to Chinese felt that they could relate to its theme somehow. That may be seen as a testimony to the work's universal applicability.

A typical theme of Arthur Miller's plays concerns the dilemma of modern man in relation to his family and work. What occurs often in a Miller play is that the hero finds himself under a pressure from his society and its ethics, tries in vain to extricate himself from the physical and spiritual quandary into which he has fallen and finds release only in death, often in the form of actual or virtual suicide. The world is harsh. There is little or no choice for the hero. Either he submits to the impossible demands of society, or he rejects them. He dies in either case. Miller is, however, not completely pessimistic. Reading his plays, one feels a faith in man and in life, however vague it may be, though very often gloom overweighs hope.

Arthur Miller is best known as author of *Death of a Salesman*. It is a sad version of the American dream. Willy Loman, the salesman of the title, is as "phony" as Mark Twain's Colonel Sellers but more hardworking and honest. He is as tragic as Fitzgerald's *Great Gatsby* but not as successful and "great." Though living in a rough world where modern civilization is suffocating, Willy never seems to be aware of that and keeps on dreaming of success and living in illusions and lies. He dreams of establishing his own business, and of owning a house where there would be space, light, and leisure to live. He dreams of a "big" future for his children who, however, inflated with his false praises, turn out to be good for nothing. Willy's kind of success is never measured except in terms of dollars. Just see with what ecstasy Willy hears his ideal articulated by Happy, his second son, when the Loman brothers plan their "big deal":

Wait! We form two basketball teams, see? Two water-polo teams. We play each other. It's a million dollars' worth of publicity. Two brothers, see? The Loman Brothers. Displays in the Royal Palms ?all the hotels. And banners over the ring and the basketball court: "Loman Brothers." Baby, we could sell sporting goods.

And the sad part of the story is that, whereas the family live with exhilaration on the illusion, we learn that one of the brothers is a thief and the other a "fake," a braggart. The Lomans have "never told the truth for ten minutes" in their house. Willy has "the wrong dreams" all the time, and lives in a dreamy state, developing the disconcerting habit of talking to himself and refusing to comprehend what other people say except as in keeping with his own dream. Thus it is no wonder that even his house has "an air of the dream" about it.

Viewed from another angle, the dreaminess of Willy is a sure symptom of the insanity which is fast overtaking him. The mind of Willy is falling apart under a pressure too much for it to bear. As he cannot think of himself in terms other than of worldly success, he is not mentally prepared for the tragedy which is befalling him. He cannot face the fact that, after working for the firm for over three decades and devoting the best of his mature life to its success, it now takes his salary away and refuses to accommodate him for 40 dollars a week. He can not accept the fact that he has come full circle in his career, placed back on the road, once more working for commission as he did at the beginning of his business life and that he is marginalized and fired by his boss in the end. He feels embittered. "Funny, y'know?" he thus says to Charley, his only friend. "After all the highways, and the trains, and the appointments, and the years, you end up worth more dead than alive." For the first time he thinks of death as a means of achieving success for his sons, if not for himself any more. He plans to stage an automobile accident so that his family could collect on his life insurance policy. Thus the greatest tragedy of this "fine, troubled," "hard-working, unappreciated prince" lies in the fact that he dreams of vainglory in death after he fails to achieve it in life. Thinking of the twenty-thousand-dollar life insurance money he would make for his loved ones, he says:

Because [Biff] thinks I'm nothing, see, and so he spites me. But the funeral ?Straightening up: Ben, that funeral will be massive! They'll come from Maine, Massachusetts, Vermont, New Hampshire! All the old-timers with the strange license plates ?that boy will be thunder-struck, Ben, because he never realized ?I am known! Rhode Island, New York, New Jersey ?I am known, Ben, and he'll see it with his eyes once and for all. He'll see what I am, Ben! He's in for a shock, that boy!

So he is resolved to see his dream happen in the lives of his sons. He drives himself into an accident and dies willingly. Willy never makes to the realization that it is the system with its social problems that has made it impossible for him to be a good achiever and that the American obsession with financial success has ruined him and people like him.

Although the play covers Willy's life and career by means of flashbacks (in the form of stream of consciousness), its time frame is just about one day, Willy Loman's last day of life. It begins in the wee hours of one day and ends in those of the next, about 24 hours altogether. Now Willy is at the end of his tether. He has been contemplating suicide for some time, and feels that now the time has come for him to make the fatal decision. Before he takes that step, he is extremely restless and his mind wild and busy sorting things out for himself. His mind keeps drifting into the past. The events of his life keep streaming through his consciousness. His reminiscences focus by and large on two questions to which it is vitally important for him to find

the adequate answers because these may justify his suicide. One of these concerns his own failure, and the other that of his two sons, especially Biff's, for whom he has had such great expectations and in whom he has invested so much. As these questions have harassed him all his life, he has to make some discovery before he leaves the scene. In all his deliberations on his own problem, he has his older brother Ben, now dead for ten years, as a yardstick to measure his achievement and behavior. Ben inherited the pioneering spirit of the family. Their father was a pioneer in the nation's historic westward movement. In one of Willy's flashbacks, Ben appears and tells Willy and his family, in a tone of love and admiration about the life of the old man, a very great and very wild-hearted man, who would start in Boston with his family in a wagon, and drive right across the west. As we know, one way of looking at the history of the United States has been to see it being formed as a nation in the long and eventful westering process that the country went through. What has proved decisive to the new nation has been its pioneering spirit. Ben himself felt proud of the success he achieved: as he has always summed up, he walked into the jungle at 17 and came out of it at 21, and by God he was rich. Or in another way in which he put it, one has to go in to fetch a diamond out. In other words one has to venture out into the wide world. The jungle represents the unknown, the untrodden ground, and one has to have the adventurous spirit, as did their father, to make oneself successful. Ben had a dream, the original version of the American dream, which consisted of both its spiritual and materialistic aspects. Measured up to this dream, Willy's is found wanting in its idealistic facet, and is therefore a distorted, adulterated one. Willy has not enough of the pioneering spirit in him. He has some, and so he wanted at one moment to accept Ben's offer to come out west to Alaska with him. But he has not enough of it to resist any remonstrance against the offer from Linda, his wife, who sees the city's settled mode of life as the better. In one of his important flashbacks, there is a tug of war going on with Willy standing in the middle, pulled wide apart by Ben on one side and Linda on the other. The mental scene occurs immediately after Willy is fired and he turns to Ben in intense agony, "Oh, Ben, how did you do it? What is the answer?" In this instance of reminiscence, Ben offers a business opportunity to Willy, and Linda helps to refuse it. The scene ends with Willy eventually agreeing with Linda and deciding to work it out in the city rather than going to Alaska with Ben. On this last day of his life when he sees his life in retrospect, this scene of dispute surfaces once more to indicate that Willy seems to have found the cause for the failure of his life and is subconsciously blaming his wife, at least in part, for it. The real reason, in addition to the social milieu of the 1930s and 1940s, may be found in his split personality. He loves both the city lifestyle and nature and the wilderness. If he had loved only one of these and focused, he would probably have been successful. He has made the terrible mistake of falling in between. His death is a foregone conclusion.

Regarding Biff's bumming around at the age of 34, Willy has all along been in denial of his own share of responsibility for it. He loves his sons and tries to help them grow up as successful people. But his has been the wrong kind of education, inculcating his wrong dream in them. At one time he adored his elder son as a young god with all kinds of potentialities, and he could never believe that Biff has turned out to be a miserable bum while his friend Charley's son, Bernard, who has never been "well liked," has become a lawyer arguing a case before the Supreme Court. And Willy has always denied having any responsibility for Biff's failure. But the issue has bugged him all the time and given him no peace. He has always been declaring that Biff has trashed his opportunities for higher education and for a respectable career out of spite for him. But he refuses to go further and asks why the once-loving and admiring son should go out of his way to spite him.

On the last day of his life, when he is fired and finds himself face to face with Bernard in Charley's office, Bernard's question "What happened in Boston?" touches Willy to the quick. It sets him thinking, and thinking good and honest. What happened in Boston seventeen years ago comes back to him in one other important flashback which he has when he lands in a restaurant's restroom, deserted by his two sons. Then the painful memory of his affair with a Boston woman and Biff's inadvertent encounter with them in a Boston hotel room begins flooding through his mind. He makes the belated confession that that affair of his has scarred the boy's emotional makeup and caused the boy's downward spiral. The once promising high school basketball team captain with three colleges open to him lost his faith in life totally and has been wandering around the country ever since. Willy is now willing to take his responsibility for Biff's failure. Now satisfied with his findings, Willy is ready for the step he is about to take.

Willy is not a perceptive person. In both of the important reminiscences mentioned above, he falls wide of the mark. The decision to stay on in the city is in the final analysis his decision. Linda, a loving and caring and protective woman, has always been unobtrusive, and Willy has been both the breadwinner and decision maker of the family. Linda has only offered her advice regarding Ben's Alaska offer. The lion's part of the responsibility for that critical decision is no doubt Willy's, and it would be inappropriate, if not exactly wrong, to shift it wholly on Linda even though in a silent subconscious manner. As to Biff's life, Willy may be accountable for its bad start. But Biff should have been able to bring his own life back on track after he comes of age. It would be inaccurate for Willy to think that his extramarital affair alone has ruined his son's life. There is one area, however, where Willy can be held mainly responsible for Biff's failure, and Willy does not seem to be aware of it. That is the impact of his false dream of success in the city which fetters Biff's imagination all his young life. Although Biff has a grudge against his father? He cannot bring himself to forgive his father's one time infidelity to his mother, his quarrel with his father does not occur mainly on this score. Biff loves nature. He is a poet in temperament. When he talks about the spring on a farm or a calf being born, he is carried away despite himself. He hates the working environment in the city. But Willy has been exceptionally successful in planting his own dream in Biff's consciousness so that the young man can never settle on a farm and feel happy as his father's expectations keep fighting with his own dream in his mind. He keeps coming back home and hopes to give an account of himself to his father with whom he has been long at loggerheads. That is why they expect to see each other, but begin to fight as soon as they meet, and why at their last meeting, Biff asks his father to let him go.

When *Death of a Salesman* was first produced there was a tremendous feeling of newness. What Miller did was to wipe out the old realistic stage setting and go back to the Elizabethan kind of stage where the audience saw a house which was only a frame. People could have action in the house; they could wander out of the house. Moreover, in the case of *Death of a Salesman*, the artful manipulation of light, now shining on the left and now falling on the right, helps to change the setting in a highly flexible manner. The stage setting deals not only with space but with time. As it is "wholly or, in some places, partially transparent," it can bring back any event or person from the past in an extremely fluid way to help present the fluid kind of life that this victim of the myth of success is leading, for the problem with the suffering Loman is that he cannot dissociate the present from the past, and cannot remember whether he is living in the one or in the other. His mind shuttles quickly back and forth between the two zones of time, with the result that the frustration of the present is intolerably intensified by past remorse: The characters such as Ben and

the woman never appear except as flashbacks across the mind of the salesman. One may even suggest legitimately that the transparency of the setting effectively presents the psychological drama of Willy Loman in a stream-of-consciousness technique. In addition, the portrayal of Willy's character is interesting to note, too. Willy's personality is projected through other characters in the play. Ben and Linda represent between them the whole of Willy's character, with Ben bodying forth Willy's love of nature and whatever pioneering spirit he has in him, and Linda representing Willy's love of the city and its settled spirit. Ben features as Willy's alter ego and his conscience in addition to being his role model. Biff and Happy each embodies one side of Willy's character, Biff his love for nature and Happy his desire to succeed in the city. Everybody else fits in the characterization of the protagonist. The Boston woman represents Willy's sense of guilt toward his son as well as his wife. Charley functions as a symbol floating ever before Willy's eyes: that of the ideal successful American self-employed businessman, Bernard as a painful reminder of Biff, and the two of them, father and son, between them constitute a negative reflection upon Willy as a failed man. Howard, Willy's boss, whose decision to kick him out of the company like a piece of trash, triggers off the suicide, incarnates the callousness, the inhumanity, and the brutality of the social system itself. Thus *Death of a Salesman* is a modern classic of the American theater from every conceivable point of view.

The 1950s was a decade in which America went through substantial changes. The country became increasingly prosperous. Small town life received publicity. Technical advances like the car and the refrigerator made life easier and comfortable. But at the same time there were feelings of anxiety and disquiet. In addition to such factors as the nuclear bomb, the cold war, and Viet-Nam which weighed heavily on the consciousness of the nation, there was a good deal of frustration and bitterness at different levels of existence, personal, social, as well as psychological. American playwrights responded to the complexities of the age in a competent way. William Inge (1913-1973), Robert Anderson (1917-), Arthur Laurents (1918-) and a good many others wrote and made the success of American drama in the 1950s. Take William Inge for example. His famous *Bus Stop* is an adequate expression of the period spirit. Here its main character, Cherie, feeling the pull of the booming city, comes to the city only to find disappointment in store for her. She falls in love and tries to find consolation in personal relationships but meets only disillusionment. Then she tries to escape into the sanctuary of a ranch which, however, offers nothing of the kind. The promise which the American dream inspires ceases to exist. She feels stifled.

Now we come to Edward Albee (1928-), who seems likely to stay in history alongside O'Neill, Williams, and Miller. If Albee has hinted that he alone is the heir to the great traditions of O'Neill and Williams, he has probably told a truth. Albee first began writing when he was still in school, and learned substantially from his social experience as office boy, restaurant counterman, and Western Union messenger. His first play, *The Zoo Story* (1958), was staged in Berlin in 1959, and was later produced off Broadway. A series of one-act plays such as *The Death of Bessie Smith* (1960), *The Sandbox* (1961) and *The American Dream* (1961) that followed led to his first full-length play, *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* (1962), which represented the culmination of his powers as a dramatist. It won many awards and established its young author as one of the most distinguished playwrights to appear in the postwar period. It pushed his dramatic career to such a sudden, thrilling climax that it has dwarfed his other later productions. Over the years Albee has

written many more plays such as *The Ballad of the Sad Cafe* (an adaptation of Carson McCullers' work, 1963), *Tiny Alice* (1964), *A Delicate Balance* (1966, winning a Pulitzer Prize), *Box and Quotations from Chairman Mao Tse-Tung* (1968), *All Over* (1971), *Seascape* (1975, winning another Pulitzer Prize), *The Lady from Dubuque* (1978), *The Man Who had 3 Arms* (1983), and *Three Tall Women* (1994, winning the third Pulitzer for Drama).

Albee has been linked with the traditions of the Theater of the Absurd which came into vogue in the 1950s and 1960s. The theater of the absurd refers to some plays the theme of which centers on the meaninglessness of life with its pain and suffering that seems funny, even ridiculous. We think of Samuel Becket's *Waiting for Godot* and *Endgame*, or Eugene Ionesco's *Amedee* and *Rhinoceros*. In these works the playwrights try to force the audience to face up to the human condition as it is, instead of presenting a false picture of it and pandering to the public need for reassurance. Edward Albee has written in this spirit. His plays seem to have dwelled on one problem only, that is, the absurdity of human life built very much on a frail illusion and spiritual emptiness. *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* is a good illustration. George and Martha are a middle-aged childless couple. Childlessness has been in fact the source of a good deal of unhappiness for both. They revel, have fun and games, try to lose themselves in their cups, but deep down, the fact of childlessness keeps harassing them and fills them with a sense of loss which they cannot face with courage. Somehow, they agree to pretend that they have a son who was born some twenty years ago, and that they should keep the secret between themselves. On the night before the supposed twenty-first birthday of their son, they invite a young couple. Nick and Honey, to come and join them in their violent, boisterous, and essentially absurd and murderous "games." The four meet around two o'clock in the morning. Everybody drinks and turns quickly from mellowness to semi-insanity. It seems that life has become such an absurd business that night replaces day, and the control of reason gives way to the free play of imagination with the subconscious now running wild. George and Martha keep up a show of violent quarrels and threaten to stop at nothing short of murder. Honey gets so drunk that she sleeps on the tiled floor of the bathroom. And Nick, who seems to maintain a balance of mind, finally succumbs to the pressure of his own psychic wound and starts chasing Martha in the kitchen and bedroom. It turns out that Nick may be impotent and his wife is slim-hipped, and though they want desperately to have children, they cannot. Like the older couple they are doomed to a lonely and empty existence. By four o'clock in the morning everyone has gone practically insane.

Just as sexual impotence in Eliot and Hemingway denotes spiritual poverty, so here in Albee childlessness is only a representation of a much graver problem with which these people are beset. Take George, the history professor, for example. His life is crippled from the very beginning by patricide or a semblance of patricide. He marries Martha, the daughter of the president of the college, with the prospect of taking over when the old man leaves the scene, but is found wanting in some of the required qualities. For a while during the war he chairs the history department but is apparently a failure in that job. He suffers defeat in his career as an academic. Thus his life has been frustration, defeat and despair. As a history professor acquainted with "patterns of history," he foresees that "cultures and races will eventually vanish ... the ants will take over the world." And he finds relief, that is, if there is ever relief for him, in escapism, escaping as he does into the comfort of illusion. He declares at one point of the four-quartet that he will fight with his life to keep Berlin intact from the submerging attack of modern civilization because, as he tells us, "There is a saloon in West Berlin where the barstools are five feet high. And the earth ... the

floor ... is so ... far ... below you. I will not give up things like that. No ... I won't. I will fight you, young man ... one hand on my scrotum, to be sure ... but with my free hand I will battle you to death." As Nick is a scientist, he represents, in the eyes of the history professor, the threat of modern scientific civilization.

At home George constructs the illusion of a son having been born to him and amuses himself through life with it. But he knows it is an illusion, and not a truth, and he cries deep inside. The truth of the "sad, sad, sad" life of George and Martha breaks through the illusory surface when "the exorcism" is about to begin. Here Martha is heard making a pathetic speech which she would not make when she is sane:

... Daddy White-Mouse; do you really have red eyes? Do you? Let me see. Ohhhhhh! You do! You do! Daddy, you have red eyes ... because you cry all the time, don't you. Daddy. Yes; you do. You cry alllll the time... I cry all the time too. Daddy. I cry alllll the time, but deep inside, so no one can see me. I cry all the time. And Georgie cries all the time, too. We both cry all the time, and then, what we do, we cry, and we take our tears, and we put 'em in the ice box ... and then ... we put them... in our ... drinks.... Up the drain, down the spout, dead, gone and forgotten...

The mental suffering of all the people in the play is graphically illustrated here in this "I'll-tell-you-all" kind of speech. When Nick starts mounting his hostess like a dog and Honey screams hysterically "I want a child," the spell over all is broken. What is left is sheer despair and fear to live on: "Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf" George sings at the end of the play, and Martha, now reconciled with both life and George, finally admits that she is. The "Virginia Woolf" in the title is significant in a couple of ways. First, Martha is well read and has a kind of respect for language. Had she been younger, she would have identified herself with Virginia Woolf who had an incredible amount of verbal wit. Martha is afraid of Virginia Woolf who committed suicide in the end. She could have done the same, given the enormous amount of despair she feels all her life, if she had not lived on her frail illusion that she has a son. Then "Virginia Woolf" is used as a homophone for "wolf," and the title is in fact a humorous way of repeating a line from a ballad, "Who is afraid of the big, bad wolf?" The wolf here is a metaphor for something terrible like poverty etc., and the wolf that has scared the four people in the play is the hopelessness that stretches before them. At the end of the play, however, they seem to have to come to terms with the absurd life that they are made to live, and face with courage the darkness which it offers them.

Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf? is an impressive work from a formal point of view. The three acts, "Fun and Games," "Walpurgisnacht," and "The Exorcism," represent the typical structural pattern of Albee's plays: normal opening, gradual building up toward emotional crack-up, and quick drop-off. The withholding and release of information is skillfully handled so that the audience's interest is sustained throughout the play. What touches off the waves of hysteria is Martha's revelation to Honey that she and George have a son. George's threat to react violently seems puzzling, until Martha discloses that George does not like the boy because he is not sure whether the son is his own. For a moment George's virility is in doubt. Thus humiliated, George resolves to retaliate. The games that he introduces to the little party lead steadily to the removal of the spell until, in the end, their illusion evaporates and they find themselves suddenly face to face with the naked truth of life. Martha is an archetypal character in Albee's dramas. She is the domineering woman, the tragicomic figure who is at the center of the emotional tangle and without whom Albee's plays would have lost much of their emotional appeal.

The two preeminent playwrights that have impacted contemporary American theater are

Sam Shepard and David Mamet. Sam Shepard (1943-) tends to explore the world of the subconscious and the repressed. He feels fascinated with subjects like incest and violence. One major subject for him is failed family relationships, relationships that can be terrible and impossible. In this world people are estranged from life, and stress and pressure come primarily from within them. Shepard tends to mystify the West and create a kind of cowboy mythology, no longer the original American mythology, but still something larger than the present-day fast-food existence in America. Over the years, Shepard has written a good number of plays like *Buried Child*, *Fool for Love*, *A Lie of the Mind*, *Paris, Texas*, *Motel Chronicles*, *Geography of a Horse Dreamer*, and *States of Shock*. Let's take a brief look at *Buried Child*. Here Young Vince comes home with his girlfriend Shelley to visit his family. But there is no welcome, not even sufficient attention, from his grandparents and his father. All of the three elders are preoccupied with their own thoughts. The grandfather sits in front of the TV and drinks. The grandmother is dressed in black grieving over her lost child. And the father is busy bringing vegetables to the house from a back garden. Outside the house is buried the dead child. All live in their own world and behave like borderline neurotics. There is a hint that the buried child is born out of an incestuous joining between Vince's father and his grandmother. It represents a past that bears heavily on the present. The play seems to be saying that family generates pain. Its members look like "a global race of strangers." The children (like Vince's father) leave but are drawn back only to suffer in an embroiling relationship devoid of warmth and understanding. The desert ?the mythical "West" ?no longer rehabilitates like the dream that it used to be. The people live in search of meaning, but fail to find it. They feel the need to believe in something but cannot believe it. Thus they enact their versions of life very much like their fathers and grandfathers before them and then dissolve in the end. Vince comes to realize that life is a purposeless repetition through generations.

David Mamet (1947-) is the most important playwright to emerge in the 1970s. Mamet's major thematic concern relates to his pessimistic view of the dilemma with which contemporary America is faced in the areas of social, economic, and human relationships. Over the years he has written a number of plays such as *House of Games*, *Sexual Perversity in Chicago*, *American Buffalo*, *Glengarry Glen Ross*, *The Woods*, *The Shawl*, and *Speed the Plow*. All are impressive; *American Buffalo* has been seen as one of his most ambitious works.

American Buffalo is a two-act play that established its author David Mamet's reputation. It is at once a critique of American business ethics and a portrayal of failed human relationships. The story is set in a junk store in Chicago. Three thieves plan to rob a man who bought an antique buffalo-headed nickel. These include Don, the owner of the small resale store, Bobby, a drug addict, now a protégé of Don's, and Don's friend, Teach, and some other misfits. The crime never occurs because the three simply do not know how to do it. They know little about the man they are to rob, do not know how to get into his apartment, pry open the safe, and identify the coin. They do not have the courage, either. They suffer from paranoia and behave like psychotics. Their conversations are significant because they reveal their views of American business ethics. The free enterprise offers, according to one of the three, a freedom for people to do whatever they think could justify their end of making a profit. What is implied here is that, just as corporate morality differs from that of the individual, and just as the slaughter of the buffalos and the displacing of the American Indians are justifiable in terms of American progress, so is crime, including this planned, unexecuted project of petty theft. The system blurs the distinction between crime and business. In terms of helping achieve the theme of the play, the crime is not important; it is the process of the

planning that matters most. The thieves pass their time together and enjoy each other's company. They stretch their imagination, create a kind of fantasy in which they have a role to play, and feel happy enough to let their lives stay at the fictive level. There is the acutely felt need for communication. Occasionally, the three function like family. Don appears to be a father figure, with Teach and Bobby, both emotionally inadequate, like two brothers. But they could never achieve that intimate sense of attachment that makes for gratifying human relationships. They remain "isolatos" in a world of alienation.

In the recent history of American drama there have been a good number of playwrights trying to offer, on Broadway or off it, a variety of productions which have invigorated the theater. The generation of authors such as Jack Geiber, Jack Richardson, Arthur Kopit, and Ronald Ribman are followed by a good number of younger playwrights, and all are trying to add in their own ways to the development of American drama. Following the heavily political theater of the 1960s, the 1970s experienced a change in taste. With the theater of the absurd no longer the dominant trend, realism made a comeback. Realistic, even naturalistic portrayals of life, especially life of the lower social strata, are offered on the stage. Albert Innaurato's *Gemini* (1977), Beth Henley's *Crimes of the Heart* (1979), and August Wilson's *Joe Turner's Come and Gone* (1988) are all good examples of the plays of the period. This was also the period in which feminist theater exerted its influence. Marsha Norman's *'night, Mother* (1983), Tina Howe's *Painting Churches* (1983), and Wendy Wasserstein's *The Heidi Chronicles* (1988) were among the most successful plays that portray women's lives in a realistic way. The last couple of decades since the 1980s have witnessed some change in values again. Experimental drama is back in vogue in some plays. Symbolism, fantasy, and the theater of the absurd combine with realism and naturalism in representing life in such plays as David Henry Hwang's *The Sound of a Voice* (1983), Caryl Churchill's *Top Girls* (1982), Tony Kushner's *Angels in America* (1992), and Milcha Sanchez-Scott's *The Cuban Swimmer* (1984).

The major feature of recent American drama has been the emergence of the multiracial and multiethnic plays on the stage. African Americans, Native Americans, Asian Americans, and other ethnic groups have felt the need for theatrical expression. After the militant works of James Baldwin, LeRoi Jones, Lorraine Hansberry, and Ed Bullins, there has emerged August Wilson, who is probably the most powerful African American playwright of recent history. A number of other African American playwrights active at work include, to name just a few, Sonia Sanchez, Alice Childress, and Adrienne Kennedy. Regarding the plays of the Native American Indians, these began receiving attention in the late 1960s when a number of their works were staged. In the 1970s the Native American Ensemble was established and became later American Indians in the Art. In the meantime some other theatrical organizations such as Four Arrows and the Indian Performing Arts Company also came into being to help Native American Drama grow. **Hanay Geiogamah was the first Native American to bring out his collection of plays in 1980.** For the Asian Americans there have been Laurence Yep and David Henry Hwang; an anthology of Asian American plays, entitled *Between Worlds*, was published in 1980. The Chicano theater has had such playwrights as Luis Valdez, Lynne Alvarez, and Milcha Sanchez-Scott (whom we mentioned a little earlier on). It is obvious that American drama is going through a process of redefining. It is a process that will enrich the American theater in a significant way.

CHAPTER 20 Postwar Poetry Poets of the 1940s Generation

A Brief Introduction

Postwar American poetry has been amazingly different from its immediate predecessor. The well-established styles of the great Modernist masters like T. S. Eliot and the "orthodox" New Critical paradigm began to lose their hold on the imagination of the younger generation of poets. The new arrivals on the scene of the 1950s and 1960s believed that the heritage of the previous period was no longer adequate for their new experience. They felt the urge to address their unique problem in their unique way. They decided to break away. They rebelled. The rumble was heard already in the early 1950s when Charles Olson published his explosive essay "Projective Verse" (1950) and called for a new mode of thinking and writing. His dissenting voice was reinforced in the mid fifties when Allen Ginsberg started to "howl" like a prophet in the wilderness. A significant blow was registered to the New Critical poetry when one of its veterans, Robert Lowell, decided to take a new direction in his monumental work, *Life Studies* (1959). The age of Postmodernism had arrived.

What is Postmodernism? Postmodernism represents a new mode of perception and a way of writing. In poetry it strives to go against the vogue of the New Critical poem and its parent style, the High Modernism of the previous decades. In its thematic concerns, Postmodernism views the world as one that is not to be molded, but as formless and unpredictable. Postmodernism does not endeavor to impose on life and reality, but is willing to embrace it for what it is. And it tends to use topics and subjects of a personal, even a forbidden, nature. In its formal aspects, Postmodernism seeks for a freedom in literary expression. It prefers, for example, colloquial and informal speech, not always grammatical and coherent in syntax. All this and more offer a striking contrast with the poetics and styles of the previous period. Postmodernism thus asserts its own identity by virtue of its negation, partial in some cases, of its inheritance. It is good to note, however, that it is closely linked with that heritage as it acknowledges part of it at least ?Pound and Williams and Cummings ?as the sources of its inspiration, and that their reaction against Eliot and the New Criticism is also an indication of their debt to High Modernism. The Postmodernist novel exhibits its own unique features such as metafiction, black humor, and forms of avantgardism, which we will discuss in chapter 23 of this survey. Postmodernism is still ongoing as the dominant literary movement at the moment.

It is wrong to see Postmodernism as anything monolithic, however, because it is not. It is a blanket term covering a wide range of diverse experimentation that has been going on since the end of World War ?. Although both Allen Ginsberg and Charles Olson howl, they do so in drastically different ways. If John Ashbery and Robert Lowell happen to take shelter under the same umbrella, it is not because they look alike or love one another, but because they have nowhere else to turn. The postmodernist group is indeed a vast, heterogeneous crowd. In the chapters 20 through 22, we will talk about some important poets in some detail and mention some others briefly. If we do not touch on such well-established authors as Howard Nemerov (1920-), James Dickey (1923-), John Haines (1924-), Galway Kinnell, (1927-), and Donald Hall (1928-), and many others, it will be because of space constraint only. The readers are earnestly advised to place these on their own reading list.

What happened in the previous period that has brought about the change? In socio-political terms, the postwar years has witnessed many great changes. New experience in the new period demands new ways of expression: memories of war savageries like those of the concentration

camps, Dresden, and Hiroshima, still fresh and haunting, the cold war that went on for decades, the menace of the nuclear bomb and the shadow of fear it cast, McCarthyism and the scare and harm it caused, Civil Rights and race relations, awareness of ethnic and cultural diversity and difference, the Vietnam war; the Beat Generation, communal living and drugs, the impact of the TV, feminism and the fight against patriarchy, the fight for sexual freedom, the self-assertion of the gays, the computer and the information explosion that has followed in its wake, the increase in self-awareness and identity, the consciousness of environmental protection including the ozone layer, greenhouse effect, and species preservation, the exploration of space and the new vistas of vision it has opened up for humankind etc., and of course the economic growth and the increasing affluence. With all these happening around, human perceptions could never remain the same. Neither could human sensibility and values. Experience becomes more individualized, and expression tends to be more personal, even idiosyncratic.

In addition, the poetic scene of the 1950s encouraged rebellion from the younger generation. Eliot's ascendancy had been in evidence for a quarter of a century. He had been the model along with Yeats and Frost. The New Criticism exerted decisive influence in the reading, criticism, and canon making of poetry. The earlier, New Critical, works of Robert Lowell (such as *Lord Weary's Castle*) and Richard Wilbur (like *The Beautiful Changes*) were much admired and imitated. The atmosphere proved to be stifling to some dynamic spirits. They saw little room for renovation and a broader range of activity.

The New Criticism's dominance as an academic orthodoxy deserves special mention as a contributing factor to the change. As we mentioned earlier on in this survey, this school of criticism and poetry was based on T. S. Eliot's writing and critical theorizing. It evolved in the 1920s through the 1940s in defense of High Modernism against conservative attacks. It kept the basic Modernist values (economy, wit, irony, impersonality, careful with form etc.), but abandoned or toned down other High Modernist features such as extreme fragmentation, paratactic syntax, ellipsis, symbolism and myth, cross-culturalism, and allusions. As a result it became cautious and traditional, and less revolutionary and disorienting, and was more acceptable to all tastes and more popular with the rising younger generation of the 1940s. In the 1940s and the 1950s it was introduced into the classroom as a paradigm for poetry writing and criticism and became a widespread orthodoxy, otherwise known as "academic formalism." As such it became tyrannical and influenced quite a number of young poets, Robert Lowell, John Berryman, and Richard Wilbur, to name just a few. In literary creation, attention was paid to the poem as a well-wrought urn, with its coherent form, coherent images and figures, rhymes and stanzas, impersonality, and integrated attitude and vision. As a critical theory, it focuses on the text as an independent entity, disregarding other factors like the author's life, social background, influences etc. Thus codifying values and methods, the New Criticism eventually became a dogmatic straightjacket to the imagination. Some people felt fed up and began to struggle out of its bondage. Even some of its followers began to see it leading to nowhere but a dead alley.

Furthermore, in the field of literary creation, there had been no palpable change in style (i.e. the High Modernist style) for over 40 years (ca. 1910-1950). Pure and simple imitation would not ensure survival for the younger generation; their way out was to look for something new that they could call their own. In addition to the restrictions and inhibitions of the New Criticism, the High Modernist style itself was too difficult to follow, with its traditionalism, internationalism, and intellectualism (difficult for both writers and readers so that its works reached only an elite

readership), and the notion of impersonality became more and more an emotional barrier between the authors and their readers. These left no leeway for anything reflective, meditative, and conversational. There had to be a change. Moreover, the new and fashionable always easily attract notice and make a stir and help build a reputation. Eccentricity, in the sense of being off the center, came in vogue. As critic David Perkins puts it, Dada gestures, Tibetan chants, surrealist associations, Jungian archetypes, epiphanies of Mayan and Egyptian deities ?all these and more became welcome in the postwar decades.

And sure enough, the wind of change was blowing. It could be felt even in T. S. Eliot's own works, that is, his later poetry. The master's change from High Modernist to the meditative mode was apparent in the *Four Quartets*. But what made the general change more visible was the works of Ezra Pound and William Carlos Williams. In the late 1940s, the two poets came out with works that appealed to the imagination of the groping younger generation. Pound's *Pisan Cantos* and Williams' *Paterson* brought a fresh breeze at the time. Spontaneous, free, autobiographical, and reflective, the *Pisan Cantos* broke away from the High Modernist concrete and fragmentary mode of presentation and its doctrine of impersonality, and offered a new way of writing not seen for a long time. Its emotional intensity proved exceptionally attractive because impossible for High Modernist and New Critical poetry. Williams' *Paterson* (1946-1958) was delightfully open. It appeared to be moving, changing, forever in process, acting on the impulse of the moment rather than planned. In the long run, both the *Cantos* and *Paterson* were to be appreciated more in terms of poetic structural considerations. One champion of the new verse, Charles Olson, elevated both older poets to the stature of father figures for contemporary poetry when he called writers of the new verse ?the "projective verse" ?their sons. In a way Olson helped make the new eminence of Pound and Williams when he called upon postwar poets to pick up the fruits of the two poets' experiments. Olson felt that the *Cantos* makes more "dramatic" sense than the plays of T. S. Eliot, and that its methodology points a way by which the problem of larger content and larger forms may be solved. Around the same time the new prophets were acknowledged, T. S. Eliot began to take back stage.

With regard to the changes in taste and values that occurred in the 1950s and 1960s and the salient features of this new, contemporary poetry, we begin with the change in the very idea of art. In the 1890s and the first years of the 20th century, art and poetry were regarded as the finished products of the creative process, closed in form, with rhymes and stanzas, coherent images and figures, and completed in plot enacted. Now art and poetry are seen as open, on-going, not as the end of thought, but as the process of the mind thinking, stressing motion, created on the impulse of the moment, and not previously well-planned. And there is not much of the finely metered Modernist poem in the new verse that, instead of aiming at an elite readership, endeavors to reach the common people as much as possible.

Thematically, the new poetry normally portrays everyday experiences, events, and emotions. It envisions man as vulnerable and helpless and at the mercy of overwhelming odds. It accepts life for what it is, feeling resigned, painfully aware of its inability to control and contain life. Instead of trying (in vain as the new poets see it) to "[give] shape and significance to the immense panorama of futility and anarchy that is contemporaneous history" (as Eliot puts it), the new verse tries to represent life as it is with its strengths and weaknesses, as something inconsistent, ever changing, and never wholly knowable. The poets' job is, seen by some people, to seize the moment and make the best of it for themselves as well as for the world at large.

As regards formal considerations, the new verse embraces open form, "the perfect, easy discipline of the swallow's dip and swoop, 'without east to west'" (as Gary Snyder states it). It rejects the "stale skunky pentameters"(as Kenneth Kock puts it). It repudiates the Eliotic, New Critical values of impersonality and objectivity as distancing art from life. It refuses to use "persona" as they feel it separates the writers from their readers. In the new verse, there is usually no surrogate speaker; the poet is often speaking himself. The poem is very often autobiographical; the tone is personal and emotional; the emotions are often intense though qualified: there is ambivalence and humor amid remorse, disgust or anguish. The diction of the new verse is mostly from daily speech, its style is conversational, colloquial, discursive and meditative, and its mood generally casual and relaxed. It is necessary to note here that contemporary American poetry is not always easy to read. In fact, much of this poetry is very hard to understand. Possible reasons for this may include the private nature of the poet's thinking and expression, and their self-indulgence encouraged by the postmodern tendency of extreme individualization.

As change became inevitable, new schools of poetry appeared on the scene. One major characteristic of postwar poetry is its diversity. There has been a visible growth in popular interest in poetry, which has become one "dominant expression" of American literature; there has also been an equally remarkable growth in the number of poets writing to increase the country's singing strength. Surveying the contemporary poetry scene in the mid 1970s, Daniel Halpern noticed the excitement everywhere over the proliferation of poets and poetry, the wide-ranging interest in poetry ?creative writing workshops springing up overnight around the country; the thousands of new magazines in existence, with as many poets supplying their material, and some of these magazines receiving over 3 000 poems a month; the submissions to first-book awards having doubled and redoubled; and nearly four hundred books of poetry being published every year. It is good to note here that the 1950s was also an era of formalism, and technical virtuosity. The formal, academic verse of such poets as Robert Penn Warren and Stanley Kunitz who achieved a degree of recognition before the war, Robinson Jeffers, Theodore Roethke, Elizabeth Bishop, John Berryman, Jarrell Randall, Richard Wilbur, and Howard Nemerov were still popular then. As time wore on, however, some of the poets like John Berryman and Robert Lowell began to depart from their New Critical allegiance and write a different kind of poetry.

Whereas some of these poets began to veer in a new direction in theme and form, the period between the late 1950s and the whole of the 1960s witnessed the rise of several different poetic groups which drew more from the tradition of Whitman, Ezra Pound, William Carlos Williams, and Wallace Stevens than from T. S. Eliot and Robert Frost. These were included in Donald M. Allen's famous 1960 partisan anthology of *The New American Poetry, 1945-1960*, in which the editor ingeniously and insightfully grouped the postwar poets into different schools such as the Black Mountain poets, poets of the Beat Generation and the San Francisco Renaissance, poets of the New York school, and other poets who have developed their own styles and ideas of poetry. These poets, as Donald M. Allen notes, "have created their own tradition, their own press, and their own public." Beginning with the 1970s, American poetry has become too heterogeneous to group and define. One may take the poets who have attended the Writers' Workshop at the University of Iowa as one group; one may take others for a West Coast School, or a neo-New York group. And the attention that the poets of multiethnic origins have received is simply amazing. But there has been such crossbreeding and such an admixture that grouping is no longer possible. In matters of form it is good to add that, while the new verse has become the dominant style, some

poets have chosen to keep to the traditional forms in expressing the spirit of the new period. Richard Wilbur comes to mind along with some younger poets who think it apt to give those forms a new lease on life. The picture of contemporary poetry would not be what it is without their efforts.

For our survey here, we propose to begin by following Donald M. Allen's classification. His grouping was a bit arbitrary; but it has been neat and convenient enough for later anthologists, critics, and readers alike for a long time now without too much of a problem. Looking back, we may note that it is good to provide room also for the Confessional poetry that has now been widely recognized as distinct all by itself, for some poets like John Ashbery (who, more meditative than anything, does not quite belong with the New York group) and such authors like James Merrill and W. S. Merwin, and for a wide diversity of poetry such as African American, Native American (or American Indian), Asian American, Hispanic American, and poetry by authors of other ethnic origins. For prioritizing, we may take a good look at some of the poets who have received enough attention to warrant a niche in contemporary history, and leave the rest for the readers to handle for themselves.

Elizabeth Bishop (1911-1979)

Let's begin with a look at some of the older poets, especially those of the 1940s generation. As the war produced no significant verse in America (we remember Karl Shapiro [1924-] and his war poems), we will place emphasis on those who, though brought up with the New Critical values, came to see the need for change in the new period and changed to keep step with the spirit of the times. These include, among others, Elizabeth Bishop, John Berryman, and Randall Jarrell. Richard Wilbur merits our attention, too, as he has been a great exception to his generation in formal concerns. So is basically the case of James Merrill. As to the still older poets such as Robinson Jeffers (1887-1962), Richard Eberhart (1904-) Stanley Kunitz (1905-), and Theodore Roethke (1908-1963), it is necessary to note that their contribution is by no means negligible even though there is not much space here to elaborate on their works.

Now Elizabeth Bishop was born in Worcester, Massachusetts. She lost her father when she was eight months old, and her mother was placed in a mental institution when she was five. So she was first brought up by her maternal grandparents in Nova Scotia, Canada, and was then taken care of by her paternal grandparents in Boston, Massachusetts. She graduated from Vassar College, and traveled to Europe, Mexico, and Brazil. From 1952 to 1969, she lived in Brazil, then came back to the U. S., and taught at University of Washington and Harvard University in her later years. One noticeable fact about Elizabeth Bishop is her rising reputation. Never slighted by critical circles, she was a significant minor figure in American poetry until the last couple of decades when her work began to draw more and more critical attention. She was a prize-winning poet. Her second volume of poetry, *Poems* (1955), was awarded the Pulitzer Prize for poetry, and her fourth volume, *The Complete Poems* (1969) won a National Book Award. Her other works include *Questions of Travel* (1965) and *Geography ?* (1969).

Bishop's poetry is in large measure a response to her personal experiences. Occurrences such as the loss of her parents in her childhood, her travels in Europe and South America as well as in her home country, and her meetings with Marianne Moore and T. S. Eliot ?all these had impact on her writings. First, the sense of loss, vaguely felt at first but more keenly with time, is built into the texture of her poetry. Then, Bishop was a widely traveled person. She visited Newfoundland when she was young. Later she went to New York, Europe, Paris, and London,

North Africa and Spain, South America, and lived for a long time in Brazil. Only reluctantly did she come back to teach when she was already in her late fifties. That is the reason why her poetry contains a lot of her traveling experiences and observations. Finally, her meeting with Marianne Moore in 1934, widely publicized and discussed over the years, proved to be important to the evolution of her style. That she handled details with meticulous care is attributable to the influence of the older poet. Her meeting with another celebrity of the time, T. S. Eliot, a year earlier, not as much known, was equally significant to her poetic career if not more. This occurred when she was attending Vassar College. In her interview with the poet, she heard the visiting T. S. Eliot call his epochal work, *The Waste Land*, "a piece of rhythmical grumbling," and she read his important essay, "Tradition and Individual Talent," from which she came to realize that writing is "the perpetually changing integration of what has been written and what is being written." She saw and understood the Postmodernist inclination in late T. S. Eliot, which affected her writings very much. In addition to all these, we need to mention her interest in painting and the influence of contemporary art and surrealism, both of which have left a visible imprint on her work.

Let's take a look at some of her poems. "Sestina" and "One Art" are interesting ones to begin with as they are so frequently anthologized (along with "The Fish"). Even though "Sestina" cannot be called autobiographical, the readers can feel the poet writing herself into her work. Here we see a grandmother and a child grieving over something to be deciphered only by the readers' imagination. That something is fully known to the grandmother and the readers, but only vaguely to the child. The emotional constraint, resulting from this deliberately elliptical description, empowers the readers' minds so that they feel the grief intensely as much as does the grandma (and the poet with her). In a similar way, "One Art," on the art of losing, of accepting losses, leaves so much unsaid, so much open-ended, that we need to read the poem over and again to experience the pain, the agony, the "disaster" that the loser may have felt when the losses first occurred, losses ranging from trivial and less personal (as in the 2nd and 3rd stanzas), to grave and galling to the soul (as in the last three). One can only understand how the poet can dismiss these so easily when we begin to embrace life for what it is as the poet tried to do. One thing to note about "Sestina" and "One Art" is Bishop's interest in traditional forms. Bishop was not partisan or doctrinaire in her literary creation. She regarded form as a means to achieving theme. Whatever served her purpose was good for her. Thus she could enjoy writing in such tricky traditional patterns as the villanelle and sestina as shown in the two poems above, and at the same time write with equal facility in forms open and free and keep in step with the spirit of her time.

Elizabeth Bishop wrote with increasing awareness that the time for the Modernist mode of literary creation, no matter how grand, was over and that something new had to take over from it. She was a Postmodernist both in her acceptance of life for what it is and in her openness in theme and form. One basic feature of her poetry lies in its at once material portrayal of life and immaterial suggestion about it. The readers are plied with an abundance of naked details but invited to relish a subtler taste. This feature of her art stems in a way from her catholic vision of life itself. This vision, large and all-inclusive, sees the world as one of joy and sorrow, physical and metaphoric, which the poet embraces and tries to represent so that life never becomes totally impossible. Bishop never theorizes about life. To her the physical, ephemeral setting, against which we live out our lives, is impersonal, amoral, non-judgmental, and there is nothing we humans could do about it but observe it faithfully and accept it. Poetry should be open because life is open. So she is open to life's numerous, probably unpredictable possibilities. Life is to her

forever unfolding and relative, and she allows it to register itself on her mind as it unravels itself.

"Filling Station" and "Over 2 000 Illustrations and a Complete Concordance" are both good examples here. In "Filling Station," the poet faces the fact of the filling station without any pre-conceived notion of like or disgust. She just walks in. What she sees is its overwhelming black dirtiness. There is oil everywhere; everyone is just oily and dirty. Of taste and elegance there exists not the faintest trace. Then her eyes fall on the spot of color of the comic book that seems to offset the drabness of the place. Then she notices the dim doily over the taboret, and the hirsute flower, and becomes aware of the attempts, no matter how feeble and crude, at beautification and exquisiteness, attempts which then begin to pound on her questioning mind as waves break on the seashore. Her skepticism is dispelled when she sees the oil cans arranged in symmetry with a soothing effect on the incoming automobiles, the same as a mother's comforting croon on an agitated child. Then, only then, does she begin to recognize the love in human activities, including that of the filling station. In "Over 2 000 Illustrations and a Complete Concordance," the poet perceives order, as represented by the Bible concordance, in its first movement (?1-30). Once one opens the book, one always sees the same things arranged in the same manner, "serious, engravable[,] be it the Seven Wonders of the World, or the squatting Arab, or one of the group of Arabs pointing to the Tomb, the date-palms, the cobbled courtyard, the Well, the brickwork conduit, or "the human figure / far gone in history or theology," or the silence, the gesture, the specks of birds "suspended on invisible threads above the Site," or the smoke etc., in a word, everything of "God's spreading fingerprint." These are always readily comprehensible ("when dwelt upon, they all resolve themselves"). The sense of order breeds a sense of control and a measure of assurance and certitude. But the 2nd movement of the poem (? 31-64) introduces the notion of disorder that seems to inhere in actual life experiences, i.e. her travels: at one moment the poet was in Newfoundland, where she saw a medley of things peculiar to Canada, at the next she was in Rome which offered a different sight, then she was in Mexico and heard some mariachi music, then she was in North Africa and stood in front of a ruin, then she was in Southwest Ireland, in a Moroccan city, where she saw "[a] holy grave, not looking particularly holy," the marble trough half-filled with dust, and an Arab looking on amused ?here in contrast to the silent order of things in the Bible concordance, everything is haphazard, chaotic, without a sense of direction, trying to defy comprehension. Order is confronted and disrupted by disorder. The open mind of the poet begins to think. In the third movement of the poem, the poet becomes aware, almost like an epiphany, that the idea of order or disorder is just our mind's response to experience and that anything can be seen in different ways and is relative in nature: "Everything only connected by 'and' and 'and.'" Even the Nativity scene in the concordance can look different when viewed differently.

Bishop's openness is well illustrated in her attempts at achieving a sketchy but suggestive effect, which not only reveals the author's mind being open to all possibilities of interpretation but also leaves the readers wanting more. This we can feel in our reading of "The Fish." The poem can be divided into a few sections, revealing visible steps of movement on the part of the poet from a pure objective observation and concrete description as in the first 20 lines to some emotional involvement and the increasingly subjective depiction in the next 25 lines, to the display of admiration (?45-65) and to the final highly emotionally charged decision to set the fish free (?65 through the end). These steps represent the jumps in the growing awareness of the poet from observation to inspiration to discovery, enacting her notion of "the perpetually changing

integration of what has been written with what is being written." Now in the first movement of the poem (?1-20), the fish begins in the readers' perception as a mere physical object. The beginning line "I caught a tremendous fish" states a mere fact that does not seem to be a big deal. This is followed by a concrete, minute, matter-of-fact description of the fish without much of an emotional response—love or hate or any shades in between—on the part of the poet. In the second movement (?20-45), the poet's subjectivity increases until the nonchalance of the defeated, ("[Its eyes] shifted a little, but not / to return my stare. / It was more like the tipping / of an old object toward the light"), its arrogance, begins to awaken some echo of admiration in the poet. The admiration grows when she sees the five big hooks planted firmly in the mouth of the fish ("Like medals with their ribbons"). It is now an admiration for the fish's wisdom and heroism: the five old pieces of fish-line appear to be more than the fish's badge of courage (?44-64). Then, in a moment of a sudden revelation (?65-76), the poet becomes aware of her own wisdom and courage of which the fish is the unequivocal symbol. An overwhelming sense of pride and joy of self-recognition comes over her: she is the fish's equal, and perhaps more than that: "I stared and stared ... until everything / was rainbow, rainbow, rainbow!" Thus in exhilaration, and also probably out of gratitude for the epiphany the fish has been instrumental in inducing to her, the poet sets it free as it well deserves. With the fish swimming back to the ocean, the readers' imagination, along with that of the author's, is set free for a wild run as well. The appreciation of the poem does not end with the conclusion of the work; and the process of diverse interpretations continues, probably indefinitely, regarding the question why "I let it go." Possible answers may include the poet's conscious or subconscious identification with the fish, the notion of "Heroes love heroes," respect and compassion for the heroic, willingness to help keep a worthy rival's dignity etc. The poet does not offer the expecting readers the reply, or the moral, because she does not have one; she does not think the reality she is face to face with is finite, final, absolute. Incidentally, the poem reflects a mind thinking instead of presenting a closed thought process. By the same token Bishop's poetic career was similarly a process of continual growth and continual acceptance of new discoveries. The boundaries of her poetry kept receding as her visions of life grew wider with time.

The poet's emphasis on presenting the on-going nature of our cognitive process is closely linked with her belief in eternal change. The world keeps changing and so our knowledge is "flowing, and flown" as she puts it in her much critiqued poem, "At the Fishhouses" (1955). The poem describes a static moment in a manner that stresses continual and unavoidable change. The first part of the poem (?1-40) portrays such a moment when the poet talks quietly with the old fisherman in one of the fishhouses, watching him netting there. Everything seems stagnant against the backdrop of the sea from which change is forthcoming. But even in this seemingly still moment, signs of change are observed: the shuttle "worn and polished," the moss-covered shoreward walls, the wooden capstan cracked, the ironwork rusted, the black old knife with its blade almost worn away, and dried blood, the ephemeral nature of the light ("an apparent translucence," iridescent coats of mail and iridescent flies etc.), and the decline of population and the implied demise of the poet's grandfather—all indicate change, decay, and growth in the wake of change. The scene of apparent stillness is soon superseded by one of motion related to the sea in the second part of the poem (?41-83): the introduction of the sea, the waves of the sea swinging above the stones, the recurrence of the sea breaking upon the shore, breaking no less forcefully upon the poet's mind and setting it thinking and keeping it thinking which results in an epiphany:

It is like what we imagine knowledge to be:
dark, salt, clear, moving, utterly free,
drawn from the cold hard mouth
of the world, derived from the rocky breasts
forever, flowing and drawn, and since
our knowledge is historical, flowing, and flown.

This "forever, flowing and drawn," not only about the nature of knowledge but also about time and reality, offers no sense of finality and certitude about all these. Bishop's point is that life is open and endless, so is our process of perceiving it, and so is our portrayal of it in our works of art: "the recognition itself of what is being written must be kept fluid," as she put it in one context. This fluidity of the writer and his subject, the very notion of everything moving in a constant flux, is imbedded in the fabric of Bishop's poetry and bodies forth a good deal of contemporary epistemology.

Elizabeth Bishop wasn't an inventor in the sense T. S. Eliot was. She was, to be more just, an eclectic in that she managed to build her own work on the best of her past, especially the artistic achievements of the great masters of her previous generation. Thus we see in her works visible imprints of Marianne Moore's observation of detail, Pound's Imagistic instant, Eliot's objective correlative and impersonal presentation, and Stevens' urge for aesthetic perfection. And there is also a glimpse of William Carlos Williams in her works like "A Cold Spring," or even "Brazil, January 1502."

Elizabeth Bishop has become a tradition of a kind for contemporary American poets. Although not comparable in any way to such preeminent figures as T. S. Eliot, Ezra Pound, Robert Frost, and William Carlos Williams, she has impacted contemporary American poetry in visible ways. Richard Wilbur learned how to write poetry first from her works; Randall Jarrell felt an empathy of spirit with her; and Robert Lowell's famous "Skunk Hour" was written in response to her "Armadillo." Her criticism of her fellow poets' work has been always taken seriously. She has become one of the most admired poets of her generation.

Richard Wilbur (1921-)

Richard Wilbur was born into a New York family, and attended Amherst College and Harvard University. He fought in WW? in Europe, and published his first volume of poetry, *The Beautiful Changes and Other Poems*, in 1947. It was an immediate success, and he has kept writing and publishing ever since. *Ceremony and Other Poems* came out in 1950, followed by such volumes as *Things of This World* (1957), *Advice to the Prophet and Other Poems* (1962), *Prince Souvanna Phouma: An Exchange between Richard Wilbur and William Jay Smith* (1963), *Complaint* (1968), *Walking to Sleep: New Poems and Translations* (1971), *Seed Leaves: Homage to R. F.* (1974), *The Mind-Reader: New Poems* (1976), *Verses on the Times* (1978), *Pedestrian Flight: Twenty-one Clerihews for the Telephone* (1981), *Seven Poems* (1981), *New and Collected Poems* (1989), and *Bone Key and Other Poems* (1998). Wilbur has also written some plays, done some translations, and edited some books. In addition to writing, he has been teaching in a few universities. He has been president of the American Academy of Arts and Letters.

Wilbur has been to his generation what Robert Frost was to his. Both have tried to keep step with their generation in spirit, but neither has been quite willing to go all the way with their contemporaries in handling forms. So he has done a rare thing: imbibing the vitality of the 1960s but open to all formal possibilities, he has written poems true to life and reality but in the most

part carefully metered and rhymed. The result has not always been happy for the poet: he is loved and respected; but he is also often misunderstood. His fidelity to physical experience is often, along with his colloquial speech, given much less attention than the grace and charm of his forms for which he has been on occasion branded "elitist" and "reactionary." But being the individualist that he is, Wilbur has stood his ground and has received recognition as one of the finest postwar poets.

Wilbur was the most elegant of his ?the New Critical ?generation. When his career began, the first wave of High Modernism had passed. The New Critical poem, with its formal standards and its impersonality, was fast becoming tyrannical as the pattern for the struggling poets. Wilbur's first volume, *The Beautiful Changes* (1947), formal, witty, and impersonal like the High Modernists but a lot easier and charming and tailored to the popular taste, won him the fame that has stayed with him ever since. His poetry, formally exquisite and refined both in meter and rhyme regularity, left a very pleasant impression upon the minds of his readers, one that still endears him to the reading public.

Wilbur is Postmodern in spirit. Both in theme and form he shares the concerns of his contemporaries. To him the world is not always the best possible for us; life is a struggle, often doomed. A good deal of his poetry reveals the disturbing and ugly side of reality. The sucking center in "Marginalia," The falling earth in "Juggler," and the soul's reluctance to descend to its body in "Love Calls Us to Things of This World" ?these are just a few of the poet's many attempts to depict the physical world the same way his contemporaries do. The central idea which holds the three seemingly incongruous stanzas of "Marginalia" together is the poet's opinion that the best of our lives is marginal: The soul in "Love Calls Us to the Things of This World" enjoys the peace, joy and beauty of the heavenly scene where angels (or an illusion of them) live and interact with one another so much that it would rather stay "bodiless and simple" for eternity than descend into its natural habitat ?the body of a man. Reluctantly, however, the soul crawls into its "waking body" and acts differently. After all, this is where it belongs; the "bodiless and simple" state, absorbing as it is, lasts only "for a moment," giving an illusory sense of existence only.

Wilbur shares, with many of his contemporaries, the postmodernist notion that reality is not always knowable. The poem, "Epistemology," consisting of two couplets, reveals the skepticism inherent in his sensibility: You may break your bones getting to know it, but reality remains nebulous and mysterious. But for writers, to know or not to know it well can make or mar their writing careers. Thus we see that the poet's daughter writing in the poem "The Writer" is probably not fully aware that the reality as she sees it is something difficult to understand and still more so to represent. She feels confused, but she cudgels her brains to discover the truth, and brings her writing to a finish. Apparently the daughter as writer is experiencing the full gamut of Henry James' "despair, reward, torment, and delight" all over again in representing reality. However, the poet sees his daughter's success as only a one-time, isolated undertaking. Writers have to strive always to see the light and acquire the vision in their on-going careers. Moreover, life is a mystery as Wilbur's "A Hole in the Floor" reveals. What we observe of reality is only a "hole" perception, far from perfect, by no means whole: Here is our visible life with the lamp light and the damask love seat and the wooden floor, but we may not be aware that there is a whole lot of "buried strangeness" lying beneath the surface of reality, hidden, vital or inconsequential, adding a new dimension to our knowledge and understanding. By extension, our civilization may have been built on some "buried strangeness" like "the crowns of Troy," which is a mystery worth exploring.

Any discovery that we make may enrich us with fresh energy and watchfulness.

What can art do to life? This has been a life-long concern for Wilbur. Art can offer relief from the humdrum life, but the escape it offers, no matter how joyous and uplifting, is at its best temporary. Ultimately we have to come back down and touch ground. The implication ?often only an implication from Wilbur ?is that we have to face reality squarely, and try to live with it. Take "Juggler" for example. The world is "weighty"; it pulls us down. We struggle to do our best (we "bounce"), but are doomed to fall inevitably, by virtue of earth's gravity, into dull routine again. Then the juggler comes on the scene: his art intervenes and mediates between our earthly troubles and our aspirations. The "small heaven" of his balls completely keeps our mind off our worries and cares. So does his juggling of the table, the broom, and the plate though in a lesser degree as the articles of his art begin to remind us of our drab existence and bring us closer down to our earth. This "small heaven" reminds us of Eliot's Modernist idea of art giving shape and purpose to the chaos and purposelessness of life. But here Wilbur's Modernism ends. His Postmodernism begins when his juggler finishes and goes, leaving us behind to shift for survival with whatever is available: table, broom, etc. These are solidly ours; these are what we live by, however we feel about them. These ?emblematic of our world and our life ?are here to stay, not the juggler with his clever and beautiful tricks. The advice for us here is to take what we have and make the best of it. In a way the poem smacks also of Wallace Stevens' meditations on earth and heaven, and of Robert Frost's "Birches" though without the older poets' forthright declaration of attitude.

One important thing to note about Wilbur is his avowed fidelity to reality. To the details of life and the world, no matter how insignificant and little they may look, his devotion is unswerving. He enjoys contact with the true sights and sounds of the world. The meticulous care with which he presents the sight of a dying toad, physical and picturesque, offers a graphic illustration. Some readers of "The Death of a Toad" may feel that Wilbur is unnecessarily sentimental and mythical here, reading so much into a sight as trivial as this. But his poetry is full of such carefully portrayed and catalogued trivialities of the most banal or vulgar kind. He has his point. "Everything is not," he stated on one occasion, "dramatic, world-shaking, and momentous, for these little stories are about the people whose lives are the true history of this year and of all years." And on another he said that he likes to see the ideas of a poem presenting necessary aspects of life. This indicates his acceptance and tolerance of life with its variegated forms, pleasant or otherwise. "A Summer Morning," "A Fire Truck," "Next Door" etc, are all good examples.

With regard to form, Wilbur is open to anything that can do his errand well. Although there is always wit and grace and formal dexterity, he refuses to be dogmatic and extreme in formal patterns. It is true that he does not think of traditional forms such as sonnets and terza rima as outdated, and feels drawn to these because of the power and effectiveness he sees in them. And it is true that Wilbur broke through the values of the New Critical poem: "We are not always divided in spirit," he says while commenting on the New Critical notion that poetry should accommodate the discordance of life and consciousness. However, he has never felt the need to have to discard traditional forms to fully represent the spirit of his time. There is no doubt that he is as open as is his time, and that he encourages tolerance in general. He shows due respect for William Carlos Williams, and is faithful to the physical world no less than is the older poet. He admires Robert Lowell's mid-career transformation, and writes beautiful free verse himself. In language he can be casual and relaxed. Altogether he is pleasant to read.

Now in retrospect, when all is said, Richard Wilbur has weathered well through time. Although people have felt that he is a bit too traditional, he has been consistent in his own way of composition and has, by virtue of his perseverance, earned the recognition that he so well deserves. He won a Pulitzer for his *Things of This World* (1956), the third volume of his poetry (for which he won also a National Book Award), and another Pulitzer for his volume, *New and Collected Poems* (1989). He was appointed US Poet Laureate for 1988. Over the years he has earned a great reputation. He is one of the most accomplished poets of the contemporary period.

John Berryman (1914-1972)

John Berryman was born in McAlester, Oklahoma. He attended Columbia University and Cambridge University, wrote his dissertation on Stephen Crane at Columbia, and received his Ph.D. there. He taught at Harvard and Princeton before he settled in Minneapolis to teach at the University of Minnesota. He was a Confessional poet. All through his life and career, he wrestled with his self. When he was 12, his father shot himself outside his window. The event left him emotionally scarred so much that he spent his whole life and poetic career thrashing things out for himself. He did not succeed. After enduring incredible despair and pain, he broke down and committed suicide: he jumped off into the river in Minneapolis in 1972.

So, to a large extent, the major theme of his poetry has to do with his father's suicide. At the unconscious or subconscious level of his being, Berryman always felt tormented over it. He had to confront the sense of guilt he never stopped feeling for that death, and the pain and anger that came along with it. He had to grapple with his own despair and death urges which were compounded, in addition, of the tangle of his own life: his love hunger and sexual guilt, his debilitating alcoholism, and his struggle with his art for recognition as well as for perfection. In a word, he had to face his own psyche squarely. So his poetry is full of the stuff of his life, or its heavy cargo (to borrow from Wilbur). There in his works he "pried himself open" for the whole world to see: the detailed events of his life such as binges, hospitalizations, insurance forms, teaching, and his opinions on Vietnam and beer, poets, and dentists, his dreams, memories, fantasies, gossip, grudges, and private jokes, "a maze of concentric circles of concern" (as critic McClatchy puts it), which were confessions of his involvement with loss, deaths, and terror, or sequences of confessions as attempts to come to terms with the magnitude of that fatal event in relation to his life.

Thus reading his earlier poetry such as "The Ball Poem" and "Fare Well," and his collections like *Poems* (1942), Berryman's *Sonnets* (1947/1967), *The Dispossessed* (1948), and even his *Homage to Mistress Bradstreet* (1953), we see this laborious effort on his part to discover the primary cause of his debilitation so as to handle it for survival. Take "The Ball Poem" (1942) for example. It depicts a little boy unable to cope with his loss. He has lost his ball, which bounced into the water. Shaken with grief, rigid, and trembling, he stares down into the harbor where his ball is gone. As we read on, the metaphoric significance of the ball and the harbor suddenly comes to mind. The ball stands for his father, and the harbor actually for his inner world. In other words the loss has sunk real deep into the depths of his soul. The boy wishes to "stand up" like all others who have suffered losses, and keeps rationalizing about it to himself just to reduce the gravity of the matter. But all to no avail. He will not let it drop until he has made sense of it. So he starts soul-searching for his part in the loss. And the boy-Berryman in real life kept on doing it not just in "[a]ll his young days" but right up to his breaking point. Berryman's frenzy at self-dissection reaches its maddest point in his *The Dream Songs* (1964-1968), wherein he looks for a way out of

the maze of his life but, to his great disappointment, finds none. In his later work, *Love and Fame* (1970), he delves repeatedly into his innermost world to confront possible deposits of horrors there in order to find God for salvation, only to witness a vast void of emptiness characteristic of his life all the time. His life and struggle come full circle in his literary creations. In *Delusions, Etc.* he resigns to "an empty heart" and feels happy to sleep for good on the empty bed of his dream song number one.

The best of Berryman's poetry is *The Dream Songs*, which is very much his Whitmanesque "Song of Myself" without the older poet's optimism. When he was writing this, on and off, over some fifteen years, Berryman was going through a hellish time emotionally. Always cast in the gigantic shadow of that death, his life was a total confused mess. The past meddled in the present, and both intermingled with the future. Dream visions paraded through the responsive screen of his mind; the line between real and imaginary dimmed and faded out. The show was on, and no one – least of all, the poet – could stop it. Besides, the poet did not want to stop it because he needed it to afford him a window of opportunity to revisit his own life carefully and examine his psyche as does a surgeon in the operation theater. He needed space and time to think things over and decide upon a survival strategy. Berryman began *Dream Songs* with a clear sense of direction, went on braving a new world for a while, but somehow lost control in the end.

The Dream Songs is a sprawling collection of 385 poems. It appeared first in the two volumes, *77 Dream Songs* (1964) and *His Toy, His Dream, His Rest* (1968), which won the Pulitzer Prize and the National Book Award respectively. Although the collection structurally appears to be sloppy, Berryman was able to develop an affinity for the blend of poems, sufficient to ensure coherence and a resemblance of unity. The songs, mostly of eighteen lines each (three six-line stanzas), were composed in open form, thematically connected, but formally independent. They are not chronological or sequential. Seen as a whole, they are like projections of moments crossing time boundaries in a flow of the poet's consciousness. The scene is contemporary; it is strewn with occurrences current to the author's life. These include news items, travel, low life, Negro music, world politics, etc., all these forming the backdrop against which the main character's life is played out. It might not be the poet's intention, but the songs turn out to be an examination of the human condition through the life of a single person. *The Dream Songs* has a wide cast of characters, but it centers on the main character, who is a middle-aged white American, by the name of Henry, most possibly a surrogate for the poet himself, although Berryman places a disclaimer in his preface to the book that Henry is imaginary, "not the poet, not me." Berryman needs Henry for a number of reasons. The character offers the poet some distance to cool down and view himself and his life with a degree of detachment. In so doing he could get a second opinion, or a third, about his predicament. Viewed from a slightly different angle, this distancing provides a breathing space for the poet to stop being himself and act as a spectator even though it is brief and delusive. The world had been too much with Berryman, and nothing would be more grateful than an avenue of escape, narrow and fragile as it was. There is good reason to believe that Berryman wrote the songs at least partially for some therapeutic purpose (he wrote his *Berryman's Sonnets* while going through psychoanalysis). In addition, Henry proffers room for the poetic imagination to weave a web and then unravel it so as to play with life a little. Berryman needed some sense of humor to add color to a life the force of which was fast siphoned off. Besides the main character, there is another person, obviously Henry's friend. He is nameless, probably an African American, who addresses Henry as Mr. Bones or its variants. This friend can

be a real person around Henry. He appears to be like that most of the time. But he can be imaginary, someone that, Henry in his wild fantasies feels, is present in his life. In this form the friend could be Henry's conscience, or his alter-ego, someone he could act out his wishes or daydreams with, his talking partner, his shrink, his punching bag, in a word, everything that could help save his sanity and help him drag on until the impossible point comes.

The world of The Dream Songs is one of darkness, disorder, and oddness. It is full of suffering and pain. Henry grieves over his loss, talking about himself sometimes in the first person, sometimes in the third, and sometimes even in the second. He has lived in misery. An inveterate alcoholic, he is life-weary, hungry for love and sex, stressed out, desperate and depressed, and always wanting to die. His father committed suicide, and his life is never the same again:

Huffy Henry hid [sic.] the day
unappeasable Henry sulked.

...

All the world like a woolen lover
once did seem on Henry's side.

Then came a departure.

Thereafter nothing fell out as it might or ought...

The "departure" means, needless to say, his father's suicide. Henry can never be happy after the loss of his father brought an abrupt end to his happy childhood. He finds it hard to understand how the world can endure and live on (dream song 1). He finds life boring ("I am heavy bored" [dream song 14]). He feels responsible for his bereavement: "There sat down, once, a thing on Henry's heart / so heavy, if he had a hundred years / & more, & weeping, sleepless, in all them time / Henry could not make good" (dream song 29). He feels angry: "I spit upon this dreadful banker's grave / who shot his heart out in a Florida dawn"; he would get right down under the grass and "ax the casket open" just to see how his father managed to do it and make him feel so downright miserable (dream song 384). He thirsts for love that has never been there for him, a "bitter Henry full of the death of love" (dream song 48). He wishes life to be a handkerchief sandwich, and his African American companion diagnoses his malaise and offers a cure:

?You is from hunger, Mr. Bones,

I offer you this handkerchief, now set
your left foot by my right foot,
shoulder to shoulder, all that jazz,
arm in arm by the beautiful sea,
hum a little, Mr. Bones.

His friend concludes that Henry's disorder stems from want of love. Perceiving this, the companion loses no time helping fix it, by showing a gesture of love and offering to dance with him. But this friend is, in this instance, probably an imaginary person, and the conversation above is probably an interior monologue of Henry's. He is fantasizing his wishes and trying to romanticize himself out of his dilemma. Of course it fails to work, as in the end nothing happens to relieve his gloom: "I saw nobody coming [to dance with me], so I went instead" (dream song 76). And he is overcome with the urge to sing a song, his dream songs, "the like of which may bring your heart to break" (dream song 143). The songs open him up in an amazingly honest manner, as a soul suffering, mortified, anxious to confess, begging for salvation. He has hoped, in

this way, to find some room for survival, or some "middle ground" between the threatening world and his soul, to address his "to be or not to be" problem, but feels frustrated in the end. Life is still unbearable to him; he has still to "scold [his] heavy daughter" for bringing new life into the world (dream song 385). So Henry Berryman resigns to his fate and gives up his fight.

In formal concerns, Berryman had always a powerful literary ambition. He struggled hard for a style of his own. As one of the 1940s generation, he began writing in the overwhelming New Critical mode. He was heavily indebted to William Butler Yeats and W. H. Auden in many aspects of his writings, and never really felt totally comfortable with free verse. For instance, he loved the bookish, or cross-cultural references, so abundant in the High Modernist works but used only grudgingly in the verse of the postwar period. He tried not to be a mere follower of the masters. He endeavored to break through the New Critical and other influences when he wrote *Homage to Mistress Bradstreet*, which has been, nonetheless, regarded as an academic poem of the 1950s with its formal meters and rhymes and diction and syntax. But *The Dream Songs* embraced the new values of the contemporary period. It is composed in the open form; its subject is autobiographical; its tone is personal and confessional. His diction runs wild with a wide array of expressions, baby talk, black and beat slang, dialects, O's, ah's, linguistic eccentricities, illiteracies of diverse kinds etc. He flouts grammar deliberately and confuses references on occasions. And there is a strong neurotic coloring peculiar to Berryman's language. Even so, there is still a lingering of some features of the previous period such as the irritating allusions that occur in quite some of his songs, irritating because they do not seem to have a legitimate place there as they often impede the lucid flow of the language as well as the emotions.

John Berryman has been neglected in recent decades. Some anthologies do not even include him. He deserves better. In terms of emotional intensity and poetic craft, he was probably one of the finest 1940s poets to survive into the postwar period. As such he has a good chance to stay in history.

Randall Jarrell (1914-1965)

Randall Jarrell was born in Nashville, Tennessee. As a result of his parents' alienation and divorce, he spent his childhood with his grandparents and great-grandparents in California, but returned to Tennessee in his early teens to attend high school there. Later he studied under John Crowe Ransom at Vanderbilt University and came under the influence of the New Criticism and the Fugitives. He taught at some universities most of his adult life except for brief periods as editor and during the war in which he served in the United States Air Force (1942-1946). Jarrell's death was probably the result of his emotional disturbance: he just walked to the path of a car on the highway. Jarrell wrote quite a few volumes of poetry. These include such as *Blood for a Stranger* (1942), *Little Friend*, *Little Friend* (1945), *Losses* (1948), *The Seven-League Crutches* (1951), *The Woman at the Washington Zoo* (1960) which won the National Book Award, and *The Lost World* (1965), about the best of all his works.

Jarrell was an important poet and critic of this period. Though one of the 1940s generation, he felt, almost from the outset, acutely uneasy within the High Modernist and the New Critical boundaries. He was willing to dissociate himself from any convictions or opinions that were dogmatic in nature. He rebelled to look for a style of his own. His poetry strives to be pleasant and sympathetic in theme, and personal and honest in tone. And he can be sentimental and heartbreaking. His style tends to be plain, prosy, and verbose, but witty and deeply moving (which

is his saving grace). As a critic he was savagely perceptive and honest, and was feared by not a few. He was probably a better critic than he was a poet.

Jarrell's poetic career can be split into three visible phases: the early poems of childhood desolation, the war poems (in which the motif of the child dying helpless and confined recurs), and the postwar return to the theme of his childhood life in a slightly altered focus. His poetry reveals his obsession with the childhood theme, which is probably traceable to his own childhood when a traumatic experience thwarted his happy growth as a kid. As we noted earlier, his parents' divorce had a great impact on his life. He was first left in the care of his paternal grandparents and great-grandparents in California, but then had to attend school in Tennessee and live with his mother. He was in a way "displaced" from the loving care of the old folks. That phase of his childhood was one of confusion and insecurity and emotional turmoil. It left a big hole of affection and motherly love which he was busy the rest of his life trying to mend. As his wife put it, all his life Jarrell was struggling to maintain a precarious personal balance. In a sense he was so scarred by his childhood that he remained a child psychologically all his life. The best of his poetry always has to do with subjects associated in some ways with childhood or his reminiscence of childhood years.

Jarrell's early poems project a vague sense of a search for the lost mother and an awareness of the hopelessness of the undertaking. Poems such as "The Skaters" and "The Bad Music" from his first book, *Blood for a Stranger* (1942) both portray a child gazing or dreaming in its earnest fantasy about its mother. There are so many stars in the sky of the "The Skaters" that it is impossible to locate the one the child wants. The same goes with the crowd in "The Bad Music": "... and see, all the miles north inside my head, / You looking down across the city, puzzling... / High over the millions who breathe and wait and sparkle..." Reading Jarrell, we need to remember that his "Mama" and "Pop" are reserved for his grandparents, and his mother appears always with the name of "Anna."

So one persistent motif in Jarrell's poetry is the image of a child alone, at a loss, and often in danger or pain or both. One good example is his famous poem, "The Death of the Ball Turret Gunner." This is from his volume of fine war poems, *Little Friend, Little Friend* (1945), based on his war experience in the Air Force during the war. It is obviously about fear and death, and Jarrell thought that the best vehicle for expressing those dire emotions should be the image of the child and its helplessness as a fetus in the womb:

From my mother's sleep I fell into the State,
And I hunched in its belly till my wet fur froze.
Six miles from earth, loosed from its dream of life,
I woke to black flask and the nightmare fighters.
When I died they washed me out of the turret with a hose.

The ball turret gunner is portrayed as a fetus in the mother's womb. He tries to make to life, but dies before he is able to do it. However, he makes to the realization that he has always been a fetus, never an adult person ?first in his mother's womb, then in the womb-like State (the bomber fighter or by extension his country), which like the mother feeds him but keeps him unborn, un-adult. The irony is that, just after he realizes that he has never lived in his own individuality, he dies and leaves no trace behind. A number of Jarrell's other war poems, in which the womb and the birth-death motif recurs, also represent the lost child psyche of the soldiers. "A Pilot from the Carrier," "A Front," "Pilots, Man Your Planes," and "2nd Air Force" are just some examples here.

Jarrell's postwar poems such as those in the collections, *The Seven Leagues of Crutches* (1951) and *The Lost World* (1965), revert back to his early theme: the confusion, innocence, and betrayal by life. There are three poems in his 1951 volume that particularly showcase his child vision and mentality. In all of these death occurs in the child's life; pain chills and crushes the emotional resilience of the child, who has to endure the loneliness, the sense of being deserted, and possible mental derangement resulting from all the suffering involved. The child in "The Truth" has to face three deaths (father, sister, dog) and ends up in a mental institution. The child in "The Black Swan" has to cope with her sister's death and imagines her sister and herself turned into a swan by the swans. And "The Orient Express" reveals the adult poet looking around with a pair of child's eyes and feeling the same way a child does: in the sunlight he feels safe, but at dusk, his mind darkens with fear and insecurity as the lands darken.

"The Lost World" in *The Lost World* collection is an epitome of the best of Jarrell's poetry. It consists of three poems in which the poet, an adult now, tries to recap the warmth and security and joy of his childhood, lost in time and space, but captured and held sacred in memory. The first of these, "Children's Arms," lists the dear old things he did as a kid, the dear old possessions he had then, the dear old people he grew up with, the good old times he enjoyed, and tells everything in Jarrell's usual colloquial, anecdotal, plaintive tone of a child, which sounds pathetic yet reassuring to the poet-speaker and to the readers. For here is something positive, something one can call one's own, something with which one can live one's life on one's own terms. What is particularly impressive is the picture of the child sitting in his tree house, feeling the sense of power and autonomy in his own world where he takes orders from no one but himself and follows none other than his own agenda: "To leave my tree house for reality? / There was nothing there for me to disbelieve. / At peace among my weapons, I sit in my tree / And feel: Friday night, then Saturday, then Sunday!" The last part of the poem relates his visit to the library when the child feels the coziness of "a womanish and childish / And doggish universe." This world is appealing to the child because it is one where the weak stay shielded from possible harm. Jarrell's response to the feminine part of the world will be our concern later on in the discussion. What interests us now is the child's fascination with the world of animals: "If only people purred and panted!" This fascination is given fuller expression in the second poem, "A Night with Lions." He reminisces about his one-time play with a lion, named Tawny, which was kind, good-natured, and ready to oblige. Between the child and the beast, there was genuine cordiality and caring absent from "the Petrified Forest" which is a child's fairy-tale notion of the real world. The third in the series, "A Street off Sunset," probably the most well-known of the three, records the poet's fond remembrance of the dear old folks who brought him up, the grandparents, Dandeen, a grandaunt, and the great-grandparents, the people who helped mend his child's universe. The famous scene, where "Mama" kills a chicken out of necessity to feed him and her folks, apparently took a long time for the child and the poet to understand properly:

The body hurls
Itself out ?lunging, reeling, it begins to run
Away from Something, to fly away from Something
In great flopping circles. Mama stands like a nun
In the center of each awful, anguished ring.
The thundering and scrambling go on, go on ?then
they fade,

I open my eyes, it's over...[.]

It was an act of love if anything ("Like all who love").

The poem, another of his famous poems, that wraps up the autobiographical *The lost World*, is entitled "Thinking of the Lost World." It pulls together, true to form, all the loose threads of the whole volume and gives it a sense of closure. Here once again Jarrell reminisces back to his childhood, the best of his times, and tries to hold it up as a frame of reference against which to judge in the hope of coming to terms with the miserable present. Here a spoonful of chocolate tapioca brings back a flood of endearing memories of the past when he was a child with "Mama and Pop and Dandeen." He finds himself traveling back through the time tunnel, "... back to that calm country / Through which the stream of my life first meandered." He is back in Los Angeles with its sunshine, and remembers the orange groves, his bow and arrows, his knife and the eucalyptus tree, the stair-sticks and the planks of the tree house, and the gray smoke smelling of a perfume he smelt in his childhood. Though the past is gone, he believes that its innocence and its primitive quality are perennial. He would believe in the permanence of fairy-tales and pristine Indians in contrast with the unpleasant, even sordid, criminal present (one token of which is "the mad [Indian] girl" with her disconcerting eyes). He would believe that the Indians still live the way they used to do and that his own dead folks, his dog Lucky and the Lion Tawny he played with, are still around in the land of the blest. Although all of this is gone, nothing has vanished for him. The scene of dear old "Mama" having to kill a chicken in order to feed her family, first described in "A Street off Sunset," comes to his mind once more: "The chicken's body is still going round / And round in widening circles, a satellite / From which, as the sun sets, the scientist bends / A look of evil on the unsuspecting earth. / Mama and Pop and Dandeen are still there / In the Gay Twenties." Now that he is getting old, having come back to his present from his time travel, heard a boy call him "Santa Claus," and seen his own brown and spotted hands and ridged nails, the poet feels a wave of nostalgia come over him. He sees his own childhood hand with its smooth white-bitten fingernail; he sees himself in his tennis shoes and khaki riding-pants, and he is thrilled with this moment of sudden revelation to him:

I have found that Lost World in the Lost and Found
Columns whose gray illegible advertisements
My soul has memorized world after world
LOST ?NOTHING. STRAYED FROM NOWHERE.
NO REWARD.
I hold in my own hands, in happiness,
Nothing: the nothing for which there's no reward.

This is in fact an echo to the title of the poem. The lost world of the past is not lost, or is lost but found again, resurrected in the act of the mind thinking. He is comforted in the discovery that the past is here to stay and that he has not lost it after all. It may be invisible and intangible, and he does not have to pay to get it back, but it is solid here with him now, providing him with the values he needs so badly to live his present life meaningfully. The universal applicability of his epiphany is self-evident.

One other thing about Jarrell is what he mentioned on one occasion as his semi-feminine mind. He enjoyed using female personae in some of his poems that involved looking at life from a woman's point of view. As this was unusual with a male poet, it came to the notice of some writers and critics. Some became aware that Jarrell never drank or smoked. Others heard him say things

that women tended to say. Robert Lowell felt that Jarrell was not quite one of the boys. Whatever has been said on the subject, it should be made clear that there was nothing wrong with Randall Jarrell in terms of sexual orientation and that he used female narrators in his works because he had a special purpose in mind to accomplish. Jarrell was sensitive to human vulnerability and suffering. He was soft and tenderhearted toward the weak. As one of his poems indicates earlier on, he would like to live in the sanctuary of a childish, womanish, and doggish world, one that would offer comfort and security to the helpless and shield them from possible harm. This impersonation and masquerade helped him convey his feelings effectively and fully dramatized his sensibility. His famous poems in which women personae are employed include, among others, "A Girl in a Library."

Randall Jarrell was a very famous critic of his time. He was probably the greatest poet-critic of his generation. He wrote commentaries at a time when literary criticism was thriving in America. He had so much passion and respect for poetry that he even went as far as to compare poetry to air and food. In addition, he had the perspicacity, the catholic taste, and the acumen that characterize a great critic. He was widely read in literature and knew a lot about music and visual arts. With his native intelligence, he was well equipped for the job. But he did not regard critiquing poetry as a job that one has to do as required. For him critiquing poetry was the most fascinating thing to do. It is no wonder that he wrote many commentaries not only perceptive but fascinating to read. He was affectionate and sympathetic, witty, energetic, and honest in his essays. He was outspoken and refused to budge in face of dissent and negativity. What he said came straight from his heart and revealed his own emotions and personality so that the readers feel close to him and have confidence in his observations. He avoided being vague and pompous and tried to be clear and credible. He was generous and caring. His criticism was for the most part just downright brilliant. Jarrell had a mysterious and uncanny insight. Quite a few of his bold predictions actually came true. For instance, he predicted against the grain, in his essay, "The End of the Line," that Modernism would die, at a time when Eliot and the New Criticism were still successful and influential, and sure enough Modernism did phase out in time. He predicted that Elizabeth Bishop would become great, and so would Robert Lowell whose poetry people would read as long as men remember English. And sure enough he was right again. His criticism wielded the power of "make or mar" in some cases. He revived reputations which were on the verge of neglect and losing out to time. He was generous with his favorable comments. He made others' works his own major concern and sincerely wanted to see them succeed. He wrote about his fellow poets' works in a way that often made them feel better about themselves. This made a number of poets feel special and grateful. Whereas his praises were weighty, his negative comments were no less so. Some of these cruel and harsh comments were compared to acid. His remarks about fellow poets such as Oscar Williams and Josephine Miles were well founded and clever, which increased his savagery. Because his criticism was genuine and sincere, he left no hard feelings and made no unnecessary enemies. Jarrell wrote four volumes of criticism: *Poetry and the Age* (1953), *A Sad Heart at the Supermarket* (1962), *The Third Book of Criticism* (1969), and *Kipling, Auden and Co., Essays and Reviews, 1935-1964* (1980). He helped shape his generation's taste in poetry in more than one way.

James Merrill (1926-1995)

It is difficult to place James Merrill here or as a poet who wrote mostly in the meditative mode. As essentially one of the 1940s generation, Merrill was brought up in the New Critical

values and persisted in his creative career mostly in that way of writing, but he was sensitive enough to the wind of change of the 1950s and 1960s to accommodate it in his works, very much like Wilbur (though the two are different in many ways).

James Merrill was born son of Charles Merrill, one of the founders of Merrill Lynch. As such he lived a rather privileged life, not having to work except for a brief period of teaching. The one event that cast its long shadow over his life and career was his parents' divorce when he was still young. It was so overwhelming as an emotional trauma he had to live through and live with that he wrote about it directly or obliquely in many of his works. "Broken Home" (1966) comes to mind; so does one of the three plot threads in "The Book of Ephraim," the first part of his trilogy of the 1970s, *Changing Light at Sandover*. Merrill attended Amherst College, where he came under the influence of Marcel Proust, the French modern novelist and R. M. Rilke, the German poet. Wallace Stevens appealed to him enormously as well. As he grew up, Merrill discovered his homosexual orientation, and for a long time (over 25 years) lived with his companion, David Jackson, the "DJ" in his trilogy. From 1955 Merrill began receiving messages from the Ouija board. "The absurd, flimsy contraption, creaking along" (to quote his description of it) was installed in his dining room, where he (as MJ in his long poem) and DJ managed to communicate with the dead, as the poet claims. The transmittals, we are told by the poet, became the substance of his trilogy. Merrill was a poet of immense imaginative powers. His themes include such as romantic love, family, recapturing and reevaluating the past, and science as potential destroyer of human life. He was obsessed with form, believing that art is form. A brilliant versifier, he exhibited virtuosity in traditional forms of various kinds such as the sonnet, the sestina, blank verse, terza rima, and a host of other stanzaic patterns. Although he never accepted the notion of open form, Merrill did write in free verse occasionally. For him literary creation is a process of conscious deliberation and revision; he did not believe in spontaneity. Imbibing the air of change of his time in taste and values, Merrill wrote both impersonal and autobiographical poems, his personal poems often encased in traditional forms. If we recall his poems about his parents and also those about his Greek lover, we will see how he wrote his personal life into his work. Even in the long poem, the trilogy, the author's personal life is very much in evidence. His love for and companionship with David Jackson, his childhood experiences, etc. All these revealed the subtle influence of the Confessional poets, and it is notable that the archangels in the long poem speak in free verse. Merrill has also been noted for his love of puns, overtones, word games, and enormous wit. He was a prolific writer. His volumes include *First Poems* (1950), *The Country of a Thousand Years of Peace* (1959), *Water Street* (1962), *Nights and Days* (1966), *Braving the Elements* (1972), and his trilogy, *Changing Light at Sandover*, which consists "The Book of Ephraim" (1976), *Mirabell: Books of Number* (1978), *Scripts for the Pageant* (1980), and a coda, *The Higher Keys* (1982). In 1983 he collected some of his best poems and published *From the First Nine and The Changing Light at Sandover*. Merrill was also a novelist and playwright. He won the 1977 Pulitzer Prize for poetry and the 1979 National Book Award. At one time he was judge for the Yale Younger Poet series.

The trilogy has been, no doubt, Merrill's claim to eternal fame. Its substance is, as noted earlier, supposed to come from the author's communication with the Ouija board. Ouija is the trademark for a board with the alphabet and other signs on it. The board is used with a planchette to seek spiritualistic or telepathic messages. The two lover-friends, JM and DJ, as the poem tells us, connect with the board as they connect with one another, the game thus becoming a bonding

process between them as well as getting information from the world beyond, or the dead. The trilogy is 560 pages long, of which the first part, "The Book of Ephraim," makes up 92 pages, the second part, *Mirabell*, 183 pages, the third part, *Scripts for the Pageant*, 244, and the coda, *The Higher Keys*, 41.

"The Book of Ephraim" consists of 28 sections, each beginning with a letter of the alphabet from A to Z. It functions as a preface to the poem, mostly narrative, summarizing the teachings of the communicator, Ephraim, who was a favorite of Roman Emperor Tiberius (42 BC-37 AD; Roman emperor, 14-37 AD). As the poet tells us, Ephraim appears in the early phase of their Ouija board experience, and as a result his teachings are narrated rather than presented in the form of its original's transcription. In this section the poet wrote quite a bit of his own life into the poem, mainly the previous nineteen years of his experience. "The Book of Ephraim" is woven of three threads of narrative interest. The first of these focuses on the relationship between DJ and MJ, and their increasing contact with Ephraim at the board which increases their closeness: the Ouija board keeps them together, almost secluded from the rest of the social life, and opens up a new world of "the beyond" which is more sympathetic to their relationship. The second strand of interest relates to the novel MJ had had in mind to write and to the correlative interaction between it and the poem MJ has written. The novel contains characters which approximate the personalities that the poem delineates, thus offering a double perspective for appreciation. The poem is supposed to be telling the real story, and the novel is regarded as fictional, but they relate and correct one another, thus reading in a vague sort of way like Nabokov's *Pale Fire* inverted. One significant character that features in both the novel and the poem is Ephraim who is Eros in the novel. This is indeed as it should be if we remember how the Ouija board at which Ephraim surfaces cements the love relationship between the two friend-lovers. The third strand of interest traces the history of the composition of the poem and the novel, which is important because it reveals some of Merrill's literary theories. One important of these is his effort to recapture the past. Merrill believes that the past should be able to become the present when it is recalled and reconsidered, and there is always revision and modification of it in the mental process. This reminds us at once of T. S. Eliot's "Tradition and the Individual Talent" and Wordsworth's "emotion... recollected in tranquility." As "The Book of Ephraim" goes on, the poem tells us, a higher power comes on the scene, demanding the poet to leave off his contact with Ephraim and starts writing "poems of science," as it dictates to him. Hence the next two parts of the long poem.

The second part of the long poem, *Mirabell: Books of Number*, is made up of the major sections (0 to 9), each of these being split into subdivisions numbered as 0.1, 0.2, and so on. The communicator here is 741, a batlike creature thinking in terms only of numbers or mathematics. Later 741 seems to be transformed into or taken over by *Mirabell*, a peacock. This part adopts a scientific view of reality. The third, the longest, part, *Scripts for the Pageant*, consists of three major sections, "YES," "&," and "NO." It raises the question of whether mankind will survive or if they have God on their side. The answer is indefinite, as it first says yes, and then no. The two parts contain mostly messages transmitted from the Ouija board to the friends ?DJ, MJ, WHA and MM and others ?who try to make sense of these instructions. Since WHA and MM are both dead, the discussion has to be held with the help of the Ouija board as well. The coda presents a big party at Merrill's boyhood home at Sandover, which offers the occasion for Merrill to read his poem to his guests from "the beyond" such as Jane Austen, T. S. Eliot, and Dante.

The thematic and formal concerns of the trilogy are obvious enough. The long poem deals

in the main with the disastrous effect of science and technology on man and his life. It is trying to say that the world is threatened, its "greenhouse" is being destroyed, so that it is in danger of becoming a void, one of nothingness in which man and his life matter no more. The world faces imminent ruin. Death, the sense of mortality, overwhelms. It is a black hole that has to be reckoned with. The poem expresses both intellectual uncertainty and emotional ambivalence that the thinking minds feel in face of overwhelming odds. The trilogy also offers a positive outlook on the homosexual relationship: it reads like a song in praise of the love and companionship between two lover-friends, DJ and MJ. Both of the themes are deftly interwoven with the help and in the guise of the Ouija board communications. In formal terms the trilogy is a consummate work of art in conception, structure, and execution. The whole of it is organized with meticulous care, which indicates the workings of an exquisite mind. In versification, the trilogy is an adequate illustration of Merrill's versatile genius. The narration is done in blank verse; 741 communicates in lines of 14 syllables each; the archangels speak in free verse and the voice of God in ten-syllable syllabics; the dictation from the Ouija board is written out in capitals. By virtue of all these strengths, the trilogy will have good chances to stay in history along with other postwar long poetic efforts like *The Waste Land*, the *Cantos*, and *The Bridge*. It is good to note for the record, however, that *Changing Light at Sandover* has provoked some controversy regarding some points of a mooted nature such as reincarnation, the nine stages of life in the after-world, the continuous existence of the dead, and the authentic nature of the Ouija board messages. As it is, it is still anybody's guess whether and how these would affect the seriousness of the theme of the work.

Before we leave Merrill, it is good to take a look at some portion of "The Book of Ephraim" just for a taste of the long poem. This is taken from its section C in which the two friends hear Ephraim speak at the board, doubt the truth of his information, and decide to interact with him. Ephraim divulges information about life in this and the after-world, which is germane to the rest of the long poem. Here is mostly Ephraim speaking. Ephraim anticipates their questions and answers them straight away. What Ephraim is trying to say is that there are nine stages in the whole of life, of which we humans, the living, the little savage souls, have not yet had a footing in stage one. We are representatives of our patrons, the spirits, who watch us, angry with our behavior and fussing about it, but are forbidden to intervene except for the phase of intermission when we move between incarnations and they teach us then only with the help of the *savoir-vivre*-?or the knowledge of how to live? in order to move up the ladder of perfection and become patrons ourselves. As we move upward, our patrons go higher likewise in their evolution. The process of incarnation may go on and on. The excerpt here is a good illustration of the occult message behind the long poem.

CHAPTER 21 The Confessional School The Beat Generation

The Confessional School

One distinct group of poets in the postwar period is the Confessional school. This includes, in a broad way, many people whose poetry seems to share common features such as a ruthless, excruciating self-analysis of one's own background and heritage, one's own most private desires and fantasies etc., and the urgent "I'll-tell-it-all-to-you" impulse: Delmore Schwartz (with his emphasis on "the wound of consciousness"), Stanley Kunitz (with his "gang of personal devils" set

loose), Theodore Roethke, John Berryman, W. D. Snodgrass, Allen Ginsberg, Robert Lowell, Sylvia Plath, Anne Sexton, and Adrienne Rich, to name the obvious few. In a narrower survey of the scene, Lowell, Plath, and Sexton seem to stand closer and have been mentioned and meant often when the epithet "Confessional" is brought up in the context of a poetry discussion. The reasons for this are evident. Although Confessional poetry did not begin with Robert Lowell —there were Whitman, Pound, and Eliot, to some extent, to cite the famous examples in recent memory, no one made it such a vogue in the postwar period, as did Lowell with his ruthless self-dissection. Lowell's *Life Studies* gave Confessional poetry a new life and a new level of popularity in an unprecedented manner, and his poetry lectures at Boston University showed the way to poetry and fame to at least two of his many students: Sylvia Plath and Anne Sexton. Plath went even further than her teacher in her frankness about herself. Thus in a sense Lowell created this postwar school of poetry. One interesting fact to note about the three poets is that they had one more thing in common: all of them stayed at one time of their lives at the McClean's (a mental hospital), Massachusetts. We include Adrienne Rich in our discussion here but she is "Confessional" only tangentially.

Robert Lowell (1917-1977)

Lowell came from a distinguished New England family which included famous poets like James Russell Lowell and Amy Lowell. This background served Lowell well in at least two ways: it endowed him with culture and taste in the very texture of his being, and at the same time offered a window of opportunity for him to scrutinize and dissect the decline of his New England tradition as an index to the overall disintegration that he felt overwhelming his nation. He was well educated at Harvard (for two years) and then at Kenyon College, Ohio under the well-known New Critical poet and critic John Crowe Ransom. During the war, he first tried to enlist and was rejected, then refused to serve later in the war in reaction against the allies' war brutalities, and stayed in prison for a few months for draft evasion. All the time he had been writing, and his poetic career reached a height when he received a Pulitzer for his second volume, *Lord Weary's Castle* in 1946. Now a rising star on the scene, he was appointed Consultant in Poetry at the Library of Congress in 1947. Lowell was silent for a while (1951-1959), felt unwell, stayed in an institution, and contemplated on poetry of his age. He experienced personal mental disturbances and was in fact advised by his doctor to write about his emotional agonies so as to relieve him of their pressure on his collapsing mind. The result was *Life Studies* (1959). When he appeared in print again with this new work, he had switched from the New Critical style to open form, and had inadvertently initiated a new school of verse, the Confessional poetry. He received the National Book Award for the new book. In the late 1960s he was arrested for his part in the march on the Pentagon against the Vietnam War.

Robert Lowell began as a strict formalist of the New Critical school in the 1940s. He had a solid education in the poetics of the school from Ransom, Warren, Tate, and Cleanth Brooks. All his poetry before the end of the 1950s was regular in form, witty, packed, and well crafted. But after 15 years of immersion in the New Criticism, Lowell felt fed up with building its clever type of artifice and thirsted, along with the trend of his time, for "human richness." The Beats had already begun to howl; William Carlos Williams was rising from obscurity; John Berryman was raving; and across the Atlantic there were the English Movement poets like Philip Larkin (1922-1985) speaking out their personal truths. Lowell's change in style came about as part of the overall change in climate. His *Life Studies* was, in retrospect, a matter of course in his personal

evolution as a poet. But it should be noted that Lowell was never slack and undisciplined in form. Although he wrote in free verse (and was autobiographical), there is always visible discipline in his artistic control. He always kept his formal values in mind.

Thematically, the change was a natural corollary of the gradual evolution of Lowell's vision of man's fate and "the fate of selfhood in time." Aghast at "all the horrors of this age," Lowell had always been interested in man's existence and his salvation. In the first two volumes of his poetry, *Land of Unlikeness* (1944) and *Lord Weary's Castle* (1946), he was concerned with Christian humanism, and was fired with a religious kind of fervor to find a way out of the slough of despond into which man has fallen. He was critical of the society which is immoral with its dehumanizing materialism, or "Mammon's unbridled industry," and the spiritual decay it has caused. *Land of Unlikeness* reveals that man's soul has changed; it is no longer like God and even itself. Man is in danger. He is heading for Hell. *Lord Weary's Castle* portrays modern man as dull and hopeless and neglecting salvation. Poem after poem, Lowell is almost howling like a prophet in the wilderness. Read his "Mr. Edwards and the Spider," or "After Surprising Conversions," and there should be no doubt about his message, that it is time man searched for means of salvation. There is the smell of the Edwardian hell. There is the sight of perverse man roasted over fire. Or read his "The Quaker Graveyard in Nantucket" which has been regarded as Lowell's best war poem. Here the world of *Lord Weary's Castle* is graphically delineated: war and death, aggression, corruption, tyranny, impotence, rapacity and greed, inhuman cruelty, spiritual alienation, and all that "blinds and binds." The poem, especially in its first five sections, is full of images of destruction: the shipwreck and Winslow's and the sailors' death, the doom of Pequod, warships in the hand of an angry God, the world about to be destroyed, the rotting viscera of the whale, etc. The mood is that of anger and desolation. But there is some redeeming grace, too: among other things, Quaker pacificism, Father Mapple's warnings, intimations of Christ's resurrection, the Messiahs killing the Leviathan, the shrine of the Virgin at Walsingham (with its meditative peace and calm and promise of salvation), and the new covenant with God. The last two sections of the poem suggest renewed creation and the transfiguration of the dead. Here the poet is contemplating, as does a traditional Christian mystic, a number of things urgent to him such as God and His power, man's alienation, warning signs, and salvation. He recommends faith in Christ, union with God, and embracing the contemplative life.

In his third volume, *The Mills of the Kavanaughs* (1951), Lowell turns away from his religious enthusiasm to some more secular material like society and individual life stories, and explores the possibility for people to find stability, a secular stability, through supra-personal forms of belief, myth, or meditation. His portrayal of individual characters seems to offer a new kind of certitude. "In Falling Asleep over the Aeneid," the old man finds strength and meaning in love and morality (which is the central theme of the whole volume). *The Mills of the Kavanaughs* constitutes a turning point in Lowell's career. From here onward he veered in a new direction of writing. He began to see man as he is. A footnote is in order here, though, that although God does not appear much in his work after 1950, His voice continues to be heard for a long while in Lowell's poetry.

A departure came roundabout the end of the 1950s when Lowell turned inward and began his painful soul-searching within himself. He left his "City of God" and touched earth in the "City of Man" of which he was part. He examined his societal and family background and the potential of art as a means to his own salvation. From there he proceeded to examine his origins and his

own self and, after vilifying his parentage and himself and suffering intensely in the course of it, found hope in an otherwise desolate landscape. Of all this Life Studies is his poetic record.

A masterpiece of Confessional poetry, Life Studies consists of four parts. Part one, four poems, delimits the context of human behavior and offers the frame of reference for subsequent revelations. Here the poet-speaker ?"I" ?sets foot in the City of Man: "Life changed to landscape," "Our mountain-climbing train had come to earth." This is an indication of the weakening or loss of his faith in God. In his new endeavor, instead of finding where life belongs, he has now made up his mind to locate where he belongs ("Beyond the Alps"). Here he realizes that worldly matters need worldly standards of judgment and understanding ("The Banker's Daughter"). Here history repeats itself and has learned no wisdom ("Inauguration Day: January 1953"). And here man is seen at his most abject: he is no more than an animal ("A Mad Negro Solder Confined at Munich"), a point the poet keeps firmly in mind to come back to address at the end in "Skunk Hour." With these observations, the stage is set for the poet's self-scrutiny.

Part two is the book's prose section, entitled "91 Revere Street." This is a strictly autobiographical segment, which reveals the poet's anxiety over a decaying culture as he sees it embodied in his father's personality. The father appears to be the archetypal effete New Englander who is, in the eyes of his son, essentially an impotent man. "He was deep, not with profundity," the poet thus writes of him, "but with the dumb depth of one who trusted in statistics and was dubious of personal experience." In his forties, the son-poet goes on to tell us, the father's soul goes underground. He survives, in the twenty-two years after he leaves the Navy, only "to drift from job to job, to be displaced, to be grimly and literally that old cliché a fish out of water." "91 Revere Street" also offers a startling portrait of the deterioration of the social milieu of the poet's childhood. The adulteration and the consequent degrading of the New England tradition is seen as an ominous sign of the nation's down-slope movement. The prose section also insinuates that the child's background and upbringing has somehow prepared him for some artistic endeavor, which paves the way for the next section, part three.

Here this section of four poems is designed to explore the possibility of art as an avenue of escape and survival for the poet. He examines, for his own reference, four American poets, of different dispositions and styles, in "For Madox Ford," "For George Santayana," "To Delmore Schwartz," and "Words for Hart Crane." Ford demonstrates the awkward groping ineptness. Santayana shows him the natural nobility of the artist. Schwartz is a poet both visionary and stalled, very much his self-portrait. Crane reveals to him the cost of achievement ?the dedication of one's body and soul.

Then follows part four, entitled "Life Studies," which consists of two subsections of altogether 15 poems. Section one is a sequence of 11 poems, all about failure: the first seven about the family's failure, and the last four about his own. The first of these, "My Last Afternoon with Uncle Devereux," touches upon the dreams of the Winslow family and ends on a sad note of disappointment and death. It sets the tone for this part of the work. "Dunbarton" that follows reveals Grandfather's disappointment at Uncle Devereux's failure which is a negative reflection on the old man's own life. In "Grandparents," one of the book's strongest poems, the Winslow world of tradition falls, and in "Commander Lowell" the poet's parents' dream world is shattered. His father's failure is traced further back in time in "Terminal Days at Beverly Farms" and "Father's Bedroom": his father had a dream which did not happen. With his father dead, gone also is his cottage along with Mother's will to life ("For Sale").

The eighth poem, "Sailing Home from Rapallo," records the end of the Winslows' dream with Mother's death, and brings the poet face to face with himself. He feels the inadequacies of his past and begins to see his own failure, which is somehow suggestive of his daughter's possible failure ("During Fever"). "Waking in the Blue" reveals the poet's sense of his own incompetence to carry on the family tradition and his sense of guilt for it. There he wakes up only to find the night attendant tired with grappling with the meaning of life, Stanley fighting with age, and Bobbie struggling to fend off aging. He discovers in them his own absurdity and impotence. He is waking, but he is in the blue: depressed and at a loss as to what to do. The last poem of the section, "Home after Three Months Away," portrays the poet cured and feebly poised for something like a new beginning.

And this finally brings the poet to the long overdue self-examination. This is done in section two. The four poems here are all about the poet himself. "Memories of West Street and Lepke" laments over his loss of hopes and dreams and of the vigor and valor that he thought he once had. "Man and Wife," one of the poet's most telling poems, pictures a man sandwiched between his resolve to leave tradition behind and his indecision to do so. This is a reflection of the poet's own dilemma in love and marriage. "To Speak of Woe That Is in Marriage," spoken as an interior monologue by the wife but overheard by the husband, suggests the poet's awareness both of the evil power of tradition over humans as marriage illustrates and of his brutish behavior as part of that tradition. It can also indicate that the poet is becoming conscious of the extent of suffering he is bringing upon others and upon himself. He learns that he is repeating family ?human ?history. The poem implies that he must not only stay away from tradition, but also find his own way to survival. But he is confronted with the question, whether he has the will and the sense of direction to survive the wreckage that he has now become.

"Skunk Hour," the last poem of the book, probably the most famous of Lowell's poems, does not, at first sight, seem to offer a forthright answer. Here all around the poet is engulfed in an atmosphere of impotence: the hermit heiress living old and purposeless, "our summer millionaire" committing suicide probably because of weariness life or bankruptcy or both, and the fairy decorator whose existence is meaningless and without any sense of direction. All these abnormalities of life, static and hopeless, are symbols of spiritual corruption and form an objective correlative for the poet's own personal disintegration. As "Beyond the Alps" indicates his loss of faith in God, "The Skunk Hour," echoing it at the end, reveals his loss of faith in man, in himself, and in life. His best route of escape is death. And sure enough, he knows that his mind is not right. He is going through hell. It's a dark night, and he is out on "the hill's skull," looking at the lover-cars in the giant shadow of the graveyard. He feels bleak and his spirit sobs. Death becomes attractive. Then he sees a sight the portent of which is as ambiguous as ambiguous can be. A mother skunk is dauntlessly leading her kittens out hunting for food. They are having a hearty meal and are enjoying life. At the sight of vitality and fertility, the poet suddenly realizes that he has a thing or two to learn from the animals. Life flickers up again within him. The image of the skunk is interesting. The skunk is probably the most disgusting, the most despicable, of animals, and the poet realizes that he is not even as good as that. If man is reduced to such an abject animal state, there should be nothing left of his spiritual dignity. But then if there is the will to life and the courage with it, if we can forget our pettiness and stop self-deprecation, and try to pick up a lesson from our brute fellow creatures, then there should be probably still hope. The title "Skunk Hour" is interesting, too. It is the hour for skunks to be out eating; it is the hour when humans should

realize that they have become like skunks and should behave likewise. It is the hour when the poet reaches the lowest of the low in life, when he is at the lowest circle of hell, and achieves self-realization and makes a prophetic kind of call for humankind to do the same. It is a hellish hour for him and humankind, it is true, but the way after that point can only be the way upward. Lowell's message is clear that we humans have been dehumanized, but we do not need to feel disheartened. There is yet light at the end of the tunnel. Thus on this positive note the poem ends, and so does the volume as a whole. It is natural that *Life Studies* concludes the way it does because it is meant to be a series of studies on life and survival. A series of studies of personal life to begin with, *Life Studies* becomes eventually a scrutiny of American life in general.

Lowell's interest in human survival continues in his later works such as *For the Union Dead* (1964), *History* (1973), and *Day by Day* (1977). The title poem of the volume *For the Union Dead* merits particular attention. It presents modern man's moral decline and his loss of heroism and idealism. The epigraph in Latin, which is the inscription on the Shaw Monument in Boston, makes the theme of the poem clear from the very beginning: "He [Colonel Shaw] leaves all to serve the state." But the heroic public spirit of the Union dead in the civil war is gone. In its place there is only cowardice stemming from selfishness. This concern only for one's interest drives man countless centuries back in his evolution. The scene of the poem is set in a modern Eliotic wasteland ("a Sahara of snow," a picture of all-engulfing cold and apathy). The poet, sizing up the cityscape, spots four of its scenic features, and has a hard time reconciling and relating them to modern man and his life. These include the old South Boston Aquarium now dilapidated and closed, the underground garage in full steam under construction, the Shaw Monument in memory of the Union dead, and the swashbuckling Mosler Safe advertisement. The aquarium is now all gone. The underground garage is relentless to anything in its way. When completed, it will accommodate, as we will be told later in the poem, "giant finned cars... [of] a savage servility." The Shaw Monument, which is being shaken along with the Statehouse by the construction of the garage, is no longer an object of veneration. To the poet, it is still a "compass-needle" to orient modern man, but who cares now! The advertisement of the American Mosler Company, with Hiroshima boiling on a Mosler safe, illustrates modern man's view of things graphically: they gloat over a petty material gain (the safety of the Mosler safe with its money and treasures kept intact from the nuclear blast in Hiroshima) in total disregard of the far more weighty issue of the loss of countless innocent lives in that disaster. The poet feels that no one can expect such people to commit themselves to noble causes deal well with challenges to justice and righteousness, such as the bombing of Hiroshima, the school integration, and the larger human rights issues. So through censuring modern man (himself included), the poem is really an effort to find how to survive and, preferably, with dignity.

Lowell did not feel himself any better than his fellow creatures. "This age is mine, and I want very much to be a part of it," he said in 1965. The greatness of Lowell lies in the fact that, in talking candidly about himself, he is examining the culture of his nation. The identification of personal experience with that of an age has always ensured greatness and even immortality as it did, for instance, for T. S. Eliot in *The Waste Land*, for Fitzgerald in *The Great Gatsby*, and further back in time, for Goethe in his *The Sorrows of Young Werther* (1774). Lowell seems to be fired with a sense of historic mission that gives his poetry an epic dimension. It is not just his prophetic denunciations or injunctions, but also the intensity of his commitment, that leave readers with a somewhat larger and morally more uplifting impression. Lowell was one of the finest poets (if not

the finest) in postwar America.

Plath and Sexton

Sylvia Plath (1932-1963) was a very sensitive person. She was frail and sensitive ever since she was a child. Her peculiar emotional makeup had to do with her parentage. She was of German descent: her father, Otto Plath, immigrated to the U. S. in 1901. She had a hard time integrating herself into the rest of her community, especially in school during WW?. She felt guilty of being of German extraction and was made to feel more so by the intentional or casual anti-Nazi remarks of her fellow students. What made things worse was the death of her father when she was eight years old. The family was suddenly left to shift for itself: Her father left no retirement arrangement or money; her mother had to hunt for a job; and her grandfather lost his at the critical moment. This sense of forlornness and insecurity must have haunted the child so that she might have felt deserted by her father. Her memories of her father must have come flooding back, especially those of him acting like an autocrat within the family and to his wife, who gave up her job to accommodate his wishes for her to be a homemaker. Sylvia Plath once told one of her classmates that she had wished to have killed her father many times over and that, when he died, she wished that she had killed him. This outburst was an indication of her troubled, abnormal psyche since, as a child, she had been the center of her father's attention, and she had loved and adored him. In fact, his death was the biggest incident of her life after which she was said to be never happy again. This abnormal psyche accounts for her repeated attempts at suicide. However, it did not seem to affect her life for a while. She did very well in school, got married, and had children, writing and publishing poetry all the time. But when her husband, the English poet Ted Hughes (1930-1998), began seeing another woman in 1962, her world, physical as well as emotional, finally suddenly collapsed. Not, however, before she poured out her best poetry that she believed would make her name for her. The last few months of her life (the period of "creative fury" as critic J. D. McClatchy puts it) proved to be the most prolific and memorable when she produced almost one poem a day. Her books of verse include *A Winter Ship* (1960), *The Colossus and Other Poems* (1960), *Ariel* (1965), *Uncollected Poems* (1973), *Crystal Gazer and Other Poems* (1971), *Winter Trees* (1971), *Fiesta Melons* (1971), *Crossing the Water* (1971), *Lyonesse: Hitherto Uncollected Poems* (1971), and *Pursuit* (1973). She also wrote some plays and a novel, *The Bell Jar* (1961).

For Sylvia Plath writing was a process of release, of exorcising her acute sense of "existential anxiety," caused by her self-consciousness of being a German descendant, the shadow of her father's death, her intense subconscious dislike of her mother, and the hurt she received from the infidelity of her husband which she did not succeed in alleviating for herself. So she was obsessed with death and suicide: "Dying is an art... I guess I have a call" as she puts it in her poem "Lady Lazarus." And this, along with the suffering and the agony, became the major theme of her major works. Hence the most painful making a clean breast of it, the most intimate divulging of her innermost secret of life galling to her soul, the celebrated elements which made her "a supreme example of the confessional mode in modern literature." So there it is, this palpable autobiographical strain in her poetry, "the longest suicide note ever written." But Sylvia Plath was not happy with a simple display of her personal experience. Her consummate art lies in her power to make sure that her individual experience goes through a process of reworking within the possibilities of her poetic art so as to acquire a measure of universal applicability. Thus isolated and private in nature, her life is transformed and magnified enough for people to relate to without too much of a stretch of their imagination. "Daddy" and "Lady Lazarus" are both good illustrations.

"Daddy," probably the most famous of all Plath's poems, spearheads its attack mainly at her father and in passing, but no less intensely, at her husband, and obliquely at her mother to whom the poet reveals her consistent hostility in poems such as "Medusa" and "The Disquieting Muses." The poet, by bringing out the gamut of her pent-up feelings ?grief, rage and hate, and love ?toward the three most important people in her life in this highly charged work, hopes to clear all accounts with history and turn her life around.

As we noted earlier on, her father's death, for which she was not prepared, left her emotionally scarred for life. Because he left her suddenly and left a black hole of emptiness in her heart, he became the villain, the bastard. That hole did not diminish with her mother, unappreciative of her probably because of the mother's attention to her younger brother (in her opinion), and it became larger and darker with her father's surrogate ?her husband ?storming into her life and then abandoning her as she felt her father had done. The betrayal that all this represented so outraged her, and her sense of victimization was so excruciating, that her revenge became a dire necessity if she was to move on with her life at all. In a sense the writing of "Daddy" is like a clearance sale of daddy's things along with those related to him: everything must go, everything from physical to psychic reminders of her connection with her past. It is an attempt to forget and begin all over again.

Let's begin briefly with the title, "Daddy." There is more to it than meets the eye. The word, mainly a child's moniker for its father, carries a good deal of closeness and love with it. To entitle her work ?that has not much of a kind word to say about her father ?in this way is decidedly an act of mixed significance. And the mixed feelings begin to flow right with the first stanza. Now in the first stanza the poet compares her father's impact on her whole life to the black shoe for the foot. She complains that she has failed to live her life the way she should all because of him. The hate is obvious, but the love is equally strong: the shoe is protective as well as constraining. The next stanza sells her father's body: the tall, powerfully built, religious man who suffers diabetes mellitus, with his toe swollen and then a leg amputated (which is all biographically true). The memory brims over with love as she recalls the endearing scene of joyous play with her father at the beach and with her childish attempts to bring him back from the dead through prayers (stanza 3). When the hurt returns (stanzas 4 through 7), she remembers her ancestry and the anxiety she has felt because of it. Apparently she blames her father for bringing her into the world with a wrong identity. Her mother seems to appear in stanza 8 in which her native place ?Austria ?is mentioned, and her mask ?of an attractive facade hiding her indifference to her daughter's opinion ?is delineated. From that point onward, the poet imagines herself to be a Jew, which is a pure figment of her imagination, as her mother was not Jewish, just to intensify her sense of oppression. The image of the Jew continues when the father is made out as a Nazi in stanzas 9 and 10 (the biographical fact was that her father had nothing to do with Nazi Germany), symbolizing repressive forces of all kinds. This transference leads to the identification of her father with her husband. The transition begins with "Every woman adores a Fascist, / The boot in the face, the brute / Brute heart of a brute like you." Here Ted Hughes is brought to the defense's seat. Although "You stand at the blackboard" alludes to her father who taught in a university, the cleft in the chin is a clear reference to her husband, who is "the black man who / Bit my pretty red heart in two." Back to her father in stanzas 11 and 12, she relates her suicide attempts which indicate how indispensable the father had been to her life: as her father did not do enough to save himself from his diabetic death, it almost looked like a suicide; and Sylvia's suicide attempts have been

deciphered by some as efforts to emulate her father and rejoin him in death. Thus love breaks out of her lines here once more despite herself. But hate again gets the upper hand in "I made a model of you." Now revenge, blood for blood, overwhelms her being. She is saying, "I cut off all communication with possible remonstrance; I am bent on this manslaughter. I have finally killed the both of you who, like vampires, have sucked my life out of me by making it a black mess, and 'Daddy, you can lie back now' because this time you are really dead for me." "I'm through," repeated in the last stanza a couple of times, can mean a couple of things: either she is also dead, token of another suicide attempt, or she has done with her sale of him, cleared all accounts with him, and is now ready for a new ?her own ?life. Here the love element pops out again: there is a detectable love under-song in the poem after all. In biographical terms, both interpretations are good since directly after she finished the poem, she wrote to her mother in a jubilant tone that she was beginning a new chapter of her life, but the optimism failed to stay strong enough to prevent her from her last, successful suicide a few months later. It is interesting to notice that the poem begins and ends with her life as it is first and foremost about her life rather than anybody else's.

"Lady Lazarus" dramatizes her life in a more gruesome way. It is about her repeated attempts at suicide. "I have done it again. / One year in every ten / I manage it 糗.]" She has done it three times in her thirty years of life. There is indication of self-disgust and an almost morbid gloating over self-disposal. There is indication of suffocation and oppression (probably by the male gender). And there is indication of revenge, a kind of striking back, even in death. A struggle is going on at three different levels of gravity: Lady Lazarus with "Herr Doktor," the crowd of spectators, and her own desire for revenge and immortality. The overriding emotion is rage and hate, and the undercurrent of "Daddy"'s love is dimmed if not all gone. The name Lazarus indicates that she identifies herself possibly with three Lazaruses in Catholic history: the Lazarus in John 11.4, the one in Luke 16, and St. Lazarus the Confessor. In the first instance, Jesus saves Lazarus to display his own powers and win the faith of the crowd. This parallels the effort of "Herr Doktor" to save her and make her his "opus," "valuable," and "gold baby" so as to win admiration and confidence of the people around. The second instance is a parable about a rich man and Lazarus: the rich man refuses to offer help and goes down to eternal torment in hell while poor Lazarus goes up to heaven. As this poor Lazarus can be a leper ("Lazarus" as a first name can mean "leper"), one who loses his limbs if the disease is not cured, the connection between him and the poet-speaker here is apparent: in the poem, the lady loses all her body parts, which are strewn all around, foot, skin, teeth, bones, face, etc. She becomes an object of hypocritical sympathy. But she is not ready to let the crowd go at that. Now she is charging them for a fee and takes over the control of the situation. Shining as her own sun, she is beginning to taste success. A third possible link with the name Lazarus is St. Lazarus, the Confessor, a medieval Stylite monk who believed that self-discipline leads to a spiritually higher state. The lady of the poem believes that she is the one to come out victor eventually in the struggle: she'll win revenge and immortality ("Out of the ash / I rise with my red hair / And eat men like air"). The poem thus successfully dramatizes the intensity of human reaction at victimization.

It is good to note that as "Lady Lazarus" is a very rich work, it can be interpreted differently. For example, it can be read simply as the poet's self-contempt for her repeated failure at suicide and her fury at it. It expresses her rage with outside interference with her attempt. She is angry with people who know no better than mind their own business like the doctor (explicitly), with her family (implicitly) who took her to hospital, and with the crowd who happened to be around the

scene either because they did care or just out of some curiosity. The poem can also be seen as a rebirth fantasy, a dramatizing of the notion that the dead can be brought back to a new, higher, stronger level of existence where oppression will not exist, or oppressor and oppressed will change roles to the satisfaction of the latter. This is where a feminist reading of the work – and for that matter, of Plath as a whole – is possible. In addition, it has been suggested that the poem may represent the poet's struggle to perfect her art and achieve immortality for it. With death permeating most of her works, the poet's effort to achieve final and perfect death may be construed as a metaphor for her strenuous attempt to strive for excellence in her poetic art.

Anne Sexton (1928-1974) lived a rather colorful life. She eloped with her lover (later her husband), gave birth to two daughters, experienced mental disturbances, attempted suicide, stayed in a mental hospital and was advised to write as part of her treatment, published amazing volumes of poetry, received awards and honorary doctorates, taught at universities including Harvard, and was a full professor at the time of her suicide. All these reveal the depth and extent of her experience with life and people, which gave her plentiful opportunities to observe life at close quarters. The range of human relationships that she touches upon in her work includes men and women, parents and children, and gods and humans. She was at her best when dealing with the subtleties of human emotions, especially those of her own.

Anne Sexton was a forefront Confessional poet. She found her creative spring in her mental breakdowns and was further inspired during her stay at McClean's, MA. She came to poetry late. She did not write any until she was nearly thirty. Then a distinguished scholar-poet, I. A. Richards, talking about poetry on TV, proved inspiring to her, and her study under Robert Lowell (with Sylvia Plath) started her off on her career. From 1960 through her suicide in 1974, she published quite a few volumes of poetry and won some awards including a Pulitzer for her third book, *Live or Die* (1966). There is a direct connection between her emotionally disturbed life and her writing efforts. Her poetry demonstrates vividly her volcanic need to pour out so as to release her pent-up internal pressure. The effect is generally shocking. She felt that poetry should shock the senses and should almost hurt. She was painfully open about herself. "I tell so much truth in my poetry," she said on one occasion, "I am a fool if I say any more."

Her basic themes include such issues as madness, victimization, a sense of engulfing chaos, fascination with suicide and death, incest, adultery, illegitimacy, guilt, and addiction. Her first volume, *To Bedlam and Part Way Back* (1960), focuses on her mental problems, her stay in an institution, and her patching it up with her daughter and her husband. Her second book, *All My Pretty Ones* (1962), contains poems about her parents' death within three months of one another and her deliberations on death. Her prize-winning volume, *Live or Die*, her *Transformations* (1971), *The Death of Notebooks* (1974) and *The Awful Rowing toward God* (1975) are mostly about suicide and about whether she would be able to receive religious absolution. Her work represents the journey of life that she went through, an emotionally eventful one, one that she took, struggling for survival, but eventually failing to find salvation. Reading Anne Sexton, the readers often feel the same way as she did, her despair, her anger, her sense of exigency. The sense of immediacy, of getting involved, or participating, is just overwhelming. Indeed, the readers need to imagine themselves into the scenarios of her circumstances to fully appreciate the emotional intensity of a life forever poised on the verge of agonizing but alluring death. What makes Anne Sexton fascinating was her irresistible desire to write. She must write to get what she calls "the rat" out of her system. Thus her poetry is always emotionally loaded, and as such always possesses

a kind of contagious power. Anne Sexton committed suicide in 1974. She failed to handle her problems that might not be just her own but also those afflicting modern women in general. She was one of the most sensitive of them, the most hurt, and the most eloquent about their dilemma.

One of her famous poems, the one she liked so much that it has become her signature poem, is entitled "Her Kind." There are three stanzas here, each of which addresses one aspect of her personality. In the first stanza the "I" compares herself to a witch, possessed, secretive, malicious to her folks, lonely (because ostracized), gone mad. A witch is generally repressed by society and family and is always struggling to do right by herself. In the second stanza the "I" likens herself to a housewife who is both hardworking and caring, but who is a little eccentric and wishes to have things her own way (which is another way of saying looking for freedom or release). The third stanza portrays a Dickinsonian passenger riding along with Death in his cart, not arriving in hell yet though already feeling its ordeal and torture, and still trying to stay on this side of the grave. So there are repression, the desire for escape, and the toying with the idea of death. A common denominator to all three images is the repression, the self-assertion, and the will to life versus the death wish. All help fantasize the desire to escape an abominable existence, but none proves good enough to offer complete release. "Her Kind" presents a painful self-analysis and the thought of death as a way out. It dramatizes the thirst for freedom on the one hand, and on the other, the confused states of readiness and reluctance to die.

Some of Anne Sexton's poems can be read as possible footnotes to "Her Kind." "Housewife" and "Young" come easily to mind. The first one describes what the poet feels marriage is all about to most people. "Some women marry houses," where they do two things, cleaning house and being a sex and procreation instrument. "Young" relates the poet's experience one night when she was little and not a woman yet. She felt the difference between her parents as they behaved differently at night. The innocent, romantic-spirited child intuited her mother's desire and the father's callousness: "my mother's window a funnel / of yellow heat running out, / my father's window half shut, / an eye where sleepers pass..." Questions came to her mind: "and I .../ told the stars my questions / and thought God could really see / the heat and the painted light, / elbows, knees, dreams, goodnight." But God did not, and this could create emotional problems for women.

Her questions and the problems are discussed in greater depth in "The Farmer's Wife." This tells about the amount of internal pressure, not transitory but building up over an extended period of time, in a disaffected wife. The pressure is such that it is fast reaching explosive point. The dissatisfaction comes from the emotional emptiness and spiritual isolation of the wife's barren existence. For her husband marriage is all lust and lovemaking while the wife feels that "there / must be more to living / than this brief bright bridge / of the raucous bed [...]" There is no spiritual union; her mind is apart from his, "living her own self in her own words / and hating the sweat of the house/ they keep..." From this come feelings of disgust, self-pity, and the ill will that her husband would become a "cripple, or poet, / or even lonely, or sometimes, / better, my lover, dead." This amalgam of negativity, pent-up in her bosom, will turn out to be destructive in time to her own person if not involving others. Anne Sexton's view of life and marriage is reinforced by her revisionist fairytale, "Cinderella." Sexton does not believe in any success story ending with "they lived happily ever after." She sees life as full of pain and grief, and regards marriage as the beginning of human problems. The four rise-from-rags-to-riches stories at the beginning of the poem, all told in obvious irony, set the tone for the Cinderella story that follows. After all the

suffering she goes through, Sexton's Cinderella is married to the prince, but the tone in which the life of the royal couple is portrayed insinuates that the lucky girl is already embarking on a new stage of suffering.

The figure of death features prominently in the poem "Death Baby." This macabre song harps on the poet's fascination with death. She identifies herself with death all the way through. Images of death abound in this six-section poem. "I" was an ice baby that "my" sister dreamt of having been placed in the refrigerator or devoured at a dog's party. "I" had a doll that died twice. "I" died seven times in seven ways, "letting death give me a sign, / letting death place his mark on my forehead, / crossed over, crossed over." And "my mother" died of cancer. The poet fondles Death as if it were a cherub and loves it as she does "small children." But she is not ready to give up yet. "Max and I / ... / two burdeners, / made a pact. / To beat death down with a stick. / To take over," And in her deepest despair and at the bottom of her soul, she still wishes for absolution and salvation: her supplication sounds the most pathetic of all. "Oh Madonna, hold me. / I am a small handful."

This desire for absolution from God is more apparent in her "Rowing." The first part of the poem (II.1-27) is a sketchy retelling of the story of her life. She sees her birth as an event no one cared much about, just like a packet being mailed to her family. Her crib was a cold place to stay. Her toddler years left her with only some memory of her dolls as company. Then there was school that was all discipline and depersonalization, and offered nothing but a sense of helplessness. Then she was married, but experienced little love though it was all she craved. But she grew against odds and weathered through much difficulty and pain galling to her soul. All the time she kept growing but remained ignorant of God until now she reaches middle age. Feeling still young and aware of God as an island, she has begun rowing toward it. The journey is not easy: the oarlocks are not good, the sea is rough, the wind pushes her back, but she has kept on the good effort. She knows that the island may not be perfect, but she has his "rat" inside her that she must get rid of and present to God. She is sure that God will be kind to it and embrace it. The significance of the rat metaphor here is open to discussion. It may be, most probably, a desire for love so conspicuously absent from her life. It may be her yearning for freedom or a peace of mind or forgiveness. Or simply it may be a combination of all these. What matters is her faith in God as her final refuge.

Anne Sexton's contribution to Confessional poetry is great. Some even think of her along with Lowell as parents of the school. There is some truth in the notion although it overestimates her part a little. In time her poetry may transcend the restrictive boundaries of the label to assume a more universal plane of applicability to the human situation in general as indeed has happened to the works of Lowell and Plath. Her personal truth may be becoming an expression of the public truth, which ensures a place in history.

The Beat Generation

Howling like a prophet on the city sidewalk in a period that he saw as one of the fall of America, Allen Ginsberg made his voice heard as the poet laureate of the Beat Generation. In the 1950s there was a widespread discontentment among the postwar generation, whose voice was one of protest against all the mainstream culture that America had come to represent. This has come to be known as the Beat Generation. The word "beat," which Ginsberg and his friend Jack Kerouac picked up from a junkie friend of theirs, represented a non-conformist, rebellious attitude toward conventional values concerning sex, religion, the arts, and the American way of life. It was

an attitude that resulted from the feeling of depression and exhaustion and the need to escape into an unconventional, sometimes communal, mode of living. "Beat" literature offered something like a fresh breath of wind both in the prose and poetry of the 1950s and 1960s. On the prose side Jack Kerouac's *On the Road* and William Burroughs' *Naked Lunch* are the representative works. In poetry, Ginsberg's *Howl* and Lawrence Ferlinghetti's *Pictures from the Gone World* have been recognized as the most enduring of the works that Ferlinghetti's City Lights Bookshop published in San Francisco during the "San Francisco Poetry Renaissance" of the 1950s.

Ginsberg's first public reading of *Howl* in 1955 helped kick off an outburst of literary activity on the west coast and became an event of historic significance. It happened one October evening that year. Kenneth Rexroth (1905-1982) presided over it, and all the major figures of the Beat Generation were present. These included, in addition to Ginsberg and Snyder, now seen as the most important poets to come out of the Renaissance, Lawrence Ferlinghetti (1919-) and Philip Whalen (1923-), and Jack Kerouac. Six Beat poets read their poetry to an audience of over one hundred people. The best performance was Ginsberg's reading of the first section of his *Howl*. The poet read and sobbed; tears rolled down Rexroth's face; and the audience howled like mad. Kerouac called the evening "the night of San Francisco Poetry Renaissance." Soon poetry reading became popular in San Francisco, and poetry stormed into cafes, museums, and aquariums. Now known as the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance, this important literary movement has made itself felt and heard not only in the United States, but also internationally. Within the space of five years (1955-1960), poets such as Gary Snyder, Jack Spicer (1926-1965), William Everson (1912-1994), Gregory Corso (1930-), Philip Lamantia (1927-), Michael McClure, and Philip Whalen joined forces with Ginsberg, Kerouac, and Burroughs in their literary endeavors, and they traveled across the country, reading their poetry in bookstores, cafes, and public libraries, and finally managed to bring it to university classrooms. And with the help of publisher and poet Lawrence Ferlinghetti and with the success of their counterparts in the field of prose such as Kerouac and Burroughs, they broke the monopoly of academic verse and made their important contribution to contemporary literary history.

A few words are in order here about Rexroth and other minor figures in the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance before we move on to Allen Ginsberg and Gary Snyder. Rexroth was older and more mature than the other Beat writers. He was an iconoclast, perspicacious enough to see T. S. Eliot as a hindrance to the growth of postwar American poetry and calling on poets to break new ground. He was a learned person himself, knowing five languages and publishing eight volumes of poetry. His support for the Beat Generation proved to be an impetus to the development of the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance. Then there was Ferlinghetti whose was a prominent voice in the Beat poetry movement. As an editor, a publisher, and owner of the famous City Lights Books press in San Francisco, he made the publishing house a meeting place for the Beat writers. His publication of Ginsberg's *Howl* in 1956 made quite a stir on the literary and social scene of the country. He was arrested and tried on obscenity charges. He was acquitted, but the country was thrown into an uproar, which increased the popularity of the Beat movement as well as Ginsberg. Ferlinghetti is a poet, a novelist, a playwright, and a translator. He is known for his political poetry, seeing politics as "an enemy of the State," and happy as a dissenter within the system. He received the Commonwealth Club of California Silver Medal for poetry (1986) and the City of Rome poetry prize (1993). A street in San Francisco was named after him in 1994. Other figures that merit attention include Philip Whalen who has embraced Zen Buddhism and become a

monk, and has published over twenty volumes of verse and two novels; William Everson, a pious Catholic, who wrote and published many books of poetry in his life; and Philip Lamantia who is in the main a surrealist poet, writes often under drug influence, and has published over eight volumes of poetry. The Beat poets as a group ceased to function as a movement in the 1960s. Now looking back, it should be noted that, without their ventures, postwar American literature would not have been the same.

Although the Beat movement was and has been seen as one that threatened to discredit all the established values of the Eisenhower-Nixon period, Ginsberg had his own opinion of the effort of his associates. In a 1982 speech on Jack Kerouac, he said that the literary, spiritual or emotional aspect of the movement was not so much protest at all but a declaration of unconditioned mind beyond protest, beyond resentment, and beyond winner or loser. He said that it was a declaration of unconditioned mind, a visionary declaration, one of unworldly love that has no hope of the world and cannot change the world to its desire; he said that unworldly love means the basic nature of human minds, totally open, totally one with the space around, with life and death. So he said that, naturally, having that much insight, there would be obvious smart remarks that might change society, as a side issue, but the basic theme was beyond the rights and wrongs of political protest. His rhetoric sounds confusing, like a disclaimer of a kind that does not sound convincing when matched with the effect of their works on contemporary poetry. In the final analysis, the Beat Generation and the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance will have to be evaluated in historical perspective rather than from one of its authors, however significant he may have been. For our discussion here, one thing comes across all right, that the people involved were serious; they had a vision; they did what they did out of love, unworldly or otherwise, protest or otherwise. And, from a historical point of view, they achieved the kind of success they desired in literary, spiritual, and political terms.

Allen Ginsberg (1926-1997)

Allen Ginsberg was a rebel, a trailblazer, and an explorer of the unknown. For him, life was an open fair that offers goods that everyone can take according to his taste. He was born in Newark, New Jersey. Both of his parents exerted their share of influence on his literary career. His father, a Paterson, New Jersey middle-class teacher, a poet but never recognized for his timid, conformist lyric poetry, offered a model for the son to react against; and his mother, a radical in social ideas and insane most of the time, may have well contributed to the son's visionary flights with his theme of social protest. Ginsberg went to Columbia University and met the people there who were to represent with him the Beat generation. These included Lucien Carr, William Burroughs, and Jack Kerouac, and formed the nucleus of the Beat Generation. These people, well read, well educated, and of respectable, well-off parentage, were rebellious in temperament, and enjoyed contradicting or revolting against established values of life being lived then. They had long nights of intense conversations about the status of the arts, about social life, about their souls, etc., and thought they had achieved a very good understanding of their own soul. They came to the conclusion that they had to have a new vision, a new way of perceiving the world that would give it some meaning, that they had to find values that were valid to their generation, and that all this was supposed to be done through literature. In their new vision they saw art as merely and ultimately self-expressive, and felt, to quote Ginsberg, that "the fullest art, the most individual, uninfluenced, unrepressed, uninhibited expression of art, is true expression and the true art."

Kerouac and Burroughs introduced him to the world of drugs and its ways of transcending normal human consciousness. Kerouac also nudged him to action when he finished his *On the Road* in three weeks of "spontaneous outpouring." When he was suspended from Columbia for writing graffiti on classroom windows, Ginsberg had a good solid street education. He worked at various jobs, and knocked about for quite some time: he washed dishes, became a sailor, was arrested for sheltering a drug dealer, and went to a mental institution to avoid jail. This street education proved more generic to his career. He met William Carlos Williams and embraced his literary doctrine of representing contemporary life in daily speech. By the beginning of the 1950s, he had basically completed his education for a poetic career with a clear vision of his literary future: he would write a kind of poetry of anti-mainstream in a natural, spontaneous diction. He was now poised for an ambitious endeavor.

Ginsberg had by now had a cozy coterie around him whom he saw as the cream of the intellect of his generation. In addition to the original four, there was also the second category and the third circle including, among others, Neal Cassady, Gregory Corso, and Robert LaVigne. A significant addition to this circle was Carl Solomon, a friend he met at the Columbia Presbyterian Psychiatric Institute where the man had voluntarily committed himself after his arrest in the company of his underworld companions (it is good to note that Solomon later became the publisher of William Burroughs' famous or notorious *The Naked Lunch*). These people became, to Ginsberg, "the best minds" of his "the Beat" generation.

The genesis of his famous work, *Howl*, is archetypal of Ginsberg's life as a whole. He did not plan to write a poem, less to say a famous one. He was thinking of his friends and typing away at his second-hand typewriter one day in a shabby apartment room in New York, apparently having nothing better to do. With no preconceptions whatsoever, he began each sentence with the anaphoric "who," and suddenly he found words and ideas pouring out of his mind. He found himself describing glibly his encounters with his friends and his opinions and impressions of these people. He found himself reliving through paraphrasing incidents from his own life. Lines and sentences, long piled up and stored away at the back of his mind, the result of "ten years' animal screams and suicides," seemed now to have found an outlet, and kept flooding out until he got well over seven pages. Now the exuberance gave way to a cooler seriousness, and planning began. He found that each of the sentences beginning with a "who" talks about one of his group (including himself), and all the ideas, opinions, and impressions always relate back to the person, Solomon. It was then that he decided that he had been obsessed with Solomon and all that Solomon represented and that it would be good to wrap up the whole endeavor with a section solely devoted to Solomon. And so he did.

Thus *Howl* is a personal becoming prophetic and general poem. It is personal because it quotes freely from the poet's own experiences with life and people and ideas. A careful study of Ginsberg's life would help identify the lines in the poem relating to the incidents of his own or his friends' lives. For example, "The best minds of my generation" (in "I saw the best minds of my generation destroyed by madness, starving hysterical naked, / dragging themselves through the negro streets at dawn looking for an angry fix...") refers on the personal level to his coterie of friends who met in Columbia University or the bars or shabby apartments of New York and discussed and shared the ideas that became a kind of intellectual declaration of the Beat Generation. Most of these people were literally institutionalized at one time or another: hence all "destroyed by madness" (except Kerouac and Burroughs to whom *Howl* makes only an oblique

reference). As to the prophetic nature of the howl and its general applicability, a close look at the poem will reveal these readily for us. Now Howl consists of three sections. Section one, the longest, is a portrait of the poet and the Beat Generation going through a nightmarish experience, section two a digging into the root cause of their plight and their nightmarish experience, and the last section is at once an elegy about the possible defeat at the hands of fate and an effort to brace for the future. So the title Howl ties in with the theme of the poem beautifully well. The loud cry comes from agony, despair, terror in face of death and annihilation, and also as an assertion of faith in one's destiny.

Now section one envisions Ginsberg and his friends going through hell, depraved, decadent, and in despair, anathematizing their lot every step of the way in a language intended to jostle the general public out of their silly smug complacency. They suddenly realize that the eccentricities and unconventionalities of the Beat Generation such as drug addiction, sexual promiscuity as occurred in communal living, and homosexuality can only be the natural result of a dreadful experience, and that the howl, so desperate and uncanny, can only be a voice of misery and pain. We may note here that the same tone is echoed in another notable Ginsberg poem entitled "America," which opens with the poet's fully-loaded complaint that he has given all to America but now he is nothing, conveying effectively the feeling of the postwar generation, especially its intellectual, thinking minds, that they had been badly cheated and ruined. The theme is pervasive in a number of Ginsberg poems.

Now let's take a closer scrutiny of section one first. It adumbrates and immortalizes the Beat Generation with all that it is noted for: its anti-mainstream way of living, its vision and its power, its ambition and sense of mission, and the depth of their despair in face of the threat of failure. Section one is a well-cooked broth of all these. First, their lifestyle is anti-mainstream. It may have to do with their poverty ("starving," "poverty and tatters and hollowed," "hungry and lonesome," "[walking] all night with their shoes full of blood on the snowbank docks"), and they are unhappy and angry. They do drugs and get arrested on drug abuse ("[getting] busted...with a belt of marijuana," "[eating] fire...or [drinking] turpentine," "[P]eyote solidities of halls," "...endless ride...on benzedrine," etc.). They live dissipated and depraved and promiscuous ("alcohol and cock and endless balls," "[balling]... scattering their semen freely," "[copulating] ecstatic and insatiate," "[going] out whoring through Colorado in myriad stolen night-cars," etc.). They "[publish] obscene odes on the windows" of college classrooms and get expelled. They are angry and in despair. They wander through places in the States and outside it, such as Tangiers, Mexico, and the Caribbean, restless, suffering, violating accepted standards, but questing for what they do not quite yet know.

They are a visionary group of young men. They sit in supernatural darkness, baring their brains to Heaven and seeing Mohammedan angels, hallucinating, dreaming, with cloud and lighting in the mind illuminating the world of time, studying telepathy and bop Kaballa, seeking visionary Indian angels, yaketyakking, screaming, mad in supernatural ecstasy, conversing about America and Eternity, creating the lava and ash of poetry, wishing to establish connection with Absolute Reality, driving seventy two hours to look for a vision, and praying for the soul "illuminating its hair for a second."

And they are ambitious with a huge sense of mission for history. What they dream of accomplishing is nothing short of making history. With "a sudden flash of the alchemy of the use" of their experiences, they dream to make a kind of poetry that posterity will remember. "[T]he

madman bum and angel beat in Time, unknown, yet putting down here what might be left to say in time after death, / ... / with the absolute heart of the poem of life butchered out of their own bodies good to eat a thousand years." This in actual life they did, but not before they had their share of despair.

Section one is also testimony to the depth of despair they suffer. Sensitive in intellectual texture, they become frustrated in face of difficulty and get easily hurt as a result. There are a number of things they worry about. For instance, they fear that their dreams of achievement and fame may not happen and that their best bet may only "be crowned with laurel in oblivion." They make their last, desperate attempt but feel no consolation: the last book flung out, the last door closed, the last telephone slammed at the wall in reply, possibly to a publisher's rejection, "the last furnished room / emptied down to the last piece of mental furniture, a yellow paper rose twisted on a wire hanger in the closet, and even that imaginary nothing but a hopeful little bit of hallucination" ?and they find themselves bogged down "in the total animal soup of time" of which, butchered and boiled, they become proper ingredients. They feel doomed in face of the three goddesses of fate, one of whom, probably referring to censorship, "does nothing but sit on her ass and snip the intellectual golden threads of the craftsman's loom."

The feeling of doom becomes more intense in section two of the poem when they try to trace their trouble back to its root cause, the Moloch of American civilization. This section concentrates its attack on the mechanical civilization of America. Ginsberg's name for it is Moloch, the biblical heathen god of fire to which children were sacrificed. To the god of Modern America not children but the best minds of the nation are sacrificed. It is Moloch who breeds solitude, filth, suffering and ruthlessly washes visions, dreams, miracles, illuminations, ecstasies, in a word, "the whole boatload of sensitive bullshit," down the American river. And of course, hope with it all. Hence "Mad generation" "down the rocks of Time!" Thus the whole of the second section reinforces the theme of the first and adds touches of tragic pathos to a portrait of the consciousness of a nation definitely gone mad:

Real holy laughter in the river! They saw it all!
the wild eyes! the holy yell! They bade
farewell! They jumped off the roof! to solitude!
waving! Carrying flowers! Down to
the river! into the street!

Despair reaches its breaking point when they scream like mad: "Visions! omens! hallucinations! miracles! ecstasies! gone down the American river! / Dreams! adorations! illuminations! religions! the whole boatload of sensitive bullshit! / Breakthroughs! over the river! flips and crucifixions! gone down the flood! Highs! Epiphanies! Despairs! Ten years' animal screams and suicides! Minds! New loves! Mad generation! down the rocks of Time!" The one that brings about all this tragedy and annihilates the human mind, Moloch, represents all that is evil: greed, poverty and violence, repression, senseless governments, technological and materialistic progress with its pure machinery and factories and oils and electricity and banks, loveless, soulless, inhuman and dehumanizing. Omnipotent and omnipresent, Moloch is embodied in all forms of existence: "Robot apartments! invisible suburbs! skeleton treasures! blind capitals! demonic industries! special nations! invisible madhouses! granite cocks! monstrous bombs!" It is this "sphinx of cement and aluminum" that bashes open skulls and eats up brains and imagination. And it is impossible to get rid of it. Hence the despair.

The third section is dedicated to his friend, Carl Solomon, who is apparently madder than he is. Of the poem and Carl Solomon, William Carlos Williams once wrote: "Literally Ginsberg has, from all the evidence, been through hell. On the way he met a man named Carl Solomon with whom he shared among the teeth and excrement of this life something that cannot be described but in the words he has used to describe it." Section three immortalizes Carl Solomon as a symbol of victimization. It is an elegy of sorts, pathetic in ethos, but it is much more than that. The repetitive "I'm with you in Rockland!" identifies the poet with all the inmates of the Rockland mental hospital and asserts an indomitable sense of solidarity in face of repeated oppression. Carl Solomon is a man of imagination (a writer) to whom the life of the mind is everything. He loves his country which, however, feels uneasy about it. He ends up in the Rockland State Hospital at Orangeburg, New York, with his "innocent and immortal" soul probably to "die ungodly in this armed madhouse": He is made to undergo ruthless therapies. The faculties of his mind are being numbed; his soul, innocent and immortal, is dying as "... fifty more shocks will never return your soul to its body again from its pilgrimage to a cross in the void." He is going on this pilgrimage, and will meet, sadly, with the poet in the Western night of death. But they ?Solomon, Ginsberg, and their generation ?are not done yet. Their Messianic mission is yet to be fulfilled: "you will split the heavens of Long Island and resurrect your living human Jesus from the superhuman tomb" which is Molochan America. Here their faith in the justice of their fight and its immortality in history exhibits itself as religious and invincible. In retrospect it was with this drive for attaining the utmost freedom of the mind that Ginsberg and his Beat Generation managed to make a scratch on the rock of eternity.

In formal terms Ginsberg has borrowed freely from the cataloging form of Whitman's prose poetry and from William Carlos Williams in tone and rhythm. Ginsberg's poetry is a little expansive and sprawling, but its sheer power comes through and conquers. His influence grew quickly in the 1950s and 1960s. On first reading *Howl*, readers tend to have the feeling that it is a bundle of obscenities. Obscene ideas expressed in obscene words including the four-letter word assail their genteel sensitivity so that they feel awkward in face of such linguistic vulgarities. No wonder, as we mentioned earlier on, that, as soon as it came out in 1956, *Howl* incurred the wrath and condemnation of the dominant WASP opinion, and went through a trial. But this proved to be more than a blessing in disguise, for it rallied to the poet's support an important portion of the academic and critical community (including quite a few writers) which would have otherwise possibly been indifferent, and it helped to pique the curiosity of the reading public as well. The trial increased the sales. *Howl* went through over thirty imprints within a short span of time and became the best-selling volume of poetry since the end of the war. Since then it has become clear that *Howl* is a consummate work of carefully worded invectives, a torrent of deliberate voluble curses, spearheaded against an America that has destroyed "the best minds" of the postwar generation. *Howl* is now regarded as the most significant long poem of the contemporary period, ranking, among others, with Whitman's "Song of Myself" and T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*.

Ginsberg has won an international reputation. Beginning with *Howl* and the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance, his literary career stretched well over four decades. His life went through colorful stages, one of which was his conversion to Buddhism. His ideas evolved into a system of its own that exerted its due share of influence on postwar thinking. He wrote and published more: his other collections include *Kaddish and Other Poems* (1960), *Empty Mirror* (1960), *Reality Sandwiches* (1963), *The Change* (1963), *Planet News* (1969), *The Fall of America* (1973), *Mind*

Breaths: Poems 1972-1977 (1978), Collected Poems 1947-1980 (1984), White Shroud, Poems 1980-1985 (1986), and some others. Although few of his later writings touched Howl in emotional intensity and technical virtuosity, he has received and is still receiving abundant attention as a major figure on the contemporary literary landscape. **He will be remembered, first and foremost, as the spokesman of the postwar Beat Generation in American literary history.**

Gary Snyder (1930-)

Gary Snyder was connected with the "Beats" in the mid 1950s and early 1960s. He has been placed next to Ginsberg in reputation among this group. He met with the major figures of the San Francisco Poetry Renaissance, Kenneth Rexroth, Jack Kerouac, and Allen Ginsberg, participated in the poetry readings that kicked off the west coast renaissance, and traveled with Ginsberg to India. Kerouac offered a portrait of him in his novel, *The Dharma Bums*. Snyder was in spiritual consonance with the Beats. Growing up in Oregon, he had an Emersonian love for nature. He imbibed the American West wildness and primitive myths such as those of the American Indians so that these were woven into the very fabric of his system. He loves nature and sees it as restorative and healing. He has always tried to stay in direct contact with nature. He studied Zen Buddhism in Japan and lived for long in the foothills of the Sierra Mountain in California. He studied Chinese, read translations of Chinese literature, and translated the poems of the Chinese Zen poet, Han Shan. In addition, he took interest in Chinese and Indian philosophy. He did physical work like a timber scaler, a forest fire lookout, a logger, and a hand in a ship's engine-room. He is said to live now by growing vegetables and hunting in addition to teaching at a university. All these have impacted his poetry. "My poems follow the rhythms of my physical work I'm doing and the life I'm leading at any given time." He finds nature and the ancient traditions ?especially those of the American Indians ?a counterpoint to contemporary culture and its dominant values which his works tend to criticize. He tries to hold history and wildness in his mind so that his poetry "may approach the true measure of things and stand against the unbalance and ignorance of our time." Some critics see some trace of anti-civilization in him.

For Snyder the wildness is always a tonic to man. He feels that we humans need to sink back in nature to brace up for life even if it is for a stay as brief as one night. We leave the city, hiking up the mountains, going up a mile in the air, lost in meadows, snowfields, and mountain peaks, lying in sleeping bags, talking with no worry or care half the night, and listening to the wind and rain, and then we will get reenergized enough to face life anew. This is what Snyder tries to say in his "August on Sourdough, A Visit from Dick Brewer." Dick comes from San Francisco and is going to New York: his life begins from a city and ends in another, but it is made tolerable and good, Snyder suggests, by his visit to mother nature. Though different in more ways than one, the poem is a reminder of Frost's "Birches" or "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening." Then we notice that, when Dick has left, the poet goes back to his mountain, "and far, far, west." The reason for this action is explained in his "Mid-August at Sourdough Mountain Lookout." He loves nature. He is close to it. Everything there fascinates him: a smoke haze in a valley, the heat, the rain, the glowing fir-cones, the rocks and meadows, and the swarms of fireflies. He sees them, hears them, and feels them. With them he is carefree: he forgets the things he reads and the friends in the cities. There in nature his imagination runs free and he becomes whole as he drinks "cold snow-water from a tin cup" and looks down "for miles / through high still air." He is a Thoreau in his own day.

The "still[ness]" is central to Snyder's poetic concern. He seeks to locate a point of stillness

amid the constant change of the universe. This stillness is important because it offers a moment, a break, a breathing space for modern man and makes it easier for him to cope. What happens in the duration of this moment we can surmise from his poems: it is a moment of freedom and relief when the mind ceases to remember, the body loses its individuality and merges into nature, and the local reveals the universal. It is Emerson, Frost, Williams, and Zen Buddhism all in one. This is a moment of epiphany, one of ecstasy, when the poet "looks down for miles through high still air" to witness the sublime, the essence of the universe. Such a moment of stillness occurs in his poem, "Straight-Creek ?Great Burn." There is change everywhere in the world around. The dry grass is freed of snow. The chickadees are pecking seeds. The avalanche and the water under it "spills out / rock lip pool," bending over, foaming, and returning to the deep-dark hole. Change comes over the creek boulders, the spring, the snow, the "grand dead burn pine," the lichen, the talus rock. "Far light on the Bitterroots; / scrabble down willow slide / changing clouds above / shapes on glowing sun-ball / writhing, choosing / reaching out against eternal azure." What appears before us so far is the inanimate part of the world (?1-34). Skipping lines 35-36 (which we'll discuss shortly), we notice the movement of the other part of the universe, the animate, "the feather garments" of Heaven, as represented by the birds swooping up and round, tilting back, flying apart while hanging on together, "never a leader, / all of one swift / empty / dancingmind." The birds arc and loop and then settle down (?37-52). Sandwiched in between the inanimate and the animate, there is the human who, like the birds, achieve a point of stillness after hiking: "us resting on dry fern and / watching" (?35-36). This is when meditation begins, when the body becomes transparent and the mind is open to the eternal and the universal. The poetic reaches its zenith here: hence the last line, "end of the poem."

Snyder seems to think that the job of the poet is to catch sight of the poetic, and the poetic resides nowhere but in the natural world. Now what is the poetic to Snyder, and what is the eternal and the universal that he thinks we have got to learn about? One clue is offered when Snyder said on one occasion that his work has been "driven by the insight that all is connected and interdependent ?nature, societies; rocks and stars." One early trace of the notion is already visible in his poem, "Riprap." This is a typical Snyder poem in its natural fusion of the physical with the metaphysical, of the real world with that of the imagination. The poem demonstrates at once a fine intermingling of the two planes of things and a clear distinction between them. A riprap is, Snyder notes, "[a] cobble of stone laid on steep slick rock to make a trail for horses in the mountains." But the poet sees more than a mere mountain trail here. The cobbles become words. The trail becomes matter for thought. Made of the things of the actual world ("Solidity of bark, leaf, or wall"), it looks like the Milky Way; the people and the lost ponies appear to fit in the grand scheme like straying planets; and all these are "poems" to the observing poet. What is seen is not just the three-dimensional world of ours; there is the extra dimension, the fourth, the mythical, the extra-sensual, the unknown. The mystery is deepened when we face not one world but "worlds" that are endless and perpetually changing: "ants and pebbles / In the thin loam, each rock a word / a creek-washed stone / Granite: ingrained / with torment of fire and weight / Crystal and sediment linked hot / all change, in thoughts, / As well as things." There is the eclectic Snyder well on display here. Each rock like a word ?this sounds like Thoreau in one sense and Pound in another. There is poetry in life and nature ?this is Williams. The world exists for meditation (?1-6) and all change ?Snyder's Zen Buddhism is speaking. The juxtaposition of images, their incremental effect, the meticulous attention to detail, the absence of connectives, the colloquial diction ?all these and

more form an exquisite chaos of various traditions contemporary as well as ancient and foreign.

It is necessary to say a few words about Snyder's poems that portray the erotic experience, one primal activity of human life. The tone in these works is always celebratory. "It Was When," one of these, offers an exciting account of the copulating experiences of the poet-speaker with his sexual partner, presumably his wife. The diction and tone are both spicy enough to recap the pitch of exhilaration that the poet-speaker felt: "bent cool / breasts brush my chest [...] ...us naked / brown nipples.../ cloud / rain" (the last two words are probably a literal translation of a classic Chinese term meaning "ejaculation" or more broadly "making love"), "... I swung you / around and came into you / careless and joyous," or "saltwater caked / skin swing / hips on my eyes / burn between." The net result of all this love-making is the conception of a new life in the womb of the mother: "That we caught: sprout / took grip in your womb and it held, / new power in your breath called its place." This unabashed frankness about sex and love, about this Adamic human act, occasionally reminiscent of D. H. Lawrence, is characteristic of Snyder's rhetoric concerning the subject. Read, among his other works, his "Beneath My Hand and Eye the Distant Hills. Your Body" or "Song of the Taste" for example, and the point will be hammered home. Also revealed adequately here is his deep love for the new life, a theme which runs through quite a few of his poems such as "The Egg."

Snyder may be didactic; he may have a political vision that is good. But he will not be mainly remembered for these. He will make an imprint on history if he persists in his belief in nature as the stay against confusion (to quote Frost) and writes accordingly. The few lines from his "For the Boy Who Was Dodger Point Lookout Fifteen Years Ago" are already worth memorizing:

In this burning, muddy, lying,
blood-drenched world
that quiet meeting in the mountains
cool and gentle as the muzzles of
three elk, helps keep me sane.
Merwin, Bly, and Wright

Sharing Snyder's stance on civilization and nature but different from him in varying aspects are a few poets whose works have revealed some quality in common. These include W. S. Merwin (1927-), Robert Bly (1926-), and James Wright (1927-1980). They do not seem to like the sight of the manifestations of "civilization" such as roads, wires, and the cityscape. They are worried about environmental pollution like global warming, oil spills, and the use of pesticides which threatens the survival of the humankind and the species in general. They feel the terror of war. Somehow they find value in the primitive, in nature and wildness, and believe that the humankind would be better off if they could live the way Snyder does, or like Robert Bly (who once stayed in the farm country of Minnesota). To them nature and civilization form an inevitable antithesis, and we humans stand at the point where two roads branch out into the future. Critic David Perkins lump these poets together with the label of "Against Civilization."

W. S. Merwin was born in New York, son of a clergyman. He studied medieval literature and romance languages, and stayed long in Europe ?France, Spain, and Portugal. The theme of his poetry is generally concerned with the dilemmas of humankind and the wholesome effect of the natural world. He wrote about Vietnam war (read his "The Asians Dying"), the death of the whales (read "For a Coming Extinction"), the ecological pollution ("The Last One"), and the direction America takes, its poisoning of the earth and its hi-tech triumphs emerging as symbols of death.

There is a pessimistic strain of thought in Merwin. Even when he writes about erotic love and he has written quite a few of these, there is little or no warmth or emotional release. The lovers in his "Summer Doorway," for instance, look like static figures from a painting. Merwin often appears to be moody, despairing, and angry. He writes his feelings into his poetry as he believes that the future is so bleak that there is no point in writing. Take "For a Coming Extinction" for example. The first stanza tells of the coming extinction of the gray whale, and accuses humankind of inventing forgiveness but forgiving nothing. The second stanza continues the angry accusation against humans lording it over all other species ruthlessly simply because they were created on a different day and were given the dominion over others. The poet sees the death of the future for the humans along with the extinction of their fellow species: "The bewilderment will diminish like an echo / Winding along your inner mountains / Unheard by us / and find its way out / Leaving behind it the future / Dead / And ours [.]". The last stanza of the poem, after surveying "the black garden" where all extinct and endangered species gather, ends on a bitter sarcastic attack on the self-importance of man.

But everything is not lost yet. Nature and solitude may offer "a pale resurrection" to man. "The Drunk in the Furnace" illustrates the point well. There is this deserted furnace in this gully, which looks like "a hulking black fossil" people do not seem to know about any more. Then one day someone comes along, makes a fire, and homesteads there. He enjoys working there, and loves the music and rhythm that comes from "[h]ammer-and-anvilling with poker and bottle / To his jugged bellowings." When he is done for the day, he "[sleeps] like an iron pig." He is carefree and happy. The people around do not like this trespasser of their territory and their lives for that matter, but the children, still innocent in their ways, seem to be learning something:

In their tar-paper church
On a text about stoke-holes that are sated never
Their Reverend lingers. They nod and hate trespassers.
When the furnace wakes, though, all afternoon
Their witless offspring flock like piped rats to its siren
Crescendo, and agape on the crumbling ridge
Stand in a row and learn.

"The Drunk" in the title of the poem, seen as a drunk by the community nearby, may not be a drunk after all. He is probably the most awake, the most lucid of them all. He stays away from the maddening crowds and takes up his abode in deserted nature. Here man can have a peace of mind and sleep like a pig. The gully with the furnace looks like a fallen Garden of Eden, but wholesome nature can help resurrect the lost hope. It is significant that the children are intrigued and are learning. The poet sees hope in it.

Merwin's style has undergone some changes over the years, but there is always his emphasis on myths and emblems which he sees in the occurrences of daily lives. And there is always conscious artistry.

Robert Bly (1926-) grew up on a farm in Madison, Minnesota. He was enlisted in the navy during the war and returned to complete his B. A. at Harvard. Then he spent three years in solitude, mostly in New York City, and stated later that a poet needs to experience loneliness and "inwardness." After attending the Writers' Workshop at the University of Iowa in 1955, he went on a Fulbright scholarship to Norway where he met famous European and South American authors like the German poet Goerg Trakl and the Chilean poet Pablo Neruda. Back to the U. S., he settled

on a farm his father bought for him and started a literary magazine, first entitled *The Fifties*, but with time changed it to *The Sixties*, *The Seventies*, and *The Eighties*. Along with other postmodern poets of his time, Bly stood against the kind of academic verse which Eliot and Ransom championed, and supported surrealist poetry. One of the things Bly did with his magazine was to use it for his translations of such poets as Trakl and Neruda, hitherto little known in the U. S., and for helping struggling young writers out. His first volume of verse, *Silence in the Snowy Fields*, came out in 1962, in which appeared some of his best "Snowy Fields" poetry. Pastoral life, the beauty of natural scenery, and the stillness and solitude, free of the intrusion of noise and crowds, are extolled as conducive to the life of the mind. Now in retrospect, decades have passed and Bly has been prolific with some twenty volumes of poetry to his credit, but his early "Snowy Fields" poems remain still fresh in the readers' minds as probably his most permanent work. In the 1960s, Bly was deeply involved in the anti-Vietnam War movement, helping found the society of "American Writers against the Vietnam War," donating the cash prize of the National Book Award (for his 1967 *The Light around the Body* volume) to the war resistance, and took an active part in the antiwar demonstrations. Around this time he wrote and read a lot of his political poetry. When this phase of his life was over, he turned to meditation, seeking light and "interior space" from the unconscious, the primitive, and Oriental wisdom.

Regarding Bly's poetics, in addition to his views on surrealism, he feels that the poet must free himself from his rational ego and release the deeper, the less conscious levels of the mind, and that modern poetry should grasp the flowing psychic energy. His notion on imagery is known as the "deep image." To Ezra Pound the image was "petals on a wet black bough," Bly said on one occasion, but to him, it was "death on the wet deep roads of the guitar." This is associated with his stance on the deeper, unconscious aspect of the poetic mind. This "deep image" idea of his influenced quite a few contemporary writers like Robert Creeley, Gary Snyder, and James Wright. Bly's poetry is generally moody. There is exhibited an amount of obsession with death in some works. His 1979 volume, *This Tree Will be Here for a Thousand Years*, along with his "Snowy Fields" poetry, contains some of his best memorable poems.

A few things about the life of James Wright (1927-1980) are necessary to know to appreciate his poetry. First, he was born and grew up on a farm in Martins Ferry, Ohio and experienced poverty and its emotional impact in the years of the Depression that was his childhood. This was to exert a visible influence on the themes of his work. Mostly he wrote in his poetry about the Midwest, the America he knew at first hand, the poverty of the river towns along the Ohio, the suffering, both physical and emotional, of the underdog, the low, the "social outsiders." His sympathies were always with the common run of mankind. He was sensitive to the seamy side of life and felt keenly about the sad aspects of the world of man where there is so much of loneliness, pain, weariness, and death. Hence the depressed mood of his poems. Then there are the formal features of his work to consider. Wright experienced some drastic stylistic change in his career, and this had to do with his college education. He began writing poems in traditional forms, such as the sonnets, the iambic pentameter, and regular rhymes. Read his first two volumes, *The Green Wall* (1957) and *Saint Judas* (1959), and we will see the influence of Robert Frost and Edwin Arlington Robinson, and also that of John Crowe Ransom and Theodore Roethke to which he was drawn when he attended the Kenyon College and the University of Washington in Seattle. After his second book Wright felt a moment of crisis when he could not go on writing well in the traditional way. Trakl's poetry of semi-surreal leaping images and Wright's

timely acquaintance and friendship with Robert Bly conspired to make the change possible. Wright visited Bly's farm, fell under the influence of the "deep image" or "emotive imagination," abandoned his previous methods of writing, and wrote a new poetry of leaping images and free verse of American colloquial speech. His third volume, *The Branch Will Not Break* (1963), contains remarkable lyrics that would align him in theme as well as in form with his Postmodernist contemporaries. "Lying in a Hammock at William Duffy's Farm in Pine Island, Minnesota" is one of his famous poems. Lying in a hammock on a farm one evening, the poet sees a number of things around in nature and experiences an emotional awakening of a kind. Here he sees the butterfly asleep on the black trunk, blowing like a leaf in green shadow; he sees the cowbells following one another into the distances of the afternoon down the ravine behind the empty house; he sees the droppings of last year's horses blazing up into golden stones in a field of sunlight between two pines to his right; and he sees a chicken hawk floating over, looking for home. The poet leans back as dusk falls. The mixture of feelings that these sights and sounds of nature combine to arouse in him result in a moment of ecstasy: he makes the painful self-discovery when he concludes by suggesting that he has somehow wasted his life. In other words he felt that he should have come earlier to the farm and should have lived in nature longer. Wright's other volumes include *Collected Poems* (1972) which won him a number of awards including the Pulitzer Prize, *To a Blossoming Pear Tree* (1977), *This Journey* (1982), and *Above the River: The Collected Poems* (1990).

CHAPTER 22 The New York School Meditative Poetry The Black Mountain Poets

The so-called New York School became well known with the publication of Donald Allen's 1960 anthology. The school then included Frank O'Hara, Kenneth Koch (1925-), John Ashbery, and James Schuyler (1923-). One of the things they all did, for a while in the 1960s, was their experiment with Surrealism. The surrealist works of Kenneth Koch, the collage of Ashbery's *The Tennis Court Oath*, and the surrealist verses of O'Hara ?all these conspired to make the impression that the New York School was a group of collagists, Dadaists, and surrealists and was not to be taken seriously. This is a misunderstanding of the school that still persists today. There is no doubt that these young poets were eager to experiment; their contact with avant-garde artists in New York City offered food for thought and added to their enthusiasm to break new ground. But their experiment with Surrealism lasted for a while only, and all dropped it to move on to their major phases of writing which have produced quite a good number of impressive poems. They were so immersed in their creative endeavors that they did not pay much attention to the political and social issues of the time as did their contemporaries such as Lowell and Ginsberg. They did not feel the religious impulse like Snyder or the fascination with myths like Olson. They had their own artistic concerns. The poets of the New York School were different in their separate pursuits, but their poetry reveals something they shared in common. For one thing, they were all vehemently up against the dominant New Critical values such as the impersonal presentation of images, and tried to assert their individual poetic voice. They also introduced the popular and the low features of life into their writings like popular songs, comic strip figures, and Hollywood movies. Thirdly, they exhibited a huge sense of humor, offering room as their poems did for elements like the vulgar and the sentimental. Finally, they experimented with Surrealism, for a while.

Frank O'Hara (1926-1966)

The central figure of this school was Frank O'Hara (1926-1966) who was born in Maryland and grew up in Massachusetts. During the war he served in the navy for two years. Then he attended Harvard and did some graduate work at the University of Michigan. O'Hara worked mostly in New York City, a center of innovative ferment in the arts, and he was very sensitive to what went on around him such as abstract expressionism. Apart from his personal friendships with the poets of the New York School, he was closely associated with many artists whose enthusiasm to "make it new" proved to be contagious to him. He was the poet of New York for his time. O'Hara was gregarious; he wanted to be everything to everybody everywhere. The way he composed poems is interesting to note. His works were a lot of them "occasional" poems written for a birthday, a thank-you etc. His poems are full of names of people, places, and literary works without proper introduction (one thinks of Olson's *The Maximum Poems*). He wrote poetry effortlessly, often composing poems in his lunch hours. Hence one of his volumes entitled *The Lunch Poems*. He made less effort to get his works published, and his uncollected poems were found either from scraps of paper in boxes and trunks or retrieved from letters. These were put together and became the five-hundred-page *Collected Poems*.

O'Hara's early poems like "Second Avenue" were mostly surrealistic, and as such were often painfully obscure though there is a good deal of wit there. Later he was noted for the "I do this I do that" type of poems which he was pretty much the first to write. In these poems O'Hara tells in a flat tone the little things he did on just one or any of the days in his life. The details pile up not always connected; names of people appear often known to none but the author himself. The readers feel bored through most of the reading process, but feel well rewarded often by a surprise in wait for them, one that is not, however, always apparent. Often we need to reflect back on the whole poem to appreciate it well. "Why I Am Not a Painter" and "The Day Lady Died" are good examples for us here. The former talks about painting and poetry. The poet tells us in casual language about his visit to his painter friend, Mike Goldberg by name. Mike is starting a painting which has sardines on it. It takes days to finish. In the middle of it, the poet pays him another visit, and the painting is still going on. When he shows up again in the studio, the poet sees the finished painting but not the sardines in it. "It was too much," Mike tells him. For the poet himself he is beginning to write a poem about the color of orange. Soon he has written pages, twelve poems altogether, some even in prose, but he finds that "I haven't mentioned orange yet." Yet he entitles the work "Oranges." One day he sees his friend's painting on exhibition in a gallery; it is called "Sardines." The readers don't seem to get it until they read the poem again and finds tucked away somewhere in the poem the lines "... There should be / so much more, not of orange, of / words, of how terrible orange is / and life..." Now the point begins to dawn upon our minds: it is all about life, the painting and the poem, and because life is "terrible," the painter and the poet wish to evade it a little instead of coming to grips with it directly. Thus O'Hara possesses a tragic vision. The vision is well illustrated in poems such as "Joe's Jacket," where the poet-narrator is at a party and tells us why he drinks. He drinks to smother his sensitivity, he says. He drinks to kill the fear of boredom, the mounting panic of it. He drinks to reduce his seriousness (which may be induced by his fear of life), and to die a little. This all boils down to the point that just as "sardines" is too much for the painter and orange for the poet, so is life for the poet-narrator here. He wishes to be able to escape from it "a little," instead of confronting it right away.

"The Day Lady Died" is interesting because it is one of the most dramatic of O'Hara's "I do

this I do that" poems. The first four of the five stanzas of the poem describe the poet's mundane world and humdrum life. "The mounting panic" of boredom is just around the corner. The day threatens to be just another of so many dull days. It is a Friday. The poet goes to visit friends. He gets a shoeshine, has a Hamburger and a malted, buys a copy of New World Writing, goes to the bank where he gets a cold shoulder from the cashier (no big deal as it happens often), and then buys presents for his friends and cigarettes. Then he buys a copy of New York Post and sees the face of the famous blues singer and the obituary about her death. Life stops being commonplace. There is something to mourn over and feel about now. The singing of "Lady Day" (nickname for the great blues singer Billie Holiday [1915-1959]) touched him to the quick on one occasion which he recalls now: "and I am sweating a lot by now and thinking of / leaning on the John door in the 5 SPOT / while she whispered a song along the keyboard / to Mal Waldron and everyone and I stopped breathing[.]" The emotional impact of the death on the poet is so intense that he stops being careless and nonchalant and begins to feel serious. Life is worthwhile living, and people are worth caring for. The day Lady died may have well passed as just another meaningless day, but the death of the lady makes him think and makes the day an extraordinary one. O'Hara also wrote a number of love poems which touch upon his homosexual relationships in a natural and easy manner. It is also important to note about his language that it is colloquial, anecdotal, bare of ornaments, so he was definitely well in step with the contemporary anti-literary, anti-artistic tradition.

John Ashbery (1927-)

John Ashbery was for quite some time regarded ?and correctly ?as one member of the New York School. But as he moved into the more mature phase of his career, his poetry reveals, more and more, the salient features of a meditative mind. It is therefore more appropriate to see him as a meditative poet.

Ashbery grew up in Rochester, New York. He went to Harvard and met Kenneth Koch and Frank O'Hara there. The three moved to New York City and wrote poetry which shared features such as the emphasis on the individual voice, popular culture, high spirited humor, and experiments with Surrealism. As noted earlier on, they became known as the New York School. After Harvard, Ashbery went to Columbia to do graduate work in English and French literature. His volume of *Some Trees* was chosen by W. H. Auden for publication in the Yale Younger Poets series in 1956. The same year he went to France on a Fulbright Fellowship and lived there for ten years, working as an art journalist (a job which he did for the next thirty years). As a poet Ashbery benefited not a little from his acquaintance with painting and painters. "Europe" came out in 1960; it is a long poem of collage and fragmentation. Such features continued in *The Tennis Court Oath* (1962). Ashbery had yet to experiment with his style and methods ?*Rivers and Mountains* (1967) became different again (it was amazingly expansive) ? before he hit on his mature style, discursive and disorienting, which first appeared in his *The Double Dream of Spring* (1970). Meditative, idiosyncratic, and obscure, the style continued to evolve in *Three Poems* (1972) and reached its extreme in *A Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror* (1975). The volume won the Pulitzer Prize, the National Book Award, and the National Book Critics Circle Award. *The Vermont Notebook* (1975), which is full of parodies and collages, was followed by *Houseboat Days* (1977) and *As You Know* (1979). Since then he has published *Shadow Train* (1981), *A Wave* (1984), *Selected Poems* (1985), *April Galleons* (1987), *Flow Chart* (1991), *Hotel L'Autremon* (1993) and *Can You Hear, Bird* (1995). Now Ashbery has become one of the most meditative poets in contemporary America.

John Ashbery is probably the most obscure of contemporary American poets. Reading his poetry, the readers frequently toil not so much to discover its surface meaning ?his language very often offers little difficulty, or to hunt for sources as with reading Pound and Eliot; it is the undercurrent of meaning that his verbal structure embodies. Ashbery says it best when he wrote in "Like a Sentence" to the effect that we may think we know our destination but we often end up in "brilliant woods." The woods are well lit and transparent, like the language of his poem with its logical syntax and common words and phrases, but the poem as a whole is still like a "woods" in which we can and do often get lost.

Ashbery knows this. His "Paradoxes and Oxymorons" tries to address the problem of his obscurity. The first stanza of the poem raises the question about the concern of his poem which as he says is "language on a very plain level." The "very plain level" of language is the level of easy common speech, colloquial, logical grammar, meant to cater to the need of the majority of readers. Even though the poem tries to endear itself to the reader, the latter is impatient and restless because he is caught in a dilemma: he knows the language, but cannot make sense of the poem. The next two stanzas explain why this is the case. Language, consisting of many things, is after all a system of signs with which our imagination ("[a] deeper outside thing"), in relation to reality, plays its dreamed role, and follows the pattern that the Romantics of history had figured out for the imagination to follow in its interaction with reality, i.e. imagination recreating reality. Reality is open-ended, so is the poem representing it, trying to catch its essence, its truth, but always failing in the process of nailing it down on paper. Being a latter-day Romantic, Ashbery has played the game again, regarding the reader as the sole reason for his existence as a poet, only to find that the reader is not responsive. But he is not giving up as he shares the poem with his reader who, as part of reality, is part of the poem and, as such, is not easy to represent either. "Paradoxes and Oxymorons" is thus at once a complaint and a plea to the readers for understanding, and points at reality as the bad guy. The poet tries to approximate reality which is, however, too slippery to get hold of.

Let's take a couple of strophes from one of Ashbery's more lucid poems, "Grand Galop," and find out what hinders comprehension in his poetry. The first two sections of the poem will serve our purpose well. Here we come in contact with two things juxtaposed: The physical aspect of reality as represented by today or Monday's lunch of Spanish omelet, lettuce and tomato salad, jello, milk and cookies and tomorrow's lunch of sloppy joe on bun, scalloped corn, stewed tomatoes, rice pudding and milk. As this crosses the poet's mind, it focuses its attention on the metaphysical aspect of reality, which is the profound issue of getting to know reality. The poet says we have to wait for reality to reveal its totality, but that never will happen because we are time-bound and have to wait forever. Then the next physical triviality, like water dripping from an air conditioner on those passing underneath, catches the mind's attention. Thus the poetic mind seems all-inclusive and does not bother to select from its raw materials. This can never be true of the creative process, of course: the most perfect of stream-of-consciousness writers cannot avoid choosing the best streams available. Choosing entails discarding. What is allowed to stay is the most artistically necessary. What causes the hitch in comprehension here in the first two sections of "Grand Galop" is not the language, apparently. Every linguistic component is lucid, even simple. It is not the ideas expressed, apparently. The lunch for today and tomorrow, the vision of things hindered (fragmented) by time, water dripping on passers-by ?all these are lucid, even simple. The difficulty lies in the fact that the insignificant is placed alongside the significant and receives equal

notice in the making of poetry. The juxtaposition of these apparently unrelated elements is the root cause of the obscurity. The readers' logical process of thinking is suddenly disrupted and disoriented. Now how, in this case, are the lunch and the dripping water artistically indispensable to the representation of reality?

This then begs the question, what are Ashbery's views of reality? For Ashbery reality is full of paradoxes and oxymorons, elusive, ever-changing, ever moving to a new beginning, complex with multiple facets, contingent, and for ever surprising with its unexpectedness. It may have no inherent order or meaning. As such it is difficult, if not impossible, to reveal its whole truth. What the imagination has to do is to be engaged in a continual endeavor to observe and record whatever comes its way so as to hope to catch a glimpse of the whole truth of reality. As our mind is reactive, and its workings are fragmented by time, its vision of reality can only be momentarily complete; the wholeness, while possible ("Nothing is partially incomplete"), comes only when seen properly, and that does not happen because we are time-bound and have to wait. While waiting, the trivial or the ridiculous aspects of reality may appear before us as reality itself does not prioritize. But the human mind does. So it keeps on creating and murdering its versions of reality and beginning always anew, feeling the exhilaration of "[riding] on the rapid flux" of change in the meantime. The first two sections of "Grand Galop" may have been the poet's attempt to approximate reality and the mind trying to catch hold of it. Its message may be this, that reality is not quite easily knowable as it is a medley of things that the mind has to sort out.

It is no wonder that Ashbery is obsessed with the life of the mind finding out the truth or nature of things. He indulges his mind in its meditations, reflections and deliberations. His poetry, meditative to a fault, serves as a record of these extravagant "mental acts." His mind operates in its own way and on its own terms, often defying obvious canons of well-received logic. When this happens, the poetic mind stops sharing its ruminations. With time Ashbery has become more private in his perception and expression. To him the job of the poet is to address "the imaginative problem of embodying poetic time." It involves the mind juggling with abstractions, foraying in any direction that may catch its fancy, breaking boundaries of coherence and reason, making utterances seemingly wide apart in sense so that they fail to make sense to impatient readers. Ashbery's mind works this way because he shares the Romantic notion that the vision of true reality is at best transient. It is traceable back to Wordsworth, Shelley and Keats, and Stevens. These poets try to highlight the sublime, the extraordinary, moments of reality and still tie their imagination to life (though in varying degrees). Wordsworth is the most of the earth earthy. Shelley and Keats can be wild in imaginary flights, but still manage to touch ground. Stevens can be very difficult but mostly approachable. Ashbery is the most difficult of them all.

His poetry, long or short, often bewilderingly long, is normally a record of a consciousness flowing, observing whatever attracts its momentary notice, and commenting profusely along the way, using its own images and language (privy often to itself only) so that it appears discursive, disjunctive, indeterminate, mysterious, an amalgam of the rational with the irrational. It is often a structure where words seem to cluster together not so much to build toward meaning, but to test the ultimate limit of their communicability, which is probably also the farthest point to which the poet can carry his experimental endeavor. Such poetry, not surprisingly, is befuddling. But it is important to note that Ashbery is always well focused and coherent and that nothing is irrelevant in his best poetry.

Let's take a look of some of his poems. "Illustration" (1956), one of his earliest works,

begins to show the silhouette of the typical Ashbery work. Ashbery is obsessed thematically with getting to know reality, and formally with indirection in his mode of expression. "Illustration" reveals both aspects of his obsession. With regard to its theme, the poem is all about the possibility of knowing reality. In the first section of the poem, the seminary student in the act of committing suicide is a symbol of reality that puzzles all around wishing to know her wants and help her through the ordeal. Everybody thinks that they know what she wants and offers whatever they have, but they still fail to save her because they do not know what she would like to have. It is like the re-enacting of the fable of the blind men and the elephant. The poet then wonders, in the second section, whether the student alone represents the truth we seek to know because other things are happening at the same time of her suicide: the rockets soaring over the city, the feasting that was going on, in a word, so much is happening in that moment. The multiplicity of reality is evident. After all, reality may have more than one single aspect and more than one single manifestation. It is not possible for us to see the whole of it. Furthermore, our perception is questionable, too, as the beautiful, the kindness, in us hinders us from seeing the whole reality of the novice. The fact that we fail to see the truth about the student has nothing to do with her truth. The facets of reality do not lessen our understanding. We ourselves do; our indiscretions do because we are time-bound and space-bound. Even though we try to get beyond the limitations of space, and fly up and see her falling, then what we would get to know would be the reality of her only from one attitude! And there can be so many attitudes toward reality. So the poet is in fact saying that reality may not be knowable, and it does not care whether we know it anyway as it is a miracle not really meant for our ever-incomplete epistemological process to decipher.

One source of difficulty in reading Ashbery is his peculiar way of saying things. The first section of "Illustration" is still not quite in the mature Ashbery style yet. The narrative is smooth; transitions are natural; words coalesce with their sense; the whole of it is lucid and meaningful. The Ashbery style per se begins to appear in the second section. Words begin to divorce from their normal significance ("resemble a taller / Impression of ourselves," "indiscretions," "attitudes," "the end" etc.). Transitions are abrupt; ideas and images jump and lack surface connections. Lines leave things half said and leave ample room for speculation. There are so many linguistic resources available for the poet to smooth things out and help readers focus on the theme of the work, but Ashbery does not use them. As he matured as a poet, he has discarded the mode of writing evident in the first section of "Illustration," and developed and persisted in that of the second section. Now this kind of writing is too idiosyncratic for the readers at large to share. The result is often that the work remains the private assets of the poet. And of course much of Ashbery's poetry seems to remain still his private assets, however much this is against his best wishes. Hence his plea to the readers in his "Paradoxes and Oxymorons."

Ashbery's most famous poem, "Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror," bodies forth his view of reality and his poetics best. Long as it is ? it is a 6-strophe work, the poem is all about one thing: reality, getting to know it, and representing it in an art form, painting or poetry for example. In his opinion, reality and art both change and keep on changing to become ever something else, or what he terms the "otherness." As nothing ? reality or art or the artist for that matter ? stays the same, it is difficult to get to know the "whole" of the truth, and it would be extravagant to expect anything like an authentic artistic representation of reality. So there has been distortion all along. Although it looks bizarre and extremist, the 16th-century Italian Mannerist painter Parmigianino's self-portrait represents actually the rule of distortion, rather than an exception to it, in the history

of artistic portrayal of reality, epitomizing as it does the idea of distortion. This is what the Ashbery's poem dwells on, over and over and from different angles. This argument is the thread that alone will lead us out of the labyrinth of the poem. The thesis of the poem is then just this one single point, that reality is not authentically knowable and representable; we only distort it in trying. Never lose the point, and we shall not lose track in our reading of the poem.

The first reading of the poem will prove to be a frustrating experience for many readers. Some portions of the first strophe still make sense, but some other parts of it may be stupefying. The rest of the poem drags on, throwing the readers into an even greater confusion. Those who manage to finish reading the poem already deserve compliment; many probably give up in impatience or disgust in the middle of the effort. This may have to do with the poet's abrupt transitions, his use of images and symbols that seem to be beside the point under discussion in the text, and his self-indulgence in perception and expression. But if we calm down and set our mind on plodding through the text with "normal nerve, normal breath," and persist with patience and care, we will find that the poet has never for a moment swerved from his line of thinking and has never said anything irrelevant in the whole of his 552 lines. Some critics think that Ashbery is good at piling up nonsense before letting any sense break through. The accusation does not apply to the "Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror," and to his poetry in general, for that matter.

In the first strophe (?1-99), the poet sees a painting, the self-portrait by the Italian Mannerist painter Parmigianino (Girolamo Francesco Mazzola, 1503-1540) on a convex piece of poplar wood. Historically, Parmigianino did this probably to show that there is no single "correct" reality: "...this man .../ '...whose wish / Here was .../ To impart the sense of novelty and amazement to the spectator'" (?217-221). The poet feels uncomfortable with this kind of artistic representation. First, it is not authentic because it is twice removed from reality: the mirror reflection of the person painted and the painting's reflection of the mirror reflection. In addition, the painting is inadequate to the expression of the soul of the person painted. Everything is framed, fixed, "life englobed," no longer alive and changing. The painting restrains reality, and it is superficial: it has its medium for the surfaces but none for the essence in the recesses. It is impossible to represent the "visible core" ?the ultimate truth ?of things. The Mannerist self-portrait embraces the belief that art can represent reality, but it warns that it can do so in different ways, the Mannerist distortion included, because there can be different versions of reality. Ultimately, the poet feels that the self-portrait offers no authentic representation.

The 2nd strophe (?100-150) states that we as part of reality change with reality as external factors (such as the balloon popping and friends visiting) and our memories of these factors influence our thinking and our perception so that our mind itself is not in control ("I see in this only the chaos / Of your round mirror which organizes everything..."). In addition, reality is a symphony of diverse elements ("one neutral band"), there is no need to settle for just one mode of representation ("... I can not explain the action of leveling"). We should assert our individuality and be tolerant toward that of others (" My guide in these matters is your self, / ... accepting everything..."). Nothing is "extraneous." Realism is no good now and neither is Mannerism because reality keeps changing and proves too difficult for any style to represent it authentically. All this implies that the poet feels that there has to be a new vision of art in relation to reality.

The 3rd strophe (?151-206) states that theories of art tend to codify the mind and kill our dream for perfect art. Though necessary as a guide, these theories are "weak" because they subsume and rigidify everything and become a routine for us to accept without even noticing or

thinking of change. And we accept theories such as Mannerism also because it takes advantage of "our idea of distortion" and because we are accustomed to art selecting and generalizing ("[a] dream which includes them all"). Ideal art should get beyond the limitations of all forms and theories. There are no such theories or forms now good enough to meet our needs. What these really do is to frame the mind and so kill changing reality and our dream for perfect artistic representation: Our dreams become "inconsequential until one day / We notice the hole they left... /.../ And we realize this only at a point where they lapse / Like a wave breaking on a rock, giving up / Its shape in a gesture which expresses that shape." The result is that a semblance of living (but not real living) occurs; we become codified and dead.

The 4th strophe (?207-250) introduces the idea of otherness. Everything, including the self-portrait and the angel, constantly changes to become something else ("lost beyond telling"). What Parmigianino did was actually an example of catching the novelty that the process of becoming exhibits. The poet goes even further to declare that, even as the painter works, he undergoes a change and so does his room ("the strict / Otherness of the painter in his / Other room"). We feel startled by the change because we are not aware of it, not prepared for it, and we have nothing better to do or have no choice for ourselves, implying that our normal state of mind is languid or helpless: the surprise is like being startled by a snowfall when we do not expect to see it happen, when at the end of the day we are awakened, unable to go to sleep soon, and having nothing better to do, we look out the window and feel surprised to see the snowfall (?244-250).

The 5th strophe (?251-310) paves the way for the exposition of the poet's own stance on reality and art. Authentic reality ("The shadow of the city") waits for our authentic representation. While Parmigianino's studio is being isolated, something new has appeared on the scene. This is the poet's vision of art in relation to reality. It may be hard to understand and may jostle people out of their established way of thinking ("this unlike / Challenger pounding on the gates of an amazed / Castle"). Although Parmigianino offers no answer to our question regarding reality and art, and his self-portrait is all surface with no recesses for the essence of reality, he represents one of the phases and one of the efforts in history to portray reality the best we can. There has been no right or wrong in our endeavor; there are only phases in our epistemological process. Our search for the best possible way goes on; the questioning of a particular style's strengths and weaknesses should be seen as normal and as no menace to anyone. What the poet implies is that he may have been writing to question the way art has been representing reality, and has thus amazed the public, but he means well and would like to see that this kind of questioning will become general and natural, and not bizarre as his own way of thinking has been criticized.

Strophe 6 (?311-552) explains the poet's view of the relationship between reality and art. Coming back to the self-portrait, the poet says to Parmigianino: your painting is a page in history, and it is good and useful to look at it. He then goes on to assert that any attempt at pinpointing or nailing down reality in any way is in fact killing reality and art with it. Art, beautiful art, is part of a historical continuum and is created both on the basis and imbued with the recollection of the best of the past. Though any one style is meaningful for its own time, it represents not just one phase of history but all of it when considered out of its immediate context and in the long run of history. Reality, part of it being the self-portrait, changes and is elusive. The whole truth of reality cannot be known, but can be felt vaguely. The poet feels that he has seen the light and is determined to tell about it although he knows that he is a little ahead of time. In his opinion, change is ongoing and continuous. Reality, the artist, and his art all keep changing. The notion of continuous time

(the present undivided from both the past and the present) is justified and should be good for us if we do not want to distort things in our artistic reflection. But distortion has been the rule rather than the exception in the history of art because of the constant change. The poet repeats that Realism is no good; neither is the self-portrait's Mannerism. The search for the ideal art is hopeless. The hand of reality is not recording; each part of reality just happens haphazardly, in fragments, soon forgotten, except for individual occurrences (which may be recorded and noted down as all styles of art have been trying to do), remembered but not well remembered ("in cold pockets / Of remembrance"), almost inaudible to us because outdated ("whispers out of time"). Thus the poet's view is that reality is not authentically representable.

So "Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror" is trying to say that from the beginning of time, art has been all inevitably distorting reality. Although Ashbery has his point, he has told only one side of the truth. The whole truth may be that reality is unstable, but it also has its aspect of relative stability that makes life possible to live and gives it some meaningful, recognizable form. Ashbery's truth could lead to a void, a nothingness, where no effort, distortion or no distortion, would be worthwhile. Thus in the final analysis his is probably also a half-truth, in itself another kind of distortion. This may be where Ashbery's aesthetic crisis ultimately lies.

The case of Ashbery involves our attitude toward individual talent. When someone has persisted in writing in this meditative mode for decades, putting out volume after volume of such obscure poetry, should we readers not give him the benefit of the doubt and stop to ask why the poet has been able to survive the ravages of time and the anger of his readers? Is it not probable that he has an individual talent that we need to try and appreciate? In conclusion we can say that, both daring and self-indulgent, Ashbery is in the main a poet of personal vision. He impresses by his own kind of logic or want of logic, his complex imagery, and his fine visual representation of the world, thus leading the reader into a realm of enjoyment through art, very often on a personal and private level, though this experience is possible often only to an elite group endowed with a similar sensibility as that of the poet. Hence his small readership. But Ashbery has been influential in his own way. He is one of the finest poets of his time.

Another major contemporary meditative poet is A. R. Ammons (1926-). Ammons is well read in Wordsworth, Emerson, Whitman, and Indian and Chinese philosophy, and writes often in the Romantic tradition. Highly aware of the natural world with its multiple significance, he sees the here and now, i.e. nature and life in their sundry forms of being that ranges from the infinitesimal to the infinite, but he tries also to see and comprehend the larger silhouette of a design, a mystery probably unknown to man, and feels that his art should try to present his vision as accurately as possible.

One of Ammons' best poems that well reveal the poet's thematic and formal concerns is his "Corsons Inlet" (1965). One thing that we notice about Ammons' poetry is the walk motif recurrent in some of his works. As one walks, one observes the constant changes that occur around and the diversity and mutability that are the norm of nature and life. A meditative mind can transcend surface and perceive the built-in larger scheme. Ammons even goes as far as comparing a poem to a walk. "Corsons Inlet" is both a description of the scenery along this tidal inlet in New Jersey that the poet sees while walking along it and a record of his meditations, his discoveries, and his poetic rendering of these all. The poem begins with "I went for a walk over the dunes again this morning / to the sea," and he sees the world of nature around and meditates on its various manifestations of life and its kaleidoscopic changes: the sea surf, the naked headland, the

muggy sunny scene, the wind from the sea, the sand, the eddies, the inlet's cutting edge, the grass, the white sandy paths, areas of primrose, bayberries, reeds, yarrow, the creek, the undercreek, black shoals of mussels, the air and the sun, the waterline, the gulls, the crabs, a ruddy turnstone, the white blacklegged egret, the black mudflats, swallows, the twittering of birds, their beaks and the wings, blue tiny flowers on a leafless weed, snail shell, minnows, etc. etc. The long list reveals the poet's sharp eye for minute details of life and nature. Individually viewed, the things keep forever changing in shape and form; there may be fighting and killing (almost in the Darwinian sense or akin to Tennyson's nature "red in tooth and claw") with suffering and death, perpetual moving, always in the process of "becoming," as if there were no beginnings or ends. But out of these details, their chaos and disorder and confusion in plan and arrangement, their mutability, their motion, and their formlessness, the poet perceives an order of a large nature ?the "Overall," something that, somehow, resembles Emerson's "Oversoul" or God's grand scheme of things. This "Overall," as the poet tells us, is permanent, changeless, with perfect form and order, a state of things absent from the temporal, spatial, phenomenal world of man: "No arranged terror: no forcing of images, plan, / Or thought: / No propaganda, no humbling of reality to precept[.]"

The poem demonstrates how nature and the poetic mind interact with one another. The mind sinks into nature, carries on a dialogue with it, and intuits the absolute inherent in it. To the mind that suffers the restrictions and limitations of human perception, nature is liberating: "I was released from forms, / from the perpendiculars, / straight lines, blocks, boxes, binds / of thought / into the hues, shadings, rises, flowing bends and blends / of sight[.]" The mirroring mind observes and digests and creates spontaneously: "I allow myself eddies of meaning: / yield to a direction of significance / running / like a stream through the geography of my work: / you can find in my sayings / swerves of action / like the inlet's cutting edge: / there are dunes of motion, / organizations of grass, white sandy paths of remembrance / in the overall wandering of the mirroring mind[.]" Here the poet so skillfully juxtaposes the physical with the metaphorical that one glides into the other smoothly, soundlessly. Nature and art merge in a subtle, exquisite way. In this respect, Ammons reads, occasionally, like Gary Snyder. The liberating effect of nature is well reflected in the formal aspect of "Corsons Inlet." Here the poem runs in its free verse, with its run-on lines and its natural varying line lengths. It is William Carlos Williams both in subject and form and in mode of perception.

Some of Ammons' short poems are simply memorable. One of these would be his "Mountain Talk." It tells a simple story, as the poet explained on one occasion. It is a person "going" on a "dusty highroad" when suddenly he becomes aware of the massive presence of the mountain. The mountain stands there motionless and silent. The person becomes aware that there are two modalities of existence for him to choose from: the one in which he is living ?moving, changing, uncertain, and the one the mountain represents ?stable, unalterable, and offering a sense of certitude. The mountain asks him whether he would like to stay with "a changeless prospect" and enjoy "an unalterable view," but the person decides to go on with his wandering. Simple as it looks, the poem is pregnant with meaning. "[G]oing" suggests the idea of a journey (which is a familiar metaphor for life). "[T]he dusty highroad" could mean Robert Frost's "road not taken," an un-trodden, unknown, area to be explored. Life is unpredictable, haphazard, full of challenges and possibilities. Living is what makes it meaningful and worthwhile being a human. The silent, apparently abrupt decline of the mountain's offer on the part of the person ("I") seems to indicate a self assertion in defiance of a power which, although there is nothing he could do about it but

moving on in silence, he does not feel obliged to obey. The line, "nevertheless, said the mountain," sounds a little like Stephen Crane's God speaking. Though the mountain may not be as cold and indifferent, the person does not seem to show affection for it. Ammons' "I" may be more self-confident and less reliant on others.

The same vein of thought runs through "So I said I am Ezra," one of his early poems. Here the "I" is apparently an insignificant man in face of the nonchalant universe. The wind and the waves of the sea are just downright indifferent to "my voice." "My" repeated "I am Ezra" simply "falls out of being / so I Ezra went out into the night / like a drift of sand / and splashed among the windy oats / that clutch the dunes / of unremembered sea[.]" "I" feels bad, but is not ready to give up. By going out into the night and splashing among the oats, "I" does something to assert "my" existence. In other words, "I" understands that "I" is not much of a being that the cosmos or nature would condescend to reckon with, but "I" would go on questing, even though in vain, for something larger and more infinite.

The Black Mountain Poets

One group of poets active on the contemporary scene include, among others, Charles Olson, Denise Levertov (1923-), Robert Duncan (1919-), and Robert Creeley (1926-). As these people were either associated with Black Mountain College, or with Black Mountain Review (edited by Robert Creeley), they have become known as the "Black Mountain Poets."

Black Mountain College was founded in the 1930s as a liberal educational center. It was near Asheville, North Carolina. In the 1950s it became a focus for all dissidents in art, literature, and matters of academic interest in general when Charles Olson was first instructor and then rector there (1951-56). Teachers, painters, sculptors, writers, musicians, and film makers with unique ideas of their own came to visit or stay. Cid Corman's little magazine *Origin* and Black Mountain Review were ready to publish their works. Allen Ginsberg and Charles Olson were among the contributing editors of the Review. Williams Carlos Williams, Gary Snyder, Jack Kerouac, and Philip Whalen were some of their published authors. Although closed in 1956, the College did its best to help with the growth of postwar art and literature, and the Black Mountain poets made their significant addition to contemporary American literature.

Charles Olson (1910-1970)

The leading figure of this school of poetry was Charles Olson, who joined the college in 1951 and was its rector until 1956 (year of its closure). He turned it into a center of arts. He wrote the well-known essay "Projective Verse" (1950), one of the most significant statements in postwar American poetry, and fought for the birth of a new poetry almost single-handedly against the New Critical hegemony of the publishing world then. He had the support of the brave little magazine, *Origin*, and was able over time to create a new poetic community. The first to call for a new American verse in the postwar period, he has remained an influence on contemporary American poetry. His poetry as in *In Cold Hell, In Thicket* (1953) and *The Distances* (1961) contains some of the most exquisite of poetic works written in the 20th century. His *The Maximus Poems* (1953-1968) is a collection of lyrical, sociological, and experimental poems which has, together with the works of Ezra Pound and William Carlos Williams, made up the basic poetics of a good deal of contemporary American poetry. In theme Olson is critical of the American way of life; in form he borrows from the metrics of Pound and Williams.

Charles Olson was born in Worcester, Massachusetts, grew up there, spending summers in

Gloucester, and did the course work for the Ph. D. at Harvard. He did excellent work as a scholar in such fields of activity as archaeology, education, and anthropology. His first critical work, *Call Me Ishmael* (1945), reveals a mind as idiosyncratic as it was seminal. As a poet and a critic, he wrote and contributed very much toward moving American poetry away from the tradition of T. S. Eliot and the New Criticism and elevating the poetics of Williams and Pound. Olson had a huge sense of mission. He was one of the first, if not the first, to locate clearly the problem with American poetry in the 1950s. As his friend Robert Creeley put it, "...what confronted us in 1950 was a closed system indeed, poems patterned upon exterior and traditionally accepted models. The New Criticism of that period was dominant and would not admit the possibility of verse considered as an 'open field.'" Olson lost no time addressing the problem. He began by defining art and poetry. "Art is the only twin life has," he states in his essay "Human Universe" (1950), "because it does not seek to describe but to enact." His essay "Projective Verse," when first published, exploded as it were on the consciousness of the people involved. William Carlos Williams called it an "excitement" that was widely shared, and across the Atlantic the British poet Donald Davie was impressed, too. Olson aimed at starting in poetry writing a revolution, the stature of which would be comparable to "the revolution of ...1910." He would like to "suggest a few ideas about what stance toward reality brings such verse [projective or OPEN verse] into being, what that stance does, both to the poet and to the reader." And he envisioned something of some magnitude for American poetry in the new period, "a change beyond, and larger than, the technical, and may, the way things look, lead to new poetics and to new concepts from which some sort of drama, say, or of epic, perhaps, may emerge." It already sounded like a manifesto. Sure enough he took the bold "advance-guard action" and developed a poetics that encouraged poets to depart from the "closed" form. In so doing he impacted quite a few of his contemporaries such as Robert Duncan, Robert Creeley, Paul Blackburn, and LeRoi Jones (Amiri Baraka). As Creeley put it, Olson became "the man from whom our creative impetus must spring."

Now what was this "projective or OPEN verse" all about? Olson defines "the NON-Projective" verse as "closed" verse in his famous essay, and by "closed" he means everything which appeared in English and American literature before "the work of Pound and Williams," or anything in the traditional form. Olson felt that it was time contemporary poets, or as he called them, "the sons of Pound and Williams," picked up the fruits of the experiments of the older poets. The new poet, he says, should work in the "OPEN," or engage in "FIELD COMPOSITION," or "COMPOSITION BY FIELD," as opposed to inherited line, stanza, over-all form, what is the 'old' base of the non-projective." He calls a poem "the field" where all the syllables and lines must be managed in their relations to each other. So "composition by field" is his way of saying writing projective verse or new verse as against writing in traditional poetics. Olson declares that poetry is energy transferred from where the poet got it all the way to the reader through the poem; the poem must be, at all points, a high-energy construct and an energy discharge.

On the role of breathing in the composing process, Olson asserts in his prophetic voice, "Verse now, 1950, if it is to go ahead, if it is to be of essential use, I take it, catch up and put into itself certain laws and possibilities of the breath, of the breathing of the man who writes as well as of his listenings." He places emphasis on the syllable. He calls it "king and pin of versification" which he feels should be allowed to replace rime and meter in the fore of the mind "to lead the harmony [of the poem] on." Poets should listen to the syllable constantly and scrupulously. The

ear is close to the mind and has the mind's speed. The syllable is thus born of the union of the mind and the ear. "Let me put it baldly," he states in his essay. "The two halves are: the HEAD, by way of the EAR, to the SYLLABLE / the HEART, by way of BREATH, to the LINE [.]". The syllable and the line between them make a poem. The line comes from the breathing of the poet who writes at the moment he writes and ends a line where breathing terminates. Breath allows all the speech force of language back in the poem. He asserts that the poet can indicate exactly the breath, the pauses, the suspensions even of syllables, the juxtapositions even of parts of phrases which he intends, and that he can record the listening he has done to his own speech and by that one act indicate how he would want any reader to voice his work.

Concerning form and content, Olson affirms Robert Creeley's idea that the principle presiding over the composition of a projective poem is that form is never more than an extension of content, and that right form is the only and exclusively possible extension of content under hand. He says that the conventions which logic has forced on syntax must be broken, tenses and grammar must be stretched so that "all parts of speech suddenly, in composition by field, are fresh for both sound and percussive use, spring up like unknown, unnamed vegetables in the patch, when you work it, come spring." In actual writing, one perception must immediately and directly lead to a further perception. The poet must "keep moving, keep in, speed, the nerves, their speed, the perceptions, theirs, the acts, the split second acts, the whole business, keep it moving as far as you can.... USE USE USE the process at all points, in any given poem always always one perception must must must MOVE, INSTANTER, ON ANOTHER!"

This poetic stance has to do with his view of reality. To Olson and his associates and probably to quite a few of his contemporaries, reality is infinite, forever in the process of becoming, and changing. Things happen and reflect only a part of the whole. And they are unpredictable. Our knowledge of reality can only be fragmentary and imperfect. So the job of the poet is not to describe reality, but to enact it, as truthfully and swiftly as he can. To do this well, poets need to watch and follow and change accordingly. "I myself would wish," Olson said on one occasion, "that all who spoke and wrote, spoke always from a place that is new at that moment that they do speak." On another occasion, he said that he "[takes] space to be the central fact of man born in America." To him, if people live in space, every moment or point is a new beginning. We must live always in the immediate present. The implication is that nothing, the writer included, is immune to change. This recalls in a way Ashbery's idea of "otherness."

The corollary of all this is that the poetic mind moves by leaps and bounds; it is often pulled along by its own associations which may be inspired by an idea, or a word, or a combination of these that the poet has already written down in the process of composition. The form is open and becomes no more than an extension of content; the content is, however, often disjunctive or haphazard. The poem possesses intrinsic coherence, no doubt, but its surface often appears rugged and difficult to connect. The readers experience fragments of ideas, a confusing syntax, a sudden jump from the physical level of discourse to the metaphysical. Grammar is not always followed and parentheses may not be always closed. Furthermore, Olson's utterances are often so original that they fail to invoke immediate associations of recognition on the part of the readers, thus forcing them to stand on shaky ground and conjecture. And there is, in addition, a show of multi-culturalism here and there that seasons the writing with a taste of exotic obscurity. On top of all these, Olson was self-indulgent in his ways of expression, full of private references and allusions, throwing in, for instance, bits of information such as names of people or places known

probably only to himself. And last but not least, his thought system can be so unique that it holds no obscurity only to himself. All these and probably more account for the difficulty that Olson's poetry presents. Olson is not easy to read.

Let's take a look at some of his most famous work, *The Maximus Poems*, just to get a feel of how his poetry reads like. *The Maximus Poems* is a collection of poems that he wrote over a period of twenty years (from 1950 through his death). It consists of three volumes. The first of these depicts Maximus sizing up his hometown Gloucester, finding it wanting in good values, and moving on to take a systematic look at the history of the town and America. The second volume, *Maximus ? , ? , ?*, Maximus re-enacts certain myths and fables of the ancient world. The final volume, which was found among the author's papers, continues with Maximus' intense scrutiny of Gloucester and of himself. The central idea of the whole is to try to reinvent, with the help of ancient values, the town of Gloucester that has been degraded by the commercialism of modern life. In formal terms there might have been, for Olson, a broad overall scheme as to how the poems would connect into a whole, but it could have been at best a skeleton of a scheme to be fleshed out over time. The poems keep adding up without much of a thematic focus and with only loose connective tissues like the place ?Gloucester ? as the collection's locale, its history, its fishermen and their rituals and lives, its present-day commercial transactions, and Olson's poetic imprint. The collection is autobiographical, recording Olson's personal experiences and observations in large measure. It is his intellectual history in a poetic framework. He stresses the importance of being close to nature, values the people's direct, personal, wholesome link with it, and censures in contrast the capitalist proprietors' estranged relation to it. The Olson-Maximus figure is probably Olson's ideal of men. The name of the persona of the poem, Maximus, sounds probably a little presumptuous, named after Maximus, the 4th-century Phoenician mystic, but it fits Olson's ambitious plan well. This Olson-Maximus lives life to the fullest, discovers himself while discovering his place, observing, ruminating, keeping finding the ultimate relationship to both life and nature. The urge toward the mythical becomes increasingly evident in his deliberations as the collection grows in volume and moves toward its end.

Let's take a look at one of the Maximus poems, "Maximus, to Gloucester, Sunday, July 19" just to get a feel of his poetry reads like. The two-section poem is about an annual ceremony that the people of Gloucester hold in memory of the fishermen drowned on the sea. It is held before the sculpture of a fisherman on July 19 when the people throw a lot of flowers into the sea. On this day this year, a group of visitors come and stand in front of the sculpture, apparently wondering what it is all about. They see the flowers whirling in the sea, changing its character and moving it so as to allow the drowned a chance of rebirth. The poet-visitor, contemplating the scene of the flowers on the sea, switches his reflections to modern life ("as gold for wares wares for gold") and comes to realize that the dead have had neither fame nor power and have been condemned by God. Section two begins with a picture of our earth riddled with death and diseases. We should, however, have the courage to live on. The sea drowns, but it is all-inclusive: "When a man's coffin is the sea / the whole of creation shall come to his funeral[.]" The ceremony opens our eyes to the miraculous powers of nature and the sea: "the globe / is below, all lapis / and its blue surface golded / by what happened / this afternoon: there are eyes / in this water / the flowers / from the shore, / awakened / the sea." We should be close to nature and keep "the door of [our] divine intelligence" open to the fact that nature rectifies what needs to be rectified and resurrects the dead ("... not one life was lost"). But this door of divine intelligence is being shut in the din of modern

life: as soon as the ritual is over, the people are back to square one and drowned in the sea of modern existence: "radar sonar radio telephone good engines / bed-check seaplanes..." The result is that goodness is not within us but just "over and under us." The ritualistic significance of the ceremony, so vital to us, is again buried and gone. Olson has few kind words to say about modern civilization. He always harks back to ancient values, inherent in the people who live close to nature. He sees positive qualities in the fishermen's rituals, and contrasts these significantly with the depriations of modern culture. So in regard to his attitude to nature and modern civilization, "Maximus, to Gloucester, July 19" is very suggestive of Olson's Maximus poems.

This calls to mind one of his famous poems, "The Kingfishers," the first of The Distances Poems (1950). As we noted earlier on, one major Olson theme is the excavation of lost values from the submerging modern life. He called himself an "archaeologist of morning" not just because he was an archaeologist and a student of history. There was a more important reason. For him the recovery of the American past was of paramount importance. "The Kingfishers" is a good illustration. At one time Olson was studying the Mexican Mayan civilization. The demise of this ancient Indian culture must have moved him in his deliberations on the value of primitive traditions and inspired the writing of the poem.

This early work of the poet's reads like a reminiscence of something he had had at the back of his mind that was ever ready to surface at the first possible opportunity. It was probably one of his visits to an Indian burying ground while he was studying the Mayan culture in the Yucatan, Mexico. So, as the poem tells us, when he woke one morning from a party he had gone to the previous night, he remembered to check on his kingfishers in the cage. He recalled the remarks of one of the people at the party about the birds and their feathers. These were at one time important to the Indians both spiritually and materialistically, but now no one cared about them any more. He thought of the importance of primitive values and the cruelty of the conquerors and the destroyers of an ancient civilization. He felt the need to apologize to a fellow race. All the way through he meditated upon change and sought the possibility of rebirth. This was part of his life-long effort to reconnect people with the natural process from which he thought modern man has been alienated.

The poem consists of three sections, with section one subdivided into four parts. The first part of section one surprises the readers with its opening line: "What does not change / is the will to change." The truth that it states, that everything changes, paves the way for the sudden, equally surprising utterance, from one of the people at the party: no one cares about the kingfishers and their feathers any more; the birds' feathers were once wealth and exported. Part two of section one picks up from here and goes on to tell us that it is not the loss of interest in the birds that bothers us so much. It is what they symbolized for the people. They assumed a legendary, ritualistic significance in the past and embodied values gone from modern life, values of a pristine nature that could give a sense of direction to life and make it worth living. The poet does not lose heart yet, however. He sees new growth born of the dead and decayed and hears hope ring in Mao Zedong's 1949 slogan: "The light of dawn is before us. We must rise and act." Part three of section one introduces the cause of the loss: the destruction of the ancient peaceful life of the Indians by the conquering colonizers and the encroachment on the primitive values with their way of life. The reference is clearly to Hernando Cortes and his hordes, conquerors of Mexico. The last part of section one, while asserting the inevitability of change, laments over the fact that our life is changing for the worse; we have lost our individuality: we have lost "[t]his very thing [we] are."

One possible implication of this is that a race has been almost extinct.

Serving as a footnote to section one, section two begins with the poet visiting the Indians; the visit surfaces here very much as a flashback. He sees their ritual of burying the dead, significant to the poet because meaningful to the Indians and relevant to modern life. There the poet witnesses the devastation that the conquerors caused of the Indian culture, and hears the complaint of the dead in "the whiteness which covers it all." The pathos, the anger, that the visiting poet feels, is self-evident when he sees the extinction of the Mayan Indian civilization as the result of the Western version of cannibalism: "la piu saporita et migliore / che si possa truovar al mondo" (a quotation from Marco Polo's record of cannibalism in Asia: "the most savory and best that can be found in the world"). It is in this mood that he contemplates over the hypocrisy, the negation of positive human qualities, the dirtiness, and what is even worse that underlies the modern West.

In the last section the poet declares that the Indians are his "next of kin," and that he commits himself to their tradition of staying close to nature and to the primitive and the familiar ("I offer, in explanation, a quote: / si j'ai du gout, ce n'est guerre / que pour la terre et les pierres" [a quotation from French poet Arthur Rimbaud's poem, "Faim," which in English means: "If I have any taste, it is only for earth and stones"]), thus aligning himself with this ancient people. This sounds very much like an apology long overdue to the dead and the wronged. He asks the brunt question whether there can be any good to uncover in the ruins of the Mayan civilization, of which the kingfishers are emblematic and to which the symbolic "E on the stone" is closely linked. This "E," a connection with the oracle of Delphi, is a reminder of another ancient civilization, the values of which have been by and large neglected or forgotten. The poet finds value in the past and keeps hunting for it to serve as a corrective to the sordid present. In so doing the poem affirms the relevance of ancient values to modern existence and sees renewal in ruins and decay. The ending of the poem can be read differently, however. "I pose you your question" can be construed as a condemnation of the conquerors (and their descendants?) for having done what they did. The "uncover[ing] honey / where maggots are" is virtually impossible. The very last line, "I hunt among stones," denotes that "I" may have faith and hope, but the outcome is anybody's guess. In this reading there is a note of pessimism around.

In its formal aspect "The Kingfishers" is heavily Poundian and Williamsian. Pound's heavy allusiveness and his cross-culturalism are embedded in the texture of the poem, and the imprint of Williams' rhythm, diction, and prose interpolations can be clearly seen. Reading early Olson poems like "The Kingfishers" is in a way similar to reading Pound and Eliot. Hunting for sources constitutes a good deal of the reading effort.

Olson at his best can be very lyrical and beautiful. He was at his best when he was free from theories and preconceptions. The fact of the matter is that his poetic mind was not always free and open. He often had rigid notions of what he was going to write, and the way he said it was very mannered sometimes. All this may have detracted from the exquisite quality of his works. And of course there was the shadow of Pound and Williams. Olson tried to shake Pound off his back. He achieved partial success in his later phase, but Pound and Williams have always loomed large in his poetry. His major poetic effort, *The Maximus Poems*, resembles the *Cantos* in its cumulative structure as an intellectual diary and Paterson in its belief in localism and its overall form. However, when all is said, there is no doubt that Olson represents a monument, a milestone of a kind, in his own way in contemporary poetry. In the postwar revolution of poetry writing, he

played a part that will be remembered in history.

Creeley, Levertov, and Duncan

Robert Creeley (1926-) was born in West Acton, Massachusetts. He attended Harvard and left it without a degree, received his B. A. from Black Mountain College, and an M. A. at the University of New Mexico. He published widely in the 1950s, became famous in the sixties, and has been teaching at some universities. Creeley began his career as a staunch member of the Black Mountain group. Olson was a mentor to him. With regard to content, he fully agrees with Williams' "No ideas but in things," and with Pound's stance that "[a]ny tendency to abstract general statement is a greased slide." This is further affirmed in his preface to Charles Olson: *Selected Writings* (New York: 1966), where he states, "The most insistent concern I find in Olson's writing is the intent to gain the particular experience of any possibility in life, so that no abstraction intervenes." In matters of form, in face of the New Critical orthodoxy of the 1940s and 1950s, Creeley felt along with Olson that "formal" order could no longer be assumed as a necessary virtue, and that form is no more than an extension of content. Creeley's literary credo is clearly that of open form. Creeley edited the *Black Mountain Review* (1954-1957), and helped promote the works of Olson's group of poets. Over the years Creeley developed his own style and made his presence felt on the literary scene of his time. His poetry takes daily life experiences as its subject matter, and his diction is colloquial and conversational. He is said to be the simplest of the group and of the new verse in general. His volumes of poems include *For Love: Poems 1950-1960* (1962), *Words* (1967), *The Charm: Early and Uncollected Poems* (1967), *Pieces* (1969), *A Day Book* (1972), *Thirty Things* (1974), *Away* (1976), *Later* (1979), *The Collected Poems 1945-1975* (1982), *Mirrors* (1983), *The Memory Gardens* (1986), and *Windows* (1990). Creeley has written essays, stories, a novel, and a play.

Creeley's usual subject is love and marriage and the intricacies of relationships and human ties between individuals of the two sexes. "The Business," "The Riddle," "A Form of Women," "Sing Song," and "Ballad of the Despairing Husband" are just some of the titles that come to mind. But his theme is wider. "After Lorca" and "For My Mother" are not quite of the "domestic" brand that he was at one time accused of writing. Creeley's style is interesting. It has been described as "minimal," in the sense that he prefers to be short and simple. This has proved to be his strength especially when reinforced by his subtle handling of metaphors. Creeley is suggestive. His poetry connotes superbly at its best. When his best poems appeared in *For Love, Poems 1950-1960* in 1962, his style was imitated actually. Since then he has published quite a few volumes.

Creeley can be deceptively simple. Read his "I Know a Man" or "Oh No," and we will find depth and complexity not always justly judged sometimes to be rare in his works. Let's take a look at "I Know a Man":

As I sd to my
friend, because I am
always talking, ?John, I
sd, which was not his
name, the darkness sur-
rounds us, what

can we do against
it, or else, shall we &

why not, buy a goddamn big car,

drive, he sd, for
christ's sake, look
out where yr going.

Our first reading reveals a simple conversation in a simple context of life ?two friends driving out on the road. The one driving says something not seemingly relevant to the immediate business of daily existence, and the other, a bit worried and impatient at this distraction, tells him to shut up and concentrate on driving. A rule of thumb for reading Creeley is, don't stop at the surface meaning, but read the poem again. In our second reading we will become aware that the point which the driver makes is one which only the thinking and the sensitive minds are capable of making because it reveals the larger and deeper nature of life than meets the eye: the darkness is enveloping us, and there is not much we can do about it. This represents the speaker's tragic vision of life. Then we will come to realize that the two friends are different in intellect and mindset and that they represent between them the two broad segments of humanity: the physical and practical on the one hand, and the philosophical and the idealistic on the other. One is awake and aware, and the other, representative of the majority, lives in a stupor (in a Thoreavian sense). Then we will notice that the more sensitive one ?the driver ?proves to be the more hurt by life because he is being careless, probably driving under the influence of substance abuse and even unable to remember his friend's name (an indication of deficiency of his short memory). Why does he do drugs and run the risk of running into an accident? It is anybody's guess. Probably he feels despair as he could do nothing about the engulfing darkness he sees crushing down. He does suggest buying a big car, that is, indulging in a kind of irresponsible, degrading materialistic horseplay just to dull the senses and kill meaningless time, but he sounds dejected and feels skeptical about it himself. Now coming back to the title, we may ask, who is this "I" here? And who of the two people in the poem could have said "I Know a Man"? Again the point is open to speculation, but we may suggest that it is the passenger in the car who, thinking more about what his friend said, becomes enlightened and convinced of his view of life. If that is the case, "I Know a Man" should be an appreciative and complimentary remark from the passenger, meant also to disseminate his friend's perceptive observation.

We may enjoy a similar reading experience with Creeley's poem entitled "Oh No":

If you wander far enough
you will come to it
and when you get there
they will give you a place to sit

for yourself only, in a nice chair,
and all your friends will be there
with smiles on their faces
and they will likewise all have places.

The simplest reading of this is to see it as about a gathering "you" stumbles into. The meeting sounds as if it is scheduled to occur at regular intervals. The "you" seems to be a latecomer but has come anyway, only to find all his friends already there. Then the motif of a journey comes to mind, a journey of life, in which case, the "wandering far enough" might mean

the end of the road, the "it" that "you" comes to is the terminal point, probably the place of the blest, or Heaven. The rest of the poem all ties in well with a happy ending for all except for the title, "Oh No." The logical response to the offer of a chair with smiles all around would be a "Thank you." The refusal to take a seat could mean either of the two things: you are not ready enough to do it because, to quote Robert Frost, you still have "miles to go"; or you are not willing to take your place here because you think there is a better one for you. To you this is not Heaven; it is Hell. Suddenly we feel the irony in the "nice," and see forced "smiles" on the faces, and comprehend the matter-of-factness of the whole affair better. The poem then assumes the significance of an indomitable spirit of perseverance in face of adversity, or self-defense and self-assertion against overwhelming odds. There is a tragic vision of a kind, along with the will to life and the affirmation of the human spirit.

Denise Levertov (1923-1997) is regarded as one of the most respected poets of her generation. She was born and raised in England, and published her first book of poetry there, *The Double Image* (1946) in traditional English rhymes and meters. Later she married an American writer and came to the United States in 1948. Over the years she taught at a number of universities including Vassar, M.I.T., and Stanford. She took an enormous interest in the poetry of William Carlos Williams and Ezra Pound and was one member of the Black Mountain group for quite some time. Beginning with her second volume, her verse changed over to the freer rhythms and diction of postwar American poetry. There is some similarity between some of her poetry of the time and that of Creeley's, but their difference is probably more striking. With time her career developed in its own direction so that she did not think it proper to link her with any particular school. With 30 books of poetry, translations, and essays from some 60 years of almost daily work under her belt, she went far beyond the Black Mountain phase of her career and is now evaluated in her own right. Her volumes of poetry include *Here and Now* (1957), *The Jacob's Ladder* (1958), *Overland to Islands* (1958), *With Eyes at the Back of Our Heads* (1959), *O Taste and See* (1964), *The Sorrow Dance* (1966), *Relearning the Alphabet* (1970), *To Stay Alive* (1971), *Footprints* (1975), *The Freeing of the Dust* (1975), *Life in the Forest* (1978), *Candles in Babylon* (1982), *Oblique Prayers* (1984), *Breathing the Water* (1987), *A Door in the Hive* (1989), and *Evening Train* (1992).

Denise Levertov can be remarkably Williamsian in some of her works. Apparently the earlier shorter lyrics of the older poet have left their mark on her work. "Six Variations (Part ?)" (1961) is a good example:

Shlup, shlup, the dog
as it laps up
water
makes intelligent
music, resting
now and then to take breath in irregular
measure

The observation is accurate, the presentation is in veritable open form, and the rhythm imitates daily speech. The fluctuating line lengths, the rhythmical pauses, and the harmony of sounds combine to make indeed intelligent music. Levertov is saying, along with Williams' "The Red Wheel Barrow," that there is beauty and poetry in the life around us. That there is beauty in life has been a major thematic concern of her literary creations.

Over the years Levertov developed a poetic vision and an esthetic of her own. She had a strong sense of mission as a poet. There is almost a religious intensity to her work ?she has written some religious poetry such as "Salvation" and has been, though not really appropriately, called a religious poet. In her essay, "A Poet's View" (1984), Levertov emphasizes the importance for an artist to believe in inspiration or the intuitive, to have "Imagination," to be sensitive to "the transcendent, the numinous," and "experience mystery" in the creative act. "The concept of 'inspiration' presupposes a power," she goes on to state, "that enters the individual and is not a personal attribute; and it is linked to a view of the artist's life as one of obedience to a vocation." It is evident that poetry has a mission to accomplish and that the poet is committed to helping people survive with illuminations and revelations of things which may have been unseen or forgotten. She claims that if we focus enough, we may discover aspects not previously seen in an experience new or otherwise. Levertov exhibited an inclination toward some religious vision.

Levertov's poetry shows a clear social purpose. She was all along interested in humanitarian politics. Her enthusiasms ranged over a variety of subjects from concern with women's experience as a person, in marriage, and their sexual appetite (such as in "Eros at Temple Stream") to painful reflections on grave issues like the Vietnam War and the Gulf War. It is good to note that she was a political activist with 30 years' experience in the antiwar movement of the country. All these aspects of her writing career had no doubt to do with her upbringing and family heritage: both of her parents were committed people in terms of faith and social and political justice. It was an inheritance which the poet valued very much in her literary endeavors as her works such as "Dream Instruction" and "Illustrious Ancestors" well attest.

A good illustration of her poetic vision would be her poem, "Making Peace." The poem consists of five irregular stanzas. The first one of these describes the request of people living in a "dark" world that poets do their job properly and bring the "imagination of peace" for them. With the second stanza begins the poet's reply. Making peace, she says, is like the making of a poem. It is not just imagination; it is real. Just as grammar and syntax are ingredients to a poem, so peace requires justice and mutual aid (second stanza). It takes patience and time; it needs getting ready and meditation and comprehension (stanza three). It requires us to reconstruct our lives, revoke our profit and power motives, question our needs, and meditate long and well (stanza four). Then ideal peace may come, which is "not only the absence of war," as is portrayed in the last stanza: "A cadence of peace might balance its weight / on that different fulcrum; peace, a presence, / an energy field more intense than war, / might pulse then, / stanza by stanza into the world, / each act of living / one of its words, each word / a vibration of light ?facets / of the forming crystal." Here there is this subtle equation of poetry with life, of the making of poetry with the making of peace. It is the poet's belief that good poetry comes from a world enlightened and good. "You cannot," as she said in one 1983 interview, "make a good poem out of opinion and good intentions." You have to act, do well, and live well. To her poetry is light and harmony to a world of darkness and division, and poetic vision is a summoning of the ideal.

A lot of her poetry focuses on subjects of a more personal and more immediate nature. For example, there is the heart-warming interpersonal contact in "A Solitude," a poem which, in one interpretation, can be read as handling the interesting and intricate dialectics of solitude and community. The blind man lives at once in solitude and with his community. He envisions community in his solitude, and is a better and fuller person for that. "He knows where he is going" as a distinct individual. He is going nowhere because he stays forever with the community. His

mind is filled with the people and things of the world. Another subject of Levertov's is her gloomy view of marriage as shown in "The Ache of Marriage": it is an institution that hurts physically, offers no spiritual relief (as there is no union of minds), and will devour us like a monster with the help of its lure of "joy." We are in danger of submersion in the flood of pain: "the ark of the ache" will stay as long as would its biblical counterpart.

Levertov's perception of the difference between man and woman is another interesting thing to note about her. It is not quite feminist in nature but comes close to it. Both "Abel's Bride" and "Leaving Forever" talk about human fidelity, the former directly and the latter obliquely. "Abel's Bride" features a third-person observer. First this person talks about man: when a man leaves home, he forgets who he is and to whom he is committed ("No mirror nests in his pockets"). He is led by his hopes of new involvement and attachment. So the woman is afraid whenever he ventures out. For her own part, the woman never forgets her identity ("When she goes out / she looks in the glass"). She remembers her duty, remains her original, primitive self, deep and tolerant and receiving, and stays faithful to the "bones at the hearth" like a dog. She feels lucky that she sees marriage the way she does, but is sad about the uncertainty of her man. "Leaving Forever" is more direct in tone but less explicit in sense. It is about a man and woman leaving home by ship. They think of their departure differently:

He says the waves in the ship's wake
are like stones rolling away.
I don't see it that way.
But I see the mountain turning,
turning away its face as the ship
takes us away.

The man feels a happy relief at leaving the "stones" of commitment and obligation behind and at a possible new beginning (don't the stones roll away from the Easter tomb in the Bible?). But the woman is overcome with grief at the change: "the mountain" weeps as it is forsaken and forgotten. The woman sees herself identical with the mountain and feels sad that her man rejects and forgets so quickly. Levertov's stance is within a stone's throw of that of the feminists.

Robert Duncan (1919-1988) was an active supporter of Olson's views and became a unique poet of the "projective verse." There are a couple of things to know about Duncan in order to appreciate his poetry well. One concerns his ideas on poetry which include, among other things, his views of poetry as life-generating and of language with its regenerative possibilities to renew and reorder. Duncan believes that no single poem is ever complete in its meaning and that each poem awakens the possibility of a new beginning. Duncan is a love poet. There are quite a number of explicit sexual images in his poems. He holds that poetry is the soul of life, it is the means by which love is given and received, and life is love in its most perfect form. Love is holy. It involves loss and recovery. Hence in his poetry the recurring image of Atlantis as a paradise lost but regained through the effort of the poet. There is unified divine life in which the demonic is one with the divine. Another thing about Duncan is his acquaintance with a great number of writers and styles and his readiness to use and merge these skillfully in his own work. Duncan knew well the works and styles of Dante, Blake, Whitman, H. D. Gertrude Stein, Joyce, D. H. Lawrence, as well as Pound, William Carlos Williams, and Olson, and did well in integrating the best of these in his own poetry. His own style changes and ranges from the obvious to the most subtle. He can be difficult and allusive as Pound sometimes. In addition, he was drawn to and immersed in the study

of myths and ancient cultures, and took a great interest in mysticism, the magical, and the occult. He said somewhere in his *The Truth & Life of Myth: An Essay in Essential Autobiography* (1968) that fairy tales and myths were to remain the charged ground of his poetic reality. All through his career, Duncan believed in the truth of myth, and he used myths to define his function as a poet and the nature of poetry. In terms of style, Duncan was, as we noted a moment earlier, ever open to the diverse influences over him. Early in his career Duncan wrote some Modernist verse modeled on Gertrude Stein's style of creating a sense of discontinuity by means of inverting the word order and other linguistic possibilities. Then he turned to embrace Olson's theory of "projective verse," believing that poetry projects, as do movies, words, and syllables which pour out of the bosom of the poet. Duncan is a prolific writer. Some of his works include *Heavenly City Earthly City* (1947), *The Opening of the Field* (1960), which contains some of his best work like "A Poem Beginning with a Line by Pindar," *Passages* (1966), *Roots and Branches* (1964), *Bending the Bow* (1968), *Ground Work: Before the War* (1983), and *Ground Work?: In the Dark* (1987). His best poems include "Often I am Permitted to a Meadow," "Roots and Branches," "A Poem Beginning with a Line by Pindar," "Doves," and some others from his collection, *Passages*.

Now let's take a look at his "A Poem Beginning with a Line by Pindar." Most of the basic features of Duncan's work are present here. His genuine interest in the enduring power of myth, his concerns as a poet, and his vision of poetry as a vehicle of improving the lot of the people constitute the recurring leitmotif of the work. The underlying myth used here is the Greek story of Cupid and Psyche. The essential part of the story is Psyche's thirst for knowledge that brings her through a series of ordeals in her search for her lost love. Love is the essence of Psyche's and the poet's creative undertaking. The job of the poet is, as indicated in the poem, to pick up where his predecessors have left off and continue their work. Here in the poem we notice Duncan's reference to Whitman (a poet of love as can be seen from his "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd"), William Carlos Williams (a poet of love for life and for his country), and Ezra Pound (the basic theme of whose *Cantos*, and especially the *Pisan Cantos*, can be construed as an effort toward building an earthly paradise for men). The theme of the poem is clear that love, love that resides in the heart, addresses human problems. If all the presidents had been as loving and caring as Lincoln, the nation might have been free of the suffering, the strife, and the multitude of problems that have existed, and still do, relating to the human situation. Thus Psyche's search, identical with the poet's own and running parallel to it, becomes its apt metaphor. The poem is difficult as it is full of allusions very much like a Pound poem. There has to be source hunting first. Otherwise, the formal features of the work keep in line well with those of postmodern contemporary poetry.

CHAPTER 23 Postwar American Novel (I)

We are now entering the post-World War II period. So much has occurred since 1945 that recent American literature, dealing with the new experience, has acquired an imposing stature. The postwar prosperity produced a sense of optimism, which was, however, very soon vitiated by the "Cold War" between the powers. Crisis was impending. Chaos became institutionalized. A sense of life being absurd undercut the very existence of man. The life of the 1950s was poisoned at the root by McCarthyism, and that of the sixties enriched by the Civil Rights movement, the appearance of a counter culture, and an upsurge of feminism and feminist power. Whereas the Vietnam War weighed all the time on the consciousness of the people, life was complicated by violence, political or racial, including the assassinations of John F. Kennedy and Martin Luther

King. Everything seemed to be subjected to a prevailing skepticism. New advances in science and technology have given people an increasing sense of power, but have also further deprived life of its mysteries. The representation of the multifaceted life of postwar America has remained the reward and despair of the writers who began to publish after the war.

This is a very interesting period in the history of American literature, invigorated as it is with robust energy and bustling with creative activity. The new generation of authors have proved their newness and competence by a wide range of experimentation that would have dazzled even their brilliantly original predecessors like Faulkner and Hemingway. Ihab Hassan has noticed the variety of postwar fiction. His categories are clear though somewhat arbitrary. He has listed the war novel, the southern novel, the Jewish novel, the Beat novel and alienation, the Black novel, and satire and the novel of manners, which came to public notice in the years from the end of the war through 1960. And the period after that has been one in which American fiction is noted for its fantasy and surrealism, its nonfiction, science fiction, black or absurd humor, parody and pop, and its experimental novelistic techniques. Tony Tanner has kept his attention on the development of original narrative techniques and the exploration of new fictional areas in contemporary literature. There have been achievements, as he observes, like Saul Bellow's social-psychological comedies, Norman Mailer's provocative experiments, and John Barth's brilliant "fun-house." Themes such as the tyranny of society, the subjugation of the individual, the quest for self-identity, and the self-indulgence of the writer in relation to his environment have become the concern of many contemporary authors. Some of these people have achieved a measure of recognition, others are still struggling, and all are doing their best to contribute to "the great American Novel" as Norman Mailer calls it, or "the bright book of life," to borrow from Alfred Kazin.

Let us now take a more detailed look at the postwar literary scene. As the period is still in progress and the list of names and titles is alarmingly long, we will do well to choose a few out of this impressive multitude. We begin with the novel. Talking about the authors of his generation, Norman Mailer stated some years ago that, in his opinion, there were about twenty good writers in contemporary America. Since he did not specify any names, his list became everybody's guess. We may venture to suggest that Saul Bellow should be on the top of the list. Then coming down the column, there should be Norman Mailer, J. D. Salinger, Joseph Heller, Kurt Vonnegut, Jr., John Barth, Thomas Pynchon, and of course Nabokov. We naturally think of other novelists whose works have impressed the postwar reading public. These include, among others, Bernard Malamud, John Updike, John Cheever, Ken Kesey, Flannery O'Connor, Philip Roth, Donald Barthelme, Jack Kerouac, John Hawkes, William Gaddis, E. L. Doctorow, William Styron, Truman Capote, and Joyce Carol Oates. As such a short list tends to mislead, the readers' own discretion is advised.

Critical consensus suggests that Saul Bellow (1915-) is about the best-known writer of his generation. Born into a Russian Jewish family in Canada, he grew up in Chicago. His first book, *Dangling Man*, was published in 1944, and for over half a century now, he has written a good number of novels, short stories and plays, and won a good number of awards. After *The Victim* (1947), he published *The Adventures of Augie March* (1953), which won the first of his three National Book Awards. In 1956 *Seize the Day* came out, to be followed by *Henderson the Rain King* (1959). In 1960 he won the Friends of Literature Fiction Award. His next book, *Herzog* (1964), received four awards: the James L. Dow Award, the National Book Award, the Formentor Award, and the International Literature Prize (1965), and has been seen by many as his

masterpiece. It made his reputation as a significant figure in contemporary American fiction. His collection of short stories, *Mosby's Memoirs* (1968) was awarded the French Croix de Chevalier des Arts et Lettres, and *Mr. Sammler's Planet* (1970) won his third National Book Award (1971). *Humboldt's Gift* appeared in print in 1975, and *The Dean's December* and *More Die of Heartbreak* respectively in 1982 and 1987. *The Bellarosa Connection* (a novella) and *A Theft* came out in 1989 and *Something to Remember Me By* in 1991. Saul Bellow also wrote some plays, one of which, *The Last Analysis* (1964), ran on Broadway through 28 performances. His career reached its exciting climax in 1976 when he was awarded the Pulitzer Prize and the Nobel Prize for Literature. Thus he has become, in the words of Leslie Fiedler, the emerging heir to the Hemingway-Faulkner prestige.

Saul Bellow's basic themes are essentially three-fold: First, he views contemporary society as a threat to human life and human integrity. Modern civilization tends to dehumanize, making people lose their distinction and turning them into what he calls "fat goods." Material affluence distracts and produces a sense of alienation. Then, living in such an environment, people tend to become paranoid, high-strung, and impotent, and so lose their sanity. Bellovian characters suffer most from a kind of psychosis. They go through a phase before they regain their mental balance and serenity. Finally, there is the quest motif, a quest for truth and values, difficult, excruciating, but successful in a way. To Saul Bellow, the human search for affirmation should end happily, and people should see light at the end of the tunnel. His fictional world is full of people both tragic and comic, but happy in the end. He is a very human writer indeed.

Saul Bellow is keenly aware of his Jewish heritage. He reminds his readers in ways subtle or apparent that his characters are Jews. The Jewish condition offers a valid metaphor for Bellow to talk about human existence. The Jews are God's chosen people as they feel themselves, but are often rejected by the community at large. The awareness of being the chosen intensifies the agony of the rejection. Thus the sense of alienation they feel is identical coincides with that of the general humanity in contemporary society. By dramatizing the Jewish dilemma, Saul Bellow succeeds in adumbrating the human condition in general.

Saul Bellow's strength lies in his faith in man and man's ability to offer "a spirited resistance to the forces of our time" (as he puts it). His works are in essence affirmatively humanistic. As he sees it, modern man has lived through frustration and defeat, managed to grapple with destructive historical pressures, and striven for "certain durable human goods" ?truth, freedom, and wisdom. Bellow writes with the confidence that he is acting "the culture figure," making explicit the implicit thoughts of the people, and expressing their common needs and preoccupations. Most of Saul Bellow's heroes are Jewish intellectuals or writers who, facing violence and victimization, try to discover "the queerness of existence" and overcome it. Very often a Bellovian protagonist, Tommy Wilhelm (*Seize the Day*), or Asa Leventhal (*The Victim*), or Augie March, or Herzog, is found in a situation which involves a good deal of "suffering, feebleness, servitude," and is seen behaving in an impotent, tragicomic way. Moving in his cold and apathetic world, his impotence makes his life ignominious and absurd. The wretchedness of his existence is so overwhelming that one wonders how he can struggle through the quagmire of despair. However, Saul Bellow feels that "on nobler assumptions, man should have at least sufficient power to overcome ignominy and to complete his own life." So his novels usually end on an affirmative note. It is not always a happy ending, but it is an ending which calls for hope more than despair. Thus although Asa Leventhal, the "social" victim, is in part instrumental in creating his own unhappy condition, his

ordeal helps to bring out his humanity and alleviate his suffering. And Tommy Wilhelm, who ends up, after an impossible day, in a Jewish funeral service, manages to wash away in his tears a part ?if not all ?of his sorrow and to be able to breathe again: The world carries on as before, as cold and indifferent as ever, but there is observable in Wilhelm a subtle transformation which ensures his future survival.

Then there is Augie March, the Jew, who, though battered by "rough forces," yet remains a "laughing creature, forever rising up." The world in which Augie March finds himself is a harsh one. From his boyhood onward, there have existed forces trying to manipulate him, and Augie's life has been a constant rejection of any effort to place him in a certain pigeonhole. He has got to discover his own "identity" and define it in his own terms. He wants to become what he would like himself to be, though his problem has always been that he does not know exactly what it is that he would like to be. So he is seen running away from anything which would pin him down in an established mode of life. He never hesitates to let wealth slip off his fingers if wealth appears to be a trap to him. The world does not allow him to live as he pleases, and as he is unable to settle for "a fate good enough," he never finds "the right thing to do." He is born to be a victim of the social forces from which he cannot get away. He keeps dreaming. He envisions marrying a lovely wife and doing some farming and bee-keeping on a "private green place." This pastoral ideal of his never comes true. Augie starts wondering whether he is "a man of hope or foolishness," and may never be able to make to the realization that he is both: he is foolish because he is hopeful. In a sense Augie's problem is archetypal of modern Western man. Modern civilization has made it virtually impossible to keep one's individual identity. The Adventures of Augie March made quite a stir on the literary scene when it was first published. Critics agree that it has continued the picaresque tradition of *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*.

If Augie March is forever on the move, escaping into an ever new circumstance, Moses Herzog retreats into his intricate consciousness for peace and tranquility. Herzog is an unemployed professor of physics, descended from unsuccessful Russian Jewish immigrant parents. At the age of 47 he looks old, with wrinkles and graying hair. He is going through a harrowing phase of life in which nothing is working out the way it should. His family life is frustrating, and so is his personal life, which he sees as a sheer waste. Divorced from his young wife Madeleine, and fighting for the custody of his daughter, June, he is for a while mentally disturbed. He begins to write letters which he does not intend to mail out. He writes to both the living and the dead ?friends, acquaintances, celebrities, and leaders. His discussions in these letters range over a wide variety of subjects such as the intolerable social iniquity which is driving him out of his mind, poverty, unemployment, social unrest, political hysteria, industrial pollution, racial conflicts, crime, violence, and the appalling suffering that exists on all conceivable levels of life. All these seem to keep assailing his sanity and threatening to throw him off his mental balance. He meditates very much and acts very little. He wishes for a morally higher life, but fails to define it as an ideal. For instance, he thinks of giving up all his possessions to help the poor, and of persuading others to do the same. He would like to see a new relationship between people, which would put an end to alienation. But the reality as he sees it is ruthless. To him human values are disintegrating. He is concerned about the development of man and his civilization, and is ambitious enough to plan a big book on social progress, but he finds it impossible to carry out his project because life has gone wrong. Unable to endure the mental torment any longer, Herzog despairs. The real issue has to do, however, with his post-divorce neurosis, the bitter memory of his recent past which weighs

him down every day. He feels mad at the way Madeleine has manipulated and then dumped him for his one-time friend Valentine Gersbach. He hears his little girl June crying at the back seat of their car. And he is mortified that he has treated his first wife Daisy badly. He suffers so much that he is afraid that he may go crazy. He writes letters endlessly and fanatically, and keeps moving from place to place with his valise full of papers just so that he may find some breathing space. On one occasion he goes with a gun to seek out Madeleine and Valentine, but backs down, moved at a glimpse of Valentine giving little June a bath. His heart softens. After spending a day with his little girl (which ends up in an accident) and a night in jail for carrying a gun, he begins to see his own weakness and the positive side of things. He allows himself to sink into the healthy influence of nature at his Ludeyville home, admits to his craziness, and recovers his full sanity. Hence the opening sentence of the book: "If I am out of my mind, it's all right with me, thought Moses Herzog."

Herzog undergoes a significant change in his personality and his way of perception. We see a gradual but clear movement from restlessness to tranquility, from cold and icy feelings to warm recollections of the past and joyful contact with child and nature, and from a negative outlook to an attitude of affirmation. At the beginning Herzog is intensely unhappy. He complains about everybody and about everything. He feels that Madeleine, Valentine, and Madeleine's mother are all scheming against him; the lawyers and friends and the policemen are not helping; the city is impersonal and stifling; society and its pressures, or what he calls Moha, are encroaching upon individuality; and even Ramona, the woman who loves him dearly, is suspect of looking for a husband. He complains about all except himself. He broods a lot and is capable of genuine suffering. In face of what he sees as a disintegration of man and his culture, he feels a huge sense of responsibility and launches out as a Messiah figure: "The revolutions of the twentieth century, the liberation of the masses by production, created private life but gave nothing to fill it with. This was where such as he came in. The progress of civilization ?indeed, the survival of civilization ?depended on the successes of Moses E. Herzog." He sees himself as the man on whom the world depends to do certain intellectual work, change history, and influence the development of civilization. The lengthy letters that he wrote all indicate his desire for improvement of the human condition.

However, he could not hope to save anybody before he saves himself. He has to touch ground and place himself under close scrutiny. The process of self-analysis has been going on even when he is at his most neurotic. All the time he is raving against everyone, his yearning mind harks back to a point of time in childhood when his loving parents offered him love and faith in human fellowship: the scene of his mother pulling him on a sled over crusty ice one January evening is always heart warming. And he frequently thinks of his brothers, Shura and Will, and his family as a whole. Family and love furnish the basis for his self-awakening. All the time he is cursing the rest of the world, he reminisces about Daisy, his first wife, whom he feels bad having mistreated somehow. This can be the beginning of his self-searching. Even before he regains full sanity, he begins to see the futility of his letter-writing, and begins to feel the warmth of humanity. However, all these remain in the form of undercurrents until the accident jostles him finally out of his dreamy state. Then he discovers his inadequacy as a human being. He has hurt the child, and he might have had himself killed. He is now thinking positive, seeing positive things in people, and beginning to forgive and love even his foes, Madeleine and Gersbach. He comes to realize his problem: "[C]ivilized individuals hate and resent the civilization that makes their lives possible.

What they love is an imaginary human situation invented by their own genius and which they believe is the only true and the only human reality. How odd!" He recognizes his ingratitude to people and to life in general. Now he is accepting life for what it is. Withdrawing to his Ludeyville home, he merges into nature. He walks in the woods, picks flowers for his table, fills his hat with rambler vine, stretches out on his Recamier couch, and listens to the rhythmical scratching of the house cleaner. Everything makes good sense now. He decides to stop writing. He has no more massages for anyone. "Nothing. Not a single word." He feels contented.

It is interesting to note that Herzog's change is, in a sense, archetypal of the change in the temper of the times. The 1950s and 1960s witnessed a transformation on the literary scene from Modernism to Postmodernism. This manifested itself in both thematic and formal terms. Thematically, there is, between the two phases of literary creation, a difference in attitude toward life. The modernists tend to impose shape and significance on life with which they feel at odds, while the postmodernists accept life for what it is, chaotic and contingent as it is, and try to make sense of it for survival. In formal aspects, modernist writings tend to be ponderously retrospective, often full of interior monologues or stream of consciousness features, relegating story interest to a secondary place. Postmodernist writings, however, while feeling free to borrow technically from modernist works, feel equally free to borrow from every other mode of writing that serves their purpose (in addition to their own unique creative features). Herzog reflects both aspects well. It is basically a stream of consciousness work, especially in the first two thirds of the book. There is a lot of Mrs. Dalloway in Herzog, a lot of thinking without much plot interest. Although told mostly in the third-person point of view, the narrative filters through Herzog's mind so that we come away with the impression that Herzog is thinking and telling his story. The prose movement is intriguing in this section (about five of the nine chapters). It is agonizingly slow. For instance, Herzog is going to visit Ramona. From the time he decides to go in chapter one, up to the time he arrives in chapter five, he meditates or writes letters most of the time except for his visit to a friend, Libbie. He reminisces about his divorce with Madeleine, about Daisy, about the war and Paris, about his parents and childhood, and about Sono, his Japanese mistress, before he arrives at Ramona's at long last. In the last third of the book, the narrative pace quickens, with more action, less thought, denoting Herzog's movement away from self-immersion to closer contact with reality and final acceptance of it.

Saul Bellow's quest as a literary artist is essentially for the human. He is highly critical of modern life in which the old value system is no longer functioning. His major characters, Herzog, for instance, or Mr. Sammler, or Humboldt, are all concerned to find a way that would keep American civilization from going under. They represent Bellow's vision of disoriented modern man in an urban society where humanism is under determining pressures. They body forth Bellow's credo that art aims at achieving stillness in the midst of chaos, and that a novelist, beginning with disorder and disharmony, goes toward order by "an unknown process of the imagination." Indeed, Saul Bellow's ambition is to be a social historian. He places emphasis on the truthful representation of life, and writes in the realistic tradition in which Flaubert, Stendhal, Tolstoy, and Dreiser wrote. He also draws from the modernist tradition in his creative work. His vision of the world as being chaotic and absurd and of modern man's impotence in face of life, the existentialist ideas which his works reveal, and his use of subtle techniques in exploring the subconscious of his characters ?all this places him alongside such modern masters as James Joyce and Marcel Proust. And there is an obvious postmodern element in his works. The bridging of the

traditions of Realism and Modernism with Postmodernism has put Saul Bellow at the center of contemporary American literary experience. Bellow is perhaps the most prominent living American novelist in vision as well as in volume of productivity. He has produced a significant body of work which has already impacted American fiction visibly. He has transcended the Jewish label and reached general humanity well. He will be remembered as one of those whose works have helped people to stay more alert to their situation.

One of the most ambitious writers of this period is perhaps Norman Mailer (1923-), who has, by virtue of his enormous imagination and immense literary output, become part of the American consciousness. It was at Harvard that Mailer first decided to become a major American author. He joined the war against Japan in 1944 partly because he was obsessed with the idea to write a big war book. He volunteered as a rifleman with a reconnaissance platoon fighting in the Philippine Mountains. From there he wrote his wife four to five letters a week packed with voluminous notes just in case that, if he could not survive the war, his novel would. *The Naked and the Dead*, for this was the title of his first book, became a spectacular success in 1948. The critical world was thrilled at the prospect that a new major writer was emerging on the horizon. However, popular enthusiasm for Mailer cooled down after a time. The reception of his second book, *Barbary Shore* (1951), was not all favorable, and that of his third, *The Deer Park* (1955), was lukewarm, to say the most. Although he continued to write and the critical world continued to keep an eye on him, no serious extensive study of his works occurred until 1968 when *The Armies of the Night* received the National Book Award, the Pulitzer Prize and the Polk Award, and brought him the largest reading audience of any single book since *The Naked and the Dead*. Then came *Marilyn: A Novel Biography* (1973), and *The Executioner's Song* (1979) which won him the Pulitzer Prize for the second time. Other works that have appeared in print in the last two decades include *Ancient Evening* (1983), *Tough Guys Don't Dance* (1984), *Harlot's Ghost* (1991), and *The Gospel According to the Son* (1997). Mailer also wrote *Advertisements for Myself* (1959), *An American Dream* (1965), *Why Are We In Vietnam?* (1967), *Miami and the Siege of Chicago* (1968), *Existential Errands* (1972), and *Genius and Lust* (1976). In addition, Mailer is renowned for one important essay he wrote in 1957, entitled "The White Negro," in which he defines his notion of "the existential hero." With his canon solidly established, Mailer has become the focus of some critical attention. Critical opinion is divided. Some are sympathetic, a few decidedly hostile, but all seem to agree that he is a remarkable literary figure on the postwar scene.

Mailer is a multi-faceted talent. He is a philosopher-metaphysician, a poet, a playwright, a filmmaker, a journalist, a politician, and a performer, in addition to being a novelist. Although he has always been outspoken about himself, he remains, in large measure, an enigma yet to be solved. Mailer called himself a chameleon, and he was perceptive enough to see himself that way, for no other word can reveal the nature of his career and his vision half as clearly. Mailer engages in too many polarities, almost squandering his aesthetic talent and creative power in too many genres. His ideas change quickly, and so does his style. A man of apparently prodigious imagination and energy, he remains restless and fluid, both signs of the fact that he has yet to acquire a vision clear enough for him to be surer of himself. It is true that some critics see Mailer's quick-changing art as an asset to the author's genius. It is an attempt on Mailer's part, they feel, to make realistic literature catch up with the rate of change in American life. There may be truth here.

Norman Mailer's first book, *The Naked and the Dead*, is probably still his best work. It tells the story of a fourteen-man platoon that lands on the barren beach of Anopopei, a small

Japanese-held island in the South Pacific. The platoon is part of a six-thousand-man force deployed to seize control of the island and prepare the way for a larger American move into the Philippines. The characters include a Mississippi farmer, a Jew from Brooklyn, a Mexican-American, a west Texas rancher, a laborer from the coal mines of Montana, an Irishman from South Boston's working class, a Kansas salesman, a Chicago hoodlum, and a hedonist from Georgia. It is apparent that Mailer intends them to constitute a microcosmic portrait of the American populace. General Edward Cummings assigns to his staff officer, Lieutenant Robert Hearn, the task of landing the platoon in the jungle south of Anopopei on a reconnaissance mission behind the Toyaku Line. Midway in the patrol's incursion, Private Wilson is shot in the belly, and of the four men who attempt to carry him back to safety, two give up in exhaustion and the other two take him over muddy hills, across baked fields and through the suffocating jungle, where he ultimately dies. The patrol goes forward on its slow and perilous journey, in the course of which Lieutenant Hearn and Corporal Roth meet their doom. The ruthless Sergeant Sam Croft drives the men onward up Mount Anaka. Just as they are about to attain the summit, a nest of hornets explodes upon them, and they fall down the mountain slope. Meanwhile, in the absence of General Cummings, Major Dalleson orders a battalion through a breach in the Toyaku Line, and destroys a major Japanese supply depot and the secret Japanese headquarters that houses General Toyaku and his staff. The novel's climax is a victory for the U.S. Army, but a personal defeat for Cummings. His masterful battle plan ends in nothing. The men of the reconnaissance group rejoin their regiment.

Mailer has been thought of as one of the American naturalist writers. This is true of his early works that appeared before the 1960s. The prose of *The Naked and the Dead* recalls the clarity and precision of Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath*, and the stance Mailer takes toward his characters resembles that of John Dos Passos in his trilogy *U. S. A.* In the naturalistic world, the individual is prey to certain forces over which he has no control. These forces are biological, social or geographical. The universe of *The Naked and the Dead* is a cold, indifferent, wanton cosmos where man labors only to die, and God takes no interest in his welfare. In opposition to this deterministic universe, three men try to define themselves: Croft, Cummings, and Hearn. They are committed to defining themselves by their own inner lights, rather than in accordance with any exterior measure. Their lives are existential. General Cummings uses his brilliant mind primarily for self-aggrandizement, and Sergeant Sam Croft is obsessed with finding a channel for unrealized power. Hearn, on the other hand, makes no effort to seek power. Though unable to have his own way, he never concedes defeat to powers that be. He is an alien in his world.

The experimental feature of the novel merits attention. Mailer wedges "chorus" and "the time machine" adroitly into his otherwise normal narrative. "Chorus" appears five times in the whole story, recording fragments of the soldiers' conversations. The locales of these chats vary from mess tents, trenches, lavatories, and camping sites. They reflect the soldiers' thoughts and attitudes. "Choruses" are generally short, roundabout one printed page. "The time machine" appears ten times. They offer the biographical sketches of the major characters, about ten in number, such as Cummings, Hearn, and Croft. The sketches describe their looks, personalities, environments of growing up, work experiences before the war etc., which serve to add to and annotate the main story line. These pieces are actually short stories, vivacious, exuberant, and entertaining with their separate narratives, dialogues, and characterizations. Between them the "chorus" and "the time machine" constitute a foil and a footnote to the whole narrative endeavor.

On a different ?the linguistic ?level, these interpolations or flashbacks bring an animated novelty and help dispel any possible sense of monotony and dullness that a massive book like this might generate in the readers.

Examining the will of the individual in relation to contextual restraints in microscopic detail, *The Naked and the Dead* has been hailed as the finest novel in English to come out of World War ?. Critic Stanley Rinehart set the keynote for many reviewers when he compared the novel with such famous books as Dos Passos' *Three Soldiers* and Hemingway's *A Farewell to Arms*.

In addition to this classic, Mailer is well known as an innovator of the nonfiction novel. Over the years the notion of "totalizing" experience in the traditional form has gone through some drastic change. The Mailer who at one time said that any great American novel would have to be about WW ? has with the passage of time changed his mind and his style of writing. Beginning with his *Advertisements for Myself*, *Presidential Papers*, and his novel, *An American Dream* (1965), Mailer has experimented with a new way of writing, which presents fantasy and fact with equal emphasis, interlocking the story of a fictional character with that of a real person. *An American Dream* still employs fictive methods, but it deals with subjects more appropriate for journalism. This is Mailer's way of contributing to the novel in the new period, or his way of catching up and coping with the upsurge of new novel-writing experience. In *Why Are We in Vietnam?* ?the work that would establish Mailer as a pioneer of the genre, fictional narrative and actual events claim equal attention and space. *The Armies of the Night* uses fictional strategies to represent the actual protest against the government. It is a novelistic description of his personal experience in the 1967 anti-Vietnam War march on the Pentagon. Mailer employs a third-person narrative to tell a story in which he becomes the protagonist, a character in the narrative. Norman Mailer writing about Norman Mailer in the third person offered him new ways of presenting history in the form of a novel and creating a novel as history. Hence the subtitle of the book, "The Novel as History, History as a Novel." It also made it easier for him to view contemporary events with distance and irony while bringing closer the two genres of fiction and autobiography and the two identities of novelist and reporter. The sense of immediacy and straightforwardness which the book was able to engender exerted a good deal of influence on literary journalism, a style of writing later known as "The New Journalism." This quasi-journalistic way of writing develops further in his *Marilyn: A Novel Biography* and *The Executioner's Song*. Take *The Executioner's Song* for example. This is a document done in the form of a novel, recording the life and execution of the Utah murderer Gary Gilmore. Mailer drew on hundreds of interviews with people involved in the case, and also on the records of the murder case. The documentary that resulted from the effort is panoramic; the literary resources which the author brought in play are numerous, including the amazing number of speakers and the multiple points of view. It is an altogether provocative nonfiction narrative dumped upon the American literary sensibility of the time. The encasing of actual reportage in a novelistic framework represents, in a way, a form of change which the traditional novel has probably had to undergo in the contemporary period.

Norman Mailer has been talking for some decades now about the ultimate novel or the large social novel that he will write for his time. He would like to make a revolution in the consciousness of his historical period. He said as far back as his *Advertisements for Myself* that his present and future work would have the deepest influence of any work being done by an American novelist in these years. Prolific and prominent, he has been credited, among other things, for his spirit of nonconformity in style and for the fact that his work constitutes an authentic

representation of the volatility of American life itself. Mailer has written a page for himself in his country's literary history.

J.D. Salinger (1919-) is a unique writer for a couple of reasons. He wrote one novel and became famous for it. Then, for the last few decades now ever since 1953, he has been a recluse in his New Hampshire home, refusing interviews or any other forms of contact with the press and the world outside. He has been writing little, and his presence and his writing have been both eagerly sought for. One of his letters was auctioned for \$156 000. It is amazing that the public has kept up such a continual interest in him, and he has been able to stay in evidence forever. Some people say that his seclusion has increased both his popularity and the sales of his works. Now over eighty years old, he remains still very much of an enigma to his readers.

Salinger was born into a Jewish middle class family in New York City. As a child, he was shy and unsociable. He entered Valley Forge Military Academy at 15 and felt out of place there. He was literary editor of a journal at the academy, and began writing stories. The academy became the prototype for Pencey, the high school, in *The Catcher in the Rye*, and some aspects of Holden's life were to replicate some of young Salinger's experience there: A classmate was expelled, another jumped to his death from a building, and he was the head of the fencing team at the academy. After graduation, he attended a short-story writing class at Columbia University, and published his first story "The Young Folks" in the *Story* magazine. This was the first time Salinger dealt with the subject of a boy thrown into the adult world to shift for himself. From 1941 he began to contribute to famous magazines like *Collier's* and *Esquire*, and placed his short story "Slight Rebellion off Madison" in *The New Yorker*. Another short story, "I'm Crazy," came out in print in the same time period. Both stories introduced Holden Caulfield, the main character in *The Catcher in the Rye* (1951), and both were revised for later inclusion in the novel. Two years after the novel came out, Salinger published his *Nine Stories*, a collection of short stories, some themes and characters of which, especially the Glass family, kept recurring in some of his later works. *Franny and Zooey* (1961) is a good example. It is a story about the youngest member of the Glass family, Franny, and her brother Zooey. The story of the Glass family also continues into the book, *Raise High the Roof Beam, Carpenters*; and *Seymour: An Introduction* (1963), a collection of two novellas.

Salinger's one novel, *The Catcher in the Rye*, has been definitely a very influential book to come out of the postwar period. It relates the painful story of a high-school boy growing up in the world of decadent New York. A common saying about adolescents in the West is, "They are going through a phase." Although many have written about this phase of life, few have done so with such an awareness of the intensity of suffering and depression it involves as does J.D. Salinger in his *The Catcher in the Rye*. Young Holden Caulfield is expelled from school because of poor academic performance. Afraid to meet his parents earlier than they should expect him, he checks himself into a New York City hotel that crawls with prostitutes and "queers." Soon he becomes aware that the world of adults is a "phony" one, and that he is surrounded by "jerks" of all kinds. His first night in New York ends in a bitter quarrel with a pimp who cheats him out of his pocket and beats him up. The next morning proves dull and spiritless. The day moves on slowly, sad and weary. A meeting with a friend ends with another quarrel; drinking with an old acquaintance does little to improve his mood. He gets drunk and feels depressed and lonesome. Night falls. Holden sneaks back home to see his kid sister Phoebe. She is a loving kid, but her talk about their father

"killing" him sickens him, and he thinks of an ex-schoolmate jumping out of the window and lying dead on the stone steps. Creeping out of home, he goes to his former teacher, Mr. Antolini, the one person who takes any interest in him and who he feels he can trust, only to find that the man is a homosexual. His second night in New York thus ends with a hasty escape from Antolini's house. Christmas is coming, but Holden feels himself sinking. Now he is thinking of going west and spending the rest of his life there. He goes to say good-bye to Phoebe who, to his dismay, insists on going with him. This unexpected act of love jostles him out of his dream and his nightmarish three-day adventure in New York. He goes home, falls ill, and recovers and convalesces in a psychiatric ward in California. It is there that he recounts his sad story of growing up in *The Catcher in the Rye*.

The novel depicts in eloquent language an adolescent's disgust and despair at the fallen state of the adult world around him. It is a world of jerks and perverts, a salient feature of which is its decadence. The hotel in which he stays, with its prostitution and all forms of sexual perversity, is to Holden the miniature of a larger space in which he is probably the only normal person. It is here that he begins, subconsciously, to lose his own innocence. He is assailed with an acute sense of not belonging anywhere, an intense anxiety of placelessness which is well illustrated in his seemingly childish concern for the whereabouts of the ducks in the lagoon of New York City's Central Park: The idea of having nowhere to go and belong haunts young Holden and generates a sense of alienation and despair in him. It is no wonder, then, that during his tramping in and out of the bars and hotels of New York City, he cries out in anguish for some thirty times that he is "damned lonesome and depressed"; about five times he either expresses a death-wish or thinks of death; and for once at least he contemplates suicide in a serious way. He hates the "phony," evil, crooked and cruel world of adults. He would not like to grow and change: The Egyptian mummies in the museum appeal to him because they remain the same. He would not like to work and live the way adults do, and he would take no interest in science, law, or anything in a world where life is wrong, and where one cannot find a place that is nice and peaceful because there is not any.

If there are ever any moments in his stay in New York City which help in anyway to light up the ambient gloom, these relate mostly to children and the thought of innocence. It is really the innocence of children and reminiscences of childhood experiences that have ultimately saved Holden from despair and doom. Realizing, only faintly maybe, that all kids like him are in danger of losing their innocence, he wishes to be a "catcher in the rye." Explaining this to his kid sister Phoebe, he says that he has kept envisioning thousands of little children playing in a field of rye, without any adult around except him standing on the edge of a cliff, just so as to catch anyone if they start to go over the cliff. He tells her that when the kids are running and do not look where they are going, there is the danger of falling and he has to be there to catch them. What he really means is that he would stand there and save the unsuspecting children from losing their childhood integrity and goodness. As he knows that it is impossible to do, he calls himself crazy.

When it first came out in 1951, *The Catcher in the Rye* became an immediate success. It has been especially popular with the postwar young generation who have found in Holden an approximation of their own experience. Holden represents a social type of adolescents thrown upon themselves in a corrupt and decadent world. It is a critical look at the problems facing American youth during the 1950s. These are delineated in Holden's psychological battles, his depression, nervous breakdown, sexual exploration, confrontation with vulgarity and other erratic behavior, his typical adolescent mood swings and denial, and the conspicuous absence of parental

and social understanding and guidance. Holden serves as a mirror for his peers. There is a lot in him with which the young can identify readily. Much of Holden's candid outlook on life is still relevant to the youth of today and contains a truth of an eternal nature. The fact that the boy is lonely, bewildered, and pitiful, his troubles, his failings, even his minor delinquencies, and his howling for help still find warm echoes among the young because these represent pretty much of their own situation. This accounts for the book's continual popularity. It has been read and reread by millions across the world. The book's success has also to do with its superb handling of language. Salinger's rendering of teenage speech is wonderful: the unconscious humor, the repetitions, the slang and profanity, and the emphasis are all managed just right. His thoughtful and sympathetic insight into adolescence and adulthood, his unobtrusive symbolism, and his insistent avoiding of slogans and cliché—all these add considerably to the spectacular achievement of the novel.

J.D. Salinger is still writing. So far his reputation seems to rest chiefly on this earlier book and will probably do the way Ralph Ellison will on his *Invisible Man*.

Next we come to Bernard Malamud (1914-1986) who has been regarded as one of the major writers of the Jewish group in the postwar period. His works, except his first book, *The Natural* (1952), are all about Jews and their lives. These include his novels *The Assistant* (1957), *A New Life* (1963), *The Fixer* (1966), *The Tenants* (1971), *Pictures of Fidelman* (1974), *Dubin's Lives* (1979), *God's Grace* (1982), and his posthumous *The People* (1989), and collections of his short stories, *The Magic Barrel* (1958), *Idiot's First* (1963), and *Rembrandt's Hat* (1968). As a major 20th-century writer, Malamud helped introduce marginal ethnic culture to mainstream America.

Malamud was basically an autobiographical writer. He converted the facts of his Jewish life and immigrant background into imaginary fiction. Thus, for instance, his parents' Brooklyn grocery store is immortalized as the setting for *The Assistant*; *A New Life* reproduces his teaching experiences at Oregon State University; and his life as a literary artist finds expression in *Pictures of Fidelman*. Malamud's characters—a professor, or a fixer, or an aging writer, or a rabbinical student, or an assistant—are all learning about life and struggling to survive with dignity. They grow as they strive for self-improvement and become morally better human beings. To Malamud, a Jew is a good person. One does not have to be one of the Jewish race and faith to be a Jew. Everyone is a Jew in the sense that the Jewish condition is universal to all mankind. Malamud wrote for a purpose. The pattern is generally that out of suffering and despair come epiphany and eventual growth. People learn wisdom, accept responsibility, and become more loving and tolerant. Malamud once said, "My work, all of it, is an idea of dedication to the human. That's basic to every book... I'm in defense of the human."

A typical Malamud narrative, *The Assistant*, is a heart-warming story. Morris Bober, a Jewish immigrant, runs a small grocery store in Brooklyn, New York City, and lives a poor life with his wife Ida and daughter Helen. Business is slack, life is weary, and the only comfort for him is to look forward to taking his after-lunch nap. One night, two robbers rush in and hurt him on the head. Some time later, a poor young Italian, Frankie Alpine by name, comes along to beg for a job. Though most reluctant, Morris agrees to take him in as an assistant. Frankie works hard, but Ida and Helen do not like the idea of a gentile living among them. One day Frankie is caught stealing from the cash register and has to leave. The tiny grocery store is losing ground in face of the competition of a newer, bigger store, and then Morris is hospitalized. Frankie comes back in, saying that he owes to Morris Bober. Running the grocery store by day, the young man works at a

coffee shop at night so as to keep the store alive. When Morris returns home, Frankie confesses that he was one of the two robbers. Morris, not surprised, says that he knows it. But as he cannot forgive Frankie for stealing in the shop, he dismisses him again. Then Morris dies of pneumonia, and Frankie comes back again to help with the business and the family. He behaves more and more like Morris. Later he becomes a Jew.

The Assistant successfully portrays a good old Jew, Morris Bober, kind, honest, compassionate, and capable of helping people regenerate with his "Jewishness." Morris embodies the notion that love is a moral responsibility. He knows he has to suffer, and knows he does so for a purpose. So he never gives up hope and faith in adversity. Morris is the archetype of the suffering Jew. Suffering is one major feature of his life. He suffers to atone for humankind. He falls in business, but rises in moral and spiritual stature to which Frankie's new birth is convincing testimony. Malamud reveals his consummate skill when he makes the best of the tension between optimism and pessimism, and between hope and despair. There is gloom, but there is also the light of humor to help alleviate it.

Another novel for which Malamud is noted is *The Fixer*, which won both the Pulitzer Prize and the National Book Award for him. Its protagonist, Yakov Bok, is the very image of the suffering Jew. The story is set in anti-Semite Czarist Russia. Young Yakov grew up in an orphanage: his mother died of childbirth, and his father was killed in a pogrom. He is pessimistic about life, and hides his identity as a Jew. He serves in the Russian army, and learns Russian, history, science, geography, and arithmetic. He works hard, and hopes for a better life. Living in his village, Yakov feels miserable and imprisoned; even his wife leaves him. So he sets out for Kiev to get to know about the world. On one occasion he saves a brickwork owner from being smothered in the snow, and becomes his handyman. Somehow at the workplace he incurs the ill will of a superior, and is later falsely accused of ritual murder of a Christian boy. He receives inhuman treatment in prison: impossible food, beaten by fellow prisoners, narrowly escaping death by poisoning, and chained like an animal. He goes on a hunger strike, howls at the injustice against him, and argues in vain in self-defense. He refuses to succumb to the powers that be and makes no false confessions. He knows he is innocent; it is the Czarist government looking for anti-Semite excuses that deliberately confuses facts with religious prejudices and prosecutes him on false testimonies. One sympathetic magistrate is found dead; one attorney is determined to convict him. Yakov keeps his faith in himself. Despite the incredible suffering he experiences in prison, he reads, meditates, and communicates with the few people he knows. He begins to understand the meaning of responsibility and accept suffering as a way of identifying himself as a Jew and as a human being. He learns to see life in a different light: he learns to feel and be responsible for his fellow creatures, friend or foe. He becomes a symbol for the people, one of love for freedom and justice and for humanity.

The Fixer is good in formal terms. Essentially a realistic work, the novel glimmers with occasional flashes of romantic expression. For instance, the imaginary scene of the face-to-face argument between Yakov and the Czar is a tour de force that contributes well to Yakov's characterization. Furthermore, although based on the facts of history, Malamud's book places emphasis elsewhere. It is not history, but the process of revelation and growth through a nightmarish experience, that receives most of its attention. In a word, Malamud fictionalizes, not to immortalize the actual victim of the case, Menahem Mendel Beilis, but to make a statement about Jews and the human condition.

Malamud's short story, "The Magic Barrel," from the National Book Award-winning collection of the same title, follows a similar pattern. Leo Finkle, the rabbinical student expecting ordination, finds the advice attractive that he should get married in order to help win a congregation. As he has no one immediately available, he seeks help from a matchmaker, Salzman. True to form, the man comes with several suggestions none of which is agreeable to Leo. But the young man does invite one young lady out, and feels disgusted with the matchmaker's brass lies to both parties. He decides to have nothing further to do with him. But Salzman will not budge. He tactfully leaves Leo with a manila envelope which contains the pictures of a few women. Leo does not bother to look at them until one day he opens the envelope. The pictures are no good, but one snapshot catches his attention just at the moment he is about to give up hope. It is the picture of a young lady that he falls in love with at first sight. He tries to get information from Salzman who, however, snatches the picture away and refuses to reveal her identity. Pressed hard and in despair, Salzman blurts out that the girl is his daughter who is dead to him because she prefers prostitution to poverty. The violence of his emotional response sets Leo thinking and self-searching. For the first time he discovers and admits that he is unloved and loveless, and that although conversant with the Jewish law, he is Godless. His conversion and redemption begins the moment he thinks of loving others more than himself. He is getting ready to suffer for the prostitute. Now he is not thinking of marriage for his own good; he comes to see that love is now a sacrifice for or a commitment to a larger cause. The way the story ends ?Leo going to meet the fallen girl with flowers in his hand ?is quietly provocative as it offers a possibility of growth rather than a reality. As with *The Assistant*, humor here serves as a means of redeeming the absurdity of the scenario and alleviating the anguish of the suffering. Thematically, Salzman is both a clown and a means of leading to salvation. Formally, he is a structural necessity to enliven the dismal built-in atmosphere. Pages of seemingly useless stuff serve to build up the suspense which, when felt, is so rewarding. That is Malamud at his best.

John Updike (1932-) is a prolific writer of the period under discussion. He has written a lot in his long-stretching career: his "Olinger" fictions, set in fictional Olinger, Pennsylvania (based on his hometown), the best of which is *The Centaur* (1963), other works like *Couples*, *Marry Me*, many stories about Richard and Joan Maple, his recent *Gertrude & Claudius*, and of course his brilliant short stories and his poetry. He has won a number of awards including the National Book Award and the Pulitzer Prize.

But he is best known for his "Rabbit" pentalogy: *Rabbit, Run* (1960), *Rabbit Redux* (1971), *Rabbit Is Rich* (1981), *Rabbit at Rest* (1990), and *Licks of Love* (2000). The plot of the series is nicely sequential and coherent. Rabbit runs away from home in *Rabbit, Run*, comes back in *Rabbit Redux*, becomes rich in *Rabbit Is Rich*, is laid at rest in *Rabbit at Rest*, and is resurrected in the memories of his folks in *Licks of Love*. Having himself survived into the new millennium, Updike just could not resist the temptation of writing a sequel to his four Rabbit novels and so published a fifth, a novella.

This "Rabbit" is the nickname for the main character. Harry Angstrom, a person of no importance in American middle-class society. The series of novels relates the saga of this man, a blue collar, whose peak in life was as a high school basketball star. The nickname indicates two major character traits of the man ?his uncontrollable sexual desire and his place as a petty person in society. Harry is forever tormented by his hunger for intimacy, and is forever haunted sexually. He has an energy for which he does not have a good outlet. Like a Rabbit, he is always looking for

something and is always running away from something. After the success of the first of the series, Updike has kept the rate of publishing a Rabbit novel every ten years. So Harry keeps his presence fresh in the minds of the readers. Each book tries to size up the social landscape of America in the duration of ten years through the lens offered by Harry and the characters around him. The Rabbit has thus become a legend in the postwar period.

Let's take a quick look at the Rabbit series with emphasis on the first of these. As soon as it was out, *Rabbit, Run* became immensely popular and established the young author's place as a major novelist. The story line is simple. Harry the Rabbit, a young man in his mid twenties, is already feeling empty and depressed. His wife, Janice, now pregnant, drinks and watches juvenile TV programs, leaving their car and small son Nelson at their parents'. After playing a game of basketball with some teenagers, Harry feels a promise of life surging in his bosom and decides to run away. As he runs, he does not feel the sense of freedom he desires. So he turns back, not home but to his former coach for advice. The older man puts him in touch with Ruth with whom he starts housekeeping. A young minister, Eccles, comes to intervene but fails to find a solution. Harry now works as a gardener for a wealthy widow, and Ruth becomes pregnant. When his wife gives birth, Harry deserts Ruth, returns home, and works for his father-in-law. Then driven by his sexual urge, he leaves for Ruth, his wife gets drunk and drowns the baby girl while giving her a bath. Unable to deal with the tragedy and the accusing eyes of his folks, and rejected now by Ruth, Harry runs away for good. Rabbit is on the run. He runs away from job to job, from adviser to adviser, and from woman to woman. No job is good enough for him; neither are his advisers and women. The result is that he keeps on running, and probably looking, though there is no clue at the end of the book whether he has found anything to stop him. Our hindsight tells us, of course, that he has not.

The reasons for his restlessness are evident from the story. He is not happy at home. Janice, coming from a richer family and spoiled a little, feels that she has married beneath herself, and does not keep their home the way she should. Rabbit is not happy at work. He begins as a salesman, then works as a gardener for a wealthy widow, then he changes over to a position in one of his father-in-law's used car lots. None of these can bring him any closer to the kind of promise his high school basketball stardom ever made for him (or he thought it did). His counselors in life – his mother, his former coach, and the minister Eccles – prove each of them stupid and impotent for him. His mother keeps adding fuel to his quarrel with his wife, saying that he is always welcome in her house if things go from bad to worse in his domestic scuffle. Mr. Marty Tothero, his high school coach, now himself barely able to keep his head above water, should have been the last person Harry turns to because the best the man could do is to lead the indiscreet young man into deeper despair. As to the young Episcopalian minister, he is not any wiser, either. He tries but feels at a loss as to what good advice to offer. Rabbit is at the end of his rope. The only way out is to flee from the present.

Harry's problem is symptomatic of his age. He has energy enough, but does not have the proper channel for it. The way he lives his life – making love, working at a mediocre job, playing golf, and taking care of his clothes – is too humdrum and tepid. His involvement with people brings nothing but trouble and frustration. He is not satisfied, yet he cannot define what he wants: it is "something that wants me to find it." Rabbit knows that he is a failure, and he feels agony over it. He is aware that he has a problem, but he cannot pinpoint it, less to say to address it. He is harassed by his sense of meaninglessness, but cannot figure out what to do about it. Eccles, very

much in evidence in Harry's life, vaguely feels that the man is not spiritual enough and that, separated from God, Harry is going through some religious crisis. So Updike paints the portrait of a person living on the edge of the abyss, without any spiritual resource, left all alone to shift for himself in a society which generates so much hardness of the heart and offers so little hope for grace and salvation. Hence the epigraph of the book: "The motions of Grace, the hardness of the heart; external circumstances" (Pascal's *Pensees* 507).

The epigraph goes in fact for the whole of the series. Harry continues his directionless existence, and the rest of the world around him fares no better. People crash into each other, learn little or nothing, and stumble along a path that no one knows and cares to know leads where. In *Rabbit Redux*, 36-year-old Harry comes back and works for his father-in-law. Now fat around the middle, he is cynical and defends the Vietnam War vehemently. He lives his routine life in a spirit of resignation. Janice then moves in with her lover, and Harry allows a teenager runaway girl Jill and a black fugitive, Skeeter, to live with him and his son. Later, in a fire in which his house is burned down, Jill is killed, and Harry helps Skeeter to escape. Janice comes back in reconciliation. When *Rabbit Is Rich* opens, Rabbit takes over the management of his father-in-law's successful Springer Motors after the old man passes away. Now in his mid-forties, rich, heavy, and soft, Harry feels happy despite the impudence of his wife. Then a young woman appears to disturb his snug complacency; he suspects that she is his natural daughter by Ruth. Harry tries to ascertain her identity, but Ruth denies it. Added to his worries is his son, Nelson, now a college student, with no clear sense of direction and already veering toward substance abuse. He wants to quit school and begin work in the family business. Harry has a hard time sending him back to college. In *Rabbit at Rest*, Harry is 56, overweight with a bad heart, being forced out of the game by his wife conspiring with their son. Nelson's drug abuse becomes more serious, joins a program and is rehabilitated. The young man would like to be a social worker. Now in semi-retirement Harry lives half of the time in Florida, eats lots of junk food, and suffers a heart attack. He takes advantage of his daughter-in-law and takes her to bed one night. His wife catches him, and he runs away. One day he plays basketball with a boy and dies of a heart attack. Now in *Licks of Love*, Rabbit is back alive, resurrected in the memories of his family. Janice has married a retired salesman, Ronnie Harrison, whose sidekick on Bill Clinton, "he has lied to us," has become a catch phrase of a kind. They live well in Rabbit's old home. Harry's son Nelson, a mental health counselor, hears on Christmas morning that one of his patients has committed suicide. Harry's illegitimate daughter, Annabelle, now forty years old, a nurse, has to put up with Ronnie's cursing her father as "a hooker and a bum." In the conversations of the people, Harry's soul floats up and down between Pennsylvania and Florida.

Updike is still productive. Critics complain that he focuses far too much on his characters' inner lives and tends to neglect the kaleidoscopic world outside. This is not really very true as we do get a sense of what is going on in the America of Harry's lifetime: the Vietnam War, the sex revolution, the loss of faith, the Clinton scandal etc., and Updike's social landscape is amazingly authentic. In addition, it is necessary to understand that Updike does not seek to hook and hold his readers with complex plots. He is more preoccupied with characterization, with how his characters react emotionally to events that involve and delimit them. He takes immense delight grappling with experience in order to reveal its quintessence and derive a sense of orientation. He is a very serious literary artist.

Mention should be made of John Cheever (1912-1982), who will be mainly remembered as

a fine short story writer the same way Katherine Anne Porter will be. His best stories are collected in *The Stories of John Cheever* (1978) which reveals his thematic concern in a graphic way. In addition to his short stories, Cheever also published some impressive novels, such as his National Book Award-winning *The Wapshot Chronicle* (1957), *The Wapshot Scandal* (1964), *Bullet Park* (1969), *Falconer* (1978), and *Oh What a Paradise It Seems* (1980).

Cheever wrote mainly about the suburban middle class people. He was authentic in depicting their manners and morals. There is most of the time surface reality, beautiful houses, well-off lives, but also numerous trials and tribulations. Very often the people struggle with their sin and guilt, cope with their impossible experiences, and exhibit an occasional trace of heroism. Life is gloomy, but they aspire for light. For it is John Cheever's belief that man's inclination toward light and brightness, spiritual light, is very nearly botanical, and that people need it and struggle for it. Dubbed as a "New Yorker writer" because he published most of the time in that entertaining magazine, Cheever's serious theme has not been well excavated critically. This has caused critical neglect of him in the American canon. This has also been compounded by the fact that he tried to work all his life in the watertight compartment of his own, as it were, shunning involvement in experiments and new ideas, and keeping to the more conservative mode of mannered realism.

Cheever has written some of the finest short stories of the 20th century. The oft-anthologized "The Swimmer" deserves particular notice. This typical Cheever work tells the story of a middle-aged man leaving a friend's party to swim home from pool to pool across an 8-mile long area. Happy and vigorous as the summer day at his friend's party, Neddy Merrill is suddenly struck by this whim of "taking a dogleg to the southwest" to get home by what he jocularly calls the Lucinda River, named after his wife and imagined as it is 14 private pools linked with one public. As he swims through, Neddy meets with people, observes the landscape of life, and digests his experience with affluent but uncertain middle class America. Along the "bonny and lush" banks of the Lucinda River, he hears people partying, sees a home for sale, feels the sting of snobbishness, and weeps at the rudeness of a mistress and the cruelty of fate. Just as the seasons rotate, from summer to autumn to approaching winter, Neddy undergoes a massive change in his own person, from sprightliness to gloom, from healthy middle age to withering elderliness, and an equally massive change occurs in his family fortunes: he goes broke, has to borrow money, has to sell his house, and his children are in trouble. When he arrives home, it is no longer home. The house is in padlock and his family are gone.

Here as in most of his works, Cheever was a faithful follower of realism in his use of a Jamesian narrator and in his descriptions of people, manners, and scenes. Here is this third-person narrator who occasionally pops his head out to address us readers as "you" and make a storyteller's sweeping comments. Here is this meticulous watchfulness for minute details as the author strives for a photographic precision. Cheever knows his class and their life so well that he makes it possible for his readers to live it authentically for themselves. Take, for example, the description of Teddy's meeting with the Grahams, his diplomacy, his polite demeanor, and the emotional ripple in his bosom, and we will find the thorough middle class-ness in the writer himself. It is as though he was recounting his own life story. However, "The Swimmer" has an unmistakable surreal air about it, too. The man begins his journey home one summer afternoon when life seems perfect. He goes through a storm, and reaches home in late autumn to find his own house locked in rusty padlocks. The symbolism might appear a little stereotyped and superficial, but it works well

enough to get a point through. The journey could mean that human effort is doomed to failure, as Bertrand Russell put it, and that Teddy might be asserting his will against overwhelming odds, which is a feeble semblance to a Hemingway hero under pressure. It could also symbolize that no party will last forever, and it is good to be ready for a mutability that is life itself. Neddy thus assumes suddenly the stature of a vigilant consciousness, floating around to warn the improvident world of middle class America of what might be in store for them, and the readers tend to feel sad somehow for the people in the story as well as for themselves.

During the period under discussion, southern literature continues to grow with the painstaking efforts of such writers as Flannery O'Connor (1925-1964) and William Styron. Flannery O'Connor has been described variously as southern, Catholic, and grotesque. She was all of these but more. Born and raised in the south, she took what she knew best as her major subject matter. Her imagination, living through a time of mid-century Catholic revival, was colored by a religious vision that attains in all her works. And she was good at representing the grotesque and violent aspects of human existence and magnifying them to shocking dimensions. "[F]or the almost-blind you draw large and startling figures," she said. But her works break through all the boundaries and apply to a much broader extent of life and experience.

O'Connor's sensibility was a unique one. She took interest in the lives of those country people, often freaks, either physical or emotional or both, that embrace a single, ferocious belief, and of those southerners, often poor and benighted religious fanatics, who appear as sufferers of one kind or another in need of salvation. These poor souls become protagonists of her stories, and help make a statement of her views on the human condition. Flannery O'Connor shows understanding and compassion toward her characters, and tries to discover ways to salvation for them. Her stories are full of death, suffering, and violence, but always also moments of grace and redemption. Her characters are often uncouth and hideous, her plots jarringly unnerving, and her portrayal of violence and sinfulness appalling, but these serve to reveal her religious vision. There is in her writings a kind of mystery that cannot be readily unraveled in light of normal human experience. Her style is simple but suggestive, full of comic and melodramatic details that are meant to horrify the minds of the readers. She treats sudden and unexpected events with a calm detachment and tries to reveal and examine the invisible aspects of human nature with precision. There is a Gothic element and an obvious absurdist tendency in her works. These include *Wise Blood* (1952, a novel), *A Good Man Is Hard to Find* (1955, a collection of short stories), and *The Violent Bear Is Away* (1960, a novel). Other published works are collected in her posthumous *Everything That Rises Must Converge* (1965). The *Complete Stories* came out in 1971. When she was alive, O'Connor had already earned a substantial reputation for herself, and over the years she has been receiving growing critical attention. She is best known and will be remembered mostly as a short story writer.

The best ingredients of an O'Connor story converge in her most famous work "A Good Man Is Hard to Find." This is a story about a family of six which, on its way to Florida, gets wiped out by an escaped convict named the Misfit. The major character is the Grandmother, and her family include her son Baily, his children, John Wesley and June Star and the baby, the children's mother, and their cat. The Misfit is a cold-blooded criminal, quite an intellectual with strong views on religion and society. He could not believe in something he has never seen, especially God. He and the Grandmother have an intellectual war with the old woman feebly on the side of her inherited

faith and him preaching from something akin to Satanism. The Grandmother, in a clear moment, asserts her humanness and reaches out to the convict in a Christian manner to forgive him. The Misfit draws back in horror, and shoots her after he has had the others killed.

Although violent and absurd, the story makes sense when we take into account O'Connor's southern background, her Christian faith, and her particular perception of the use of violence in fiction. O'Connor's fiction is steeped in the traditions of the American south. The Grandmother is a typical southern white, classy, condescending, believing in the value of her southern lineage and, no matter how superficially, in God and the Word. She sees southern gentility as originating from God. To her a southern gentleman's good blood is his worth, and that worth is his Word. When painfully slowly she makes to the realization that she is facing eternity, she feels somehow that the Misfit is her responsibility to save because they share their roots in the Christian mystery. Then her head clears for an instant, and she murmurs: "Why you are one of my babies. You are one of my own children!" Thus her humanness cuts in, and she reaches out and touches his shoulder. But she gets three shots in the chest. Readers would find the behavior of the Grandmother ridiculous, but O'Connor feels that the old lady's gesture of spiritual compassion will "grow, like the mustard seed, into a great crow-filled tree in the Misfit's heart and will be enough of a pain to him there to turn him into the prophet he was meant to become." The Grandmother thus enjoys a special kind of triumph here in the author's opinion: her action "made contact with mystery." Readers may disagree with her, but she has a point here.

This leads to O'Connor's firm belief in Christian values and mysteries. O'Connor accepts Christian mythology naturally. "A Good Man is Hard to Find" follows a general pattern visible in O'Connor's stories. The pattern stems from her Christian perspective of experience which she describes as moving from a condition of sinfulness to a recognition of sin, repentance, and absolution. The concept of grace figures prominently in her works. Here in "A Good Man Is Hard to Find," it is not just the Misfit that the Grandmother and Red Sammy complain about; neither is it just the good old days that are gone by not to return. O'Connor is talking about the sinfulness of this world of matter in which her characters live. Hers is a godless place with godless people in it. The Grandmother's family is dysfunctional in Christian spirit. The Grandmother, though good at heart, is not a very loving grandma, and not a very godly, prayerful type of person. Her son is at best a marginal father, and her grandchildren are disobedient and faintly obnoxious. They are not the best possible Catholics and need grace in their way. The Misfit is at first glance a veritable emblem of sin, though further scrutiny may reveal him to be richer in imagination. O'Connor constructs her story, as always, in such a way as to dramatize the sinfulness and the need for grace. Her characters, in this case the Misfit and the Grandmother, eventually recognize this need, but they behave differently when the opportunity occurs: they either accept it or ignore it. The Grandmother at her most lucid moment prior to death (the moment of grace) exhibits her redeeming missionary spirit while the Misfit behaves in a way which critics of the story have thought differently about. Some see him as a demonic character, irrational and ill at ease with his circumstances. He is not simply ignorant and senselessly violent. He kills because he has a quarrel with the world for not treating him fair and with God for allowing injustice to happen to him. The image of death is firmly planted in his head. O'Connor does not use strong language to condemn his heinous crime, but the cold bloodiness of the violence makes our blood curdle. He is in essence very much like the backwoods preacher in O'Connor's novel *Wise Blood* where the demon preaches Satanism and replaces faith with violence. O'Connor may have created such characters to

voice her religious doubts. But other critics take note of the subtle change in the Misfit's speech and behavior and feel that he may be impressed by his victim's show of humanity and thus begin to move toward spiritual transformation in the pattern of St. Paul. This interpretation is plausible if we remember O'Connor's repeated statements in her essays regarding the writer's responsibility to the world and this one in particular: "It is one of the functions of the Church to transmit the prophetic vision that is good for all time, and when the novelist has this as part of his own vision, he has a powerful extension of sight."

Then there is O'Connor's belief in the use of violence as a vehicle for awakening people to the need for grace. "I have found," she writes about the story, "violence is strangely capable of returning my characters to reality and preparing them to accept their moment of grace. Their heads are so hard that almost nothing else will do the work... With the serious writer, violence is never an end in itself. It's the extreme situation that best reveals what we are essentially... Violence is a force which can be used for good or evil, and among other things taken by it is the kingdom of heaven." Although the Misfit kills six innocent lives three of which are children, O'Connor still does not want to equate him with the devil. She sees an almost imperceptible intrusion of grace here. There is still the possibility, however unlikely, for him to be saved: the Misfit seems to be more concerned with faith, and he kills not to quench his thirst for blood but as a show-down with God and a challenge to Him. O'Connor even believes that he has a greater capacity for grace.

"A Good Man Is Hard to Find" is exemplar of O'Connor's style. The narrative is simple, lucid and quiet, with the easy flow of the colloquial speech of her native south. There is at the same time always her type of suspense that is tucked away carefully here and there, pointing forward to the lurid tragedy for which the readers are least prepared. She was good at catching people unawares. For the first part of the story, there is nothing unexpected but the everyday details of a humdrum family life the rhythm of which needs some break, or the details of a banal three-day vacationing barely funny enough to keep people awake and hooked. But careful readers already find mention of the Misfit having escaped from prison, the possible death of the Grandmother as a lady, and the family burying ground ?all foreshadowing the upcoming sanguine event. Then the automobile accident occurs, and the family gets ready for "the line of woods [gaping] like a dark mouth." The first killings are faintly heard but not seen as if nothing gruesome had transpired. We could only feel their magnitude to the old woman through the changes in her conduct and speech. Then comes the ghastly finale of the drama. The story is not focused on the violence, but the sketchy account of it is meant to color the reading of the whole of it so as to shock the readers into recognition of the criminal, grotesque aspects of life and of the importance of religion and faith.

Known for her complex themes and rather difficult symbolism, Flannery O'Connor has left a legacy of mystery behind and remains a powerful voice in American literature.

William Styron (1925-) was born in Newport News, Virginia. By virtue of the small but remarkable body of work he has written, he has become one of the leading Southern writers. Over the years he has won a number of awards including the Prix de Rome of the American Academy of Arts and Letters, the Pulitzer Prize, and the National Book Award. His first novel, *Lie Down in Darkness*, which concerns the disintegration of a middle-class southern family, was published in 1951 and received favorable reviews. His second book, *Set This House on Fire*, came out 1960, to which the critical response was mostly mixed or negative. *The Confessions of Nat Turner* (1967), Styron's third novel, was based on an 1831 slave insurrection known as Nat Turner's Rebellion,

which took place in Southampton County, a remote region in Southern Virginia, not far from Newport News. In 1979 Styron published his best-known novel, *Sophie's Choice*, which grew essentially out of his earlier encounter with a Polish survivor of the death camp at Auschwitz. The novel is a long, complex narrative that blends fact with autobiography, comedy with pathos, and history with fiction. It represents an attempt on the part of the author to universalize the Holocaust and explore the extent of human evil. The story was made into a successful movie starring Meryl Streep and Kevin Kline, which won the 1983 Oscar Award. In the early 1980s Styron underwent a period of psychological decline and was once hospitalized for depression. He emerged from the experience to publish his memoir, *Darkness Visible: A Memoir* (1998), which is a powerful, accurate evocation of melancholia. Since the decade of the 1990s, Styron has kept writing and publishing. A collection of three novellas, *A Tidewater Morning*, came out in 1993. Styron's other works include *The Long March* (1953, a novella), *In the Clap Shack* (1972, a play), and *This Quiet Dust and Other Writings* (1982).

Styron's major work, *Lie Down in Darkness*, relates the tragic story of a middle-class white family of the American south. Milton Loftis, the father, susceptible to the influence of the Northern lifestyle, disregards traditional morality, becomes a "sot," and indulges in extramarital behavior. Helen, the mother, abides by tradition and firmly keeps her religious faith. As a result, alienation occurs between the two, and Milton's emotional focus transfers itself to their daughter, Peyton. When the girl grows up, a sort of incestuous relationship develops, leading to the eruption of the latent volcanic conflict of the family. Peyton is married off to the distant north. As this fails to extricate her from the complex emotional tangle of love and hate in which she has been involved, and she keeps missing home and father, Peyton seeks for a mental balance in developing relationships with men. Again this fails to save her from agony and despair. So she decides to jump naked down from a high-riser. Here Styron, following the southern literary tradition in which he was brought up, successfully displays the loss of moral absolutes after the industrialization of the south and the loss of direction, the pain, and the despair that come as its aftermath. His narrative style which is akin to that of the Bible, the conflict between the fundamentalist religious tradition and modern skepticism, racial conflicts, and the process of industrializing the agricultural south—all these proffer the background against which the family tragedy of the Loftises works itself out in its slow, agonizing disintegration. Infidelity is present; so is incest. Where Peyton goes, she carries, along with her beauty, that destructive passion that finally encompasses her own undoing. Marriage for Milton and Helen is made to appear as a melodrama, and Helen loves only whatever she feels she can control—her handicapped daughter Maudie, for instance. All die and lie down in darkness in the tomb of life.

The Confessions of Nat Turner is a true story told in the form of fiction. It is told from an African American rebel's point of view. Styron calls it "a meditation on history." He based the novel on the details of Turner's life and a pamphlet with the same title that was presented as evidence at Turner's trial. The book presents a story of horror that stems from slavery. Turner was born into slavery in 1800. He grew up in a religious home and studied the Bible everyday. Well educated by his white master, he was turned into a fanatic by the Old Testament God of Ezekiel. As a self-styled preacher, Turner claimed that he had his first religious vision at 25 and believed that God had ordained him for some great purpose: Ezekiel came to him in a vision, telling him to lead a revolt against slave-masters. Turner claimed that he saw white spirits locked in battle with black spirits and the sun darkened. One day Turner was working in the fields and felt he saw drops

of blood on the corn. On another he saw the alphabet written in blood on the tree leaves. And he saw other signs that indicated to him from above that the day of judgment was close at hand. On August 21, 1831, he decided to fulfill his destiny as an angel of death. He had five slaves with him, and they began killing slave owners. Presently a small army of forty slaves began to form itself and within 36 hours they slaughtered fifty-nine white men, women and children in Southampton County, Virginia. Then government troops were sent out. They killed innocent black people, and the white militia murdered their own slaves. There were rumors of more slave revolts up in the air. In the bloody encounters that followed in the next few days, most of Turner's men were killed or arrested. Turner managed to hide himself for a few weeks before he surrendered. He was taken to the county jail and was interviewed there by Thomas Gray, a journalist. The 20-page "The Confessions of Nat Turner" was the reporter's written record of Turner's story. Turner was hanged, but the effects of his mutiny lasted for decades. For the next twenty years the laws became more brutal and repressive regarding the slaves. The whites became split in their attitudes toward the slaves. The argument between abolition and anti-abolition became more fierce. Some historians believe that, if Virginia had ended slavery following the insurrection, the Civil War might have been avoided. Styron read widely about the rebellion before he began writing. The novel was praised for its audacity and was damned for its effrontery. There was a heated controversy about it. Upon its publication, some African American writers and critics argued that the story was one that only a black person could tell, and that Styron exploited slavery in adopting a black persona and pretending to know how he felt. They felt that Styron's presentation of the Turner case seems to suggest that the blame lies not so much in the slavery system as in Turner's mind. Styron was hurt when his novel was labeled racist, but felt that it was probably politically incorrect for him to put his own interpretation into the soul and heart of a black man. Probably, Styron's emphasis is different from an African American writer's handling of the subject. He may have allowed his story to pivot on the theme of redemption rather than on the description and censure of an inhuman system at work. It is good to note that James Baldwin defended him against charges of racism.

In formal terms, Styron's works are eloquent testimony to the influence he received from the southern literary tradition and the currents of thought in 20th-century philosophy and literature. For one thing, Faulkner's literary ideas and style have cast a long shadow over Styron's literary creations. To Faulkner, the only thing worth writing about is the conflict within the human soul. Styron has been writing exactly about this. Basing his perceptions of life on his understanding of human nature, he focuses on the delineation and analysis of the self-conflict that rages in the inner world of his characters, revealing the damaging effect of contemporary existence upon the human consciousness. *Lie Down in Darkness* is strewn with flashbacks and recollections which serve to throw the inner conflicts of the characters into relief. Peyton Loftis tries to shake off the shadow of her tragic home, tries to fend off the stifling tradition of the south, its history, and its culture, and tries to seek a new life for herself, but all to no avail; the genetic impact of her southern family and upbringing, always catching up with her and poisoning and twisting her soul, encompasses her undoing in the end. She has no choice but to jump out of a window and be content to lie down in darkness. *The Confessions of Nat Turner*, though treating a historical subject, does not place so much emphasis on the misery of the African Americans and the grandeur of the scenes of their rebellion as on the confessions of Nat Turner, thus revealing the immense injury done to their souls that turned them into violent individuals. The same goes for *Sophie's Choice*. It is true that

the book is all about the war's savagery, but instead of directly describing it, the novel turns on the fate of one individual whose soul and faith suffer against the vast backdrop of the externalities of that atrocity, so much so that she sees death as the only avenue of escape from suffering after the war. She has tried to heal herself, tried to face her emotional as well as physical wound, and tried to respond to passionate love and the call to cut off ties with the past and build her life anew, but all to no avail. Her choice is still death. In formal aspects, Styron's works bear the visible imprint of the style of William Faulkner. The structure is seldom strictly chronological; the story is often deliberately fractured; and there is always a stream of consciousness built into the fabric of the narrative. Although Styron has tried to come into his own, his success is more the result of a reaction rather than anything else.

Styron is sensitive to the currents of thought afloat in the cultural atmosphere of his time. Freudian psychoanalysis led to the efforts to explore and excavate the inner world of man. As a result of this monumental development, literature could never be the same again. Literature began turning inward in its description of life, and new techniques such as the stream of consciousness and psychological realism emerged. Basically realistic, Styron has drawn, in his literary endeavors, from a variety of sources of nourishment from these modern literary traditions. One notable example would be Peyton's long interior monologue before her suicide, which occurs at the end of *Lie Down in Darkness*. It is evidently modeled on that of Molly Bloom with which James Joyce wraps up his *Ulysses*. Styron has also added his own unique discoveries to these traditions. For instance, he is good at presenting the subconscious, portraying dreams, depicting human sexual drive, varying the point of view, etc. Styron has been regarded as one significant contemporary American writer.

Mention should be made of Truman Capote (1924-) who, born in New York, is a southern writer by theme. Most of his work is set in the Louisiana-Mississippi-Alabama area. His is a Gothic and violent world. He is an autobiographical writer in the sense that some motifs basic to his works replicate his own life experience over and over again. For instance, when he was a child, his parents were divorced and his mother was remarried. The child, thus "orphaned" and brought up by relatives, yearned at the bottom of his soul for love and understanding. This becomes a thematic thread running through many of his short stories and novels. Take his longer works for instance. *Other Voices, Other Rooms* (1948) features a boy looking for his father in a world of grotesques and accepting homosexuality after he fails to win heterosexual love. *The Grass Harp* (1951) tells the story of a boy and his cousin rebelling against accepted standards and learning in the end that love for the world as well as for oneself is the most important thing. *A Christmas Memory* (1956) portrays the excruciating loneliness and unhappiness of a boy whose best expectation in life is getting ready with his cousin for the holiday. Although a girl replaces a boy in his novel, *Breakfast at Tiffany's* (1958), the young lady is an orphan. She comes to New York to look for love and a comforting sense of belonging. In most of Capote's short stories, the same theme is recurrent, always a boy, thirsting for love, seeking it, and failing in his attempt.

If we look at his best-known work, *In Cold Blood* (1966), we could still catch a glimpse in one of the killers, Perry Edward Smith. Criminologists might, with a stretch of the imagination, trace his cold murder of the Clutters to his neglect in his childhood. Perry had an alcoholic mother and a drifter of a father, and when he was little the poor wretch was tossed around from one orphanage to another. Later he lives a thankless life in the merchant marine and the US Army, and runs into an accident, leaving him in pain with disfigured legs. Then he commits burglary and

serves time in a Kansas prison where he meets his future fellow murderer, Dick Hickok, whose plan of robbery appeals to him immediately. Having heard the rumor from a cellmate that a wealthy Kansas farmer, Herbert Clutter by name, keeps forty thousand dollars at home to pay his workers, Dick schemes to get rich quick by robbing the Midwest family. The two robbers come to the Clutters' house, ransack it, but find nothing. Despite the good wheat farmer's pleadings for mercy, they kill the whole family. A special agent, Alvin Adams Dewey, is assigned to bring the murderers to justice. Together with the team he heads, Alvin succeeds in arresting them in Las Vegas and sends them back to Kansas for trial and execution.

In *Cold Blood* is remarkable in theme as well as in form. Capote calls it "a nonfiction novel" as it touches the boundaries of two seemingly incompatible spheres of truthful reportage and the imaginary act of novel writing in its handling of the episodes of escape, pursuit, and capture, and the courtroom scenes. As such the novel has exerted its measure of influence on contemporary documentary novels in both America and Europe. It has been well received by readers and critics alike. It can be viewed on different planes of interpretation: as a symbol of violence in American life and of the failure of the American Dream, or as a study of criminal behavior. It is so far the best contribution Capote has made to contemporary American fiction. Capote enjoys both a national and international reputation.

Philip Roth (1933-) is a major American Jewish writer. He has written a good deal of his personal Jewish experience into his fiction. His childhood in Newark, New Jersey, his college education, his brief military career, his marriage, his college teaching, his psychoanalysis, and his travel – all these find their way into his works. Famous with his first book, *Goodbye, Columbus*, and *Five Short Stories* (1959), which won the National Book Award and is still considered by many to be his best, and prolific so far, Roth has yet to fulfill his early promise. He is best known for his *Portnoy's Complaint* (1969): it made him one of the most controversial writers on the contemporary scene.

The stories in *Goodbye, Columbus* are all about Jews and their confrontations. In the title story, one young Jew, Neil Klugman, fights with the well-to-do suburban Jewish group (at the head of which stand the wealthy Patimkins), and he finds it hard to compromise and adjust to his environment. Confrontation constitutes the thematic focus of the next story, "The Conversion of the Jews": locked in the battle are on one side Ozzie Freedman, an inquisitive Jewish pupil, trying to assert himself by threatening to jump from the rooftop and, on the other, his mother and the learned Rabbi Binder and the Judaic system having to make a painful compromise about God and Jesus Christ. "Defender of the Faith" tells a story of a Jewish sergeant in relation to three Jewish trainees in his training company. He finds them a serious threat to his integrity. As he feels one of them deliberately makes trouble, he has to take vengeful steps against them. The Jews in the last story of the collection, "Eli, The Fanatic," who live in the suburbs of Woodenton and have been assimilated into the mainstream, are not happy with the presence of a Jewish boarding school in their residential area; they employ a lawyer to help force it to relocate, or take their advice and modernize itself accordingly so as to keep step with the times and do justice to their respectability. Naturally, the collection enraged the Jewish community who accused the author of being anti-Semite. Roth wrote profusely in self-defense, reiterating over and again that he was happy to be a Jew, but the fury went on for a long while even after he wrote two uncontroversial novels in an attempt to appease his critics.

The frustrated writer decided then to write something different. *Portnoy's Complaint* came

out in print to the angry uproar of the public. This is a confessional story, narrated by a patient, Alexander Portnoy, in his analyst's couch. At the age of 33 (born in 1933) and now an associate commissioner for human opportunities in New York City, Alex lives a guilt-ridden life. He cannot shake off the long shadow that his mother has cast upon his life and fails to achieve harmony with his family, lovers, and friends. He cannot control his urgent sex drive and fails to free himself from a life of hedonistic abandonment. His mother does not understand her son's behavior after all the care and love with which she almost smothers the boy. Alex directs his most virulent language at his domineering mother. None of his lovers, from his first sexual contact Rita "Bubbles" Girardi to Mary Jane Reed, who really loves him, to Kay Cambell, an ideal of American womanhood, seems to address his problem adequately. When he tries to seduce Naomi, he discovers his impotency, and ends up on the psychiatrist's couch for therapy. Portnoy's Complaint has been censured for its obscenity and its attack on the Jewish mother. Its frank portrayal of scenes of masturbation and sexual intercourse, along with its vulgarities and profanities in language, can be and has proved to be offensive to taste and decency. Its ruthless depiction of the mother, especially in view of the essential role that the Jewish mother has played in the faith, has been, to a good many people, inconceivable and unjustified. But it is a well-written book, humorous, conversational, and accomplished in form.

Over the years, Roth has mellowed in spirit and tone. He has become more autobiographical in content and repetitive in themes. The same subject, self vs. social commitment, license vs. repression, sexual desire and failure, etc. recur within the larger context of ethnicity and interpersonal relationships. He has edged visibly toward affirmation. Technically, he is very accomplished with his manipulation of narrative voices and style and his unfailing sense of humor. Primarily a realist and a novelist of manners, and with over 20 volumes of work to his credit, Philip Roth has made his impact on contemporary American consciousness.

One important contemporary writer is Joyce Carol Oates (1938-) who is a talented, prolific writer. She has published over 30 volumes of collections of short stories, novels, poetry, plays, and essays, and is still tirelessly writing. Some of her works have been very popular with the readers such as *Them* (1969), *Wonderland* (1970), and *Do with Me What You Will* (1973), and she has won many awards including the National Book Award, a Guggenheim Fellowship, an O'Henry Award for Special Achievement, and an award from the Lotus Club. She was elected to the National Institute of Arts and Letters in 1978.

Oates is a social novelist writing in the realist tradition. She chooses her characters from the common run of mankind, and makes their lives the subject of her stories. There are in her works students, merchants, teachers, clergymen, and workers, with their fears, anxieties, and misfortunes as well as their joys and laughter. Oates is good at representing their inner complexities and their sufferings in face of overwhelming pressures, either from society, or from the interference of fate, or from their emotional inadequacies. Theirs is a dreadful, absurd, "Gothic" world of violence, murder, suicide, rape, and arson that occasionally recalls that of Edgar Allan Poe, Flannery O'Connor, and William Faulkner. Oates feels that she is offering an authentic representation of contemporary life. The gloom characteristic of her works has earned her the nomenclature of "the dark lady of American Letters." For a long while she did not receive adequate critical attention, but a few significant book-length studies have appeared in the last couple of decades.

The award-winning novel, *Them*, is one of Oates' best works. Set in Detroit, it relates the tragic story of the two generations of a poor family during the three decades from 1937 through

1967. Intertwined and crisscrossed are the lives of the three major characters ?Loretta, the mother, Jules, the son, and Maureen, the daughter. The book opens into the poor and violent slum world of the Detroit of the late 1930s. Young Loretta falls in love with a young man, but her angry brother kills him and runs away. Hopeless and scared, she gets married to a policeman. When the war breaks out, her husband is enlisted, and she takes her children with her to live in the country for a while. Later she returns to the city, attempts to live by prostitution, and is busted by the police. At the end of the war, her alcoholic husband comes back, and often beats her up. He is killed in an accident, and Loretta remarries. She begins to fade into the background, but remains visible and audible all the time her children play out their lives. Maureen, now in her mid teens, hates to live under the same roof with her stepfather. In order to run away, she allows herself to become a child prostitute and tries to make money for herself. Her stepfather beats her up so that she lingers for a long time in a comatose state. Her furious mother divorces her husband. Later Maureen recovers, matriculates in a night school, and falls hopelessly in love with her instructor, who subsequently gets his divorce in order to marry her.

The story of the son Jules, the major focus of the novel, is more dramatic in its bizarre and macabre undulations. The young man gets to know an underworld figure, meets and falls in love with the man's niece, Nadine, and the two elope to the south. Tortured in intense heat and absolute poverty, Jules has to steal, catches the flu, and falls into a coma. Nadine runs back home and is married to a wealthy lawyer. Surviving his mishap, Jules returns north, sees Nadine by chance, and the two agree to meet in a hotel. After sleeping together, Nadine shoots first Jules and then herself in hope of staying together in death. Jules survives the nightmare once more but remains in a stupor for a long time. He lives once with a woman, rapes a girl, and becomes her pimp. Later a riot occurs in the city and wakes Jules up from his trance. He picks up a rifle and kills a pursuing policeman. Then he goes to California with a radical.

The novel tells a shocking tragic story. It depicts a world of chaos and despair. The continuous scenes of the wretched lives of the city poor, manslaughter, desertion, prostitution, riot, deceit, violence and death etc., keep floating in front of the readers, frighten and suffocate them, and reveal the emotional and psychological crisis present in contemporary American life. The descriptions are naturalistic, the sense of urgency is immediate, and the effect is just appalling.

The interplay and interlocking of the three distinct lives merits attention. Loretta is a kind, unimaginative, accepting woman. She grows up in a naturalistic environment, flows with the currents of her life, and makes no conscious attempt to alter or better it. She moves from youth to middle age to elderliness, taking it easy, reacting to occurrences the way a normal person does, and feeling pain or joy no more than is required for the occasion. In the long view of things, Loretta is a middle-of-the road kind of person, not without useful common sense, and representative of the broad segment of common mankind. Maureen is a romantic born into a humdrum world, very much like the boy of James Joyce's "Araby." Feeling imprisoned and intensely unhappy with her lot, she daydreams, tries to fantasize herself out of her poor and dull existence, and ends up with not much more than a dubious blessing. As for Jules, he is all instincts. Directionless and led by primitive forces, he rushes along forever where desire takes him. If Nadine is anything like a Juliet in the tangle of her emotional life, Jules is not by any means a Romeo. He is the type that can never live a rational life. The characterization of the three personalities indicates the author's amazing insight into the nature of life and man.

In addition, Joyce Carol Oates has written some very good short stories which have been

frequently anthologized in textbooks. She will remain an impressive presence in contemporary American fiction.

We now conclude here with our discussion of two younger writers on the contemporary scene. We mean Anne Beattie (1947-) and John Grisham (1955-). Anne Beattie has been active with writing in the last couple of decades. She has already built a solid reputation for herself. Beattie was born in Washington, D. C. and grew up with her baby boom generation in the turbulent 1960s. She did her graduate work in English at the University of Connecticut and has taught at Harvard University and the University of Virginia. She began to publish in the early 1970s in influential magazines like *The Atlantic Monthly* and *The New Yorker*, and won a degree of success with the reading public. Her first novel, *Chilly Scenes of Winter* (1976), received immediate critical attention upon publication. Then Beattie came up with some collections of short stories such as *Distortions* (1976) and *Secrets and Surprises* (1978) which, revealing Beattie at her best, established her place in contemporary American literature. Her keen insight and unique prose style have proved to be so impressive that the *Washington Post* called her the only famous writer among the new generation, and *The Boston Globe* regarded her *Secrets and Surprises* the most celebrated voice in the contemporary American novel. Beattie has kept writing and publishing. Her recent works include her novels *Falling in Place* (1980), *Love Always* (1985), *Picturing Will* (1990), *Another You* (1995), and *My Life, Starring Dara Falcon* (1997), and her collections of short stories, *The Burning House* (1982), *Where You'll Find Me and Other Stories* (1986), *What Was Mine and Other Stories* (1991), and *Park City: New and Selected Stories* (1998).

Basically, Ann Beattie's works are observations of life and deliberations about it. Her characters come mostly from the middle class, well off and well educated, but diffident and impotent in face of widespread change and moral decline. They feel disoriented, living in the debris of an asphyxiating life. Either they lament over the evanescence of human existence, or they indulge in their recollections of the past. They do not want to work, but seek to have a good time, and take delight in being cynical toward life and people. So Beattie's world is one that is dominated by desire and sexual depravity. Here confronted with defeat and adversity, the people do not know how to react, remain passive and helpless, and feel a profound sense of loss that they in the 1970s could never compare with the people of the previous decade in participation and accomplishment. It is a world, contemporaneous, at once ordinary and extraordinary. The author observes life around her, and tries to help make sense of it. There is prosperity with huge improvements of living standards in general, and there is a tangible change in values. Life is full of perversities and broken families; people need to contemplate and find ways to come to terms with the overwhelming anomie in their time and space. *Chilly Scenes of Winter* is a good illustration. This is a story of a young man in his early twenties who craves for love but, frustrated in his attempt, feels loneliness and a sense of loss. The novel looks very realistic as it unfolds its authentic picture of the physical and spiritual features of life in the 1960s. Somehow, it serves as a mirror of the reality of that much publicized decade and of author's own time as well. When made into a movie, the work received popular acclaim. Ann Beattie has been seen as a chronicler of the temper of the 1960s.

Ann Beattie has been called a minimalist, along with writers like Raymond Carver, mainly because she limits her work to a strictly phenomenological surface. She abstracts and simplifies life so that social reality appears to be a spare and even dull skeleton. Like Hemingway who she admits has been a major stylistic influence on her, Ann Beattie's language is sketchy and

suggestive. Her sentences are simple and declarative, and her prose unemotional and unadorned. It produces an effect very much like that of photo-realism or of abstract impressionism, all surface, but provocatively connotative, leaving readers with the impression that there is more beneath. Beattie's stories are most realistic in appearance but not realistic at all. She has already developed her own distinctive mode of writing.

One very popular novelist in the last couple of decades is John Grisham who has been often on the best-selling list of authors. Grisham studied law and accounting in college and practiced law for ten years after graduation. He specialized in criminal defense and personal inquiry litigation. In 1983 he was elected to the House of Representatives and served there until 1990. He began writing in the 1980s, and published his first novel, *A Time to Kill* in 1988. Since then he has been very prolific, with almost a book a year: *The Firm*, *The Pelican Brief*, *The Client*, *The Chamber*, and *The Rainmaker* followed one another in quick succession. His recent books include *The Partner* (1997), *The Street lawyer* (1998), *The Testament* (1999), and *The Brethren* (2000). Many of these have been made into immensely successful movies. His earnings from his writings may have so far exceeded one billion dollars, far more than other best-selling authors like Danielle Steele and Stephen King. Grisham is compelling in complexity of plot and logical deduction. His stories are breathtaking.

Most of his books focus on legal matters such as murder, betrayal, tax evasion, and organized crime. A good example would be his *The Firm*. This is a story about an attractive ambitious young lawyer, Mitchell Y. McDeere. He is accepted into a very prestigious law firm, and works so well that he is showered with many gratuities and gifts such as a new car and a low-interest mortgage loan. The prospects are simply bright for this new member of the firm. Being a typical workaholic, Mitchell frequently works over 16 hours a day, spending little quality time with his wife Abby. Then Mitchell comes to realize that the firm is not his idea of the best possible workplace. He discovers something evil and devious about it when two of his associates are killed mysteriously. He sends his wife away from danger and begins to investigate the deaths. It turns out that the firm has been helping organized crime leaders evade taxes and escape the law. Mitchell is in a quandary, torn between conflicting allegiances. He makes the ethical decision and helps the FBI bring the criminals to justice.

The ethical decision features in another of his novels, *The Street Lawyer*. The young lawyer works in this high-paying law firm and is making toward partnership. His wife feels gravely neglected. Then a holdup occurs in the firm in which the gunner, a homeless man, is killed. The lawyer, surviving the incident, finds, in the man's grievance, a trace of misconduct on the part of the firm in handling a real estate eviction case. The gunner turns out to be one of the victims of the case. The lawyer goes to the site of the housing estate involved and discovers the cause for the eviction which has made many poor families homeless. A powerful contractor has wanted to develop the shabby place into a more profitable fashionable real estate property, and the lawyer's firm has been helping with legal matters. Working together with the law office for the homeless, the lawyer sneaks into his law firm and steals the necessary papers for the illegal eviction. He is fired and joins the law office for the homeless. One of the families evicted is a young black mother with three little children. The lawyer has met them one night when he decided to help in spare time with one institution for the homeless. Now he is involved and concerned in the plight of the young family, he hopes to be able to help them again. But when he emerges from his warm bed after a night of snowstorm, he learns that the family have been all suffocated to death in their little

car. Furious but discreet, he sues his firm and wins the case for the homeless. The young mother and her children have a dignified funeral, and the victims get the compensation overdue to them.

Grisham has a weakness for plot lines that often go beyond the boundaries of probability. For him plot is always the primary priority: events must grab attention. This is a dubious blessing because, whereas he hooks his readers and enjoys their acclaim, he may incur neglect of serious criticism. John Grisham is a rising star. Some people have compared him with William Faulkner. Time will decide whether he will get room for himself "in the library of great writers like Faulkner" (as he put it himself).

CHAPTER 24 Postwar American Novel (2)

The Postmodernist Novel

The period since the 1960s has been a time of more than usual ferment in American social, political, and artistic life. The unpopular war in Vietnam, the political assassinations, the race riots, the hippie counterculture, pop art, mass poetry readings, street theater, vigorous avant-gardism in all the arts, predictions of the death of the novel, etc. All these were all assailing the thinking minds at the same time in the decades of 1960s and 1970s. Since then social concerns have become intense when information begins to explode on the amazed public from different channels now available such as the mass media, television, computers, and satellites. There has appeared a marked change in the nature of things like the ideals of democracy, individualism, and the credibility of the government along with a similar marked change in popular awareness. All of a sudden, people have found the boundaries between fact and fiction obscured or no longer existing.

This is an interesting period of changes for the American novel. Traditional realistic narrative techniques designed to produce an illusion of reality and the related willing suspension of disbelief were widely felt in the 1960s and 1970s to be not only inadequate but falsifying in presenting life. John Barth was the first to announce that the traditional novel is dead, and that traditional novelistic resources have been exhausted. A whole new way of writing would have to be found for the novel to continue as a genre. Read his important essay "The Literature of Exhaustion," and there will be no doubt that change was inevitable and was already happening then. Thus the postmodern novel is no longer Jamesian, offering little or nothing of his kind of a self-contained illusion of reality with a consistent point of view and fairly obvious interpretable levels of meaning. It is a thorough deviation from L. R. Leavis' "Great Tradition."

The new experience gave a vigorous impetus to experimental writing in those decades. Postmodernism made a huge stride forward. There was, for instance, the novel of the absurd, metafiction, and avant-gardism. Let's take a look at the novel of the absurd first. The notion that the universe is absurd, that neither God nor man, nor theology nor philosophy can make sense of the human situation, was not really new to American authors. The modern American novel as written by Hemingway and Faulkner in the 1920s and 1930s and by Saul Bellow and Norman Mailer near the end of the forties and throughout the fifties always treated the theme of "an absurd universe." The major difference between these authors and the "absurd" novelists of the sixties lies in the fact that, while the former represent the absurdity theme essentially in traditional novelistic devices, the latter tend to regard the conventional novel as "literature of exhaustion." To them the old ways of presentation are no longer good enough, and even obsolete. To reflect the new, stupefying and sickening reality, these conventions must be updated, while at the same time new devices should be found. If, in the earlier decades, only the thinking minds felt the chaos and

meaninglessness of modern existence, the 1960s and 1970s proved to be a period in which the common run of humanity had also come to sense absurdity existing on all conceivable levels of life, and it fell to the "absurd" novelists to discover a new rhetoric effective enough to voice that feeling in literature. Incidentally, these novelists appeared, responded to the call of the time, and took it upon themselves to present a vision of absurdity in what have been termed "absurdist" techniques.

So we notice that the novelists of the absurd tend to burlesque traditional novelistic devices. They parody other novels, other styles and forms and take them with highly equivocal attitudes: they want to prove the artificiality of any literary art which, by pretending to bring order to reality, falsifies it and keeps people from comprehending its absurdity. They embrace the theory of Einsteinian relativity and quantum physics which hold that truth and reality are multiple, elusive, and uncertain; they regard any pretension of any traditional form to represent reality authentically as illegitimate and misleading. In doing these the novelists intend to upset all traditions and deliberately create confusion in the readers, so as to jostle them into the recognition that the absurdity of their universe does not disappear simply because they have come to terms with it. The universe is out of joint. It is a tragic place to live in. But as the contemporary novelists tend to be more nihilistic than, say, Faulkner's Mr. Compson who has no faith in any absolutes, they cannot produce tragedy. Instead, they offer a kind of comedy which verges on being grotesque. The tragic absurdity of the human condition is often seen in their works as a cosmic joke. The response they intend to provoke in the reader to the blackness of modern life is laughter, that is, laughing in face of a tragic situation. Hence black humor, or black comedy, which is one of the commonly employed devices of the novelists of the absurd. These authors generally do not laugh at their characters; in fact, they take them seriously. But if they do laugh at some of them at times, it is because they feel amused at their attempt to try to create order in their disordered and absurd world. What occurs oftener is a sense of grief and pain coming through the laughter, a feeling of frustration and being bottled up.

The attitude of the novelists of the absurd is not always an unmitigated "No." The modernist feeling of the world as a random, contingent and chaotic place is intensified in contemporary times. If the modernists like T. S. Eliot and Virginia Woolf tried to control the meaninglessness and disorder through the agency of art, hoping to transcend it by shaping it and giving it an art form, the contemporary writers of the absurd tend to accept the world as it is, and as they are skeptical of their self-integrity and their own ability to "give shape and significance to the immense panorama of futility and anarchy," they open themselves up to that disorder and contingency which they believe no art can mediate. They regard these features of modern existence as normal and locate themselves within the messiness of their world. Rejecting the modernist nostalgia for an organic wholeness and feeling that life's quandaries are not resolvable, the contemporary authors attempt to generate meaning (that is, if meaning is generatable) in the face of, but without denying, chaos and absurdity. For them uncertainty is the rule. Because they believe that the self constitutes part and parcel of the world, involvement, immersion, and participation become their ethic. So these authors are postmodernists (as against modernists).

One of the notable transformations that occurred in novel writing was what has come to be known as metafiction, a form of writing about fiction in the form of fiction. It is a style of fictive narrative that tries to tell the readers that fiction is fiction and is not an illusion of reality as the realists have tried to deceive the readers into believing. To metafictional writers, traditional realists

try to make their fiction look like reality. Metafiction writers feel differently about the idea of authentic representation of reality. They as postmodern writers agree with poststructuralists that, as language is culture-bound and not value-neutral, all writing is a fabricated text manipulated by the author in keeping with his own values and subject to the reading of the readers who come to the work already heavily cluttered with their backgrounds and cultures. So novels are written not to raise and then meet the traditional expectations of traditional readers and critics, but to shock and subvert those presuppositions based on the willing suspension of disbelief as traditional realism has so far succeeded in generating and requiring. Burlesque and parody are used as means to reject the traditional referential of art so that they become self-referential or self-reflexive. Moreover, the text of the novel is often self-subversive. A narrative may have three beginnings instead of only one (take Flann O'Brien's *At Swim-Two-Birds* for example), and it may get read or "edited" by a character in the text so that another text may appear within the major text and the question, "What is the real story?" may become irrelevant because unanswerable (Vladimir Nabokov's *Pale Fire* comes to mind immediately, just for instance). Notable metafictional strategies include such as text within text, authorial personae, and undecidability with no real story.

As to avant-gardism, it has been used as a term of preference for postwar writing which has enjoyed some vanguard status. An avant-garde novel represents a clean breakaway from normal novelistic conventions, has little or no story interest, often dull, not satisfying, even offensive to middlebrow taste, and is often not readable. Writers who exhibit this tendency include, among others, John Hawkes (with his *The Lime Twig* [1961]), John Barth, John Pynchon, Robert Coover (with his *The Universal Baseball Association, Inc.* [1968] and *The Public Burning* [1977]), Walter Abish (with his *Alphabetical Africa* [1974]), William Gass (with his *Willie Masters' Lonesome Wife* [1971]), Donald Barthelme, Guy Davenport, William Gaddis, and Steven Millhauser. Some of these writers, John Barth for instance, are at once among the most famous and the least read. In the postwar period, avant-gardism, along with terms like "postmodernism" and "metafiction," has been largely synonymous with "experimental."

The group of postmodern writers is so large, so we have to be selective. Let us, then, take a brief look at some of the works of Joseph Heller, Kurt Vonnegut, Ken Kesey, John Barth, Thomas Pynchon, Donald Barthelme, William Burroughs, and Vladimir Nabokov for an illustration. These authors all deal with the absurdity theme in their unique ways. Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* has been seen as one of the most famous if not the most famous to come out of the period, dealing with the subject of absurdity in typical "absure" techniques. Kurt Vonnegut's novels, especially *Slaughterhouse-Five*, focus particularly on the absurdity of life and man's modern disease of schizophrenia. Ken Kesey's masterpiece, *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*, amplifies, in its comic exaggeration, the plight of man being dehumanized. There are Donald Barthelme, with his paratactical, fractured narrative, and his disjunctive and staccato prose, and William Burroughs who reinforces the absurd and decadent life of modern man with his absurdist technique of fantasizing and collage. And Nabokov's contribution here is a fascinating episode to narrate in this chapter of American literary history. There are a good many others, of course. Between them these authors have worked out a new rhetoric to reflect the nature of their world of fear, neurosis, and absurdity.

First, let's take a look at Joseph Heller (1923-1999), the most prominent American novelist of the absurd in the postwar period. Heller served in the US Air Force during the WW II, and wrote

a book about his experience in the war. This is the famous *Catch-22* (1961), a novel, the title of which has become a new addition to the English language. Since then Heller has written a few more works such as *Something Happened* (1974), but his reputation has so far rested mainly on his first book.

Catch-22 was the first book in America to treat the absurdist theme with absurdist techniques. It protests against the absurdity of modern America as embodied by the military power structure it describes. The story takes place in a United States Air Force base in wartime Italy. Here stands a military hierarchy, wielding its preposterous authority over the lives of its wretched bomber pilots, who fear flying and wish to be grounded and escape death. In face of the increasing number of flying missions and the increasing chances of meeting death, the pilots are hopeless and desperate. One of them, the protagonist, Yossarian, is afraid of death. He has lost faith in God, and feels no sense of security any more. Along with his fellow pilots, he is horrified at the sight of death and absurdity around him. He feels confused at the behavior of those at the top of the military machine, the generals, colonels, and Milo's enterprises, so that he has a hard time making sense of it. He is disconcerted by the terrible death of his fellow pilot, Snowden, which features perpetually as a heavy load on his mind. And he is baffled at the conduct of another fellow pilot, Orr, first feigning madness (talking with crab apples and chestnuts in his mouth, experimenting with being shot down, being beaten up by a whore in Rome etc.), and then disappearing mysteriously. It takes him a long time to realize that Orr has been planning his own escape all along. Yossarian's outlook undergoes a change. He was brave once but now has a different notion of courage and heroism. Soon he is seen receiving his decoration naked. He begins to ponder over ways to fend for himself, and finally manages to escape the clutches of war and death.

The world of Yossarian is an absurd one, and the way Heller exposes it is through burlesque, the ruthless burlesque of the military unreason, as Charles Harris puts it, as best represented by its three major features: the structured chaos of the military build-up, the military logic, one symbol of which is a "rule" known as "Catch-22," and the widespread absurdity on all levels of existence. First, the chaos in the military structure is well illustrated in the novel. Here is a place where the absurd is the norm: people still very much alive like Doc Daneeka are declared dead and people long dead such as Mudd are kept "alive" on the official roster; one officer, Major Major, welcomes visitors in his office only when he is out; and only those are allowed to attend "educational sessions" who never ask questions. These are only a few from many of life's bizarre manifestations. What the author castigates is the absurdity of not only the military bureaucracy but the whole of the capitalist world in which a traitor like Milo, who profiteers in the war and plots the German bombing of the American squadron, is set free simply because he has made money. Milo is one of the very few characters that are fully portrayed in the book. He is a symbol of a system that lies at the bottom of all the absurdity: the capitalist free enterprise, portrayed as immoral and a menace to human survival. Milo is in a sense the personification of death, especially when Snowden is dying and his M&M Enterprises' medical kit fails to offer the badly needed medication.

Another object of ridicule is the military logic inherent in the monstrous establishment. The bureaucracy has more faith in paper work than in the stark reality of the war. For instance, when Yossarian moves, in the middle of the night, the bomb line (represented by a red ribbon on the map) up over Bologna, the headquarters really believe that they have captured that city and the commanding officer is actually awarded a medal. Then there is this overriding "Catch-22," which

does its work effectively in absurd situations. For instance, all bomber pilots are afraid of flying bombing missions. They have to fly unless they are crazy. Orr is crazy and can be grounded. All he has to do is to ask to be grounded, but as soon as he starts asking, he is no longer considered crazy and must fly more bombing missions. This is the simple logic of Catch-22. And even when Colonel Cathcart increases the number of flying missions continually for the sake of his own promotion to the rank of general, the rule can eloquently rationalize its violation of an Air Force ruling. Everybody knows that Catch-22 does not exist, but all think that it exists and obey its absurd logic. This is itself a proof of the "power" of absurdity which rules and ruins modern existence. The third manifestation of absurdity is its widespread existence in the war machine. The scramble between the generals, Major Major's promotion by an I.B.M. machine, Colonel Scheisskopf's promotion to lieutenant general, Yossarian's liver condition, the joke about T. S. Eliot, the court martial of Clevering, the assigning of an atheist as assistant to the chaplain, Major Major's father's not growing alfalfa, Mrs. Daneeka's reaping of the benefits from her husband's "death" ?all these and a good deal more well reveal the absurd nature of life in the war system and the world at large.

Furthermore, Joseph Heller uses an absurd linguistic surface to reflect the depth of the absurdity of the modern world. Devices such as "circular conversations," to use Harris' terms, constructions with their comic, unexpected responses, the "wrenched cliché" which results from the change of "a key word in an otherwise hackneyed expression," juxtaposed incongruities, sudden tonal changes from seriousness to triviality ?all these are skillfully employed to convey the illogicality and the unpredictability of a mad world. The effect of the burlesque and its absurd verbal expression is irrepressible laughter on the part of the readers; everyone would have a good laugh if they care to read the book through. The laughter is, however, inevitably followed by the acute awareness that it is based on the suffering and misfortunes of their fellow creatures. This is what is meant by "black humor." Think of the funny language which adumbrates the scene of Orr being beaten up by Nately's whore's sister and the readers laugh, but when they get to know the truth that Orr has paid her to do so just in order to appear crazy, they feel sad. Listen to the conversation between Yossarian and Milo concerning the pilot's liver trouble and the readers laugh, but when they stop to think that Yossarian refuses to eat fruits just to keep his liver condition because he has to choose the lesser evil that may allow him to live longer, they feel sad. The same comic and sad effect occurs with the joke relating to T. S. Eliot which is presented in such a funny manner but reveals such crass ignorance, therefore such incompetence, of those on top who wield the power of life and death over their subordinates and may easily send them to a Snowden's death as grisly as described here: "Yossarian ripped open the snaps of Snowden's flak suit and heard himself scream wildly as Snowden's insides slithered down to the floor in a soggy pile and just kept dripping out... He forced himself to look again. Here was God's plenty, all right, he thought bitterly as he stared ?liver, lungs, kidneys, ribs, stomach and bits of the stewed potatoes Snowden had eaten that day for lunch." Snowden, a boy of nineteen, strictly, has not lived; he dies very much in the manner as depicted in Randall Jarrell's famous war poem "The Death of the Ball Turret Gunner." The readers' laughter ends in tears when they become aware of the pathetic situation of the bomber pilots. Death and absurdity stalk their world. People either pretend to be mad or they are really mad when they revel in depravities (look at them in Rome) and violent feasting (think of their Thanksgiving celebrations) and can think of nothing positive about life and future. And most of them have really no choice in face of the deadly threat except escape and

make the best of what they still have available. If they live for the moment, they are the living dead. Hence the death motif, which is, in the final analysis, the thematic basis on which the book's formal comedy plays itself out.

One other formal feature of the book is its apparent "formlessness." For quite some time after its appearance, *Catch-22* was seen as a structural failure despite the admiration it inspired for its narrative power. The novel is arranged by the names of the characters rather than follows a causal or sequential order. Events recur; past and present mingle. Time as a frame of reference ceases to exist. Narrated in the third person but with Yossarian as the presiding consciousness, the book reads like a mind reminiscing about a nightmare of the past. This mind does not only deny the relevance of time as happens with the use of stream of consciousness; it obliterates it altogether. Any notion of clock time that might be traced through the events centering round Milo, for example, is readily shattered by the engulfing psychological time that ticks in Yossarian's mind. As a result, time stops functioning as a coordinate system. It would be frustrating, for example, to pinpoint the time of Snowden's death: at one point the readers are told that he was killed over Avignon a week before Yossarian's decoration and before the Great Siege of Bologna, but at another Yossarian is seen taking his rest leave after Bologna when "Snowden was alive then, and Yossarian could tell it was Snowden's room..." When time is absent, life loses its timely order, the book recording such life loses its timely structure, and the readers are thrown back, as it were, to the beginning of the universe when everything was wrapped up in chaos. From a traditional point of view this may appear to be a failure, very much in the way American fiction was once seen as trivial and insignificant from a European point of view. But Heller's book has appealed to its audience so much that its formlessness has been recognized as a technical innovation, as it indeed is. As Harris and many other critics have observed, Heller writes in a way that deliberately confounds the notion of coherent time and seeks to thwart any attempt to impose a chronological order on the events of the novel. In a world where life ceases to be rational and orderly, nothing like a sequential development is possible and, consequently, to present it in any logical time sequence would be, it seems to Heller, trying to cover up its absurdity and impede a public recognition of it. Through the temporal chaos, the novel leads its readers successfully through its maze of incredible people and incidents from the farce of its early pages to the eventual protest and horror it reveals. Then the readers begin to see the point Heller tries to make, that it is all about man's survival, and that *Catch-22* is a metaphor for man finding ways of escaping power control and death, and eventually succeeding in his endeavor. This undertaking is, naturally, timeless.

When it first appeared, *Catch-22* was a "curious" book to readers and critics who had initial mixed feelings about it. It is a war novel, but it represents a new mode of writing about wars, distinct from the realistic tradition as set in works such as Stephen Crane's *The Red Badge of Courage*, Hemingway's *A Farewell to Arms*, contemporary works like Mailer's *The Naked and the Dead*, Irwin Shaw's *The Young Lions* (1948), and James Jones' *From Here to Eternity* (1951). It has no formal and structural precedent. Nor has it had any visible follower so far, although Thomas Pynchon's *V.* (1963) and Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) both apparently share its absurdist techniques and features of black comedy. Whether Heller tried to imitate himself is anybody's guess, but he surely failed to produce another novel that can touch *Catch-22* in any way. The book simply exploded on the critical consciousness in the early 1960s so that people had a hard time coming to terms with its novelty. It defied traditional definition; it made a

tradition of itself. Gradually the critical world has come to see it as a milestone in the history of the American novel. Marking the beginning of a new genre in the American novel, the novel of the Absurd, and placed safely on the list of college textbooks, the book has now become a world classic.

Now Kurt Vonnegut (1922-) is basically a science fiction writer. He wrote in obscurity until the publication of his sixth novel, *Slaughterhouse-Five* in 1969. The book brought him to general attention and established his place of prominence in contemporary American novel. All through his long career, he has kept publishing novels such as *Player Piano* (1952), *Mother Night* (1961), *Cat's Cradle* (1963), *Breakfast of Champions* (1973), *Slapstick* (1976), *Jailbird* (1979), *Deadeye Dick* (1982), and *Galapagos* (1985), *Bluebird* (1987), and *Hocus Pocus* (1990). Collections of his short stories include, among others, *Canary in a Cathouse* (1961), and *Welcome to the Monkey House* (1968). Over the years he has received numerous honors, the most recent of which is that he was named State Author for New York in 2000.

Slaughterhouse-Five is essentially autobiographical. The protagonist, Billy Pilgrim, offers an effective medium for Vonnegut to speak his own mind. Like Billy, he was born in 1922, became a prisoner of war during WW?, and survived the Allied firebombing of Dresden narrowly as fate played a favorable joke on him. Vonnegut, as an eyewitness of the tragic event, knew perfectly well that the bombing had no strategic importance except to diminish the morale of the Nazi regime and the German people. He learned later that the raid was the most deadly of all in WW?, including the atomic bombing of Hiroshima. Dresden was the beginning of Vonnegut's life-long distrust of technology and his theme of man's inhumanity to man which is central to his novels and short stories. WW? led him to question many morals and traditions of human society. A decade after the war, Vonnegut realized that he was obligated to write about this largest massacre in human history. What Dresden was all about was the killing of about 135 000 people in the course of a night, and he saw a mountain of dead people ("tons of human bone meal in the ground," as he puts it in his famous novel). And that made him think. *Slaughterhouse-Five* was a vehicle for him to express his sadness for and indignation at the human race.

The story of *Slaughterhouse-Five: Or, The Children's Crusade, a Duty-Dance with Death* (well known now simply as *Slaughterhouse-Five*) is told by a narrator, mostly third-person, except in the first and last chapters in which the author takes over the narration. The protagonist, Billy Pilgrim, survives the war and returns to his hometown, Ilium, NY, where he becomes an optometrist, gets married, and lives well before he suffers a nervous breakdown. Then there is an air-crash, which he survives, but his loving wife dies on her way rushing to the hospital where he is taken. Then he becomes "vocal about flying saucers and traveling in time." He begins to talk on the radio and publish letters about his life on the planet Tralfamadore. He says he was kidnapped on the eve of his daughter's wedding, and the aliens from Tralfamadore taught him about the fourth dimension where all moments of time stay for review and reliving. Then he was released and came back to earth to spread the new knowledge to his fellow earthlings. So Billy, first becoming "unstuck in time" in the war, now travels back and forth frequently in time: "Billy has gone to sleep a senile widower and awakened on his wedding day. He has walked through a door in 1955 and come out another one in 1941. He has gone back through that door to find himself in 1963. He has seen his birth and death many times, he says, and pays random visits to all the events in between." He has no control over where he is going or what part of his life he is going to relive next. And he relives the horrors of the war frequently and becomes a perpetual prisoner of war.

The book records his time travels, mostly his revisiting the scenes of his life when he "returns" to wartime Germany, sees his comrade Roland Weary die in the boxcar carrying them to Dresden (where they are kept in an underground slaughterhouse meat locker numbered five), sees one of his fellow prisoners executed for "stealing a teapot" after the bombing, and recalls the threat of another of his war buddies, Paul Lazaro, who vows to hire someone to kill him after the war to avenge Roland's death. Billy is shot and dies in a park where he is addressing a crowd about death: when he is shot, he "experiences death for a while. It is simply violet light and a hum." Billy is made crazy by his war experiences. He and his comrades behaved like a bunch of children in the war and after it, dying or suffering shellshock but knowing so little about the meaning of the war that their war effort seemed to be a children's crusade. Hence the second part of the book's title.

Thus *Slaughterhouse-Five* is a war book, an antiwar novel. It is first a statement about war and man's inhumanity to man and about life and history. The war reveals man's savageness against man which makes life miserable. Billy becomes schizophrenic even during the war and his life can never be happy again. He is well off, respectable, with a wife that adores him. But his mind stays split. It is so full of suffering and deaths that there is little or no room for happiness. Take his recollections of deaths for example. He remembers the deaths that occurred in the war, deaths of the Americans, Germans, Jews, and his Christ, and also the deaths in peace time, say of his parents and his wife, and probably his own. Everything is recorded in such detail that the book about him becomes a litany for the dead and dying. Death continues long after the war even as the author appears in his own voice speaking directly to the reader in the last chapter. There he mentions the assassinations of Robert Kennedy and Martin Luther King, and the corpses in Vietnam. Death is mentioned one hundred times in the novel and is always followed by "So it goes," a phrase that combines so many shades of emotional coloring such as anger, agony, apathy, helplessness, and cynic distaste at life and history. In this connection the novel addresses the purpose of life and the meaning of history. Vonnegut seems to be fascinated with the phrase "if accident will" as an answer to his question about life and history. He implies that history has neither meaning nor purpose, and God is not interested in the human dilemma. Life is absurd, haphazard, embarrassing, so that the people do not seem to care about if it ends. In the novel the author sounds desperate, giving in to the senselessness of it all: a bird has the last word in the novel.

The absurdity of life, the central theme of the book, is illustrated well in characterization and structure. First, Billy Pilgrim is all absurdity as a person. He looks awkward, behaves awkward, and speaks awkward. The way he walks, reacts with people, the things he does—all is intended to delineate a hapless, innocent, confused person, without much of a personal will, completely at the tender mercies of circumstances and fate. Just read chapter two and recall the scene in which he is kicked and knocked about behind the German lines, and we will understand what a veritable picture of human innocence and helplessness he is in life as well as in war. But he is, as such, the best equipped of all (very much like *Forest Gump*) to become a prophet with a new message, to tell something new in a world where, as Vonnegut complained on one occasion, people tend to "fart around and don't let anybody tell any different." Billy's message is basically this, that humans should be kind and nonviolent to their fellow creatures. The underlying irony of all this arrangement is that the message, coming from an imbecile-like person and edited by his pessimistic creator, is not to be taken seriously.

Then, the absurdity theme of the book is well corroborated by its structure. This is intriguing for more reasons than one. First, it is the way time is handled. Basically in the mode of the stream

of consciousness but often following the jerky movements of Billy's schizophrenic states of mind, the novel approximates Billy's experiences of time in a fractured sequence. Billy's mind moves in leaps and bounds. It often works in an associational manner. When he experiences something that has the faintest connection with a past occurrence, his mind will go off back in time to relive that point of his life (as the Tralfamadoreans say, "[a]ll moments, past, present, and future, always have existed, always will exist"). For instance, when he passes out at a New Year's party and is violently shaken awake, his mind switches over in time to a scene behind the enemy lines when Roland Weary banged him ruthlessly back to life from exhaustion. Or when he hears a siren announcing high noon, he is right back in the American prisoners of war camp. Sometimes his mind jumps from one scene to another without notice, as when he is kidnapped and put to sleep on the planet of Tralfamadore but wakes up to find himself on the train taking him and his fellow prisoners to a prison camp. The corollary of all this is the absence of sequential connection in the structure of the book. Just as life is a series of events caused by accidents, so the novel is, or looks like, a collage of isolated vignettes and fragments of life as experienced by a schizophrenic, disjointed, with no hint of a clear linear chronology. This applies both to the overall structuring of the ten chapters and to the contents of each and every one of them. It is a hodgepodge of God's plenty for patient readers to sort out for themselves. The lucky part of it is that unlike *Catch-22* where the notion of time is obliterated, here in *Slaughterhouse-Five* time still exists, however fluid and jerky it may be, as the basis for attempts to chronicle the incidents.

The absurdity feature of the book is also enhanced by the portrayal of scenes and the use of language that help generate a sad humor all the way through. The book contains countless scenarios the description of which induces simultaneous irrepressible compassion and laughter. One of these is recorded in chapter four:

Listen ?on the tenth night the peg was pull out of the hasp on Billy's boxcar door, and the door was opened. Billy Pilgrim was lying at an angle on the corner-brace, self-crucified, holding himself there with a blue and ivory claw hooked over the sill of the ventilator. Billy coughed when the door was opened, and when he coughed he shit thin gruel. This was in accordance with the Third Law of Motion according to Sir Isaac Newton. This law tells us that for every action there is a reaction which is equal and opposite in direction.

This can be useful in rocketry. (*My italics*)

The piteous, ridiculous position in which Billy lies to ride on the boxcar, the use of words such as "self-crucified" and "shit thin gruel," and the invocation of Newton, a benefactor to humankind, and of rocketry, the superpower competition about which horrified mankind so ?all these engender a laugh at once qualified in so many ways by the fact that it depends all on the danger that Billy is experiencing in that position: he could have died so easily.

Slaughterhouse-Five is an interesting specimen of formal experimentation. For one thing, it manifests evident features of metafiction. One metafictional strategy is to tell the readers that what they are reading is the author's fabrication. Vonnegut makes it very clear repeatedly that he is

telling a story. "So it goes," in addition to its other functions, colors everything the narrator says as doubtful, and "listen," used repeatedly in the imperative mood, indicates somebody behind the scene, the narrator, or the author, or some wire-puller, made both audible and visible, that destroys any possible illusion and verisimilitude of reality that traditional realism seeks to create. Furthermore, authorial presence and authorial comments help make the narrative appear fictional. Vonnegut appears directly in the first and last chapters of the book and talks about the process of its creation. There are also a number of occasions when he pops out in the middle of the narrative with a comment of his own. He also appears in the novel in other more subtle ways; for instance, the phone call Billy receives one night from a drunk with breath "like mustard gas and roses" hints at the author hidden backstage. The difference between Vonnegut and the postmodern novelists on the one hand and Jamesian realists on the other lies in this, that whereas the latter try to manufacture reality out of fiction, the former do their best to make fiction out of reality. Vonnegut was writing about his own war experience in *Slaughterhouse-Five* but he did it as if he was telling something not real. It is good to note that Vonnegut uses metafictional strategies well in his other works such as *Breakfast of the Champions*, *Jailbird*, and *Cat's Cradle*.

Vonnegut is also well known as a short-story writer. In these short writings he is good at combining black humor with science fiction. His short story, "Harrison Bergeron" (1961), is a good example. Read the first paragraph and the satirical edge is crystal clear: "The year was 2081, and everybody was finally equal. They weren't only equal before God and law. They were equal every which way. Nobody was smarter than anybody else. Nobody was better looking than anybody else. Nobody was stronger or quicker than anybody else." If anyone is smarter like Harrison's father, they would have to wear a handicap radio in their ears which will reduce the level of their cerebral activity to average. If anyone is prettier, they have to wear an ugly-looking mask. As Harrison is smarter, taller, stronger, and more rebellious, he will have to be locked away or eventually shot. This is a dark satire against the leveling, or depersonalizing, tendency of modern life. The readers feel amused so much that even the execution scene does not appear very bizarre and evil.

In the postmodern move to subvert realism, Vonnegut has done a good deal. Both in the absurd fiction and science fiction, he has made a significant contribution. If he had not written anything else, one *Slaughterhouse-Five* would have been just enough to ensure a space for him in American literature.

Another well-known novelist of the absurd is Ken Kesey (1935-). He was born in Oregon, where he still lives, graduated from the University of Oregon, and studied at Stanford under famous critics and writers such as Malcolm Cowley and Frank O'Hara. So far he has written a few novels including *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1962), *Sometimes a Great Notion* (1964), *Demon Box* (1986), and *Sailor Song* (1992). In addition, he has written a couple of children's books.

Kesey is well known for his novel, *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*. The story is set in a mental hospital near Portland, Oregon. The life of the inmates seems to be placid until Randle McMurphy storms into it. McMurphy comes after feigning psychosis in order to avoid physical labor that he had to do on a farm of correction for minor offenses he committed. At 35 he is jovial and dynamic and feels soon repulsed by the totalitarian rule that Big Nurse exercises over the patients. He begins to act and undermine her authority. Taking the lead in the successive rebellious acts, he manages to awaken the patients to the need to assert their rights as humans and to their

potential for growth. One of them, Chief Bromden, an American Indian of mixed blood, changes from a deaf mute to an active follower of this hero. Confrontations occur, and Big Nurse is losing ground. The scales are tilting toward McMurphy's side when, in a final showdown, Big Nurse takes action to destroy the chief rebel. She has him seized to undergo a forced lobotomy. Chief Bromden smothers the atrophied McMurphy, and runs to freedom.

The metaphorical significance of the story is self-evident. The mental hospital ward is symbolic of a microcosm of the world at large. Here is an authoritarian system at the head of which sits the cool, cold ruler, Nurse Ratched, or Big Nurse. She is an efficient administrator, making rules of control, and making people follow them. The cost of the uniformity and forced peace in her ward is enormous in terms of human worth and human rights. The inmates feel the way Big Nurse wants them to feel; they live the way her system tells them to live. As for room for cure and growth, there is none, and there is little enjoyment. The patients smile little, laugh less, and behave mechanically as parts of a machine. "The Combine," as Chief Bromden calls Big Nurse's control system, has turned everyone into the nuts and bolts of her repressive mechanism. Dehumanization has gone on in full swing unchecked for a long time. The satire of the novel spearheads directly against the leveling, conforming tendency of the contemporary mechanical civilization. The fight between McMurphy and his followers on the one hand and Big Nurse and her jackals on the other assumes a social magnitude and sends out a message of universal implication.

Big Nurse represents total control. Her system is well devised. She divides her patients into neat categories such as the Acutes, and Chronics which is further subdivided into Walkers, Wheelers, and Vegetables. She plays the inmates against each other. She has them spy on one another, and takes advantage of their emotional inadequacies such as fear. Tolerating no relaxation like music and laughter, she crushes any hint of disobedience. She gets upset and lets people know that when anything goes out of her prescribed routine. She trains her black boys and her staff in such a way that all tune in with her in everything. Sitting in the Nurse Station with a steel panel of dials and buttons, she rules with absolute power, and enjoys it with full relish. She does not have to raise her voice or lift her finger. The Combine runs "like a smooth, accurate, precision-made machine," and the ward hums the way a cotton mill does. She is all self-control, herself a paragon of automation of her own making. Big Nurse embodies the extremity of total control in life.

In contrast, McMurphy represents total freedom. He hates to see one person lording it over all and making all wretched. He hates the stifling atmosphere of the ward. He hates the kind of living death that the inmates are experiencing. Now that he is here, he tries to initiate a change. He introduces smiles and laughter into the lives of the miserable people. Laughter celebrates and frees the irrational, releases repressed energies, and helps restore injured instincts. He introduces alcohol and sex both of which prove to be effective restoratives to the patients' emotional balance. And he brings music and singing back into their dull, high-strung existence. All these arouse their interest in living and behaving with dignity. They follow McMurphy and become his fellow rebels. McMurphy almost succeeds. The inmates all manage to recover somehow. In varying degrees the crowd relearn to breathe as they please and rediscover their self-esteem and their own potential for cure, for love, and for enjoyment of life. Chief Bromden's transformation is the most noticeable. The last scene of orgy offers convincing proof that most of them are loosened up and almost cured. McMurphy saves them all, or almost. He has been a Jesus Christ to them. This is the positive side of the rebellion. The title of the book, although dubious, is at least meant to be a partial reference

to McMurphy's redeeming action. Taken from Chief Bromden's Grandmother's song, the goose that flew over the cuckoo's nest was the one that asserted itself best. As the cuckoo's nest means also a mental asylum, the title should be a paean of both McMurphy and Chief Bromden, though ultimately to Bromden and to man's successful attempt to live a free and whole life.

There is also a downside in McMurphy's character to consider. A close look at McMurphy's behavior reveals an ambivalence in the man's personality. There is in him a tendency to resent and resist all rules and regulations. The doctors report that there is in him a marked disregard for discipline and authority; and in his life, free or exacerbated, he has had a history of arrests for street and barroom fights, drunkenness, disturbing peace, and statutory rape. Big Nurse and her staff are biased against McMurphy as one who has been hostile to authority everywhere he has been, in school, in the service, or in jail. McMurphy is not noted for self-control. He acts like a child occasionally; he allows his anger to overpower him; and he can be confused as to what to do sometimes. As a result, he exposes himself as well as his buddies to unnecessary danger. His success is not an unqualified one after all. Deaths have occurred. Cheswick and Bibbit could have lived. So could he himself. But it did not happen that way. Using evil to fight evil at the end and losing his sanity at the critical moment, he pays his own price for his mistakes. All in all, McMurphy stands at the other end of the line: he embodies the extremity of total freedom.

Neither of the extremes is the best possible for human conduct. Both are flawed approaches to human existence. Chief Bromden grows to learn to reject them and locate the mean in between. Chief Bromden is the only major character who grows fully in the course of the fight. Before he landed in the mental hospital, he had suffered gravely. His father was an Indian chief; his mother was a white woman. The government tried to talk his father into selling his property including his land and falls for money, but the father resisted long and hard, knowing well that, in complying, his Indian way of life was at stake. He was big, probably the biggest Indian in Oregon, or California, but with his wife "civilizing" and making him ever smaller, and the government threatening and actually beating him up, he could no longer keep up the fight. In despair he lost himself in cans of beer, and died of drunkenness. He was defeated by a white America and its discriminatory system. Chief Bromden witnessed all this and was mentally upset. As he told his new-found friend and role model, McMurphy, the Combine (his way of calling the government and its control system) would tolerate no one big and different, exactly the way Big Nurse is dealing with him now. In a way Chief Bromden sees in the fight between Big Nurse and McMurphy a reenacting of the horrible drama between the government and his father. The difference lies in this, that this time he is a participant, no longer scared and a lot wiser. And sure enough, he envisions and warns McMurphy of the impending doom over his head.

Chief Bromden's growth begins with McMurphy's appearance in the ward. He has been through numerous electroshock treatments and has been depending on medication to help him cope with his fears and feelings of estrangement from others. All he has done has been to sweep the floor everyday; he has been a walking "vegetable" to all around. McMurphy's distinct personality, his fighting spirit, and his self-respect all combine to inject vitality into the Chief's being so that he slowly revives. He begins to smile, recovers his numb senses and emotional responses, retrieves his memory, overcomes the shadow of the past, and learns to be his natural self. And he regains his courage. Through the constant contests between Big Nurse and McMurphy, and evidently during the fishing trip, Chief Bromden achieves maturity and gets ready to live the way a human being should. He saves his friend, now pathetic after the lobotomy, by

killing him, and then runs for his freedom. From the fight that rages between the two sides, he emerges the winner, with McMurphy dead and Big Nurse losing out to his spiritual legacy. In this sense he is both the narrator and the major character; the novel is mainly about neither McMurphy nor the Combine; it is about Chief Bromden's spiritual progress toward recovering the wholeness of his humanity. It is ultimately he who represents the thematic focus of the book. As he survives well enough to tell the story, he has apparently become a writer, a measure for observing and evaluating life and people. It is interesting to note that the depletion of the master and the growth of the disciple go side by side, the former contributing to the latter in a decided way. McMurphy and Chief Bromden body forth between them a vision of life and man, that self-assertion and preservation of one's individuality is necessary for survival in the overall repressive and conformist milieu of society.

The world of *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* is an absurd one. For one thing, the fog-generating machine creates a surreal impression. It makes everything opaque and nebulous so that the real and the unreal intermingle and make for uncertainty. The impression becomes particularly poignant when we hear about the fog from Chief Bromden, who appears to be a schizophrenic at first. Then the narrator's reliability is in question. His mental derangement throws a veil of doubt over his story. Yet we know that he is not a severe mental patient; he is sane most of the time; and he is recovering his mental health. His mental state thus conditions his narrative with an interesting air of a medley of reality with the grotesque. The world he sees is a cartoon world; the people he deals with are cartoon figures except they are real (as he put it): they are strangely real and grotesque at the same time. The characters are archetypal of human character traits of some kind so that they appear to be abstractions in a medieval morality play. Most of the time, Chief Bromden's spectrum has only two prime colors, black and white. Big Nurse is all evil; McMurphy is all good; there is nothing secondary or tertiary in between. Both are cartoons. Yet they are such people of blood and flesh. Big Nurse is so real bad, and her foe is so real good. The absurd effect thus hardly susceptible steals into the minds of the readers.

One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest has become a classic. Ken Kesey will be remembered as its author.

Now we come to John Barth (1930-). Barth was born in Maryland and became a college writing teacher in the early 1950s. Both were significant facts of his life because the first relates him to the "southern" literary tradition of Faulkner and Thomas Wolfe, and the second places him among a generation of writers many of whom have to do with the academia. There is a southern flavor in his writings, and many of his stories are set in a university locale. He has been a prolific writer, publishing *Letters: A Novel* (1979), *Sabbatical: A Romance* (1982), *The Tidewater Tales* (1987), and *The Last Voyage of Somebody the Sailor* (1991) in addition to the works to be discussed below. His essays and nonfiction writings were collected in *The Friday Book* (1984).

Barth is a highly significant writer of the period. One of the things with which he has been credited is the essay he wrote in 1967, entitled "The Literature of Exhaustion," which signaled the beginning of postmodern and metafictional fiction in the US and declared the death (his word for the idea) of traditional realism. He thinks that the novel as a genre has been perfected by the great masters of the 19th century and the first part of the 20th, its possibilities as a form have been exhausted, and all the available plots have been used up. Flaubert, Tolstoy, Hemingway, and Faulkner have our respect and admiration, but possess no more appeal to writers of the last third of the 20th century. The traditional novel is dead with Joyce and Kafka. Younger writers will have to

find a new way of writing. Barth did not embrace Sigmund Freud and D. H. Lawrence; he turned instead to the earliest novelists like Cervantes (1547-1616), Henry Fielding (1707-1754), Laurence Stern (1713-1768), and even *The Arabian Nights* for inspiration. He took great interest in the narrative mode of linking many stories in one framework, and found the absurdist and metafictional works of English playwright Samuel Becket (1906-1989) and Argentine novelist Jorge Luis Borges (1899-1986) especially attractive. With the publication of his works such as *The Sot-Weed Factor* (1960) and *Lost in the Funhouse* (1968), Barth began to take the lead in the postmodern endeavor in America.

John Barth's attempt to chart out a new way of fiction writing began ?if not very consciously ?in his first two novels, *The Floating Opera* (1956) and *The End of the Road* (1958). Both works still follow the traditional models, but changes in theme and technique have appeared. In theme, Barth presents an absurd world with no purpose and meaning, which is to become the thematic focus of his later works as well. To the narrator of *The Floating Opera*, for instance, nothing matters in the world including the truth. He views the world as one not only absurd but also nihilistic. The world of *The End of the Road* is no less preposterous and bleak to its protagonist, Jacob Horner. To him nothing is important, and he has lost interest in doing anything. He does not finish his MA degree. He does not want to go anywhere. He teaches but does not care "a damn about the job." He commits adultery with a friend's wife but feels nothing about it. Altogether he feels nothing for anything. In formal aspects, there appears a kind of playfulness akin to jazz improvisations, and to black humor then fast emerging as a trend. He parodies authors like Camus on suicide in his first novel and Sartre on commitment and protean freedom in his second. He was also trying to frame exhausted literary forms within his own structures so as to reinvigorate them. Incidentally, parody and framing were to become the major features of his postmodern writing.

The Sot-Weed Factor has been regarded by many as his masterpiece. The title needs explaining. A sot-weed factor is a merchant in tobacco. *The Sot-Weed Factor* is also the title of a poem published in 1708 in London by an actual poet, Ebenezer Cooke. Now the novel is simple in story line. The plot follows Ebenezer Cooke through a series of amusing adventures in 17th-century England and America. Young Englishman Ebenezer Cooke, son of a planter and trader, decides to devote himself to virginity and poetry. Owing to the unorthodox methods of instruction of his tutor, Henry Burlingame ?, Ebenezer is a failure at the age of 27 both as a scholar and a businessman. On one occasion he gets involved with a prostitute, Joan Toast, but he refuses to have anything to do with an exchange of money for sex. He falls in love with the trollop. Although the affair is not consummated, Ebenezer feels inspired, writes a poem to virginity, and decides to become a poet. Joan begins to like him. However, this gets him in trouble with Joan's pimp John McEvoy and also with his father who receives McEvoy's letter about the incident and sends Ebenezer to Maryland to oversee the family plantation ?Malden ?there. He comes over with a commission naming him the poet laureate of the province and is plunged into the political intrigues there. Joan follows him to Maryland. The story is riddled with plots and counter-plots, coincidences, disguises, and reversals. Ebenezer exchanges identity with his servant, is taken by pirates and thrown overboard, loses his estate and has to work as a servant on it, is captured by the Indians, etc. Eventually he regains the plantation, marries Joan, and writes a bitter poem, entitled *The Sot-Weed Factor*. The difference between the actual content of the poem and that of his original romantic conception shows that Ebenezer has grown from an innocent fool to a worldly

person. As his tutor Burlingame ? says, experience is superior to innocence.

The Sot-Weed Factor is one of Barth's major experimental works. It is the author's deliberate attempt at the use of parody. It parodies the 18th-century novel and its various conventions in general, and Henry Fielding's *Tom Jones* and the picaresque tradition in particular. The 18th-century view of the world was hierarchic in nature, with everything well fitting into a carefully structured scheme. Fielding's *Tom Jones* is a typical 18th-century novel, representing the orderliness of the universe by means of its highly structured form. The book thus achieves a unity of form and theme, a wholeness which breathes affirmation. Now John Barth and other novelists of the contemporary period have recognized the painful fact that their world is a radically different one. Ultimately they also work for affirmation, it is true, but they have got to do it in their own ?different ?ways. Barth sees the possibility of splitting form and theme, of producing a jarring incongruity between them so that the absurdity of reality may be presented more clearly. In other words, Fielding's conventional form is still used, but it no longer serves as a vehicle for communicating the notion of order and harmony. Thus *The Sot-Weed Factor* is a "formal farce," a farcical ?absurd ?theme encased in a well-structured form.

Barth's story is outrageous. *The Sot-Weed Factor*, like *Tom Jones*, also contains a series of coincidences, but not for the same purpose. Whereas to Fielding all that happens is part of a divine design, to Barth, the unexpected occurrence is a sign of the unpredictability and absurdity of a universe capable of no design whatever. In *The Sot-Weed Factor*, coincidences are not always credible, identities are frequently confused, and sexual encounters are tasteless at times. Ebenezer is in the New World to manage his family tobacco business. The Malden issue, its loss, and the steps taken for its recovery intertwine with its owner's attempt to write his epic *Marylandiad*. Joan's fall and rise and eventual marriage to Ebenezer adds to the improbability and preposterousness of life. Instead of an ordered, meaningful world of *Tom Jones*, *The Sot-Weed Factor* presents a thoughtless world of thoughtless men and women. It is John Barth's opinion that the reality of modern life is too complex and elusive for man to rationalize and idealize. Hence the failure of Ebenezer to regulate his life with his arbitrary standard of virginity. Only when he rejects it and embraces the world for what it is, can he feel the significance of his life adequately. This is, incidentally, an illustration of Barth's belief in participation, in accepting the chaos and absurdity of the world as the only meaningful way of life.

In addition to parody, other postmodern strategies are used, too. There is in the novel *mise-en-abyme* or stories within the story, which is one prominent feature of metafiction. For instance, there are quite a few lengthy tales of misfortune which Ebenezer hears from strangers; there is also Burlingame's discovery of Captain John Smith's "secret diary," a burlesque, which tells the funny "true" story of the Captain and the Indian Princess Pocahontas. And black humor permeates Ebenezer's world of cruelty, rapacity, and nightmares, a world where the only way man can avoid going crazy is through laughing out of despair.

Giles Goat-Boy is another of Barth's experimental work. The story is set, as often with Barth's works, in a university ?New Tammany College ?with two campuses, the East Campus and the West Campus. The protagonist is a demigod figure, a goat-boy, born of a human mother impregnated by a super automatic computer. The boy, Giles by name, is brought up by a professor, gets into the college, and tries to unravel the riddle left by his parents, "Pass All Fail All." He undergoes persecution by one professor and experiences corruption through sexual and spiritual temptations by another. He meets people, gets involved in events, and tries to make sense of them

all. Finally he discovers the meaning of the message, but feels unhappy ever after (as the motto on the Founder's scroll says, "Self-Knowledge Is Always Bad News"). Thematically, the novel is absurd in its impossible characters and events, and presents a world of ultimate futility, one of losers, as the hero eventually discovers. Formally, in addition to the fact that it is an amalgam of genres (fable, science fiction, allegory, epic etc.), the book's metafictional strategies are conspicuously noticeable. It exposes the artificial nature of narrative (annotating the meaning of each step that Giles takes in his adventure from birth to disappearance), and parodies the traditional techniques of allegory. The novel exhibits Barth's fascination with mythologies and legends. Here he examines all heroic conventions, their structures and functions and manipulates these for his purpose. As Barth explains somewhere in *Chimera* (1972) that myths as poetic distillations of human psychic experience point to daily reality, so it would be better "to address the archetypes directly." His exploration of myths and legends continues in *Lost in the Funhouse* (1968) and *Chimera*, two collections of short stories of significant experimental value.

The stories in *Lost in the Funhouse* echo the author's ideas expressed in "The Literature of Exhaustion." These stories are self-reflective, and self-referential. They reveal their fictional strategies, or as Barth puts it, turn their narrative means into part of their messages. Their author is acutely conscious that they are fictions and makes incessant comments upon the way they get written or develop as such, so that they end up being not only fictions but also about fictions or metafiction. *Lost in the Funhouse* is metafiction pure and simple. Take the title story, "Lost in the Funhouse," for example. This is a simple, short story. Every step of the way, the author is aware that he is fabricating a story, and loses no time telling his readers so. He is physically present all the time, explaining why things like italics are used, or poking fun at realist traditions and practices. The narrative topography of the fourth paragraph may be an illustration as good as any in the piece. Continuing the story line of Ambrose going on a visit to Ocean City with his family, the paragraph begins with a nine-line comment on characterization, then goes on with a 12-line description of the mother and the uncle, and then switches back to a 3-line authorial observation about James Joyce and his *Ulysses*. Then six lines of story interest follow, and another 10-line authorial comments on his use of metaphor or related narrative strategies wrap up the paragraph. If we do our sums right, authorial comments and observations account for well over 50% of the whole of the narrative. So the story is about two things at the same time: it tells not only a story, but also how to write a story. It is not quite fiction in the normal sense of the term. It is about fiction, too. Hence metafiction.

If we take a closer look at the structural design of the whole story, the result is even more amazing. Out of the 52 paragraphs (long and short) that make up the story, 26 are of narrative interest, 21 of both narrative interest and authorial interpolations, and 5 (i.e. paragraphs 1, 9, 34, 46, and 47) consisting wholly of the author's chat about fiction making. Even in the 26 paragraphs devoted to story telling, authorial intrusions like addressing the readers as "you," "your," or occasionally "we" often occur so as to remind the readers that someone is manipulating behind the scene. Such a metafictional manner of storytelling is new and offers a new way of writing. Its experimental value is significant as it adds a fresh strategy to a narrative form which seems, to some people, out of date and inadequate in face of new experience. This is its positive side. The other side of the coin is that such a story like "Lost in the Funhouse" can put readers off, especially those who read for pleasure and not to learn to be a writer, least of all a good one. The result is that if they decide to go on reading, they may keep jumping and skipping, or else they

lose interest and drop the book altogether. Luckily for the readers, however, John Barth can always pick literature apart, play with it, and wrap the threads of interest together in time for amusement and revelation. So as the story goes, Ambrose sets out for the funhouse, gets lost in it, learns wisdom, and goes home more grown up.

John Barth feels that the conventional novel's attempt to impose order on a disordered reality is artificial and falsifying. So he has been trying constantly to prove to his readers the artifice of his novels. Metafiction has stood the test of time and has been received as a good narrative method in literary creations. John Barth has been instrumental in helping it take root in America. Seen from a larger perspective, his effort has helped the growth of postmodernism in novel writing. He was happy to list over 20 authors of the postmodernist tendency in his "The Literature of Replenishment" (1979), who have helped to revive the novel and injected new blood into it. The genre is more alive today for their efforts.

Another postmodern writer is Donald Barthelme (1931-1989), who was a short story writer, a novelist, and a writer of children's literature. His works made him a preeminent figure of experimental fiction. A trailblazer of his time, he became a postmodernist even before the classification came in use. Sensitive to the change taking place in life and literature, Barthelme wrote with a keen awareness that realism was outmoded for his time and that something like new modes of perception and expression truer to the spirit of the time had to appear. Influenced by the French symbolists, European surrealism of the 1920s, and writers like John Dos Passos, Barthelme has been renowned for his comic and surreal vision, his portrayal of the grotesque and the fragmented, his experimental style of montage, visual effects and graphic play, and his parody of traditional forms of storytelling, all that classified him definitely as postmodernist and avant-gardist. He was a leading figure in the renaissance of the short story as a genre, and his short stories have been collected in nine collections such as *Come Back, Dr. Caligari* (1964), *Unspeakable Practices, Unnatural Acts* (1968), *City Life* (1971), *Sadness* (1972), *Guilty Pleasures* (1974), *Amateurs* (1976), *Great Days* (1978), and *Overnight to Many Distant Cities* (1983). His four novels include *Snow White* (1967), *The Dead Father* (1977), and *The King* (1990). His children's book, *The Slightly Irregular Fire Engine: or, The Hithering Thithering Djinn* (1971) won the National Book Award for children's literature.

The absurdity feature of the book is also enhanced by the portrayal of scenes and the use of language that help generate a sad humor all the way through. The book contains countless scenarios the description of which induces simultaneous irrepressible compassion and laughter. One of these is recorded in chapter four:

Listen ?on the tenth night the peg was pull out of the hasp on Billy's boxcar door, and the door was opened. Billy Pilgrim was lying at an angle on the corner-brace, self-crucified, holding himself there with a blue and ivory claw hooked over the sill of the ventilator. Billy coughed when the door was opened, and when he coughed he shit thin gruel. This was in accordance with the Third Law of Motion according to Sir Isaac Newton. This law tells us that for every action there is a reaction which is equal and

opposite in direction.

This can be useful in rocketry. (My italics)

The piteous, ridiculous position in which Billy lies to ride on the boxcar, the use of words such as "self-crucified" and "shit thin gruel," and the invocation of Newton, a benefactor to humankind, and of rocketry, the superpower competition about which horrified mankind so ?all these engender a laugh at once qualified in so many ways by the fact that it depends all on the danger that Billy is experiencing in that position: he could have died so easily.

Slaughterhouse-Five is an interesting specimen of formal experimentation. For one thing, it manifests evident features of metafiction. One metafictional strategy is to tell the readers that what they are reading is the author's fabrication. Vonnegut makes it very clear repeatedly that he is telling a story. "So it goes," in addition to its other functions, colors everything the narrator says as doubtful, and "listen," used repeatedly in the imperative mood, indicates somebody behind the scene, the narrator, or the author, or some wire-puller, made both audible and visible, that destroys any possible illusion and verisimilitude of reality that traditional realism seeks to create. Furthermore, authorial presence and authorial comments help make the narrative appear fictional. Vonnegut appears directly in the first and last chapters of the book and talks about the process of its creation. There are also a number of occasions when he pops out in the middle of the narrative with a comment of his own. He also appears in the novel in other more subtle ways; for instance, the phone call Billy receives one night from a drunk with breath "like mustard gas and roses" hints at the author hidden backstage. The difference between Vonnegut and the postmodern novelists on the one hand and Jamesian realists on the other lies in this, that whereas the latter try to manufacture reality out of fiction, the former do their best to make fiction out of reality. Vonnegut was writing about his own war experience in Slaughterhouse-Five but he did it as if he was telling something not real. It is good to note that Vonnegut uses metafictional strategies well in his other works such as Breakfast of the Champions, Jailbird, and Cat's Cradle.

Vonnegut is also well known as a short-story writer. In these short writings he is good at combining black humor with science fiction. His short story, "Harrison Bergeron" (1961), is a good example. Read the first paragraph and the satirical edge is crystal clear: "The year was 2081, and everybody was finally equal. They weren't only equal before God and law. They were equal every which way. Nobody was smarter than anybody else. Nobody was better looking than anybody else. Nobody was stronger or quicker than anybody else." If anyone is smarter like Harrison's father, they would have to wear a handicap radio in their ears which will reduce the level of their cerebral activity to average. If anyone is prettier, they have to wear an ugly-looking mask. As Harrison is smarter, taller, stronger, and more rebellious, he will have to be locked away or eventually shot. This is a dark satire against the leveling, or depersonalizing, tendency of modern life. The readers feel amused so much that even the execution scene does not appear very bizarre and evil.

In the postmodern move to subvert realism, Vonnegut has done a good deal. Both in the absurd fiction and science fiction, he has made a significant contribution. If he had not written anything else, one Slaughterhouse-Five would have been just enough to ensure a space for him in American literature.

Another well-known novelist of the absurd is Ken Kesey (1935-). He was born in Oregon, where he still lives, graduated from the University of Oregon, and studied at Stanford under famous critics and writers such as Malcolm Cowley and Frank O'Hara. So far he has written a few

novels including *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1962), *Sometimes a Great Notion* (1964), *Demon Box* (1986), and *Sailor Song* (1992). In addition, he has written a couple of children's books.

Kesey is well known for his novel, *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*. The story is set in a mental hospital near Portland, Oregon. The life of the inmates seems to be placid until Randle McMurphy storms into it. McMurphy comes after feigning psychosis in order to avoid physical labor that he had to do on a farm of correction for minor offenses he committed. At 35 he is jovial and dynamic and feels soon repulsed by the totalitarian rule that Big Nurse exercises over the patients. He begins to act and undermine her authority. Taking the lead in the successive rebellious acts, he manages to awaken the patients to the need to assert their rights as humans and to their potential for growth. One of them, Chief Bromden, an American Indian of mixed blood, changes from a deaf mute to an active follower of this hero. Confrontations occur, and Big Nurse is losing ground. The scales are tilting toward McMurphy's side when, in a final showdown, Big Nurse takes action to destroy the chief rebel. She has him seized to undergo a forced lobotomy. Chief Bromden smothers the atrophied McMurphy, and runs to freedom.

The metaphorical significance of the story is self-evident. The mental hospital ward is symbolic of a microcosm of the world at large. Here is an authoritarian system at the head of which sits the cool, cold ruler, Nurse Ratched, or Big Nurse. She is an efficient administrator, making rules of control, and making people follow them. The cost of the uniformity and forced peace in her ward is enormous in terms of human worth and human rights. The inmates feel the way Big Nurse wants them to feel; they live the way her system tells them to live. As for room for cure and growth, there is none, and there is little enjoyment. The patients smile little, laugh less, and behave mechanically as parts of a machine. "The Combine," as Chief Bromden calls Big Nurse's control system, has turned everyone into the nuts and bolts of her repressive mechanism. Dehumanization has gone on in full swing unchecked for a long time. The satire of the novel spearheads directly against the leveling, conforming tendency of the contemporary mechanical civilization. The fight between McMurphy and his followers on the one hand and Big Nurse and her jackals on the other assumes a social magnitude and sends out a message of universal implication.

Big Nurse represents total control. Her system is well devised. She divides her patients into neat categories such as the Acutes, and Chronics which is further subdivided into Walkers, Wheelers, and Vegetables. She plays the inmates against each other. She has them spy on one another, and takes advantage of their emotional inadequacies such as fear. Tolerating no relaxation like music and laughter, she crushes any hint of disobedience. She gets upset and lets people know that when anything goes out of her prescribed routine. She trains her black boys and her staff in such a way that all tune in with her in everything. Sitting in the Nurse Station with a steel panel of dials and buttons, she rules with absolute power, and enjoys it with full relish. She does not have to raise her voice or lift her finger. The Combine runs "like a smooth, accurate, precision-made machine," and the ward hums the way a cotton mill does. She is all self-control, herself a paragon of automation of her own making. Big Nurse embodies the extremity of total control in life.

In contrast, McMurphy represents total freedom. He hates to see one person lording it over all and making all wretched. He hates the stifling atmosphere of the ward. He hates the kind of living death that the inmates are experiencing. Now that he is here, he tries to initiate a change. He introduces smiles and laughter into the lives of the miserable people. Laughter celebrates and frees

the irrational, releases repressed energies, and helps restore injured instincts. He introduces alcohol and sex both of which prove to be effective restoratives to the patients' emotional balance. And he brings music and singing back into their dull, high-strung existence. All these arouse their interest in living and behaving with dignity. They follow McMurphy and become his fellow rebels. McMurphy almost succeeds. The inmates all manage to recover somehow. In varying degrees the crowd relearn to breathe as they please and rediscover their self-esteem and their own potential for cure, for love, and for enjoyment of life. Chief Bromden's transformation is the most noticeable. The last scene of orgy offers convincing proof that most of them are loosened up and almost cured. McMurphy saves them all, or almost. He has been a Jesus Christ to them. This is the positive side of the rebellion. The title of the book, although dubious, is at least meant to be a partial reference to McMurphy's redeeming action. Taken from Chief Bromden's Grandmother's song, the goose that flew over the cuckoo's nest was the one that asserted itself best. As the cuckoo's nest means also a mental asylum, the title should be a paean of both McMurphy and Chief Bromden, though ultimately to Bromden and to man's successful attempt to live a free and whole life.

There is also a downside in McMurphy's character to consider. A close look at McMurphy's behavior reveals an ambivalence in the man's personality. There is in him a tendency to resent and resist all rules and regulations. The doctors report that there is in him a marked disregard for discipline and authority; and in his life, free or exacerbated, he has had a history of arrests for street and barroom fights, drunkenness, disturbing peace, and statutory rape. Big Nurse and her staff are biased against McMurphy as one who has been hostile to authority everywhere he has been, in school, in the service, or in jail. McMurphy is not noted for self-control. He acts like a child occasionally; he allows his anger to overpower him; and he can be confused as to what to do sometimes. As a result, he exposes himself as well as his buddies to unnecessary danger. His success is not an unqualified one after all. Deaths have occurred. Cheswick and Bibbit could have lived. So could he himself. But it did not happen that way. Using evil to fight evil at the end and losing his sanity at the critical moment, he pays his own price for his mistakes. All in all, McMurphy stands at the other end of the line: he embodies the extremity of total freedom.

Neither of the extremes is the best possible for human conduct. Both are flawed approaches to human existence. Chief Bromden grows to learn to reject them and locate the mean in between. Chief Bromden is the only major character who grows fully in the course of the fight. Before he landed in the mental hospital, he had suffered gravely. His father was an Indian chief; his mother was a white woman. The government tried to talk his father into selling his property including his land and falls for money, but the father resisted long and hard, knowing well that, in complying, his Indian way of life was at stake. He was big, probably the biggest Indian in Oregon, or California, but with his wife "civilizing" and making him ever smaller, and the government threatening and actually beating him up, he could no longer keep up the fight. In despair he lost himself in cans of beer, and died of drunkenness. He was defeated by a white America and its discriminatory system. Chief Bromden witnessed all this and was mentally upset. As he told his new-found friend and role model, McMurphy, the Combine (his way of calling the government and its control system) would tolerate no one big and different, exactly the way Big Nurse is dealing with him now. In a way Chief Bromden sees in the fight between Big Nurse and McMurphy a reenacting of the horrible drama between the government and his father. The difference lies in this, that this time he is a participant, no longer scared and a lot wiser. And sure enough, he envisions and warns McMurphy of the impending doom over his head.

Chief Bromden's growth begins with McMurphy's appearance in the ward. He has been through numerous electroshock treatments and has been depending on medication to help him cope with his fears and feelings of estrangement from others. All he has done has been to sweep the floor everyday; he has been a walking "vegetable" to all around. McMurphy's distinct personality, his fighting spirit, and his self-respect all combine to inject vitality into the Chief's being so that he slowly revives. He begins to smile, recovers his numb senses and emotional responses, retrieves his memory, overcomes the shadow of the past, and learns to be his natural self. And he regains his courage. Through the constant contests between Big Nurse and McMurphy, and evidently during the fishing trip, Chief Bromden achieves maturity and gets ready to live the way a human being should. He saves his friend, now pathetic after the lobotomy, by killing him, and then runs for his freedom. From the fight that rages between the two sides, he emerges the winner, with McMurphy dead and Big Nurse losing out to his spiritual legacy. In this sense he is both the narrator and the major character; the novel is mainly about neither McMurphy nor the Combine; it is about Chief Bromden's spiritual progress toward recovering the wholeness of his humanity. It is ultimately he who represents the thematic focus of the book. As he survives well enough to tell the story, he has apparently become a writer, a measure for observing and evaluating life and people. It is interesting to note that the depletion of the master and the growth of the disciple go side by side, the former contributing to the latter in a decided way. McMurphy and Chief Bromden body forth between them a vision of life and man, that self-assertion and preservation of one's individuality is necessary for survival in the overall repressive and conformist milieu of society.

The world of *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* is an absurd one. For one thing, the fog-generating machine creates a surreal impression. It makes everything opaque and nebulous so that the real and the unreal intermingle and make for uncertainty. The impression becomes particularly poignant when we hear about the fog from Chief Bromden, who appears to be a schizophrenic at first. Then the narrator's reliability is in question. His mental derangement throws a veil of doubt over his story. Yet we know that he is not a severe mental patient; he is sane most of the time; and he is recovering his mental health. His mental state thus conditions his narrative with an interesting air of a medley of reality with the grotesque. The world he sees is a cartoon world; the people he deals with are cartoon figures except they are real (as he put it): they are strangely real and grotesque at the same time. The characters are archetypal of human character traits of some kind so that they appear to be abstractions in a medieval morality play. Most of the time, Chief Bromden's spectrum has only two prime colors, black and white. Big Nurse is all evil; McMurphy is all good; there is nothing secondary or tertiary in between. Both are cartoons. Yet they are such people of blood and flesh. Big Nurse is so real bad, and her foe is so real good. The absurd effect thus hardly susceptibly steals into the minds of the readers.

One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest has become a classic. Ken Kesey will be remembered as its author.

Now we come to John Barth (1930-). Barth was born in Maryland and became a college writing teacher in the early 1950s. Both were significant facts of his life because the first relates him to the "southern" literary tradition of Faulkner and Thomas Wolfe, and the second places him among a generation of writers many of whom have to do with the academia. There is a southern flavor in his writings, and many of his stories are set in a university locale. He has been a prolific writer, publishing *Letters: A Novel* (1979), *Sabbatical: A Romance* (1982), *The Tidewater Tales*

(1987), and *The Last Voyage of Somebody the Sailor* (1991) in addition to the works to be discussed below. His essays and nonfiction writings were collected in *The Friday Book* (1984).

Barth is a highly significant writer of the period. One of the things with which he has been credited is the essay he wrote in 1967, entitled "The Literature of Exhaustion," which signaled the beginning of postmodern and metafictional fiction in the US and declared the death (his word for the idea) of traditional realism. He thinks that the novel as a genre has been perfected by the great masters of the 19th century and the first part of the 20th, its possibilities as a form have been exhausted, and all the available plots have been used up. Flaubert, Tolstoy, Hemingway, and Faulkner have our respect and admiration, but possess no more appeal to writers of the last third of the 20th century. The traditional novel is dead with Joyce and Kafka. Younger writers will have to find a new way of writing. Barth did not embrace Sigmund Freud and D. H. Lawrence; he turned instead to the earliest novelists like Cervantes (1547-1616), Henry Fielding (1707-1754), Laurence Stern (1713-1768), and even *The Arabian Nights* for inspiration. He took great interest in the narrative mode of linking many stories in one framework, and found the absurdist and metafictional works of English playwright Samuel Becket (1906-1989) and Argentine novelist Jorge Luis Borges (1899-1986) especially attractive. With the publication of his works such as *The Sot-Weed Factor* (1960) and *Lost in the Funhouse* (1968), Barth began to take the lead in the postmodern endeavor in America.

John Barth's attempt to chart out a new way of fiction writing began ?if not very consciously ?in his first two novels, *The Floating Opera* (1956) and *The End of the Road* (1958). Both works still follow the traditional models, but changes in theme and technique have appeared. In theme, Barth presents an absurd world with no purpose and meaning, which is to become the thematic focus of his later works as well. To the narrator of *The Floating Opera*, for instance, nothing matters in the world including the truth. He views the world as one not only absurd but also nihilistic. The world of *The End of the Road* is no less preposterous and bleak to its protagonist, Jacob Horner. To him nothing is important, and he has lost interest in doing anything. He does not finish his MA degree. He does not want to go anywhere. He teaches but does not care "a damn about the job." He commits adultery with a friend's wife but feels nothing about it. Altogether he feels nothing for anything. In formal aspects, there appears a kind of playfulness akin to jazz improvisations, and to black humor then fast emerging as a trend. He parodies authors like Camus on suicide in his first novel and Sartre on commitment and protean freedom in his second. He was also trying to frame exhausted literary forms within his own structures so as to reinvigorate them. Incidentally, parody and framing were to become the major features of his postmodern writing.

The Sot-Weed Factor has been regarded by many as his masterpiece. The title needs explaining. A sot-weed factor is a merchant in tobacco. *The Sot-Weed Factor* is also the title of a poem published in 1708 in London by an actual poet, Ebenezer Cooke. Now the novel is simple in story line. The plot follows Ebenezer Cooke through a series of amusing adventures in 17th-century England and America. Young Englishman Ebenezer Cooke, son of a planter and trader, decides to devote himself to virginity and poetry. Owing to the unorthodox methods of instruction of his tutor, Henry Burlingame ?, Ebenezer is a failure at the age of 27 both as a scholar and a businessman. On one occasion he gets involved with a prostitute, Joan Toast, but he refuses to have anything to do with an exchange of money for sex. He falls in love with the trollop. Although the affair is not consummated, Ebenezer feels inspired, writes a poem to virginity, and

decides to become a poet. Joan begins to like him. However, this gets him in trouble with Joan's pimp John McEvoy and also with his father who receives McEvoy's letter about the incident and sends Ebenezer to Maryland to oversee the family plantation ?Malden ?there. He comes over with a commission naming him the poet laureate of the province and is plunged into the political intrigues there. Joan follows him to Maryland. The story is riddled with plots and counter-plots, coincidences, disguises, and reversals. Ebenezer exchanges identity with his servant, is taken by pirates and thrown overboard, loses his estate and has to work as a servant on it, is captured by the Indians, etc. Eventually he regains the plantation, marries Joan, and writes a bitter poem, entitled *The Sot-Weed Factor*. The difference between the actual content of the poem and that of his original romantic conception shows that Ebenezer has grown from an innocent fool to a worldly person. As his tutor Burlingame ? says, experience is superior to innocence.

The Sot-Weed Factor is one of Barth's major experimental works. It is the author's deliberate attempt at the use of parody. It parodies the 18-century novel and its various conventions in general, and Henry Fielding's *Tom Jones* and the picaresque tradition in particular. The 18th-century view of the world was hierarchic in nature, with everything well fitting into a carefully structured scheme. Fielding's *Tom Jones* is a typical 18th-century novel, representing the orderliness of the universe by means of its highly structured form. The book thus achieves a unity of form and theme, a wholeness which breathes affirmation. Now John Barth and other novelists of the contemporary period have recognized the painful fact that their world is a radically different one. Ultimately they also work for affirmation, it is true, but they have got to do it in their own ?different ?ways. Barth sees the possibility of splitting form and theme, of producing a jarring incongruity between them so that the absurdity of reality may be presented more clearly. In other words, Fielding's conventional form is still used, but it no longer serves as a vehicle for communicating the notion of order and harmony. Thus *The Sot-Weed Factor* is a "formal farce," a farcical ?absurd ?theme encased in a well-structured form.

Barth's story is outrageous. *The Sot-Weed Factor*, like *Tom Jones*, also contains a series of coincidences, but not for the same purpose. Whereas to Fielding all that happens is part of a divine design, to Barth, the unexpected occurrence is a sign of the unpredictability and absurdity of a universe capable of no design whatever. In *The Sot-Weed Factor*, coincidences are not always credible, identities are frequently confused, and sexual encounters are tasteless at times. Ebenezer is in the New World to manage his family tobacco business. The Malden issue, its loss, and the steps taken for its recovery intertwine with its owner's attempt to write his epic *Marylandiad*. Joan's fall and rise and eventual marriage to Ebenezer adds to the improbability and preposterousness of life. Instead of an ordered, meaningful world of *Tom Jones*, *The Sot-Weed Factor* presents a thoughtless world of thoughtless men and women. It is John Barth's opinion that the reality of modern life is too complex and elusive for man to rationalize and idealize. Hence the failure of Ebenezer to regulate his life with his arbitrary standard of virginity. Only when he rejects it and embraces the world for what it is, can he feel the significance of his life adequately. This is, incidentally, an illustration of Barth's belief in participation, in accepting the chaos and absurdity of the world as the only meaningful way of life.

In addition to parody, other postmodern strategies are used, too. There is in the novel *mise-en-abyme* or stories within the story, which is one prominent feature of metafiction. For instance, there are quite a few lengthy tales of misfortune which Ebenezer hears from strangers; there is also Burlingame's discovery of Captain John Smith's "secret diary," a burlesque, which

tells the funny "true" story of the Captain and the Indian Princess Pocahontas. And black humor permeates Ebenezer's world of cruelty, rapacity, and nightmares, a world where the only way man can avoid going crazy is through laughing out of despair.

Giles Goat-Boy is another of Barth's experimental work. The story is set, as often with Barth's works, in a university ?New Tammany College ?with two campuses, the East Campus and the West Campus. The protagonist is a demigod figure, a goat-boy, born of a human mother impregnated by a super automatic computer. The boy, Giles by name, is brought up by a professor, gets into the college, and tries to unravel the riddle left by his parents, "Pass All Fail All." He undergoes persecution by one professor and experiences corruption through sexual and spiritual temptations by another. He meets people, gets involved in events, and tries to make sense of them all. Finally he discovers the meaning of the message, but feels unhappy ever after (as the motto on the Founder's scroll says, "Self-Knowledge Is Always Bad News"). Thematically, the novel is absurd in its impossible characters and events, and presents a world of ultimate futility, one of losers, as the hero eventually discovers. Formally, in addition to the fact that it is an amalgam of genres (fable, science fiction, allegory, epic etc.), the book's metafictional strategies are conspicuously noticeable. It exposes the artificial nature of narrative (annotating the meaning of each step that Giles takes in his adventure from birth to disappearance), and parodies the traditional techniques of allegory. The novel exhibits Barth's fascination with mythologies and legends. Here he examines all heroic conventions, their structures and functions and manipulates these for his purpose. As Barth explains somewhere in *Chimera* (1972) that myths as poetic distillations of human psychic experience point to daily reality, so it would be better "to address the archetypes directly." His exploration of myths and legends continues in *Lost in the Funhouse* (1968) and *Chimera*, two collections of short stories of significant experimental value.

The stories in *Lost in the Funhouse* echo the author's ideas expressed in "The Literature of Exhaustion." These stories are self-reflective, and self-referential. They reveal their fictional strategies, or as Barth puts it, turn their narrative means into part of their messages. Their author is acutely conscious that they are fictions and makes incessant comments upon the way they get written or develop as such, so that they end up being not only fictions but also about fictions or metafiction. *Lost in the Funhouse* is metafiction pure and simple. Take the title story, "Lost in the Funhouse," for example. This is a simple, short story. Every step of the way, the author is aware that he is fabricating a story, and loses no time telling his readers so. He is physically present all the time, explaining why things like italics are used, or poking fun at realist traditions and practices. The narrative topography of the fourth paragraph may be an illustration as good as any in the piece. Continuing the story line of Ambrose going on a visit to Ocean City with his family, the paragraph begins with a nine-line comment on characterization, then goes on with a 12-line description of the mother and the uncle, and then switches back to a 3-line authorial observation about James Joyce and his Ulysses. Then six lines of story interest follow, and another 10-line authorial comments on his use of metaphor or related narrative strategies wrap up the paragraph. If we do our sums right, authorial comments and observations account for well over 50% of the whole of the narrative. So the story is about two things at the same time: it tells not only a story, but also how to write a story. It is not quite fiction in the normal sense of the term. It is about fiction, too. Hence metafiction.

If we take a closer look at the structural design of the whole story, the result is even more amazing. Out of the 52 paragraphs (long and short) that make up the story, 26 are of narrative

interest, 21 of both narrative interest and authorial interpolations, and 5 (i.e. paragraphs 1, 9, 34, 46, and 47) consisting wholly of the author's chat about fiction making. Even in the 26 paragraphs devoted to story telling, authorial intrusions like addressing the readers as "you," "your," or occasionally "we" often occur so as to remind the readers that someone is manipulating behind the scene. Such a metafictional manner of storytelling is new and offers a new way of writing. Its experimental value is significant as it adds a fresh strategy to a narrative form which seems, to some people, out of date and inadequate in face of new experience. This is its positive side. The other side of the coin is that such a story like "Lost in the Funhouse" can put readers off, especially those who read for pleasure and not to learn to be a writer, least of all a good one. The result is that if they decide to go on reading, they may keep jumping and skipping, or else they lose interest and drop the book altogether. Luckily for the readers, however, John Barth can always pick literature apart, play with it, and wrap the threads of interest together in time for amusement and revelation. So as the story goes, Ambrose sets out for the funhouse, gets lost in it, learns wisdom, and goes home more grown up.

John Barth feels that the conventional novel's attempt to impose order on a disordered reality is artificial and falsifying. So he has been trying constantly to prove to his readers the artifice of his novels. Metafiction has stood the test of time and has been received as a good narrative method in literary creations. John Barth has been instrumental in helping it take root in America. Seen from a larger perspective, his effort has helped the growth of postmodernism in novel writing. He was happy to list over 20 authors of the postmodernist tendency in his "The Literature of Replenishment" (1979), who have helped to revive the novel and injected new blood into it. The genre is more alive today for their efforts.

Another postmodern writer is Donald Barthelme (1931-1989), who was a short story writer, a novelist, and a writer of children's literature. His works made him a preeminent figure of experimental fiction. A trailblazer of his time, he became a postmodernist even before the classification came in use. Sensitive to the change taking place in life and literature, Barthelme wrote with a keen awareness that realism was outmoded for his time and that something like new modes of perception and expression truer to the spirit of the time had to appear. Influenced by the French symbolists, European surrealism of the 1920s, and writers like John Dos Passos, Barthelme has been renowned for his comic and surreal vision, his portrayal of the grotesque and the fragmented, his experimental style of montage, visual effects and graphic play, and his parody of traditional forms of storytelling, all that classified him definitely as postmodernist and avant-gardist. He was a leading figure in the renaissance of the short story as a genre, and his short stories have been collected in nine collections such as *Come Back, Dr. Caligari* (1964), *Unspeakable Practices, Unnatural Acts* (1968), *City Life* (1971), *Sadness* (1972), *Guilty Pleasures* (1974), *Amateurs* (1976), *Great Days* (1978), and *Overnight to Many Distant Cities* (1983). His four novels include *Snow White* (1967), *The Dead Father* (1977), and *The King* (1990). His children's book, *The Slightly Irregular Fire Engine: or, The Hithering Thithering Djinn* (1971) won the National Book Award for children's literature.

CHAPTER 25 Multiethnic Literature (I):

African American Literature

African American literature has come a long way. It is a unique literature because it is all

tied up with the unique experience of the African American people and the phases of their steady growth. The African Americans have a history of their own. Their life in Africa before they were brought to America, the middle passage when so many of them died on the ships bringing them over, the slavery which was worse than death, the Emancipation after the Civil War, their movement to the cities where their life began to be polarized, the process of integration into the mainstream, and the Black Power movement and the Civil Rights movement—all these factors decide that the literary tradition of the African Americans is to be drastically different from the American literature we have been talking about so far, which is generally Anglo-American, and does not include much of American Indian culture and that of the African Americans. For a long time the images of the African Americans in mainstream American literature had been presented in a distorted manner. Even well wishing writers like Mark Twain were unable to overcome their prejudices. For instance, Jim in *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* is made out to be very funny and is important in the novel only for helping to reveal the growth of the social awareness of the white boy, Huck Finn. *Gone with the Wind*, by Margaret Mitchell (1900-1949), tells about the happy slaves happy to wait on their white masters, which is a gross distortion of African American life in the American South. Even Faulkner's *Go Down, Moses* depicts at one stage the ideal idyllic life of the past with happy African Americans as part of the picture, which tends to disgust African American readers. Neither Eugene O'Neill's *Emperor Jones* nor the famous *Uncle Tom's Cabin* is free of prejudice and condescension. These may not be intentional; the writers, dealing with an experience they do not easily share, just cannot help writing about it the way they do.

African American literature, as written by African American writers, differs in kind from all these. It centers on a myth, though also biblical, quite different from that on which mainstream American literature is based. Whereas the latter has been inspired at the outset by the myth of the Garden of Eden, African American literature is patterned on that of deliverance from slavery, that of the Hebrew prophet Moses leading the Jews in their flight from the bondage in Egypt. This is in a way the key to understanding this literature. The African American people often try to express their feelings and aspirations, in biblical terms, possibly for want of a better medium. We have noted earlier that "Go down, Moses," one of the hundreds of African American spirituals composed in the nineteenth century, translates the bondage of Israel in Egypt into a parallel of their own enslavement in America. They have been oppressed so hard that they can no longer stand, and they do not want to toil in fetters any more: they want "to go," which is another way of saying "freedom" and "emancipation." This is the essential spirit running through African American literature.

African American literature has undergone a long process of evolution. Oral tradition came first in the form of songs, ballads, and spirituals, in short, folk literature in its various manifestations. Then in the eighteenth century, African American poets like Jupiter Hammon (1720-1800) and Phyllis Wheatley (1753-1894) appeared on the scene. The abolitionist movement and the Civil War brought a new impetus to African American literature. Paul Laurence Dunbar (1872-1906) and James Weldon Johnson (1871-1938) produced substantial works of poetry and won national recognition. The African American novel began to make its presence felt in mid-nineteenth century when William Wells Brown's *Clotel; or, The President's Daughter, a Narrative of Slave Life in the United States* (1853) appeared in print in London. Brown describes *Clotel* as Thomas Jefferson's daughter by his slave, and exposes the evils of slavery and the hypocrisy of public officials. The first African American to publish her novel in the United States

was Harriet Wilson, whose *Our Nig; or, Sketches from the Life of a Free Black* (1859) focuses on race and class relations. Other works that appeared in the later part of the 19th century and the early 20th include Martin Delany's *Blake; or, The Huts of America: A Tale of the Mississippi Valley, the Southern United States and Cuba* (1859), which was the most radical novel of the century, Frances Harper's *Iola*, Amiri Baraka; or *Shadows Uplifted* (1892), Sutton Griggs' *Imperium in Imperio* (1899), another radical work stressing the need for a black organization, Charles Waddell Chestnut's *The Marrow of Tradition* (1901), and James Weldon Johnson's *The Autobiography of an Ex-Colored Man* (1912). Most of the works deal with mulattoes; all touch upon the question of racial oppression in an obvious way. The characters came from a middle class whose goal it was to achieve equal rights within the status quo.

An important event after the Emancipation was the Great Migration which occurred in full swing in the years between 1890 and 1920. On the one hand the cities were developing its industrial complexes that needed labor, and on the other large numbers of sharecroppers were driven out of the country by a number of factors such as natural calamities, poor soil, and agricultural mechanization. These people moved from the south to the north and poured into the cities in large numbers. Life in the ghettos in general, visible affluence for some, and opportunities for education ?all these paved the way for an inevitable literary expression. Of all the places where African Americans gathered was Harlem, New York City. Here large numbers of the African Americans from all places and all walks of life made Harlem the hub of black life that drew all their artists and intellectuals over. Shortly after WW?, a black intelligentsia appeared on the scene. They rebelled against the values of their fathers and their way of life. Situated as they were within New York City, the center of artistic and literary innovations, close to avant-garde places like the Greenwich Village, and living in the Jazz age, the African American artists and writers were influenced in large measure by the modernist movement then developing in the United States and Europe. They took an enormous interest in their own lives and values. They tried to solicit the attention of their African American people as well as the whites. And they began a search for a distinct tradition of their own. All these characterized a great movement in the cultural and intellectual history of the African Americans. This new upsurge of African American literature in the 1920s has come to be known as the Harlem Renaissance to which African American authors like Claude McKay (1889-1948), Langston Hughes (1902-1967), Jean Toomer (1894-1967), Countee Cullen (1903-1946), and many others contributed. McKay's poetry and novels, exalting the African American heritage, Langston Hughes' oeuvre exhibiting his love and knowledge for his own people, novelist-poet Jean Toomer's widely acclaimed novel, *Cane* (1923) and his other works, and the works of the talented Countee Cullen played an important part in the flowering of black Harlem. African American poetry became an indispensable part of American literature. Other important works, such as Nella Larsen's *Quicksand* (1928) and Zora Neale Hurston's *Their Eyes Were Watching God* (1937), continued to appear in the following years.

Then in 1940 Richard Wright's *Native Son* came out as a watershed in the tradition of the African American novel. In the 1950s, African American literature flourished with eminent authors such as Ralph Ellison (1914-1994) and James Baldwin (1924-1987), pushing it further to maturity. The 1960s proved to be a turbulent period for the United States when the African Americans awoke to the need for power, Black power, and it proved to be a period of spectacular growth in African American literature. African American writers such as Paule Marshall, Earle Conrad, John Oliver Killens, William Melvin Kelley, Jesse Hill Ford, Ishmael Reed, and John A.

Williams all rose to the attention of critics and readers alike. Then in the last couple of decades a group of African American writers added their significant contributions to the growth of African American literature. Toni Morrison and Alice Walker stand at the foremost of the group (which includes also Maya Angelou and Gloria Naylor among others), producing their best and making their presence keenly felt. African American theater was slower in developing. It was bleak in the last century and nothing of importance appeared until the early 1960s when James Baldwin and Amiri Baraka (Amiri Baraka Jones) came up with their plays to arouse their African American audiences to action. So the list is long and our discussion can only cover the most distinguished few here.

We begin here with Frederick Douglass (1817-1895) and his very important and influential book, *My Bondage and My Freedom* (1855). Frederick Douglass was born a slave, who saw his own folks enslaved and lived a brutal life himself. He managed to escape to Boston where he got a job on the docks. Gradually he came to the attention of some whites, who found opportunity to get him better jobs. He became a lecturer and a newspaper editor, editing three newspapers all devoted to educating people about the plight of the African American slaves. One of the significant things he did was to refute the propaganda of the southern whites that the African Americans were happy and well off there. He became a leading figure in the abolitionist movement. Then he went to England, where some English people got together and bought his freedom from his former master with \$700, so that he did not have to live in hiding and in danger. He became part of the intellectual life of the United States in the second half of the nineteenth century. During the Civil War he helped to enlist African American soldiers into the army. He was the greatest voice of the African Americans in the nineteenth century. His book, *My Bondage and My Freedom*, an autobiography, relates, as its title suggests, the archetypal story of African Americans escaping from their cruel and wicked white masters to emancipation. It is a moving and historically interesting book. Douglass was very articulate and spoke, as he did so for himself, of the ambitions and feelings of the African American race. Always popular, the book has never been out of print. It was later expanded into *The Life and Times of Frederick Douglass* to include his Civil War experience.

Booker T. Washington (1856-1915) came onto the scene as the next generation. His influence was felt in the last quarter of the nineteenth century and the first years of the twentieth. After the Civil War, when slavery was formally abolished, he worked against racial discrimination. He took a completely different track in dealing with this new form of oppression. Whereas Douglass wanted both freedom and equality, Washington's stance was one of compromise. This he proposed in a speech he made in 1895. What he was saying was in effect this, that the African Americans will ask for no vote, no social equality, no political power; but they should have work even though it may not be higher-level work; they should have education, though it may not be higher education; and they should make money to live well. This is what William E. B. DuBois was later to attack as "the gospel of work and money." Nevertheless, at the time Washington's speech was extremely influential and immediately welcomed by the whites and some African Americans, and Washington was acclaimed as the leader of the African Americans. The whites were especially pleased with the speech because, for one thing, it amounted to an admission that the African Americans were an inferior race, and for another, the whites saw it as a measure to avoid reform within the system by giving the African Americans some economic stability but holding them down for everything else. Washington thus had many powerful friends among the

whites, from whom he was able to collect money to found a technical institute for African American people. His position in African American history is dubious. He was accused of selling the African Americans out to the whites. Younger, more militant African Americans rebelled against him as a traitor. His autobiography, *Up from Slavery* (1901), tells about his speech and its interesting though dubious result.

The man who led the attack against Booker T. Washington was W. E. B. DuBois (1868-1963), the intellectual leader of African American protest at that time. DuBois went to Harvard where he became the first African American to receive a Ph. D., and later did further studies at the University of Berlin. A sociologist and a historian, he was also a prolific writer. He wrote dozens of books, a book of poetry, novels, essays, and some autobiography. His most influential book, *The Souls of Black Folks: Essays and Sketches* (1903), was the first published challenge to Booker T. Washington's position. DuBois helped to found a movement, the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People, the organization which fought more than any other for civil rights. However, from the 1920s, he decided that to fight for the African Americans in the United States was a lost game. This led to his developing the Pan-African movement and, later, in 1961, to his joining the Communist Party. At the age of 94 he became a citizen of Ghana. His name is closely associated with the African Americans' struggle for freedom.

During the Harlem Renaissance, African American writers came together and wrote free of conventional restrictions, to say what they wanted to say without having to suffer any oppression by the whites and without even seeing any whites. At first there was a paradox about this upsurge, that nearly all the African American writers in the Renaissance had white patrons. They tried to please the whites, get published by white publishers for a white audience, and get paid well for their books. But gradually they came to the realization that this was not what they wanted, and that this was not where they belonged. They belonged with the African Americans, and so moved over to write for them. As a result they managed to build a counter culture, a battle literature, a literature which reflects the feelings, the experience, the history, and the ambitions of the African American people. Within this framework some very interesting writing developed. A very interesting example is Jean Toomer, one of the leaders of the Harlem Renaissance. Toomer wrote only one novel, *Cane* (1923), but it is one of the big books in the history of African American literature. It is fascinating both in theme and in experimental techniques, showing that he was conscious of James Joyce, T. S. Eliot, and Ezra Pound, and at the same time very much in touch with his people. The novel is based on the author's experiences working in a school for African Americans in Georgia. It consists of three sections, with the first and the third set in Georgia and the second section in Chicago and Washington, D. C. It is a montage of 15 poems, six prose sketches, seven stories, and a play, all about African American life in the 1920s. The novel is autobiographical in the sense that it records the personal experiences of its author as acting principal of the Sparta Agricultural and Industrial Institute, in Georgia during the summer of 1921. This was when Toomer discovered his African American heritage and renewed his faith in the folklore of his race which he thought had been lost as a result of the Great Migration. Its subject covers a wide range of things such as black sexuality, miscegenation, and slavery. In addition to its subtle treatment of African American history and culture, it tries to address the question of identity. The book defies defining in formal terms. It is a mixture of different genres in one work, well arranged and balanced, with its unusual narrative strategies and shifting points of view. Its influence on contemporary writers is evident such as Langston Hughes, Alice Walker, and Gloria

Naylor.

Another example would be Countee Cullen whose precocious success may have been one of the signals of the coming of the Harlem Renaissance. Cullen was well educated at New York University and Harvard. With his poem "Shroud of Color" appearing in H. L. Mencken's *American Mercury* in 1924, and the publication of the first three volumes of poetry, *Color* (1925), *Copper Sun* (1927), and *The Ballad of the Brown Girl* (1927), he was probably the most popular African American poet and African American literary figure in America at the time. Cullen was traditional in form. He could handle "white verse" ?ballads, sonnets, quatrains etc. very well. There are skill and power in his work. Thematically, he deals with the African American experience seriously, often from a religious perspective. For a long time after his death, he was ignored, but fresh interest in his poetry has appeared in recent years, and his works have been reissued. His often-anthologized poem is "Yet Do I Marvel." The poet marvels at how inscrutable God's ways are to "make a poet Black, and bid him sing!" Here is some ambiguity of feeling well portrayed: the poet is very self-conscious and probably pleased and proud that he as a black person could write and that he was equal with others including the whites before God.

By far the most important person in the Harlem Renaissance was Langston Hughes known as African Americans' poet laureate, who ultimately outgrew the movement, and developed into one of the major African American authors to help make African American culture. Hughes loved literature. When still in school, he began to write and publish. Around 1925 he was working as a busboy in a hotel in Washington, D. C. when he met the then well-known and influential poet, Vachel Lindsay (1879-1931). Lindsay was so struck by the poems which Hughes had submitted to him for advice that he encouraged the boy to devote himself to writing. Hughes became known as "the busboy poet." The next year with the help of novelist Carl Van Vechten (1880-1966), Hughes put his poems together in a book, entitled *The Weary Blues*. This collection marks a stage in Hughes' development as an author. The poems, like the blues songs, are sad in tone, describing the fact of having to live in a very cruel and oppressive world. But there is not much fight in them. Merely describing how things are, they read as if Hughes were trying to relieve himself and his race of a mental load and to achieve a degree of reconciliation with the wicked world. His collection of short stories, *The Ways of White Folks*, appeared in 1934.

In 1935 Hughes became one of the key speakers at the American Writers' Conference. From then on his influence as an author was felt everywhere and his production was tremendous. Novels, poems, plays, essays, translations, an autobiography ?all these simply poured out of him. He was one of the founders of the black theater in the Federal Theater Project during the Depression. He was the editor of a good many anthologies of African American literature. And more than anybody else in the history of the country, he encouraged other African American writers to write. Beginning in 1933 he wrote a column for a newspaper, the main character of which was called Jesse B. Simple, who was soon to become one of American literature's most endearing fictional figures. Jesse B. Simple comments, in his very uneducated ?barroom ?manner, on all the occurrences that are taking place in the world as well as in the United States, and he is particularly impressive in his mild satire and quiet humor. The sketches were later collected in books like *Simple Speaks His Mind* (1950), *The Best of Simple* (1961), and *Simple's Uncle Sam* (1965).

The year of 1951 saw the publication of *Montage of a Dream Deferred*. The very title suggests the further development of Hughes as a writer. Whereas *The Weary Blues* expresses sadness and *The Ways of White Folks* talks about Depression, *Montage of a Dream Deferred* is an

angry book and shows a Hughes no longer able to contain his anger at the condition of the African Americans and the wretched poor. Langston Hughes wrote about 60 books and became a major figure not merely in African American cultural history and African American literature, but one whose contribution helped make the literary scene of modern America what it is. By his talent, his voluminous writings, and by the sheer force of his personality, he won the love of his readers, black and white alike, and enriched American culture in general and African American literature in particular. His is a name no student of American literature can afford to ignore.

Let's take a look at some of his poems. "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" is a good point to begin our discussion of his poetry. Hughes composed the work when he was still a student. The story of its composition is interesting to note. After he graduated from high school, Hughes' mother would like the boy to find work and help the family make ends meet. But his divorced father, living in Mexico, wanted him to go on with his education and wrote to him, asking him to come over and discuss it with him. The boy decided to visit his father, and the displeased mother did not see him off at the railway station. The sad Hughes went on board the train and on his way saw through the window the torrential Mississippi rushing forward. He began thinking about the meaning of this river to his race and his people. Scenes of what happened long before to the African Americans ?being trafficked to New Orleans and sold from there to the various parts of the country ?resurfaced to his mind. He remembered what Lincoln did, coming down on a raft to New Orleans, seeing for himself the tragic life of the slaves, and determined to rid the country of slavery. Hughes also thought of other rivers that had nourished civilizations and black culture such as the Congo, the Niger, and the Nile. As he was brooding over these, a line leapt to his mind: "I've known rivers." Taking an envelope from his pocket, he composed this famous poem in just ten minutes:

I've known rivers:

I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the
flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of Mississippi when Abe Lincoln
went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn
all golden in the sunset.

I've known rivers.

Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

The "I" asserts, in a quiet but touchingly deep tone, the long history, the age-old wisdom and courage, and the powerful aspiration of a race suffering, mistreatment and injustice for so long. "I" does not say any more than imply, but the line, "My soul has grown deep like rivers," repeated once more at the end, is powerfully loaded and offers enough food for rumination for all.

Another poem, which may have had a good measure of influence on later African American life as well as writing, is "As I Grew Older," included in the poet's first volume of poetry, *The Weary Blues* (1926). "It was a long time ago[,] it begins, "I have almost forgotten my dream. / But it was there then, / In front of me, / Bright as a sun ?/ My dream." The speaker had his dream when he was apparently very young when everything appeared young and bright to him. What happened later was that, as the boy grew older, he got to know about life better, and became aware, with the slow passage of his growing-up years, of "the wall" which rose between him and his dream until its shadow touched the sky and eclipsed everything. He became painfully aware of the fact that he is black and as such he sees no light of any dream but the thick wall, which is an obvious but vivid metaphor for racial discrimination. The poet-speaker does not feel daunted, however. He has faith in his black hands and tries to break through the wall, shatter this debilitating darkness, and retrieve his dream so as "[t]o smash this night, / To break this shadow / Into a thousand lights of sun, / Into a thousand whirling dreams / of sun!" The tone is vehement, almost suggestive of force and violence, but the outcome is positive and optimistic. The poet's dream for light, freedom, and happiness was to generate a direct influence on the Civil Rights movement of the 1950s and 1960s, and Martin Luther King, the famous Civil Rights leader, led a march of 250 000 people on Washington, D. C. and made the historic "I have a dream" speech on August 28, 1963. The dream motif recurs in Hughes' poetry (such obvious titles "Dream Variations" and *Montage of a Dream Deferred* immediately come to mind).

Hughes's thematic concerns go far beyond racial issues. He wrote in praise of the October Revolution, sympathized with the Chinese and their revolution, and visited Spain and wrote to support the Spanish people in their fight against the Fascist regime of Franco. In form Hughes' poetry is noted for its fresh simplicity and its notable features of the free verse of Whitman, Sandburg, and Paul Dunbar (1872-1906). Hughes was heir to the tradition of the African American folklore and jazz and wrote in a brisk, rhythmic manner so that many of his poems have become popular songs. His creative career has helped, in no small way, pave the way for the further development of African American literature.

The major figure to appear in the 1940s was Richard Wright who became a powerful writer and a big influence over later writers. Richard Wright experienced a bitter boyhood. Not happy at home with his stern mother and grandmother, he also suffered the agony of segregation of the American south of the time. Eventually he fled to Chicago, where in contact with left-wing friends and finally with the Communist Party, he began to see the Negro situation as part of the general human situation of the oppressed and write and publish on the strength of this growing social awareness. His first book, *Uncle Tom's Children: Four Novellas* came out in 1938, which was followed two years later by his masterwork, *Native Son*. The book made such an impact on the consciousness of the nation that Richard Wright became a national celebrity. In 1944 he broke with the Communist Party, and the next year published his second powerful book, *Black Boy*, an autobiography relating the bitter experience of his youth. The racial discrimination of the country becoming increasingly intolerable to him, Wright left for Europe, where he settled down in France. Cut off to some extent from the reality of African American experience, he was seriously incapacitated in his creative work. He was to write a good deal more, novels, stories, and essays, but none of these ever touched his best work in power and critical acclaim.

Native Son is a story about an African American adolescent's growth of awareness. It consists of three sections, subtitled respectively, "Fear," "Flight," and "Fate." The opening of the

novel forebodes ill for Bigger Thomas, living together with his mother and siblings in a ghetto kitchenette: he kills a big rat early this morning. Then he goes out hunting for a job. He fights with a gang. Eventually he is hired as a chauffeur to the Daltons and drives Mary Dalton and her boyfriend, Jan, around the city. Mary and Jan drink and make love in the back seat. When Jan leaves, Bigger Thomas has to carry the drunk Mary upstairs. When the blind Mrs. Dalton enters the room, Bigger muffles Mary to keep her quiet, but inadvertently kills her. He is caught and tried, involving an uproar of racist hatred and bigotry in the whole process. Bigger Thomas comes to realize before his death that he is a victim of racial fear and ghetto life.

Native Son is an extremely fascinating book. It simply exploded on the sensibility of the American reading public. Dealing with one of the thorniest problems with which America had been beleaguered, the racial question, the book pushed it into the reader's mind in a manner no one had ever done before. For the African Americans the message is clear, that they are human beings and should be treated as such, and that if nothing else can help to assert their dignity and identity, then it is legitimate to resort to violence. For the whites, the message is equally clear, that the moment has arrived when they have to come to terms with their African American fellowmen, and that, if they are not ready yet, they have got to be quick or they will have to take the consequences. Bigger Thomas, the hero of the book, embodies a new type of African American personality. Rebellious by nature, he never is able to feel at peace with the world in which he finds himself. The vehement violence which breaks out of him and which eventually leads him to the electric chair has been brewing in the bosom of his race for over three centuries, ever since the first of his ancestors were brought to the land of their enslavement over three centuries ago. The bitterness has fermented, and the patience and humility of the African Americans are not inexhaustible. If not given the recognition that is due to them, the African Americans are perfectly ready to take the law into their own hands. Thus Bigger Thomas, more than any other African American fictional figures, represents a higher level of African American racial awareness. In him and his actions, the African Americans saw their identity and the whites their folly and obligation. Richard Wright has been censured for his unabashed portrayal of violence and of a violent man as hero, but he would not have been as effective as he was had he not written the way he did in *Native Son*. Richard Wright's influence over subsequent African American writers has been great. To say that he began the contemporary African American literary tradition of violent self-assertion is not exaggeration. He is now a classic writer in American and world literature.

African American literature attained to a higher degree of maturity in the spring of 1952 when Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* appeared in print. *Invisible Man* tells an archetypal existential story of modern times. The protagonist-narrator is nameless apparently because he is invisible. The very opening of the book states the existentialist crisis of modern man in explicit terms:

I am an invisible man... I am invisible, understand, simply because people refuse to see me. Like the bodiless heads you see sometimes in circus sideshows, it is as though I have been surrounded by mirrors of hard, distorting glass. When they approach me they see only my surroundings, themselves, or figments of their imagination ?indeed, everything and anything except me... You often doubt if you really exist... You ache with the need to convince yourself that you do exist in the real world.

Speaking from the hole in the ground which he says is "like a grave," he relates his bitter experience of having lived a death of a life for some twenty years until he discovered his invisibility. He tells us how he began life with great expectations and won the approval of the

whites of his region who, pleased with his humility, sent him with a scholarship to a state college for Negroes in order to "Keep this Nigger-Boy Running." There he became the protégé of Dr. Bledsoe, the president, who, however, expelled him for having shown a white benefactor of the institution around places unfit for his eyes. Next he went to New York where, as the administration stipulates, blacks should be "invisible." What he tried to do was to be seen. In a factory on Long Island he incurred the displeasure of his fellow workers unintentionally in a disturbance. Later, on the occasion of an old African American couple being driven out of a flat, he made a radical speech which subsequently put him in touch with a "brotherhood," a Communist affiliation, but he was amazed to find that the brotherhood saw the cause of the African Americans only as one of so many pawns on its chessboard. His dreams all evaporated, and he went into "hibernation" in an underground cellar. It is from there that he speaks. The book ends with the narrator's awareness that "even an invisible man has a socially responsible role to play," and that "who knows but that, on the lower frequencies, I speak for you?"

The concluding section of the book is important, particularly in view of the fact that when the narrator thus speaks for "you" ?humanity at large, he transcends the physical limits of an African American individuality, becomes, all of a sudden, anyone, an Everyman, and his dilemma, thus generalized and magnified, assumes a universal magnitude. One becomes suddenly aware that what he has been talking about all along concerns the plight, not merely of an African American individual, not even of the African American race alone, but of the modern existence of man as a whole. The repeated rejection that the protagonist suffers at the hands of so many people and institutions becomes a metaphor for the rejection of the individual by society. The question that the book ultimately raises is one of a universal nature. It is the question of the interrelationship between the self and the world. The world (or the community or society) requires that all individuals conform to its standards and values and comply with its demands. This could not be done except through the individual giving up at least part of his individuality to fit as parts into the machine. Thus the world can be the enemy to the existence of the self. This could be one sense in which Grandpa's injunction can be understood. The self is placed in the enemy territory: it is in an ever on-going confrontation with the world around it. This is apparently everyone's dilemma in an age in which self-awareness and self-identity become increasingly serious considerations. How people should behave in relation to others and to society at large: this is the question that the novel tries to help solve. Ellison's "Epilogue" addresses this beautifully well. It redefines the correlation between social responsibility and self-identity. Society may encroach upon self for role-playing; self depends upon society for self-definition. These two, self vs. world, should not be mutually exclusive; in fact they are mutually complementary. There is no complete freedom or independence. Denial of self is not good; neither is social denial. Life being what it is, a part of us has to "die" in order for us to live in fellowship. The thing that matters is to strike a happy mean between these two. *Invisible Man* thus ends with counseling participation in life on this new level of awareness. In all probability, the protagonist is climbing out of his hole: "Here I've set out to throw my anger into the world's face, but now that I've tried to put it all down the old fascination with playing a role returns, and I'm drawn upward again." This is where Ellison makes it everyone's business to identify with the protagonist. Indeed, Ellison's aim in writing the novel is to represent what he termed "the American theme," and he achieved a great success in turning the impressive story of a young African American boy's life into an odyssey of modern man's quest for self-realization and turning, incidentally, the book into what a critic calls "a

resolutely honest, tormented, profoundly American book."

Invisible Man is immensely interesting as a work of art. It is more than a "protest novel." Ellison's vision is too great and his taste is too catholic to allow his book to remain merely on that level. There is, on the one hand, good reason to read the novel as one African American book on racial discrimination, black-white relationship, and the rebellious stance that the African American protagonist evinces toward an unjust and repressive society. Indeed, the book has been read that way. On the other hand, *Invisible Man* means much more than that. It covers a much more extensive territory of life, so that it transcends race and racial relations, and goes beyond protest to a new phase of perception in the evolution of the African American awareness. In so doing, what happens to an African American becomes a metaphor, a formula, or even a paradigm for all humankind. This is ultimately the reason why *Invisible Man* has appealed to its readers so much for so long.

Another reason for its popularity is its consummate craft. The formal and technical resourcefulness that it exhibits is simply amazing. To begin with, the symbolism of the book is impressive and fascinating. It may have owed its title to H. G. Wells' *The Invisible Man*, but it is more than that. Critics see the book's relationship to Kafka's story of *The Trial*, but it is more than that. They see Melville's *Confidence Man* in it, but it is more than that. The art of the book is ultimately Ellison's own. The notion of invisibility, the overriding symbol all through the novel, appears to be metaphysical at first because difficult to identify with immediately, but with some stretch of the imagination on the part of the readers, it becomes alarmingly physical and true as a universal fact of life. It forces all people to think and contemplate about their own situation. Then we notice, among other things, the exquisite skill with which Ellison manipulates his prose style. This changes deliberately with the change of the narrator's environment from the South to the North and finally to his place of hibernation somewhere in New York City. As Ellison himself professes, he dreamed of a flexible and swift style, at once facing the brutal experience of modern man and expressing hope, human fraternity, and individual self-realization. It is a style which uses all the resources of the language, its riches, its idiomatic expression and the rhetorical flourishes from past periods still alive today. Thus *Invisible Man* begins with a language more or less naturalistic, moves to something like expressionistic, and ends with a surrealistic texture. Ellison is trying to use a Protean style to achieve a reality no less mutable.

When asked in an interview whether the book would be remembered in twenty years, Ellison gave a modest negative answer. But its popularity has stood the test of time. With the universality of its theme and its exquisite art, the book has acquired the status of a major classic in American literature.

James Baldwin has been seen as Richard Wright's successor in a literal as well as a figurative sense. Like Wright he went to Europe to escape intolerable racial discrimination in the United States, and stayed there for some nine years. He did as much as Wright (if not more) in increasing the racial awareness of the African American people. Baldwin has been regarded as the most important African American writer since Richard Wright left his active battle duty. His novel, *Go Tell It on the Mountain* (1954), is remarkable in both thematic and technical terms. It consists of three sections, all about a boy, John Grimes, now 14, trying to define himself against his background—his father, his church, etc. Section one, "The Seventh Day," describes him wandering on the morning of his 14th birthday, wondering whether anyone bothers to remember it. As he moves around with the few coins his mother has given him for the occasion, he remembers how

unkind his father has been to him. He feels lonely and sad. Section two, "The Prayers of the Saints," records the sad lives of John's aunt Florence and his mother, Elizabeth, and the sad but selfish behavior of his father, Gabriel. The section serves as a footnote to the wretched lives of the family and especially to the nervous relationship between John and his father. John's biological father committed suicide in prison, and Gabriel is his stepfather. The last section of the novel, "The Threshing Floor," recounts the process of John's salvation through conversion, but ends with John not feeling much better.

Thematically, Baldwin's book relates the galling reality of African American life against a historical background which shows that the African Americans as a race have been over the centuries trying to attain to self-recognition and emotional and psychological maturity. The growth of John Grimes undergoes stages which associate his earlier memories of Sunday mornings with those of other characters like Florence, Gabriel, and Elizabeth, all memories of pain and suffering peculiar to an enslaved people. What Baldwin calls in the second part of his book, "The Prayers of the Saints," reaches the height of its pathos when "Elizabeth's Prayer" begins with Elizabeth's pathetic "Lord, I wish I had of died / In Egypt Land!" Baldwin is telling his people in powerful modern language that they are suffering an age-old injustice, and that they must fight this injustice as best as they can. The power of this book lies in the fact that the reader is forever kept conscious of an oppressed race groaning and struggling for salvation.

This is evident in John's growing up experience. The boy is wretched because he feels rejected and not loved. Like all children at the threshold of their lives, John has dreams and aspirations. He did well in school and was said to have "a Great Future." He might become "a Great Leader" for his people. This inspired hope in him that he would live in a world that would be drastically different from his father's house of darkness, that he would have good food, fine clothes, expensive whisky and cigarettes, and watch movies as often as he pleased. He would look different, and people would look up to him as somebody "beautiful, tall and popular." He would be a poet, or a college president, or a movie star. This sounds all like childish vainglory, but it is all of it a reaction to what the boy would most probably not be able to become and achieve simply because he is an African American. And it indicates his determination that he would never be poor and obscure like his father and his people. He wants a different life, a life of freedom and dignity.

But as it is now, he lives in fear and uncertainty. He fears his church and his God as he feels both have let him down. He fears the white society around and the pressure of his environment. He fears his own sin and his sense of uncertainty regarding his own identity and his own destiny. And emblematic of all that he fears most is his rejecting father. He fears his father who has been unkind all along, and he fears his father's face that is terrible in anger and unutterably cruel. When his brother Roy is wounded and lies on the couch, he feels that his father hates him for not lying there instead of Roy. John feels that he is a stepson to his father although he does not know about it.

He feels it the same way when he, instead of Roy (his father's biological son), lies on the threshing floor of their storefront church, going through the process of conversion. John feels like a wanderer, one who is not seen as belonging in his father's house. The novel begins with the boy wandering around like a rootless leaf. Later, as he lies there on the church floor, seeing surreal visions, he sees his father come close and stand just above him, looking down. Then he knew that "a curse was renewed from moment to moment, from father to son," and he would carry the curse forever. The feeling of neglect and rejection has gone right down in the depth of the boy's soul. He

feels he is a perpetual wanderer in "the perpetual desert."

John has had a peculiar relationship to the church. He has mixed feelings of reverence, fear, and doubt about it. He has been skeptical about salvation, and has been resisting conversion. His conversion, when it is completed, does not do much to change his status in the world nor his emotional response to it. The world has not changed for him, neither has his father. He feels chilly at the sight of the saints, and feels no joy at the end of the ceremony. As he walks around, he sees the old houses still standing there as they have been for ages, the old windows still staring like so many blinded eyes, the water still running in the gutters in a small discontented sound, paper, burnt matches, sodden cigarette-ends, gobs of spittle, green, yellow, brown, and pearly, still floating on the water along with the leavings of a dog, the vomit of a drunken man, dead sperm trapped in the rubber, etc. All move slowly to the black grating where it rushes down to be carried to the river and hurled into the sea. As to the people, they still live in poverty, and he is still "Frog-eyes" to them. John feels both betrayed and self-deceptive. The church and the conversion bring not much of a relief to him. A feeling of despair creeps over him.

The father, Gabriel, is another major character in the novel, next in importance to John. Gabriel is a typical stepfather, having little love for his stepson, but a lot of venom toward him. He may have faith, but he has certainly sinned against his Lord in his life. Among other things, he deserted Esther and his first son Roy (short for Royal) so that they died tragically, and he was deeply prejudiced against John, regarding him as "son of the bond woman" (an epithet that reminds people of the biblical Hagar and her son Ishmael), or "the harlot's son" whom he does not want. He is a self-styled prophet from whom, he feels, an orthodox line of offspring would issue. He is presumptuous enough to think that he has seen a vision in which he hears a voice, presumably that of God's: "And now up this mountain, in white robes, singing, the elect came. 'Touch them not,' the voice said, 'my seal is on them.' And Gabriel turned and fell on his face, and the voice said again: 'So shall thy seed be.' Then he awoke." So his sons were both named Royal. Gabriel is not aware that it is he, either as a bum when he was young, or later as a self-styled shepherd, who makes his folks suffer, especially John.

The theme of the book is reinforced by its style and its language, which remind one constantly of the Old Testament, with the Bible staying in the back of the reader's mind. We notice some semblance of a stream-of-consciousness technique at work, especially in the second part of the book. Nevertheless, the bits and fragments of the lives of the Grimeses come to the reader as a whole, gradually pieced together through the church service and the prayers. Then there is the major symbolism of the book to consider. It merits particular attention because it is powerful as it tells a truth in a forthright manner. As we noted earlier on, Gabriel calls his own son Roy. He would like to see Roy lying on the ground in the church where John lies on the night of conversion. John is to him a kind of Ishmael, not of the royal line. All the time, Gabriel is fully aware that he is a stepfather and behaves well as one. This relationship between father and son can be seen, in a way, to signify something of a broader, more national magnitude. It can be symbolic of the place of the African Americans in the nation of the United States. It reveals the clear image of the country behaving to its black offspring like a stepfather. The African Americans have felt the way they have because of this unjust treatment.

One more thing that merits attention is the harrowing question, who makes life so painful for John? If we read the second part of the book, we will get to know that John's wretchedness is traceable back to the incident of his biological father's death in jail. The man, decent in nature and

sensitive to insults and injuries, took his own life there. This proved to be a turning point for John's personal fortunes. He became a stepson. As he grows up, he becomes aware of the presence of a segment of society, the mainstream, that appears distant and oppressive though alluring to him. Thus in the final analysis, John is first and foremost victimized by the racial environment in which he lives. But this is not all of the answer to the question here. A large portion of the novel seems to suggest that the immediate cause of John's suffering is his stepfather, Gabriel. The boy lives forever in his shadow. So do the other members of his family and the other people around the man. The book probably suggests that some members of their own community may have helped to make their world more impossible than it already is and that somewhere along the line they as a race have to take some measure of responsibility. The idea is more explicitly revealed in Alice Walker's *The Color Purple*.

Somewhere in his *Notes of a Native Son*, Baldwin says to the effect that one has to accept life but must not ignore the injustices that exist in life. But acceptance is difficult. It proved "infinitely difficult" for him to do so in the late 1950s and the 1960s. His two collections of essays, *Notes of a Native Son* (1955) and *Nobody Knows My Name* (1961) show him becoming less detached to the cause of his people; and his play, *Blues for Mister Charlie* (1964), reveals an angry Baldwin condemning an unjust society which permits such evil as has victimized his people to endure. *The Fire Next Time*, recording the inhuman treatment to which the African Americans are subjected, declares for the first time in the history of the African American people that salvation for the United States lies in its African American minority. He calls for the African Americans to resort to means including force so as to bring about the nation's self-realization, and he prophesies that the fire will come next time if they fail in their mission. Baldwin's vehement condemnations added fuel to the fire which was then spreading across the country. The Civil Rights Movement did a good deal toward righting the wrongs and restoring dignity to the African Americans as an organic part of the country, and Baldwin's contribution here is to remain in the memory of his people.

James Baldwin was a very serious writer. He wanted to be an honest man and a good writer. He loved his country and because of this, he insisted on the right to criticize her perpetually. He considered this his greatest responsibility in life. Among his other books are the novels *Giovanni's Room* (1956), concerned essentially with homosexuality, *Another Country* (1962) and *Tell Me How Long the Train Been Gone* (1968), both treating the two basic Baldwin themes, race and homosexuality. Baldwin, like Ellison, has become a major American writer.

Now Amiri Baraka (1934-) was born Everett LeRoy Jones into a well-to-do middle class family in New Jersey and changed his name to Amiri Baraka ("Blessed Prince") in the 1970s when he embraced the Kwaiaida faith (a mixture of orthodox Islam and traditional African practices). His spiritual and artistic growth has been one of flux and change. In the 1950s he lived in the avant-garde aesthetic milieu of Greenwich Village of New York City in which Charles Olson, Frank O'Hara, and Allen Ginsberg were part of the set. He became more political in the 1960s, and left the Village for Harlem to establish the Black Arts Repertory Theater / School. Then he went back home to Newark, New Jersey to found Spirit House, and led the Black Community Development and Defense Organization, trying to enhance the racial consciousness of his fellow African Americans. In the early 1970s Baraka played key roles in some major African American conferences such as The Pan African Congress of African Peoples in Atlanta (1972) and the National Political Convention in Gary, Indiana (1974). Later he claimed he adopted a

Marxist-Leninist perspective. These changes have been reflected in his works.

Amiri Baraka knows what he should do as an African American artist. In one of his essays he states categorically that the mission of an African American artist is to help destroy the America as he knows it. He writes with a view to reaching and moving people, and writes so as to unite art and politics. Thus his writings, poetry, drama, and essays, especially of the more recent period, are fired with revolutionary ideology and possess a "clear revolutionary edge," so that they pierce like swords and knives into the "sinful" body of American society. Amiri Baraka was one of the masterminds of the Black Arts Movement which flourished during the whole of the 1960s and the early 1970s, and which associated Black arts with the concept of Black power. As one of the most eloquent exponents of the radical African American stance with regard to white-dominated America, Amiri Baraka has been very influential on the post-1960s African American writing. Amiri Baraka has been a prolific writer. He published his first volume of poetry, *Preface to a Twenty Volume Suicide Note*, in 1961, and has been writing drama and fiction as well as poetry. His works include *The Dead Lecturer* (1964), a volume of poems, *Dutchman* and *The Slave*, a book of plays (1964), *The System of Dante's Hell* (1965), his only novel, and *Tales* (1967). He also wrote studies like *Blues People: Negro Music in White America* (1963), *African American Music* (1967), *Raise Race Rays Raze: Essays Since 1965* (1971), and *The Motion of History and Other Plays* (1978).

Inheriting the legacy of African American literature after Hughes, Wright, and Ellison is the preeminent contemporary novelist, Toni Morrison (1931-). She was born in Northern Ohio and was educated at Howard University and Cornell University. She began writing in the early 1960s and published her first novel, *The Bluest Eye* in 1970. Since then she has written quite a few works of importance such as *Sula* (1973), *Song of Solomon* (1977), *Tar Baby* (1981), *Beloved* (1987), *Jazz* (1992), and *Paradise* (1998). Morrison is an award-winning writer. The many literary awards include the National Book Award, the National Book Critics Circle Award, the Pulitzer Prize, and the Nobel Prize for literature in 1993. She is an international celebrity.

The publication of *Song of Solomon* established Morrison's place in contemporary American literature. Winner of the National Book Critics' Circle Award, the novel is seen as another milestone in African American literature after *Native Son* and *Invisible Man*. It tells the story of an African American trying to recover his family roots. Set in a small town in Michigan, the story covers the one hundred years of African American history from the Civil War through the 1960s. The first section of the book relates the family history of the Deads. After the Civil War, emancipated slave Macon Dead ? marries an American Indian girl and has two children, his son Macon Dead ? and his daughter Pilate who was born without a navel. Then Macon Dead ? is killed by white men and loses all his property. Macon ? and his sister, pursued by the whites, are forced to kill a white man. Macon ? believes that the man is hiding money but Pilate rejects material things. As they have different values, they part company. Macon ? comes to a small town in Michigan and marries Ruth, only child of a black doctor. They have two daughters and one son, Macon Dead ? or Milkman by name, who is the novel's protagonist. Macon ? becomes a ruthless and greedy property owner. He cares neither for his family nor for his fellow African Americans. He is suspicious of his wife and leaves his father-in-law to die without medication. He also teaches his son to value nothing but money. After separation from her brother, Pilate wanders around for over twenty years and also comes to the small town with her daughter Reba and

granddaughter Hagar. Deserted by society, alone, without friendship and religious faith, Pilate works hard to stay alive. She thinks hard and long about the most important thing to her in life. Compassionate and full of love, she becomes a spiritually whole person. She teaches her nephew Milkman to be kind and sympathetic. Although forbidden to see his aunt, Milkman finds love and warmth in her home. The second section of the book focuses on Milkman's search for gold which turns out to be an undertaking far more significant in nature. Believing that his father and aunt hid some gold in a cave in Virginia when they were young, Milkman sets out for the south. In Pennsylvania and Virginia he meets with many fellow African Americans who, though poor, still live their traditional lifestyle and keep their own customs and mores. The old folks tell moving folktales, and innocent children sing folk songs, all in praise of their ancestors. Of his many discoveries, Milkman finds that a song about Solomon is actually a paean to his great-grandfather Solomon. He is amazed at the rich myth and folklore about his family's history, and learns to be proud of his roots. He finds no gold, but he achieves self-knowledge and self-worth. He becomes a spiritually and morally better man. In the end he jumps off ground in face of danger from Guitar Baines, his friend, who shoots Pilate by mistake while aiming at Milkman because he thinks that Milkman has found but will not share the hidden treasure with him.

Song of Solomon is based on the myth that Africans could fly. It is unique in its treatment of racial issues. Whereas some previous African American writers offer realistic or naturalistic accounts of the tragic lives of African American people under racial discrimination and oppression and inspire and enhance African American awareness, this Morrison novel helps the African Americans discover their family history, feel proud of their roots and tradition, and look forward to a future of freedom and happiness. Milkman is brought up in the comfort of a wealthy middle class family by a selfish, greedy father. But he receives his aunt Pilate's advice and learns to face reality and think back to the past. He becomes responsible and respects and loves others. His personality undergoes a great change. Morrison manages to achieve her theme by employing folk myths and legends and magic realism to sing praise of the long history and civilization of the African Americans and expose the evils and crimes of racism. Her interlocking plotlines, varieties of language, and the tapestry of folktales, legends, magic, and fantasy all these converge to make for the greatness of her work.

Morrison is best known for her fifth novel, *Beloved*. It is based on the true antebellum story of a slave mother, Margaret Garner, killing her own children just for them to avoid slavery. "Beloved" in Morrison's novel is the word inscribed on the tombstone of the child killed by its mother. Nineteen-year-old Sethe Suggs, a runaway slave mother, is about to be captured by her pursuers. She decides to kill all her children so that they would not have to suffer the way she had as a slave. She succeeds in slashing the throat of the youngest two-year-old baby girl and is caught and serves a prison sentence. Then she gives birth to her daughter Denver, and works as a cook. Eighteen years pass, and *Beloved* as a baby ghost comes to haunt her mother's house at 124 Bluestone Road. She manages to drive her two brothers away, but is chased away by Paul D., her mother's former fellow slave. *Beloved* reappears, however, in human form, as a twenty-year-old girl, beautiful and freakish, capable of metamorphosis and of becoming invisible. She keeps following her mother around, harassing her with disturbing questions, making incessant demands for stories and for food, and accusing her of abandoning her. Sethe is on the brink of both physical and emotional collapse. Her daughter Denver asks for the help of the community, which respond and eventually drive the ghost away by singing a song of exorcism. Sethe is still disintegrating,

but Paul D. returns to inject the desire for life in her.

The book is remarkable in its skillful fusion of its formal with its thematic concerns. The major formal feature of *Beloved* is the use of magic realism. Morrison's ghost does not make the book a ghost story. There is this obvious magic and supernatural element in the narrative: first the baby ghost causing strange voices, lights, and violent shaking, and then the ghost assuming actual human form, but behaving in uncanny ways, becoming invisible, appearing mysteriously, moving Paul D. out of Sethe's house, and exhibiting her growing psychic powers. This element shocks and jostles readers as well the characters out of their normal way of living and thinking. It fits well into the larger realistic scheme to serve the author's purpose. Talking about her book, Morrison states the importance of "dwelling on" and "coming to terms with" the truth about the past in a land where the past is either erased, absent or romanticized. The "rememory" of the past is to Morrison a very important subject to write about. Morrison feels that her people have to come to some kind of terms with their past in order to find peace and happiness. Their past is a hurdle they have to jump over in order to cope well now and in the future. Sethe is guilt-ridden. Her physical scar is an emblem of her inner bleeding scar. The appearance of the ghost is in fact an externalization of the emotional wound in her life. The disruption of "normal" life *Beloved* causes forces her mother, and also Paul D., to face the fact that they need healing and renewal. She makes it imperative for them to dive deep into the past when they suffered injustice and inhuman treatment and felt such despair that the only way to emancipation was death. The ghost offers Sethe a good opportunity to explain her act and subconsciously exonerate herself from the sense of "sin" and self-condemnation that cripple her life all along. Sethe is supposed to be free, but she is not. She has to address the "unspeakable," hidden deep down in her, which would weaken and humiliate her if she dare remember and speak about it. She has to face it in order to heal and live on a new basis. *Beloved* thus reopens Sethe's closed emotional life (along with Paul D.) and sets her on the painful road to rebuilding self-identity. Sethe is not an isolated case. What *Beloved* does to her is in fact also what the African Americans need as a once enslaved race. The grandmother Baby Suggs talks about "the Misery," which indicates the harsh condition of the African American slaves. It was worse than death. It was the reason why some slaves like Sethe chose death rather than slavery: as there was nothing they could do about it, they inflicted death and pain on themselves. The sense of self-mortification afflicts and debilitates all survivors as a ghost of the past after their physical emancipation. In this sense, *Beloved* offers a medication and a cure for all African Americans.

Beloved is also a historical novel. It reconstructs history through black folk culture and folk tales, and brings to life the horrible experience of slavery as history. It is a powerful book: it not only makes African Americans think; it compels the white segment of the society to face history, too. They have to face the harm that racism has done to baby Suggs, Ella, Stamp, as well as Sethe and Paul D., to the countless number of African Americans dead or living, and to humanity in general. The barbaric behavior of "Schoolteacher" and his like and the horrors of the system they enforced ?the Sweet Home which is a veritable hell, the slave ship, the human suffering, the indignities to which the slaves were made to submit, etc. ?all these should be enough of a reminder, and a shock, to all white people that history may be ignored or forgotten, but it is ever present in all lives as a point of reference.

Toni Morrison is a major contemporary American writer. She is the foremost author of contemporary black women's renaissance which includes, among others, Alice Walker, Gloria

Naylor, Maya Angelou, Toni Cade Bambara, and Gayle Jones. Her oeuvre has drawn the attention of her readers to the importance of reconstructing history and interpreting the past from a racial perspective. She has blazed a new trail for her fellow writers.

Another important African American novelist of the contemporary period is Alice Walker (1944-), whose works have attracted the attention of readers and critics alike. Alice Walker was born into a sharecropper's family in Eatonton, Georgia. She attended Spelman College in Atlanta, Georgia, and finished her education in Sarah Lawrence College in Bronxville, New York. She began writing in college and published her first works ?poems as well as stories ?in 1965. Later she received fellowships in support of her writing career. She has, by virtue of the great amount of fiction, poetry, and essays she has written over the years, made herself a central figure in contemporary American literature. In addition to her volumes of poetry and short stories, she has published quite a few novels such as *The Third Life of Grange Copeland* (1970), *Meridian* (1976), *The Color Purple* (1982), *The Temple of My Familiar* (1989), and *Possessing the Secret of Joy* (1990). Her greatest achievement so far is her novel, *The Color Purple*, which won for her both the American Book Award and the Pulitzer Prize.

The Color Purple is an epistolary novel. It consists of 90 letters, of which over two thirds (61 in number) Celie wrote to God, 14 to her sister Nettie, and 15 Nettie wrote to Celie. The story centers on Celie's life, with Nettie's African adventure as complementary. The time frame of the novel covers over thirty years, and Celie is now in middle age, in her mid or late forties or thereabout. It opens with Celie at 14, sexually abused by her "father" (Fonso by name) who threatened to kill her mammy if she ever told anyone but God. She gave birth to two children who were taken away from her immediately after they were born. Later her "father" "married" ?sold ?her off to Albert (called Mr. ?for a long time in Celie's letters). The man abused her and had an evil design on her sister Nettie. So Nettie ran away and found peace working for a missionary's family and taking care of their two children, Adam and Olivia. Celie never hears from Nettie for some thirty years. In the meantime Celie takes care of her husband's children and endures a hard, loveless life. Her husband's lover, Shug Avery, a flashy African American singer, falls ill and is brought over for her to take care of. The two women bond well with one another, and Shug teaches Celie to love and stand up for herself. She teaches her about God. All through her progress toward emotional maturity, Celie has Shug as her spiritual guide. Invigorated with a new sense of wellbeing, Celie begins to assert herself. She leaves Albert and stays with Shug. Celie's self-awareness quickly grows. Then she learns that Fonso was her stepfather. Her birth father, a prosperous store owner, was lynched by the white racists who hated him because they thought he had stolen their business. After Fonso dies, Celie comes into the property that is rightfully hers and becomes independent. She achieves rebirth. All the time she prospers, Albert goes down slope. He loses his will to life, becomes an alcoholic, and almost dies. He survives, becomes friends with Celie, and helps her with her sewing. It turns out that he has for years kept Nettie's letters to Celie, and Celie is happy to know that Nettie has been fine all the years, married to the missionary after his wife dies. Celie reads Nettie's letters and begins writing to her. Then she learns that the missionary's two children are adopted, and are in fact Celie's blood and flesh. They come back from Africa and reunite with Celie.

The Color Purple is a great book both in thematic and formal terms. Thematically, it is first and foremost about African American women's growth against the backdrop of social and familial oppression. Celie is a good case in point. She grew up in low self-esteem, knowing that she had

neither good looks nor good brains. She was never self-assertive, and always suffered in agonizing silence. She saw her sister running away, and subjected herself to the anguish of a loveless marriage and the drudgery of a stepmother. Exposed to abuse of various kinds, she becomes callous. As she has no one to talk with and she is too ashamed to talk with humans, she thinks of God. She writes to God but does not sign her name. This is an indication of her lack of confidence in her self-worth and in her fellow humans. Letter writing is also her subconscious way of complaining which she dare not do with anybody, of keeping track of experiences so as to understand herself in relation to her world, and learning to cope better. Life is a learning process for Celie. Ultimately through suffering, she learns about God from her blind worship through doubt to genuine faith. She learns about man: for her black folks, she moves from hate and rejection to understanding to acceptance; for her white fellowmen, she learns not to discriminate against them. She learns about love: love for others as well as for herself. And she learns about herself: she comes to see her human dignity and human worth. She is the one that eventually survives the ravages of life and gains spiritual wholeness. From a long point of view, Celie's growth covers not only the different phases of women's liberation (i.e. defenselessness in face of repression, awakening and self-assertion, and equality with men that does not end in separation from her man as often is the case with other women): she goes a step further. She reconstructs a new relationship between the two genders on a new basis of understanding and reunion in harmony. From a feminist point of view, the book relates a story of solidarity between the oppressed women in a sexist, racist world. Along with Celie and Shug Avery, there are Sofia and Mary Agnes, among others, who fight together for survival.

The Color Purple is about black men's change and growth as well. Celie's misery is caused, immediately, by her own men folks. It is true that it is, in the final analysis, the result of racial oppression. Had her white neighbors not lynched her biological father, she would have had chances for a happy life. This motif is reinforced by the subplot of Sophia's tragedy: Sophia suffers both in prison and as a maid to a white family because of white supremacy. However, the novel also devotes enormous space to the depiction of the familial factors that make Celie's life wretched beyond words. These include her stepfather and her husband, both of whom battered her physically and mentally and made her life a hellish nightmare. Materially they have enough to live well. Just look at what they have on their table for breakfast: ham, grits, eggs, biscuits, coffee, sweet milk or butter milk, flapjacks, jelly, jam, orange juice, grapefruit, strawberries and cream, and tea. But they often cause domestic violence probably because they are not happy in a society of discrimination. Albert is a classic example. For a long time he is a Mr. to Celie and the readers because he is to her just another spiteful stranger and to the readers his identity is vague as he is not whole as a person. He needs development. This will not happen unless he wages a war within himself, a war between his old self and the self struggling to be born. When the women bind together to assert their rights, he is forced to do soul-searching. It takes time and suffering and a death wish. He touches hell to reach a new heaven for him. He succeeds.

Thus The Color Purple marks a new phase of growth in African American consciousness. It raises questions for thought for the African Americans: they need to get to know themselves better and get ready for accountability for their own lives. These questions are relevant especially now when discrimination has to make way for a new life for both races, however reluctant it is to vanish into history. The stage is getting set for the African Americans to make the best of what life offers for them. Harpo follows his father's example and achieves reconciliation with his wife

Sophia. Everybody learns about life. The new phase of African American awareness is also exhibited in Celie's keeping a white man in her employ: she learns to strike a racial balance. Love flourishes in her life. It redeems. This leads and adds to the happy ending.

In formal terms the novel is impressive in more aspects than one. The first thing to note is the book's narrative scheme and the suspense with which it manages to hook and hold its readers. Their anxiety stems from the way the novel deals with the secret which lies in the heart of Celie's life and of the main plot ?her biological father's death. For a long time into the novel, the readers are harassed by the incestuous violence and worried about the offspring from it. They are kept waiting until some two thirds into the story when the secret begins to trickle out and shed light on the identities of the two children. Then, there is the language to consider. Celie's letters are written in black folk language in sharp contrast with the formal English in which Nettie couches her letters. Celie's language is substandard, but vivacious and fresh and energetic while Nettie's is a little on the didactic side. The two registers of the language serve to reflect two levels of experience so well complementary to one another in the book. In addition, the novel's symbolism is noticeable. The title is pregnant with meaning. The color purple indicates dignity, love, human fellowship, and surviving whole as well as suffering and pain (if we think of the color as that of an eggplant, a combination of blue and red). It represents God's creation, common humanity, significant and not to be ignored. Altogether *The Color Purple* is a very important work in American literary history.

Now we will take a look at a few more significant figures before we bring this discussion to a temporary close. We mean Alex Haley (1921-1992), Maya Angelou (1928-), Gloria Naylor (1950-), Toni Cam Bambara (1939-1995) and Rita Dove (1952-). Alex Haley was a journalist and a novelist. His major achievements were the two important books he wrote, *The Autobiography of Malcolm X* (1965), and *Roots* (1976). The first of these he collaborated with Malcolm X, and it became probably the most influential African American autobiography of the 20th century. *Roots* is a novel of over six hundred pages, a finely wrought chronicle of an African American family from the middle of the eighteenth century through the time of writing. Although fact and fiction melt into each other so that one is not quite sure where the one ends and the other begins, one has to accept Alex Haley's statement that nothing in his book is so fictitious as to be improbable. The reader is further assured of the authenticity of the narrative by the fact that it is based on a meticulous research which the author did for over a dozen years in the libraries and archives and on an immense amount of reading on history and anthropology. The book marked a new level of self-awareness of the African American people as a race. Along with its two televised versions, it created quite a stir about racism and slavery. A painful record of the African American people falling into slavery and struggling to survive it, the book has produced a shock of recognition in readers both black and white, the African Americans getting to know their true ancestry, and the whites, some of them at least, stirred to the depth of their being by the extent of the injustice their race was capable of committing. Although Haley's influence may be more cultural than strictly literary, his *Roots* has added a new dimension to African American literature.

Maya Angelou is a multi-talented genius. Hers is a spectacular African American success story. She has been through a lot of adversity as a child victim of rape and a teenage mother, but she struggled upward with an amazing resilience that has ultimately made her what she is today. She has excelled in many fields, as an actress, a dancer, a singer, a professor, a writer, a poet, educator, director, and civil rights activist. In 1993 she became President Clinton's inaugural poet

(the second person ever to do so for a president in history, the other being Robert Frost), and received from him the National Medal of Arts a few years later. Angelou's well-known work is the five volumes of her autobiography, which records the difficult but successful experience of this remarkable woman. The first of these, *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings* (1970), relates her life in her hometown, Stamps, Arkansas with her grandmother after her parent's divorce. The second book, *Gather Together in My Name* (1974), records the postwar life of the African Americans and her own brief experience with drugs and prostitution. The third volume, *Swingin' and Swingin' and Gettin' Merry Like Christmas* (1976), covers a period of her life when career and motherhood clashed. The fourth volume, *The Heart of a Woman* (1981), signals Angelou's maturity as a writer, an actress, and a political organizer. The last of these, *All God's Children Need Traveling Shoes* (1986), relates her African journey (1962-1965). Maya Angelou's poetry has inspired people all over the world. Her volumes of poetry include *Just Give Me a Cool Drink of Water 'Fore I Diie* (1971), *And Still I Rise* (1976), *Shaker, Why Don't You Sing* (1983), *Now Sheba Sings the Song* (1987), and *Life Doesn't Frighten Me* (1993). Angelou has written some important collections of short autobiographical essays and some works for children. Her main theme was love and the universality of all lives. To her the honorary duty of a human being is to love, and love is the answer to all issues humanity may be faced with. "I am human, and nothing human can be alien to me," she says. Maya Angelou is one of the most phenomenal women in America today.

Gloria Naylor (1950-) began publishing in the early 1980s. Her first novel, *The Women of Brewster Place* (1982), won the American Book Award for the Best First Novel that year and also the National Book Award. So far she has published five novels ?*Linden Hills* (1985), *Mama Day* (1988), *Bailey's Caf?*(1992), and her most recent work, *Sophhira Wade* which is a sequel to *Mama Day*, and a collection of short stories, *Men of Brewster Place* (1998). Naylor is particularly good at depicting the lives of the African American women. Sensitive to their feelings and problems, Naylor portrays their struggles for survival with compassion and humor. Her detailed accounts of their environments, characterized by poverty, sexism, racial and patriarchal oppression, and the complexity of interrelationships, offer a convincing testimony of her conviction that an artist has to stay in contact with their culture and heritage. Naylor has a strong sense of place in her writing. For instance, Brewster is a prison-like, hellish place for the women to end up at, and Linden Hills is a suburban area where African Americans tend to be cut off and lose their vitality. Naylor is also conscious of the literary traditions which have nourished her writing career. These include Shakespeare and Dante among the western influences, and Toni Morrison and Alice Walker within the African American heritage. Naylor's best known work is *The Women of Brewster Place*, a book of seven chapters relating the interrelated lives of seven African American women, all different in age and background but sharing the pressures of roughly the same bitter and sad existence. Mattie Michael, the protagonist, is made to suffer, within the larger racial social frame, first by her father and then by her son whose breach of good faith results in her loss of her house and relocation to the dead-end Brewster Place. But Mattie survives by the sheer force of her will to life and her humanity. So do other women of Brewster Place in varying degrees. Gloria Naylor is a rising star on the contemporary American literary scene.

Mention should be made of Toni Cade Bambara (1939-1995) who fought for black America, for black women, and for the ethnic minorities in America. She wrote vehemently against racial discrimination and racial stereotyping, and asserted the identity of the African Americans in face of Anglo-American culture and of some African Americans following the mainstream. Her short

story collections include *Gorilla, My Love* (1971) and *The Sea Birds Are Still Alive* (1977). Her other works range from essays, poems, screenplays, and novels such as *The Salt Eaters* (1982) and *If Blessing Comes* (1987). She also edited two anthologies of African American writings. One of her short stories, "Blues Ain't No Mockin Bird," is a good illustration of the themes and the tenor of her writings. Here two county cameramen come along to photograph the life of an African American family for the county welfare program. The "Granny" of the family does not like the idea of strangers invading the privacy of her home. All her life she has kept moving house because she hates people nosing into her affairs and condescending to her folks. Tension between the cameramen who insist on taking the pictures and Granny doing her best to fend them off reaches breaking point when Grandpa appears on the scene. To the consternation of the two intruders, Grandpa kills a chicken hawk and breaks the camera, actually putting the two kinds of trespassers to death at the same time, one physically and one symbolically. The title of the story helps achieve the theme of the story very well: one interpretation could be that African Americans are not always sweet and docile.

We are now wrapping up this discussion with a sketchy introduction of Rita Dove (1952-), the first African American poet who was appointed to the position of Poet Laureate of the United States in 1994. Dove writes mainly poetry. Her themes cover African American life and the life of other ethnic groups as well. She sees poetry in the daily lives of the people and hears poetry in their daily speech. Her poetry appeals by virtue of its lyric, often endearing tone. Dove is very often autobiographical, hoping to touch the lives of other people by first understanding and living her own to the fullest. Her collections of poems include *The Yellow House on the Corner* (1980), *Museum* (1983), *Thomas and Beulah* (1986) which won the Pulitzer Prize for her, *Grace Notes* (1989), and *Selected Poems* (1993). She has written a verse drama, some short stories, and a novel. One of her poems, "Daystar," is apparently a description of her grandmother's life as a mother: her devotion to her family, her love for her husband, her willingness in self-sacrifice, and her desire for more ?all these help present a picture of happiness in its fullest measure.

CHAPTER 26 Multiethnic Literature (II)

In the last few decades, diversity has been particularly prized as a strength of American culture and literature. Interest in multiculturalism has been on the increase and along with it the enthusiasm for the literatures of the different ethnic groups in America. This has had to do with the 1960s and 1970s when multiracial awareness grew among the various ethnic groups in America. The African Americans took the lead, and the other minority groups like the Hispanic Americans and the Asian Americans followed suit. This consciousness received instant literary expression. As a result, American literature is now no longer seen as one monolith of Anglo-American writings for which Hawthorne, Whitman, Eliot, Frost, Hemingway, Faulkner, Lowell and Bellow have been well known. It needs rethinking. This has been clearly demonstrated in such publications that came out in the late 1970s as *Minority Language and Literature* (ed. Dexter Fisher), *Afro-American Literature: The Reconstruction of Instruction* (eds. Dexter Fisher and Robert B. Stepto), *Three American Literatures* (ed. Houston A. Baker), and *Studies in American Indian Literature* (ed. Paula Gunn Allen). The re-conceptualization of American literature is bringing its so called "mainstream" and "tributary" components closer, and American literature is becoming more inclusive to its multi-ethnic writers. A more authentic American literary history is now in the process of being written which will exclude none of its multiracial facets. The recent literary scene

is already becoming amazingly colorful. Following the African Americans who have in recent decades had their Ralph Ellison, Toni Morrison and Alice Walker and have received due recognition as an integral part of American literature, other minority ethnic groups such as the American Indians (or Native Americans), the Asian Americans, and the Chicano Americans have also written and received critical acclaim. Our discussion here will center on some of the writers from these ethnic groups who, by virtue of their creative endeavors have made their presence felt.

Let's begin with the Native American literature first. The image of the American Indians in American literature has been for a long time a distorted one, presented by non-Indian authors; they appear good or bad not as the American Indians see themselves, but as some white authors conceive of them. Thus, whatever portrayal of them there is in mainstream literature has been once or twice removed from the truth. For example, in James Fenimore Cooper's "Leather-stocking Tales," the good Indians are almost always those who stand on the side of the British against the French; and Cooper himself admitted that he had really never seen an Indian himself but had only heard people talk about them or read about them. As the Native American writer N. Scott Momaday puts it, "There was at one time a real danger [of the] Indian simply being frozen as an image in the American mind." For a long time now, the Native Americans have been telling their own stories from their own perspectives, and they have succeeded in dislodging that image so that it has become something vital and real. Their writings did not get publicized, however, until the last few decades.

At the time of European settlement, well over three hundred Indian cultures existed in the North American continent. The different nations of the American Indians such as Lakota, Hopi, Chickasaw, and Mohawk all had their own separate civilizations. It is therefore necessary to put it on record here that, strictly, to place the writings from the authors of the different nations in the same category of Native American literature is not fair and well justified except for the sake of convenience in nomenclature. Now at the beginning, there was a very rich oral tradition in all Native American cultures. When the Christians came, orality gave place to literacy, and some Christian converts began to write in English. A good example was Samson Occom's well-known Sermon Preached at the Execution of Moses Paul, an Indian (1772). Then the autobiographies of some "famous" Native Americans came out in collaborative ventures, followed by an interest in the autobiographies of Native Americans not so famous. From the mid-19th century through the early years of the 20th, three important autobiographies came out in print: The Life of Ma-ka-tai-me-she-kia-kiak, or Black Hawk (1883), Wooden Leg: A Warrior Who Fought Custer (1931), and Black Elk Speaks (1932). The genre remains an important part of Native American writing even today. N. Scott Momaday's The Names (1976) and Leslie Marmon Silko's Storyteller (1981) are the best samples. Following the first Native American novel, Life and Adventures of Joaquin Murieta (1854), imaginative writing has improved with time. In the early 20th century John Milton Oskison's Wild Harvest (1925), Black Jack Davy (1926), and Brother Three (1935) were widely read. Then in the 1930s two novelists, John Joseph Matthews and D'Arcy McNickle made their impact felt and did the spade work for the outburst of Native American literary creativity of the late 1960s. Matthews' Sundown (1934) and McNickle's The Surrounded (1936) have become influential over subsequent Native American writings as works of genuine literary merit rather than of simple anthropological significance.

In 1968 N. Scott Momaday published his House Made of Dawn and won the Pulitzer Prize. This led to what has become known as "The Native American Renaissance" around the end of the

decade. A host of Native American writers appeared and wrote with enthusiasm. The four major novelists who have achieved utmost prominence in the last few decades of the last century are N. Scott Momaday, Leslie Marmon Silko, James Welch, and Gerald Vizenor. Around these literary giants revolve constellations of other writers such as Louise Erdrich, Michael Dorris, Paula Gunn Allen, Susan Power, Sherman Alexie, Linda Hogan, W. S. Penn, Gordon Henry, and Louis Owens. Today books by Native American writers fill the bookstores, and their literature has become a distinct ingredient of American literature.

The man who initially helped set the stage for the Native American Renaissance of the 1960s was D'Arcy McNickle (1904-1977), the writer who devoted his life to improving the lot of his fellow American Indians. McNickle was a half-breed, born to a Cree mother and a white father and adopted into the Flathead Indian tribe. He grew up on a reservation and attended the University of Montana. Later he sold his allotment on the reservation in order to enroll in Oxford University. As a young man he rejected his heritage, but later he came to embrace it and did his best to better the lives of his fellow Indians. He wrote a number of nonfiction works, the most important of which is *Native American Tribalism: Indian Survivals and Renewals* (1973). But he is best known as the author of the novel, *The Surrounded* (1936), a milestone in the history of Native American literature.

The Surrounded tells a tragic story of cultural dislocation and split identity. Young Archilde Leon is a mixed blood. Feeling uncomfortable living with neither of his parents, his Salish mother and white father, he leaves for the city where he lives like a white man. When he comes back he plans to stay only long enough to visit his folks around. But he is drawn into the whirlpool of life in his native place so that he never manages to get away. First, he hears that his brother Louis is in trouble. Louis has stolen some horses and is hiding in the mountains. Then he learns that his nephews have been troublemakers. And his father, estranged both from his seven sons and his wife, is relenting when he sees Archilde, his youngest son, back home. Archilde tries to patch up the broken relationship between his parents. His mother asks him to accompany her on her last hunting in the mountains. There he meets with his brother Louis, and they go hunting the next day. Louis kills a deer, and the game warden, Dan Smith, comes along to investigate. Louis draws on him and is shot dead by the warden. His mother kills the warden. Archilde buries Dan Smith and takes Louis' body home. He is detained but released soon. Then he falls in love with Elise La Rose, his parents die one after another, and Elise advises him to run with her to the mountains just in case Dan's body should be found and there should be no witness to testify that he is innocent. He follows her advice and soon faces the sheriff who comes to arrest him. Elise shoots the sheriff, and Archilde, now completely surrounded, submits to his fate in silence.

There is a visible silhouette of the young McNickle in the character of Archilde. The story reveals the painful process of the disintegration of the Native American culture. It points its accusing finger directly at the intrusion of the whites into the traditional lives of the Indians. To begin with, Archilde is torn between divided allegiances to the different elements of his heritage: Indian and white, and he runs away. But the curse of being a half-breed follows him and he is destined to run into his own undoing. The gun as a technological advance introduced from outside makes the world a lot more violent and deadly. Archilde, who is too tenderhearted to kill a deer and who never kills anyone in his life, is doomed as a scapegoat for the deaths that have occurred during his stay home. The Indians start wondering about the change for the worse in their existence and about the loss of their powers: whereas in the old days tribal fighting was a game, it

is now a slaughter, and their powers no longer protect them. In their desire to establish a connection with some spiritual powers, they are ready to embrace Christianity, which is to be a dubious blessing at the best. The journal entries of Father Grepilloux, a character in the novel, show that he is complicit, probably unconsciously, in the collapse of the Indian traditional way of life as well.

By far the most influential Native American writer of the last few decades is N. Scott Momaday (1934-), a novelist and a poet. Momaday is a Kiowa Indian, brought up on Navajo and Jemes Pueblo reservations. He was educated in the University of New Mexico and Stanford University. Following his prize-winning first novel, *House Made of Dawn*, he published, among other works, his memoir, *The Names* (1976), and his next novel, *The Ancient Child* (1989). Momaday likes to think of himself primarily as a poet. His volumes of poetry include *Angle of Geese* (1974), *The Gourd Dancer* (1976), and *In the Presence of the Sun: Stories and Poems* (1992).

His best-known novel, *House Made of Dawn*, is about the experience of a Native American in relation to his own cultural heritage from which he is estranged and to the capitalist mainstream society which is alien to him. Abel, a Native American youth, has difficulty relating to his own Indian way of life. He has never known his father, and both his mother and brother died before he went to the war. After he comes back from the war, he finds it very hard to reintegrate into the Indian pueblo life of which his grandfather, who brought him up, is an integral part. He finds work, splitting wood for Angela St. John, a woman from Los Angeles who comes over for the local mineral baths but mainly to recuperate from her depression. Abel has an affair with her. In the meantime, Abel has a fight with an albino Indian and kills him. He is tried and made to serve a six-year sentence in prison. After his release, he works in a factory where a Navajo Indian, Ben, befriends him and welcomes him to live with him. The two are cornered one day by a corrupt policeman, Martinez, who takes Ben's paycheck by force and beats Abel for having nothing for him. Frustrated in his effort to melt into the white society, Abel seeks Martinez out for revenge. He is beaten almost to death instead. Ben takes him to hospital where Angela comes along to visit him. By now, Abel is convinced that the best course of action for him is to go back to his grandfather. He finds the old man dying and tries to take care of him in the last six days of his life. His grandfather devotes his last six dawns to pass necessary information for his grandson's reintegration into Indian life before he dies. Thus reeducated and reassured, Abel gets ready for the Indian ceremonial dawn running.

House Made of Dawn is a formal novelty. First, with regard to the notion of time, the novel is a chronological chaos. It consists of a prologue and four sections, "The Longhair," "The Priest of the Sun," "The Night Chanter," and "The Dawn Runner." The first and the last sections are set in the Jemez pueblo, Walatowa ("Village of the Bear"), while the two interior chapters are located in Los Angeles. All the sections are dated to offer a faint notion of time for the story. This is necessary because the sections interlock and intersect and crisscross with flashbacks and memories so that the readers tend to lose track of time. Abel's story, for instance, has to be laboriously pieced up in the course of very careful reading. The first section, which relates the main story, offers a series of flashbacks about his scant knowledge of his own family, his estrangement from the Jemes Pueblo, his vision of an eagle overhead with its talons closed on a snake etc. His story continues in broken rhythm in the second section when we see, in the background of the priest's sermons, the young man lying in a ditch, and learning in flashbacks,

among other things, about his mother's and brother's death, his trial for the murder of the albino, his relationship with Ben and Milly (a social worker), and his war experience. We get to know about his lying in the ditch in the third section when Ben tells us about his fight with Martinez, his hospitalization, and Ben singing the Navajo night chant "House made of pollen, house made of dawn" for Abel's spiritual recovery. The section is interpolated with Abel's memories of his happy childhood times. The final section wraps the whole narrative on the affirmative note that Abel is now integrating himself with his Indian way of life.

Furthermore, the book is heavily tinted in American Indian color: the race for good hunting and harvests, the fiestas The Feast of Santiago with its ceremony of the rooster pull race and the winner's flailing of a fellow participant, and the fiesta of Porcingula, with its Pecos bull ceremony, the annual eagle hunt and its sacrifice in an Indian ceremony, the Navajo night chant which offers spiritual healing (as Ben does for Abel), and the dawn running with the runner's arms and shoulders marked with burnt wood and ashes. *House Made of Dawn* is an authentic representation of the Native Americans surviving in the modern world while trying, and successfully, to keep their traditions intact and their selfhood whole.

Another famous Native American writer is James Welch (1940-), who was born in Montana to a Blackfeet father and a Gros Ventre mother. Growing up on the reservations, Welch learned a good deal about the ways of life of both Indian nations. He was educated at the University of Minnesota and the University of Montana. In 1971 he published his first volume of poetry, *Riding the Earthboy* 40, but then he turned his creative energies to fiction. So far he has published a few novels including *Winter in the Blood* (1974), *The Death of Jim Loney* (1979), *Fools Crow* (1986), and *The Indian Lawyer* (1990). The Montana plains offer the backdrop for most of his stories, and the contrast between modern and traditional lifestyles provide the basic thematic focus for his fiction. Welch's tone of storytelling is usually not optimistic. There is an element of desperation in his narratives. It may have to do with his acute awareness of "the Indian problem" (as he puts it), that once the Indians are placed on a reservation, they lose quite a bit of their traditional ways. As always Welch presents the Indian side of the case.

His third novel, *Fools Crow*, is a historical novel about the 1870 genocidal massacre of the Pikuni (Blackfeet) Indians. The focus of the tragic story is, however, on human development rather than a simple presentation of facts. The protagonist is White Man's Dog (later called Fools Crow). He is not very lucky as a young man: at the age of 18 he has still no good horses, no lodge of his own, and no wife. In contrast, his childhood friend, Fast Horse, has everything and the promise of inheriting his father's job as the tribe's keeper of the most valuable beaver medicine bundle. Then there is a horse-taking raid on the camp of the Crows, their traditional enemies. Yellow Kidney, the raid's leader, takes both young men along with him. Fast Horse disobeys the command and breaks the cover of secrecy by shouting arrogantly to the sleeping Crow Indians, and causes the raiding mission to fail. Yellow Kidney is caught and tortured by the Crows beyond description. White Man's Dog proves himself responsible in the mission and is honored by his people. In addition, when Yellow Kidney does not return, White Man's Dog helps his family out by sharing his kill with them. The tribe entrusts more responsibility with him and he becomes a mature, respectful member. Later when his tribe and the Crows meet to have a showdown, he kills their leader and earns the name of Fools Crow. He marries Yellow Kidney's daughter and has a son born to them. On the other hand, his friend, Fast Horse, fails to keep the promise that his people saw in him. After Yellow Kidney miraculously survives and returns to the camp, Fast Horse

banishes himself and joins a renegade group. Although he later redeems himself a little by acknowledging his responsibility for Yellow Kidney's misfortune, he never has the courage to live among his own people. He leaves for where many lone people live.

The historical aspect of the novel relates to the white men's arrival and their subjugation of the Indians through whiskey, blankets, shotguns, and massacre. The Napikwans, or the white Europeans, represent the forces of darkness against which the Indians' struggle for survival plays out. What the whites forebode and try to bring about for the Indians is both their physical and spiritual extinction. In the beginning the Indians have no immunity to the "gifts" of the white men, nor do they see through their true colors. There is the small pox ravaging the Indians, the dispensation of the northern plains, and the massacre on the Marias, which the novel reproduces from the Indian perspective. The tragic scene that Fools Crow witnesses after meeting a small group of survivors reveals the extent to which the whites have worked havoc with the Indian world. In the camp of Heavy Runner's tribe, the houses are razed to the ground; dead bodies lie in the snow, still smoldering from the fire. Heavy Runner is killed. Though a small group escape alive, Fools Crow shudders to realize that the tribe is extinct as there are no children left. Fools Crow's maturing occurs against this dreadful backdrop of death and annihilation. He grows to fully appreciate the traditional life of his tribe and the vital importance for him to participate in it as a responsible member. His individual fate is thus bound up with the fate of his people, and he is ready for commitment to his community. Given eventually the burden for healing his people, Fools Crow feels, vaguely, some hope amid the debris of Napikwan devastation. Spring arrives, the son is born, and the rain comes; the world looks forward to renewal and resurrection.

As Welch states, the story is told from the Indians' point of view, "never from the white point of view." Fools Crow is narrated from the inside of the Indian cultural perspective. One illustration of this perspective is the dream motif that runs through the tale. There are a number of dreams that make sense in the context of the Indian lives. For instance, Eagle Ribs dreams of a white death-horse. The horse is obviously emblematic of the encroaching white conquerors that will never see them as rightful humans. Fast Horse dreams of the Cold Maker, the Pikuni winter god, requiring him to do a couple of things neither of which he does. The dream is apparently prophetic of his moral fall in the world. On the journey to the camp of the Crows, Fools Crow thinks about a recurrent dream of his that keeps bugging him. He has dreamt of the same occurrence for three nights. In the dream he walks in the snow to a lodge in which white-faced girls lie naked and one of them desires him. As he walks toward her, he wakes up. Fools Crow knows intuitively that the girl signifies danger for his people as well as for himself. The girls are like sirens, temptations that lead to death. As a sexual temptation is hard to ward off, the tempted has no defense to put up and walks to his death even though he knows the tragic outcome. The dream is a sign for the Indians. In face of white temptations ("the white man's water," blanchest, shotguns etc.), the Indians' fate is sealed. One more thing to note before we leave Welch in our discussion is that he tends to write a sparse and lean prose. For Welch this is deliberate because this language is well in line with the bleakness of the scenes that his book adumbrates.

Now we come to Leslie Marmon Silko (1948-), who is of mixed blood ?Laguna Indian, Mexican, and white. She was brought up in a cultural milieu in which the oral tradition was still very much valued. She listened to her great grandma's stories about a long, long time ago and felt infinitely fascinated and inspired. She attended the University of New Mexico as a law student, but quit when she saw the injustice built into the Anglo-American legal system. She turned to

writing as her career in order to seek justice. When her first novel, *Ceremony*, was published in 1977, she was established as a major literary figure in the Native American Renaissance in full swing then. She became as famous as N. Scott Momaday and James Welch. Then she wrote *Storyteller* (1981), a mixed-genre autobiography, and her novel, *Almanac of the Dead* (1991). Her other works include *Laguna Women* (1974), a volume of poetry, *Sacred Water* (1993), an autobiography, and *Yellow Woman and a Beauty of the Spirit* (1996), a collection of essays.

Ceremony is a story of profound philosophical meaning. It is about the quest of its protagonist, Tayo, for the wellness of his own person which assumes, by extension, universal significance for his Indian nation, and for the world in general. Tayo is a war veteran. He has been away for six years from home. During that time, he served in the US army, was in a Japanese prisoner-of-war camp, and stayed in a mental hospital in Los Angeles. But he comes back, still sick. He keeps vomiting. In the meantime, the Laguna land suffers drought. His grandmother brings in the Navajo medicine man, Betonie, who restores him to some measure of health and sends him on a journey that would cure him and help the community at the same time. This is the ceremony he has to go through for full recovery. He has to go and find uncle Josiah's spotted cattle. In keeping with Betonie's directions, he comes and meets Ts'eh, a half-mythic woman. With her help he accomplishes his mission. His final test is to resist the temptation of killing Emo, a fellow Indian GI, who is a token of evil. The man has tried to hurt him earlier by cutting his stomach with a broken beer bottle, but now Tayo thinks the better of it. He tries to purge Emo of the evil in him. When he is cured, the Laguna land is blessed with rain.

Tayo is an upright and responsible man. When he was in the army he was made to swallow a lot of lies of violence and war, which he found it hard to stomach, though Emo fell prey to the "witchery." His vomiting is a sign that he keeps purging himself of whatever effect the war experience might have had on him. During the war he was made on one occasion to shoot at the Japanese soldiers lined in front of a cave. He could not pull the trigger because he saw his uncle Josiah's face in one of the Japanese there. The death of his cousin Rocky was a load on his mind as well. Rocky died of a festering wound in the Philippines in the rain and Tayo could do nothing to help except curse the rain then. When he comes back, the land of his community is cursed with severe drought. So he feels responsible for the deaths of his uncle and cousin and also for the ruin that is visited on the Laguna land. This sense of responsibility, this sensitivity to the suffering of others, stems from Tayo's innate quality of seeing himself connected with his fellow creatures. The spirit of fellowship proves to be the healing element for Tayo and for all humankind.

Ceremony is a remarkable work the texture of which is woven of the Indian oral tradition of myth and legends. Silko is able to bring the greatness of her Indian heritage to the notice of the whole world which has tended to ignore the greatness of minorities like the Native Americans. The amazing thing about this tradition is its similarity to the much more publicized European culture. For instance, there must be a hero venturing out into the wide world to complete a ritual or a feat like a quest or conquest for the good of the humankind. Then there is the basic story of the novel to consider. It tells about a search for rain and water, which is similar in motif to T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*. But different from the Arthurian legend, the Laguna Indians have their own version of the myth. The woman who helps with the search, Ts'eh, turns out to be a mythic figure. Her name, Ts'eh Montano, means "mountain water." Her sexual union with Tayo, her love, serves to break the spell on the Laguna land with rain and water. Many details in Tayo's encounter with Ts'eh tie in well with the essential structuring ingredients of a myth or legend. For example, when

Betonie sends Tayo away on his mission, he tells him to look for four things to make sure that he has reached the right place for his quest: the star overhead, the spotted cattle, a woman, and a mountain, the four things that the Navajo medicine man has seen in a vision. And sure enough, Tayo meets Ts'eh, sees the stars, and finds the cattle. The prophecy is thus fulfilled.

Leslie Marmon Silko is also noted for her short stories. These portray Native American life in its sundry manifestations from an American Indian perspective. One good example is her "The Man Who Sends the Rain Clouds." It is about the burial of the Indian grandfather. The grandchildren would like to do it their way such as covering the body with corn food while the pueblo Catholic priest would have it done in the Catholic way. One of the grandchildren thinks it wise to ask the priest for help with the holy water, but when approached, the priest feels that the last rites are at least necessary. But he comes to the funeral with the holy water any way. So the old man is buried mainly in the Indian manner with the help of the church. Although short, the story is full of tension between different faiths, cultures, and ethnic ways of conduct. There is reluctance on both sides to do things not their way, but there is also a readiness to compromise. Things get done in a mutually helpful and acceptable fashion. The implication is that people of different faiths and ethnic origins are taking small steps to get close to one another and try to work it out between themselves. The title sets our mind thinking, too. Who is the man to send the rain clouds, the rain that makes good life possible for all people involved? The story says it is the spirit of the grandfather, but it could be God, too, as the old man manages to send rain clouds with the help of God.

One important Native American writer who has made her presence felt is Louise Erdrich (1954-). Erdrich was born in Minnesota and grew up in North Dakota. She is of mixed blood, her father being a German-American and her mother an Ojibwa Indian. She was educated in Dartmouth College and Johns Hopkins University. Her first novel, *Love Medicine*, came out in 1984 and won a number of awards including the National Book Critics Circle Award for Best Work of Fiction. It established her place as a major American writer. The novel was expanded in 1993 with five new stories added to the first edition. The initial success was followed by five more novels, three of which. *The Beet Queen* (1986), *Tracks* (1988), and *The Bingo Palace* (1994) form her famous North Dakota tetralogy along with *Love Medicine*. Erdrich has written more novels such as *Tales of Burning Love* (1996) and *The Antelope Wife* (1998). She has collaborated in her writing with her husband Michael Dorris, a Native American novelist in his own right. Erdrich is a prolific writer. She has also produced some volumes of poetry and works of nonfiction. In all her works, Erdrich focuses on the features of her Ojibwa Indian inheritance, but she is too sensitive to human nature to lose sight of their universal significance. *Love Medicine* is a good illustration.

This is story of love and forgiveness between Native American families, which overarches half a century of four generations' history of survival. Although the larger mainstream social background looms menacing and evil, the book concentrates on the vicissitudes of Native American life working itself out within its own frame of reference. It begins with the death of June, Marie Lazarre Kashpaw's adopted daughter, in a freezing snowstorm and ends with June's son bringing her spirit home from the wilderness.

Of the first generation Margaret Kashpaw is the one that *Love Medicine* tells some details about. One important fact from her life is that she manages to hide one of her sons, Eli Kashpaw, from being taken to school by the government at the expense of the other son, Nector Kashpaw.

Consequently the two brothers grow up into two different personalities: Eli, a backwoodsman, simple and honest and celibate, while Nector, though good, is basically a city type, wily and not very responsible. Margaret's part of the story forms the tapestry of life of the next generation on which the novel focuses its major narrative attention. This generation includes three primary characters, Marie Lazarre Kashpaw, Nector Kashpaw, and Lulu Lamartine, the love triangle of the novel. Now when she was young, Marie was sent to stay at a convent where she clashed with Sister Leopolda and finally left it in triumph. She met Nector Kashpaw on her way back home and, in the course of the two of them struggling for a pillowcase, had sex with him. Although in love with LuLu Nanapush Lamartine, Nector married Marie and raised a large family of both their own and adopted children. Educated in a boarding school, Nector turns out to be a calculating man. With his mother complicit in the scheme, Nector keeps his own land intact with the money that two other households have entrusted to him and allows them to lose their land. He carries on an affair with Lulu and has a son by her, Lyman Lamartine whom he never acknowledges. Marie proves to be a woman of strength and love. She brings her children up well. When her adoptive daughter June, who suffered abuse and neglect in childhood, asks for leave to go and live with her uncle, Eli, in the woods, she sees her point and lets the child have her way. Marie also helps Nector become the tribal chairman. Later she manages to come to terms with Lulu, and even visits and forgives sick Sister Leopolda. Lulu is married to Henry Lamartine Senior but none of her eight sons is his. One of them, Henry Lamartine Junior, is her brother-in-law ?Beverley Lamartine's son, who later in the story, returns from Vietnam and commits suicide as he is unable to adjust to life. When it is found out that Lulu's house is located on a piece of land that is not hers and she has to move, Nector as chairman goes to deliver the eviction notice to that effect. Inadvertently, while waiting at Lulu's house for her return, he drops the paper and his cigarette butt burns it. The flame that results from this burns the house to the ground, and Lulu comes back to have just enough time to save her child from the blaze. Lulu loses her hair and ends her relationship with Nector. In his old age Nector suffers from loss of memory and complains about his brother Eli always having a hearty appetite. As he is still attracted to Lulu, his grandson tries to secure his heart from wandering with a local Indian love medicine made of turkey hearts. He takes it, chokes, and dies.

Of the next generation June Morrissey Kashpaw stands out not as a corporeal presence (except in the first chapter when she allows herself to die in a snowstorm), but as of a metonymic significance in the novel. When she was little, June was abandoned and lived a hard life in the woods until she was brought to the love and care of Marie Kashpaw. Her psychic wounds were such that her adoptive mother agreed to let her go and live with her uncle, who brought her up in the woods. She was married to Gordie Kashpaw who treated her badly so that she had to divorce him. They had a son, King Kashpaw, and she had a son, Lipsha Morrissey, by another man, Gerry Nanpush. After her death her son King Kashpaw buys a blue Firebird with her life insurance money. The car becomes increasingly linked with her throughout the book, especially when her two sons have it as the stake for their poker game and one of them, Lipsha Morrissey, wins and brings it home, signifying her spirit's final return from the storm. Some time after June's death, Gordie dies of remorse and alcohol poisoning. Then there is Lyman Lamartine, son of Lulu by Nector. Lyman is a young man with a good heart. He is good at making money. At one point he and his brother Henry Lamartine Junior bought a convertible and had a good time driving across the country. The experience proved to be a watershed for Henry. Soon he left for Vietnam and

came back a different man. He suffers from a severe depression as he is unable to readjust himself to life. Lyman tries to cheer him up but to no avail. He crushes the car just in order for Henry to have something to do fixing it up. The ruse works for a while but Henry lapses back in his depressive mood. Once the two brothers sit at the bank of a river and have a good time chatting and having a few beers together. Things seem to go well, but Henry suddenly gets up and jumps into the river, never to return. Lamartine feels so guilty that he is not himself for a while before he takes a job at the Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA). Then his mother takes him back to run a factory for her. Although his father, Nector, never acknowledges him, he manages to arrive at some understanding with Marie after the old man's death and feels gratified about it.

With regard to still the next generation, there is Albertine Johnson, Marie's granddaughter. Albertine is not on good terms with her mother because she has not stayed on the reservation and has married a Catholic. She mourns genuinely for her aunt June's death whom she regards as a good aunt to have. Albertine is a positive influence on conflicting and wounded personalities and relationships. She has a kind of healing power with her. Then there is Lipsha Morrissey, born to but abandoned by June. He was brought up by his grandmother Marie. His quest for his identity offers a connective thematic link to the loosely knit novel. He has healing powers like his ancestors and local medicine people. He prepares a love medicine for his grandfather Nector and causes his death in a well intentioned way. Humbled by his failure, he learns to love and forgive. Later he receives from Marie his mother's legacy, the beads which his mother wore when she was first brought to the Kashpaws, and hears the truth about his parentage from Lulu. He joins the army, sees a vision sent by his grandfather Nector, and comes back to help his father flee to Canada and bring his mother's soul home.

Love Medicine is a formal novelty. To begin with, its point of view is fresh and provocative. With the exception of the third-person narrative of the first chapter, all the following chapters are narrated in the first person by different people. There are six primary characters, primary in the sense that they speak in one or two sections. Marie, Nector, and Lulu each narrate two sections, one when they are young and one in their middle age. There are in addition three young narrators: Albertine, Lipsha, and Lyman. Their stories interweave and intersect, a little like Faulkner's *Go Down, Moses*, but more intricate. The thread of time becomes a problem. Told in this way, the non-chronological nature of the story is obvious. Although the author tries to help with dating all the chapters, the timeline of events is still hard to determine. But Erdrich is skillful enough to bring all the voices well under control so that the novel is a well-wrought whole of art. The circular frame of the book grabs attention, too. June serves as the connective tissue for the disparate elements of the story and encloses the whole of it within the time between her death and her spiritual return home. This is a fitting formal arrangement because June's life is a mirror for the Indian life of Love Medicine, with her abandonment as a child, her abuse, her unhappy marriage, her infidelity, and the love she had though in large measure unconsciously. One more thing to note here is the fact that many of the characters appear in the author's North Dakota tetralogy. Some continue to be major characters; some become minor ones; and the later works and Love Medicine serve to footnote one another beautifully well in many interesting ways.

Native American poetry is amazingly rich. One unique thing about this poetry is that most of the major fiction writers are all also poets of the first intellectual order. These include, among others, N. Scott Momaday (and his "The Bear"), Paula Gunn Allen, James Welch, and Louise Erdrich. The number of modern and contemporary well-published poets is simply impressive.

These include Maurice Kenny (1929-) whose *The Mama Poems* won the American Book Award in 1984; Carter Revard (1931-), well noted for his use of his native Oklahoma speech patterns; Simon Ortiz (1941-), informal in diction, and moving in mordant irony; Lance Henson (1944-), who believes that the mysterious powers of the native Americans may offer hope for America; Joy Harjo (1951-), noteworthy for her lyricism; and Diana Bums (1957-), impressive for her humor and honesty. And there are many others working on the scene like Wendy Rose (1948-) and Roberta Hill Whiteman (1947-), and all trying to enrich the representation of the American Indian experience. As a result of the hard work of the Native American writers, Native American works have come out of the closet and kept appearing in the bookstore today.

Now Asian American literature as a category breaks down into subdivisions such as Chinese American, Japanese American, Indian American, Korean American, and Filipino American. As these Asian Americans have different cultures and historical backgrounds to fall back to in their writings, Asian American literature is variegated and highly diversified. The origins of Asian American literature can date back to the first years of the twentieth century or even earlier when books on Asia or Asian Americans were written by non-Asians. Pearl Buck (1892-1973) was a good example. Her *The Good Earth* (1931) was very popular and paved the way for her Nobel Prize for literature. The first commercially successful Asian American writer was C. Y. Lee (1917-) whose first novel, *The Flower Drum Song* (1955) was adapted for Broadway and for a movie. Asian American literature began to make its presence felt as a category in the mid-1970s when the Civil Rights movement of the 1960s generated a spirit of ethnic nationalism among the various minority groups in the United States. "Ethnicization" of curriculum on college campuses occurred. Academic programs in Asian American studies emerged. The Immigration Reform Act of 1965, which brought in new waves of well-educated immigrants, made the cultural milieu more conducive to the further development of Asian American writing. The early 1970s witnessed the publication of some anthologies of Asian American writers. Then in 1976 Maxine Hong Kingston made her impact with her widely acclaimed books, *The Woman Warrior* and *China Men* (1980). More Asian Americans, especially those from the Chinese, Filipino, and Japanese backgrounds who had longer history in America, kept up writing in the 1970s and 1980s. Some anthologies of their writings came out, such as Kai-yu Hsu and Helen Palumobinskas' *Asian American Authors* (1972) and Jeffrey Paul Chan's *Aiiieeeee! An Anthology of Asian American Writers* (1974). Elaine H. Kim published her seminal study, *Asian American Literature: An Introduction to the Writings and Their Social Context*, in 1982. However, it would take more time and a few more successful writers like Amy Tan, Michael Ondaatje, and Bharati Mukherjee yet for Asian American literature to receive recognition as a more distinct entity, and for mainstream publishers to take Asian American writers more seriously. Sure enough, these writers have written since the 1970s and have become conspicuously noticeable. Amy Tan's *The Joy Luck Club* (1989) proved to be a kind of watershed. Before its publication, New York mainstream publishers released one work by an Asian American once every two or three years. After 1989 two or three Asian American works are placed on the store shelves every month. In addition more anthologies of Asian American writing have appeared in print. These include, among others, Shaw Wang's *Asian American Literature: A Brief Introduction and Anthology* (1996), Shirley Geok-lin Lim's *The Forbidden Stitch: An Asian American Women's Anthology* (1989), and Elaine H. Kim's *Making More Waves: New Writing by Asian American Women* (1997).

The most famous of the Asian American writers is Maxine Hong Kingston (1940-) whose

The Woman Warrior: Memoirs of a Childhood among Ghosts (1976) won the National Book Critics Circle Award for nonfiction for 1976 and established her as a preeminent contemporary American writer. Kingston's parents emigrated to the U. S. in the 1930s. She was born and raised in a bicultural milieu: there has been an obvious Chinese-American conflict and conflation in her upbringing that has made the question of identity and race and ethnicity one of her major concerns in her writing as well as in her life. *The Woman Warrior* deals with the subject; so do her other works, *China Men* (1980) and *Tripmaster Monkey: His Fake Book* (1989). Her most critically praised work, *The Woman Warrior*, is a difficult work to classify. It was written as a memoir, but reads like a combination of autobiography and fiction. It consists of five sketches of both fact and fiction. The first chapter, "No Name Woman," is a retelling of a family tragedy told the author by her mother; it is mostly factual. The No Name Woman was her aunt, her father's sister, a housewife who gave birth to a child out of wedlock and had to commit suicide because of the pressure of family and social censure. As the narrator sees it, she had to drown herself and her baby in the family well because she was weak and powerless as a woman. She is portrayed as a symbol for all women victims of patriarchy (both in feudal sexist China and racist America). The narrator's identification with victimized womenfolk is obvious. The next chapter, "White Tigers," avenges the No Name Woman vicariously, through a woman warrior who is empowered by her niece-narrator's imagination. The woman warrior is no other but the legendary Chinese heroine Hua Mulan. Instead of following the traditional version of the legend, the narrator makes the well-trained warrior fight and win and return to the capital to behead the emperor who had wronged her father. Here Hua Mulan is married and has a baby and orders her husband around to do her errands. Obviously she is the narrator's projection of her best possible notion of a woman's life. The second part of the chapter relates the narrator's painful experience of racial and sexist discrimination and her pent-up wrath. Her desire to be a woman warrior is apparent. In the same way Hua Mulan has her sword, the narrator has her pen. "The swordswoman and I are not so dissimilar," she says in her feminist tone.

The third chapter, "Shaman," describes the narrator's mother who has had experience with two worlds of China and America, embraced Chinese values and had a hard time taking America as her home. The narrator's experience is just directly opposite, born and brought up in America but living in the shadow of Chinese culture as embodied by her mother. The question of identity is keenly felt by the two women of the two generations. The fourth chapter, "At the Western Palace," is about the sad life of the narrator's maternal aunt who, abandoned thirty years ago and brought to America to rejoin her lost and found husband, experiences the second rejection and loses her sanity and dies. The aunt, a Chinese pure and simple, has difficulty accepting the Americanized behavior of her nieces and is not accepted by her Americanized husband. The final section of *The Woman Warrior*, "A Song for a Barbarian Reed Pipe," is mainly about the narrator trying to make the best of her own life. It images the famous ancient woman poet, Ts'ai Yen by name, as the narrator's ideal model of fighting with her pen. Ts'ai Yen lived among a different race, "the barbarians," for twelve years and returned to write to reclaim her identity and assert herself. The parallel between the ancient poet ?another type of woman warrior ?and the narrator cannot be mistaken. The narrator has to deal with the excruciating encroachment of the world upon her selfhood in a heroic manner.

Formally, the book is noted for a number of things of which its symbolism and its use of language merit attention. The "ghost" in the title is symbolic all through the book. The "no name"

aunt is harassed by the shrouded villagers. The woman warrior's trainers, the old-young couple, move in an atmosphere of fantasy. The narrator faces a world of apparitions all of which pose some menace to the survival of her selfhood. And the narrator has to battle the shadow of her uncertain identity. The ghosts present a backdrop of the past, of the otherness, and of the larger environment against which the narrator thrashes out the harrowing question of their race and nationality for herself. Another thing to note about *The Woman Warrior* is its unique style of writing. Its sentences are often short and elliptical and read like Chinese translations. It is poetic in the sense that it leaves ample room for the imagination. The prose can be beautifully idyllic and pastoral:

One afternoon peace and summer rested on the mountains. Babies napped in the tall grass, their blankets covering the wildflowers with embroidered flowers. It was so quiet; the bees hummed and the river water played the pebbles, the rocks, and the hollows. Cows under the trees whisked their tails; goats and ducks followed the children here and there; and the chickens scratched in the dirt. The villagers stood about in the sunshine. They smiled at one another. Here they all were together, idle above their fields, nobody hoeing, godlike; nobody weeding, New Year's in the summer.

The language of the book, as epitomized here in the description, reveals the conflation of the conflicting cultural influences on the author's life. It manages to retain the beauty of both of the languages to which she has been sensitive. With the succinct, imagistic element of the Chinese language subtly embedded in the English, Kingston's prose possesses an idiosyncratic feature that endears her to her readers.

China Men is well known as well. It won the American Book Award for nonfiction for 1981 and the American Academy and Institute of Art and Letters Award for literature for 1991. It is a series of biographical and autobiographical narratives describing the tragic lives of several generations of the author's male ancestors living on the fringes of mainstream life, victimized and oppressed as a result of their race and ethnic origins. One of these worked as a farm hand in Hawaii, another helped build the transcontinental railroad; still another owned a tiny laundry and was cheated by his partners. Racial discrimination and self-identity remain the focus of the book's concern. Kingston's one novel, *Tripmaster Monkey: His Fake Book* (1989), portrays a 5th generation Chinese American, Wittman Ah Sing, living in a California Chinatown in the 1960s, dangling between two cultures, knowing something about both, Chinese folklore and culture on the one hand, and Rilke and Joyce and American counterculture on the other, and trying to work out as a poet, a storyteller, and a graduate. Race and nationality are topmost in his mind all the time. We could still get a glimpse of the author in this male protagonist.

Another important Asian American writer is Amy Tan (1952-), whose first novel, *The Joy Luck Club* (1989), made quite a stir on the contemporary American literary scene and brought Asian American literature to the intensive scrutiny of readers and critics alike. In more ways than one, the novel is a continuation of the thematic concerns of Kingston's *The Woman Warrior*.

The Joy Luck Club is intriguing in both thematic and formal ways. Thematically, it is a story of eight women of two generations from four families telling their separate stories, stories that share something in common as a connective tissue between them. The way these stories are told is interesting to note. In 1949 four Chinese women form a club to play a traditional Chinese game, mah-jongg by name. They invest stocks, eat dim sum, and talk about their past. This is the club to which the title of the novel refers. About four decades later, one of them, the founder of the

club, dies, and her daughter comes to take her place at the mah-jongg table. Only then does she get to know about her mother's secret and her meaning well. Her experience proves to be contagiously educational to her friends. It turns out that the younger generation has its own story to tell as well.

The Joy Luck Club consists of four parts, each of which begins with a vignette, or prologue, a brief italicized statement, narrated by one of the four mothers, which indicates the theme of the section. Each part includes four mothers, which indicates the theme of the section. Each part includes four individual stories told by the four immigrant mothers or their American-born daughters. Thus in part one, "Feathers from a Thousand Li Away," and part four, "Queen Mother of the Western Skies," the mothers speak, while the other two parts, "The Twenty-Six Malignant Gates" (part two) and "American Translation" (part three) allow the daughters to talk. For each of the four families mother and daughter each tell their separate stories. As one of the mothers (Suyuan Woo) dies recently, her daughter Jin-mei takes her place at the mah-jongg table and tells her mother's stories as well as her own. Together these sixteen stories tell about the Joy Luck mothers' past and present and their daughters' rebellious growth. A dividing line can be drawn between the two generations of women. The mothers on one side tell their stories of their experiences in China while the daughters talk about their lives in America. The relationships between the mothers and their daughters are strained and even confrontational at times not only because of the generational gap but also mainly as a result of their different upbringing and cultural experiences. For instance, the name of the club, Joy Luck, signifies a lot for the mothers, but means little to the daughters. For the older women, it means hope and happiness in spite of misfortunes and suffering. The character, Suyuan Woo, started the first Joy Luck Club in the 1940s in China when the Japanese were wrecking havoc with the country. The major activity of the club then was four women playing mah-jongg and hoping for joy and luck amid destruction. When Suyuan immigrated to America, she started another such club in San Francisco in the same spirit. The daughters see their mothers' mah-jongg game as a shameful Chinese custom and cannot work up any enthusiasm for it. One other example is the mothers' ambitions for their daughters. The mothers want to see their daughters grow into somebody. As the image of duck-swan of the first prologue of the first part indicates, the girls are ducks but their mothers would like them to become swans. These mothers are, no doubt, loving and caring mothers, but they make impossible demands which the daughters cannot meet and have no other choice but resist and reject. The girls love independence and demand respect for their own persons. They feel ashamed of the ways of the old country to which their mothers cling. Hence the inevitable clash between the two generations. The talk-stories ultimately bridge the gap and represent the efforts of the American-born daughters to understand and come to terms with their Chinese heritage.

Let's take the most important of all the stories for an illustration. The leading story is that of the Woos': Jin-mei and her mother Suyuan. As noted earlier, Suyuan Woo was the initiator of the club in San Francisco. Her story is the most affectionate. During WW ? she was forced to abandon her twin daughters in her attempt to flee for her life in face of a Japanese attack. Before she left them, she hid in their clothes some jewels to pay for their care, and also left her name and address in Shanghai so that they could be returned later. After she lost everything in the bombing, her house and her family, she did everything possible but could not recover the babies. From 1944 to 1949 she tried in vain to search for them before she immigrated with her second husband to America. She gave birth to her daughter Jin-mei (June) in 1951, and kept looking for her lost children from America in secret until her death in 1987, a short while before the novel opens.

Eventually the lost daughters are found and write to her, but she has already passed away. The members of the club, the other mothers, suggest that Jin-mei go and see her sisters in China. Jin-mei feels suddenly the need to know about her mother better. She and her friends have taken their mothers too much for granted. Her mother loved her dearly and had huge ambitions for her. When Jin-mei was little, her mother would like her to become a Shirley Temple, and when that did not seem possible, she wanted the girl to be a famous pianist. She wanted her daughter to have the best of all life can offer. She would like to see her thrive with the Chinese tradition in the midst of American abundance. Jin-mei, a thirty-six-year old college dropout, has not always been appreciative of her mother's ambitions for her. For example, when her mother wanted her to be a concert pianist, she took advantage of her tutor's deafness and had a good time playing without making any effort. And she appreciated American-style hugs and kisses more than the more substantial meals of dumplings and crab meat that her mother prepared for her. Now she reaches back into the past she learns more about her mother and understands her better. The fact that she is telling her mother's stories is a cogent proof that she has come to accept her mother as a source of nourishment not just in the personal mother-daughter sense of the term, but seeing her as an embodiment of the Chinese tradition. Thus reconciled with her heritage, she is ready for the trip to China. Her visit to China and reunion with her two sisters there signifies a double outcome for her: her coming to terms with her mother and with her Chinese inheritance, which is so essential to her life in America. This part of the novel is told once before in Amy Tan's short story, "A Pair of Tickets," which she wrote after she visited China in 1987.

The formal aspect of the book is interesting to talk about, too. The sixteen stories are all narrated in the first person, two by each of the eight characters except in the case of Jin-mei, who tells four stories, two of her own, and two of her mother's. The multiplicity of the voices seems to be dazzling, but is stimulating to the imagination. And there is little or no sense of dislocation between the different sections. Everything falls in place in due time and fits well into the general scheme of things. The reason for this is not hard to find. There is a common denominator to the disparate stories. For the mothers it is the common shadow of the past that brings them together at the mah-jongg table: among other things, Suyuan Woo's loss during the war, the tragic suicide of An-mei Hsu's mother as the third concubine of a rich Tientsin (Tianjin) merchant, Lindo Jong's arranged marriage back in China, and Ying-ying St. Clair's abandonment by her first husband and the loss of her child before she came to America. And they all worry about their daughters' growing up and face recalcitrant behavior of the younger generation. For the daughters it is their struggle for self-identity in face of roughly the same odds with which they are overwhelmed: they all try to define themselves not only against the shaping influence of their Chinese heritage (as represented by their nagging mothers), but also the mainstream assimilation with which they deal constantly in their daily lives. With the help of this distinct thread, the readers can string up the beads easily. This manner of telling a story is not really new with Amy Tan. In the recent past there was Louise Erdrich's *Love Medicine* (1984), which is done in basically the same way. Farther back in time, William Faulkner's *Go Down, Moses* (1942) has an essentially similar narrative scheme. Still the telling is different with each of the writers and the structuring is ultimately their own.

Contrasting, in a way, the Native American and Chinese American writers' emphasis on accepting one's heritage, Bharati Mukherjee (1940-) seems to suggest something unique to herself. To her America is the new place where she becomes a new person. The transformation requires, as

her fiction reveals, the dropping off of one's old self, including the part of the one's past that one would wish to discard. Bharati Mukherjee insists on seeing herself as a mainstream American and does not like the possible nuances of the word "multiculturalism" or the label that people tend to place on her as a writer, "South Asian-American." This has probably a lot to do with her personal background. Mukherjee was born into a wealthy upper-middle class family of Calcutta, India. She was educated in England and Switzerland before she came in 1961 to attend the University of Iowa where she received her Ph. D. She and her Canadian husband lived in Canada from 1966 to 1980 when they immigrated to the United States.

Mukherjee's fiction all explores the nature of the experience of cultural assimilation in a foreign land like North America. Assimilation means metamorphosis and self-reinvention. She approaches the issue from a woman's point of view. All her protagonists have been, so far, women, or Indian women: Tara in *The Tiger's Daughter* (1972), Dimple in *Wife* (1975), Jasmine in *Jasmine* (1989), and Hannah in *The Holder of the World* (1993). All these women try to find their new place in the new society they have come to live in. The stories are different in each case, but their portent is about the same. Tara comes to the United States at 15 and is horribly homesick at first. Later, however, she is married to a foreign man and comes home to India. Now she faces a cultural shock the other way round: she finds it hard to fit into the life of her native place where corruption, suffering, and poverty prove so sickening to her. Her outlook on things goes through a change. She sees her upper-class friends as of a dying class, living a life which is in fact spiritual dearth, and is worried about her old country's weakness in failing to change in step with the times. She gradually abandons her traditional view of things and embraces the new perspective she has acquired away from home. Now she is impatient to return to the States. Dimple in *Wife* has a greater dilemma to address. It is no longer possible to go on playing the role of the obedient wife in the new country as she did back in India. The stress that keeps building up in her bosom reaches its breaking point when she murders her husband for self-assertion and cuts herself off completely from the past. Jasmine in *Jasmine* is more moderate and more balanced in spirit. Her response to the challenges of the new life works well for her. She has a dream, the American dream, which she is determined to make happen; no defeat or frustration could stop her. When she is raped on her first day in America, she does not kill herself as her traditional values would require of her. She kills the victimizer instead. She becomes her own measure of happiness in life. So when her husband dies, she plans her new life ahead instead of dying on his pyre with him. All the three novels talk about Indian women's reaction to their new life in the new country. In all three works, the Indian women make all necessary adjustments so as to settle down and live happily. Mukherjee's next novel, *The Holder of the World*, works differently, though also dealing with the subject of cross-cultural experience. It is about immigration the other way round. Here instead of Indian women coming over and trying to make out here in the US, the novel describes two women going over to live in India. One of these two is Hannah, a Puritan woman of New Salem, who emigrates to India and has amorous adventures in Indian upper society. The other is Beigh Masters, who does research on the life of Hannah. The two women learn to live across cultural boundaries at different times. Mukherjee is about the most famous South Asian American writer today.

Regarding poetry, the most prolific Asian-American poet today is probably Garrett Hongo (1951-), a Japanese American. Hongo was born and grew up in Hawaii, moved with his family to South Los Angeles, and traveled extensively in Japan. As a poet, he is motivated by his search for ethnic and familial roots, and cultural identity and poetic inspiration. He feels the need for a life of

the mind. As his career moves on, he is increasingly fascinated with the material with which he is most acquainted: the landscapes, folkways, and societies of Japan, Hawaii, and Southern California. Writing for him is a process of keeping his cultural and moral values intact and accommodating them in what he calls "the whirlwind" he lives in. His poetry reveals his deep attachment to the places and people he calls his own. Hongo has been an award-winning poet. He has received, among other things, the Guggenheim Fellowship, the Hopwood Prize for Poetry, and the Pushcart Prize. His works include *The Buddha Bandits Down Highway 99* (1978, in collaboration with Lawson Inada and Alan Lau), *Yellow Light* (1982), and *The River of Heaven* (1988).

In the last few decades a good number of Asian American writers have written to make their voices heard. Their works include, among others, Monica Sone's *Nisei Daughter*, John Okada's *No-No Boy*, Jeanne Wakatsuki Houston and James D. Houston's *Farewell to Monzanar*, Toshio Mori's *Yokohama, California*, Diana Chang's *The Frontiers of Love*, and the shorter fiction of Frank Chin (also a playwright) and Jeffery Chan. There are, in addition, the plays of David Henry Hwang and Wakako Yamauchi, the poetry of Cathy Song, Janice Mirikitani, and Stephen Shu-ning Liu. Asian American writing is increasing in volume and is being recognized as one important component of contemporary American writing.

Another interesting component of multiethnic American literature is Spanish-American or Chicano literature. The word "Chicano" is a derivative of "Mexicano." Chicano literature is a body of writings by Americans of Mexican extraction or Mexicans in the United States writing about the Mexican-American experience. For Chicano writers a sense of ethnicity is a critical part of their literary sensibilities, and the portrayal of the Chicanos' ethnic experience in the United States is their major concern. This literary tradition is traceable back to the mid-19th century when the Mexicans of the Southwest were conquered and became Mexican Americans. In face of Anglo-American superiority, a Chicano consciousness began slowly taking shape. This consciousness did get some literary expression which, however, did not become loud enough to attract much attention until the mid-1960s when the civil rights movement among the Mexican Americans brought Chicano literature to a new phase. The Chicano family, the Chicano community, and the struggle for civil rights became the thematic concerns of the Chicano writers. Chicano literature had its renaissance from the mid-1960s through early 1980s. This is known as the contemporary Chicano literary movement. An anthology of Chicano creative writing came out in 1970, the one entitled *El espejo/The Mirror*, published by the Quinto Sol Publishers. Chicano literature found its way into the classroom. From the very beginning, this literature appeared to be a challenge to Anglo-American chauvinism both in thematic and formal concerns. It may have been the literary expression of the reaction to the anti-Hispanic, anti-Mexican bias that Mexican-Americans have felt existing in the culture of the country. Our survey here will offer a sketchy account of the most significant part of it, the part written since the Chicano movement, or the civil rights struggle, of the mid-1960s.

Chicano fiction has come a long way in the last few decades. One of the major themes of the Chicano authors relates to the search for or assertion of Chicanos' identity. This involves the upholding of their cultural traditions under the pressure of mainstream values and their attempt to fight against assimilation. Jose Antonio Villarreal's novel, *Pocho*, Raymond Barrio's *Plum Plum Pickers*, and Richard Vasquez's *Chicano* are all good illustrations of the early Chicano attempt in this direction. The first of these describes the growing up of a boy with his immigrant father. Plum

Plum Pickers is about farm workers' struggle, and Chicano portrays the impossible demands of life for immigrant children and grandchildren. All the works exhibit the consciousness of the Chicanos as an independent ethnic entity trying to stop their values from disintegrating and getting lost. Then there have been the Chicano Big Three, Tomas Rivera, Rudolfo Anaya, and Rolando Hinojosa, all novelists whose works continue the same preoccupation with identity. Rivera's ... Y no se lo trago la tierra (... And the Earth Did Not Part, 1971), Anaya's Bless Me, Ultima, and Hinojosa's Estampas del Valle, all rural in background, attempt to address the question of keeping tradition and identity intact amidst overwhelming odds. These novels try to carve out a space which the Chicanos can call their own. As they are set in a time some decades apart from the present, the works tend to provoke a sense of nostalgia for the past. Next to the Big Three and as famous is Miguel Mendez who writes about urban Chicano life. Although Mendez reveals conflicts within the Chicano community in his works, he chooses the underprivileged as his protagonists and makes a point of ending his stories with the affirmation of the Chicano heritage. His well-known novel is Peregrinos de Aztlan. Other well-known Chicano novelists include John Rechy, Oscar Zeta Acosta, Amado Muro (pseudonym for Chester Seltzer), Eusebio Chacon, Gary Soto and Ana Castillo, to name just a few. Some of these have won the American Book Awards for fiction.

Over the years Chicano poetry has experienced spectacular growth. As with the novelists, one thematic preoccupation of the Chicano poets is with the expression of their ethnic experience and the assertion of their Chicano heritage. A lot of it is in a sense ponderously political and sociological, closely tied up with the struggle of the Chicano people for equality and recognition in a predominantly Anglo-American environment. Their poetic perspective differs from mainstream poetry, their images and metaphors are drawn from their own lives, and their language has been a mixture of English and Spanish. What Chicano poetry tries to represent is the ghetto existence of the Chicano people, their existential dilemma of being lost in the grasp of the modern society of America, and their yearning for change. Chicano poetry strives for love, dignity, and justice for its people, and at the same time expresses the sense of pride that the Chicanos feel for being Chicano. The recent decades have witnessed a good number of Chicano poets making their presence felt. These include Luis Omar Salinas, Alurista, Richard Garcia, Abelardo Delgado, Miguel Ponce, Jose Montoya, Richard Anchez, Lorna Dee Cervantes, and Sandra Cisneros (who is also a fiction writer).

A pioneer in the growth of modern Chicano literature is novelist Tomas Rivera (1935-1984). He was born into a migrant farm laborer's family in Texas and attended Spanish-speaking schools before he enrolled in Southern Texas State University. Eventually he received his Ph. D. in the University of Oklahoma and worked in colleges and schools and became Chancellor of the University of California at Riverside in 1969. He held the position until his death. Rivera wrote both poems and stories to describe the lives of Mexican-Americans. In his literary career he was heavily influenced by Sherwood Anderson and William Faulkner, and was indebted very much to Mexican folk culture. The tension that gives his writing its uniqueness stems from Rivera's personal experience with living in America as a Mexican-American, the dilemma, the subtlety, and the despair that the peculiar human situation engenders for the people of this minority, conscious of its own distinctiveness with its culture, its own way of life, and its own traditions, but at the same time acutely aware of the leveling, assimilating forces that the "Anglo" mainstream keeps generating. Rivera's works aim at enhancing understanding among his fellow Mexican-Americans

so as to help them cope better with their lives. His most famous work is his collection of short stories entitled ... Y no se lo trago la tierra (... And The Earth Did Not Part). Although it consists of fourteen stories, its thematic unity is ensured by the main character who appears in all of them. The main character is a nameless child, a migrant worker, whose thoughts and reflections provide substance for some of the stories. The basic theme is the struggle of a people, the Chicanos, in a culture foreign to them, one that makes their lives impossible. The responses of the Chicanos to this culture vary. Some try to come to terms with it, some fight back, and some others, like the main character, pray in vain for a better lot. Humanity suffers intolerable alienation.

One prominent Chicano poet is Luis Omar Salinas (1937-), whose involvement in the Chicano movement began with his book of verse, *Crazy Gipsy* (1970), which contains his two best poems, "Aztec Angel" and "Quixotic Expectations." There is a good deal of social criticism in Salinas' poetry. Highly aware of the Chicano condition in America, he possesses a tragic vision in every possible sense of the term. Take "Aztec Angel" for example. Here as elsewhere in his works, Salinas tries to offer a glimpse of real life in the real world of the Chicanos: alienation, derangement, and exploitation. It is the kind of life that threatens to repress man's natural, primitive being and places the Chicanos in an existentialist quandary. The Aztec angel is an outsider, an outcast, who pawns his heart for truth. Alienated and marginalized, he witnesses a society to sanction exploitation of one class or ethnic group for the benefit of another. He experiences an existential crisis, loses his self-assurance, but manages to regain his identity in the end. He acknowledges that he is the offspring of a tubercular woman who is, however, "beautiful." The word "beautiful" represents a firm reiteration of the poet's assertion of his ethnic values. As there is a good deal of "Indianness" in the Chicanos and there has been little beautiful in the American Indians from a mainstream point of view, to declare oneself beautiful is in fact affirming one's positive outlook on oneself, and that is a noble, dignified thing that Salinas has done. Technically, Salinas is heavily influenced by surrealist writers such as the Chilean poet Pablo Neruda and the Spanish poet Miguel Hernandez. Salinas tends to describe the hard and humdrum reality through dreamlike images and metaphors. Surrealism functions as one major structural mechanism in his poetry.

American literary history is going through a process of reconstruction. The canon of American literature is becoming more relevant to the reality of the nation's variegated experience. More and more writers of multiethnic origins have come to recognize the importance of their experiences and have become more vocal about these. As a result an amazing assortment of writings has appeared to appeal to the imagination of the American reading public. It is true that these writings need further critical scrutiny; the country's literary awards committees need to size up the contemporary literary scene more carefully. But all these are happening. More minority writers are getting the credit they so well deserve. All these developments will ultimately enrich American literature so that it will be the expression of the variety of experiences of all Americans. The change will impact canonizing and teaching enormously. The result will probably be a refocusing and reprioritizing of American writing in general. Indeed, the term "multiethnic" will cease to be meaningful when the line between the "dominant" culture and the "non-dominant" cultures finally vanishes. It will take time, but it is beginning to happen.

Now when Henry James wrote *The American*, he named his hero Christopher Newman. He did not do this by any coincidence. "Christopher" apparently suggests Christopher Columbus, the man who discovered America ?the New World. His name has acquired the connotation of

exploring into the unknown. "Newman" may have been the combination of Hector St. John de Crevecoeur's "new man," the two-word epithet Crevecoeur gave to the American in his famous *Letters From an American Farmer*. "New man" is, as Crevecoeur defines it, free from tradition and the past. In the three hundred-odd years since the first Americans set foot in the New World, the American writers of the successive generations have tried, each of them in their own way, to be a Christopher Newman, ceaselessly exploring and experimenting, never content to sit on the inheritance their ancestors bequeathed them, and always managing to improve on and add to it with their new discoveries. Thus it is that colonial writers struggled for a literary independence, which the American romanticists finally won in the first flowering of American literature. With the passage of time, local colorists and realists came on the scene, whose sole, explicit aim it was to represent the average and the norm of experience in America. The brutalizing life of the 1890s and the first years of the present century, clamoring for a more forthright and less genteel expression, called literary naturalism forth into being. Then, the loss of faith and the sense of life being chaotic and fragmentized, which became more keenly felt in the 1920s, made the second renaissance a fact of history. The writers of the 1930s responded sensitively to the exacting demands of the Depression, and all the authors who wrote between the two wars made American literature of the intervening years one of the greatest in the literary history of the world. The postwar period, which is still in progress, has been one of great literary output and of more vigorous experimentation. Postmodernism has been having its fullest expression in America. Not a year passes but some new people pop out with some new surprises for the readers and critics alike. And there is the valuable addition of the emerging multiethnic writers, increasing their multicultural expression in volume and quality especially in the last few decades. Thus the literature of the United States has kept the momentum with which it first got started, and is achieving new successes. Each day seems to be newer than the one that has passed, and each generation derives its vitality from a partial negation of the tradition of the last. Some contemporary authors may be too self-indulgent and egocentric, and some may be too decadent; but all seem to be trying to be new in some way. It is, ultimately, this effort to stay new that deserves attention and admiration.